THE SORCERER'S DAWN

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Book Five of The Lattice Chronicles

THE SKILL JUNKY

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First edition.

For everyone who kept a window,
and for everyone who opened the door.

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And if you go walking where I can't see,
Leave a light in the window, love, and come home to me.

— The Lantern Song

PROLOGUE

The Glass Queen

YSENNE OF THE GLASS had not seen her own face in nine hundred years.

She thought about it on the white road, on the night the edge came down, with her sister on a chain behind her and her brother walking away.

She thought about it the way you think about a tooth that has been gone so long you've stopped putting your tongue in the gap. Not often. Not on purpose. Only sometimes, at night, when everything else was quiet, and the gap was all there was.

◆ ◆ ◆

OZ DIDN'T LOOK BACK.

She watched him go. East. Across the snow. Off the grey-gold dust and onto the white, where the Veil had stood for nine hundred years and now stood nothing at all. The biggest man in the world, gold, glowing like a coal, walking into the dark with a gold cup in one hand and his other hand pressed flat against his chest.

The snow went gold where he stepped.

Of course it did.

She watched the gold footprints go away from her across the white. One. Two. Ten. Fifty. A gold road, a step wide, wandering east toward a sky full of tiny lights.

Lanterns. Every one of them lit. A whole world of little windows with fire in them.

We go and see everyone, he'd said.

He'd said it in the hall, too. Nine hundred years ago. And again a year ago, when he woke, with Mae's crown in his hand and green coming through the crack. *Then we'll go and see everyone.* Warm. Deep. Certain. Like a bell.

It hadn't sounded like a bell tonight.

It had sounded like a bell with a crack in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's gone*," said Rhosyn.

Ysenne didn't turn round.

"*Yes*."

"*He didn't say goodbye*."

"*Oz never says goodbye*," said the Glass Queen. "*He doesn't know how. He thinks if he doesn't say it, it doesn't count.*"

Behind her, in the dust, a small dry sound. The chain. Glass links touching glass. *Chime*. Rhosyn shifting where she sat.

"*He's like that because of Father*," said Rhosyn.

"*Everyone's like everything because of Father*."

"*You're not*."

Ysenne turned then.

Her sister was sitting on the white road. In the dust. With her thin knees drawn up and her arms wrapped round them and her crown of thorns crooked on her grey hair. With the chain running from her wrists across the dust to Ysenne's own clear hand.

She looked terrible. She'd always looked terrible. Even as a girl. All elbows and knees and dirt under her nails, out in the gardens with the under-gardeners when she should have been at her lessons, coming in at dusk with leaves in her hair and roses in her fists. Mother used to despair.

She looked worse now. Grey. Not the grey-green she'd been for nine hundred years. *Grey*. Like ash. Like the inside of a dead tree. She'd spent every thorn she had in that last hour at the tower, holding back a thousand of Oz's gold servants so two Harrow boys could run. Every stem. Every root.

There was nothing left in her.

"*I'm not what*?" said Ysenne.

"*Like you are because of Father*." Rhosyn looked up at her. Green eyes. The only green thing left in the grey country. "*You were like this before.*"

"*Like what*?"

Rhosyn didn't answer.

She didn't need to. Ysenne knew what she meant. She'd always known what everyone meant. That was the trouble with being the one who saw.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND WAS STILL coming in.

She felt it on her face. On her clear cheeks, on her clear hands, on the glass of her. Cold. Wet. Smelling of snow and woodsmoke and something green and growing under the snow. Pouring west past her, past Rhosyn, along the white road. Into the grey-gold dim. Into the Court.

The first wind in nine hundred years.

It was going *in*.

She stood on the white road and felt it go past her, endless, soft, like a river finding a hole in a dam, and she thought: *it isn't stopping*.

She thought: *it isn't ever going to stop*.

And under it, faint, going the other way—out, east, into the world—the dust. Grey. Fine as flour. The dust of the Court. The dust of a closed room nobody had walked through in nine hundred years.

Going out.

Into all those little windows.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The dead are going*," said Rhosyn. Very quietly. "*Look.*"

Ysenne looked.

Grey. Rising. All over the plain. Columns of dust standing up out of the drifts and swaying, the way smoke sways in a room with a window open, and leaning, all of them, east. And going.

Past them. Past the place where the edge had been. Into the world.

Thousands.

She hadn't known there were so many. She'd never looked. You didn't look at the dust. You walked through it, on the white road, between the palaces, and it came up round your feet and settled again behind you, and you didn't think about who it had been.

She thought about it now.

The first year. Before Oz went out with his hands. Before Mae went out with her moths. The ones they hadn't reached in time. Cooks and grooms and pages and nursemaids, coming apart in the silent halls because there was nothing in the Court to eat and nothing to drink and nothing to be. Lying down in the corridors. Not getting up.

Becoming the floor.

She'd walked on them for nine hundred years.

She watched them rise and lean and go east into the world, on the first wind, toward the lanterns.

"*Where are they going*?" she said.

"*Home*," said Rhosyn. "*The warden told them. The tall one with the scarred hands. There's a pool. In a green field. Full of room.*" A pause. "*He said it's still very little.*"

"*Then it will drown*," said the Glass Queen.

"*Maybe*."

"*Thousands of them. And a pool still very little.*" Ysenne looked east. "*It'll fill up and stop. And they'll be standing round it. Forever. Like the kept. Waiting at a door nobody can open.*"

"*Maybe*," said Rhosyn again.

"*You don't care*?"

"*I care*." Her sister put her chin on her knees. "*I just don't know anything. So I say maybe. It's what people say when they don't know.*" The green eyes moved. "*You should try it, Ysy.*"

"*I always know*."

"*I know*," said Rhosyn. "*That's what I mean.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED BACK.

West. Along the white road. Ysenne first, tall and clear and glittering, and the chain running back from her hand, and Rhosyn on the end of it, stumbling. Barefoot. Her rotten silk dragging in the dust.

She could have carried her. Ysenne thought about it. She was glass, but glass is strong, if you know where to hold it. She could have lifted her sister

the way you'd lift a sack of bones and carried her the forty miles to the palaces and set her down somewhere soft.

She didn't.

She let them go, she thought. *She let them go. She held the thorns for them. She's been sending roses through the crack since the spring. She gave them the tower.*

She chose them. Over us.

Over me.

She walked a little faster.

The chain went tight. Rhosyn stumbled. Fell. Got up again. Said nothing.

Ysenne didn't look back.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEPT WERE WALKING the other way.

She passed them on the road. Hundreds. Then thousands. Gold. In the grey-gold dim. Coming toward her out of the west and going past her east, on both sides, slow, so slow, a finger's width at a time.

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape.

Oz's household. The household of the Gilded King, kept in gold on the night of the exile so that none of them would come apart in the grey. Cooks with gold spoons. Grooms with gold bridles. Nursemaids with gold children on their hips. Soldiers with gold spears held upright. Gardeners with gold trowels.

She'd walked past them for nine hundred years too.

Lining the white road. Standing. Their eyes moving. Following you. Saying something you couldn't hear.

They weren't standing now.

They'd turned. All of them. When the edge fell. When the wind came in. And now they were walking. East. Toward the place where the Veil had been. Toward the world.

And humming.

One note. From thousands of gold throats. Low. Worn smooth.

...home...

◆ ◆ ◆

"*They'll never get there*," said Ysenne. "*At that pace.*"

"*They've got time*," said Rhosyn. Behind her. On the chain. "*They've got all the time in the world. That's what Oz gave them.*"

"*He gave them safety*."

"*He gave them time*," said her sister. "*Nine hundred years of it. Standing by a road. Watching us walk past.*" A pause. "*I used to talk to them. Did you know? When I was out in the thorns. The ones nearest the tenth tower. A laundress. Two boys from the stables. A man with a gold harp.*" Her voice cracked. "*I don't think they could hear me. But I told them about the roses.*"

Ysenne said nothing.

"*What did you tell them, Ysy*?"

"*Nothing*."

"*In nine hundred years*?"

"*I didn't need to tell them anything*," said the Glass Queen. "*I showed them.*"

And it was true. She had. Every one of them. Every gold face along the white road. She'd stopped, sometimes, on her walks between the palaces, and stood in front of one. A kitchen girl. A soldier. And held up her clear hand, like a mirror, and let them see.

Themselves. Gold. Stopped. Kept. Their own eyes moving in their own gold faces.

Some of them had wept. You couldn't see it—gold doesn't weep—but you could see it in the eyes. That was the thing about the eyes. They still did everything.

She'd thought it was a kindness.

The truth is always a kindness. That was what she'd believed for nine hundred years. The truth is cold and hard and clear and it cuts, but it is never, ever a lie, and a lie is the one unkind thing.

She'd shown them the truth.

She walked a little faster.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE THOUGHT ABOUT THE girl.

The first of them. An hour ago, at the edge, before Oz went. Out ahead of all the others, small, in a grey dress too big for her. Gold. With a wooden spoon in her hand.

Walking. Not a finger's width. A step. A real step. Slow and stiff and scraping, but a step, and another, and another, down the white road, east, toward the edge.

Ilda, thought the Glass Queen. *The spit-girl. The one the boy made cry.*

She'd watched it. In the summer. Through the glass of the Court. A small dark boy with a cupped hand, kneeling on the white road in front of a gold kitchen girl, making a little room in front of her face. And the girl's gold eyes filling. And one tear, gold, running down a gold cheek.

And a word.

Mam.

Nobody had ever made any of them cry. Not Oz. Not Mae. Not her. She'd tried. Once. Nine hundred years ago, in the first year, with a gold page-boy. She'd shown him himself, and shown him himself, and shown him himself, until his eyes went still and wouldn't move anymore.

She hadn't tried again.

And a boy from the world had knelt down on the road with his hands cupped and done it in an afternoon.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GIRL HAD WALKED past her.

Close. A yard off. At the foot of the white road, where the edge had been. And as she passed, Ysenne had turned—she hadn't meant to, she hadn't decided to—and held up her clear hand. Flat. Between them. The way she'd held it up to a thousand gold faces on this road.

Look, she'd thought. *Look at yourself. Look at what you are.*

Ilda hadn't looked.

She'd walked past the Glass Queen's raised hand as if it were a branch, or a post, or nothing at all, and stepped off the dust onto the snow, and gone on east toward the lanterns.

Toward a boy with a cupped hand who'd promised he'd come back.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE LIFTED HER HAND now. On the white road. Walking. She didn't mean to.

Her own hand. Clear. Glass. With the grey-gold dim showing through it, bent, the way the world bends through a lens. With the white road behind it, and the walking gold, and the dust going up.

Everything showing through it.

Everything but her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ysy*," said Rhosyn. Softly. From the end of the chain.

She lowered her hand.

She hadn't stopped walking. She didn't stop now.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS PALACE STOOD where it had always stood. At the end of the white road. Among the towers. Glass and iron and gold and bone and the tenth tower wrapped in its dead brown thorns.

Hers was the tallest. Of course it was. Oz had built his gold one first, so she'd built hers higher, and he'd laughed and said *you would*, and she'd said *I did*. Spires on spires. Halls of mirrors. Floors you could see through, all the way down. Walls that showed you the hall behind them, and the hall behind that, and the hall behind that, until the eye gave up.

Every surface of it a window.

Every window looking out.

That was the thing about glass. She'd learned it in the first year, alone in her palace with nothing to drink. Glass wasn't a wall. It looked like a wall. People treated it like one. They put it in their windows and thought it kept the world out.

It didn't keep anything out.

It let the light through. And if the light came through, so could she.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CHAINED RHOSYN IN the hall of the long mirror.

Not cruelly. She wasn't cruel. She looped the glass chain round the foot of a pillar and left her sister enough slack to lie down, and Rhosyn lay

down, at once, on the clear floor, and curled up like a child, and closed her eyes.

"*You'll stay there*," said Ysenne.

"*Where would I go*?"

"*To them. Your Harrow boys.*"

Rhosyn opened one green eye.

"*Ysy*," she said. "*I can't stand up.*"

Ysenne looked at her. At the grey face. At the hands, thin as twigs, lying on the glass. At the crown of thorns, brown, dry, not a single green leaf on it.

She went away down the long hall and didn't look back.

◆ ◆ ◆

ORRIN WAS WAITING AT the end of it.

He was always waiting at the end of things. That was what stewards were for. A tall stooped shape of dust and silk, grey-gold, hunched under a chain of office that had once been silver and was now the colour of everything else. With his long patient face and his hands folded in front of him and his wings—what was left of his wings—folded down his back like an old cloak.

Mae had made him. Fed him on stolen light, on the long road out, so he'd never come apart. He'd been the Gilded King's steward before that. And after Mae went, and after Oz woke, he'd been everyone's.

He bowed.

"*Majesty*."

"*The King has gone into the world*," said Ysenne.

"*I saw, Majesty*."

"*He won't be coming back*."

A pause.

"*No, Majesty*," said Orrin. "*I didn't think he would.*" He lifted his long grey face. His eyes were the colour of old candlelight. "*Did he leave instructions?*"

"*He said, we'll go and see everyone*."

Orrin waited.

"*That's all*," said the Glass Queen.

"*Ah*."

"*So there are no instructions*." She walked past him. Into the next hall. The hall of a thousand panes. "*Except mine.*"

Orrin followed. As he always did. A respectful three steps behind. The dust of him drifting.

"*Yes, Majesty*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL OF A thousand panes was round.

And tall. And lit from nowhere. Its walls were windows. Hundreds on hundreds of them, small and large, square and round and arched, set into the glass of the walls from the floor to the ceiling a hundred feet overhead. Each one a different shape. Each one a different glass.

She'd made each one herself.

Nine hundred years. Nothing else to do. Nothing to eat or drink or grow or kill. Just glass, and the long grey dim, and the slow discovery of what glass could do.

That every pane is a door. That every still pool is a pane. That every lantern-glass, every mirror, every polished brass plate and dark window at night and spoon held up to a fire is a pane, and every pane is the same pane, if you know how to look.

That if you stand in front of one, you can look out of all of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD IN THE middle of the round hall and lifted her hands.

And looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WORLD CAME IN.

All of it. All at once. Through every pane in the hall, every window in the walls. Not the Court. Not the grey. The *world*.

She'd only ever had a crack before. A finger's width of Seren Harrow's blood carried west by Mae's last moth, and the light through it thin and hard to hold, like looking at a lit room through a keyhole. She'd made it work. She'd stood in the Harrow boys' windows. She'd stood in the water

barrel. She'd reached her hand out of a dark pane at night and touched a sleeping child's cheek.

But it had been a keyhole.

Now there was no edge.

Now there was nothing between her glass and theirs.

◆ ◆ ◆

A THOUSAND WINDOWS.

Ten thousand. A hundred thousand. Every pane in every house in every town in Caldor. Every lantern-glass on every sill. Every mirror on every wall. Every puddle in every lane. Every pond and trough and bucket and the still black water in every well.

Lit. Every one. It was the night they lit their lanterns. The Lady's night. Every window in the world had a light in it, and every light was looking out, and she was looking in.

At them.

◆ ◆ ◆

A KITCHEN IN A mill-town. A woman at a table with her head in her hands and a lantern in front of her, and a man's coat on the back of the chair across from her that nobody was wearing.

A barracks. Twenty young men round a fire, singing, too loud, out of tune. A lantern on a nail, and a name cut into it.

A nursery. A child asleep. A woman in a chair beside the bed, asleep too, with her hand through the bars.

A village green. A cracked old Stone. A hundred lanterns hung round it on poles and strings, and children running between them, and an old man on a bench with a pipe, watching.

An inn. A hall. A palace. A ship. A tent. A cave on a mountain hung with eleven hundred little lights, every one of them lit, and a tall thin woman with ink on her fingers standing at the mouth of it, alone, looking up at the sky.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT ALL of them.

She'd always been able to see what was in people's faces. Since she was a child. She'd sit at the long mirror in the nursery and look at the room behind her in it, over her shoulder. At her nurse. At her brothers. At Mae doing her hair. At Oz, sprawled on the window seat with his boots on the cushions.

And tell them what they were thinking.

You're cross because Father didn't come to your fencing.

You're sad about the dog.

You don't like her, you only say you do.

They'd hated it. All of them. They'd thrown cushions. Oz had laughed and said *Ysy, you're a monster*. Mae had said *it's rude, darling, people are allowed to have insides*.

She'd never understood that.

Why would anyone want insides nobody could see?

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT A hundred thousand faces in a hundred thousand windows and saw what was in every one of them.

Grief. Joy. Fear. Love. Hunger. Hope. Boredom. Lust. Rage. The thin bright fear of a mother at a cot. The thick dull ache of a man at a grave. The fizz of children. The hush of the very old. The hard set of a jaw that has decided something. The soft fall of a face that has stopped deciding anything at all.

All of it. Laid out. Like goods on a table.

Every one of them looking out of their window into the dark, at the night, at the lanterns, not knowing she was there.

Every one of them, if they'd only turned round, with something behind them in the glass.

Themselves.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOWERED HER HANDS.

The windows went dark.

She stood in the middle of the round hall in the grey dim, and the thousand panes in the walls showed her the hall.

The floor. Clear. The walls. Clear. Orrin, three steps behind her, grey-gold, stooped, with his hands folded. Reflected in every pane. A thousand Orrins.

And in the middle of the hall, where she stood—

Nothing.

The far wall. Through the place where she was. Bent a little, the way things bend through glass.

That was all.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD HAPPENED AT the pool.

She didn't remember it happening. Nobody did. That was the thing about the Drinking. You knelt at the edge of a black pool in a hidden garden, nine of you, with your crowns on, and cupped your hands, and drank. And it was cold and it was sweet and it was the most beautiful thing you'd ever tasted. Like being *made*. Like being made again, new, forever.

And then you stood up.

And you were what you were going to be. Forever. Fixed. Finished.

And you went in, laughing, all nine of you, to the long hall with the long mirror, and stood in front of it, arm in arm, to see what deathless looked like.

And she'd looked.

And she wasn't there.

◆ ◆ ◆

OZ WAS THERE. HUGE and laughing, gold already at the edges. Mae was there, tall and grey and luminous, her eyes like lit windows. Cad, square and dark. Rosie, at the end, not laughing, with dirt on her hands. Their four cousins. The empty space where Hes should have been.

And between Mae and Oz, where Ysenne was standing, with their arms through hers—

The wall behind.

Ysy, Oz had said. Laughing. Looking down at her. *Ysy, where've you gone?*

And she'd laughed too. Because it was a joke. It was a trick of the light. It would pass.

It hadn't passed.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D THOUGHT, FOR A while, it was the glass. The mirror. Something wrong with the silver. She'd had it taken down and another put up, and another, and another.

She'd thought it was the pool. Something she'd drunk that the others hadn't. Too much. Too little.

She'd thought, in the long first year, in the grey, that if she made enough glass, if she learned enough about it, if she understood every pane and every surface and every angle of every light, she'd find it. The trick. The flaw. The place where her face had gone.

Nine hundred years.

She knew everything about glass now. She could walk through it. Look out of it. Reach through it. She could stand in a window two hundred miles away and look out of a lantern into a child's nursery.

She'd never found it.

And at some point—she didn't remember when—she'd stopped looking.

She'd started showing other people theirs instead.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Majesty*," said Orrin. Softly. Three steps behind.

"*What*."

"*You've been standing there a long while*."

She looked at him. In the thousand panes. A thousand old stooped men, patient, grey-gold, with their hands folded.

"*Orrin*," said the Glass Queen. "*Do you know what's in the world?*"

He considered it. He always considered things. It was why Oz had kept him.

"*People, Majesty*," he said. "*A great many people.*"

"*And what else*?"

"*I don't know, Majesty*."

"*A net*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED TO THE nearest pane.

Not a window. A small square of dark glass, low in the wall, no bigger than her hand. She'd made it in the summer. After the crack. After she'd looked through the keyhole for the first time and seen what was out there.

She knelt in front of it.

And looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT AT A WINDOW. Not at a lantern. Not at a face.

At a *stone*.

Pale. Tall. Clouded, like old ice. Standing on its own on a village green, cracked from top to bottom down the middle, with lanterns hung round it on poles. And inside it, under the cloud, deep, the faintest glimmer.

Silver-blue.

Threads.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D FOUND THEM IN the summer. Through the keyhole. She hadn't known what they were.

Stones. All over the world. In every village. On every green and every crossroads and every square. Hundreds of them. Thousands. Pale and clouded and humming very faintly with a light that came from inside.

The world called them Lattice Stones.

The world put its children's hands on them when they were sixteen, and the Stones looked at the children, all the way through, and told them what they were.

Kindling, they called it.

She'd watched one. In the autumn. Through the crack. In a mill-town in the south. A boy. Thin, nervous, sixteen, in his best coat, with his whole village watching. He'd put his hand on the Stone, and the Stone had lit up from inside, silver-blue, and the boy had gone very still, and then he'd laughed.

Laughed and laughed. And turned round to his mother with his whole face shining.

She'd known what was in his face. She always did.

It saw me.

◆ ◆ ◆

It's glass, she'd thought. In the autumn. Kneeling at the keyhole. *It's only glass. Very old. Very deep. Very strange. But it lets the light through.*

So it's a pane.

And every pane is a door.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE PUT HER CLEAR hand flat against the small dark square in the wall.

And reached.

Through the glass. Through the grey. Out of the Court and across the Sundered Lands and over the snow and down into a village green two hundred miles away, where a cracked old Stone stood among the Lady's lanterns.

And in.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS COLD INSIDE.

Cold and enormous and humming. Like standing in a cathedral made of frost. Like being inside a bell after it's been struck. Threads everywhere. Silver-blue. Running away from her in every direction, fine as spider-silk, crossing and recrossing, knotting and parting, millions on millions of them. Each one humming its own small note.

Each one a *person*.

She could feel them. Every thread. A name on it. A class. A level. A life. The whole world, written out in light, strung across the dark like dew on a web at dawn.

She'd never seen anything so beautiful.

She'd never seen anything so *clear*.

◆ ◆ ◆

Oh, thought Ysenne of the Glass.

Oh, it's a mirror.

It's a mirror of everyone.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS WHAT THE net was. She saw it all at once, the way you see the shape of a room when someone lights a lamp. Not a cage. Not a lid. Not a gift. Not any of the things they called it in the world.

A mirror.

The greatest mirror ever made. Held up to every living soul. Showing each one what they were. Their name. Their class. Their level. The shape of them. Written in light, for them to see.

It saw me.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND AT THE MIDDLE of it—

She felt it. Far off. Deep down. At the bottom of the world, under the grey river, under the drowned country, where every thread came in and crossed and met.

A centre.

Warm. Gold. Like the hearth at the heart of a house.

And empty.

Nobody there. No hand on the threads. No one holding the mirror. Just a place where someone used to be, and the threads running into it and out of it, humming, untended, the way a harp hums in a room where nobody plays.

The crown in the road.

Cad had told them about it. In the hall. When they woke. Before he went down the thread. *The Root of the net is empty, Oz. The smith gave it away. It's lying there. Whoever turns the Key, the net offers them all of it.*

And Oz had said *the child first*. And Cad had said *the Key first*. And they'd argued, the way they always argued, and Cad had gone down the thread, and the Key had been turned by an old man in a crown that said *no*, and Cad had fallen with the thread into the dark, nodding.

And nobody had picked it up.

It was still lying there.

◆ ◆ ◆

If I held it, thought the Glass Queen. Inside the Stone. In the frost and the humming. *If I held the mirror. If I were the centre. If every thread in the world ran through my hands—*

Then it would see me.

Every thread. Every soul. Every name. Every one of them would look through the mirror and see—

Me.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE REACHED FOR IT.

Down. Along the threads. Toward the warm gold empty centre at the bottom of the world. Her clear hand going through the frost, through the humming, through the millions of fine bright lines, the way it went through any glass, easily, coldly, like a knife through water—

And the net turned her away.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT HARD. NOT ANGRY. Nets don't feel things. It just—turned. The way a door turns on its hinges when you push the wrong side. The way a lock turns a wrong key. Her hand slid off the centre like rain off a window.

And something came up the threads to meet her.

Not words. Not a voice. A *shape*. Gold. Very old. Stamped into the warm empty place at the middle of the net, the way a maker's mark is stamped into a horseshoe.

A name.

VEY.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE PULLED HER HAND back.

Out of the Stone. Out of the frost. Back across the snow and the Sundered Lands and the grey, into the round hall of a thousand panes, where she was kneeling on the clear floor in front of a small dark square of glass with her hand pressed flat against it.

She took her hand away.

It was shaking. She looked at it. She'd never seen it shake. Nine hundred years.

"*Majesty*?" said Orrin.

◆ ◆ ◆

Vey.

She knew the name. Everyone in the Court knew the name. Aurelian Vey, who wove the net that cast them out. The Listener with the little hammer, who stood on the shingle while the boat came and wouldn't look at them.

His blood was in the centre. Of course it was. He'd built it. He'd put himself in it like a stone in the foundation of a house. And the house remembered. Nine hundred years later, the house still opened only to his blood.

The smith gave it away, Cad had said.

The smith. The tall one with the burned arms and the grey eyes and Mae's handprint on his cheek. Lex Vey. Aurelian's blood, and Arion's.

And Hes's.

And the warden. His brother. With the scarred hands and the patience.

And—

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE STOOD UP.

She walked across the round hall. Past Orrin. Past a thousand reflected Orrins. To a pane she knew. High on the wall. Round, like a porthole. Clear.

She looked into it.

◆ ◆ ◆

A VALLEY. AT THE end of the world. Snow on the ground. A birch wood. A stream. A small stone cottage with one storey and an oak ramp and a blue door.

And in the window, on the west side—

A lantern. Horn-paned. A crooked hinge. Lit.

She couldn't see through horn. Horn doesn't let the light through clean; it scatters it, it softens it, it turns it to a glow with no shape in it. She'd learned that in the summer, at that very cottage, when the smith hung horn in every window and she couldn't find a way in.

But the stream outside was clear.

And still, at the edges, where it ran under the ice.

And from the stream she could see the window.

And through the window, past the horn lantern, in the firelight—

◆ ◆ ◆

A MAN ASLEEP IN a chair by the hearth. Big. Burned arms. Grey-gold handprint on his cheek. Asleep with his mouth open.

And on his chest, asleep too, with one square fist closed round the collar of his shirt and the other round a nail on a ribbon at her own neck—

A child.

A year old. A fluff of dark hair standing up like a bird's crest. Round face. Small. New.

New.

◆ ◆ ◆

OZ HAD WANTED HER.

From the very first night. Standing in the hall under the split cocoons with Mae's crown in his hand. *Bring me the smith's child.* Because she was new, and the Crowned can never make anything new, not ever again, because they drank the Well that new things come in by.

He'd wanted to keep her. Gold. Forever. Safe. His heir.

He'd gone to the cottage with the blue door. He'd sat on the floor by the fire and drunk tea from a lopsided cup. And the child had looked at him and said *no*.

And he'd come away with the cup instead.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE LOOKED AT THE child through the window, through the stream, through the ice, two hundred miles away.

At the fist round her father's collar. At the other fist round the nail.

Vey, she thought.

Vey on her father's side. Harrow on her grandmother's. Crowned, all the way back, to Hes.

And new.

Nobody's ever been all three.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CHILD STIRRED.

In her sleep. On her father's chest. Turned her head. And opened her eyes. Dark grey. Going green at the edges. Like a field going from frost to grass.

And looked at the window.

At the horn lantern. At the stream beyond it. At the ice. At the still clear water under the ice, where, two hundred miles away, through a round pane high in a glass wall, a woman with no reflection was looking back.

Ysenne went very still.

The child looked at her.

Not past her. Not through her. *At* her. Steadily. With the frank enormous interest of the very small, who have not yet learned what they are not supposed to see.

As if there were something there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN SHE YAWNED. AND put her fist in her mouth. And closed her eyes again. And went back to sleep on her father's chest.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE STOOD AT THE round pane in the high glass wall for a long time.

Behind her, Orrin waited. Three steps back. His hands folded.

In the hall of the long mirror, at the foot of a pillar, her sister slept on the clear floor with her crown of thorns crooked and a chain of glass round her thin grey wrists.

In the world, the wind went on coming in.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Orrin*," said the Glass Queen.

"*Majesty*."

"*How long does a child take to grow?*"

He considered it.

"*Some years, Majesty*," he said. "*I believe. It's been a long time since I had any to do with them.*"

"*Too long*," said Ysenne.

She turned away from the window.

"*Majesty*?"

"*The net opens to the blood*," said the Glass Queen. "*To his blood. Aurelian's. The house remembers its builder.*" She walked past him. Out of the round hall. Into the long one. "*So I'll need a Vey.*"

"*The smith, Majesty*? *The warden?*"

"*They'd never*," said Ysenne. "*Not freely. Not for me. And they're very strong now, Orrin. Too strong to make.*"

She stopped at the door.

Looked back. At the round pane, high on the glass wall, with the valley in it and the stream and the window and the sleeping child.

"*No*," she said. "*I'll need a small one.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

DOWN THE LONG HALL, in the dim, Rhosyn opened her eyes.

She didn't move. She lay on the clear floor at the foot of her pillar, in her chains, grey as ash, and listened to her sister's footsteps going away through the glass.

And in the dead brown thorns of her crown, very faint, so small that nobody would have seen it unless they'd been looking—

A bud.

Green.

PART ONE

THE OPEN EDGE

CHAPTER 1

Good Morning

"*Good morning*," said Lex to the fire.

It was banked down to a heap of grey ash with a red eye in the middle. He knelt on the hearthstone and blew on it, gently, the way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

It woke. Flickered. Caught the kindling. Climbed.

Good morning, said the fire.

Not in words. A warmth. A lift. A small bright gladness. The way a dog is glad when you come down the stairs.

He waited.

Nothing.

He'd known there'd be nothing. Seven weeks. Forty-nine mornings. He'd counted. He didn't want to count, but he was a smith, and smiths count. Strokes. Heats. Days.

Forty-nine mornings of kneeling on this stone and saying good morning and waiting, for a breath, for half a breath, for a dry small voice in the back of his head to say *[Good morning. You're up early.]*

Forty-nine mornings of nothing.

He fed the fire a stick of birch. It took it gladly.

He said it anyway. Every morning. Out loud.

It would be rude not to.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS MIDWINTER.

The shortest day. The longest night. Outside the east window the sky was still black, with a thin grey line along the top of the birch wood where dawn was thinking about it. Snow on the ground. Snow on the sill. Snow on the roof of the lean-to, and on the stepping stones across the stream, and on the grey stone by the water with the lanterns round it.

He could see them from the window. Small gold lights. Twenty of them. In a ring. In the snow.

They'd never gone out.

Hollis Penn came up from Ashbourne every second day with a can of oil and filled them. Nobody had asked him to. He just came. Trudged up the track through the birch wood in his baker's apron with flour on his elbows and filled the lanterns round the grave and trudged back down again. Lex had tried to thank him, once. Hollis had gone red to the ears and said *it's only oil* and fled.

Twenty lanterns. Iron and tin and clay. And a turnip, hollowed out, with a candle in it, that Pim had made, which had gone soft and black in the frost and which nobody had the heart to take away.

Round a grey stone. By a stream.

With two words cut into it, in letters Lex had cut himself, on the morning after Lantern Night, with a cold chisel and a hammer and his hands shaking so badly he'd had to stop three times.

ARION VEY.

And under that, smaller, because his mother had asked for it:

He turned back twice.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD AT THE window and looked at the lanterns until the grey line over the birches had gone pale.

Then he went to make the porridge.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COTTAGE AT HARROW was four rooms and a loft. Grey Vale stone and new oak beams and a door that stuck in wet weather. A table by the east window. A small iron lantern on the sill, with one word cut into the base where only someone who picked it up would see.

HERE.

Still lit. Always lit. For whoever was in the room.

This morning, that was Lex, and the porridge pot, and—arriving at speed down the loft ladder, backwards, on her stomach, with a sound like a sack of potatoes being thrown down a well—his daughter.

"*Lark*," said Lex.

She landed at the bottom. On her bottom. Sat there for a moment, considering whether this was the sort of thing she cried about.

Decided it wasn't.

Got up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D BEEN WALKING FOR three weeks.

If you could call it walking. It was more like falling forward and catching herself, over and over, very fast, with her arms out and her square fists clenched and a look of fierce concentration on her round face, like someone carrying a full bucket across an icy yard. She went everywhere at that speed. She didn't seem to have another one.

She came across the floor now. *Thump*. *Thump*. *Thump*. Lurching. Wobbling. Her fluff of dark hair standing straight up on top of her head like the crest of an outraged bird. In a nightshirt Wren had cut down from one of Lex's, so long it trailed behind her like a train.

She arrived at his legs. Grabbed his breeches in both fists. Hung there. Looked up at him.

Grey eyes. Going green. More green than grey now. From the edges in, like a field in spring.

"*Morning*," said Lex.

"*Mmo-ning*," said Lark. Approximately.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D SAID IT FIRST on the morning after Lantern Night. To the fire.

He'd been kneeling on the hearthstone. And she'd come across the floor on her hands and knees—she hadn't been walking then—and sat down beside him and looked at the flames. Very seriously. The way she looked at everything. And said it.

Mo. Nn. Mmo-ning.

And the fire had leaned toward her.

He'd seen it. All the flames. Bending. Together. Toward the small square figure on the hearthstone, the way grass leans in the wind, the way a dog leans against your legs. Glad.

And for a moment—

He didn't think about that moment. He'd decided not to. He'd decided it was a fire being a fire, and a baby being a baby, and a man who'd lost a voice in his head hearing it where it wasn't.

Probably.

He'd decided that forty-nine times.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Porridge*," he said.

"*No*," said Lark.

"*Yes*."

"*No*."

"*You haven't even seen it yet*."

Lark considered this. Then let go of his breeches, sat down hard on the floor, and said, with enormous satisfaction, as if settling the matter for all time:

"*No*."

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS HER WORD.

She had others now. *Mmo-ning*. *Mam*, for Wren. *Da*, for him, sometimes, when she wanted something. *Ash*, for the dragon, and for anything else large and frightening and wonderful. *Gog*, for the goat. *Hot*, for the fire and the stove and the forge and, for some reason, the moon.

But *no* was her word. Her first. The one she'd said to a king.

She'd been sitting on the hearthrug in his mother's cottage, three weeks before her first birthday. And the biggest man in the world had been kneeling in front of her. Gold. Glowing like metal in a crucible. With his great gold hand held out. Reaching for her. Very slowly. Very gently. The way you'd reach for a bird.

Come here, little one.

And she'd looked at him. At the hand. At the furnace eyes.

And taken her fist out of her mouth.

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D LAUGHED.

That was the thing Lex remembered. The Gilded King, kneeling on the floor, with his hand out, and a baby telling him no. And he'd thrown back his great gold head and laughed. Not cruelly. Not angrily. As if it were the best thing he'd heard in nine hundred years.

Then he'd taken his hand back.

And he hadn't reached for her again.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Please*," said Lex.

"*No*."

"*There's honey*."

A pause. A long one. The round face working.

"*Hunny*," said Lark. Thoughtfully. Not committing to anything.

"*Lots of honey*."

She got up. *Thump*. *Thump*. Arrived at the bench. Raised both arms. Waited to be lifted, with the air of a queen waiting for her carriage.

He lifted her.

She grabbed his nose.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME DOWN WHILE the porridge was still too hot. Barefoot. Yawning. In his old shirt and her own breeches, with her fox-red hair in a braid down her back that she'd slept on and was coming apart.

She stopped at the bottom of the ladder.

Looked at the table. At her husband, with his nose in their daughter's fist. At their daughter, with honey on both cheeks and in her hair and, somehow, on her eyebrow.

"*I was gone ten minutes*," said Wren.

"*Fifteen*."

"*How is it on her eyebrow*?"

"*She's very thorough*."

Wren came and sat down. Kissed Lark on the one bit of forehead that didn't have honey on it. Kissed Lex on the cheek. On the left side. On the handprint.

She always kissed that side. He'd noticed. Since the Blightmarch. Since a Moth Queen slapped him in the deep and left her hand there, grey-gold, five fingers, a palm, permanent. Wren always kissed it. As if to say *I see it*. As if to say *it's mine too*.

"*You were up early*," she said.

"*Midwinter. It's dark till eight.*"

"*You were up at four*."

He didn't answer.

She didn't push. She took the spoon off him and started feeding Lark herself, with the brisk efficiency of a woman who had been feeding babies for fourteen months and had stopped expecting it to be clean.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WATCHED HER DO it.

Her right hand on the spoon. Her left hand on the bowl.

Her left hand.

The first two fingers. And the thumb. Gold.

Not gilt. Not paint. *Gold*. From the tips to the second knuckle. Stopped. Kept. Smooth and bright and cold, like the fingers of a statue, with the nails still on them, gold too. She could move the hand. The wrist. The other two fingers. But the gold ones didn't bend.

The Night of Glass. Midsummer. The yard at Harrow full of gold dust and glass and screaming, and Orrin's storm coming over the wall, and Wren with her bow up and her mist pouring out of her, fogging every pane, every barrel, every bucket, so the Glass Queen couldn't find a way through.

And the dust had come down on her drawing hand.

She'd kept shooting. Lex had seen it. Afterward. Seen the arrows in the yard, in the mud, in the gold, a dozen of them, every one of them loosed after her fingers stopped.

She hadn't said anything about it. Not that night. Not since. She'd learned to draw with her right. She'd learned to tie her boots with three

fingers. She'd learned to braid her hair one-handed, badly. She'd learned to hold their daughter in the crook of her left arm with the gold fingers spread so they wouldn't press.

She never complained.

He sometimes wished she would. So he'd have something to *do*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're staring*," said Wren. Without looking up.

"*Sorry*."

"*It's fine*." She wiped Lark's eyebrow with her thumb. Her right thumb. "*Is it the fingers or the porridge?*"

"*Both*."

"*The porridge is your fault*," said Wren. "*The fingers are his.*" She spooned another mouthful in. Lark took it. Under protest. "*Eat yours. You're going over the stream.*"

"*How do you know*?"

"*Because it's Midwinter*," said his wife. "*And she'll have been up since four too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT OVER THE stream.

Across the stepping stones, in the snow, with his breath smoking. Five stones. Flat grey ones, slick with ice. He'd laid them himself, two springs ago, so his father's chair could cross. Then he'd built the ramp on the other side, when the stones got too much. Then he'd stopped needing to.

He didn't look at the grave as he passed it.

He always looked at the grave as he passed it.

He looked at it now. The grey stone. The twenty lanterns. The soft black turnip. The snow on top, a little drift, like a cap. *ARION VEY*.

Morning, he thought.

He didn't wait for an answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BLUE-DOOR COTTAGE WAS small and stone and one storey, with an oak ramp up to the door and the boards down off every window now. Brannoc had come up the week after and taken them down, one by

one, and stacked them in the lean-to without a word. And polished the glass with a rag. And gone away again.

The door was open a crack.

Smoke from the chimney. A smell of tea.

He knocked anyway.

"*It's open*," said his mother. "*It's always open. You know that. Stop knocking.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS AT THE table under the west window.

In a grey shawl. With a cup of tea going cold in front of her, and a book open beside it. Grey cloth binding. Rubbed pale at the corners. Thick. Full of loose pages tucked in at the back, and a ribbon, and a pressed flower.

The grey book.

She looked up when he came in. Brown eyes. Not grey. Never grey. That was his father. Lex had his father's eyes, and Antho had his mother's, and when she looked up at him in the morning light he always had a moment of—

Nothing. A moment of nothing. Of reaching for something that wasn't there.

"*Sit*," said Seren. "*There's tea in the pot.*"

He sat. He poured.

The cup was blue. Chipped at the rim. Not lopsided. Not too thick. Not the one with the thumb-print. That one had gone gold, and walked away east in a gold hand, and was somewhere in the world now, with a gold disc of tea in it nobody could ever drink.

He drank.

It was the good kind. In a tin.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE SILL BEHIND her, in the west window, a lantern.

Horn. Four panes. A crooked hinge—the left one. He'd meant to fix it. He'd been meaning to fix it for a year. He'd made the whole thing in the spring, at the forge, at night, when nobody was watching. Shaped the iron frame. Shaved the horn panes so thin you could read through them. Cut two words into the base, where only someone who picked it up would see.

And wrapped it in sacking. And hidden it. And carried it across the grey country and back. For her birthday. For Lantern Night.

It was lit.

He'd lit it himself, on the morning after Lantern Night, in the grey dawn, with his own fire. He'd carried it in and set it on this sill, beside the candle Wren had left there. Facing out. Facing west. Facing the road and the birch wood and the grave by the stream and the edge of the world.

TOO LATE.

It hadn't gone out either.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's Midwinter*," said his mother.

"*I know*."

"*The shortest day*." She turned a page. Not reading it. Just turning it. "*He used to say it was the best one. Because after it, they all get longer.*" A small dry sound. Not quite a laugh. "*He said that every year. I remember. I remember every single time he said it.*"

Lex said nothing.

"*Eleven times*," said Seren Harrow. "*Eleven Midwinters. Ten in the old cottage, before he went away. And one here, last year, that I didn't remember at the time and remember now.*" She shook her head. "*Your brother at four. You in a basket. The year it snowed so hard we couldn't open the door and he climbed out of the window to dig us out, in his nightshirt, and fell in a drift.*" She put her hand flat on the open page. "*I remember all of them now. Every one. And there won't be any more.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS THE THING.

He'd thought about it a lot. In the forge. At night. Kneeling at the hearth.

For a year and a half, his mother hadn't remembered his father at all. Not one day. Not one word. She'd given every memory of him to the Ferryman to come home. She'd come out of the dark at the Hollowmaw past eleven hundred lanterns to an old man in a wheeled chair she'd never seen before, and said, politely, *you have a nice voice*.

And fallen in love with him. All over again. From nothing. In a year and a half. An old man she didn't know, getting older every week, dying in front of her.

And then, at the very end—two nights before Lantern Night, in a bed by this window—she'd got it all back.

Ember had paid for it.

A love for a love. That was the Ferryman's price. Ember had given its love for Lex, the whole of it, everything it had felt for him in seven years of living in the back of his head. And the Ferryman had given Seren back thirty years.

Every Midwinter. Every word. Every snowdrift.

And then his father had died. That same night. With her hand in his.

She'd had him for an hour. All of him. The whole thirty years, every memory, all at once, back where it belonged. For an hour.

And now she had to lose him twice.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mam*," said Lex.

"*Don't*," said his mother. "*Don't be kind. I can't stand it this morning. Your brother was kind all of last week and I nearly hit him with the kettle.*"

"*I wasn't going to be kind*."

"*What were you going to be*?"

He thought about it.

"*Hungry*," he said. "*Wren made porridge. There's honey in Lark's eyebrows.*"

His mother looked at him for a long moment.

Then she laughed. A real one. Short and surprised and cracked down the middle, like ice on a pond. And put her hand over her face. And sat there with her shoulders shaking.

He didn't know if she was laughing or crying.

He didn't think she knew either.

He reached across the table and put his hand on her arm. And left it there. And drank his tea.

◆ ◆ ◆

AFTER A WHILE SHE took her hand away from her face.

"*There*," she said. "*That's done.*" She wiped her eyes on the corner of the shawl. "*Every morning. I sit down and I open his book and I think, this morning I won't. And then I do.*" She sniffed. "*Harrow women don't cry, you know. My mother never cried. Not once. Not even when she was dying.*"

"*Did it help*?"

"*No*," said Seren. "*I don't think so. I think it just made her very good at not crying.*" She looked at the open book. "*He cried all the time. Did you know? At weddings. At songs. At the first lambs. He cried when you were born. Both of you. He cried at the Spire, the first day, on the steps, in the rain, when I told him my name.*" A pause. "*I thought he was mad. I was nineteen. I thought, who is this man, crying on the steps because a girl told him her name.*"

"*Was he*?"

"*Mad*?" She smiled. "*Completely. He was two hundred years old and he'd never been in love before. It went to his head.*" She turned another page. "*It never came out again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT THE page she'd turned to.

His father's handwriting. Small. Neat. Slanting a little to the right. The hand of a man who'd kept ledgers for two hundred years.

It was the last page.

He knew it was. He'd seen it. On the morning after. His father had written it himself, in the spring, after the long list of names—the Vhessan dead, eleven thousand of them, every one he could find, every one his breach had killed—and after Isaura Kell, and after Elric Thorne. At the very bottom. Last. Where he'd asked to be.

One line.

Arion Vey. Who had a very long life and a very good wife. Twice.

And under it, in another hand—Lex's hand, cramped and heavy, a smith's hand, pressing too hard—the date.

That was all.

That was the whole of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I read it every morning*," said his mother. "*Every morning. Like a madwoman.*" She closed the book. Gently. "*Then I go and stand at the window and look at the lantern and think, too late. Every single morning.*" She looked at him. "*Do you know what I think, Lex?*"

"*What*?"

"*I think he knew*," said Seren Harrow. "*When he wrote it. Page nine. Don't ever leave a light on for me.*" She put her hand flat on the grey cover. "*I think he knew I'd do it anyway. I think he wanted me to have something to say back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STAYED AN HOUR.

He mended the hinge.

The left one, on the horn lantern. He took it off the sill and carried it to the table and opened the little iron door and looked at the flame inside—small, gold, steady, on its twist of tallowed cotton—and then shut it again, carefully, and fixed the hinge with a pin and a tap of the little hammer from his belt while it was still lit.

It took four minutes.

He'd been meaning to do it for a year.

"*There*," he said. And set it back on the sill.

His mother looked at it. At the hinge. Straight now. At the two words in the base.

"*Thank you*," she said.

"*It's only a pin*."

"*I know what it is*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT BACK ACROSS the stream in the full grey light of the shortest day.

Past the grave. Past the twenty lanterns. Past the black turnip.

Morning, he thought.

He went into the forge.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FORGE AT HARROW was small. A lean-to against the east wall of the cottage, stone on three sides and open on the fourth, with a slate roof and a chimney he'd built himself. One anvil. One hearth. One bellows. A rack of tools. A water barrel with a lid on it now—a wooden lid, heavy, that he'd made in the summer and nailed a strap to, so that nothing could look out of it at night.

Every pane at Harrow was horn now. Every window. Every lantern.

Every bucket had a lid.

He lit the hearth.

Good morning, said the fire.

Morning, said Lex. Out loud.

He waited. Half a breath.

Nothing.

He picked up the little hammer.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BASKET WAS UNDER the bench.

Wicker. Old. Lined with straw. The kind of basket you'd carry eggs in, or apples, or a cat to the farrier. It had been his father's. Then it had come down to the bottom of the world with him, on Lantern Night, through Mal's pool and down the long dark to the Knot.

He pulled it out. And knelt. And lifted the lid.

◆ ◆ ◆

THREE PIECES OF BLACK iron.

Not black like soot. Black like the space between stars. Lying in the straw. A ring—the bow. A short square bar notched like a ward—the bit. And a long slim shaft—the blade—that had once held them together.

The Key of Shadows.

Nine hundred years ago a frightened young man with a little hammer had forged it out of his own shadow. It had locked the starving Well. It had unwritten names. It had been held by a traitor and barred by a forge-thing called the Lockward and kept in the Knot at the bottom of the world by an old man's thread for four years.

And on Lantern Night that old man had put on a dead girl's crown and turned it, one last time, against the Veil.

And it had come apart in his hand. Into three. The way it had been made.

Lex had picked up the pieces. He didn't know why. He'd knelt on the black glass at the bottom of the world with his brother beside him and the Veil falling somewhere far off overhead, and picked them up, one by one, and put them in the basket.

He hadn't touched them since.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BESIDE THEM, IN the straw—

A crown.

Small. Plain. Grey. Not silver. Not gold. Not set with anything. Seven points, short and blunt, like the teeth of a comb. The kind of crown you'd make for a child out of whatever metal was lying around.

Hesper's.

The tenth heir. The girl who wouldn't drink. Who stood at the edge of a black pool in a hidden garden nine hundred years ago with her brothers and sisters kneeling round it, and took off her crown, and set it on the grass, and said *no*.

It had said no ever since.

For nine hundred years. In a box. On a chair in an empty tower. On an old man's head, at the bottom of the world, with the whole net offering him everything.

No. Not me. Not ever.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T PICK IT up.

He'd tried, once. In the first week. And it had been cold in his hand, very cold, colder than iron in snow, and very still. Not saying anything. Not to him. Just—resting. The way a dog rests by a door.

I think it might have one more no in it, his brother had said.

Antho had carried it out of the dark. Up through the pool. Home. He'd held it in his scarred hands the whole way, very gently, the way you'd carry a bird with a broken wing.

And put it in the basket. Beside the three pieces of the Key.

And they'd sat there. In the straw. Under the bench. For seven weeks. While Lex lit the forge every morning and said good morning to the fire and made nails and hinges and horseshoes and pot-hooks for half of Ashbourne, because his hands needed something to do.

He looked at them.

What am I supposed to do with you?

They didn't answer either.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT THE LID back on.

And stood up.

And because it was Midwinter, and because he was a smith, and smiths count—

Status, thought Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
ATTUNEMENT
  Flame ........ COMMANDING
  Stone ........ COMMANDING
  Tide ......... SPEAKING
  Gale ......... SPEAKING
  Hollow ....... SPEAKING
  Shade ........ ANSWERING
  Radiance ..... ANSWERING
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT.

Silver-blue. Hanging in the air in front of him, over the anvil, where only he could see it. The way it had hung every day of his life since a stranger walked into the Ashbourne forge and the seal on his blood cracked open in a storm of gold fire.

Ninety-nine.

The top of Tier IV. As high as you could go. As high as anyone had gone since Aurelian.

There was nothing after ninety-nine. Nothing anyone knew of. Not in the net. Not for anyone with a thread. Except, maybe, the thing nobody wanted. The thing his brother had felt under his hands at the bottom of the world, on Lantern Night, when the net turned toward an old man in a borrowed crown and offered him *everything*.

The crown in the road.

Still lying there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T LOOK AT the level.

He looked at the bottom of the panel.

At the empty space under the last line. Where, for seven years, there'd been something else. Not on the panel. Not in silver. In *gold*. Bleeding through. A line of warm ember-coloured text, small, at the very bottom, in the corner, the way you'd sign a letter.

[Good morning, Lex.]

Or *[You're doing it wrong]*. Or *[Footnote six hundred and eleven: the smith has once again failed to eat breakfast]*.

Seven years.

He looked at the empty space under the panel for a long time.

Then he closed it. And picked up the hammer. And drew a bar of iron out of the fire, glowing, and laid it on the anvil, and struck.

Clang.

The forge rang.

It was the only voice there was.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE ELEVEN NAILS before noon.

Hinges for Hollis Penn's bakehouse door. A pot-hook for the widow Tull. A new tyre for a cartwheel off one of the Coldwater wagons, which he did in the yard in the snow, with the wheel on the stone and the tyre heated in a ring of fire he called up out of the ground, because it was quicker than the hearth and he wanted to feel it. The heat. The roar. The weight of it.

[Show-off,] said nobody.

He shrank the tyre on with a bucket of snow. It hissed. Steam went up in a white cloud into the grey Midwinter sky.

He stood in the yard in the steam and breathed.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC CAME UP THE track at noon.

He came most days. On the pretence of bringing something—a sack of charcoal, a bundle of bar-iron, a pie from Hollis that Hollis had sent up and Brannoc had eaten half of on the way. He never stayed long. He'd stand in the doorway of the lean-to with his great arms folded and look at whatever Lex was making, and grunt, and say something about the quench. And go away again.

He was sixty-five. Huge. Bald. Soot in the creases of his face that never washed out, and a beard like a burnt hedge. He'd taken Lex in at eleven, after the fire. He'd swung him up onto the anvil on the first day and said *this is yours now, lad*.

He was the father Lex had actually had.

He stood in the doorway now. With a sack over his shoulder and half a pie in his other hand.

Not his other hand. His *left* hand.

The fingertips. All four. And the thumb. Gold. To the first knuckle. Smooth and bright and cold. Where Orrin's dust had come down on them on the green at Ashbourne in the spring, when the gilt-storm came and Brannoc stood between it and a cart full of children with nothing but a hammer and a hymn.

He'd laughed about it. Afterward. Held them up in the firelight in the Crooked Kettle and said *look at that, lads, I'm worth something at last*.

He'd never complained either.

Lex sometimes thought that was the worst thing about the people he loved. None of them ever complained.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Pie*," said Brannoc.

"*Half a pie*."

"*It was a long walk*." He held it out. Lex took it. Mutton and onion. Still warm. Brannoc set the sack down. Charcoal. Then looked at the

cartwheel on the stone in the yard. At the tyre. At the faint ring of scorched earth round it in the snow.

"*Hm*," said Brannoc.

"*It's tight*."

"*I can see it's tight*." He walked over. Bent. Looked at the join. Ran his good thumb along the rim. Then his gold one. *Tick*. Gold on iron. "*Called it up out of the ground again, did you?*"

"*It was quicker*."

"*Quicker*." Brannoc straightened up. Slowly. His back cracked. "*You've got a hearth, lad. Right there. Bellows and all. Took you a week to build.*"

"*I know*."

"*So use it*." The old smith looked at him. Small black eyes in the soot. Steady. "*Or don't. Your forge. But I've known you since you were eleven and you've never once done a thing the quick way unless you were running from something.*"

Lex didn't answer.

He ate the pie.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC DIDN'T PUSH EITHER. Nobody ever pushed. They all just stood there and looked at him, and said one thing, and went quiet, and waited. As if he were iron in the fire and they were waiting for the colour to come up.

He wished one of them would just *hit* him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Raven came*," said Brannoc. After a while. "*At the Forge. For you. From the west.*" He reached into his apron and drew out a folded paper, small, tied with black thread, and a little crushed from having been in a smith's apron with a pie. "*Elowen's hand.*"

Lex wiped his fingers and took it.

◆ ◆ ◆

Lex,

Westerling. Nine miles in from the old edge. Snow. Bad.

They're coming in. The gold ones. The nine thousand. Spreading out across the Westmarch, a few hundred yards a day, some faster. They don't do anything. They don't touch anything. They just walk. East. Through fields, through hedges, through the middle of villages. People are frightened. A carter at Hobb's Cross took an axe to one. Axe went in an inch and stuck. The gold man didn't stop. Walked on with the axe in his shoulder. The carter's not right since.

They hum. You know what they hum.

Roole's still in the gate at Greyfall. Still gold. Still standing. I go and see him every few days. I talk to him. I don't know if he hears. His eyes move.

Something else.

At Westerling the bread won't rise.

I know how that sounds. I didn't believe it either. The baker there is a sensible woman, and she sent for me, and I went, and I watched her make a batch. Good flour. Good yeast, fresh from the brewer. Warm kitchen. It sat in the bowl all night under a cloth and in the morning it was exactly the same. Not risen. Not soured. Not anything. As if it hadn't noticed the night go by.

Her hens haven't laid in a fortnight. The ones on the next farm have laid and the eggs don't hatch. A boy cut his hand on a scythe a week ago and it hasn't closed. Not festered. Not healed. Just stayed. As if it were still the moment he did it.

It's only at Westerling and the farms west of it. Nearest the old edge. For now.

Seraphine thinks it's moving.

Come and look. Bring Wren. Bring your eyes. I don't know what I'm seeing.

E.

P.S. The King's footprints go east from the old edge across the snow for sixty miles and then turn north toward Thistledown. Gold. A step wide. You can see them from the hills. Nobody will walk on them.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX READ IT TWICE.

Then he folded it again. Carefully. And held it.

"*Bad*?" said Brannoc.

"*I don't know*." He looked west. Over the birch wood. Over the stream and the grave and the blue-door cottage with its horn lantern in the west window. At the grey Midwinter sky. "*The bread won't rise.*"

Brannoc frowned.

"*Bread always rises*," he said. "*If you leave it. That's what bread does. That's the whole point of bread.*" He paused. "*Bad yeast?*"

"*Good yeast. Warm kitchen.*" Lex looked at the paper in his hand. "*It sat all night and didn't notice the night go by.*"

The old smith was quiet.

He looked down at his left hand. At the gold fingertips. Smooth. Bright. Cold. Stopped.

"*Ah*," said Brannoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT BACK IN.

Lex finished the pie. Then he stood in the yard for a while, in the snow, by the cartwheel, with Elowen's letter in his hand, looking west.

It hasn't closed. Not festered. Not healed. Just stayed.

As if it were still the moment he did it.

He thought of a gold field. Forty sheep. A boy among them with his crook out. Mid-step. His eyes moving.

He thought of a hawk. Gold. Stopped in the air, mid-stoop, its wings half-folded, hanging over a field at the edge of the world as if somebody had pinned it to the sky.

He thought of the grey country. The dust. The white road. The towers. A country with no sun and no wind and no rain and nothing growing, where nothing had been new for nine hundred years.

And no edge between it and the world anymore. Nothing at all.

Seraphine thinks it's moving.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE WAS LOW in the forge when he went back in. He knelt and fed it.

Good afternoon, it said. Glad.

He didn't say anything back. He was thinking.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS WHEN HE heard it.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT A VOICE IN his head. Not anymore. Nothing lived there now.

A voice in the *fire*.

No.

Under it.

In the hollow of the hearth. In the space under the coals, where the ash falls through the grate into the dark. The small round emptiness every hearth has at the bottom of it, that nobody ever looks at. The room a fire stands in.

[...smith...]

He went very still.

He knew the voice. He'd have known it anywhere. Small. Soft. Frightened. Too big for itself and too young for its size. Like a child talking in a very large dark house.

It had spoken to him on Lantern Night. At the bottom of the world. *[...smith, come UP...something's happening...]*

It hadn't spoken to him since.

Mal?

[...smith...can you hear...I'm in your fire...I mean...not IN it...under...in the little room under it...every hearth has one...I didn't know I could...I'm sorry...]

I can hear you. He knelt on the hearthstone with his hands on his knees. *Mal. What's wrong?*

A pause. A long one. Somewhere very far away, three hundred miles off, in a green circle in the east with a pool in the middle, something enormous and young was trying to find words.

[...they're HERE...]

Who?

[...the grey ones...the ones from over the edge...they came on the wind...the first night...I felt them coming...thousands...and they're here now...all round me...round the rim...standing...waiting...]

The voice shook.

[...they want to come IN...they want to come home...and I want to let them...I do...I really do...I'm the room...that's what I'm FOR...]

Then let them—

[...I CAN'T...]

It came up out of the hollow under the coals so hard the fire flinched. The flames bent away. Ash puffed out over the hearthstone.

[...I'm too LITTLE...smith...I'm still too little...there are so many of them...if I let them all in I'll...I'll be FULL...and then I'll stop...and then there won't be any room...not for them...not for the new things...not for ANYTHING...]

Silence.

The fire flickered. Steadied.

[...Ivy's here...] said the seventh Well. Smaller. *[...she says to tell you...she says come...she says bring your brother...she says...]*

A pause.

[...she says she's frightened too...]

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX KNELT ON THE hearthstone in the forge at Harrow, on the shortest day of the year, with a letter from the west in his apron and his hands on his knees and the fire leaning toward him, glad, the way it always was.

He looked at the basket under the bench.

He looked west.

He looked at his hands.

[...smith?]

"*I'm coming*," said Lex.

Out loud. To the fire. To the little room under it.

"*I'm coming*."

CHAPTER 2

The Dead at the Rim

ANTHO VEY COUNTED THE lanterns every morning.

He didn't need to. He knew how many there were. He'd hung most of them himself, over seven years, one by one, on hooks and nails and iron pins driven into the stone of the cave at the Hollowmaw, from the mouth all the way back to the black door at the end. Lanterns for the lost. Lanterns for the ones who hadn't come home. Iron and brass and tin and clay and glass and horn. Every shape. Every size.

One thousand, one hundred and thirteen.

He counted them anyway. Every morning. Walking slowly down the long cave in the grey light with his hands behind his back, looking up. The way his father used to walk the ledgers in the Spire. The way you'd walk a line of sleeping children to make sure they were all still breathing.

One. Two. Three.

It was a habit. It was a prayer. He'd started it in the mad years, when he was alone up here with a voice in his head that wanted to eat the world, and counting was the only thing that held. He'd never stopped.

Four hundred and twelve. Four hundred and thirteen.

They were all lit.

They'd been lit since Lantern Night. Every one. Not one had guttered in seven weeks. He hadn't filled them. Nobody had. They didn't need it. They burned on nothing now, on air, on whatever it was that a given light burns on when the giving is finished and the light stays anyway.

Nine hundred and ninety-nine. One thousand.

At the end of the cave, at the black door, the last three. Hung together. On one hook. A clay lamp, small and lopsided, with a thumb-print in the rim. An iron one, with *ARDENT* on the base. And a third, plain tin, that his father had hung there the night before the wedding, two winters ago.

One thousand one hundred and eleven. One thousand one hundred and twelve.

He stopped in front of the tin one.

One thousand one hundred and thirteen.

He stood there for a while.

Then he went back up the cave to put the kettle on.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS MIDWINTER. THE shortest day. Snow at the mouth of the cave, deep, blue in the dawn. The Greyspine white and sharp against a sky like a knife. Cold enough to crack stone.

Seraphine was asleep.

She slept in the alcove off the cave mouth, on the low bed they'd built into the rock, under three blankets and a bearskin and a quilt Odile had made, with her spectacles folded on the shelf beside her and her ink-stained fingers curled under her chin. She slept like a scholar. Badly. With books. There were four in the bed with her this morning. One of them was open on her chest, rising and falling.

He stood in the doorway of the alcove and looked at her.

He did that a lot. More, lately. Since the autumn. Since a bed by a west window and a hand going slack in his, and his mother's voice, very quiet, saying *there*, the way you'd say it when the last stitch goes in.

He'd come home from the bottom of the world on Lantern Night and walked up the mountain in the dawn and found her here. Standing at the mouth of the cave. Alone. Looking up at the sky. With every lantern behind her lit.

She hadn't said anything. She'd just put her arms round him.

He hadn't let go for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE THE TEA.

He made it the way his father had made it, in the Spire, two hundred years of practice: warm the pot, one spoon each and one for the pot, water just off the boil, not on it, never on it, *you'll scald the leaf, Anthoren, it's not a horseshoe*. He'd learned it in the last year. In the mornings at Harrow, in the blue-door cottage. His father in the wheeled chair by the window, too weak to lift the kettle, telling him how. Patiently. Every morning. As if it mattered.

It did matter. Antho knew that now.

It was the only thing his father had ever taught him with his hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK A CUP to the cave mouth and stood in the snow and drank it.

Below him the mountain fell away into cloud. Somewhere under the cloud was Ashbourne. And beyond Ashbourne, south, the Vale. And somewhere at the end of the Vale, in a birch wood, by a stream, a grey stone with twenty lanterns round it, and a cottage with a blue door, and a horn lantern in the west window.

TOO LATE.

He'd been at the window when Lex set it there. In the grey dawn after Lantern Night. He'd watched his little brother carry it up the ramp and through the door and set it on the sill. And stand there. And not move. For a long time.

He hadn't said anything. There wasn't anything to say.

He drank his tea.

He looked at his left hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE BACK OF it, between the knuckles and the wrist, a coin.

Not a coin. A *place*. A round of gold the size of a coin. Smooth. Bright. Cold. Where a single grain of the Gilded King's dust had landed on him in the grey country, in the crack, running, with the Glass Queen's servants behind them and Hask going gold.

He could feel it. Not with the hand. With everything else. A small cold stillness in the middle of him. Like a held breath. Like a door that won't open, in a house where all the other doors do.

He'd tried to open it.

Every night. In the dark. With Shade, with Hollow, with everything he had. He was the Threshold Warden. He was the man who kept the edge between the world and the dark. He'd opened the black door at the bottom of the Hollowmaw with a knock. He'd opened a breach in the world a hundred miles across by asking.

He couldn't open a coin of gold on the back of his own hand.

It's not locked, Lex had said. In the autumn. Holding the hand. *It's not a door. It's kept. There's nothing in it to open.*

Then what do I do?

I don't know, his brother had said. *I don't know. I'm sorry.*

He'd never heard Lex say that. Not about iron. Not about anything you could put your hands on.

He put the hand in his pocket. And drank his tea.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VOICE CAME AT noon.

He was in the cave, halfway down, on a ladder, taking down a lantern from a high hook to look at its chain, which had gone thin at one link. Not because it needed doing. Because his hands needed doing.

And the lantern spoke.

No.

The *hollow* in the lantern. The round empty space inside it, under the flame, where the light stood. Every lantern had one. Every lamp, every cup, every bowl.

[...brother...]

He nearly fell off the ladder.

[...brother...it's me...I'm in your lantern...I mean...not IN it...in the room in it...I didn't know I could do that...Ivy says I can do it anywhere there's a little room...I'm sorry...did I frighten you...]

He held onto the ladder.

He knew the voice. He'd known it for eight years, when it was the only voice in the world and it wanted to eat him. And he'd known it for two years since, when it came back, small and sorry and frightened, asking for the lamp-lady and for someone called *Mal*.

Mal.

[...brother...]

I'm here. He came down the ladder. Slowly. With the lantern in his hand. *I'm here, Mal. What is it?*

[...they're here...] said the seventh Well. *[...the grey ones...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOLD HIM ALL of it.

In pieces. In the small frightened voice of a child in a very large dark house. The grey ones. The first night. The wind, coming from the west, and on the wind, thousands of them. Drifting. Grey. Columns of dust standing up off the snow and swaying, the way smoke sways. Coming across the world from the edge. Toward the green circle. Toward the pool. Toward *him*.

[...because I'm the room...that's what they want...they want somewhere to GO...and I'm the only room there is...]

Then let them in.

[...I CAN'T...]

The lantern shook in his hand. The flame flinched.

[...there are so many...brother...thousands...and I'm still so little...if I let them all in I'll be full...and if I'm full I'll stop...and then there won't be any room...not for anything...not for babies or seeds or bread or new things or ANYTHING...]

Silence. The flame steadied.

[...I told the smith...] said Mal. Smaller. *[...just now...I found his fire...he's coming...Ivy says bring you too...she says...]* A pause. *[...she says please...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT TO THE alcove.

Seraphine was sitting up in the bed with her spectacles on and a book in her lap and another one under her elbow and a quill behind her ear. She looked up when he came in. Saw his face.

She put the book down.

"*Mal*," she said.

"*Mal*."

"*In the hearth. Just now.*" She pointed. At the little fire in the alcove grate. "*It talked to me. Out of the ash pan. I thought I was dreaming. I've*

been sitting here for ten minutes writing down what it said in case I was." She held up the paper. Her hand was shaking. *"Antho, it said there are thousands of them."*

"It said that to me too."

"It's frightened."

"It's frightened." He sat down on the edge of the bed. *"It's been frightened for seven weeks. Seven weeks, Sera. With thousands of the dead standing round it. And it didn't say anything. To anyone. Because it didn't know it could."*

She looked at him.

"Like someone else I know," said Seraphine Ilvane. Gently.

He didn't answer that.

He got up and went to saddle the dragon.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CAME UP THE mountain at dusk.

On foot. In the snow. Fast. The way he always came up mountains, as if they'd insulted him. With a pack on his back and a coat over his forge clothes and his face red with cold and the handprint on his cheek standing out grey-gold against it. And the bell. Antho could hear the bell, under his shirt, faint, as he came up the last switchback. Not ringing. Just moving. The way a bell does when the man wearing it is walking hard.

Ashka heard him first. She lifted her great head off the snow at the mouth of the cave and made a sound low in her chest. Not a growl. A rumble. The sound she made for people she'd decided were hers.

Lex stopped at the top of the path. Looked at the dragon. At his brother. At the saddle on the dragon. At the packs.

"You heard it too," he said.

"Out of a lantern."

"Out of my hearth."

"Out of the ash pan," said Seraphine. Coming out of the cave with her arms full of books. *"Hello, Lex. Have you eaten? You haven't eaten. You never eat when you're frightened. Antho, give him the bread."*

Antho gave him the bread.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FLEW EAST IN the dark.

Ashka was the size of a barn now. Grey as a storm, with silver along the edges of her scales like frost along the edges of slate, and wings that cracked when she opened them like a ship's sail filling. She'd been the size of a cat once. Antho had found her in a snare with a torn wing in the Greyspine, ten years ago, in the mad years, and carried her home inside his coat.

She carried him now.

Him and his brother and his wife and a pack of books, east across the sleeping world at Midwinter, under a sky so full of stars it looked like frost on black glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY TALKED MUCH.

You couldn't, really. Not on a dragon. The wind took the words. But it wasn't only that.

Lex sat behind him. Not touching. Antho could feel him there. A warmth at his back. Steady. The way you feel a banked fire in a room behind you.

He thought about the last time they'd flown together. East. Home. From the edge. In the autumn. With the grey country behind them and a gold road running across the world below them, a step wide, wandering, the King's footprints. And their father dying at the end of it.

They hadn't talked then either.

Lex, he thought. Into the wind. Into the dark. *Lex. Do you still say good morning to it? The fire?*

He didn't say it out loud. He knew the answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEWHERE OVER THE VHESSAN hills, past midnight, Lex spoke.

Close. At his ear. Over the wind.

"*Elowen wrote*."

"*What did she say*?"

"*The bread won't rise*."

Antho turned his head. In the dark. Lex's face was a pale shape behind him, and the handprint a darker shape on it, and his eyes—grey, their father's—catching the starlight.

"What?"

"At Westerling. Near the old edge." Lex's voice was flat. Careful. The voice he used for things he didn't understand yet and didn't want to frighten anyone with. *"Good yeast. Warm kitchen. Sat all night. Didn't notice the night go by."* A pause. *"Eggs won't hatch. A boy's cut won't close. Not healing. Not festering. Just staying."*

Antho was quiet for a long time.

Then he looked down at his left hand. On the dragon's neck. In the dark. At the place on the back of it where there was a round of gold the size of a coin.

"Kept," he said.

"Not gold," said Lex. *"Not like that. The bread's just bread. The boy's just a boy. Nothing's gold."* The wind took some of it. *"But—"*

"But stopped."

"Yes."

Neither of them said anything else.

They didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN OVER the green circle at dawn.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HAD SEEN IT before. Every month since the Blightmarch. A hundred miles across. A ring of green cut into the dead grey of the old march, where for sixteen years there had been nothing but Gloam and ash and silent birds, and now there was grass. Real grass. And clover. And thorn and hazel and young birch coming up in clumps along the old trench where the brothers had cut the glyph. And a river, new, that hadn't been there two years ago, finding its way across the green from somewhere in the hills.

It was under snow now. White. A white circle a hundred miles across, glittering, with the sun coming up over the eastern rim of it red as iron.

And in the middle—

A pool.

Small. Round. Dark. Not frozen. Never frozen. A disc of black water, still as glass, that didn't reflect anything. Not the sky. Not the snow. Not

the sun. You could look straight down into it and see nothing at all, not even your own face. Just dark. Soft. Deep. Like looking into a cupped hand at night.

And at the bottom of it, very far down, three small gold lights. Close together. Like candles in a window a long way off.

Malachi. Aurelian. Isaura Kell.

The three who'd stayed.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ROUND THE POOL—

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D KNOWN. MAL HAD told him. *Thousands*. He'd heard the word. He'd thought he understood it.

He hadn't.

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THEY STOOD ROUND THE rim.

Grey. Columns of dust. Tall as a man, some of them. Taller. Some no higher than a child. Standing up out of the snow in their thousands, on every side of the pool, close together, ten and twenty and fifty deep, so many that from the air the dark disc of the water looked like the pupil of an eye and they were the iris round it. Swaying. All of them. Very slightly. In a wind that wasn't blowing.

The way smoke sways.

The way the tall grass sways at dusk when there's no one there to see it.

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ASHKA WOULDN'T LAND AMONG them.

She circled. Twice. Low. Antho felt her trembling under him. Not afraid. Dragons aren't afraid. *Unwilling*. The way a horse is unwilling to go into a burned stable. She came down at last a quarter mile off, on the snow, outside the ring, and folded her wings, and put her head down, and would go no further.

They got off.

They walked in.

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IT WAS QUIET AMONG the dead.

That was the first thing. Not silent. Antho knew silence. He'd lived in it. This was quiet the way a church is quiet, or a sickroom, or a house at night with a baby asleep upstairs. Quiet with something in it. Something holding its breath.

The snow was grey.

That was the second thing. Outside the ring it was white. Blue-white, sparkling, new, the way snow should be at dawn. Inside the ring, among the dead, it was grey. Not dirty. Not ash. Just *grey*. The colour gone out of it. As if somebody had laid a fine grey veil over it, the way you'd lay a cloth over a mirror in a house where someone has died.

He knelt and touched it.

It was cold. It was snow. It was just snow.

It didn't melt under his fingers.

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THE DEAD DIDN'T MOVE as they passed.

They swayed. That was all. Tall grey columns, fine as flour, standing in the grey snow. You could see through them. Not clearly. The way you see through mist. A shape here and there, maybe. A shoulder. The line of a head. A hand. Then gone again, into the grey.

And as he passed each one, close, Antho heard them.

Not voices. Not words.

Names.

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HE WAS THE THRESHOLD Warden. He kept the edge between the world and the dark. He'd made pacts with spirits in the mad years—terrible pacts, pacts he still dreamed about—and he'd walked the grey river and talked to the Ferryman and held the hand of a grey girl in a dead world while she went up into the light.

He could hear the dead. He always could. It was the oldest thing about him.

And these dead were saying their names.

Over and over. Very quietly. Each one. The way you'd say your name in the dark, to yourself, if you'd been lying on the floor of an empty hall for nine hundred years and were frightened you might forget it.

Wenlock. Wenlock. Wenlock.

Bess, I'm Bess, I'm Bess.

Hollin of the stables. Hollin. Hollin.

Tamsy. Tamsy. My name is Tamsy.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED WALKING.

Seraphine stopped beside him. She couldn't hear them. Not like he could. But she could hear something. He could see it in her face. The Scribe of the Seventh, who heard the spaces between things. She could hear the gaps where the names were.

"*Antho*," she said. Very quietly.

"*They're saying their names*."

"*I know*." She'd gone pale. "*I can hear the holes in the air where they are.*"

Lex had stopped too. A little ahead. He couldn't hear any of it. He was looking at the grey snow. At the dead. At the dark pool beyond them, with its three small lights.

He looked very young suddenly. Antho hadn't seen him look that young in years.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FOUND IVY ON the rim.

She was sitting on the very edge of the pool, on a folded blanket on the stone, with her crutch beside her and her bad foot tucked under her and her good one hanging over the water. Small and thin and sixteen, with her hair in two plaits and a shawl round her shoulders and her nose red with cold. Talking.

To the pool.

Quietly. Steadily. The way you'd talk to a frightened animal in a stall. About nothing. About sheep. About the snow. About a cat at the Coldwater house that had had kittens in a boot. About anything.

She'd been talking to it for two years. Since the Blightmarch. Since a Well the size of a country came up through a breach a hundred miles wide

and folded itself down into a pool the size of a pond, small and dark and frightened, and a girl on a crutch who'd been Kindled with a class nobody could name sat down on the rim beside it and started talking about sheep.

HOLLOWKEEPER. Unique. The net had never seen one before.

She looked up when they came through the dead. And her face—

Antho had seen that face before. On children in the mad years. On villagers who'd seen him come down the mountain with black eyes.

On himself. In still water. Once.

The face of someone who has been holding something very heavy for a very long time, all alone, and has just seen someone else come into the room.

"*Oh*," said Ivy Moss. "*Oh, you came.*"

And burst into tears.

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SERAPHINE GOT TO HER first.

She sat down on the stone and put her arms round her and held her, and Ivy cried into her shoulder in great ragged gulps, the way children cry when they've been brave for too long. And Seraphine held her and rocked her and said *I know, I know, I know*, over and over, the way you do.

Lex stood over them. Helpless. With his big burned hands hanging at his sides.

Antho looked past them.

At the boy.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WAS SITTING A little way along the rim. On his own. On the stone. With his knees drawn up and his arms round them. Very still. Watching the dead.

Fourteen. Nearly fifteen. Small for it. Thin. Dark hair sticking up. A face that had learned, in twelve years of silence, not to show you anything, and was only now, slowly, learning how.

He didn't look round when Antho came and sat down beside him.

They sat together. Not talking. Pim had never talked much. Two words in a row was a speech. And Antho had learned, in seven years, that the best thing to do with Pim was sit.

So he sat.

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"*Tamsy*," said Pim. After a long time.

Antho looked at him.

"*That one*." Pim lifted his chin. At a grey column a few yards off. Small. No higher than a child of six. Swaying. "*She says it. Over and over. Tamsy.*" He swallowed. "*I can't hear it. Not like you. But I can feel the shape of it. In the room.*"

The room. Pim had a room. A little piece of the seventh, inside him. A hollow he'd made in himself out of being hurt, in the years before the Keep, before anyone was kind. Moths couldn't drink from him. The Gilded King's gold couldn't set in front of him. He could cup his hands and make a little space in the air where something could breathe.

"*There are so many*," said Pim.

"*I know*."

"*And Mal can't*." Pim's jaw was tight. "*Mal wants to. Mal cries. At night. Ivy hears it.*" He looked at the pool. "*I hear it too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CAME DOWN FROM the Coldwater house at mid-morning.

It stood a half mile off. A long low timber house with a turf roof and a smoking chimney and a forge-shed and a pen with three goats and a horn lantern in every window. Where Kit and the Coldwater crew lived, and kept the pool, and fished the new river, and sat on the rim in shifts at night so the Hollowkeeper could sleep.

He came through the dead without looking at them. A big man. Bigger than Lex. Grey-bearded. Grey-lunged—Antho could hear the catch in his breath from twenty yards, the faint rattle at the bottom of it. With Isaura Kell's old staff in his left hand. Cut down. Shod with iron.

His left hand.

His right arm hung at his side. Gold. From the fingertips to the elbow. Smooth and bright and cold. With a black seam down the forearm, where an old iron scar had been, gold now too.

His pick-arm.

He stopped at the rim. Looked at the brothers. Grunted.

"*Took you long enough*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TALKED IN THE Coldwater house.

Round the long table, by the fire. With bread and cheese and Kit's fish stew, and the goats complaining in the pen outside, and the dead standing grey in the grey snow beyond the windows, a half mile off, swaying.

Ivy had stopped crying. She sat with Seraphine's arm round her and a bowl of stew in her lap she wasn't eating.

"*Seven weeks*," she said. "*Since the first night. The night the edge came down.*" She looked at her hands. "*They came on the wind. From the west. I saw them coming. Like smoke. Like fog. Over the rim of the circle. And then down. Toward the pool.*" She swallowed. "*And Mal said—Mal said—*"

"*Mal said come in*," said Hask. Heavily. "*First thing. Before anyone could stop it. Come in. Come home.*"

"*It's what Mal's for*," said Ivy. "*It's a room. It can't help it.*"

"*And some of them did*." Hask turned his cup in his good hand. "*Went in. A few hundred. That first night. Drifted down onto the water and went under like smoke going down a chimney.*" He looked at the window. "*And the pool went grey.*"

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"*Grey*?" said Seraphine.

"*At the edges*," said Ivy. "*Just at the edges. A ring of grey round the black. Like frost. And Mal went quiet. Very quiet. For a whole day.*" Her voice shook. "*And when it talked again it was—slow. Like someone talking through a mouthful of something. Like someone very tired.*"

"*Full*," said Lex.

Ivy looked at him.

"*Fuller*," she said. "*Not full. Not yet. But fuller. And it got frightened. Because it could feel it. The room getting smaller. And there were thousands more outside, all waiting, all wanting to come in, and if they all came in—*"

She stopped.

"*Then there'd be no room left*," said Seraphine. Quietly. "*Not for anything.*"

"*Mal said that*," said Ivy. "*Mal said, if I fill up I'll stop. Like the grey country stopped.*" She looked at the window. At the dead. "*So it asked them to wait. It said please. It said, I'm sorry, please wait, I'm too little, I'll grow, I promise I'll grow.*"

"*And they're waiting*," said Kit. Quietly. From the end of the table. He was nineteen now, Kit. Thin and solemn, with Coldwater coal-dust still in the creases of his knuckles though he hadn't been down a mine in two years. "*They've been waiting seven weeks. They don't do anything. They don't go anywhere. They just stand there. Saying their names.*"

"*And where they stand, the snow goes grey*," said Hask.

"*And the grass under the snow*," said Ivy. "*I dug down. Under one. It's grey too. Not dead. Just—grey. Stopped. Like it's waiting too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAT VERY STILL.

Like the bread, he thought. *At Westerling. That didn't notice the night go by.*

He looked at Lex. Lex was looking at him. The same thought. The same face.

It's the same thing, thought Antho. *Here and there. The dead here, with no room to go. The edge there, with no edge at all. Grey coming in. Stopping things.*

It's the same thing.

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"*Let me talk to it*," said Lex.

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THEY WENT BACK OUT to the rim.

Through the dead. Through the grey snow. Ivy on her crutch, Seraphine beside her. Hask behind. Kit. Pim, who'd stayed on the rim all the while and hadn't moved.

Lex knelt on the stone at the edge of the pool.

He put his hands flat on the cold rim. And leaned over. And looked down into the dark. Into the soft black water that didn't show you anything, not even your face.

Antho saw the grey. At the edges. A ring of it, a hand wide, round the black. Like frost on a window. Like the beginning of a cataract in an old man's eye.

Mal, said Lex. Out loud. Gently. *I'm here.*

◆ ◆ ◆

[...smith...]

Not from the hollow of a lantern. Not from the ash pan of a hearth. From the pool. From the dark. From everywhere. Soft and enormous and very young, like the whole night sky trying to whisper.

[...you came...you came...]

I came. Lex's hands were white on the stone. *Ivy told me. About the grey ones. About the room.*

[...I'm sorry...]

Don't be sorry.

[...I AM sorry...I should be bigger...I should be big enough...I'm the room...it's what I'm FOR...and they've been waiting nine hundred years...nine hundred years with nowhere to go...and I'm too little...]

Something moved in the dark. Far down. The three gold lights flickered. As if the water over them had shivered.

[...I was bigger once...] said the seventh Well. *[...I remember...before...I was a pool in a garden...a little one...but I went DOWN...all the way down...I went down to the bottom of everything...there was room in me for the whole world...]*

I know, said Lex.

[...and then they drank me...]

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SILENCE. ON THE RIM. Among the dead.

Antho felt it go through all of them. The Coldwater crew. Kit. Hask. The word. *Drank*.

He'd seen it. In the Well's own memory, two winters ago, in a cold-room at the Keep with a Delve folding shut under Pim's hands. Nine crowned figures kneeling at the edge of a black pool in a hidden garden. Cupping their hands. Drinking. Laughing. Standing up.

And a tenth. A girl. Standing apart. With her crown in her hands.

Not drinking.

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[...they drank me dry...] said Mal. *[...nine of them...and I was empty...and empty is hungry...and I was hungry for nine hundred years...I don't remember all of it...I don't want to...]*

I know.

[...and then the old man sang to me...and the other old man held my hand...and the lamp-lady brought me home...and I wasn't hungry anymore...] A pause. *[...but I was still little...]*

Because they've still got it, said Antho.

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HE HADN'T MEANT TO say it. It came out of him the way things did. Too fast. Too loud. Before he'd thought.

Everyone turned.

He was standing at the rim behind his brother. With his hands in his pockets. With the coin of gold on the back of his left hand cold against his thigh.

"*Because they've still got it*," he said again. Slower. "*What they drank. They drank it nine hundred years ago and they never gave it back. It's still in them. That's what they are. That's why they don't die. That's why they can't make anything new.*" He looked down at the dark. "*They're full of you, Mal. And you're empty.*"

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THE POOL WAS VERY still.

Then—

[...yes...] said the seventh Well. Slowly. As if remembering something. *[...yes...I felt it...]*

Felt what? said Lex.

[...on the Night...the lantern night...when the old man turned the Key...and the grey curtain fell...] The dark stirred. *[...something came HOME...]*

What came home?

[...a piece of me...a big piece...heavy...cold...from very far down...from the very bottom of everything...where the Key was...] A pause. *[...it was cold like iron...it came up through the dark and into me...and it said one thing...as it came in...]*

What?

[...it said...Hesper's...]

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ANTHO CLOSED HIS EYES.

He saw it. He'd been there. At the bottom of the world, in the Knot, on Lantern Night. A square dark man with an iron crown, standing on the last thread as it went slack. Letting the brothers go. Looking at the old man in Hesper's crown. Nodding. The way he'd nodded at her on the shingle, nine hundred years ago, in chains.

Hesper's.

And stepping off. Into the dark. With the thread.

Caddoc.

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"*Caddoc*," said Seraphine. Out loud. She'd gone white. She had her notebook out, the way she always did when she was frightened, and her quill, and she wasn't writing anything. "*Caddoc fell. With the thread. And what he drank came home.*"

[...and I got bigger...] said Mal. *[...a little...not enough...but I felt it...I felt the room get bigger...like a breath...]*

"*Because he died*," said Lex. Quietly.

"*Because he let go*," said Antho.

They looked at each other.

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"*Then that's it*," said Hask.

Everyone turned. He was standing at the back. Leaning on Kell's staff with his good hand. His gold arm hanging. His breath catching at the bottom.

"*That's the answer*," said Silas Hask. "*Three of them left. The King. The glass one. The thorny one.*" He shrugged. A heavy movement. "*They're full of what the pool needs. So we take it back.*"

"*They're deathless*," said Seraphine.

"*Caddoc wasn't*." Hask looked at the pool. "*Not in the end.*"

"*Caddoc chose*," said Antho. "*He stepped off. Nobody pushed him.*"

"*Then we push*."

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NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The dead swayed round them in the grey snow. Saying their names. *Wenlock. Bess. Hollin. Tamsy.*

Antho looked at Hask. At the big grey grim man, Unbound by Lex at a Coldwater Stone four summers ago, who'd become the most powerful Delve-breaker in Caldor, and drunk a Moth Queen's light, and broken a hundred shafts down into the young Well before anyone understood what they were. Who'd stood in the crack in the grey country, in the autumn, with gold dust coming down, and curled himself round a boy so it wouldn't touch him.

Who kept the pool now. With a dead woman's staff. And a gold arm.

He wasn't cruel. Antho knew that. He'd never been cruel.

He was only very tired. And very sure.

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"*No*," said Lex.

He hadn't got up. He was still kneeling on the stone at the rim, with his hands flat on it, looking down into the dark.

"*We don't push*."

Hask looked at him.

"*Smith*," he said. "*You've seen what the King does. You've seen my arm. Your wife's hand. The boy in the field.*" His voice didn't rise. It never rose. "*You want to ask him nicely?*"

"*Yes*," said Lex.

He stood up.

He turned round. To Hask. To all of them. Grey-eyed. Burned. With the handprint dark on his cheek.

"*She asked*," said Lex Vey. "*Hesper. At the pool. Nine hundred years ago. She didn't push anyone in. She didn't make anyone drink or not drink. She stood there with her crown in her hands and asked them to stop. And when they wouldn't, she poured hers back and walked away.*"

He looked at the dead. At the grey snow.

"*That's what we do*," he said. "*We don't take it. We ask for it.*"

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THE POOL WAS QUIET.

Then, from the dark, very small—

[...yes...] said Mal. *[...please...ask...]*

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HASK DIDN'T ARGUE.

He looked at Lex for a long moment. Then he grunted. And shifted his weight on Kell's staff. And looked away. At the pool. At the three small gold lights at the bottom.

"*She'd have said that*," he said. Gruffly. "*Kell. She'd have said exactly that.*"

"*I know*," said Lex.

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IT WAS PIM WHO moved.

He'd been sitting on the rim all the while. Silent. Watching. With his knees drawn up and his arms round them.

He got up now. And walked. Away from the pool. Into the dead.

"*Pim—*" said Seraphine.

He didn't stop. He walked out into the grey snow, among the tall swaying columns, small and thin and dark-haired, until he was twenty yards off, in the middle of them. And stopped. And stood there.

And cupped his hands.

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ANTHO WENT AFTER HIM.

Not close. He stopped a few yards off. And watched.

The boy was standing among the dead with his hands cupped in front of him. The way he'd cupped them on the white road, in the summer, in

front of a gold kitchen girl. Making a room. A little space in the air. Where something could breathe.

He was saying something.

Antho couldn't hear it. He moved closer.

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"*The bread-woman*," Pim was saying. Quietly. To the dead. To the grey columns on every side. "*Is she here? The bread-woman. From the King's kitchen. She had a daughter. Ilda. Eight. A spit-girl.*" His voice cracked. He steadied it. "*She was coming apart. The first year. In the grey. With her daughter in her arms. And the King kept the girl. But not her.*"

The dead swayed. Saying their names.

"*I promised*," said Pim. To the cupped space in his hands. "*I promised Ilda. I'd come back. When it's big. When there's room. I'd find her mam.*" He swallowed. "*I'm finding her. I'm finding her now. Is she here?*"

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SILENCE.

The names. All round. Soft. Over and over. *Wenlock. Bess. Hollin. Tamsy.* Thousands of them. The whole grey field, murmuring.

And then—

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ONE OF THE COLUMNS bent.

Antho saw it. A tall one. A little way off. Grey. Fine as flour. Standing in the grey snow with the others. Swaying.

And then not swaying. *Bending*. Toward the boy. Slowly. The way a woman bends over a cot. The way a mother leans down to a child who's said her name in the dark.

And as it bent, Antho heard it. Under all the others. Not a name.

A word.

...Ilda...?

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PIM DIDN'T MOVE.

He stood in the grey snow among the dead, with his hands cupped in front of him and the tears running down his face, and didn't make a sound.

"*She's here*," he said. Barely a whisper. To Antho. Without turning round. "*She's here. She's been waiting.*"

The grey column leaned over him. Toward the room in his hands.

...Ilda...?

"*She's coming*," said Pim. To the bread-woman. To the dust. To nine hundred years of a mother on the floor of an empty hall. "*She's walking. She's on her way. She's coming home.*"

He looked down at his cupped hands.

"*I promise*," he said.

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BEHIND THEM, ON THE rim, in the dark of the pool, the seventh Well was crying.

Antho could hear it. Soft. Enormous. Like rain on a very large roof at night.

[...I'm sorry...] it was saying. *[...I'm sorry...I'm sorry...I'll grow...I promise I'll grow...]*

And on the stone, kneeling, with his hands flat on the cold rim and his head bowed over the dark water, his little brother was saying something back.

Antho couldn't hear what.

He thought it might have been *good morning*.

CHAPTER 3

The Bread That Wouldn't Rise

THE DOUGH SAT IN the bowl.

Lex looked at it. Wren looked at it. Elowen Dunmore, Knight of the Keepers, in her mail and her grey cloak with snow on the shoulders, looked at it with her arms folded and the face of a woman who'd already looked at it a great deal and was tired of it.

It was a good bowl. Brown glaze, chipped at the lip. A clean cloth folded back from it. A kitchen as warm as a forge, with a big black range and copper pans and bunches of thyme hanging from the beams, and the smell of woodsmoke and flour.

And in the bowl, a round pale lump of dough.

"*Four days*," said the baker.

Her name was Marta Fell. Keeper Ada Fell's cousin. A broad brisk woman of fifty with forearms like hams and flour to the elbow and a mouth that had set itself, over four days, into a straight hard line.

"*I made it on Midwinter morning*," she said. "*Before dawn. Like always. Good flour, from the mill at Hobb's Cross. Barm fresh from the brewer that morning. Warm water. Salt. Kneaded it a quarter hour.*" She folded her arms. "*Covered it. Set it by the range. Went to bed.*"

They all looked at the dough.

"*Four days*," said Marta Fell again. "*By the range. And it hasn't moved a hair. Not up. Not down. Not sour. Not crusted. Nothing.*" She reached out and lifted the cloth all the way off. "*Smell it.*"

Lex leaned down and smelled it.

Yeast. Flour. Warm water. The clean sharp smell of new dough, the smell of every bakehouse he'd ever walked past at dawn.

Fresh.

As if it had been made a minute ago.

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"*It's not the barm*," said Marta Fell. "*Before you say it. Everyone says it. The Keeper said it. I took the same barm next door to Bet Arley's and she made a batch and it rose in an hour like a bride's cake.*" She looked at the bowl. "*Bet Arley's is six doors east. Mine's the last house on the west road.*"

Lex put out his hand.

He didn't touch the dough. He held his palm an inch above it. Felt the warmth of it. The life in it. The small busy world of a thousand thousand yeast-things that should have been eating and breathing and pushing the dough up toward the cloth.

And he reached.

Not with fire. With the other thing. The newest thing. The seventh Well, the one he'd learned last, the one that wasn't heat or weight or water or wind, but *room*. The empty space every new thing is made into.

Hollow.

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HE'D LEARNED IT AT the Blightmarch. From his wife, actually. Lying in the grass beside her on a summer night with his hand on her belly, feeling their daughter kick for the first time. Feeling the room she was in. The room Wren had made in herself, without trying, without knowing, for something new to grow into.

Every casting needs a mould. Every forging needs an anvil. Every new thing needs somewhere to *be*.

He'd been reaching for it ever since. Listening. Answering. In the spring, in Ashbourne, with gold dust coming down on the green, he'd learned to make room in front of the gilt before it set. *Speaking*.

He reached for it now. Into the dough. Into the warm pale lump in the brown bowl.

And there wasn't any.

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NOT A LITTLE. NONE.

He could feel the yeast. Alive. Not dead, not cold, not poisoned. Alive and ready and waiting. Like a crowd at a door. Like horses at a gate.

And nowhere to go.

No room in front of them. No space to grow into. Not because something was blocking it—he'd have felt that, a wall, a lid—but because the room had *gone*. Been drawn out. The way the air goes out of a bellows when you lean on it. The way water goes out of a bucket with a hole in the bottom.

West.

He could feel it going. Even now. Even as he held his hand over the bowl. A faint, steady, endless pull. Out of the dough, out of the kitchen, out of the walls and the beams and the thyme hanging from them, out through the west window and away. Toward the edge.

Like a draught under a door.

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HE PUSHED.

He made room. With his hand. The way he'd made it in front of the gilt on the green. Cupped the air an inch over the dough, and *asked*, and felt the seventh Well stir in him, faint and far—three hundred miles off, a pool in a green field, frightened—and answer.

The dough moved.

Everyone saw it. Marta Fell made a small sound. The pale lump in the bowl *lifted*. Swelled. Rounded. A finger's width. Two. Like a sleeper taking a breath.

And then sank back.

Slowly. Softly. To exactly where it had been. As if the breath had gone out of it again. As if the room he'd made had been poured out of the bowl as fast as he poured it in, and gone west, through the window, into the snow.

Like pouring water on sand.

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HE TOOK HIS HAND away.

"*Well*," said Marta Fell. Very quietly.

Nobody said anything.

Lex stood in the warm kitchen with flour on his boots and looked at the dough. Then he looked out of the west window. At the snow. At the white road out of the village, running west. At the low grey sky over it.

He couldn't see anything. Snow. Hedges. A field. A copse of black trees.

He could feel it. Right there. Past the copse. Past the field.

Something drinking.

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THE BOY'S NAME WAS Davy Pruett.

He was nine. Red-haired and gap-toothed and enormously proud of his bandage. He sat on an upturned bucket in his mother's yard at the next farm along the west road and unwrapped it for them very carefully, as if unwrapping a present, and held out his hand.

Across the palm, from the base of the thumb to the edge, a cut.

Clean. Straight. Not deep. The kind of cut you'd get from the edge of a scythe if you grabbed the blade instead of the snath because you were nine and showing off.

Red. Open. A thin bright line of blood standing in it.

As if he'd done it a minute ago.

"*Nine days*," said his mother. From the door. With her arms wrapped round herself. "*Nine days, and it hasn't so much as scabbed. It doesn't bleed. It doesn't close. It doesn't go bad. I've had the Keeper's healer to it and the hedge-woman from Barrow's Knap and they both stood where you're standing and looked at it and went away.*" Her voice cracked. "*He can't hold a spoon.*"

"*I can*," said Davy Pruett. "*With the other one.*"

Wren crouched down in front of him.

She didn't say anything at first. She just looked at the cut. Then at the boy. Then she held out her own left hand. Palm down. So he could see the gold.

Davy's eyes went very round.

"*Is that real*?"

"*Real gold*," said Wren. "*Right down to the bone. I can't bend them.*" She wiggled the other two fingers. "*These ones I can.*"

"*Does it hurt*?"

"*No.*"

"*Mine doesn't hurt either*," said Davy. "*That's the funny thing. It's open and it doesn't hurt.*" He looked at his palm. "*It's like it's waiting.*"

Wren didn't answer that.

She put her good hand over his. Very gently. And held it. And looked up at Lex over the boy's red head.

He knew the look. He'd seen it on her face in the yard at Harrow in the summer, with gold coming down on her drawing hand and her bow up and the arrows still flying.

Fix it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TRIED.

He knelt in the snow beside her and held his hand over the boy's palm and reached for room. And felt it. The same as the dough. The cut, waiting. The flesh on either side of it ready to knit, the way flesh is always ready to knit. Alive. Patient.

And nowhere to knit into.

He made room. He pushed. The edges of the cut drew together—Davy gasped—a hair's breadth. Pink. Closing.

And opened again. Softly. As the room drained away.

West.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT BACK ON his heels in the snow.

"*Sorry*," he said. To the boy. To his mother. To the cut. "*I'm sorry.*"

"*That's all right*," said Davy Pruett kindly. "*The Keeper's healer said that too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY RODE WEST.

Lex and Wren and Elowen, on Keepers' horses, along the west road out of Westerling in the snow. Elowen's two sergeants behind. And behind them, in a cart, a load of stakes.

Ash poles. Five feet long. Pointed at one end. Painted white at the other.

"*Seraphine's idea*," said Elowen. Riding beside him. "*Three weeks ago. When the first letters came. She wrote back by return and said put a stake in the ground at every farm that's been touched. Write the date on it. Then go back every day and see where the touching's got to.*" She nodded ahead. "*So we did.*"

He saw them as they rode.

White-topped poles. In the snow. Along the road. In the fields on either side. In a long ragged line, north and south, as far as he could see, every few hundred yards. And another line, a little further west. And another. And another.

Like the rings of a tree.

"*Slow, at first*," said Elowen. "*A few hundred yards a day. Then faster.*" She didn't look at him. "*It's near a mile a day now. One day, in the big wind, nearly three. And it's still getting faster. Straight east. Along the whole edge, as far as we've been able to ride.*"

"*How far is that*?"

"*North to the Teeth. South to the sea cliffs at Morrow.*" She shrugged. "*Two hundred miles of it. Maybe more. My people are thin.*"

"*Seven weeks*," said Wren.

"*Nine miles*," said Elowen Dunmore. "*Give or take. It reached Westerling yesterday.*" She looked back, east, toward the village. "*Ashbourne's two hundred and ten.*"

Nobody said anything.

They rode on. West. Past the stakes. Going back in time. Each line with a date on it in black paint, in a Keeper's careful hand, and each line a little closer to the last, the further west they went, the way the rings of a tree crowd together near the heart.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT BEFORE they'd gone a hundred yards.

Not a line. Nothing so clear. There was no wall in the snow, no change in the colour of the sky. The hedges went on. The fields went on. A crow went over, cawing.

But the snow was different.

He couldn't have said how. It was white. It was snow. It lay on the hedges and the fields and the road exactly the way snow lies on things. But it lay there the way snow lies in a painting. Not falling. Not settling. Not melting where the sun touched it, or drifting where the wind took it. Just *there*. Finished.

And the quiet.

He noticed it the way you notice a clock has stopped. Not at once. After a while. The crow had gone. The horses' hooves made no sound. Not muffled—*none*. He could see them lifting and falling in the snow and couldn't hear them land.

"*Lex*," said Wren. Very low.

"*I know*."

"*The wind's still blowing*." She had her face turned up. Her eyes half closed. The way she held it when she was listening to the air. Mistwalker. Gale Commanding. She'd felt wind the way other people feel heat since she was twenty. "*Feel it. It's blowing. West. Hard.*" She opened her eyes. "*And the snow isn't moving.*"

He looked.

The wind was blowing. He could feel it on his face, on the back of his neck, pulling at his coat. Steady. Endless. West. Pouring past him toward the edge like a river pouring into a hole.

And the snow on the hedge beside him lay perfectly still.

As if the wind were going somewhere else. Through it. Past it. Not touching it.

As if the snow had stopped noticing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELOWEN DREW REIN.

They'd come to the first line of stakes. White-topped. In the snow. Running north and south across the road and away over the fields. And on the nearest one, in black paint, yesterday's date.

"*Here*," she said. "*Yesterday.*" She nodded back, east. At the village. At the last house on the west road, with its chimney smoking. "*It'll be at Bet Arley's by tonight.*"

Lex got down.

He walked to the stake. And past it. West. Into what yesterday had been.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULD FEEL IT now. On his skin. In his hands. In the place under his breastbone where the Wells lived.

The room going.

Out of everything. Out of the snow and the hedge and the frozen furrows under the snow and the roots under the furrows. Out of the air. Out of *him*. A faint, soft, endless pull, west, like standing in a river with the current pulling at your legs. Like the draught under a door.

It didn't hurt. That was the thing. It didn't hurt at all.

It just—*took*. Gently. A little at a time. The room in front of every moment. The space where the next thing would happen. Took it, and drew it west, and left everything exactly where it was.

Waiting.

Kept, he thought. *Not gold. Not stopped. Just—kept.*

The bread didn't notice the night go by.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED FOR FIRE.

He didn't decide to. It came up in him the way it always came, when he was frightened or angry or didn't understand something. Heat. Weight. The roar of a forge with the bellows going. Flame Commanding. He'd brought a dragon's breath out of the ground in the Greyspine. He'd burned a thousand moths out of the air over the Blightmarch with black heat.

He held up his hand. Palm out. West.

And let it go.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT.

A gout of it. White-gold. A column of fire the width of a cart, roaring out of his palm and across the snow toward the west. He felt the heat of it on his face. Saw the snow go up in steam where it passed. Heard it—

He didn't hear it.

He saw it roar. He didn't hear it.

And a hundred yards out, over the field, toward the old edge, it—

Went.

Not out. Not quenched. It didn't hiss or smoke or gutter. It just went *thinner*. And thinner. Paler. Like a line of ink in water. Like a shout in a very big empty room. Spreading. Thinning. Drawn out west across the snow, out and out and out, toward a horizon he couldn't see, until there was nothing left of it but a faint warmth on the air.

And then not that.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD IN THE snow with his hand still up.

He'd poured enough fire into the world to forge a wagon-tyre. He'd felt it go.

The snow at his feet hadn't melted.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME AND STOOD beside him.

She didn't say anything. She took his hand. His raised one. And brought it down. And held it. Her right hand in his left.

"*Like water on sand*," he said.

"*I saw*."

"*It just drinks it*." He looked west. "*Whatever it is. Whatever's out there. It drinks it and drinks it and it's never full.*"

"*Because it's empty*," said Wren. Quietly. "*It's been empty for nine hundred years.*" She looked west too. Her eyes were very green in the white light. "*Like Mal was. Before.*"

He looked at her.

She'd said it simply. The way she said most things. And it went into him like a nail into green wood.

Like Mal was.

The grey country. Nine hundred years with all its room drunk away. A country the Crowned had emptied, the way they'd emptied the Well. Starving. Hungry. *Empty is hungry*. Mal had said that. At the rim. *I was empty, and empty is hungry*.

And now there was no edge between it and the world. No wall. No Veil. Nothing at all.

And it was drinking.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY RODE ON TO the old edge.

It took the rest of the day. Nine miles of snow and silence and white-topped stakes, crowding closer and closer together. Past farms with no smoke in their chimneys, empty, the families gone east to cousins. Past a mill with its wheel turning in the stream and no sound coming off it at all. Past an orchard where every tree stood in the snow with its bare black branches up like hands and you could feel them, Lex could feel them, every bud on every branch ready and waiting and going nowhere.

Past the gold ones.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THE FIRST at noon.

A man. In a field. Off to the right of the road, two hundred yards. Gold. Tall and stooped, in the clothes of a groom from nine hundred years ago, a short tunic and leggings and a hood. With a gold bridle in his hand. Walking.

East.

So slowly. Lex could see him move only if he looked away and back. A finger's width. A finger's width. Across the snow. Through the field. Toward a hedge. Toward the world.

And then another. Further off. A woman. With a gold basket on her hip.

And another. Two together. Small. Children. Holding hands.

And more. And more. As they rode west. Scattered across the snow on both sides of the road. Dozens, then hundreds. Gold figures in the white, a long way apart, all walking. All facing east. All so slow they might have

been statues someone had set out across the fields in the night, for no reason, facing the sunrise.

He could hear them. Even through the silence. Even here, where his own horse's hooves made no sound.

One note.

...home...

◆ ◆ ◆

"*They don't do anything*," said Elowen. Riding beside him. Not looking at them. She'd stopped looking at them, Lex thought, a long time ago. "*They just walk. Through fences. Through barns. A woman at Hobb's Cross woke up with one walking through her kitchen. Took him all day to get from the door to the hearth. She sat in the corner with the children and a poker and watched him the whole time.*" She shook her head. "*He didn't even look at her. Walked through the hearth and out the back wall. There's a hole in it now. Man-shaped.*"

"*Walked through the wall*?"

"*Not through. Into. And kept walking.*" Elowen's mouth twisted. "*They don't stop. You can't stop them. The carter at Hobb's Cross put an axe in one. It's still in him. He's two miles east of there now, still walking, with an axe in his shoulder.*"

"*Do they hurt anyone*?"

"*No*," said Elowen. "*No. Never. They don't touch anyone. They just go round you if you stand in the way. Very slowly. It takes hours. But they go round.*" She was quiet for a while. "*It's the eyes, Lex. That's what frightens people. Not the gold. The eyes. They move. They look at you. They look at you as you go past, and you know—*" She stopped.

"*Know what*?"

"*That they know*," said Elowen Dunmore. "*All of it. What's happened to them. How long it's been. Where they're going.*" She looked away. "*And that they'll never get there. Not at that pace.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME TO NAN Ashby's croft at dusk.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A LOW stone house in a fold of the hills, eight miles from the edge, with one tree by it and a byre. No smoke. The door shut. Snow drifted against it.

Elowen didn't stop.

"*She's not there*," she said. "*She's never there.*"

They rode on. Over the last hill. And down.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIELD WAS STILL there.

Gold. All of it. A long slope of gold grass running down to a gold hedge, under a sky going purple with dusk. Not under snow. The snow had fallen on it and lay on it, white, and the gold showed through underneath, glowing faintly, the way coals glow under ash.

Forty sheep. Gold. Heads down. Grazing.

A hawk. Gold. Overhead. Pinned to the sky mid-stoop with its wings half-folded, twenty feet up, the snow lying in a thin white line along the top of each wing.

And among the sheep, tall and thin, mid-step, with his crook out and snow on his cap—

A boy.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND AT THE EDGE of the gold, on the grey ground, on a three-legged stool, wrapped in a shawl and a horse-blanket with a basket at her feet and snow on her shoulders—

A woman. Talking.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*—and the byre roof's held, which I didn't think it would, after that wind, but your father built it, and he was a fool about most things but he could build a roof. And the hens are in the kitchen. I know. I know what you'd say. But it's cold, Col, it's so cold this winter, and they're only hens.*"

She didn't look round as they came down the hill.

She didn't look round when they stopped, a little way off, and got down from the horses, and stood in the snow.

She went on talking.

"—and the smith came back. Did I tell you? The one with the handprint. He's standing behind me now with his wife and the Knight. I can hear them breathing. I expect they want to look at you." A pause. *"Everyone wants to look at you."*

Lex stood very still.

Nan Ashby turned round on her stool.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS OLDER THAN he remembered. Much older. In the spring she'd been a hard brown woman of fifty with a basket and a sharp tongue, walking eight miles every morning to sit at the edge of the gold and bring her son his supper. She looked seventy now. Grey-faced. Hollow-cheeked. Her eyes very bright and very dry.

"Smith," she said.

"Mistress Ashby."

"You came back." She looked at him. Up and down. At the handprint. *"You said there was a way. In the summer. You said you'd found the room in front of it."*

"I did. Before it sets." His throat was tight. *"He's set."*

"I know he's set. I can see he's set." She turned back to the field. To the boy. Gold. Mid-step. With his eyes moving. Following her. Always following her. *"They carried me east in the summer. The Keepers. When the King came through. I bit one."* She almost smiled. *"I came back in the autumn. When he'd gone. I've been here every day since."*

"It's not safe," said Elowen. Gently. *"Nan. The grey's going past you. It went past you weeks ago. You're sitting in it."*

"So's he," said Nan Ashby.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE boy.

At Col Ashby. Fourteen. Gold from his cap to his boots. Standing in a gold field at the edge of the world with his crook out, the way he'd been standing since the spring, since the first gold dust came through the first crack in the Veil and settled on him while he was walking out to his flock on a Tuesday with the wind from the west.

His eyes moved.

They moved to Lex. Held there. A long moment.

Then went back to his mother.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT DOWN BESIDE her stool.

Not to try anything. There was nothing to try. He'd tried in the spring. He'd poured fire into the gold until his hands blistered and it hadn't even warmed. He'd reached for room in it and found none—not drunk away, like the bread, but *never there*. Kept. Finished. A door with nothing behind it.

He knelt down beside her because she was alone.

Wren knelt on the other side.

And the three of them sat there in the snow at the edge of the gold field in the dusk, and looked at the boy, and Nan Ashby went on talking.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*—and you'll never guess what. The bread won't rise. At Westerling. Marta Fell's in a state. Her bread won't rise and the Pruett boy's hand won't close and nobody's hens are laying.*" She pulled the blanket tighter. "*I said to Marta. I said, now you know. Now you know what it's like. Waiting for something to happen that won't.*"

A long silence.

"*She didn't like that*," said Nan Ashby. "*But it's true.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LEFT HER THERE. At full dark. Because she wouldn't come, and they couldn't make her.

Wren left her own scarf on the old woman's shoulders. Elowen left a lantern, lit, on the grey ground by the stool. Lex left nothing. He didn't have anything to leave.

He looked back once from the top of the hill.

A small gold light at the edge of a field of gold. And a woman on a stool beside it, talking.

And past her—past the field, past the hedge, past the last of the gold—the edge.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS NOTHING THERE.

That was what he couldn't get used to. He'd seen the Veil. Twice. Grey. Hanging from nowhere. Falling to nowhere. Moving very slightly, the way a curtain moves in a room with a window open somewhere behind it. A wall across the end of the world.

It was gone.

Past the gold field, the snow went on. White. Then, without any line at all, without any seam, without anything to say *here*, it went grey. Grey-gold. Fine as flour. Lying in drifts. Going on. West. Flat. To the end of everything.

And running away into it, starting at the foot of the place where the Veil had been, broad, straight, white as old bone—

A road.

And at the end of the road, on the edge of the dark sky, very small, very far—

Towers.

Glass. Iron. Gold. Bone. And one wrapped in something brown and dry, like a bramble patch at the end of winter.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND WENT PAST him.

West. Down the hill. Over the gold field. Over the woman on the stool and her son. Over the hedge. Onto the white road. Into the grey.

Endless. Soft. Steady. Like a river pouring into a hole in the ground.

And the grey country drank it.

He could feel it drinking. From here. From the top of the hill. A great dry patient thirst, nine hundred years old, as wide as the world. Not cruel. Not angry. Not anything. Just *empty*. Taking the wind. Taking the room. Taking everything new that came within reach and drawing it in, and in, and in, and never being full.

A mile a day, he thought. *And faster.*

Ashbourne's two hundred and ten.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STAYED THE NIGHT at Greyfall.

It was a Keepers' outpost on a crag above the old edge, stone-walled, with a tower and a gate. It had been the last outpost before the Veil for two hundred years. The Wardens had built it to watch the grey and report what moved there.

It was empty now. Elowen's people slept at Westerling.

She'd brought them for the gate.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STANDING IN it.

Exactly where he'd stood in the summer, when the Gilded King walked out of the crack in the Veil and east across the world. Square in the middle of the gateway. Feet planted. A staff held crosswise in both hands, chest-high, barring the way. The way you'd bar a door with your own body.

Gold.

Daxian Roole. Commander of the Keepers of the Stones. Warden-Captain once. Inquisitor. The man who'd hunted Lex across Caldor when he was nineteen, and been spared, and changed sides, and led the reformed Wardens for five years with a stiff arm and a stiff back and a stiff sense of what was right.

He'd sent his Keepers east. He'd sent everyone east. Then he'd stood in the gate.

You're not coming through this gate.

And the King had walked up to him. And looked at him. And reached out, very gently, and touched his face.

Somebody has to stand somewhere, Roole had said. Elowen had told them. One of the Keepers had heard it, running. The last thing he said.

And the King had said *yes*. *Yes, they do. Forever.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS SNOW ON his shoulders.

Elowen brushed it off. Carefully. The way you'd brush snow off an old man's coat at a door. Then she stood in front of him in the dark gateway, with a lantern in her hand, and said, quite ordinarily:

"*Evening, Commander.*"

The gold face didn't change. It couldn't.

The eyes moved. To her. To the lantern. To Lex and Wren behind her.

"*Brought the smith*," said Elowen. "*And his wife. They've been to see Nan Ashby. Bread's still not rising in Westerling. The line moved a mile and a quarter today.*" She set the lantern down at his gold feet. "*I'll be back on Thursday.*"

She turned away.

Lex saw her face as she passed him. In the lantern light. Just for a moment.

He looked away.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD IN FRONT of Roole for a long time after she'd gone.

He didn't try anything. There was nothing to try.

He thought about a forest in the spring, seven years ago. A Warden-Captain on his back in the mud with Lex's hammer at his throat. Grey eyes, hard. *Do it*.

He hadn't done it.

He thought about the same man, a year later, in the ruins of Ashbourne, holding out his hand. *I was wrong. About you. About all of it. I'd like to help.*

He thought about him standing here. In the summer. Alone. With a staff.

Somebody has to stand somewhere.

"*You did*," said Lex. Out loud. To the gold. "*You stood.*"

The eyes moved. To him.

And held.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SLEEP MUCH that night.

He lay on a Keepers' cot in the empty tower at Greyfall with Wren asleep beside him, her gold fingers spread on the blanket so they wouldn't press, and listened to the wind. Going west. Past the walls. Past the gate. Past Roole. Down the hill and over the edge and into the grey. All night.

Endless.

He thought about bread.

He thought about a boy's hand, open, waiting.

He thought about nine thousand gold people walking across the world a finger's width at a time toward a home that had been gone for nine hundred years.

He thought about the dead at Mal's rim, swaying, saying their names.

He thought about three Crowned, somewhere in the world, full of what Mal needed, who'd never given anything back in nine hundred years.

We ask, he'd said. At the rim. As if it were easy.

He lay in the dark and didn't know how.

◆ ◆ ◆

IN THE MORNING, AT the farm below Greyfall, an old woman met them at her gate.

She'd heard there was a smith. With a handprint. She'd been waiting for him since dawn, in her shawl, in the snow. Eighty if she was a day. Bent. Bright-eyed. With a clay pipe in her teeth and a look of great satisfaction, like someone who has a piece of news nobody else has heard.

"*You'll be wanting to know about the big gold one*," she said.

Lex stopped.

"*Came by here*," said the old woman. "*A month back. Just after the edge came down. Walking. Very slow. Very careful. Like a man walking through a house full of glass.*" She took the pipe out of her mouth. "*Stopped at my gate. Asked if he could come in for tea.*"

"*What did you say*?"

"*Said no*," said the old woman. "*Course I did. I'm not daft. I've seen the field.*" She put the pipe back. "*So he sat on the wall. Outside. In the snow. And I brought him a cup. Old one. Chipped. Didn't care if it went gold.*" A puff of smoke. "*It went gold.*"

"*What did he want*?"

"*Want*?" The old woman considered this. "*Didn't seem to want anything. Sat on my wall for an hour and drank my tea and asked about my grandmother.*"

"*Your grandmother*?"

"*Her name. What she was like. When she died.*" The old woman's bright eyes narrowed. "*Asked if she'd been frightened. At the end. If it hurt. If there was anyone with her.*" A pause. "*Asked about my mother, too. And*

my husband. And my sister that drowned. Wanted to know all of it. How they went. Who held their hands."

Lex didn't say anything.

"*Strange sort of king*," said the old woman. "*Sat on my wall with tears running down his face. Gold tears. They went on the snow and the snow went gold.*" She tapped the pipe on the gatepost. "*Then he got up and thanked me very kindly and asked me the way to Ashbourne.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ashbourne*," said Lex.

"*Said he had a friend there*," said the old woman. "*An old woman. With one eye.*" She grinned round the pipe. Three teeth. "*Said she'd told his steward she wasn't greedy. To his face. In a storm of gold. Said he'd been thinking about it ever since.*"

CHAPTER 4

Seven Wells

THE FORGE ACADEMY AT Ashbourne had twenty anvils, and on the sixth day after Midwinter every one of them had somebody sitting on it.

Lex stood in the doorway and looked at them.

The great hall of the Forge. Long and high and smoke-dark, with a slate roof on oak trusses and the snow sliding off it in slabs. Twenty hearths down the two long walls, banked low. Twenty anvils in front of them, black and battered. Racks of tools. Water barrels, every one of them lidded now. A smell of coal and iron and wet wool and too many people.

And on the anvils, and on the benches, and on upturned buckets and coal sacks and the edge of the great quench-trough at the far end—

Everyone.

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QUEEN LYSANDRA OF CALDOR sat on the anvil nearest the main hearth. In a grey travelling cloak with the hood pushed back and snow melting in her dark hair. Thirty now. Sharp-faced. With her grandfather's nose and her own eyes, which missed nothing. She'd ridden down from Highcrest in four days through the drifts with a dozen guards and Seraphine's letter in her saddlebag, and she looked it.

Beside her, on a coal sack, cross-legged, in a red coat with the sleeves singed, eating an apple—

"*You look terrible*," said Kestrel Varn.

"*Thank you*."

"*It wasn't a compliment*." She took another bite. "*You've lost weight. You've got that look. The one where you haven't slept since the moon was full and you think nobody's noticed.*" She chewed. "*Everyone's noticed.*"

"*Hello, Kestrel*."

"*Hello, smith*." She looked at him over the apple. Dark-eyed. Sardonic. Fire-witch of the Unlit, who'd crossed the grey river with him, and walked the Wellworld of Flame, and learned black heat in the deep. Who'd been at Harrow on Lantern Night with her fire. "*I'm sorry about your father.*"

She'd said it at the grave too. On Lantern Night. In the snow. She said it again now. Exactly the same. Plainly. Not looking away.

He found he didn't mind.

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HE KNEW ALL OF them.

Brannoc, on his own anvil, the first one, the one he'd swung Lex up onto at eleven. Arms folded. Gold fingertips tucked into his armpits. Tilda beside him on a bucket, twenty years old and square-built and soot-faced, with Brannoc's old hammer in her belt and her right hand in her lap. Gold. All of it. From the wrist to the nails. She'd learned to swing left-handed in the summer. She was better at it now than most people were with their right.

Hedda, the rune-carver from Thistledown, grey-plaited, with her chisels in a roll on her knees. Teo Brask, the Tide Speaker, down from the coast—eighteen now, gangling, with his hair dripping as it always dripped, though it hadn't rained in a week and he'd come four hundred miles. A puddle spreading round his boots on the flags. Grandmother Asha of the Ashari, very small, very old, wrapped in desert silks and three Vale blankets, sitting on the edge of the quench-trough with her bare brown feet over the cold water as if it were a hot spring.

Wren, by the wall. With Lark on her hip. Lark was asleep, for once, with her fist in her mouth and her other fist round Wren's braid.

His mother. On a bench near the door. In her grey shawl. With her hands folded.

Seraphine. Standing. At the far end. By the great hearth. With a table in front of her that she'd dragged there herself, and on the table, books.

Eleven of them. Lex counted. Open. Stacked. Bristling with paper markers. And in the middle, the biggest, very old, bound in cracked brown leather with a clasp of tarnished silver.

The Listeners' Codex.

And beside her, leaning on the wall with his arms folded and his long black hair tied back and the face he wore when he was very frightened and pretending to be bored—

Antho.

He'd come in from the east that morning on the dragon. Lex hadn't had time to speak to him. He looked across the hall now and met Lex's eyes.

Mal? thought Lex.

His brother shook his head. Slightly. *The same*.

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"*Well*," said the Queen of Caldor. "*Now we're all here.*"

She didn't stand up. She didn't need to. Lysandra had never needed to stand up to make a room look at her.

"*I've had sixty-one letters since Midwinter*," she said. "*From the Westmarch. From lords and reeves and Keepers and a great many frightened farmers. I've read every one.*" She looked round the hall. "*They all say the same three things.*"

She held up a finger.

"*The gold ones are coming. Nine thousand of them. Walking east. Very slowly. Through everything. Nobody can stop them and nobody knows what they want.*"

A second finger.

"*The bread won't rise. The cuts won't close. The eggs won't hatch. And it's moving. East. Toward us.*"

A third.

"*And the Gilded King is walking through my kingdom drinking tea with old women and asking them how their grandmothers died.*" She lowered her hand. "*I'd like to know what to do about any of it. I'm told this is the room to ask.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

Then Seraphine cleared her throat.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS TERRIFIED. LEX could see it. She'd been terrified of rooms full of people for as long as he'd known her—since a burned archive in the Thornwood, when she was a fugitive Warden scribe with ink on her fingers and a price on her head, and she'd stood up in front of Elric and Garrick and Lex and Antho and stammered out the truth about the Tithe.

She'd stood up in front of a lot of rooms since. She'd stood up in front of the Queen. She'd stood up in the deep in front of a Moth Queen and read Wellscript off the walls.

She was still terrified. Every time.

She did it anyway. That was the thing about Seraphine.

"*I'm going to start with the bread*," she said. "*Because it's the easiest. And because I think it's the same as the other two.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TALKED FOR AN hour.

Lex had heard most of it. At the rim. On the dragon. In letters. But he listened anyway, because she was good at it, because she put things in order the way a smith lays out tools, and because when she talked about something it stopped being a terror in the dark and became a thing you could pick up and turn over in your hands.

The grey country. A place the Crowned had emptied. The way they'd emptied the seventh Well. Nine hundred years with no room in it. No new thing. Nothing growing, nothing born, nothing changing. Not dead. *Empty*.

And empty is hungry.

The Veil had held it back. Not a wall, exactly. A seam. The edge of the exile. Woven into the net by Aurelian on the night he wove everything else, and tied into the First Knot at the bottom of the world, and holding, for nine hundred years, the line between a world full of room and a country with none.

And on Lantern Night, Elric Thorne had put on Hesper's crown and turned the Key of Shadows against it. And it had unwritten. And fallen. Like a cloth.

"*And now there's nothing*," said Seraphine. "*Between us and it. No edge at all. And it's doing what anything empty does when you open the door.*"

"*Drinking*," said Lex.

"*Drinking*." She looked at him. "*The room. Out of everything. The space where the next thing happens. That's why the bread won't rise. There's nowhere for it to rise into. That's why the boy's hand won't close. That's why the eggs—*" She stopped. Swallowed. "*It's not killing anything. It's just taking the room away. And without room—*"

"*Nothing new*," said his mother. Quietly. From the bench by the door.

Seraphine looked at her.

"*Nothing new*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How fast*?" said the Queen.

"*A mile a day. A little more. And faster every week.*" Seraphine turned a page in a notebook. Her own. Columns of figures in a tiny neat hand. "*Elowen's stakes. I've been charting them. It started slow—three hundred yards a day, the first week. It's been speeding up.*" She looked up. "*I think because the more it drinks, the stronger the pull. The way a fire draws harder the hotter it gets.*"

"*How long till here*?"

Seraphine looked at the figures for a long moment.

"*Midsummer*," she said. "*Perhaps a little after. If it keeps on as it is.*" She closed the notebook. "*Six months. Then Ashbourne. Then the Vale. Then Highcrest. Then—*"

She didn't finish.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a while.

Lark woke up. On Wren's hip. Looked round the hall at all the silent people. Took her fist out of her mouth.

"*No*," she said. Loudly. To nobody in particular.

Somebody laughed. Kestrel. Short and startled. Then Brannoc. Then half the hall. Not because it was funny. Because it was the only thing anyone had said in a minute that wasn't terrible.

Lark looked pleased with herself. Put her fist back in her mouth.

"*She's right*," said the Queen of Caldor. Dryly. "*No. We're not doing that. So—*" She looked at Seraphine. "*What do we do instead?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Two things*," said Seraphine. "*And then a third.*"

She put her hand on the Codex.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The first is the dead*," she said. "*At Mal's rim.*"

She told it. Antho told it, partly—he came off the wall and stood beside her and told the part about the names, and his voice didn't shake until the end. Thousands of them. The Outer Court's dead. The ones who came apart in the first years, with nothing to drink. Drifting east on the first wind, to the only room there was.

And the room too small.

If I let them all in I'll stop.

"*And the snow's grey where they stand*," said Antho. "*The grass under it too. They're not doing anything. They don't mean anything by it. But they've been in the grey country so long they've brought it with them. And Mal's frightened. And every week they wait, the grey round the rim gets a little wider.*"

"*So there's grey coming from the west*," said Kestrel. Slowly. "*And grey starting in the east.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*Lovely.*" She threw her apple core into the nearest hearth. It hissed. "*Go on. I can tell there's worse.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mal grew*," said Seraphine. "*On Lantern Night. When Caddoc fell.*"

She told that too. The heavy cold piece of the Well coming home from the bottom of the world. *Hesper's*. And the room getting bigger. Like a breath.

"*They drank it*," she said. "*The Crowned. Nine hundred years ago. All nine. They drank the seventh Well dry, and it's still in them. That's what makes them deathless. That's why they can't make anything new. They're full of it.*" She looked round the hall. "*And Mal's empty. Or nearly. And the grey country's empty. And the dead have nowhere to go. All for the same reason.*"

"*And if they gave it back—*" said the Queen.

"*Then Mal would grow*," said Seraphine. "*Enough, maybe. Enough to take in the dead. Enough to—*" She hesitated. "*I don't know how much. Nobody's ever measured a Well. But Caddoc was one of nine, and the four cousins came apart at the edge nine hundred years ago, and Maelis poured hers home at the Blightmarch. So what's left is in three of them.*" She counted on her fingers. "*The King. The Glass Queen. The Thorn-Crowned.*"

"*And they're deathless*," said Lysandra.

"*Yes*."

"*So we can't take it from them*."

"*No*," said Seraphine. "*Nobody can. Caddoc stepped off the thread himself. Maelis came apart because she let herself be warm.*" She looked at Lex. "*It has to be given.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT THE HALL turn to look at him.

He'd said it. At the rim. *We ask.* Antho must have told them.

"*Hesper did*," he said. "*At the pool. She poured hers back. And it was hers, and she gave it, and nobody made her.*" He looked at the Queen. "*That's the only way it works. We can't take it. So we ask.*"

"*Ask the Gilded King*," said Lysandra. "*To stop being deathless. Politely.*"

"*Yes*."

"*And the Glass Queen*."

"*Yes*."

"*Who has spent the last six months reaching out of my subjects' windows at night to show them their own faces*." The Queen looked at him. "*And whom nobody has seen since the edge fell.*"

"*Yes*."

Lysandra was quiet for a moment.

"*Arion always said you were the most stubborn person he'd ever met*," she said. "*Including himself. Including me.*"

Lex didn't answer that. He couldn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And the second thing*?" said Brannoc. From his anvil. Gruffly. "*You said two things. Then a third.*"

Seraphine opened the Codex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PAGES CRACKLED. OLD vellum. Brown and soft as cloth, written over in Wellscript—the Founders' glyphs, gold-brown with age, crowding the margins in five or six different hands.

She turned to a page Lex knew.

Seven circles. Drawn in faded ink. Six in a ring, each with its glyph: Flame, Stone, Tide, Gale, Radiance, Shade. And in the middle, a seventh. Empty, once. Filled black now, with a glyph like a ring that doesn't quite close.

Hollow.

And in the margin, in a cramped old hand, slanting hard to the right, the hand of a man writing in anger:

The one they drank. The one we caged. Forgive us.

Malachi's.

And below it, in a different hand—neater, smaller, older, the ink almost gone—the line Seraphine had found in the summer:

Unwrite it when there is someone on this side who can make room for what is on the other. Not before.

Aurelian's.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He left the Veil one last turn*," said Seraphine. "*We knew that. We found it in the summer. And we used it. We had to.*" She touched the second line. "*Not before, he said. Not until there's someone who can make room. And there wasn't. Mal wasn't ready. Mal said so. Too big, still little.*" She swallowed. "*We did it anyway.*"

"*We didn't have a choice*," said Antho.

"*I know. I'm not—I know.*" She turned the page. Carefully. "*But I went back. After. In the autumn. To see if he'd left anything else. And he hadn't.*"

She put her finger on the next page.

"*But his brother had*."

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS ON THE back. On the reverse of the page with the seven circles. In the bottom corner, so small and faint and cramped that Lex had to lean over the table and squint.

The same hand as *Forgive us*. Slanting hard. Angry. Malachi's.

Two lines.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE READ IT ALOUD. Translating as she went. The way she always did. Slowly. Carefully. With her finger under each glyph.

"*Brother*," she read. "*You built a wall because a wall needs only one Well. Stone. A wall only has to say no.*"

She moved her finger.

"*A door needs all seven. It has to say no and yes both, and know which, and when. You could not hear all seven. No one can, yet. When there is a smith who can hear every one, let him make a door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL WAS SILENT.

Lex stood at the table with his hands flat on it on either side of the old book and looked at the two lines in the corner of the page.

A smith who can hear every one.

He felt everyone in the hall look at him again.

He didn't look up.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*A door*," said the Queen. Slowly. "*At the edge.*"

"*At the edge*," said Seraphine. "*Not a wall. Not a Veil. Aurelian's was a wall. Woven into the net. Tied into the Knot. Held with the Key.*" She shook her head. "*There's no Key anymore. It's in three pieces in a basket at Harrow. And even if there were—the net can't make a door. It's a net. It can only hold.*"

"*Then how—*"

"*Forged*," said Lex.

He looked up.

"*Not woven*," he said. "*Forged. Not out of the net. Out of the Wells.*" He looked down at the corner of the page. At the cramped angry glyphs. "*That's what he means. Malachi. He wasn't a weaver. He was a Listener. He never had the Root. He never touched the net. He thought his brother was wrong to build it.*" He swallowed. "*He's saying—don't weave a wall. Forge a door. Out of everything. All seven.*"

"*And what does a door do*," said Kestrel, "*that a wall doesn't? Apart from let things through. Which is rather the opposite of what we want.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It asks*," said Antho.

Everyone turned.

He was standing beside Seraphine. With his scarred hands on the table. Looking at the Codex. And his face had changed. Lex knew the look. He'd seen it in the deep, at the black door at the bottom of the Hollowmaw, when his brother raised his fist and *knocked*.

"*A wall doesn't ask*," said the Threshold Warden. "*It just stands there. Saying no. To everything. Forever. And everything piles up against it. The grey on one side. The room on the other. Pushing.*" He looked up. "*And when it comes down, it comes down all at once, and everything rushes through.*"

"*Like now*," said Seraphine.

"*Like now.*" Antho turned his hands over. Palms up. "*A door's different. A door has a threshold. You come to it, and you knock, and it asks who's there, and what you want, and then it opens, or it doesn't.*" He looked at his brother. "*A door between the world and the grey wouldn't drink. Not all the time. Not everything. It would let the room through when someone asked. A little. On purpose. And close again.*"

"*And the dead*?" said his mother.

Antho looked at her.

"*The dead could come home through it*," he said. "*If there were somewhere for them to go.*"

"*Mal*," said Seraphine. Softly.

"*Mal. If Mal were big enough. A door at the edge, opening onto Mal's room.*" Antho shook his head. "*I don't know how. I don't know what that would look like. A door in the west opening onto a pool in the east. But that's what doors are, isn't it? That's what I am. A thing that stands in a doorway and decides.*" He looked down at his hands. "*Two places that shouldn't touch. And a way between them. That asks.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS VERY QUIET in the hall.

Then Grandmother Asha laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS SITTING ON the edge of the quench-trough with her bare feet in the cold water and her three blankets round her shoulders. Very small. Very old. Brown and wrinkled as a walnut. She'd stood in the Ashari ring on the night the Blightmarch bloomed and poured desert fire into the ground until her sister came apart into sparks beside her.

She laughed now. A dry crackling sound. Like twigs in a fire.

"*Seven*," she said. "*He says seven.*" She shook her head. "*Ninety years I have lived, and I have met three people who could hear two Wells at once. One of them is dead.*" She pointed a crooked finger. At Lex. "*And he wants all seven. From one smith.*"

"*I've got two*," said Lex. "*Commanding.*"

"*And the rest*?"

He didn't answer. He didn't need to. He reached for it.

Status.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T READ IT out. He didn't need to read it out. He just held it up in front of himself in the firelight of the Forge, where only he could see it, and looked at it.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
ATTUNEMENT
  Flame ........ COMMANDING
  Stone ........ COMMANDING
  Tide ......... SPEAKING
  Gale ......... SPEAKING
  Hollow ....... SPEAKING
  Shade ........ ANSWERING
  Radiance ..... ANSWERING
```

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO.

Seven years since a stranger walked into this town and the seal on his blood cracked open. Seven years of Malachi laughing at him in the Stillwater. Of the Wellworlds. Of the deep. Of the Blightmarch and the grey country and the bottom of the world.

Two Wells he could command. Three he could speak to. Two that would only answer.

A smith who can hear every one.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Two*," he said. Out loud. "*Three Speaking. Two Answering.*"

Grandmother Asha nodded slowly.

"*And how long*," she said, "*did the first two take you?*"

"*Seven years.*"

"*And you have six months.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

He closed the panel.

He looked at the corner of the page. At the two lines. At the cramped angry glyphs of a man who'd died singing in the deep with his arms round a starving Well.

When there is a smith who can hear every one.

"*Then I'd better start*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL DIDN'T CHEER. Nobody cheered for anything anymore. But something changed in it. He felt it. The way a forge changes when the bellows go in and the coals come up from red to orange.

Teo Brask stood up. Dripping.

"*Tide*," he said. "*I can take you to Tide. The Undertow. It remembers you. It liked you. You kept your vow.*" He went red. "*It said that. In the autumn. It said, tell the smith he kept his vow.*"

"*Gale*," said Wren. From the wall. With Lark on her hip. "*The First Breath. I can take you. I've been.*" A pause. "*It'll want something. It always does.*"

"*Shade*," said Antho. "*Obviously. Me.*"

"*Radiance*," said his mother. Very quietly. From the bench by the door.

Everyone looked at her.

She didn't look up. She was looking at her folded hands. "*I gave it once. At the Heart. When you were forging the net. I was a lullaby in the dark and I didn't know what I was doing.*" She lifted her eyes. Brown. Steady. "*I know now. I can teach you. If you'll let me.*"

Lex looked at her for a long time.

"*Yes*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And Hollow*?" said Brannoc.

They all looked at the pool. Not the pool. There was no pool here. They looked east. Toward a green circle under snow, three hundred miles away.

"*Mal*," said Lex. "*Mal will teach me Hollow. When Mal's big enough to teach anyone anything.*" He looked down at the Codex. "*Which means the Crowned. Which means asking.*"

"*And the third thing*?" said the Queen. "*Seraphine said two things and then a third.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE LOOKED AT SEREN.

Seren looked back.

"*The lanterns*," said Seren Harrow.

She stood up. Slowly. In her grey shawl. And came down the hall between the anvils, past Brannoc and Tilda and Hedda and Teo's puddle, to the table at the end. And put her hand flat on the Codex beside Lex's.

"*Moths can't drink a light that's given*," she said. "*Did you know that? Not one. It's the oldest thing the Harrow women knew. A lamp you keep for yourself, they'll come to. A lamp you give away—they can't touch it. It's not theirs to take. It's not anyone's.*" She looked at her son. "*We lit eleven hundred of them on Lantern Night. In the Blightmarch. And gave every one away. And the moths burned.*"

"*It's not moths*," said Kestrel. "*It's grey.*"

"*It's empty*," said Seren. "*The same as she was. Maelis. Empty and drinking. The grey country's no different. It drinks what it can reach.*" She looked round the hall. "*And I don't think it can reach a light that's been given. I think a given light makes its own room. I think that's what giving is.*"

Silence.

"*You think*," said the Queen.

"*I think*," said Seren Harrow. "*I'm a hedge-witch, Majesty, not a scholar. I don't know anything. I only know what my mother knew and her mother before her.*" She took her hand off the book. "*But I'd like to try. I'd like to light every lantern in Caldor and carry them west and give them away. And see if the grey goes round.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Eleven hundred and thirteen*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*At the Keep.*"

His mother looked at him.

"*They've been lit since Lantern Night*," he said. "*On nothing. Every one. They don't need oil.*" He swallowed. "*They're given already. All of them. They've been given for years.*"

"*Then that's where we'll start*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE QUEEN OF CALDOR looked round her council.

At the smith with two Wells out of seven and six months to find the rest. At his brother with a coin of gold on his hand. At a scholar with eleven books, a fire-witch with a singed coat, a boy who dripped, a grandmother

with her feet in the quench, an old smith with gold fingertips and a young smith with a gold hand. At a woman with a sleeping baby and three gold fingers. At a widow in a grey shawl who wanted to give away every lantern in the kingdom.

She sighed.

"*My grandfather*," said Lysandra, "*had a council of forty lords and a hundred clerks and an army.*"

"*Did it help*?" said Kestrel.

"*Not once*," said the Queen. She stood up. "*All right. A door. Six months. Seven Wells. Ask the Crowned. Lanterns.*" She looked at Lex. "*What do you need from me?*"

He opened his mouth.

He didn't get to answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOOR OF THE Forge banged open.

Snow blew in. Cold. And a boy. Small. Ten. One of the Pruett cousins from the mill, red-faced, out of breath, with his cap gone and his hair full of snow.

"*Smith—*" He stopped. Saw the Queen. Went white. Saw everyone else. Went whiter. "*Smith—sorry—Your Majesty—sorry—*"

"*What is it, Jory*?"

"*On the green*," said the boy. He was shaking. "*On the green, smith. By the Stone.*" He swallowed. "*There's a gold giant sitting on the green.*"

CHAPTER 5

The King on the Green

THE WHOLE OF ASHBOURNE was standing at the edges of the green, and nobody was on it.

Lex saw them as he came down the lane from the Forge. Packed into doorways. Crowded at windows. Lined up three deep along the front of the Crooked Kettle, with Benno the landlord in front in his apron holding a poker. Children on shoulders. Old men on walls. Women with their arms wrapped round themselves and their breath smoking. A hundred people. Two hundred. The whole village.

All of them looking at the middle of the green.

And nobody moving.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREEN AT ASHBOURNE was a lopsided triangle of grass between the mill road and the chapel and the lane up to the Forge. Under snow now. Trampled into paths at the edges, by the well and the chapel door. A lantern-pole on every corner, still hung with Lantern Night lights. A bench by the pond.

And in the middle, the Stone.

Pale. Tall as a man. Clouded like old ice. Cracked from top to bottom down the middle in a line as straight as if someone had laid a ruler on it. The Lattice Stone of Ashbourne, where every child of the village had put their hand at sixteen for three hundred years and been told what they were.

Where Lex had put his, at sixteen, ten years ago. And the Stone had lit, silver-blue, dim, and said *SMITH. Common. Ceiling 24.*

He'd believed it for three years.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WAS SITTING beside it.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE SNOW. CROSS-LEGGED. With his back very straight and his great hands resting on his knees, the way a man sits who has been told to keep still and is trying very hard to do it.

Even sitting, he was taller than the Stone.

Gold. All of him. Not gilded. Not painted. *Gold*, the way a coal is red. Glowing. Faintly, steadily, from inside, like metal in a crucible just before it pours. His hair was gold. His beard. His skin. His robe, which had once been something rich and deep and was now gold to the hem. And his eyes—

Lex didn't look at his eyes. Not yet. He'd learned that in the autumn. You looked at the King's eyes when you were ready to.

Round him, on the snow, a circle. Gold. A yard across. Where he'd sat down. The snow under him and round him gone gold, and the grass under the snow, and, Lex supposed, the earth under the grass, a little way down. A gold circle on a white green, with a gold man in the middle of it.

He had a cup in his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOPPED AT THE edge of the green.

Behind him, he could hear the others coming down the lane from the Forge. The Queen's guards. Kestrel's quick light step. Brannoc, breathing. He didn't look round.

"*Stay here*," he said.

"*Lex—*" Wren.

"*Stay here. Please.*" He looked at the King. The King hadn't moved. Hadn't turned his head. Was looking, Lex thought, at the Stone. "*He's not here to hurt anyone. He'd have done it already.*"

"*You don't know what he's here for.*"

"*No*," said Lex. "*So I'm going to ask him.*"

He stepped onto the green.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SNOW WAS VERY loud under his boots.

Two hundred people watching. Not a sound from any of them. Just his boots in the snow, *crunch*, *crunch*, and the wind in the bare elms by the chapel, and somewhere a dog barking and someone hushing it.

He walked straight across. Not hurrying. The way you'd walk up to a horse you didn't know.

He stopped at the edge of the gold circle.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*," said the Gilded King.

He said it without turning his head. Warm. Deep. A voice like a bell.

But not like a bell. Not quite. Lex heard it. The thing his mother had heard at the window, and Wren in the high country, and Nan Ashby's neighbour over her wall with her clay pipe. Under the warmth. Under the depth. A flaw. A hairline crack down the middle, the way a bell sounds when it's been dropped once and still rings but not quite true.

"*Majesty*," said Lex.

"*Oh*, *don't*." The King turned his head. Slowly. Looked up at him. "*Nobody's called me that since the boat. Except Orrin. And Orrin calls the furniture Majesty if you leave him alone with it long enough.*"

And Lex looked at his eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

FURNACE EYES. MOLTEN. GOLD-WHITE at the centre, going to orange at the edges, like the heart of a forge with the bellows going. He remembered them from the autumn. From the floor of his mother's cottage, with the King kneeling on the gold flags and his hand out to a baby. You couldn't look at them for long. They burned. Not cruelly. The way the sun burns.

They'd dimmed.

He saw it at once. In the autumn they'd been like looking into a furnace. Now they were like looking into one that had been banked for the night. Still gold. Still hot. Still too bright to hold. But lower. Deeper. With something in them that hadn't been there before.

Lex didn't have a word for it.

He thought, later, that the word was *tired*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Sit*," said the King. "*If you like. Not too close.*" He lifted one hand off his knee and gestured. At the snow beyond the edge of the gold. "*I've been very careful. I've been careful for two months. I haven't touched a single person.*" He looked at the circle round him. "*Things, yes. I can't help things. But not people.*"

Lex sat.

In the snow. A yard off. Just outside the gold. Cross-legged, the same as the King. With the cracked Stone beside them both and two hundred people watching from the edges of the green.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CUP WAS LOPSIDED.

He saw it now. In the King's great gold hand. Small. Too thick in the walls. With a handle that a smith had got wrong, too high, at a slant. And a thumb-print in the clay near the rim, where someone had pressed too hard.

Gold. All of it. And the tea in it. A gold disc. Still.

The King saw him looking.

"*I can't put it down*," he said. Simply. "*I've tried. I put it on a wall outside a farm near Greyfall, and walked twenty paces, and came back for it.*" He turned it a little in his fingers. Very carefully. The way you'd turn a bird's egg. "*Your mother made it. Did you know?*"

"*Brannoc made the handle*."

"*Brannoc*." The King considered this. "*The big one. With the fingers.*" He looked down at the cup. At the slanting handle. "*I gilded his fingers.*"

"*Your steward did*."

"*Orrin does what I want*." The furnace eyes didn't move off the cup. "*It's the same thing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT FOR A while.

The wind blew. The elms creaked. Two hundred people breathed at the edges of the green.

The King looked at the Stone.

"*It's glass*," he said. "*Did you know that? All the way down. Very old glass. Very strange.*" He tilted his great head. "*Ysy would like it. She likes anything you can see through.*"

"*Where is she*?"

"*I don't know*." He said it simply. Not hiding anything. Lex didn't think the King had ever hidden anything in his life. He'd never needed to. "*She went back to the Court. With Rosie. On a chain.*" A pause. "*I haven't heard her since. Not in a puddle. Not in a window. Not anywhere.*" He frowned. A great slow gold frown. "*Ysy's never quiet. Not for two months. She's never been quiet for two days.*"

He looked at the Stone again. At the crack down the middle.

"*I don't like it*," said the Gilded King.

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"*Cad's gone*," he said.

Lex didn't answer.

"*I felt it. At the edge. When it fell.*" The King looked at the cup. "*Rosie felt it more. Through her roots. She said he fell with the thread. All the way down. She said he nodded.*" A pause. "*At Hes. At her crown. On someone else's head.*"

"*Elric's*."

"*Elric's*." The King tried the name. "*Mae's friend. The grey one. With the bird.*" He shook his head slowly. "*I never met him. Cad met him. On the thread. Cad said he was the most stubborn thing he'd ever tried to move.*" A dry sound. Not a laugh. "*Cad said that about mountains, mostly.*"

"*He let us go*," said Lex. "*Your brother. At the end. He held us and he let us go.*"

The King was quiet.

"*He held Father's hand*," he said. "*At the end. Every night. For a month. Not saying anything. He was eleven.*"

"*I know. You told us.*"

"*Did I*?" The King looked at him. "*At the cottage. Yes. I told the old man.*" He looked down. "*I tell everyone. I've told four hundred people since the edge fell. On their walls. At their gates. In their yards.*" The cracked bell

of his voice went very low. "*Cad held his hand. And I stood outside the door.*"

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"*Four hundred*?" said Lex.

"*Four hundred and twelve*." The King didn't hesitate. "*I've been counting. Smiths count, I'm told. So do kings, it turns out. When there's nothing else to do.*" He turned the cup. "*Four hundred and twelve old women and old men and a few young ones, on their walls, at their gates, giving me tea in their worst cups because they knew it would go gold.*"

"*And you asked them—*"

"*How their mothers died*." The furnace eyes came up. "*Their grandmothers. Their husbands. Their children, some of them.*" He looked at Lex. "*If it hurt. If they were frightened. If anyone held their hand.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*You want to know why*," said the King.

"*Yes*."

The King looked at the Stone for a long time.

"*Because I sat with the old man*," he said. "*Your father. On the floor. At the end. And I watched it.*" His voice was very quiet now. "*I'd never watched it. Not once. In nine hundred years. Not Father. Not the cousins at the edge. Not one of my household in the first year, coming apart in the halls. I put my hand on them before they could. All of them. So I'd never have to.*"

He looked down at his hands. Gold. Enormous. Holding a lopsided cup.

"*And then I sat on the floor of that cottage and watched an old man do it*," said the Gilded King. "*With his wife holding one hand and his son holding the other. And it wasn't—*"

He stopped.

"*It wasn't what*?"

"*I don't know*." The King's face worked. Gold. Slowly. Like metal cooling. "*I don't know what it wasn't. That's why I keep asking.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIM.

At the biggest man in the world, gold, glowing, sitting in a circle of gold snow on a village green with a lopsided cup in his hand. Who had kept nine thousand people in gold for nine hundred years so he'd never have to watch one of them go. Who'd walked across half the world in the snow, stopping at walls and gates, asking old women how their grandmothers died.

He thought of a boy in a field. Mid-step. His eyes moving.

He thought of Wren's fingers. Brannoc's. Tilda's whole hand. Hask's arm. Roole in the gate.

He thought of a bed by a west window. And a voice saying *you should have gone in. He'd have liked you there*.

He didn't know what he felt.

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"*I need to ask you something*," he said.

The King looked at him.

"*Ask*."

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HE TOLD HIM.

All of it. The grey. The bread. The boy's hand. The stakes. A mile a day and faster. The dead at Mal's rim, thousands, saying their names, with the snow going grey round them. Mal, crying in the dark, too little.

And Caddoc. The heavy cold piece of the Well coming home on Lantern Night. *Hesper's*. And the room getting bigger. Like a breath.

The King listened.

He didn't interrupt. He didn't move. He sat in his circle of gold with the cup in his hands and his furnace eyes on Lex's face and listened to all of it. The way Lex's father used to listen. The way Seraphine listened. With his whole attention, as if nothing else in the world were happening.

When Lex had finished, he was quiet for a long time.

"*So I'm full*," he said at last. "*Of your pool.*"

"*Yes*."

"*And it's empty*."

"*Nearly*."

"*And my dead are standing round it*," said the Gilded King. "*Waiting. Because I drank their room nine hundred years ago, and never gave it back.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

The King looked down at the cup.

"*And you want it back*," he said.

"*I'm asking*," said Lex. "*Not taking. I couldn't take it if I wanted to. Nobody can.*" He swallowed. "*I'm asking you to give it back. Like Hesper did.*"

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THE KING DIDN'T ANSWER.

He sat very still. In the snow. Looking at the cup. For a long time. Long enough that Lex heard the chapel clock strike the half hour behind him. Long enough that a child at the edge of the green started crying and was hushed.

Then he spoke.

"*Do you know what happens*," said the Gilded King, "*if I give it back?*"

"*You'd stop being deathless*."

"*Yes*." The King nodded slowly. "*Yes. That's the first thing. I'd stop. I'd start. I'd get old. I'd get sick. One day I'd sit in a chair by a window and go through the door, and the man with the boat would come for me at last.*" He looked at the cup. "*I'm not afraid of that.*"

He said it so simply that Lex believed him.

"*Then—*"

"*That's not the only thing*." The furnace eyes came up. "*Smith. What do you think keeps them?*"

Lex didn't understand.

"*My household*," said the King. "*Nine thousand of them. Walking across your fields. Humming.*" He lifted his free hand. Not far. A few inches off his knee. Gold. Enormous. "*What do you think holds them? In the gold? What do you think keeps them from coming apart, after nine hundred years? Keeps the boy in the field from finishing his step? Keeps your wife's fingers? Keeps the man in the gate?*"

He opened his hand. Slowly. Palm up.

"*Me*," he said. "*It's me. It's one hold. I put it on them the night of the boat, all of them, at once, and I've never let go. Not for a moment. Not in nine hundred years.*" He looked at his open hand. "*It's what I drank. It's what I'm full of. That's what the keeping is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT COLD.

"*If I give it back*," said the King quietly, "*the hold goes. All at once. Everywhere.*"

"*They'd be free—*"

"*They'd be nine hundred years old*," said the Gilded King.

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SILENCE.

On the green. In the snow. Two hundred people breathing.

"*The boy in your field*," said the King. "*Fine. He'd finish his step. He'd go home to his mother. He was only kept a year.*" He closed his hand. "*Your wife's fingers. The big smith's. The girl's hand. The miner's arm. They'd wake. They'd bend.*"

He looked east. Over the elms. Over the chapel roof. Toward the world.

"*And my cooks*," he said. "*My grooms. My nursemaids. Ilda. Nine thousand people who were born before your world had a name. They'd wake up. All at once. With nine hundred years on them.*" His voice cracked. Properly, this time. Down the middle. "*And they'd come apart. Like the ones in the halls. Like the cousins at the edge. Right there. In your fields. In front of me.*"

He looked at the cup.

"*All of them*," said the Gilded King. "*At once. And I'd be standing there. Outside the door.*"

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LEX COULDN'T SPEAK.

He'd thought about it. At the rim. On the dragon. In the cot at Greyfall. He'd thought about the Crowned and what they'd drunk and

what it would mean to give it back. He'd thought it would cost them their deathlessness. He'd thought that was the price.

He hadn't thought about the nine thousand.

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"*They want to go home*," he said. Hoarsely. "*Your household. They're humming it. Home. All of them.*"

"*They are home*," said the King. "*With me. In the gold. Safe.*"

But he didn't say it the way he'd said it in the autumn. On the floor of the cottage. *They're safe*. Like a bell.

He said it the way you say a prayer you've said so many times the words have worn smooth and you've stopped hearing them.

"*Ask me something else*," he said. "*Anything. I'll do anything else.*"

"*There isn't anything else*."

"*Then I'm sorry*," said the Gilded King. "*I'm very sorry, smith. I am.*" He looked down at the cup in his hands. "*But I can't stand outside nine thousand doors.*"

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LEX SAT IN THE snow.

He didn't argue. He couldn't think of anything to say. He sat beside the King in the snow on the green at Ashbourne with two hundred people watching and the cracked Stone between them, and didn't say anything at all.

We ask, he'd said.

He'd asked.

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"*Oi*," said a voice.

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THEY BOTH LOOKED UP.

Across the green. From the far side. From the row of cottages that faced the chapel, with their gardens running down to the pond.

An old woman was coming across the snow.

Very slowly. With a stick in one hand and a cat under her other arm. In three shawls and a man's coat and a pair of boots so big they must have

been her husband's. Bent nearly double. One eye. Bright. Black. Like a bird's. The other closed for good under a fold of skin she'd stopped bothering to cover forty years ago.

The whole village held its breath.

She came straight across the green. *Thump* went the stick. *Crunch* went the boots. *Mrrp* went the cat, under protest. She didn't hurry. She didn't stop. She came right up to the edge of the gold circle, on the King's other side, opposite Lex, and stood there, leaning on her stick, breathing hard, and looked down at the Gilded King with her one black eye.

"*You*," said Old Mag. "*You're the one with the steward.*"

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THE KING LOOKED UP at her.

For a moment—just a moment—Lex saw something in the furnace eyes he'd never seen there. Not in the autumn. Not on the floor of the cottage. Not ever.

The King looked *afraid*.

"*Mistress*," he said.

"*Don't you Mistress me. Your steward did that. In my kitchen. In the spring. Bowed to me after.*" She shifted the cat. "*Came in a storm of your gold. Blew my door in. Sat on my hearth like a pile of dead leaves and offered to keep me.*"

"*I know*," said the King. "*He told me.*"

"*And what did he tell you*?"

The King looked at her for a long time.

"*He said you said you weren't greedy*," said the Gilded King. Very quietly. "*He said you said you didn't want to be kept. You wanted to be finished.*" He swallowed. Gold. "*He said, there's a difference.*"

"*There is*," said Old Mag.

"*I've been thinking about it*," said the King. "*Ever since. For eight months.*" He looked down at the cup. "*I've walked across half your world thinking about it. I've asked four hundred and twelve people. I still don't know what it means.*"

Old Mag looked at him.

Then she sniffed. Loudly. And turned round.

"*Well, you won't find out sitting in the snow*," she said. "*Come on. My step's just there. I'm not making tea out here, I'm ninety-six. Ninety-seven Tuesday.*" She started back across the green. *Thump. Crunch.* "*Bring your cup. I've only got the one good teapot and I'm not having it go gold.*"

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NOBODY MOVED.

Not the King. Not Lex. Not the two hundred people round the edges of the green.

Old Mag stopped. Ten paces off. Looked back over her shoulder. One black eye.

"*Well*?" she said.

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THE KING GOT UP.

Slowly. Carefully. The way a very big man gets up when he's afraid of breaking something. One knee. Then the other. Then all of him, unfolding, up and up, until he stood over the green taller than the chapel door, gold, glowing, with the snow sliding off his shoulders in gold flakes and the circle round his feet blazing.

The whole village stepped back. A hundred people. Two hundred. All at once. Like a field of grass in the wind.

The King didn't seem to notice.

He was looking at the old woman. At her stick. At her husband's boots. At the cat.

He followed her.

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LEX FOLLOWED TOO. HE didn't decide to. He just got up and went.

Across the green. Behind the King. The King walked very slowly, very carefully, putting each great gold foot down in the snow as if the snow were glass. Each footprint gold. A gold path across the white green, a step wide, following an old woman with a stick.

At the edge of the green, Old Mag's garden. A low wall. A gate, standing open. A path. And at the end of the path, a cottage. Small and crooked and whitewashed, with a thatch like an old hat, and a step—one

step, worn hollow in the middle by a hundred years of boots—up to the door.

And beside the door, an apple tree.

Old. Black-barked. Bent like its owner. Covered in snow.

And under the snow—Lex saw it as he came up the path, and stopped, and stared—

Blossom.

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WHITE. PINK AT THE edges. In thick clusters along every black branch. In the snow. In Midwinter. Not withered. Not frozen. *Open*. As if it were May.

It had done it two winters ago. The winter of the weddings. The winter the Hollow started coming up through the ground in Wild Delves and the world went strange—a spring in the forge yard, a second chimney on the mill—and Old Mag's dead apple tree, which hadn't flowered in thirty years, had burst into blossom in the snow.

Lex had thought it had stopped.

It hadn't. It was blooming now. In the grey Midwinter dusk. With the snow lying on it and the blossom showing through, white on white.

The King had stopped too.

He stood at the end of the path with his cup in his hand and looked up at it.

"*Oh*," said the Gilded King.

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"*Don't touch it*," said Old Mag. Sharply. From the step. "*It's mine. It's the only one I've got.*" She sat down on the step. Heavily. With a grunt. Put the cat in her lap. "*Sit there. On the path. You can look at it all you like. You can't touch it.*"

The King sat down on the path.

The flagstones went gold under him.

He didn't look at them. He was looking at the tree.

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"*Thirty years*," said Old Mag. Stroking the cat. "*Thirty years that tree was dead. My husband planted it the year we married. Gave apples like you wouldn't believe for forty years. Then stopped.*" She looked up at it. "*Then two winters ago it woke up. Middle of the snow. Like this. Hasn't stopped since. Flowers all year round. Never gives an apple. Not one.*" She sniffed. "*I don't mind. I'm too old for apples anyway. I like the flowers.*"

The King looked at the tree.

"*Why*?" he said.

"*Don't know*." Old Mag shrugged. "*The smith says it's the Hollow. The new Well. Making room. Possibilities, he calls them.*" She looked at Lex. "*Didn't you?*"

"*Yes*."

"*So there you are*." She looked back at the King. "*Possibilities*."

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THE KING SAT ON the gold path and looked at the blossom for a long time.

"*It's new*," he said at last. Very quietly.

"*It's old*," said Old Mag. "*Older than me. Older than my husband'd be.*"

"*The flowers are new*."

Old Mag looked at him. One black eye.

"*They're new every morning*," she said. "*That's the thing about flowers.*"

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LEX STOOD AT THE gate and watched them.

An old woman on a step with a cat in her lap. A gold king on a gold path with a lopsided cup in his hands. An apple tree between them, blooming in the snow.

And behind him, at the edges of the green, two hundred people. Watching. Not making a sound.

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THEY TALKED FOR AN hour.

Not about anything. Lex couldn't have said, after, what about. The cat. The tree. Her husband, who'd been a thatcher and fallen off a roof at sixty

and lived another twenty years out of spite. Her daughters, both married, both gone south. Her son.

"*Went to sea*," said Old Mag. "*At seventeen. On a salt-boat out of Saltreach. Never came back.*" She stroked the cat. "*Forty years ago. More. Storm off the Teeth, they said. All hands.*"

The King looked at her.

"*Were you frightened*?" he said. "*When they told you?*"

"*No*," said Old Mag. "*I was angry. He never wrote. Not once. Six months on that boat and not one letter.*" She sniffed. "*I'm going to tell him off. When I see him.*"

The King went very still.

"*When you see him*," he said.

"*At the bottom of the sea*," said Old Mag. "*Or wherever he's got to. Wherever you go.*" She looked at the King. Steadily. One black eye in a face like a dried apple. "*Not long now. I can feel it in my feet.*"

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THE KING DIDN'T MOVE.

He sat on the gold path in front of the old woman's step with the cup in his hands, and Lex watched the gold of his face go very still, the way metal goes still when it stops glowing and starts to set.

"*Your feet*," he said.

"*Cold*," said Old Mag. "*All the time. Since the autumn. Can't get them warm. Not by the fire. Not in bed. My mother had it. Her mother.*" She shrugged. "*It's how we go, in my family. Feet first.*" She almost grinned. "*Before Lantern Night, probably. The next one. Maybe before the spring.*"

"*I could—*" said the King.

He stopped.

"*No*," said Old Mag. Gently. "*No, you couldn't, dear. We've had that talk. Me and your steward.*" She scratched the cat behind its ears. "*I don't want to be kept. I want to be finished.*"

"*I don't know what that means*," said the Gilded King. And his voice broke. "*I keep asking. I don't know what it means.*"

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OLD MAG LOOKED AT him for a long time.

Then she did something nobody on the green would forget.

She leaned forward on her step. Over her cat. Toward the King. Until her old face was a foot from his great gold one. Not touching. Not quite. Close enough that Lex, at the gate, saw the light of the King's skin on her cheek, gold, and saw her not flinch.

"*Then you'd better come and watch*," said Old Mag.

The King stared at her.

"*When it's time*," she said. "*Come and sit with me. Here. By the fire. Hold my hand.*" She lifted her own hand off the cat. Old. Knotted. Brown-spotted. Held it out. Not to him. Just out. In the air between them. "*And don't keep me. Whatever you do. Don't you dare keep me.*"

She looked at him with her one black eye.

"*Sit with me, lad*," said Old Mag. "*When it's time. And you'll see.*"

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THE GILDED KING LOOKED at her hand.

At the old knotted fingers. Held out. In the cold. A foot from his own.

He didn't take it.

He didn't move at all.

And in the blooming apple tree over the step, a little wind came through the branches, from somewhere, from the east, and shook the snow off the blossom, and a few petals came down. White. Pink at the edges.

They fell on the gold path round the King.

And stayed white.

CHAPTER 6

Mist on Glass

WREN MISSED THE TREE.

Not the mark. The mark was a chalk circle the size of a plate on the trunk of a birch at thirty paces. She'd have been ashamed to miss the mark at thirty paces at nine years old, with her father's bow, which was too big for her.

She missed the *tree*.

The arrow went past it on the left. Into the snow. Skidded. Vanished under the white with a hiss like a snake going into a hole.

She stood in the birch wood behind the cottage at Harrow, in the grey light of a winter afternoon, with her bow in her right hand and her left hand at her cheek, and looked at the place where the arrow had gone.

Then she said a word she hadn't said since she was a tracker at Thistledown with a Ceiling of twenty-four and nothing to lose.

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SHE'D BEEN PRACTISING FOR six months.

Every day. Since the summer. Since the Night of Glass, and Orrin's storm coming over the yard wall, and the gold dust coming down on her drawing hand while she loosed and loosed and loosed into the dark.

She'd shot eleven arrows after her fingers stopped. Lex had counted them. In the mud the next morning. She'd heard him counting, under his breath, from the window. *Nine. Ten. Eleven.* She'd pretended to be asleep.

She didn't remember drawing them. She remembered her hand going cold, and the cold going into the bone, and the feeling going out of three

fingers like water out of a cup, and thinking, *not now*, *not yet*, and drawing again. With the fingers she had left. Hooking the string with the last two and her thumb—her gold thumb, that wouldn't bend—jammed against the nock like a peg.

Eleven arrows. She didn't know if any of them hit anything.

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SO SHE'D SWITCHED HANDS.

That was all. That was all it was. You held the bow in your left hand—your gold fingers wrapped round the grip, which they could do, because gripping was the one thing they were still good for, frozen in a curl like the claws of a bird—and you drew with your right.

Simple.

Everyone said so. Kestrel said so. Elowen said so. Tilda, who'd learned to swing a hammer with her left in a month, said so, and showed her how to set her feet.

Simple.

It was like learning to write with your other hand. It was like learning to walk on your other leg. Every muscle in her body had been built for twenty-seven years to draw with the left. Her shoulders. Her back. Her eye. She'd been the best bowman in Thistledown at fifteen. She'd shot a hare through the eye at sixty paces in a snowstorm to feed her mother and her brothers.

She couldn't hit a tree at thirty.

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SHE DREW AGAIN.

Set her feet. Breathed. The way Kestrel had told her. The way her father had told her, when she was nine. *Breathe in. Hold. Let it go on the out.*

Her right arm shook.

She let go.

The arrow hit the tree. A foot below the chalk. A foot to the right. It went in with a *thock* and stood there quivering.

She looked at it.

She didn't feel anything. Not pleased. Not angry. Just tired. Six months of it. Every day. In the snow, in the rain, in the summer heat in the yard. Six months, and she could hit a tree.

She looked at her left hand.

At the three gold fingers. Curled round the grip. Smooth. Bright. Cold. With the nails on them, gold too, perfect, as if somebody had cast them in a mould.

She hadn't cried about it.

She hadn't. Not once. Not that night. Not the next morning, with Lex counting arrows under the window. Not since. Not when she found she couldn't do up the buttons on Lark's smocks. Not when she couldn't plait her own hair. Not when she lay awake at night and felt them on the blanket beside her face, cold, like something that didn't belong to her.

Harrow women don't cry. Seren said that. Seren's mother never cried, not once, not even dying.

Wren wasn't a Harrow woman.

She still hadn't cried.

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SHE SHOT UNTIL THE light went.

Forty arrows. She counted. Eleven in the tree. Two in the chalk. The rest in the snow.

Then she went in.

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LEX WAS AT THE forge.

He was always at the forge. She could hear him from the yard. *Clang*. *Clang*. *Clang*. The same rhythm he'd hammered since he was eleven. Steady. Heavy. Like a heartbeat. Like a man trying to beat something into a shape it didn't want to take.

He'd come back from Ashbourne three days ago. From the green. From the King. He hadn't said much. He'd said *he won't*, and then he'd told her why, in the dark, in bed, in a flat quiet voice, and then he'd lain awake beside her until four.

She'd lain awake too. She didn't tell him.

They were both very good at not telling each other things. It was the thing about them she liked least.

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SHE BATHED LARK BY the fire.

The tin tub. In front of the hearth. Half full of water heated in the big kettle and cooled with snow from the sill. Lark loved it. Lark loved anything that let her make noise and mess at the same time. She sat in the tub with the water up to her round middle and slapped it with both square fists and shrieked.

"*No*," said Wren. "*Not on the floor.*"

"*No*," agreed Lark. And slapped it on the floor.

Wren sat back on her heels and let her.

It was the only time of day she wasn't tired. Bath. Firelight. The baby in the water, pink and furious and delighted, with her hair plastered flat for once and her green-grey eyes enormous. Steam going up. The fire ticking. The HERE lantern on the east sill, small and gold.

She soaped Lark's back with her right hand. Rinsed it. Lark grabbed the soap. Tried to eat it. Spat it out. Looked outraged.

"*That's what you get*," said Wren.

Lark slapped the water.

The water went still.

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NOT STILL. LARK WAS still slapping. Wren could see her fists going up and down. Could hear the splashes. Could feel the drops on her face.

But the water in the tub—the surface of it, between the baby and the side—

Still.

Like glass. Like a pond on a windless morning. Flat. Black. Shining.

And in it—where Wren's own face should have been, leaning over the tub in the firelight, with her braid coming apart and soap on her cheek—

Another face.

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NARROW. PALE. CLEAR. NOT pale like skin. Pale like ice. Like frost on a window. You could see through it, faintly, to the bottom of the tub. White hair, very fine, pulled back off a high brow. Ice-grey eyes. And on the brow, very thin, very bright, a crown of glass, like a line of frost along the edge of a leaf.

Smiling.

"*Hello, Mistwalker*," said the Glass Queen.

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WREN DIDN'T SCREAM.

She'd thought about it. A great deal. Six months of thinking about it. Lying awake. Every window horn. Every bucket lidded. Every sheet of glass at Harrow broken out of its frame and replaced, by Lex, in the week after the Night of Glass, with horn shaved so thin you could read through it.

She'd known it would happen again. Somewhere. Somehow. She'd thought about what she'd do.

She'd thought she'd scream.

She didn't. She put her right hand into the tub, flat, between the baby and the face, and said:

"*Get out of my daughter's bath*."

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THE GLASS QUEEN LAUGHED.

It came up out of the water like a bell under ice. Clear. Cold. Delighted.

"*Oh*," she said. "*Oh, that's good. Nobody's ever said that to me. Nine hundred years.*" The ice-grey eyes moved. To Lark. Who had stopped slapping, and was sitting very still in the tub, looking down at the water between her fists. At the face. With her mouth open. "*Hello, little one.*"

"*Don't*," said Wren. "*Don't talk to her.*"

"*Why not*? *She's looking at me.*" The face tilted. "*She's the only one who ever does. Did you know that? She looked at me in the stream. On the night the edge fell. Through the ice. Straight at me.*" A pause. "*As if there were something there.*"

Lark reached down.

Wren caught her wrist.

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"*I'm not going to hurt her*," said the Glass Queen.

"*You reached for her. At Midsummer. Out of the water barrel.*" Wren's voice didn't shake. She was pleased about that. "*You'd have had her if your brother's old man hadn't broken the glass with his cane.*"

"*Ah. Arion.*" Something moved across the clear face. Quickly. Like the shadow of a bird across a pond. "*I liked him. He knew my sisters. He told me I had Mae's chin.*" The eyes came back to Wren. "*I'm sorry he's dead. I am. I don't say things I don't mean.*"

"*I know you don't.*"

"*Then you know I'm not going to hurt her.*"

"*You don't have to mean to*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN WAS quiet for a moment.

Wren watched her. In the still black surface of the bathwater. Holding Lark's wrist. With her own heart going like a hare's.

She'd met her once. Properly. At Midsummer. In the yard. A tall clear figure stepping out of the water barrel in a long glass gown, glittering, with her hand out. Cold. Curious. Vain. Funny—that was the thing that frightened Wren most, afterward, lying awake. She'd been *funny*. She'd said something about Wren's boots that had nearly made Wren laugh, in the middle of all of it, with gold coming down.

She looked different now.

Wren couldn't have said how. The same face. The same crown. The same cold clear eyes.

But at Midsummer she'd looked like a queen come to collect something.

Now she looked like a woman who hadn't slept.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're angry*," said the Glass Queen.

"*Yes.*"

"*Not at me. Not mostly.*" The ice-grey eyes moved over her. Slowly. The way you'd look at a page. "*At your hand. And at him, a little, for looking at it. And at yourself for minding that he looks.*"

Wren didn't move.

"*And at the tree*," said Ysenne. "*In the wood. You missed it. Twenty-nine times out of forty.*" A pause. "*I was in the snow. On the ice on the stream. Watching. You didn't know.*" The clear face tilted. "*You wanted to cry. On the twenty-third arrow. You didn't. You put your teeth together and drew again.*"

"*Get out.*"

"*Why didn't you cry*?"

"*Get out of my daughter's bath.*"

"*It's a true question*," said the Glass Queen. "*I only ask true questions. I want to know.*" The eyes were very steady. "*Your mother-in-law says Harrow women don't cry. You're not a Harrow woman. You're an Ashdown. Ashdowns cry. Your mother cried for a week when your father died. I've seen it. In her window. In Highcrest. She keeps his bow on the wall.*"

Wren's breath caught.

"*So why don't you*?" said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T ANSWER.

She couldn't. Her throat had closed. She knelt by the tin tub in front of the fire with her daughter's wrist in her right hand and the Glass Queen's face in the water and her own three gold fingers lying on her knee, cold, and couldn't say anything at all.

"*Because if you start*," said the Glass Queen softly, "*you think you won't stop.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN BREATHED OUT.

Not a sigh. Not a sob.

Mist.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME UP OUT of her the way it had come at Midsummer. From the bottom of her lungs. From the place under her breastbone where the wind lived. Grey. Soft. Wet. Cold. A breath like the breath of a valley at dawn, like the fog that comes up off a river in October. Gale Commanding. Mistwalker. She'd been born in a storm. She'd carried the First Breath in her lungs for three days once, at the eye of a storm above the Teeth, and come down with something in her she still didn't have a name for.

It rolled out of her mouth and down over the tub.

Over the water. Over the still black surface. Over the face.

Fog on glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FACE WENT.

Not all at once. Blurred. Softened. The way your reflection goes in a window when you breathe on it. The clear lines of the brow and the crown and the cold eyes going grey, going soft, going—

"*Oh*, *that's clever*," said the Glass Queen. Faintly. From somewhere under the mist. "*That's very—*"

Gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WATER RIPPLED.

Lark slapped it.

Splash.

Wren knelt by the tub with mist curling off her lips and her heart going and her daughter's wrist still in her hand, and looked at the water.

Just water. Grey with soap. Rippling. Showing the firelight, broken, in a hundred little pieces.

And her own face. Tired. Freckled. Wet.

Hers.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK LOOKED UP AT her.

"*No*," said Lark. Thoughtfully. Not to Wren. To the water. Where the face had been.

Then she slapped it again.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN GOT HER OUT of the tub.

She did it very fast. She wrapped her in the towel warming on the fender and held her against her chest, wet and squirming and indignant, and stood up, and stood there in front of the fire with the baby in her arms and the tub at her feet.

Then she kicked the tub over.

Water across the flags. Across the hearthrug. Into the ashes. Hissing.

Lark stopped squirming and stared at her.

"*Sorry*," said Wren. "*Sorry, chick. Sorry.*"

And then she was crying.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT QUIETLY. NOT THE way she'd thought she'd do it, if she ever did it, alone in the wood, a few tears, wiped away.

Great ugly heaving gulps. With her face in the baby's wet hair. Standing in a puddle of bathwater in front of the fire. Her whole body shaking. Lark clutched in her arms so hard the baby squeaked.

She couldn't stop.

That was the thing. The Glass Queen was right. She'd been right about everything. *If you start, you think you won't stop.*

She didn't stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX FOUND HER LIKE that.

She didn't hear him come in. The forge had stopped—she hadn't noticed it stop—and the door had opened, and he was there. In the doorway. In his apron. With soot on his face and the little hammer still in his hand.

He took one look.

He dropped the hammer.

He crossed the room in three strides, through the puddle, and put his arms round her. Round both of them. Her and the baby. And held on.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't say *what happened*. He didn't say *are you hurt*. He didn't say *it'll be all right*. He didn't say anything at all.

He just held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD HIM. AFTER.

Sitting on the floor in front of the fire, on the wet hearthrug, with Lark asleep at last between them in a nest of towels and blankets. In the firelight. With the HERE lantern on the sill.

All of it. The bath. The face. *Hello, Mistwalker*. The stream on the night the edge fell. *She looked at me as if there were something there.*

And the rest. The tree. The twenty-third arrow. *Why don't you cry?*

"*She was in the stream*," said Wren. "*The whole time I was shooting. Under the ice. Watching me miss.*"

Lex was very quiet.

"*She knew about my mother*," said Wren. "*About Da's bow. On the wall. In Highcrest. She's been in my mother's window.*"

"*She's been in everyone's window*," said Lex.

"*I know*." Wren wiped her face on her sleeve. "*I know. But she was right. That's the worst of it. She was right about all of it.*" She looked at her gold fingers. "*She doesn't lie. Seren says. Harrow lore. The Glass Queen never lies.*"

"*No*," said Lex. "*She just tells you the true things you were trying not to know.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT HER hand.

He did it every day. She saw him do it. At breakfast. At supper. In bed. His grey eyes going to the gold fingers and staying there. Not for long. A breath. Then away. As if he'd touched something hot.

He did it now. And didn't look away.

"*I hate it*," he said.

She looked at him.

"*Your hand*," he said. "*I hate it. Every time I see it. I can't fix it. I've tried. Every way I know. Fire. Room. Hammer. Nothing.*" His voice was very low. "*I'm a smith. You bring me a thing that's wrong, and I fix it. That's what I'm for. That's all I've ever been for.*" He swallowed. "*And I can't fix this. I*

can't fix your hand or Brannoc's or Tilda's. I can't fix the boy in the field. I can't make the bread rise. I can't make the King give it back."

He looked at the fire.

"*I can't make anything*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOOK HIS HAND.

His burned one. His left. In her right. And held it.

"*You made her*," said Wren.

He looked down. At the nest of towels between them. At the round sleeping face. At the fluff of dark hair, drying, standing up already like a bird's crest. At the square fist, closed round a horseshoe nail on a ribbon.

"*We made her*," he said.

"*We made her*," agreed Wren. "*So stop it.*" She squeezed his hand. Hard. "*And stop looking at my fingers like they're your fault. They're not your fault. They're Orrin's. They're the King's. They're mine, now.*" She lifted the gold hand. Turned it in the firelight. "*I don't want you to fix them. I want you to stop being sorry every time you see them.*"

He looked at her.

"*I don't know if I can*," he said.

"*Try*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T SLEEP MUCH that night either.

But they lay awake together. For once. Talking. In the dark. In the loft. With Lark in the ash-and-iron cradle with KNIT on the rockers, breathing.

About the Glass Queen. About what she wanted. *She looked at me as if there were something there.* About the stream, which couldn't be lidded, and the ice on it, and the pond in the birch wood, and the puddles that would come with the thaw.

"*We could go*," said Lex. In the dark. "*Somewhere with no water.*"

"*Where*?"

"*The Sunreach. The Glass Desert.*" He paused. "*No. Not the Glass Desert.*"

She laughed. Despite everything. Into his shoulder.

"*Harrow women move on*," she said. "*When the moths come. That's the rule. Thirty houses in twenty generations. Seren's told me all of it. Never stay. Never leave a light on. Never let a moth in.*"

"*You're not a Harrow woman*."

"*No*." She was quiet for a while. "*I'm an Ashdown. Ashdowns stay.*" She found his hand in the dark. "*I ran in the autumn. With her. Round the high country. With the King behind me. For eighty-six days.*" Her voice went very quiet. "*I'm not running again. Not from a face in a bath.*"

"*Then what*?"

"*Then I breathe on it*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Every time.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WOKE BEFORE DAWN.

She didn't know why. The loft was dark. Lex was asleep at last, on his back, with his mouth open and one arm over his eyes. Lark was asleep in the cradle.

Something had woken her.

She lay still and listened.

The stream. Loud. Under its ice. The wind in the birches, west. The fire downstairs, ticking.

And something else.

Faint. Very faint. Like a breath. Like the sound a seed makes in the ground in spring, if you could hear it. A small dry slow *unfolding*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT DOWN THE ladder in her nightshirt. Barefoot. With her bow, because she'd taken it up the ladder with her the night before and laid it beside the bed, and her hand found it in the dark before she'd thought about it.

The fire was low. She didn't wake it.

She opened the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREY. THE VERY FIRST grey of dawn. Snow on everything. The birches white and black. The stream black and loud. The stepping stones.

The blue-door cottage across the water, dark, with one small gold light in its west window. Horn. Blurred. *TOO LATE*.

And the grave.

The grey stone by the stream. The twenty lanterns round it, small and gold in the snow. Pim's turnip, black and soft.

And beside the turnip—growing up out of the snow, out of the frozen ground, between the lanterns, at the foot of the stone—

A rose.

◆ ◆ ◆

RED.

Dark red. Nearly black at the heart. One flower. Open. On a long thin stem, green, with thorns. Standing up out of the white snow in the grey dawn by the grave as if it had every right to be there.

It hadn't been there last night. Wren had walked past the grave at dusk. She'd have seen it.

She went across the yard. Barefoot. In the snow. She didn't feel the cold.

She knelt down by the stone.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS SOMETHING TIED to the stem.

Under the flower. A scrap of cloth. Grey. Silk. Old. Rotten at the edges. Tied round the stem with a thread pulled from its own weave.

She'd seen one like it before. In the spring. Lex had brought it home from the edge of the world, from a gold field, from the place where the first rose came through the crack in the Veil. A scrap of grey silk with one word on it.

HES?

This one had more.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT INK. NOT PAINT. *Holes*. Tiny ones. Pricked through the silk in rows, in a careful, shaking hand, with something very sharp. A thorn. Spelling out letters in pinpricks, the way a child would prick out a pattern on a sampler.

She held it up to the grey light.

She read it.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSY IN STONES
WANTS CROWN IN ROAD
NEEDS VEY HAND
SMALL ONE
HELP ME

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN KNELT BY THE grave with the silk in her hand and the rose in the snow and the dawn coming up grey over the birch wood.

She didn't breathe.

Behind her, across the yard, in the loft of the cottage, through the shaved-horn window, she heard her daughter wake. And say the one word she always said first, every morning, to whoever was there.

"No."

CHAPTER 7

The Undertow

LEX DIDN'T WANT TO go.

He stood in the yard at Harrow on the morning after the rose, with his pack on his back and Teo Brask dripping patiently at the gate, and didn't want to go anywhere at all.

"*Go*," said Wren.

"*She's in the stream*."

"*She's in every stream. And every pond and puddle and window in Caldor.*" Wren had Lark on her hip and her bow over her shoulder and her face set in the way it set when she'd made up her mind and you could argue with it the way you could argue with a cliff. "*You can't stand in front of all of them.*"

"*I can stand in front of this one*."

"*And then what*?" She looked at him. Green eyes. Steady. "*Six months, Seraphine says. Seven Wells. You've got two.*" She shifted the baby. "*You stand in front of this stream for six months, and at Midsummer the grey comes up the Vale and over the hill and into this yard, and you're still standing here with your arms folded, guarding a stream.*"

He didn't answer.

"*Go*," said Wren. "*Your mother's here. Brannoc's here. Kestrel's sleeping in the lean-to and she says if anything comes out of the water she'll boil it.*" A pause. "*I'm here.*"

"*I know you're here*."

"*Then go*," said his wife. And kissed him. On the handprint. "*And come back with three.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT.

He looked back once. From the top of the track, where it came out of the birch wood onto the Ashbourne road. At the cottage. At the yard. At Wren, at the gate, with the baby. At the grave by the stream with its twenty lanterns and its one red rose.

Lark waved.

She'd learned it the week before. She did it at everything. Horses. Crows. The goat. She did it with her whole arm, like someone trying to flag down a cart.

He waved back.

Then he turned and walked to the coast.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS FOUR HUNDRED miles.

They didn't walk it. Ashka took them to the edge of the Vale, and Antho said *I'll be at the Keep, with the lanterns*, and flew back north. And from the edge of the Vale they went by cart, and by river barge, and by a fishing boat out of Saltreach with a skipper who looked at Teo's dripping hair and Lex's handprint and charged them double and then refused to take their money at the other end.

It took eight days.

Lex didn't sleep much. He lay on the deck of the fishing boat at night with his coat over him and watched the stars and thought about a rose in the snow.

YSY IN STONES.

NEEDS VEY HAND.

SMALL ONE.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY'D TAKEN IT TO the Forge. The same day. Wren had carried it there herself, in the dawn, running, with Lark on her back and the silk in

her fist. And the council had sat on their anvils again and passed it from hand to hand, and nobody had said anything for a long time.

Then Seraphine had said, very quietly: "*The Root.*"

The Root of the net. The gold centre at the bottom of everything, where every thread came in and crossed and met. Where Aurelian had sat for nine hundred years. Where Lex had stood, once, at the Heart, with a hammer in his hand and the whole world in front of him, and opened his hand and let it go.

No one at the centre, he'd thought. *Everyone holding everyone.*

You left a crown lying in the road, Elric had said. At the bottom of the world. A year later. *And they're coming to pick it up.*

"*The Stones are glass*," Seraphine had said. "*To her. Every Lattice Stone in the world. She walks in glass. And the Stones are glass all the way down to the net.*" She'd looked at the silk in her hands. "*She's going in. Through the Stones. Down the threads. To the centre.*"

"*And the centre won't take her*," said Lex. "*It's Vey. It's always been Vey. Aurelian built it that way. Only his blood.*"

"*Yes*," said Seraphine. "*So she needs a Vey hand.*"

They'd all looked at the last line. Pricked in thorn-holes. Shaking.

SMALL ONE.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LAY ON THE deck of the fishing boat and watched the stars and thought about his daughter's hands.

Square. Too big for the rest of her. Broad in the palm. Strong. A smith's hands. *Vey hands*, his father had said once. Holding her by the pool on the night she was born. *Aurelian had hands like that. In the paintings. Too big for him.*

He thought about the Glass Queen in the bathwater. *She looked at me. As if there were something there.*

He didn't sleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

TEO'S VILLAGE WAS CALLED Gull's Reach.

It sat in a notch in the sea cliffs on the long grey western coast below Saltreach, where the land ran out in a tumble of black rock and the

Sundering Sea came in green and white and enormous from the edge of the world. A harbour wall. Thirty houses. Boats drawn up on the shingle. Nets on poles. Smoke. Gulls. A smell of salt and tar and fish.

And a small round tower of grey stone at the end of the harbour wall, with a lantern on top, that was Teo's.

"*The Keepers gave it to me*," said Teo. Climbing the steps ahead of him. Dripping on every one. "*After the net. After the Undertow. They said a Tide Speaker ought to have a tower.*" He went red. "*I didn't want one. I wanted to stay at the Forge. But the sea wanted me here.*"

"*The sea told you*?"

"*The sea tells me everything*," said Teo Brask. Simply. "*All the time. It never stops talking.*" He opened the door at the top. "*It's quite tiring, actually.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM AT THE top of the tower was round and bare and very wet. Not damp. *Wet*. Water ran down the inside of the walls in thin bright sheets, all the way round, from the ceiling to the floor, and ran away through a channel in the flags and out through a hole in the wall. Like standing inside a waterfall that had been folded into a circle.

In the middle, a table. A chair. A bed with an oilskin over it. And on the table, in a big glass jar full of seawater, a fish.

Small. Silver-blue. Fat. Swimming in slow circles.

"*That's Barnaby*," said Teo.

"*Hello, Barnaby*."

The fish looked at him.

"*He came to the wedding*," said Teo. "*At the Hollowmaw. In his jar. Seraphine says he's the only fish that's ever been to a royal wedding.*" A pause. "*He liked it. He liked the music.*"

Lex looked at the fish. The fish looked at Lex. It had a very steady stare for a fish.

"*Teo*," said Lex. "*You've got a lot of water on your walls.*"

"*I know*." Teo looked at it. Mournfully. "*It follows me. It always has. Since the Undertow. I tried to stop it once and the sea was offended for a week. No fish anywhere. The whole village nearly starved.*" He sat down on the

bed. On the oilskin. Water ran off his hair and down his neck. "*I don't mind it really. You get used to being wet.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD LEX ABOUT the tide at Morrow.

They sat at the table in the round wet room with Barnaby circling in his jar, and Teo told it. Simply. The way he told everything. In a soft hesitant voice, with his long hands flat on the table and the water running down the walls all round them.

"*The cliffs at Morrow*," he said. "*Sixty miles south. Where the coast runs out at the old edge. Where the Veil came down to the sea.*" He swallowed. "*The tide didn't come in. Last week. On the Tuesday.*"

Lex stared at him.

"*It went out*," said Teo. "*The way it always goes out. Twice a day. And then it didn't come back. It's still out. A week. The fishing boats at Morrow are lying on their sides in the mud a mile from the water, and the water's just—*" He made a small helpless gesture. "*Lying there. Flat. Like a pond. Not going anywhere. Not coming back.*"

"*The grey*," said Lex.

"*I think so. The sea thinks so.*" Teo looked at the walls. At the water running down them. "*The sea's frightened, Lex. I've never felt it frightened. Not even at the Undertow. Not even when the net was on it and it hated the stillness so much it tried to drown me for coming near.*" He looked back at Lex. "*It says there's something at the edge of the world that's drinking it. Out past Morrow. Where the Veil came down to the water. It says it can feel itself going. Out. And not coming back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX THOUGHT ABOUT THE cut on Davy Pruett's hand.

Not festered. Not healed. Just staying.

He thought about the Undertow.

He'd met it once. Three years ago. In the Wellworld of Tide. Teo had taken them down—Teo, and Seraphine, and Antho—through the green and the cold and the dark to the bottom of the sea, where the current was a voice and the voice was a god, or something like one. Enormous. Ancient. Angry.

Angry at the net. At the Ceiling. At the Tithe. At the stillness. *I am the thing that moves*, it had said, in a voice like every wave that had ever broken. *Your net has held me still for nine hundred years. I hate it. I hate what holds.*

And Lex had made it a vow. On his knees, in the dark, at the bottom of everything, with the water pressing on his ears. *I'll break it. The net. The Ceiling. All of it. I'll weave a new one with nothing in it that holds.*

And he had. A year later. At the Heart.

Tell the smith he kept his vow, it had said. Teo told him. In the autumn.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It'll want something*," said Lex.

"*It always wants something*." Teo looked at his hands. "*Last time it wanted Seraphine's fear of the sea. She gave it. She's never been afraid of water since.*" He looked up. "*I don't know what it'll want from you.*"

"*Neither do I.*"

"*It liked you*," said Teo. "*Last time. Did you know? It said you were the only one who didn't beg.*" A shy smile. "*It said you swore at it.*"

"*I don't remember swearing at it.*"

"*You swore at it quite a lot*," said Teo. "*When it was drowning you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN AT the turn of the tide.

At dusk. On the shingle below the harbour wall. In the cold. With the sea coming in green and grey and enormous out of the west and the gulls going home and the lantern on Teo's tower lit above them.

Teo walked into the water.

Just walked. In his clothes. In his boots. Up to his knees. Up to his waist. Up to his chest. The waves broke over him and he didn't flinch. He stood in the sea with the water to his shoulders and the swell lifting him and setting him down, lifting and setting him down, like a cork. And turned round.

"*Come on*," he said. "*It's not cold. Not after the first bit.*"

It was the coldest thing Lex had ever felt.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D BEEN COLD BEFORE. Snow in the Greyspine. Ice on the Frostvault. The black glass at the bottom of the world. But this was different. This was cold that went *in*. Through the skin. Through the muscle. Into the bone. Into the marrow. Into the place under his breastbone where the Wells lived, where Flame was, where the heat came from.

Flame flinched.

He felt it. The fire in him, that had been in him since he was nineteen and a seal cracked open in a storm of gold, *flinched* from the water. The way a cat flinches from a bath. Pulled back. Small. Deep. A coal in a grate in a draughty room.

Easy, he thought. To the fire. To himself. *Easy.*

He walked in.

◆ ◆ ◆

UP TO THE WAIST. The swell lifting him off his feet and setting him down. Up to the chest. His breath going out of him in great gasps, white, smoking. Teo ahead of him. Calm. Patient. Waiting.

"*Now*," said Teo. "*Breathe in. All the way. And hold it.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then let it take you*," said the Tide Speaker.

He went under.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREEN.

Green and dark and cold and loud. Not loud. *Full*. Full of sound. The roar of the swell overhead. The grind of shingle on the bottom. The click and hiss of a thousand small living things in the weed. And under all of it, deeper, bigger, so big he felt it in his teeth before he heard it—

A voice.

Not words. Not yet. A *pull*. Down. Out. West. Like a hand round his ankle. Gentle. Enormous. Absolutely certain.

He let it take him.

◆ ◆ ◆

DOWN.

Through the green into the grey. Through the grey into the blue. Through the blue into the dark. Faster than falling. Slower than sinking. The light going out overhead like a candle snuffed. The cold going from cold to something past cold, to a pressure, an embrace, the whole weight of the sea folding round him like a fist closing.

He couldn't breathe. He'd known he wouldn't be able to breathe. He'd done this before. He held it. He held it. He held—

Don't, said the sea.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS EVERYWHERE.

In the dark. All round him. Under him. Over him. Through him. A voice like every wave that had ever broken on every shore since the world was water. Slow. Vast. Patient. Angry, still—he could hear it, the anger, deep down, like a riptide under a calm surface—but not at him.

SMITH.

You came back.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T ANSWER. HE was holding his breath.

Let it go, said the Undertow.

He didn't.

You are holding your breath, said the sea. Very slowly. *You have been holding it a long time. Longer than this. Longer than the dive.* The dark pressed on him. Not hard. Steady. Like a hand on a door. *Let it go, smith. You cannot drown here. You are mine here. Let go.*

He let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE AIR WENT OUT of him in a rush of silver bubbles. Up. Away. Into the dark overhead.

And the water came in.

Into his mouth. His throat. His lungs. Cold. Salt. Heavy. Filling him. Every part of him. The way water fills a jar pushed under.

He didn't drown.

He'd thought he'd drown. Every part of him that had been a boy in a village with a millpond had known for certain he'd drown.

He breathed it.

◆ ◆ ◆

There, said the Undertow. *There. That is better.*

He hung in the dark. Breathing the sea. Slowly. In and out. In and out. The cold of it going down into him and coming back out. Like a tide.

You kept your vow, said the sea.

Yes. He didn't speak. He didn't need to. Here, at the bottom of the world, under the sea, in the Wellworld of Tide, he only had to think it.

You broke the net that held me. The Ceiling. The stillness. You gave the Root away. You wove a new one with nothing in it that holds.

Yes.

I said I would remember. The dark moved round him. A current. Slow. Vast. Circling. *I remember. I am the sea. I remember everything that has ever fallen into me.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Something's drinking you, thought Lex.

The current stopped.

Not slowed. *Stopped*. For one terrible instant the whole dark sea round him went still. Like the bread in the bowl. Like the boy in the field. Like the snow on the hedge with the wind going past it.

Then moved again. Faster. Harder. Angry.

YES.

The word went through him like a wave breaking on rock.

At the edge, said the Undertow. *In the west. Where the grey curtain met me. Nine hundred years it hung there, down into my water, and I hated it. I hated it the way I hated your net. A wall. A thing that held.* The current circled. Faster. *And now it is gone. And behind it—*

The dark shuddered.

Stillness, said the sea. *A country of stillness. Nine hundred years without a single wave. Without a single drop of rain. Empty. Dry. The driest thing I have ever touched.* The voice went low. Very low. Like the drag of the tide

going out over a mile of shingle. *And it is drinking me, smith. At Morrow. I can feel myself going. Out. Into it. Not coming back.*

I know. I've seen it. It's drinking everything.

I am the thing that moves, said the Undertow. *I am the turning. I go out and I come back. Out and back. Twice a day since the moon was young.* The current slowed. Faltered. *And at Morrow I have gone out. And I cannot come back.*

Lex hung in the dark and didn't know what to say.

It is the worst thing, said the sea. Very quietly. *It is worse than the net. The net held me still. This takes me away.*

◆ ◆ ◆

I'm going to make a door, thought Lex.

The sea was quiet.

At the edge. Where the Veil was. Not a wall. A door. Out of every Well. All seven. He didn't know how to say it better. He was a smith. He didn't make speeches. *A door that asks. That lets the room through when someone knocks. A little. On purpose. And then closes.*

He felt the sea listening. The whole of it. Every wave on every shore.

Like a tide, said the Undertow.

Like a tide.

Out. And back.

Yes.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SEA WAS QUIET for a long time.

Then the current came round him again. Slow. Circling. Not angry now. Thoughtful. The way water circles in a pool below a fall.

You cannot command me, said the Undertow. *You know that. You are Speaking. You hear me and I hear you and we talk, like this, at the bottom of the world. That is Speaking.* A pause. *To command the tide is a different thing.*

I know.

It is not a thing you take, said the sea. *It is a thing you give. To command fire, you give it your heat. You did that. In the hearth, three years ago. You gave it yourself and it nearly kept you. To command stone, you gave it your*

patience. You sat all night on a mountain and waited. The current tightened round him. Very slightly. *What will you give the tide?*

What do you want?

I do not want, said the Undertow. *I am the sea. I take what falls in. I give it back on the shore.* The dark pressed closer. *What have you been holding, smith?*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T ANSWER.

You were holding your breath, said the sea. *When you came down. You held it and held it. I had to tell you to let go.*

Everyone holds their breath when they go under.

Not like that, said the Undertow. *Not for that long. That was not a breath for a dive.* The voice was very slow now. Very deep. Like the long low roll of a swell a thousand miles from any land. *That was a breath you have been holding since the night your father died.*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HUNG IN THE dark.

He didn't move. He couldn't. The whole sea was holding him. Gently. Absolutely. The way you'd hold a child who'd fallen and hadn't started crying yet.

I haven't—

You knelt by him, said the Undertow. *You held his hand. You did not cry. You walked down through the pool two nights later to the bottom of the world with his name in your mouth and the Key in a basket. You did not cry. You came up. You cut his name in a stone with your hands shaking. You did not cry.*

How do you—

I am the sea, said the Undertow. *Every tear that has ever been wept runs to me in the end.* A pause. *Yours have not come.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT A bed by a west window.

He hadn't thought about it. Not properly. Not once. In seven weeks. He'd thought about the grave and the lanterns and the stone and the horn

lantern on the sill and the basket under the bench. He'd thought about the King and the bread and the dead at the rim.

He hadn't thought about the bed.

He thought about it now.

His father. On three pillows. Under a boarded window, with one board off, and the evening coming in through it. Thin. So thin. White hair on the pillow. His grey eyes open. Looking at Seren. At his wife. Who remembered him. All of him. At last.

Leave a light on for me.

Too late.

And his hand. In Lex's. Thin and dry and light as paper. Tapping. Two fingers. On Lex's knuckles. The rhythm Lex had heard in the back of his head for seven years, in a dry small voice, before he knew whose it was.

Tap. Tap.

And then not.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT EMBER.

In the lantern. In the Ferryman's lantern. A gold flame. Small. Steady. Going away across the grey water in the dark, in the bow of a long grey boat, with his father sitting in the stern.

Ember hadn't looked back.

It couldn't. It didn't love him anymore. It had given that away. All of it. Every scrap of seven years. To buy his mother thirty years of memories for one hour.

It had chosen that.

I want to put that on the record, it had said. Once. In the forge. About something else. *In a footnote. Ember did not like it.*

Lex hadn't liked it either.

He'd never said so.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT FORTY-NINE mornings.

Sixty-six, now. Kneeling on the hearthstone. *Good morning*. Waiting. Half a breath.

Nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED HIS MOUTH.

The sea came in.

And something came out.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT it was at first. It didn't feel like crying. Crying was a thing you did with your face, with your eyes, with your throat. This came from lower down. From the place under his breastbone. From wherever it was he'd been holding his breath for sixty-six days.

It came up out of him like a tide coming in over a mile of flat sand. Slow at first. Then all at once. Then more. Then more than he'd known he had.

He couldn't see it. He was at the bottom of the sea in the dark. He couldn't hear it. The sea was too loud.

But he felt it go. Out of him. Into the water. Warm into the cold. Salt into the salt.

And the sea took it.

◆ ◆ ◆

There, said the Undertow.

Very softly. All round him. Like a hand on his hair.

There.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW HOW long it lasted. A minute. An hour. Long enough that when it stopped, he was hanging in the dark with his arms wrapped round himself and his forehead pressed against something he couldn't see, and he was so tired he could hardly think.

And the sea was moving round him.

Not circling. *Breathing*. In and out. In and out. The whole weight of the dark water drawing back from him and coming in again, drawing back and coming in, like a tide, like a chest rising and falling.

And he was breathing with it.

He hadn't meant to. He just was. In when it came in. Out when it drew back. In. Out. The way you fall into step with someone walking beside you without knowing you've done it.

Out, said the Undertow. *And back.*

Out, thought Lex. *And back.*

◆ ◆ ◆

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ATTUNEMENT — TIDE
SPEAKING → COMMANDING
"Out. And back."
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW IT. IN the dark. Silver-blue. Small. Hanging in the black water in front of his face where only he could see it.

He didn't feel triumphant. He didn't feel anything. He felt like a beach after the storm. Wet and flat and washed clean and very, very tired.

You gave me something, said the sea.

I didn't mean to.

Nobody means to, said the Undertow. *That is how you know it was given.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CURRENT CAME ROUND him one last time.

And something pressed into his hand.

Cold. Smooth. Round. Small enough to close his fingers over. He couldn't see it. He felt it. A shell. A spiral. Like the shells children hold up to their ears on the shingle at Saltreach to hear the sea.

But heavier. And *full*.

For your door, said the Undertow.

What is it?

The turn, said the sea. *The moment between out and back. When the tide stands at the bottom of the shore, and stops, and remembers, and begins to come in again.* The current tightened round his fingers. Gently. *It is the only stillness I have ever loved. Because it is not still. It is waiting to turn.*

He closed his hand over it.

Quench your door in that, said the Undertow. *And it will know how to open. And how to close again.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME UP.

Fast. Faster than he'd gone down. Through the black into the blue into the grey into the green. The light coming back overhead. The roar of the swell. The cold.

He broke the surface twenty yards off the shingle at Gull's Reach in the last of the dusk, and the sea came out of his lungs in a great choking gush, and the air went in, and he was coughing and gasping and floundering in the waves like a boy who'd fallen off the mill dam.

Teo got him by the collar.

Hauled him in. Through the surf. Onto the stones. And let him lie there, on his back, on the wet shingle, gasping, with the waves running up round him and drawing back, running up and drawing back.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAY THERE A long time.

Teo sat beside him. Dripping. Saying nothing.

The stars came out.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Did it—*" said Teo. At last. Shyly.

"*Yes.*"

"*What did it want*?"

Lex didn't answer for a while.

He lay on the shingle with the sea running up round him and drawing back, and the shell clenched in his right fist, and his face wet. Not with the sea. He could tell the difference now. He'd never been able to tell the difference before.

"*Nothing*," he said. "*It didn't want anything.*" He swallowed. "*It just took what I'd been carrying.*"

Teo looked at him.

Then he nodded. Slowly. As if that made perfect sense. As if that were the most ordinary thing in the world.

"*It does that*," said the Tide Speaker. "*It's the sea.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT ON THE shingle in the dark.

And far off, out past the harbour wall, out on the black water toward the edge of the world, the tide turned. Lex felt it turn. He'd never felt that before either. The whole sea, from Saltreach to the Teeth, standing for one long breath at the bottom of the shore, and stopping, and remembering—

And beginning to come back in.

He opened his hand. Looked at the shell. In the starlight. Small. Spiral. Pale. Humming, very faintly, against his palm, like a held breath about to be let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS WHEN THE bell rang.

◆ ◆ ◆

UNDER HIS SHIRT. AGAINST his breastbone. On its cord. Where it had hung for three years. Small. Silver. The kind of bell you'd tie round a goat's neck. With a clapper bent a little, crooked, so that when it rang it rang very slightly off.

Ting.

Malachi's bell. Hesper's, before that. A girl had given it to a barefoot boy on a grey shingle nine hundred years ago and said *then I'll know. Wherever I am. If you're sad.*

It rang when someone was sad.

Ting.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT UP.

He put his hand flat over it. Through his wet shirt. And felt it ringing. Not once. On and on. Soft. Steady. Off-key. Like a heartbeat with a stumble in it.

He'd heard it ring before. On the rubble of Duskhold. On the night the edge fell. In the forge, sometimes, at night, when he didn't know who it was ringing for.

He'd never felt it ring like this.

As if someone very far away, someone very big, was sitting somewhere in the dark, and couldn't stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN, FROM THE cliffs above the harbour, a sound.

A crack. Like a ship's sail filling.

A shape against the stars. Huge. Grey. With silver along the edges of its wings like frost along the edges of slate. Coming down. Fast. Over the harbour wall. Over the tower with its lantern. Onto the shingle twenty yards off in a roar of wind and a spray of stones.

Ashka.

And on her back, his long black hair loose and wild and his face white in the starlight—

"*Lex*," said Antho. "*Get on.*"

Lex was already running.

"*Who*?"

His brother looked at him. Down from the dragon's back. With the bell still ringing, ringing, off-key, under Lex's wet shirt.

"*Old Mag*," said Antho. "*Tilda sent word. She says it's her feet.*" He swallowed. "*She says she's asking for you.*"

A pause.

"*And for him*."

CHAPTER 8

Ninety-Seven Years

THE KING WAS SITTING on the step.

Lex saw him from the air. In the first grey light. As Ashka came down over the Vale and the elms and the chapel roof, over the green with its cracked Stone and its gold circle in the snow, over the row of cottages facing the pond.

Old Mag's garden. The low wall. The gate. The path. The apple tree, blooming. White on white.

And on the step—the one step, worn hollow in the middle by a hundred years of boots—a gold man. Enormous. Sitting with his back to the door and his knees drawn up and his arms wrapped round them. Like a child on a doorstep waiting to be let in.

Glowing.

The step under him was gold. The path in front of him was gold, a long bright stripe of it from the gate to the door where he'd walked it every day for two weeks. The snow round him was gold in a circle. And on the gold, scattered, white, pink at the edges—

Petals.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BELL UNDER LEX'S shirt was still ringing.

It had rung all night. All the way from the coast. Four hundred miles of dark and cold and stars, flat on Ashka's back with his brother in front of him and his wet clothes freezing to his skin, and the bell ringing the whole way. Soft. Steady. Off-key.

Ting. Ting. Ting.

He'd known who it was ringing for before they were halfway.

◆ ◆ ◆

ASHKA CAME DOWN ON the green.

The village was awake. It had been awake all night, Lex thought. Lights in every window. People in doorways. Benno at the door of the Crooked Kettle with a lantern. Nobody on the green. Nobody near the garden. They'd learned that in two weeks.

But they were watching.

Lex slid down off the dragon's back and nearly fell. His legs had gone stiff in the cold. Antho caught his arm.

"*Go*," said his brother.

"*You're not coming*?"

"*She asked for you*." Antho let go of his arm. "*And him. Not me.*" He looked across the green. At the garden. At the gold man on the step. "*I'll be here.*"

Lex went.

◆ ◆ ◆

TILDA MET HIM AT the gate.

Square-built, soot-faced, twenty years old, with Brannoc's old hammer in her belt and her gold hand tucked into her apron and her eyes red. She'd been Old Mag's neighbour all her life. She'd carried her water and split her wood and pulled her cart on Lantern Night with the brass lantern in it, *for Arion Vey, from Mag, who was ninety-six and never greedy*.

"*She's awake*," said Tilda. "*She's been awake all night. Asking for you.*" She wiped her nose on her sleeve. "*Her feet went cold on Tuesday. On her birthday. She said, that's it, then, that's the sign. And then she made me bring her a slice of cake in bed and ate the whole thing.*"

"*Ninety-seven*," said Lex.

"*She made me write it on the wall*," said Tilda. "*By the bed. In charcoal. She said she wanted to see it.*"

She looked past him. Up the path. At the gold man on the step.

"*He won't go in*," she said. Very low. "*Three days. Since her feet went. He came and sat on the step and he won't go in. She keeps calling for him. Through the door. And he keeps sitting there.*"

Lex looked at the King.

The King hadn't moved. Hadn't turned his head. He was sitting on the step with his arms round his knees and his great gold face turned up to the apple tree. To the blossom. And his eyes—

Lex could see his eyes from the gate.

He was crying.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT UP THE path.

On the gold. He didn't think about it. It was just stone now, gold stone, hard under his boots. He walked up it to the step and stopped. And stood there. In front of the biggest man in the world.

The King didn't look at him.

"*She's calling for you*," said Lex.

"*I know*."

"*Then go in*."

"*I can't*."

The bell rang. *Ting*. Under Lex's shirt. The King flinched. Lex saw it. The great gold shoulders twitching, as if at a sound only he could hear.

"*What is that*?" said the King. Hoarsely.

"*A bell*."

"*It's been ringing all night. I could hear it. Very far off. Getting closer.*" The King turned his head at last. Looked at him. The furnace eyes swimming. Gold tears on gold cheeks. Falling. Landing on his knees, on his robe, on the step. "*Why is it ringing?*"

Lex looked at him.

"*It rings when someone's sad*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING STARED AT him.

Then he laughed. Or tried to. It came out of him cracked. Broken. Like a bell dropped on stone.

"*Oh*," said the Gilded King. "*Oh, that's Hes. That's Hes's bell. Isn't it? From her belt. She dropped it in the kitchen when she was nine and bent the clapper. She used to wear it so the nurses would know where she was.*" He put his face in his hands. "*She gave it away. To that boy. In the garden. I always wondered.*"

He sat there. On the step. With his face in his hands.

"*It's been ringing for me*," he said. Through his fingers. "*Nine hundred years. And I never heard it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

FROM INSIDE THE COTTAGE, a voice.

Old. Cracked. Thin as paper. But not weak. Not yet.

"*Is that the smith*?"

"*It's me, Mag*."

"*About time. Come in. Bring the big one.*" A pause. A wheeze. "*Is he still sitting on my step like a lump?*"

Lex looked at the King.

"*Yes*," he said.

"*Tell him if he doesn't come in*," said Old Mag, "*I'll get up and come out there and he won't like it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LIFTED HIS head.

He looked at the door. Old. Oak. Grey with weather. With a latch, iron, black, that someone had mended a hundred times. Standing a little ajar. Firelight coming through the crack.

Outside the door.

"*I can't*," he said. Very quietly. To Lex. Not to the door. "*Smith. I can't. I'll touch her. I'll want to. I won't be able to help it. I'll take her hand, and she'll go gold, and she'll be kept, and she'll lie there in that bed forever with her eyes moving, and I'll have done it to her.*" His voice broke. "*She asked me not to. She made me promise. On the step. Two weeks ago. Don't you dare keep me.*"

"*Then don't*."

"*I can't help it*," said the Gilded King. "*Everything I touch. Everything. Since the pool. I can't stop it. I tried. The cup. Your mother's cup. I tried so*

hard. I held it and I thought, not this, please, not this one, I want to drink from it." He looked at his hands. *"And it went gold anyway."*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIM.

At the great gold hands. At the tears. At the cracked step and the gold path and the white petals lying on it, white, not gold.

Make room in front of it, he thought. *Before it sets.*

He'd done it on the green. In the spring. With gold dust coming down and a child in front of him, a little girl, Jenna Tull, with her hands up and the dust falling toward her face. He'd cupped his hands in front of her—not touching—and *made room*. A space. A hollow. Between the dust and the child. A place where something new could happen. And the dust had fallen into the room and not set. Just fallen. Grey. Harmless.

He'd learned it in a breath, with the seventh Well three hundred miles off answering him, frightened, small. *Speaking*.

He'd never done it for a touch.

He'd never done it for the King.

◆ ◆ ◆

"Give me your hand," said Lex.

The King looked at him.

"Not to touch," said Lex. *"Just hold it out. Like this."* He held out his own. Left. Burned. Palm up. *"Over mine. Not touching. An inch."*

"Smith—"

"Please."

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING HELD OUT his hand.

Slowly. Shaking. Enormous. Gold. Glowing like metal in a crucible. He held it out over Lex's, palm down. An inch above. Lex felt the heat of it. Not fire. Not heat like a forge. Heat like the sun on a stone at noon. Steady. Patient. *Keeping*. He could feel it reaching for him. Down. Across the inch. The gold wanting to come down and close over his skin, over his bones, over the blood moving in them, and *stop* it. Gently. Lovingly. Forever.

He didn't move his hand.

He reached for the room.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME.

From three hundred miles off. From a pool in a green circle under snow. From a young Well, frightened, small, too full already, with thousands of the dead standing round its rim. It came up through the ground under Old Mag's step and up through Lex's boots and into him and out through his hand.

[...smith...]

I need room. Just a little. Just an inch.

[...for what...]

For an old woman to hold a king's hand.

The Well was quiet.

Then—

[...oh...] said Mal. *[...oh...yes...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM OPENED.

Between Lex's palm and the King's. In the inch of air. A space. A hollow. Not empty—*waiting*. The way the inside of a mould waits. The way a cupped hand waits. The way the dark in a hearth waits for the fire.

And the gold came down into it.

He felt it come. The keeping. Reaching. Pouring down out of the King's hand like heat off a stone, toward Lex's skin, toward the blood moving in it, wanting to close over it and hold it, still, forever—

And it fell into the room.

And didn't set.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HUNG THERE. IN the inch between their hands. Lex could feel it. Gold. Warm. Patient. Hanging in the hollow like a coin dropped into a well that never reaches the bottom. Not touching him. Not able to. Because there was room in front of it. Room for something to happen. And gold doesn't set where something's going to happen.

The King stared at their hands.

"What—"

"Room," said Lex. *"In front of it. Before it sets."* He was sweating. In the cold. It was like holding a door shut against a wind. Like holding a hot bar steady on the anvil with the tongs while someone else struck. *"It can't keep what's still happening."*

"How long can you—"

"Not long." His hand was shaking. *"An hour. Maybe. If she—"* He stopped.

"If she what?"

"If she doesn't take longer than that," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT their hands for a long time.

At the inch of air between them. At the gold hanging in it, not setting.

Then he stood up.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK A WHILE. He was very big, and the step was very small, and he was very careful. He stood up into the blossom of the apple tree, so that the flowers brushed his gold hair, and stayed white. He stood with his hand held out flat in front of him, palm down, and Lex's hand under it, palm up, an inch apart, and the room between.

And he turned to the door.

And put his other hand on the latch.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT GOLD.

Of course it did. The old black mended iron. Gold. Under his fingers. Bright and smooth and cold.

He didn't look at it.

He pushed the door open.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COTTAGE WAS SMALL. One room. Low-beamed. Smoke-dark. A fire in the hearth, banked low. A table. A chair. A dresser with plates on it, blue and white, chipped. A rag rug. And in the corner by the fire, under the window, a bed.

Old Mag was in it.

Small. So small. Smaller than Lex had ever seen her. Propped on pillows. In a white nightcap and a white nightgown and three shawls, with a patchwork quilt pulled up to her chin. Her one black eye open. Bright. Like a bird's. The other closed for good under its fold of skin.

The cat was on the quilt. Biscuit. Ginger. Huge. Curled on her feet.

On the wall by the bed, in charcoal, in Tilda's big square letters:

97.

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"*Well*," said Old Mag. "*You took your time.*"

The King stood in the doorway. Bent nearly double under the low lintel. Gold. Filling the door. With the morning behind him and the blossom over his head and his hand held out flat in front of him over Lex's.

"*Mistress*," he said.

"*Don't you Mistress me*," said Old Mag. "*I've told you.*" The black eye moved. To their hands. To the inch of air between them. Narrowed. "*What's that?*"

"*Room*," said Lex.

"*Room for what*?"

"*For him to hold your hand*," said Lex. "*Without keeping you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

OLD MAG LOOKED AT their hands for a long time.

Then she looked at the King.

"*Is that so*," she said.

"*I think so*," said the King. His voice was shaking. "*I don't know. The smith says. I've never—I've never held anyone's hand. Not since the pool. Not without—*" He stopped.

"*Well, don't stand in the door*," said Old Mag. "*You're letting the warm out. Come and sit.*" She jerked her chin at the chair. By the bed. Low. Rush-seated. With a cushion on it. "*That chair. Mind the cat.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME IN.

It took a long time. He had to bend so far his head was nearly at his knees. He had to turn sideways to get between the table and the dresser. Lex went with him, step by step, backward, with his hand held up under the King's and the room between them, sweating, shaking, holding.

The floor went gold where the King stepped. The rag rug. The flags. A leg of the table, where his robe brushed it.

He reached the chair.

He looked at it. Low. Small. Rush-seated. Built for an old woman.

He didn't sit in it. He'd have broken it. He knelt. On the floor. Beside the bed. The way he'd knelt on the floor of Lex's mother's cottage in the autumn, with his hand out to a baby.

The flags went gold under his knees.

He knelt beside the bed and looked at Old Mag.

And she looked at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Now*," said Old Mag. "*Give it here.*"

She took her hand out from under the quilt.

Old. Knotted. Brown-spotted. Thin as a bundle of twigs. With a wedding ring on it, gold, worn so thin it was nearly a thread, that had been on that finger for seventy-five years.

She held it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT it.

He looked at it the way Lex had seen men look at a sword they'd been told to fall on. The way his father had looked at the black door at the bottom of the Hollowmaw, the first night, with his wife behind it.

"*Smith*," he said.

"*I've got it*," said Lex.

He didn't know if he had it. He didn't know anything. He knelt beside the King on the gold flags with his hand under the King's hand and the room in the inch between them, and Mal's voice faint and far in the back of him, *[...yes...yes...]*, and he moved.

He turned his hand. Slowly. Palm up still. And slid it under Old Mag's. So his palm was under hers. Under her knotted old fingers. Holding them up. Like a tray.

And the King's hand came down.

Over hers. An inch above. With the room between.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CLOSED IT.

◆ ◆ ◆

SLOWLY. SO SLOWLY. THE great gold fingers coming down round the old brown ones. Curling. Closing. Lex felt them come. Felt the gold reaching. Felt the keeping pouring down out of the King's palm like heat off a stone at noon, toward the old woman's skin, toward her thin slow blood, wanting to close over it and *hold it*—

And he held the room.

He held it the way he'd held the hammer at the Heart. With everything. With his whole body. With the seventh Well coming up through the floor of the cottage from three hundred miles off and pouring through him, *[...yes...room...here...]*, into the inch, into the hollow, into the space between a king's hand and an old woman's, so that the gold fell into it, and fell, and fell, and never reached the bottom.

The King's fingers closed.

Round hers.

Touching.

◆ ◆ ◆

OLD MAG'S HAND STAYED brown.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY BREATHED.

Not Lex. Not the King. Not Tilda, in the doorway, with her gold hand over her mouth.

Old Mag looked down at her hand. In the King's. At the gold fingers wrapped round her brown ones. Huge. Gentle. Holding. At her own skin, wrinkled and spotted and brown and alive, showing between the gold.

She looked at it for a long time.

"*Well*," she said. "*There.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING MADE A sound.

Lex had never heard a sound like it. Not from a man. Not from anything. It came up out of the great gold chest like something breaking. Like ice breaking on a river in spring. Like a bell cracking all the way through.

He put his head down. On the quilt. Beside their hands. And wept.

Not quietly. Not the gold tears on the step. *Wept*. The whole of him. Shaking. His great shoulders heaving. His face pressed into the patchwork. His hand still closed round hers—gently, so gently—and not letting go.

Old Mag let him.

She put her other hand on his head. On the gold hair. Lex saw it. Her old free hand, the one Lex wasn't holding, coming up off the quilt and settling on the King's bowed head.

It went gold.

Lex saw it happen. Saw the gold come up into her fingers from his hair. Up to the first knuckle. The second.

She didn't take it away.

"*Doesn't matter*," said Old Mag. Softly. Looking at her gold fingers in his gold hair. "*Doesn't matter, dear. It's only the one hand. I'll not be needing it.*"

And stroked his hair.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WEPT FOR A long time.

Lex knelt beside him and held the room. His arm was shaking. His back was screaming. Sweat ran into his eyes. He didn't care. He held it.

Biscuit the cat got up off the old woman's feet. Stretched. Walked up the quilt. Looked at the King's bowed gold head. Sniffed it.

Lay down against it. Purring.

The cat's fur stayed ginger.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Tell me*," said the King. At last. Into the quilt. Muffled. "*Tell me what it means. Please. I've asked everyone. I don't understand.*"

"*What what means, dear*?"

"*Finished*." He lifted his head. His face was a ruin. Gold. Wet. "*You said you didn't want to be kept. You wanted to be finished. You said there's a difference.*"

Old Mag looked at him.

"*There is*," she said.

"*What is it*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE THOUGHT ABOUT IT. Lex watched her think. Her one black eye going to the window, to the apple tree, to the blossom in the snow. To the wall by the bed. *97*.

"*A cake*," said Old Mag.

The King stared at her.

"*You make a cake*," she said. "*You put it in the oven. You wait. You take it out when it's done. And it's done. It's finished. It's a cake.*" She looked at him. "*You don't leave it in. Forever. Because you love it. Because you can't bear for it to be done. You'd burn it. Or you'd have a cake that was never a cake. Just an oven with something in it, waiting.*"

The King said nothing.

"*Kept's the oven*," said Old Mag. "*Finished is the cake.*" She squeezed his hand. Very weakly. Lex felt it through the room. "*I'm the cake, dear. I'm done. Ninety-seven years. Husband. Daughters. Boy at sea. This cottage. That tree. Eleven cats.*" A pause. "*Twelve. Biscuit's twelve. Don't tell him.*"

"*But you'll be gone*," said the Gilded King.

"*Yes*."

"*Forever*."

"*Yes*," said Old Mag. "*That's the point, dear. That's what finished means.*" She looked at the ring on her finger. Worn to a thread. "*If I went on forever I'd never get to see my boy and tell him off. Or my Will. Or my mother. I'd lie here forever with my feet cold.*" She shook her head on the pillow. "*No. I've had my share. I want to go and see them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT her for a long, long time.

Then he looked down. At their hands. At the gold round the brown. At the room between them that Lex was holding, shaking.

"*I stood outside his door*," he said. Very quietly. "*My father. Every night. For a month. With my hand on the latch.*"

"*I know*," said Old Mag. "*Your steward told me. In my kitchen. Before he bowed.*"

"*Cad went in. He was eleven. He held Father's hand. Every night. Not saying anything.*" The King's voice was barely a whisper. "*And I stood outside the door. I couldn't. I couldn't watch it. I couldn't watch him be finished.*"

"*And what happened?*"

"*He was finished anyway.*"

"*There you are*," said Old Mag. "*It happens anyway. Whether you go in or not.*" She squeezed his hand again. Weaker. "*Only if you go in, someone's holding your hand when it does.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT AT NOON.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T SUDDEN. IT wasn't anything. She talked for a while. About her husband, Will, who'd been a thatcher and fallen off a roof. About her daughters. About the tree. She asked Tilda for a sip of water, and Tilda gave it to her, holding the cup to her lips with her good hand. She asked for the cat to be given to the Pruett boy with the cut hand, because he'd like something to hold. She said the tree was Lex's.

"*Yours*," she said. Looking at him. At last. Her one black eye. "*The tree. When I'm gone. It's no good to Tilda, she's got a forge to run. And it won't give apples.*" A wheeze. "*Make something with it. Something that matters.*"

"*I will.*"

"*Promise?*"

"*I promise.*"

"*Good lad*," said Old Mag. "*You always were. Even when you were a sulky little thing with your hair in your eyes.*" She closed her eye. "*Tell Brannoc he still owes me for the pie dish.*"

Then she was quiet for a while.

Then she opened her eye one more time. And looked at the King. Kneeling by her bed. With his great gold hand round hers.

"*There*," she said. "*See? Not so bad.*"

And she breathed out.

And didn't breathe in.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS VERY QUIET in the cottage.

The fire ticked. The cat purred, against the King's bowed head. Outside, in the garden, the wind moved in the apple tree, and a few petals came down past the window. White. Pink at the edges.

Old Mag lay on her pillows. Small. Still. Her one black eye closed now too. Her mouth a little open. Her hand in the King's.

Brown.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LET GO OF the room.

He didn't decide to. It just went out of him. All at once. The way breath goes out of you when you've been holding it too long. His arm dropped. His whole body sagged. He knelt on the gold floor beside the bed and couldn't hold himself up and put his head down on the edge of the mattress and breathed.

The King didn't let go.

He knelt beside the bed with Old Mag's hand in his. And looked at it. And Lex lifted his head and saw it too.

The gold reaching. Now. With the room gone. Out of the King's fingers. Toward her skin. Toward the old brown hand, still and cooling.

And not setting.

It slid over her skin like water over glass. And didn't take. Didn't hold. Didn't keep. Because there was nothing to keep. She was finished. Done. There was nothing in that hand anymore that the gold could stop.

The King saw it.

He looked at it for a long, long time.

Then, very gently, he opened his fingers. And laid her hand on the quilt. And took his away.

Her hand lay on the patchwork. Brown. Old. Knotted. Still. With the thin gold ring on it.

Finished.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT THERE.

Lex didn't know for how long. He knelt beside him. Tilda stood in the doorway with her gold hand over her mouth and tears running down her face. The fire ticked.

And then it got cold.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE FIRE. THE fire burned. But the cold came in under it. Through the door. Through the window. A grey cold. A river cold. The cold of a long grey shingle in the dark, with water lapping on it, and a smell of wet stone.

Lex knew it.

He'd felt it in the autumn. In a cottage with a blue door. Two nights before Lantern Night. With his father's hand going slack in his.

He looked up.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN WAS STANDING at the foot of the bed.

◆ ◆ ◆

TALL. GREY. HOODED. TALLER than the King, almost, though the King was kneeling. A long grey robe that moved, always moved, the way water moves at the edge of a river. A face you couldn't quite see under the hood. Long grey hands.

And in one of them, a lantern.

Old. Iron. Plain. With four panes of clear glass. The kind of lantern you'd hang on a hook by a ferry-stage to see who was waiting on the other side.

It was lit.

A flame burned in it. Small. Gold. Steady. Warm. Not the colour of a candle-flame or a lamp-flame. The colour of an ember. The colour of

something that had been pressed into a sleeping boy's blood twenty-two years ago, like a maker's mark into a horseshoe.

Lex stopped breathing.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN LOOKED AT Old Mag.

He bent. Slowly. The grey robe flowing. And held out his long grey hand over the bed. Not touching. Waiting.

And something rose out of her.

Lex couldn't have said what. Not a light. Not a shape. A *lightness*. The way a room goes lighter when someone opens a window. The way the air changes when the last guest goes home. It rose out of the small still shape on the pillows and stood for a moment by the bed—Lex thought, for a moment, he saw a woman there, small and bent and fierce, with two eyes, both bright, black as a bird's—and looked down at the King.

And at Lex.

And grinned. Three teeth.

And put her hand in the Ferryman's.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN STRAIGHTENED.

He looked at the King. Kneeling. Gold. Enormous. Wet-faced. With his empty hands on his knees.

The King looked back.

"*Not you*," said the Ferryman. His voice was like water running over stones in the dark. Very quiet. Very old. "*Still not you.*"

"*I know*," said the King.

The Ferryman looked at him a moment longer.

"*You held her hand*," he said.

"*Yes.*"

"*You did not keep her.*"

"*No*," said the Gilded King. "*She asked me not to.*"

The Ferryman was silent.

Then—so slightly that Lex nearly missed it—he inclined his hooded head. Toward the King. The way you'd nod to someone across a room. The way a man nods to another man who has done something hard.

"*I noticed*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED TO GO.

And the lantern in his hand swung as he turned, and the light from it fell across the bed and across Lex, kneeling, with his head up and his eyes on it.

And the flame in the lantern turned too.

Toward him.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS SMALL. GOLD. Steady. A flame on nothing. The way unlatticed fire burns, that nobody ever taught to need a wick.

It looked at him.

He knew it was looking at him. The way you know someone in a crowd is looking at you. He knelt on the gold floor of an old woman's cottage with sweat drying on his face and his arm still shaking and looked back at it. And couldn't speak. And couldn't move.

Ember, he thought.

He didn't say it. He couldn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE FLAME SPOKE.

Not in his head. Not anymore. Out loud. In the cottage. A small dry voice, precise, gentle, with an old-fashioned courtesy, that came out of the lantern the way the warmth came off it. A voice he'd heard every day for seven years in the back of his skull, and hadn't heard for sixty-seven days.

[Good afternoon,] said the flame in the Ferryman's lantern.

It paused. Politely.

[I'm so sorry,] it said. *[Have we met?]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T ANSWER.

He couldn't.

He knelt on the floor and looked at it and didn't answer at all.

[You look very tired,] said the flame. Kindly. The way you'd say it to a stranger at an inn. *[I hope you'll get some rest.]*

And the Ferryman went out of the door into the garden, with an old woman's hand in one of his and the lantern in the other, and the cold went with him, and the grey, and the smell of wet stone.

And the light went down the gold path under the apple tree, and through the gate, and was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE TICKED.

The cat got up. Off the bed. Stretched. Walked across the gold floor and sat down in front of the hearth and began, very carefully, to wash its face.

Tilda was crying in the doorway.

The King knelt by the bed with his empty hands on his knees.

And Lex knelt beside him. On the gold floor. With his face in his hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

AFTER A LONG TIME the King spoke.

"*Smith*," he said.

Lex didn't look up.

"*That flame*," said the Gilded King. Very quietly. "*In his lantern. It knew you.*"

"*No*," said Lex. Into his hands. "*It didn't.*"

The King was silent.

Then—slowly, carefully, the way he did everything now—he lifted one great gold hand. And held it out. Not touching. An inch from Lex's bowed shoulder. Hanging there. In the air. Shaking.

He didn't put it down.

He just held it there. An inch away. For a long time.

Not keeping anything.

CHAPTER 9

Tea for Two

THEY BURIED OLD MAG on a Thursday, in the churchyard at Ashbourne, under the yew, beside a thatcher called Will who had fallen off a roof at sixty and lived another twenty years out of spite.

Seren stood at the back.

She liked the back. She'd always liked it. Harrow women stood at the back of things, by the door, where they could leave if the moths came. Her mother had stood at the back of every funeral and wedding and christening in every village they ever lived in, with Seren's hand in hers, and never once sat down.

So Seren stood at the back. By the lychgate. In her grey shawl. With the snow coming down soft and slow and the whole of Ashbourne in front of her, black-coated, hatless, round the grave.

Sister Agathe read the words. Ninety-three, now, and bent like a shepherd's crook, with a voice that still carried to the back of any room she'd ever stood in. *Earth to earth. Dust to dust. Into the Lady's keeping, with a light left on.*

Tilda threw the first handful. With her good hand. She was crying so hard she couldn't see where it went.

The Pruett boy stood at the front with his bandaged hand and a ginger cat the size of a small dog clutched to his chest. The cat looked furious. The boy looked as though he'd been given the moon.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND AT THE BACK of the churchyard, on the far side, under the bare black elms by the wall—

The King.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY HAD ASKED HIM. Nobody had told him not to come. He'd just come. Up the lane from the green, very slowly, very carefully, in the snow. And stopped at the churchyard wall. And stood there. Outside it. Behind the elms. As far from the grave as he could get and still see it.

The snow round his feet was gold.

He didn't come in. He didn't come closer. He stood by the wall with his great hands folded in front of him, holding a lopsided gold cup, and watched them lower an old woman into the ground.

Nobody looked at him.

Everybody knew he was there.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WATCHED HIM OVER the heads of the mourners.

She'd been watching him for a year, on and off. Since he came out of the crack in the Veil and walked east across the world. Since he followed her daughter-in-law round the high country for eighty-six days with his hand out. Since he knocked on her blue door in the autumn and sat on her floor and drank tea he couldn't drink.

Since he knelt on the gold flags beside her husband's bed and watched him die.

She'd hated him. She remembered that. She remembered it the way you remember a fever. A great hot red hate, the first night, with the gold coming up through the floor of her cottage from his knees and Lark on the rug and Arion in the bed. *Get out. Get out of my house.*

He hadn't got out.

He'd sat on her floor with her cup in his hands and told her about his father. And she'd listened. Because she couldn't not.

And then he'd stayed.

He'd stayed two nights. He'd stayed while Arion died. He'd knelt by the bed and not touched anything and not said anything and watched it, the whole of it, from the first slow breath to the last. And when the

Ferryman came, he'd stood up and backed into the corner like a child caught somewhere it shouldn't be.

Not you, the Ferryman had said. *Your punishment. Not mine.*

She didn't hate him anymore.

She didn't know what she felt instead.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED HOME AFTERWARD. Alone. Up the Vale road in the snow, and through the birch wood, along the gold path.

It was still there. The King's footprints from the autumn. A step wide. Wandering. From the Ashbourne road up through the birches to her door. Every step gold. The snow lay on them and they showed through, glowing faintly, like coals under ash.

The children used it as a slide.

She didn't mind. She liked hearing them. Shrieking. On the gold. In the snow. Hollis Penn's three, and the Tull girl, and the miller's boys, on sacks, flying down the path between the white birch trunks with their scarves out behind them.

They'd gone home now. It was getting dark.

She walked up the gold path alone.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS AT THE grave.

Not Mag's. Arion's. By the stream. Kneeling in the snow with his back to her. By the grey stone. With the twenty lanterns round him and the soft black turnip and the one red rose.

He didn't hear her come.

She stopped on the stepping stones and looked at him.

At her son. Kneeling. In his forge clothes, with snow on his shoulders. Broad-backed. Burned. Twenty-six. The baby she'd carried in a basket at the first Midwinter, while Arion fell in a drift digging them out. The boy who'd been eleven when she went into the dark, and twenty-four when she came out, with his father's eyes and a handprint on his face.

He'd come back from the coast four days ago on a dragon in the dawn with the bell ringing. He'd gone straight to Mag's. He'd knelt on her gold

floor for an hour and held the room open with his bare hand so a king could hold an old woman's.

And then he'd come home.

And he hadn't said a word about what happened after.

She knew anyway. Tilda had told Wren, and Wren had told her, in a whisper, on the ramp, with her face white.

It asked him if they'd met.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME DOWN OFF the stepping stones and stood beside him.

He didn't look up.

She knelt. In the snow. Beside him. With her knees cracking—fifty-one, and thirteen years in the dark, and her knees knew it. And looked at the stone.

ARION VEY.

He turned back twice.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It was kind*," said Lex. After a long time. Very low. "*That's the thing. It was kind.*"

She waited.

"*It said, you look very tired. It said, I hope you'll get some rest.*" He was looking at the stone. "*The way you'd say it to someone at an inn. Someone you'd never see again.*" He swallowed. "*It was so polite, Mam.*"

"*It always was.*"

"*It was polite to me the first day. In the forge. Seven years ago.*" A breath. A shake. "*Good evening, Smith. Please do not die. I have only just arrived.*" His voice cracked on it. "*It called me Smith for a month. It didn't call me Lex till—*"

He stopped.

Seren didn't say anything.

She put her hand on his back. Between his shoulders. Flat. The way she used to put it there when he was small and couldn't sleep and she'd sit by the bed and hum. And left it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I didn't know him*," she said.

Lex went still under her hand.

"*Your father*," said Seren Harrow. "*For a year and a half. I didn't know him.*" She looked at the stone. "*I came out of the dark past eleven hundred lanterns, and there was an old man in a chair, and I said you have a nice voice. And he said thank you. And I didn't know him.*"

"*I know, Mam*."

"*You don't*," she said. "*Not this part. You weren't there for this part.*" She took a breath. "*Every morning. Every morning for a year and a half, he said good morning. To me. Across the table. Across the room. From the chair. From the bed, at the end.*" She looked down at her hands. "*Good morning, Seren. And I said good morning back. Because it was polite. Because that's what you say to an old man you're living with, whom you like, whom you're beginning to—*"

She stopped.

"*And every morning*," she said, "*he looked at me like I was the sun coming up. And every morning I didn't know why.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED HIS HEAD.

He looked at her. Grey eyes. Arion's eyes. Wet.

"*How did he—*" He stopped. Started again. "*How did he stand it?*"

"*I don't know*," said Seren. "*I asked him. At the end. When I remembered. I said, how did you stand it, all those mornings, saying good morning to a woman who didn't know you.*"

"*What did he say?*"

Seren smiled. It hurt.

"*He said, I didn't need you to know me*," she said. "*I needed you to have a good morning.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HER for a long time.

Then he put his face in his hands.

She didn't take her hand away from his back. She knelt beside him in the snow by the grave of the man they'd both loved, with the twenty

lanterns round them and the stream running black under the ice, and let him.

It was getting dark.

Across the stream, in the window of the blue-door cottage, a horn lantern glowed. Soft. Gold. Blurred. With two words in the base.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING CAME AT dusk.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HEARD HIM BEFORE she saw him. Not footsteps. He made no sound in the snow. She heard the *children*. Very faint. Down at the bottom of the birch wood, where the gold path started at the Ashbourne road.

Shrieking.

Not frightened. *Delighted*. The way they shrieked on the slide.

She went to the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS COMING UP the gold path.

Slowly. Carefully. Putting each great foot down in his own footprints from the autumn, exactly, so the gold didn't spread. Gold. Glowing. Taller than the birches, nearly. With the cup in his hand and his head bowed under the branches.

And behind him, at a respectful distance—ten yards, twenty—

Children.

Hollis Penn's three. The Tull girl. The miller's boys. On their sacks. Not sliding. *Following*. Walking up the gold path behind the Gilded King in a straggling line, like ducklings behind a goose, whispering, giggling, shoving each other, daring each other to get closer.

The King didn't look round.

But Seren saw his face as he came up through the last of the birches, into the yard, into the light from her door.

He was smiling.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED AT THE foot of her ramp.

The children stopped too. At the edge of the trees. In a clump. Staring.

"*Mistress Harrow*," said the King.

"*You'll frighten them*," said Seren.

The King looked back over his shoulder. At the children. Who scattered like starlings. Shrieking. Then stopped, ten yards further off, and crept back.

"*They're not frightened*," said the King. "*They followed me from the green. They've followed me every day for two weeks. They ask me things.*" He looked down at her. Furnace eyes. Dimmed. Tired. "*They asked if I could make their snowmen gold. I said I'd rather not. They said why. I didn't know what to tell them.*"

"*What did you tell them*?"

"*That gold snowmen never melt*," said the King. "*And that they'd want to build a new one next winter.*" He paused. "*They seemed to think that was a good reason.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT HIM for a long time.

Then she stepped back from the door.

"*Come in*," said Seren Harrow. "*The floor's already gold in the middle. You might as well.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME IN THE way he'd come in the autumn. Bent double. Sideways through the door. Very slow. And knelt. On the flags. In the same place. Where the gold was already. A circle of it. In the middle of her floor. Where he'd knelt beside the bed and watched her husband die.

The bed was gone now. Brannoc had taken it, the week after. Carried it out to the lean-to with the boards from the windows. She hadn't asked him to. She'd come back from the grave one morning and it was gone, and the place where it had been was swept, and there was a rag rug on it.

The King looked at the rug.

He didn't say anything.

She put the kettle on.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE MADE TEA.

The good kind. In the tin. Warm the pot. One spoon each and one for the pot. Water just off the boil. Not on it. Never on it. *You'll scald the leaf, Seren. It's not a horseshoe.*

She'd made it that way for thirty years without knowing why. Her hands had known. Her hands had remembered him when she didn't.

She poured two cups.

One for her. Blue. Chipped. Her own.

And one for him.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D THOUGHT ABOUT IT. On the walk home from the churchyard. What to give him. He couldn't hold a cup without it going gold. He couldn't drink from a gold cup. The gold one he already had—her lopsided white one, Brannoc's wrong handle, her thumb—he carried everywhere, and couldn't put down, and couldn't drink from, because the tea in it was gold too. A gold disc. Forever.

So she took a cup off the dresser. Plain. White. Cheap. One of a set of six from the Ashbourne market. And filled it. And didn't hand it to him.

She set it on the floor. In front of him. At the edge of the gold. Just outside. On the bare flags.

And sat down in her chair by the west window. Under the horn lantern. With her own cup.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT the cup on the floor.

Steam rose off it. Thin. White. Curling up into the firelight.

"*I can't drink it*," he said.

"*I know*."

"*If I pick it up—*"

"*Don't pick it up*," said Seren. "*Leave it there. It's yours. You can look at it.*"

He looked at it.

The steam rose. The tea in it trembled very slightly when the fire popped. The light from the hearth lay on its surface, red-gold, moving.

The King watched it.

He watched it for a long time. Kneeling on her floor. With his own gold cup held in his great hands on his knees, and its gold disc of tea that never moved, never steamed, never trembled, never cooled.

"*It's moving*," he said. Very quietly.

"*It's tea*."

"*It's moving*," said the Gilded King. "*The steam. The top of it. When the fire moves.*" He swallowed. "*Mine doesn't.*"

"*No*," said Seren. "*Yours doesn't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT.

She drank her tea. He watched his. The fire ticked. Outside, faint, the children giving up at last and going home down the gold path, their voices fading into the dark of the birch wood.

"*I held her hand*," said the King.

"*I know. Tilda told Wren.*"

"*Your son held the room. Between us. So I wouldn't keep her.*" He looked at his own hand. "*For an hour. I could feel it shaking. His hand. Under mine.*" A pause. "*He didn't let go.*"

"*He wouldn't*," said Seren. "*He never does.*"

"*She went*," said the King. "*At noon. Just like that. She said, there, see, not so bad. And breathed out.*" He was looking at the steam. "*And I held her hand while she did it. And the gold tried to take her after, when your son let go of the room. And it couldn't. Because there wasn't anything left to keep.*"

He looked up.

"*She was finished*," he said. "*Like a cake.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T LAUGH.

She wanted to. It was so absurd. A gold king on her floor at dusk, saying *like a cake* with tears in his furnace eyes.

She didn't.

"*Mag said that*?"

"*Kept's the oven*," said the King. "*Finished is the cake.*" He looked down at the gold cup in his hands. "*I've been thinking about it for four days.*

Walking up and down the green. The children asking me why I'm sad." A pause. "*I told them about the cake. They didn't understand either."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Arion asked about you*," said Seren.

The King looked up.

"*At the end*," she said. "*The last night. When you'd gone into the corner. When the Ferryman—*" She stopped. Started again. "*He asked me to tell you something. Afterward. If you came back."*

The King didn't move.

"*He said*," said Seren slowly, "*tell him it's all right that he stood outside the door. Tell him everyone does, the first time. Tell him I did. Two hundred years. I stood outside every door I ever came to."* She looked at the horn lantern on the sill beside her. "*He said, tell him the second time is easier."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WAS VERY still.

He knelt on her floor in his circle of gold, with the white cup steaming in front of him and the gold cup still in his hands, and didn't move at all.

"*The second time*," he said.

"*That's what he said*."

"*I've only been in once*," said the Gilded King. "*Four days ago. With your son holding the room."* He looked at his hand. "*And I couldn't have, without him. I'd still be on the step."*

"*That counts*."

"*Does it*?"

"*Everything counts*," said Seren Harrow. "*That's the thing nobody tells you."*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SANG TO HIM.

She hadn't meant to. She'd never sung it for anyone but Arion. Not once. Not in thirty years. Not in twenty generations of Harrow women, if her mother was to be believed, had anyone sung it outside the family.

But it was dark. And the fire was low. And there was a king on her floor watching a cup of tea steam as if it were the most beautiful thing in the world.

So she sang it.

Quietly. The way her mother had sung it. The last night of summer. With the cottage half-packed.

Gold for the eldest, who feared to grow old, Glass for the vain one, who loved to be told, Iron for the soldier who never once laughed, Thorns for the gardener who listened—and drank.

She stopped there. Where it broke. Where it always broke.

The King had lifted his head.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*That's us*," he said.

"*That's you*."

"*Gold for the eldest*." He said it slowly. Wondering. "*Who feared to grow old.*" He looked at his hands. "*That's not right. I wasn't afraid of getting old. I was afraid of—*" He stopped.

"*Of what*?"

"*Of watching*," said the King. "*Of watching everyone else get old. And go.*" He looked at the white cup. "*I'd watched Father. Or I hadn't. I'd stood outside the door. And I thought, if I drink, I'll never have to go through that. Not for me. Not for anyone. I'll keep them all.*"

"*So the song's wrong*."

"*The song's nearly right*," said the Gilded King. "*Songs usually are.*"

He looked at the fire.

"*Glass for the vain one*," he said. "*That's Ysy. Who loved to be told.*" He almost smiled. "*She did. She loved it. She was the prettiest of us and she knew it, and she used to make us tell her. Every morning. In the nursery. At the long mirror. Am I pretty, Oz? Am I the prettiest? Tell me.*" The smile went. "*She was nineteen. At the pool.*"

"*And now*?"

"*Now she can't see herself*," said the King.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN PUT HER CUP down.

"*What*?"

"*In the mirror*," said the King. "*After the pool. We all went in together. To the long hall. To look at ourselves. Deathless.*" His voice was very quiet. "*And she wasn't there. In the glass. We were all there, arm in arm, and she was in the middle, and the glass showed the wall behind her.*"

Seren stared at him.

"*Nine hundred years*," said the King. "*She's never seen her own face. Not once. Not in any glass, any water, any polished thing. She's spent nine hundred years learning everything there is to know about glass, so she could find out where it went.*" He looked at the white cup. At the steam. At the firelight moving on the surface of the tea. "*She never found it.*"

"*Nobody knows*," said Seren slowly.

"*I know*," said the King. "*I was standing next to her. She made me promise never to tell.*" He looked up. "*I've just told you. I don't know why.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN SAT VERY STILL.

Glass for the vain one, who loved to be told.

She thought of a face in a bathwater. *Hello, Mistwalker*. She thought of the Glass Queen in every window in Caldor, at night, reaching out, showing people their own faces. Their true faces. Whether they wanted to see or not.

Why don't you cry? she'd said to Wren. *It's a true question. I want to know.*

She thought of a woman who'd spent nine hundred years looking out of every pane in the world and never once seeing herself.

"*Oh*," said Seren Harrow. Quietly. "*Oh, the poor thing.*"

The King looked at her.

"*Nobody's ever said that*," he said. "*About Ysy.*"

"*Nobody's ever known*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FINISHED THE SONG.

The last two lines. Quietly.

Silver for the moth, who went toward the light, And nothing, nothing, for the tenth, who stood in the door all night.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING CLOSED HIS eyes.

"*She did*," he said.

"*Did what*?"

"*Stood in the door*," said the Gilded King. "*All night. Hes.*" He opened his eyes. "*After the pool. After she poured hers back. We went inside, the nine of us, laughing, to the long hall, to look in the mirror. And she didn't come in. She stood in the garden door. In the dark. All night.*" He swallowed. "*I asked her why. In the morning. When she was leaving. I said, why did you stand there, Hes, all night, in the cold?*"

"*What did she say*?"

"*She said, in case one of you wanted to come out*," said the King.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE POPPED. A log settled. Sparks went up the chimney.

On the floor, in front of the King, the white cup steamed. Less now. Cooling. The surface of the tea trembling when the log fell.

"*Nobody did*," said the King. "*Nobody came out. Not one of us. We were in the long hall, looking at ourselves, being deathless.*" He looked at his hands. "*And she stood in the door till morning. And then she left. With her crown in a bundle. And we never saw her again.*"

"*She left the door open*," said Seren.

"*She left it open*," said the Gilded King. "*Nine hundred years.*" He looked at the white cup. "*I never went through.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT FOR A long time after that.

Neither of them said anything. Seren finished her tea. The white cup on the floor stopped steaming. The King watched it stop. Watched the last thread of steam thin and thin and go out, like a candle snuffed. Watched the surface of the tea go still, cold, dark.

"*It's stopped*," he said.

"*It's gone cold*."

"*Is that the same as kept*?"

"*No*," said Seren. "*Cold tea's finished. You make a new pot.*"

The King looked at her.

Then he laughed. Quietly. The cracked bell. Not quite broken. "*You're all the same*," he said. "*All of you. The old woman. Your husband. You.*" He shook his great head. "*Everything's a cake. Everything's a pot of tea.*"

"*Most things are*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT UP TO make a new pot.

And as she passed him, on the way to the hearth, she saw the gold cup.

In his hands. On his knees. Small. Lopsided. Too thick. Brannoc's wrong handle. Her own thumb-print in the rim. Gold, all of it, glowing in the firelight.

And the tea in it. A gold disc. Flat. Still. Polished.

Like a mirror.

She stopped.

The King saw her stop. Saw where she was looking. His great hands closed round the cup. Very slightly. The way a child closes its hands round something it's been told not to have.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She came last night*," he said.

Seren didn't move.

"*Ysy*," said the King. "*In the cup.*" He looked down at it. At the gold disc. "*I didn't know she could. It's gold. It's not glass. It's not water.*" His voice was very low. "*But it's still. And it's flat. And it shines. And I was sitting on the green in the dark looking into it, and she was there.*"

"*What did she want*?"

The King didn't answer.

"*What did she want*?" said Seren again.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's found it*," said the King. "*The crown in the road. The thing Cad went down the thread for. The middle of your net. Where the smith let go.*" He swallowed. "*She's found the way to it. Through the Stones. She says the Stones are glass all the way down.*"

Seren's hands had gone cold.

"*She says it's a mirror*," said the King. "*The net. The biggest mirror in the world. Held up to everyone.*" He looked at the cup. "*She says if she held it, she could make it keep everyone. Not just my household. Everyone. Every thread. Forever. Nobody would ever have to go through the door again. Not old women. Not old men. Not husbands in beds by windows.*"

He looked up at Seren.

"*She says nobody would ever have to be finished*," said the Gilded King. "*Ever.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN STOOD IN THE middle of her floor with the empty pot in her hands.

"*And what does she need*," she said. Very quietly. "*To hold it.*"

The King looked at her.

He didn't say anything. He didn't need to. She saw it in his face. She saw him look past her. At the door. At the dark outside. At the stream, and the stepping stones, and the cottage on the other side of the water with the HERE lantern in its east window, and a cradle in the loft with KNIT on the rockers.

"*A Vey hand*," said Seren.

"*A small one*," said the King.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POT SLIPPED.

It didn't break. It fell on the rag rug and rolled and stopped against the leg of the table. Seren didn't pick it up. She stood over the King on his gold circle with her hands empty and her heart going.

"*She asked you*," she said.

"*Yes*."

"*To bring her the child*."

"*Yes*."

"*And what did you say*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED DOWN at the gold cup in his hands.

At the flat bright disc of tea in it. Still. Polished. Showing the firelight. Showing the beams of the ceiling. Showing his own great gold face, looking down.

Showing nothing else. Not now.

"*Nothing*," he said.

Seren stared at him.

"*I didn't say anything*," said the Gilded King. "*I sat on the green in the dark with her face in the cup, and she told me. Everyone. Forever. No more doors. And I thought of the old woman. And your husband. And Father.*" His voice cracked. "*And I didn't say yes.*"

He looked up at her. The furnace eyes wet.

"*But I didn't say no*," he said.

CHAPTER 10

THE FIRST BREATH

"*There's no glass in the sky*," said Wren.

They were in the kitchen at Harrow. At midnight. With every shutter closed over every horn window and a lid on the water barrel and a cloth over the milk jug and Lark asleep in the cradle in the loft with Kestrel sitting on the ladder beside her, cross-legged, with a little flame in her palm, watching the dark.

Lex looked at her.

"*There's no water in the sky*," said Wren. "*Not still water. Not anything flat or bright or polished. Not up there. Not in a storm.*" She put her hands flat on the table. Her right one. And her left, with its three gold fingers. "*There's nowhere she can look out of. Nowhere she can reach through.*"

"*You want to take her into a storm*."

"*I want to take her where the Glass Queen can't*," said Wren. "*And you need Gale. And I know the way.*"

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IT HAD BEEN THREE days since Seren came across the stepping stones in the dark.

Without a lantern. Without her shawl. Barefoot, in the snow, with her hair coming down and her face like chalk. She'd hammered on the door with both fists. And when Lex opened it, she'd pushed past him and gone straight up the ladder to the loft and stood over the cradle, looking down, breathing, for a long time, until she was sure.

Then she'd come down and told them.

A Vey hand. A small one.

I didn't say yes. But I didn't say no.

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LEX HAD GONE TO the green that night. To find the King.

The King was gone.

His circle was there, in the snow by the cracked Stone. His gold path across the green to Old Mag's gate. His footprints, a step wide, going away from the gate and out along the mill road. East. And then north. Toward the hills.

He'd gone. In the dark. Without a word. With his gold cup in his hand and his sister's face in it.

Lex had followed the footprints for six miles in the snow, by the light of his own fire, before Antho came down on the dragon and stopped him.

He's walking, Antho had said. *That's all. He's not coming here. He's walking away from here.*

How do you know?

Because he's walking away, his brother said. *Look at the prints. Look how far apart. He's not creeping, Lex. He's running.*

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SO THEY'D WAITED.

Three days. Every window horn. Every bucket lidded. Kestrel on the ladder at night with her fire. Seren sleeping on the settle by the hearth with the grey book under her pillow. Brannoc in the lean-to with a hammer. Antho on the roof, sometimes, with his flute, not playing it.

And the stream outside running black under the ice.

And every night, Wren lay awake and listened to it.

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"*You were going to go anyway*," she said. "*Seraphine says. Gale next. After Tide. You were going to go to the Teeth.*"

"*Without you*." Lex didn't look at her. "*I was going to go with Antho. Without you. Without her. I was going to leave you here with Kestrel and Brannoc and my mother and every bucket lidded, and go and get it over with, and come back.*"

"*I know*."

"*Because it's safer*."

"*Is it*?" Wren looked at him. "*Lex. There's a stream outside the door. There's a pond in the birch wood. There'll be puddles in every rut when the thaw comes, and there's no lid in the world big enough for a thaw.*" She shook her head. "*It's not safer. It's just closer to where you can see.*"

He didn't answer.

"*She can't reach into the sky*," said Wren. "*She can't reach into the wind. She can't reach into the eye of a storm four miles up over the Teeth.*" She reached across the table and took his hand. Her right one. In his. "*It's the safest place in the world. For the three of us. Right now.*"

He looked at their hands.

"*It's a storm*," he said. "*Wren. She's fourteen months old. It's a storm.*"

"*I was born in one*," said Wren Ashdown.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LEFT AT DAWN.

Ashka took them. With Antho in front, his long hair tied back and his face set. And Lex behind him. And Wren behind Lex, with Lark strapped to her chest in a sling of oiled wool lined with fleece, bundled so thick that only her round face showed, and her fluff of dark hair standing up out of the top of the hood like a feather.

Seren stood at the gate to see them off.

She didn't say *be careful*. Harrow women didn't. She just stood there in her grey shawl with her arms wrapped round herself and looked at her granddaughter's face for a long time.

Then she reached up and put her hand on the baby's cheek.

"*Be loud*," she said.

Lark considered this.

"*No*," she said.

Seren laughed. Short and surprised. And stepped back. And Ashka opened her wings with a crack like a ship's sail filling, and the yard went away under them, and the birch wood, and the stream, and the grey stone with its twenty lanterns and its one red rose.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS COLD UP there.

Wren had known it would be. She'd been up there. Three years ago. With Lex and Antho and the others, on Vharuun's back, going up into the storm above the Teeth to find the First Breath.

She'd forgotten how cold.

It went through the oiled wool and the fleece and the three layers of wool under that and into her skin and into her bones. Her gold fingers ached with it. Not hurt. *Ached*. The way a stone aches in frost. The way a bell aches before it's struck.

Lark didn't seem to notice.

She was awake. Strapped to Wren's chest. With her face out of the hood and her eyes wide open. Grey-green. Enormous. Looking at the sky.

She didn't cry. She didn't squirm. She didn't say *no*. She just looked.

At the clouds going by underneath them, white and grey, like a field of snow. At the sun coming up behind them, red, then gold. At the mountains ahead, white and sharp against the blue, the Teeth, a row of fangs along the northern sky.

At the wind.

She couldn't see the wind. Nobody could see the wind. But Wren felt her daughter's small body go still against her chest, and felt her turn her head, slowly, into the cold rushing air, the way a flower turns to the sun.

And breathe it.

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She knows, thought Wren.

She knows what it is.

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THEY CAME TO THE storm at noon.

It sat over the Teeth the way it had always sat over the Teeth, the way it had sat there for nine hundred years and nine hundred before that. A tower of cloud. Black at the base. Grey in the middle. White at the top, so high it caught the sun and burned. Turning. Slowly. Like a wheel. Like a great slow millstone grinding the sky. With lightning walking in it, blue and white, silent at this distance. And under it, the mountains. And over it, nothing. Blue.

The wind came off it like a wall.

Ashka flinched. Wren felt her flinch. Felt the great grey body bank and slow and hang in the air a mile off the edge of the cloud, wings beating hard, holding.

"*She won't go in*," shouted Antho. Over the roar. "*Not without her mother*."

"*Then call her mother*," shouted Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO PUT TWO FINGERS in his mouth and whistled.

Long. High. Then low. Then high again. A sound like the wind in a chimney. Like a storm in a gully.

The cloud answered.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME OUT OF it like a mountain falling.

Grey. Silver-edged. Enormous. Bigger than Ashka. Bigger than a barn. Bigger than a hall. A storm-dragon, old as the Teeth, with wings that spread across half the sky and eyes like lightning in a well. Scarred along the flanks with old white scars, healed. Healed in a storm on a night twenty-seven years ago, when a woman in a cottage in Thistledown screamed and pushed, and a baby girl came out into the world, red-haired and furious, at the exact moment a dying dragon over the Teeth breathed in the first breath of a new storm and lived.

Vharuun.

She came down out of the cloud and hung in the air beside her daughter and looked at them. At Antho. At Lex. At Wren.

At the baby on Wren's chest.

And went very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FELT IT. THE great old eyes. Lightning in a well. Looking at Lark.

Lark looked back.

She didn't cry. She didn't hide. She lay against Wren's chest with her round face out of the hood and her eyes wide and her mouth a little open,

and looked at the biggest thing she'd ever seen. Grey. Silver. Lightning walking in its eyes.

And her face changed.

Wren saw it. The way a child's face changes when it sees something it has no word for yet. Wide. Open. Delighted.

"*Ash*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN BENT HER HEAD.

Down. Slowly. Through the screaming wind. The great grey wedge of her head, as big as a cart, scarred, ancient, coming down out of the sky toward the small bundled figure on Wren's chest. Until her nostrils were a yard away. Until Wren could feel her breath. Hot. Wet. Smelling of rain and lightning and cold high places.

She breathed in.

Smelling the baby. The way a mare smells a foal.

Lark reached out. Both square fists. Out of the sling. Toward the nostrils. Grabbing at the air.

"*Ash*," she said again. Firmly.

And Vharuun—old as the Teeth, mother of storms, who had lain dying in the high cold for a hundred years before a red-haired baby was born under her—breathed out.

Very gently.

Over the child.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS WARM.

Wren felt it go past her. Over her. Through her. Over Lark. A breath. Warm and wet and enormous, smelling of spring rain and summer lightning and the first green coming up through snow. It lifted Lark's hair. It lifted Wren's. It went past them and round them and on, out into the cold air, and was gone.

Lark laughed.

She'd laughed before. Of course she had. She laughed at Lex's faces and at the goat and at Brannoc's hymns and at falling down. But not like this.

This came up out of her from somewhere very deep. Big. Loud. Delighted. A laugh like the first rain on a hot day. Like a door flung open.

She laughed and laughed.

And Vharuun lifted her head. And looked at Wren.

And turned. And went back into the storm.

And Ashka followed her.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS DARK INSIDE.

Dark and loud and wet and full of wind. Rain like stones. Hail like gravel. Lightning, so close it didn't flash, it *was*—a white light everywhere at once, and a sound like the sky being torn in half, and then dark again, and the afterimage burning. Ashka bucking and plunging under them. Antho shouting something nobody could hear. Lex's arm round Wren's waist, iron-hard, holding her on.

Wren had her arms round Lark. Both of them. Her good arm and her gold-fingered one. Curled over her. Holding her against her chest under the oiled wool with her whole body.

Lark was still laughing.

Wren could feel it. Through the sling. Through the fleece. Through her own ribs. The small body shaking with it. Every time the lightning came. Every time Ashka dropped. Every time the wind hit them like a fist.

She's not frightened, thought Wren. *She's not frightened at all.*

She's home.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME OUT INTO the eye.

All at once. The way you come out of a dark wood into a clearing. One moment wind and rain and hail and lightning, and the next—

Still.

Not still. *Calm*. A great round open space in the middle of the storm, a mile across, two miles, with the walls of cloud going up on every side, black and grey and white, turning, turning, like the inside of a well. And overhead, at the top, a circle of blue sky. And in the blue, the sun.

And in the middle of the calm, hanging in the air, a stillness that wasn't still.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HAD SEEN IT before.

You couldn't see it, exactly. That was the thing. It was air. It was nothing. A place in the middle of the eye where the air was clearer than the rest, the way water is clearer in a spring than in a pond. Bright. Quick. Moving all the time, in every direction at once, and never going anywhere.

The First Breath.

The first wind there ever was. The breath the world breathed in when it was made. Gale's own heart. Or its Wellworld. Or both. Seraphine had written forty pages about it and still wasn't sure.

Wren had stood in front of it three years ago. And it had asked her what she was holding.

And she'd been holding Lex's hand.

Let go, it had said. *You cannot carry a wind and hold a hand. Not at the same time. Choose.*

She'd let go.

It had nearly killed her. Not the wind. The letting go. She'd stood in the eye of the storm and opened her fingers and felt his slide out of them and thought *I'll never get it back*.

She had. Of course she had. He'd been right there. He'd taken it again ten minutes later, on Vharuun's back, on the way down, with the First Breath in her lungs and her whole body singing.

But she'd *let go*. Not knowing.

That was the price.

◆ ◆ ◆

ASHKA HUNG IN THE calm.

Vharuun circled. Slowly. A long way off. At the edge of the eye. Watching.

And the First Breath turned toward them.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FELT IT TURN. The way you feel someone in a room turn to look at you. The air in front of them going bright and quick and *attentive*.

Wind-child, it said.

Not words. A rush. A gust. A whisper of air past her ear, with meaning in it.

You came back.

"*I brought my husband*," said Wren. "*He needs to talk to you.*"

The air moved. Round Lex. Round his face. His hands. Lifting his hair. Tasting him.

Smith. Fire and stone. And water now. New water. Salt. The air brightened. *You let something go. In the sea.*

"*Yes*," said Lex.

I can smell it on you, said the First Breath. *Grief. Gone out. Good.* The air moved on. Round Antho. *Shadow. I know you. Brother of the wind-child's man. You hold a door.* It moved on. Quickly. Restlessly. Never stopping. Down. To Wren's chest. To the sling.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD NEVER STOPPED. Wren had never felt it stop. Not three years ago. Not in all the stories. The First Breath was the thing that never stopped. It was moving. It was always moving. It was the first movement there ever was.

It stopped.

Over Lark.

The air in front of the sling went very bright and very still. Like a held breath. Like the moment before a gust.

And Lark looked up at it.

◆ ◆ ◆

Oh, said the First Breath.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She sat on Ashka's back in the eye of the storm with her daughter on her chest and the first wind there ever was hanging in front of them, *stopped*, and didn't move at all.

Oh, said the First Breath again. Very softly. A whisper. Like wind in grass. *Oh. New.*

Lark reached out.

Both fists. Out of the sling. Into the bright still air.

And laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST BREATH WENT *wild*.

All at once. Like a cork out of a bottle. Like a bird out of a cage. The still bright air in front of them burst outward in every direction, and the calm wasn't calm anymore, it was a *whirl*, a spinning, a dance, gusts going up and down and round and round, lifting Wren's braid straight up off her shoulders, lifting Lex's coat, lifting Ashka's wings so that the dragon lurched and grabbed at the air.

And lifting Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

OUT OF THE SLING.

Wren felt it happen. Felt the straps go loose—not cut, not broken, just *loose*, the knots untying themselves, the wool falling open—and felt the small warm weight on her chest *lift*.

Up.

Out of her arms.

Into the air.

◆ ◆ ◆

"Lark—"

Lex was moving. She felt him move. Felt him lunge past her, his arm going out, his hand open, grabbing—

"Don't," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T KNOW WHY she said it. It came out of her the way the mist came out of her. From somewhere under her breastbone. From the place where the wind lived.

She caught his arm. With her right hand. And held it.

"Don't."

He stared at her. His face white. His eyes wild.

"Wren—she's—"

"*Look*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WAS FLYING.

Not falling. *Flying*. Hanging in the air above them, in the middle of the eye, in the middle of the whirling bright wind. Bundled in fleece and oiled wool, with her hood fallen back and her dark hair standing up like a feather. Turning. Slowly. Round and round. The way a leaf turns in an eddy.

Laughing.

The wind had her. Wren could see it. Not *see*. Feel. The First Breath. All round her. Under her. Holding her up. The way water holds up a swimmer. The way a hand holds a bird. Gently. Absolutely.

Spinning her. Lifting her. Dropping her a foot and catching her. Lifting her again.

And Lark laughing and laughing and laughing, with her square fists out and her face turned up to the blue circle of sky at the top of the storm.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's got her*," said Lex. Hoarse. "*Wren. It's got her. It's going to—*"

"*It's not going to do anything*," said Wren.

"*You don't know that*."

"*No*," said Wren. "*I don't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T. THAT WAS the truth. She sat on the dragon's back with her husband's arm in her hand and her daughter turning in the air above them, and she didn't know anything at all.

She didn't know if the wind would bring her back. She didn't know if it would take her up into the blue and away. She didn't know if it knew what a baby was, or how small, or how easily broken.

She didn't know.

She held on to Lex's arm.

And let go of everything else.

◆ ◆ ◆

Smith, said the First Breath.

It was everywhere. In the whirl. In the gusts. In the roar of the storm walls turning round them. Laughing. It was *laughing*. Wren could hear it. The first wind there ever was, laughing with a baby.

Smith. What are you holding?

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T ANSWER.

His arm was rigid in Wren's grip. Every muscle in it locked. Straining. Toward the child. She could feel it. If she let go, he'd lunge. He'd throw himself off the dragon's back into the open air after his daughter and fall four miles to the Teeth.

What are you holding? said the wind again.

"*Her*," said Lex. Through his teeth. "*I'm holding her.*"

No, said the First Breath. *I am holding her.*

The wind spun Lark round again. She shrieked with joy.

You are holding your fear, said the wind. *Since the rose. Since the old woman's cottage. Since the night the grandmother came barefoot through the snow.* The air brightened round his face. *You have been holding it so tight you cannot breathe. Like your grief, in the sea.*

"*She's my daughter.*"

She is, said the First Breath. *And she is the wind-child's daughter. And the wind's.* A gust. Round Lark. Lifting her higher. *She was born on rubble, under lanterns, in a storm of light. She breathed me in her first breath. All children do. I am the first breath. I am in every one.*

The air came close to Lex's face. Very close. Very bright.

But she remembered, said the wind.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FELT LEX'S ARM shake.

"*I can't*," he said. "*I can't let go of it. She's—the Glass Queen wants her. The King. They want her hand. They want—*" His voice broke. "*If I let go, I'm not holding her. If I'm not holding her, anyone can—*"

Can what?

"*Take her.*"

You cannot hold her forever, said the First Breath. *Smith. You cannot. No one can.* The air was very gentle now. *You can hold her hand while she*

learns to walk. You can hold her when she falls. You can hold the door open so she can go through it. But you cannot hold her.

A pause.

That is what the King does, said the wind. *That is what keeping is.*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT STILL.

Wren felt it. All at once. The rigid arm in her grip going slack. Not giving up. *Stopping*. The way a man stops when he's walked to the edge of a cliff in the dark and someone lights a lantern.

He looked up.

At his daughter. Turning in the bright wind above them. Laughing. Her dark hair blowing. Her square fists out. Her face turned up to the sky.

Not afraid.

Not held.

Carried.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE BREATHED OUT.

Wren felt it go out of him. Through his arm. Through his whole body. A breath he'd been holding since a rose came up through the snow by his father's grave. Since an old woman's cottage and a flame in a lantern that didn't know him. Since his mother hammering on the door in the dark.

It went out of him. Into the wind.

And the wind took it.

◆ ◆ ◆

There, said the First Breath.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ATTUNEMENT — GALE
SPEAKING → COMMANDING
"Let it carry."
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◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAW HIS FACE. In the bright air. As the panel came and went in front of him, where only he could see it. Saw it change.

He didn't look triumphant. He looked like a man who'd put down something very heavy after carrying it a long way. Light. Strange. Unsteady on his feet. Not sure what to do with his hands.

He looked up at Lark.

And, for the first time in three days—for the first time, Wren thought, since his father died—

He laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND BROUGHT HER back.

Slowly. Spinning. Down out of the bright air like a leaf coming down in autumn. Turning. Laughing. Into Wren's arms. Wren caught her. Held her. Felt the small warm weight land on her chest and the square fists grab her collar.

Lark looked up at her.

Grey-green eyes. Enormous. Shining. Her cheeks red with cold and her hair standing straight up and her whole face lit like a Lantern Night window.

"*More*," said Lark Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STARED AT HER.

"*More*," said Lark again. Firmly. Pointing up. At the wind. With one square fist. "*More. More.*"

Beside her, Lex made a sound. A choked, cracked, astonished sound.

"*That's new*," he said.

"*That's new*," said Wren.

Lark beamed at them both. Proud. As if she'd known the word all along and had simply been waiting for something worth saying it to.

Then she put her fist in her mouth. And fell asleep. Instantly. Against Wren's chest. The way babies do. As if someone had blown out a candle.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST BREATH WAS laughing.

Wren could hear it. All round them. In the eye. In the turning walls of cloud. A sound like wind in a thousand chimneys. Like a summer gale through a field of barley.

More, it said. *More. She said more.* The bright air came close again. Over the sleeping baby. Very gently. Lifting a strand of dark hair. *Nine hundred years they have said that to me, every child, in their first breath, without knowing. More. And I give it.* A pause. *She is the first one who ever said it out loud.*

Then it turned. To Wren.

Wind-child.

"*Yes*."

You let go, said the First Breath. *Of his arm. Of hers. Of knowing.* The air moved round her. Through her braid. Over her gold fingers, where they lay against the sleeping baby's back. *You did it again. Like before.*

"*I didn't know if you'd bring her back*," said Wren. Her voice was shaking now. Now it was over. "*I didn't know.*"

No, agreed the wind. *That is what makes it letting go.*

◆ ◆ ◆

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WREN ASHDOWN
MISTWALKER — Level 71 → 72
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◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN AT dusk.

Out of the eye. Through the wall of the storm. Lightning and hail and wind and dark, Ashka plunging, Vharuun beside them all the way down like a grey cliff falling. And out into the open air over the Teeth, with the sun going down red behind the mountains and the cloud below them like a field of fire.

Lark slept the whole way.

Lex had his arm round Wren's waist. Not iron-hard now. Just there. Holding her on. The way you hold someone on a horse.

She leaned back against him.

"*More*," he said. In her ear. Over the wind. Wondering. "*She said more.*"

"*I heard*."

"*Two words*." She felt him smile against her hair. "*No and more. That's all she needs. That's everything*."

Wren laughed. And didn't say anything. And watched the mountains go by underneath them in the red light, and felt her husband breathe against her back, slow and easy, in and out, the way he hadn't breathed in a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN LEFT THEM AT the edge of the Teeth.

She banked. Huge. Grey. Silver. Across the red sky. And for a moment hung beside them, wing to wing with her daughter, and looked across at Wren with her lightning eyes.

At the sleeping child.

Then she turned. And was gone. Back into the north. Into the storm.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME HOME IN the dark.

Over the Vale. Over the Greyspine. Over the Forge at Ashbourne, with its twenty chimneys smoking, and the green, and the chapel, and the churchyard with a new grave under the yew.

And Wren, looking down, saw the Stone.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE GREEN. IN the middle. Pale. Tall. Cracked from top to bottom down the middle.

Lit.

Not silver-blue. Not the dim steady glow it gave at a Kindling, when a child put her hand on it and it looked all the way through her. Not that.

White. Cold. Hard. Like frost. Like ice with the moon on it. Shining up into the dark from the middle of the green. And in the crack down the middle of it—

Wren leaned over Ashka's shoulder. Stared.

In the crack, faint, where the two halves of the Stone didn't quite meet—

An eye.

Ice-grey. Wide open. Looking up.

At them.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Wren. Very quietly.

He'd seen it. She felt him see it. Felt the dragon falter under them as he pulled her round.

And beyond the green. Beyond Ashbourne. Out across the dark Vale, south and west and north. On every hill. At every crossroads. In every village square.

Lights.

White. Cold. Hard. Like frost under the moon. One after another. Coming on. Like lanterns being lit in windows. Like eyes opening.

Every Lattice Stone in Caldor.

Looking up.

CHAPTER 11

The Stones Look Back

POSY TULL WAS SIXTEEN on the fourteenth day of the new year, and her mother had been planning her Kindling since she was four.

Lex knew this because everyone in Ashbourne knew it. The widow Tull had talked about nothing else for a month. The new dress, blue, with lace at the cuffs that she'd unpicked from her own wedding gown. The ribbons. The honey-cakes for after, two dozen, from Hollis Penn, paid for in advance. The order of who would stand where on the green, and who would cheer first, and how loud.

Posy had wanted to be a Weaver. Like her grandmother. Everyone knew that too.

In the old days, before the net was reforged, she'd have been told what she was and that would have been the end of it. Common or Uncommon, most likely. Ceiling 24. A Weaver if she was lucky, a Spinner if she wasn't, and the rest of her life at a loom in the back room of her mother's cottage.

Now there were no Ceilings. Now a girl could put her hand on the Stone and be told what she was and then *grow*. Past twenty-four. Past fifty. Past anything. Dunny Tobbin had been Kindled a Berserker at fourteen and was Level 41 by the summer. Ivy Moss had been Kindled with a class nobody had ever heard of and was keeping a Well.

Anything could happen at a Kindling now.

That was what the widow Tull said. *Anything could happen*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STONE HAD BEEN white for two days.

It had come on in the night. Wren had seen it from the dragon's back, coming home from the Teeth. Every Stone in Caldor, lighting up one after another across the dark like lanterns in windows. White. Cold. Hard. Like frost under the moon.

And in the crack down the middle of Ashbourne's Stone—

An eye.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD GONE DOWN to the green in the dark. With Antho. With Wren behind them, Lark asleep on her chest, and Kestrel with her fire.

He'd stood in front of the Stone in the snow and looked at it.

Pale. Tall as a man. Clouded like old ice. Glowing white from inside, so bright it hurt to look at directly, so cold he could feel it on his face from three paces off. Like standing in front of an open door in a house in winter. Like standing in front of the sea.

And in the crack down the middle—

Nothing.

He'd looked for a long time. Close. With his face a foot from the cold white glass. He'd seen the crack. Straight as a ruler, from top to bottom, where the two halves didn't quite meet. He'd seen the glow coming out of it, white and hard.

He hadn't seen an eye.

"*It was there*," said Wren. Behind him. Very quietly. "*Ice-grey. Wide open. Looking up at us.*"

"*I believe you*."

"*It saw us. Lex, it saw her.*" She had her arms round the sleeping baby. "*It looked straight at her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SO THEY'D COVERED IT.

That night. Hedda came down from the Forge with a bolt of sacking and a roll of chisels and her grey plaits tucked into her collar, and they wrapped the Ashbourne Stone from top to bottom in three layers of sacking and lashed it with rope. And Hedda cut a rune into the frozen earth at the foot of it. Four strokes. A hush-rune. The one Pim used. The one that meant *not here*.

The white glow came through the sacking anyway. Dim. Like a lamp behind a curtain.

But nobody saw the eye again.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEEPERS WERE DOING the same, all over Caldor. Seraphine had sent ravens out from the Forge before dawn. *Cover the Stones. Sacking. Canvas. Anything. Hush-runes if you've got anyone who can cut them. Don't look into them. Don't touch them.*

Don't let anyone Kindle.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIDOW TULL HAD not got the raven.

Or she had, and hadn't read it. Or she had read it and decided it didn't apply to her daughter. Lex never found out which.

He found out the way everyone found out. At noon on the fourteenth day of the new year, with the sun white on the snow and the whole village going about its business, when a shriek went up from the green so loud and so high that half of Ashbourne dropped what it was holding and ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS AT THE Forge.

He ran too.

Down the lane. In the snow. With Antho beside him and Tilda behind and the bell under his shirt bouncing on its cord. Past the chapel. Onto the green.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SACKING WAS OFF.

It lay in the snow at the foot of the Stone in a heap, the ropes cut, the hush-rune scuffed out by boots. And round the Stone, a crowd. Thirty people. Forty. The widow Tull's whole family and half her street, in their best coats, with ribbons in their hats, and a trestle table set up by the pond with two dozen honey-cakes on it under a cloth.

And in the middle, by the Stone, a girl.

Sixteen. Thin. Freckled. Mousy-haired. In a blue dress with lace at the cuffs. With her right hand flat against the white glowing glass of the Stone.

Not moving.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIDOW TULL WAS screaming.

Not words. Just sound. Standing a yard behind her daughter with both hands over her mouth and her eyes wide and the sound coming out between her fingers. High. Thin. Endless.

Nobody else was making any noise at all.

Lex pushed through.

"*Posy—*"

The girl didn't turn round.

She was looking at the Stone. At the white glass. Right in front of her face, a foot away. Her hand flat against it. Her mouth a little open. Her eyes—

He saw her eyes.

Wide. Fixed. Not blinking. The way you'd look at something you couldn't look away from. The way a rabbit looks at a stoat.

He looked where she was looking.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STONE WAS SHOWING her her face.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT A REFLECTION. NOT the way a window shows you your face at night, faint and grey with the dark behind it. This was *clear*. Bright. Sharp. Every freckle. Every eyelash. Every pore. A face hanging in the white glass a foot in front of her, exactly her size, exactly her shape. Thin. Freckled. Mousy-haired. Sixteen.

Looking back at her.

And under it, in the glass, in letters—not silver-blue, not the Lattice's own clean glyphs, not anything Lex had ever seen in seven years of panels—in letters like frost on a window, white and fine and cold:

YOU ARE POSY TULL.

THIS IS WHAT YOU ARE.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOTHING ELSE.

No class. No grade. No level. No skills. None of the things a Stone gave you, a Kindling gave you, that told you what you could do, what you could become.

Just her face.

And her name.

And *this is what you are*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Posy*," said Lex. Very gently. "*Posy, take your hand away.*"

The girl didn't move.

"*I can't*," she said. A whisper. She didn't take her eyes off the face in the glass. "*I can't stop looking. Smith, I can't stop looking at it.*"

"*Take your hand away*."

"*It's me*," said Posy Tull. "*It's just me. That's all I am. That's all I'll ever be. It's showing me.*" Her voice cracked. "*It says I'm not anything. It says I'm just this. Just Posy. It says that's all.*"

"*It's lying*."

"*It's not*," said the girl. "*It's true. Look at it. It's true.*" A tear ran down her face. The face in the glass wept with her. Exactly. Every drop. "*I'm not a Weaver. I'm not anything. I'm just—this.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT HIS HAND on her wrist.

It was cold. Ice-cold. The cold coming out of the Stone and into her hand and up her arm. He could feel it. Like frost spreading across a pane.

He pulled.

Her hand didn't come away.

Not stuck. Not frozen. He could feel it wasn't stuck. It was just—*staying*. Her own hand, pressed flat against the glass, staying there because she couldn't bear to take it away. Because the face in the glass was hers, and true, and she couldn't stop looking.

He pulled harder.

"*Don't*," said Posy. Faintly. "*Don't. I want to see.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Wren*," said Lex.

He didn't know where she was. He hadn't seen her in the crowd. He said it anyway. Not loud.

She was beside him.

He didn't know how. She hadn't been there, and then she was. With Lark on her back in the sling and her bow over her shoulder and her face white. She looked at the Stone. At the face in it. At the frost-letters.

She leaned past Lex.

And breathed on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

MIST. GREY. SOFT. COLD. Rolling out of her mouth like fog off a river in October. Over the white glass. Over the face. Over the letters.

Fog on glass.

The face blurred. The letters blurred. The white glow behind them went grey, went soft, went—

Posy Tull's hand came away.

All at once. As if a string had been cut. She fell back. Into Lex. And he caught her, and she twisted in his arms and buried her face in his coat and screamed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK AN HOUR to get her home.

Her mother carried her. Lex walked beside them. The whole street followed. Nobody said anything. Nobody looked back at the Stone. The honey-cakes stayed on the trestle by the pond under their cloth.

At the door of the Tull cottage, Posy stopped screaming.

She stood in the doorway. In her blue dress with the lace at the cuffs. And turned round. And looked at Lex.

Her face was blotched and wet and swollen. Her eyes were very wide.

"*It was true*," she said. "*Wasn't it? It wasn't lying. It showed me what I am.*"

Lex didn't know what to say.

"*It showed you what you are now*," said Wren. From behind him. Quietly. "*Not what you'll be. Glass can't show you that. Nothing can.*"

The girl looked at her.

"*Then why did it feel like that was all*?" said Posy Tull.

And went inside.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY COVERED THE STONE again.

Four layers of sacking this time. And canvas over that. And chains. Brannoc brought the chains down from the Forge himself, on his shoulder, and wrapped them round and round and padlocked them, and stood back and looked at it with his gold fingertips in his armpits.

"*There*," he said. "*Now she'll have to knock.*"

Nobody laughed.

The white glow came through the canvas anyway. Dimmer. Like a lamp in a fog.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE CAME THAT EVENING.

On Ashka, with Antho. From the Forge, where she'd been since dawn with her eleven books and a hundred ravens going out and coming back. She came into the kitchen at Harrow with snow on her shoulders and ink on her fingers and her spectacles fogged, and sat down at the table without taking her coat off.

"*Thirty-one*," she said.

Lex looked at her.

"*Thirty-one Kindlings*," said Seraphine. "*Since the Stones came on. Two days. All over Caldor. Before the ravens got there, or after, or because people didn't believe them.*" She took off her spectacles. Rubbed her eyes. "*Thirty-one children put their hands on a Stone and saw their own faces. And their names. And this is what you are.*"

"*And—*"

"*And nothing*," said Seraphine. "*No class. No level. No skills. Nothing.*" She put her spectacles back on. "*Their threads are there. I checked. With the Keepers' readers. The net's got them. It knows they're there.*" She looked at him. "*It just won't tell them what they are. It shows them their faces instead.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's her*," said Antho. From the door. Where he was leaning, with his arms folded, the way he leaned when he was frightened. "*It's Ysenne.*"

"*Yes*," said Seraphine.

"*She's in the Stones*."

"*She's in the net*," said Seraphine. "*Through the Stones. The way the rose said.*" She pulled one of her books out of her satchel. Not the Codex. A Warden's manual. Old. Grey cloth. *On the Structure and Maintenance of the Lattice Stones*. She'd stolen it from the Spire archive eight years ago, the night she fled. "*Every Stone is a window. Onto the net. That's what they were built for. That's what a Kindling is. The child puts her hand on the window and the net looks through it, at her, all the way down.*"

She opened it. To a diagram. A Stone, drawn in cross-section. Threads going down from it. Down and down. Into the ground. Into the net.

"*She's turned them round*," said Seraphine.

"*What*?"

"*The windows*." She tapped the diagram. "*They're supposed to let the net look at the child. Now they're looking at the child for her. The Glass Queen. She's in the net, behind every Stone, and when a child puts her hand on the glass, it's not the net looking back.*" She looked up. "*It's her. And she shows them what she shows everyone.*"

"*Their faces*," said Wren.

"*Their faces. What they are.*" Seraphine closed the book. "*Glass can't show you what you could be. It can only show you what you are.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

Lark was asleep in the cradle in the loft. Seren was on the settle by the fire with the grey book. Kestrel was on the ladder. The water barrel had its lid on. The windows were horn.

"*She's walking*," said Seraphine at last.

Lex looked at her.

"*In the net*," she said. "*I can feel it. A little. Through Mal. Hollow Speaking.*" She touched her chest. "*Every thread she touches goes—cold. Like glass. Like frost spreading. It's very small. Very slow. But she's moving. Down. Thread by thread. Toward the middle.*"

"*The crown in the road*."

"*The crown in the road*." Seraphine swallowed. "*The Root. The centre. Where you let go.*" She looked at him. "*She's going for it. And she's going the long way. Through every thread. Because the net won't let her straight in. It doesn't know her. She's not of the net. She can only walk where it's glass.*"

"*How long*?"

Seraphine looked at her notebook. At columns of figures. At a map of Caldor with thirty-one small crosses on it.

"*At this pace*," she said, "*two months. Perhaps less. Perhaps she'll find a quicker way.*" She closed the notebook. "*The spring. The equinox. Round about then.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And when she gets there*," said Lex, "*it won't let her in.*"

Seraphine looked at him.

"*The Root's Vey*," said Lex. "*Always. Aurelian built it that way. It only ever answered to his blood. That's why it was ours. That's why I could give it away.*" He put his hands flat on the table. "*She can walk to the middle. She can stand there. She can look at it. But she can't pick it up.*"

"*No*," said Seraphine. "*Not without—*"

She stopped.

She looked up. At the ceiling. At the loft.

They all did.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Not without a Vey hand*," said Seren. Quietly. From the settle.

Nobody answered.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT UP THE ladder.

Kestrel moved aside for him. Without a word. She had a little flame in her palm, the size of a candle-flame. She held it up so he could see.

The loft was dark and warm and close. Wren's quilt on the bed. The little window under the roof, horn-paned, with the stars blurred behind it. And the cradle. Ash and iron. With *KNIT* on the rockers.

He looked in.

Lark was asleep. On her back. With her arms flung up over her head, the way she always slept, as if she'd been dropped from a height and landed like that and couldn't be bothered to move. Her fluff of hair. Her round face. Her mouth a little open.

Her hands.

One on either side of her head. Open. Palms up. Square. Broad. Too big for the rest of her. A smith's hands. The fingers curled a little, loose, in sleep.

Vey hands, his father had said. *Aurelian had hands like that. In the paintings.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD OVER THE cradle for a long time.

He didn't touch her. He didn't want to wake her.

He thought about the eye of the storm. About the wind lifting her out of the sling and spinning her in the bright air, laughing. About *don't*, and Wren's hand on his arm, and letting go.

You cannot hold her, the wind had said. *You can hold the door open so she can go through it. But you cannot hold her.*

He'd believed it. Up there. In the eye. With the sky blue overhead and his daughter laughing.

He stood in the dark loft with the white glow of a covered Stone faint on the horizon through the horn window, and tried to believe it now.

◆ ◆ ◆

Status, he thought.

He didn't know why. Habit. Seven years of habit. When he was frightened, when he didn't know what to do, he looked at the panel. As if it would tell him. As if it would have something at the bottom, in the corner, in gold.

It came up.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT SILVER-BLUE.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHITE.

Cold. Fine. Like frost on a window. The frame of the panel, the lines of it, the letters, all of it white and glittering and hard, the way the letters on the Stone had been. Hanging in the dark of the loft over his daughter's cradle.

And it didn't say WORLDFORGER.

It didn't say Level 99.

It said:

◆ ◆ ◆

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HELLO, SMITH.
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T MOVE.

He stood over the cradle with his hands at his sides and the white panel hanging in front of him and didn't move at all.

The letters changed. Melted. Re-formed. Like frost growing across a pane.

◆ ◆ ◆

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YOU'RE FRIGHTENED.
YOU LAUGHED YESTERDAY. IN THE STORM.
THE FIRST TIME SINCE HE DIED.
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◆ ◆ ◆

Get out, he thought.

◆ ◆ ◆

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I'M NOT IN. NOT YET.
I'M IN THE GLASS. AT THE EDGE.
YOUR NET HAS SO MUCH GLASS IN IT.
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◆ ◆ ◆

Get out of my panel.

◆ ◆ ◆

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IT ISN'T YOURS.
NOTHING IN IT IS YOURS.
YOU GAVE IT AWAY. REMEMBER?
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED FOR FIRE.

He didn't think. It came up in him the way it always came when he was frightened. Heat. Weight. The roar of a forge. He could have burned the loft down. He could have burned the cottage down. He felt it come up into his hands, white-gold, and stopped it. Just. With his daughter asleep a foot away.

He stood there with fire in his hands and nowhere to put it.

The white letters didn't flicker.

◆ ◆ ◆

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THAT WON'T WORK. I'M GLASS.
FIRE MAKES GLASS. IT DOESN'T BREAK IT.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE LETTERS went.

All of them. Melted away. And the white panel hanging in the dark in front of him was empty. Clear. Like a pane of glass in a window with nothing behind it.

And then it wasn't empty.

◆ ◆ ◆

A FACE.

In the panel. Where the letters had been. Clear and bright and sharp. Every line. Every scar. A face he knew.

His own.

Twenty-six. Grey-eyed. Burned. A handprint on the left cheek, grey-gold, five fingers and a palm. Dark hair cut badly. Tired. Older than he felt.

And on his brow—

Gold.

A crown. Not a circlet. Not a band. *Threads*. Gold threads, fine as hair, thousands of them, millions, coming up out of his head and going out in every direction, into the dark, into the world, like the rays of the sun in a child's drawing. Every thread humming. Every thread a person. A name. A life.

The Root.

His face. Crowned with the net.

Looking back at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

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THIS IS WHAT YOU COULD HAVE BEEN.
YOU GAVE IT AWAY.
I WONDER IF YOU'D GIVE IT AWAY AGAIN.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T BREATHE.

He stood in the loft and looked at the face in the panel. His face. Crowned. Holding every thread in the world. Able to touch any of them. Fix any of them. Wren's fingers. Brannoc's. Tilda's. The boy in the field. The bread at Westerling. The cut on Davy Pruett's hand.

Ember.

He could reach down any thread in the world and find a flame in a lantern and—

No.

He didn't think it. He *felt* it. Under his breastbone. Where the Wells were. Fire and stone and water and wind, all at once, saying it.

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FACE IN THE panel smiled.

Not his smile. Not quite. Something colder. Something curious. As if someone were wearing his face to see how it fit.

Then the letters came back. Over the face. Small. Fine. White. At the bottom of the panel. In the corner. Where, for seven years, there had been a line of warm gold text.

◆ ◆ ◆

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YOUR DAUGHTER'S HANDS
ARE VERY SQUARE.
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◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE PANEL WENT out.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD IN THE dark.

Kestrel's flame was gone. She'd closed her hand. The loft was black. The horn window. The stars. The faint white glow on the horizon, far off, where a covered Stone stood on a village green.

And in the cradle, his daughter. Asleep. On her back. With her arms flung over her head and her square hands open on the pillow.

He knelt down beside the cradle.

He didn't touch her. He didn't want to wake her.

He knelt there in the dark, beside her, all night. With his hands in his lap. With fire still in them. With nowhere to put it.

CHAPTER 12

The Hinge

"*Shut your eyes*," said Antho.

His brother shut his eyes.

They were standing at the end of the cave at the Hollowmaw. At the very back. Past all one thousand one hundred and thirteen lanterns, burning on nothing, gold and small, from the mouth to here. At the black door.

It was taller than a man and wider than a cart and made of nothing. Black. Smooth. Cold. Like a slab of night set into the rock. For thirteen years it had been shut, with their mother on the far side of it, holding it closed against a starving Well. Then their father had sat in front of it for three years with a lamp. Then Antho had knocked, and it had opened, and they'd gone down into the deep and brought her home.

It was shut again now. Not locked. *Shut*. The way a door is shut in a house where everyone's asleep.

On the hook beside it, the last three lanterns. Clay. Iron. Tin.

"*Are they shut*?" said Antho.

"*Yes*."

"*Properly*?"

"*Yes*, *Antho.*"

"*Then why are you squinting*?"

A pause.

"*Because I don't like it*," said Lex. "*I don't like not seeing.*"

"*I know*," said Antho. "*That's why we're here.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD BEEN FOUR days since the Stones.

Four days since Posy Tull and her blue dress with the lace at the cuffs. Four days since thirty-one children all over Caldor put their hands on the glass and saw their own faces. Four days since the Keepers started wrapping Stones in sacking and chains, and Seraphine started sending ravens, and the Queen sent word from Highcrest that no Kindling was to happen anywhere in the kingdom until further notice.

Four days since Lex came down the loft ladder at dawn with his eyes red-rimmed and his hands black at the fingertips, scorched, where he'd held fire in them all night with nowhere to put it.

He'd told Antho about the panel. In the forge. In a flat quiet voice, with his back turned, hammering a nail that didn't need hammering.

Hello, Smith.

Your daughter's hands are very square.

And his own face. Crowned. With every thread in the world coming out of his head like the rays of the sun.

I wonder if you'd give it away again.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Breathe*," said Antho.

"*I'm breathing*."

"*You're not. You're holding it and letting it out in little bits so I won't notice.*" Antho put his hand flat on his brother's chest. Over the bell. Over the place under the breastbone. "*Breathe. All the way. Like Teo's sea.*"

Lex breathed.

Antho felt it go in. All the way. And out.

"*Again*."

In. Out.

"*Again*."

In. Out. Slower. Antho felt the heart under his hand. Hammering. Then less.

"*Good*," said Antho. And knocked on the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T USE HIS fist. Not this time. He used two fingers. The way their father used to tap on a table. *Tap. Tap.*

The door listened.

He felt it listen. The way you feel a dog listen in the dark, its ears coming up. The black slab of night in front of him, cold, smooth, attending.

Who is it? said the door. Not in words.

Antho, he said. Not in words. *The Warden. And my brother.*

Where to?

Down, said Antho. *Not all the way. Not to the deep. To the dark. The starlit one. Where Shade lives.*

The door considered this.

Then it opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT WIDE. A CRACK. A slit of deeper dark in the dark, the width of a man. And through it, cold. Not the grey cold of the Ferryman's river. Not the white cold of the Stones. A *soft* cold. Like a cellar. Like a well at night. Like the hour before dawn in midsummer, when everything's still and the stars are out and nothing's moving and nothing needs to.

Antho took his brother's hand.

"*Keep them shut*," he said. "*All the way down. Don't open them till I say.*"

"*Antho—*"

"*Trust me*," said Antho Vey.

And led him through.

◆ ◆ ◆

DOWN.

Not stairs. Not a slope. Just *down*. The way you go down in a dream, without your feet doing anything. The dark closing over them like water. The lanterns of the Keep going away behind them, a long way up, small and gold, like the lights of a village seen from a mountain at night. Then gone.

Antho didn't need his eyes here.

He never had. Not in the mad years, when he'd come down here alone with a voice in his head that wanted to eat the world. Not in the

Wellworlds, or the deep, or the bottom of the world. The dark wasn't dark to him. It never had been. It was just another kind of room.

He could feel his brother's hand in his. Hot. Burned. A smith's hand. Gripping too hard.

"*It's all right*," he said.

"*I can't see anything*."

"*Your eyes are shut*."

"*I can't see anything through my eyelids*," said Lex. "*There's always something. Light. Red. Something. There's nothing.*"

"*I know*," said Antho. "*That's the point.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOPPED.

Antho felt them stop. Not hit the ground. There wasn't any ground. Just—*stopped*. The way a leaf stops when it's fallen to the bottom of a still pool.

He let go of his brother's hand.

Lex grabbed for it. Antho stepped back. Out of reach.

"*Antho—*"

"*Open your eyes*."

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD HIS BROTHER open his eyes.

He knew what he'd see. He'd seen it a hundred times. A thousand. The first time, at seventeen, a year after the fire, he'd lain on his back in it for three days and cried until he couldn't anymore.

Stars.

Not overhead. Everywhere. Above and below and on every side. Small and white and very far off, scattered across the black like frost on a window, like salt on a slate, like sparks going up a chimney and stopping, all at once, forever. Millions of them. No moon. No sun. No ground. No sky. Just the dark, soft and deep and endless, and the stars hanging in it.

And silence.

Not the silence of the grey snow at Westerling, where things had stopped. A *living* silence. The silence between heartbeats. The silence in a room after a song ends, before anyone claps. Full. Waiting.

Shade's dark.

The Well of absence. Of hush. Of the space between.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

Antho watched him. Hanging in the dark a yard off, turning slowly, his head going back, his mouth open, the starlight on his face. On the handprint. On his father's eyes.

"*Oh*," said Lex.

"*Yes*."

"*It's—*" He stopped. "*Antho, it's beautiful.*"

"*I know*."

"*You never said*."

"*You never asked*," said Antho. "*You've been coming down here for three years. Through me. Through the Bloodbond. Answering. And every time, you came down with your eyes screwed shut and your hands in fists, like a boy in a cellar.*" He shrugged. In the dark. "*You never once looked.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED. SLOWLY. IN the starlight. Looking.

"*It doesn't feel like Shade*," he said.

"*What does Shade feel like*?"

"*Cold. Quiet. The thing that takes the heat out of things.*" He looked at his hands. "*The opposite of me.*"

"*It's not the opposite of you*," said Antho. "*It's the room you're in.*"

Lex looked at him.

"*Hold up your hand*," said Antho. "*Make a light.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HELD UP HIS hand. And the fire came.

Small. He made it small. A flame in his palm the size of a candle-flame. White-gold. Steady.

It lit the dark.

A little. A circle. A yard across. His hand. His face. His coat. Antho, at the edge of it. And past that—

The stars.

Still there. Still shining. Small and white and far. Not drowned out. Not washed away by the flame. Just *there*. Round it. On every side.

"*Look at it*," said Antho.

Lex looked at the flame in his hand.

"*Now look at the dark round it*," said Antho.

Lex looked.

"*That's Shade*," said Antho. "*Not the cold. Not the quiet. Not the thing that puts the fire out.*" He came closer. Into the circle of light. "*The dark round the flame. That lets you see it. If the whole world were fire, you'd never see a candle.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE flame for a long time.

"*A lantern*," he said slowly.

"*A lantern's just a dark box with a light in it*," said Antho. "*A forge is a dark room with a fire in it. A window at night is a light in the dark, so someone coming home can find it.*" He looked at his brother. "*You've been making lanterns since you were eleven. You've hung one in every window at Harrow. You cut HERE in the base of one and TOO LATE in another.*" A pause. "*Every one of them's half Shade, Lex. You just never noticed the half that wasn't fire.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT.

There wasn't anything to sit on. They sat anyway. In the dark. Hanging in it. Cross-legged, side by side, with the stars all round them and the little flame in Lex's palm making its circle of light.

Antho didn't say anything.

He'd learned that. From their father, in the last year. From Pim, for seven years. From Seraphine, every day. Sometimes the best thing to say was nothing. Sometimes the best thing to do was sit beside someone in the dark and let them find what they'd come down for.

So he sat.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I saw myself*," said Lex. After a long time. "*In the panel. Crowned.*"

"*You told me*."

"*I wanted it*."

Antho didn't move.

"*Just for a breath*," said Lex. Very low. Looking at the flame. "*I saw my face with the net coming out of it. Every thread. And I thought—I could fix it. All of it. Wren's hand. Brannoc's. The bread. The boy in the field. The dead at the rim.*" He swallowed. "*I could reach down a thread and find a flame in a lantern and make it remember me.*"

"*I know*."

"*How do you know*?"

"*Because I'd want it too*," said Antho. "*I want it now. Just hearing you say it.*" He looked at his left hand. At the coin of gold on the back of it. In the starlight. "*I want it every time I look at this.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE coin.

"*Does it hurt*?"

"*No. It doesn't do anything. That's the worst of it.*" Antho turned his hand over. Back again. "*It's a place in me that's stopped. A door that won't open. I'm the Threshold Warden. I open doors. I opened the deep. I opened a breach a hundred miles wide by asking.*" He laughed. Short. "*I can't open a coin of gold on my own hand.*"

"*I'm sorry*."

"*Don't*," said Antho. "*Don't be sorry. Wren's right. You're always sorry.*" He looked at his brother. "*You looked at her fingers every day for six months like you'd put the gold there yourself. You look at this the same way. You look at Brannoc's. At Hask's arm.*" He shook his head. "*You didn't do it, Lex. He did. Orrin did. The grey country did. Nine hundred years of people did.*"

"*I know*."

"*Do you*?"

Lex didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT.

The flame in Lex's hand burned. Small. Steady. The stars hung round them.

"*I said no*," said Lex at last. "*In the loft. To the face. To the crown. I didn't think it. I felt it. Under here.*" He touched his chest. "*All the Wells at once. No.*"

"*Good*."

"*But I don't know if I'd say it again*." His voice was very quiet. "*If she showed me again. If I had to watch Lark put her hand on a Stone and see her own face. If the grey came up the Vale and over the hill and into the yard.*" He looked at the flame. "*If it was that or the crown.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

"*Father said no*," said Lex. "*For two hundred years. He had the Root. He could have done anything. And he said no, every day, and hid it, and got old.*" He swallowed. "*Elric said no. At the bottom of the world. With the whole net offering him everything. Not me. Not ever.*"

"*He had Hesper's crown on*," said Antho. "*It said it for him.*"

"*He said it too. I heard him.*"

"*I know*," said Antho. "*I was there.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I don't have a crown that says no*," said Lex. "*I just have me.*"

He looked at the flame. At the dark round it.

"*And Father's gone*," he said. "*And Ember's gone. And Elric. And everyone who ever said no and meant it.*" His voice cracked. "*There's nobody left to show me how.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LOOKED AT HIM.

At his little brother. Twenty-six. Burned. Grey-eyed. Holding a flame in his palm in the middle of the dark, with the stars all round him, saying *there's nobody left*.

He thought about a boy of eleven in a burning cottage. Screaming. *Antho*. *Antho*. With fire in the thatch and a door in the dark that Antho's broken power had torn open, and their mother walking into it.

He'd run. That night. Into the Greyspine. Mad. With a voice in his head. And left his little brother in the ashes.

For eight years.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Look at the dark*," said Antho.

"*What*?"

"*Not the flame. The dark. Round it.*" He leaned in. "*Look.*"

Lex looked.

"*What do you see*?"

"*Stars*."

"*Look closer*."

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED CLOSER.

Antho watched him do it. Watched him narrow his eyes. Watched him lean forward, past the little flame, into the dark beyond its circle. Watched him go still.

He'd seen it himself. The first time. At seventeen. Lying on his back for three days.

The stars weren't all stars.

◆ ◆ ◆

MOST OF THEM WERE. Small and white and far. Scattered across the black like frost.

But between them, here and there—scattered too, but fewer, much fewer—there were places where there were no stars.

Not darker. The dark was all the same dark. Just—*gaps*. Holes in the scatter of light. Small round places where a star should have been and wasn't. As if someone had reached into the frost on the window and pressed a fingertip against it, and left a clear round print.

Shapes.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What are they*?" said Lex. Barely a whisper.

"*What do you think they are*?"

Lex didn't answer. He was looking at one. Close. A yard off. Just past the edge of the flame's light. A gap in the stars. Round. The size of a man's head. Or—

Not round.

The size of a man. The shape of a man. A tall thin man, sitting. In a chair. With his hands folded. A gap in the stars exactly that shape.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*That's Father*," said Lex.

"*Yes*."

"*Antho—*"

"*It's where he was*," said Antho. "*That's all. Not him. He's gone. He went with the Ferryman. On the boat.*" He looked at the gap. At the shape of a man in a chair, made of no stars. "*It's the place he left. In the dark. When he went.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS SHAKING.

The flame in his hand guttered. Antho saw it. Saw it shrink. Go blue at the edges.

"*Don't*," said Antho. "*Don't let it go out. Hold it.*"

"*I can't—*"

"*Hold it. And look.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HELD IT.

He looked at the gap in the stars. At the shape. His father. Sitting. Hands folded. The way he'd sat in the wheeled chair by the west window at Harrow every morning for a year, with a cup of tea going cold beside him and his grey eyes on the birch wood.

The way he'd sat at the Spire, at his great desk, drawing the world from the inside with a pendulum.

The way he'd sat at the Hollowmaw, in front of the black door, for three years, with a lamp.

"*It's the same shape*," said Lex. Wondering. Hoarse. "*It's exactly the same. It's—*"

"*It's his shape*," said Antho. "*The shape he made in the world. In the dark. By being in it.*" He looked round. At the other gaps. Scattered. Few. Here and there among the stars. "*Everyone leaves one. When they go. A place where they were.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SHOWED HIM.

The others. Moving through the dark, the two of them, slowly, with the little flame in Lex's palm making its circle of light. Past the gaps.

A big one. Huge. The shape of a giant, kneeling. *Dorran*. Who'd carried the weight of the Wellworld of Stone for them and died with Ilse and Ivo's forgiveness in his ears.

A square one. Broad-shouldered. A man with a sword, standing. *Garrick*. In the breach at Duskhold. Seven years ago.

A small one. Very small. A little bent man, barefoot, laughing—you could see the laugh, somehow, in the shape of the gap, in the tilt of the head. *Malachi*.

A woman with a staff. *Kell*.

A man in a cloak, with a bird on his shoulder. Grey. The gap faintly grey at its edges, the way the cloak had been. *Elric*.

And one more. Very small. Just a bump in the stars. Round. Like a coal. Like an ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOPPED.

He hung in the dark in front of it with the flame in his palm and looked at it.

A small round gap in the stars. The size of a coal. The size of a piece of a man the size of an ember, pressed into a sleeping boy's blood like a maker's mark.

"*That's—*"

"*Yes.*"

"*But it's not gone,*" said Lex. "*It's not dead. It's in the lantern. In the Ferryman's—*"

"*It's not here,*" said Antho. "*It used to be here. In you. And now it isn't.*" He looked at the little gap. "*That's all an absence is, Lex. A place where something used to be.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT IT for a long, long time.

Then he did something Antho didn't expect.

He reached out.

With his free hand. His right. Not the one with the flame. He reached out into the dark, past the edge of the light, toward the little round gap in the stars. And put his fingertips against it.

Against nothing. Against the shape of a coal.

And held them there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's a mould*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T UNDERSTAND.

"*It's a mould*," said Lex again. Louder. Wondering. He was looking at his fingertips. At the gap. "*Antho. Look. It's the shape of it. Exactly. Every edge. Like a mould is the shape of what you're going to cast. Like a hollow in sand.*"

He turned. In the dark. With the flame in one hand and the other still out, touching the little gap.

"*You make a mould*," he said. Fast. The way he talked about iron. "*You press the thing into sand. Or clay. You take it out. And there's a hole. A gap. The exact shape of what was there.*" He looked at the gap. "*And then you pour. Fire. Metal. Whatever you're making. And it fills the gap. And it takes the shape.*"

"*Lex—*"

"*That's what these are*," said Lex. He looked round. At all the gaps. Dorran. Garrick. Malachi. Kell. Elric. His father. "*They're not just holes. They're moulds. The shape of everyone who was here. In the dark. Kept. Not kept. Held.*" His voice cracked. "*So you can see what they were. So you can make something in their shape.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STARED AT HIM.

He'd come down here for seven years. He'd lain in the dark for three days at seventeen and looked at the gaps in the stars and cried until he

couldn't. He'd come back a hundred times since and floated among them and thought *that's where they were. That's what's left.*

He'd never once thought *mould.*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Every new thing needs somewhere to be*," said Lex. Quietly now. "*That's Hollow. That's room. Wren taught me. A womb's a room. A mould's a room.*" He looked at the little gap under his fingertips. "*But a mould's a dark room, Antho. It's always dark. It has to be. You can't cast anything in the light. You cast it in the sand, in the dark, in the shape of something that was there and isn't.*"

He looked at his brother.

"*Shade's not the opposite of fire*," said Lex Vey. "*Shade's the mould.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DARK CHANGED.

Antho felt it. All round them. The stars. The silence. The soft endless cold. It didn't move. It didn't brighten. Nothing so obvious.

It *listened.*

The way the door at the Keep had listened when he tapped on it. The way Ashka listened when he whistled. The whole of Shade's dark—the Well of absence, of hush, of the space between—turning toward his brother.

Attending.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CLOSED HIS HAND.

Not on the gap. You couldn't close a hand on nothing. He closed it round the flame. The other one. The small white-gold fire in his left palm. Folded his fingers over it.

And the light went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

DARK. ALL ROUND. TOTAL. The stars. The gaps. His brother, a yard off, invisible now.

Antho waited.

He heard Lex breathe. In. Out. In the dark. Slow. The way he'd breathed at the door, with Antho's hand on his chest. Like Teo's sea.

Out. And back.

And then—

◆ ◆ ◆

LIGHT.

Not from Lex's hand. From *everywhere*. From the gaps.

Antho saw it. He saw it and didn't believe it. All round them, in the dark, in the scatter of stars—the gaps. The shapes. The places where people had been. Dorran. Garrick. Malachi. Kell. Elric. Their father.

Glowing.

Faintly. Gold. From inside. The way a mould glows when the metal's just been poured. The way sand glows round a casting in the dark of a foundry. Each shape filled, for a moment, with a soft warm light, exactly its own shape, every edge. A giant kneeling. A man with a sword. A little laughing barefoot man. A woman with a staff. A man with a bird.

A man in a chair. With his hands folded.

And a small round coal.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT LASTED A BREATH.

Then it faded. Gently. The gold going out of the shapes the way heat goes out of iron. Back to dark. Back to gaps in the stars.

But they weren't just gaps anymore.

Antho could see it now. He'd never seen it before. He'd never *looked*. Every one of them had an edge. A clean, sharp, careful edge. Like the inside of a mould. Like the hollow a hand leaves in clay. Shaped. Kept—not kept. *Held*. By the dark. So that whatever had been there could be seen, and remembered, and—

Made again. In its shape.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ATTUNEMENT — SHADE
ANSWERING → SPEAKING
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◆ ◆ ◆

LEX OPENED HIS HAND. The flame came back. Small. White-gold. In his palm.

His face in the light of it was wet.

"*Oh*," he said. Faintly.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ATTUNEMENT — SHADE
SPEAKING → COMMANDING
"Every mould is a dark."
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE STARED AT THE panel. Silver-blue. Hanging in the dark in front of him where only he could see it.

Antho could see it. Through the Bloodbond. Faintly. The way you see a candle through a curtain.

Commanding.

Two stages. In one breath. In the dark. With his hand out to a gap in the stars the shape of an ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You skipped one*," said Antho. His voice wasn't steady.

Lex looked at him.

"*Speaking*," said Antho. "*You went straight through it. Nobody does that. Malachi said nobody does that. You have to stay at each one. Seasons. Years. You have to—*"

"*I had a good teacher*," said Lex.

Antho couldn't speak.

He hung in the dark with the stars all round him and his little brother in front of him, with a flame in his palm and wet on his face, and couldn't say anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ANTHO VEY
THRESHOLD WARDEN — Level 96 → 97
"Showed someone the dark."
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAUGHED.

He didn't mean to. It came out of him cracked and wet and sudden, the way their mother's laugh came out. He put his scarred hands over his face and laughed into them.

"*What*?" said Lex.

"*Nothing*," said Antho. Through his fingers. "*Nothing. Showed someone the dark. That's all it says. That's the reason. Seven years down here, and that's what it gives me a level for.*"

"*It's a good reason*."

"*It's a terrible reason*," said Antho. "*It's the best reason I've ever had.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT UP.

Slowly. Through the dark. Hand in hand. Not because Lex needed leading. Because neither of them wanted to let go.

Past the stars. Past the gaps. Past the shape of a man in a chair.

Lex stopped, there. For a moment. And put his hand out. And touched the edge of it. The clean, careful edge of the place where their father had been.

He didn't say anything.

Then they went on.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LANTERNS OF THE Keep came back overhead. Small and gold. One thousand one hundred and thirteen. Like a village seen from a mountain at night.

The black door. The crack of grey cave-light. The hook with the last three lanterns. Clay. Iron. Tin.

They stepped through.

And the door closed behind them. Gently. The way a door closes in a house where everyone's asleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS WAITING.

At the back of the cave. By the last lanterns. With her coat on and her spectacles pushed up on her head and a raven on her shoulder. Not Quill. One of the Keepers' birds. Black. Ruffled. Furious at being indoors.

Her face was white.

"*How long*?" said Antho.

"*A day*," said Seraphine. "*And a night. You've been gone a day and a night.*" She looked at Lex. At his face. At whatever was in it. "*Did it—*"

"*Yes*," said Lex.

"*Commanding*?"

"*Commanding*."

She closed her eyes. Just for a moment. Then opened them.

"*Good*," she said. "*Good. Because this came. Two hours ago.*" She held out a paper. Small. Tied with black thread. "*From Hask.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO TOOK IT.

Hask's hand. Big. Square. Pressing too hard. A miner's hand, that had learned its letters late and never liked them.

Five lines.

◆ ◆ ◆

Grey's spread. A mile out from the rim now. All round.

Grass is grey under the snow. The new river's stopped. Not frozen. Stopped.

Kit went to fetch water from it this morning and the bucket came up and the water in it didn't move.

Mal's stopped talking. Ivy's been on the rim two days. Won't come in. Says she can't hear it anymore.

Come.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO READ IT TWICE.

He looked at his brother.

Lex was looking at the paper. At the five lines. At *Mal's stopped talking*.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't reach for fire. He didn't clench his hands. He didn't turn away.

He looked at the paper. And at the lanterns. All of them. One thousand one hundred and thirteen. Burning on nothing, gold and small, from the black door to the mouth of the cave.

Lights in the dark.

Every one of them half Shade.

"*Get Mam*," said Lex Vey. "*It's time she taught me Radiance.*"

CHAPTER 13

One Thousand One Hundred and Thirteen

HIS MOTHER CAME UP the mountain on the dragon at noon, in her grey shawl, with the grey book under her arm and a basket on her hip and a face like a woman who'd been sent for and had come but didn't approve of being sent for.

"*You could have walked down*," she said. Sliding off Ashka's back into the snow at the mouth of the cave. "*It's downhill.*"

"*I needed the lanterns*," said Lex.

His mother looked past him. Into the cave.

At the lanterns. All of them. Gold and small and burning on nothing, from the mouth of the cave all the way back into the dark, on hooks and nails and iron pins driven into the stone. One thousand one hundred and thirteen. Iron and brass and tin and clay and horn and glass.

She'd walked past them once. Two winters ago. Out of the dark. Through the black door at the end. Past every one. And every one she passed had lit, one by one, the ones a moth had darkened, relighting as she went. She didn't remember it. She'd told Lex that. She'd been looking at an old man in a chair at the mouth of the cave, and nothing else.

She looked at them now.

"*Oh*," said Seren Harrow. Very quietly.

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"*Radiance*," said Lex.

They were sitting on the floor of the cave. Halfway down. Among the lanterns. On a sheepskin Antho had brought from the alcove. His mother cross-legged, with the basket beside her and the grey book in her lap. Lex opposite. With his hands on his knees.

"*Radiance*," agreed his mother.

"*You said you could teach me*."

"*I said I'd try*." She looked at the lanterns. Hanging over them. On the walls. All round. Gold light on her face, on her brown eyes, on the grey in her hair. "*I don't know how to teach it. I've never taught anyone anything except your brother to read and you to eat porridge.*"

"*You gave it. At the Heart. When I forged the net.*"

"*I was a voice in the dark*," said Seren. "*Singing. Flat on the high note. I didn't know what I was doing.*" She turned the grey book over in her hands. "*I just knew you needed light. And I had some. So I gave it.*"

Lex looked at her.

"*That's it*," he said.

"*What's it*?"

"*That's Radiance*." He leaned forward. "*You just told me. You had some. So you gave it.*"

His mother looked at him for a long time.

"*It's not that simple*," she said.

"*Nothing is*."

"*No*," said Seren. "*But that's not simple in a different way.*"

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SHE OPENED THE BASKET.

Inside, wrapped in a cloth, a lamp. Clay. Small. Round-bellied. With a spout for the wick and a handle like a thumb-loop. Old. Lopsided. Too thick in the walls. With a thumb-print pressed into the rim where someone had held it too hard while it was wet.

Lex knew it.

He'd seen it on a hook at the end of this cave, by the black door, for three years. He'd seen it in his brother's hands in the deep. He'd seen it in the Blightmarch, held up by his mother in front of a Moth Queen.

"*My mother made it*," said Seren. "*Wenna. For your father. The first winter. She didn't like him. She made him a lamp anyway.*" She turned it in her hands. "*She said a man who's going to marry a Harrow girl ought to have something to see by. In case she leaves.*"

"*It was on the hook*," said Lex. "*At the end. By the door.*"

"*Your brother gave it back to me*," said Seren. "*Yesterday. When you were in the dark.*" She held it up. Empty. Unlit. "*He said you'd want it. For this.*"

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SHE HELD IT OUT.

To him. Across the sheepskin. In both hands.

"*Light it*," she said.

He took it. He held it in his left hand. He held his right hand over the spout, where the wick was—old, black, a twist of cotton—and let the fire come up.

Small. Gold. The way it came every morning when he knelt at the hearth.

The wick caught.

The lamp lit.

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"*Now give it to me*," said his mother.

He held it out.

She didn't take it.

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HE HELD IT THERE. In the air between them. In his left hand. Lit. Small. Gold.

His mother looked at it. Didn't move.

"*Mam—*"

"*You're not giving it*," said Seren. "*You're holding it out.*"

"*It's the same thing.*"

"*It's not.*" She folded her hands in her lap. "*You're holding it out the way you'd hold out a hammer to someone in the forge. Here, take this, I'll want it back in a minute.*" She looked at his hand. At his fingers round the clay.

"*Your hand's still on it. Look. You've got the handle. You're waiting for me to take it so you can let go.*"

He looked at his hand.

She was right. His fingers were round the thumb-loop. Firm. Holding.

"*So let go*," he said.

"*If I take it*," said his mother, "*you're not giving it. I'm taking it. That's a different thing.*" She didn't move her hands from her lap. "*Give it to me.*"

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HE DIDN'T UNDERSTAND.

He sat on the sheepskin with the little clay lamp in his hand, lit, held out, and his mother looking at him, and didn't understand at all.

"*How*?" he said. "*How do I give it if you won't take it?*"

"*Put it down*," said Seren.

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HE LOOKED AT HER.

"*In front of me*," she said. "*On the sheepskin. And take your hand away. And don't watch to see if I pick it up.*" She looked at him. Brown eyes. Steady. "*That's giving. You put it down. For someone. And you go.*"

He looked at the lamp.

He set it down. On the sheepskin. In front of her knees.

And took his hand away.

And looked at her.

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"*You're watching*," said his mother.

"*Mam—*"

"*You're watching it*," said Seren. "*And me. To see if I'll pick it up. To see if I like it. To see if I'm grateful.*" She shook her head. "*That's not giving. That's lending with your eyes.*"

He looked away.

At the wall. At a lantern on a hook. Tin. Battered. With a name scratched in the base that he couldn't read from here.

His mother didn't say anything.

He looked at the lantern on the wall. He made himself. He didn't look at the clay lamp on the sheepskin. He didn't look at his mother.

He felt it. He felt the lamp there. On the sheepskin. Small. Lit. *His*. His fire. He'd lit it. He felt the fire in it the way you feel your own hand. His. On the sheepskin. In front of someone else.

And he felt himself wanting to turn and look.

To see if she'd taken it. To see if it was still lit. To see if she liked it.

Lending with your eyes.

He didn't look.

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HE SAT THERE A long time.

And slowly—very slowly—the feeling changed.

Not went. *Changed*. The way iron changes colour in the fire. Not all at once. From the edges in.

The fire in the lamp was still his. He could still feel it. But it wasn't *on* him anymore. It wasn't a hand he'd left behind on the sheepskin. It was—

Out.

Somewhere else. In front of someone else. Doing what fire does. Burning. Lighting. Being looked at, or not.

Not his business anymore.

Out.

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"*There*," said his mother. Very softly.

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ATTUNEMENT — RADIANCE
ANSWERING → SPEAKING
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HE LOOKED AT IT. The panel. Silver-blue. Hanging over the sheepskin in the gold light of eleven hundred lanterns.

Then he looked at his mother.

She hadn't picked up the lamp. It was still on the sheepskin. In front of her knees. Small. Lit. Gold.

She was crying.

Not much. Not loudly. Harrow women don't cry. Two tears. One on each cheek. In the lantern light.

"*Mam*?"

"*He did that*," said Seren. "*Every morning. For a year and a half. Your father.*" She looked at the lamp. "*Good morning, Seren. And he'd put down a cup of tea in front of me. On the table. And look away. Out of the window. At the birch wood.*" She wiped her face. "*He never watched to see if I drank it. Never once. I thought he was shy.*"

She looked at Lex.

"*He wasn't shy*," she said. "*He was giving it to me.*"

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THEY SAT FOR A while.

The lamp burned on the sheepskin. Small. Gold. Nobody's.

"*Speaking*," said Lex at last. "*Not Commanding.*"

"*I know*."

"*How do I—*"

"*I don't know*," said his mother. "*I told you. I don't know how to teach it. I only know what I know.*" She looked round. At the lanterns. On every wall. All the way back into the dark. "*But I'll tell you what my mother told me. The first night I was old enough to hold a lamp.*"

Lex waited.

"*She said, never leave a light on*," said Seren. "*Not for yourself. Not in your own window. Never. A light you keep for yourself is a light that calls. Moths come to it. Things come to it. Things that want what you've got.*"

"*I know. The rule.*"

"*That's half the rule*," said his mother. "*Everyone knows that half. Never leave a light on. Never let a moth in.*" She reached out. Not for the lamp. For the grey book in her lap. Opened it. To a page near the back. Not Arion's hand. Hers. Small and quick and slanting, written in the spring. "*Nobody remembers the other half.*"

She read it.

"*Never leave a light on for yourself*," she read. "*But never, ever go past a dark window without leaving one there.*"

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LEX STARED AT HER.

"*Thirty houses*," said Seren. "*Twenty generations. Never a light in our own windows. Not once.*" She closed the book. "*And in every village we ever lived in, every winter, on the Lady's night, my mother went out after dark with a basket of clay lamps. Lamps she'd made herself all autumn. And she went down the lane, and up the lane, and round the green. And every window that was dark—every house where someone had died that year, or gone away, or couldn't afford the oil—she left one. On the sill. Lit.*"

She looked at the clay lamp on the sheepskin.

"*And walked on*," she said. "*And never looked back to see who took it in.*"

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"*That's why the moths couldn't drink them*," said Lex slowly.

"*That's why*."

"*Because they were given*."

"*Because they weren't anyone's*," said his mother. "*A light you keep is yours, and a moth can take what's yours. A light you give isn't yours anymore. It's not the person's you gave it to, either, not yet, not till they pick it up. It's just—*" She spread her hands. "*Out. In between. A light in a window for whoever needs it. And nothing can take it, because nobody owns it.*"

She looked round at the cave. At the eleven hundred lanterns.

"*Your brother's been giving these away for seven years*," she said. "*Every one of them. To people who never came home. He never once thought they were his.*" She smiled. "*That's why they burn on nothing.*"

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LEX LOOKED AT THE lanterns.

All of them. On every wall. Gold. Small. Steady.

Out.

"*The grey drinks*," he said. "*Room. Out of everything. Out of anything it can reach.*" He looked at his mother. "*It's like the moths. It's empty, and it drinks.*"

"*Yes*."

"*So it can't drink a light that's given*."

"*I don't know*," said Seren Harrow. "*I've never seen the grey. I've only seen moths.*" She looked at him. "*But I think a light that's given makes its own room. Round it. I think that's what giving is. Making room for someone else.*"

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HE STOOD UP.

He walked to the nearest wall. To a lantern on a hook. Tin. Battered. The one he'd been looking at. He lifted it off the hook. Turned it over. Read the name scratched in the base.

For Hob Tanner, it said. *Who went to the mines and didn't come back. From his sister.*

He held it.

He felt it. The light in it. Gold. Small. Burning on nothing. Not his. Never his. Not Antho's, even. Not Hob Tanner's sister's, anymore. *Out*. Given. A light in a window for whoever needed it.

He looked down the cave.

One thousand one hundred and thirteen.

"*Mam*," he said. "*How far do you think these would stretch?*"

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ANTHO DIDN'T WANT TO.

Lex saw it in his face. When he came down from the cave mouth at dusk with Seraphine and found his brother and his mother standing in the middle of the cave with a tin lantern, talking about *how many* and *how far* and *carts*.

His face went still.

He didn't say anything for a long time. He stood in the cave he'd lived in for seven years, alone and then not, with the lanterns he'd hung one by one on every wall. Counting them every morning. Walking down the long cave with his hands behind his back, looking up. The way their father walked the ledgers. The way you'd walk a line of sleeping children.

"*All of them*," he said.

"*As many as we can carry*," said Lex.

"*They're for the lost*," said Antho. "*For the ones who didn't come home.*"

"*I know*."

"*Hob Tanner*." Antho looked at the tin lantern in Lex's hand. "*Went down the Coldwater mines in the Gloam years and never came up. His sister walked here from Vhessa. Two hundred miles. In winter. To hang that.*" His voice wasn't steady. "*She stood where you're standing and hung it on that hook and said, now he's got a light. Now he'll find his way.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*They're not mine*," said Antho. "*None of them. I've never thought they were mine. I just—*" He stopped.

"*Keep them*," said Seraphine. Softly. Beside him. "*You keep them.*"

Antho looked at her.

"*You do*," she said. "*You don't own them. You keep them. Like a keeper keeps a light. Every morning. One by one.*" She put her hand on his arm. "*Antho. Love. That's what a keeper's for. To keep them till they're needed.*"

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ANTHO LOOKED AT THE lanterns for a long time.

At all of them. On every wall. All the way back to the black door.

"*The grey's at Westerling*," said Lex. Quietly. "*And it's round Mal. A mile out from the rim. The river's stopped. Mal's stopped talking.*" He held up the tin lantern. "*These are given. Every one. They've been given for years. They're the most given lights in the world.*"

His brother didn't answer.

"*Hob Tanner's sister hung a light so he could find his way home*," said Lex. "*There are thousands of people at Mal's rim who can't find their way home either. Nine hundred years. With no light at all.*"

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ANTHO CLOSED HIS EYES.

He stood like that a long time. In the middle of the cave. With his scarred hands at his sides and the gold light on his face.

Then he opened them.

"*Half to Mal*," he said. "*Half to the west.*" He looked at Lex. "*And I count them out. Every one. And I count them back. When it's over. Every one I can.*"

"*Every one you can*," said Lex.

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IT TOOK TWO DAYS to take them down.

All of them. Every lantern on every hook. One by one. Antho did it himself, on the ladder, with Seraphine below him taking each one and passing it to Lex, and Lex passing it to their mother, and their mother wrapping it in straw and setting it in a crate. Brannoc came up from Ashbourne with a cart, and Tilda with another, and Hedda, and Benno from the Crooked Kettle with his dray, and half the Forge.

Antho counted.

Out loud. Every one. As he lifted it off its hook. *One. Two. Three.* In a flat steady voice. Not stopping. Not hurrying. Reading the names scratched in the bases, sometimes. *For Hob Tanner. For Mother. For the Pell twins. For Wat Fuller, who went over the pass and didn't come back. For anyone.*

Five hundred and fifty-six. Five hundred and fifty-seven.

His voice didn't change. Not once.

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THE CAVE GOT DARKER.

That was the thing. Lex hadn't thought about it. With every lantern that came down, the cave got a little darker. A little colder. The gold light going back and back, from the mouth toward the door, like a tide going out.

By the second evening there were only three left.

On the hook. By the black door. At the end. Clay. Iron. Tin.

Antho stood in front of them for a long time.

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THE CLAY ONE WAS gone already. Their mother had it. Wenna's lamp. She'd carry it west.

The iron one. *ARDENT*. Lex's. He'd hung it there the night before the double wedding, two winters ago, with his hands shaking, beside his father's.

And the tin one. Plain. Small. Battered. Their father had hung it. The same night. The night before the weddings. When a message shone on the

black door from the far side—*Leave a light on, I'm coming home, but not alone*—and Arion Vey lifted a tin lantern off the table where he'd been keeping it for three years and hung it on the hook and said *one thousand one hundred and thirteen*, very quietly, to nobody.

Antho lifted the iron one off the hook. *ARDENT*. Handed it down to Lex.

Then he looked at the tin one.

He didn't touch it.

"*Not this one*," he said.

Lex looked at him.

"*This one stays*," said Antho. "*Here. On the hook. By the door.*" His voice was flat. Steady. "*For him. Someone has to keep one for him.*"

Lex didn't argue.

He looked at the tin lantern. Small. Plain. Battered. Burning on nothing. On a hook by a black door at the end of an empty cave.

One thousand one hundred and thirteen.

"*Yes*," he said. "*Someone does.*"

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THEY SPLIT THEM AT the foot of the mountain.

Five hundred and fifty-six east. To Mal. Antho and Seraphine, on Ashka, with as many as the dragon could carry slung in nets on either side, and the rest following by cart on the long road across the Vale to the green circle.

Five hundred and fifty-six west. To the grey. Lex and his mother and Brannoc and Tilda and half the Forge, by cart, by horse, by anything that would roll, on the road to Westerling.

And one on a hook in an empty cave.

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ANTHO CAME TO LEX at the parting. At dawn. In the snow. With the dragon loaded behind him, swaying under the nets, and the gold light of five hundred lanterns glowing through the straw.

He didn't say anything.

He put his hand on Lex's shoulder. And held it there. And looked at him. With their mother's brown eyes.

Then he got on the dragon and flew east.

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IT TOOK SIX DAYS to get the lanterns to Westerling.

Lex didn't remember most of it. The road. The snow. The carts. The villages they passed through, where people came out of their doors and stood in the snow and watched them go by. Cart after cart. Every one glowing. Gold through the straw. Five hundred and fifty-six lanterns going west.

At Hobb's Cross a woman stopped them. In the square. With a lantern of her own. Iron. Old. Lit.

"*For the line*," she said. Holding it up. "*Whatever you're doing. I heard. For the line.*"

Lex looked at her.

"*It has to be given*," he said. "*Not lent. You put it down and you walk away and you don't come back for it.*"

"*I know*," said the woman. "*My grandmother was a Harrow.*" She set it in the cart. On top of the straw. And walked away.

She didn't look back.

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AT THE NEXT VILLAGE, three more.

At the next, eleven.

By the time they came over the last hill and saw Westerling below them in the snow, with its smoke going up and Marta Fell's bakehouse at the end of the west road, there were seven hundred and twelve.

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THE GREY WAS PAST Westerling now.

Lex could feel it. From the top of the hill. Coming down into the village. The faint soft endless pull, west. The room going out of everything. Out of the snow and the hedges and the roofs and the smoke. Out of him.

Elowen's stakes. White-topped. In lines. Across the fields. Past the village. East of it now. A mile east. More.

Bet Arley's bakehouse, six doors east of Marta Fell's, had no smoke.

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THEY SET THE LANTERNS at the edge of it.

All of them. Along the newest line of stakes. North and south. A lantern every hundred paces. Then every fifty. Every twenty. As far as they had lanterns. A long line of small gold lights in the snow, running away across the fields in both directions, over the hills, out of sight.

Lex set the first.

He took it out of the straw. Tin. Battered. *For Hob Tanner, who went to the mines and didn't come back. From his sister.* He knelt in the snow by yesterday's stake. And set it down. On the ground. Lit.

And took his hand away.

And stood up.

And walked away.

He didn't look back.

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HE FELT IT, THOUGH.

Behind him. He didn't need to look. He felt it the way he'd felt the clay lamp on the sheepskin. A light. Out. Given. Not his. Not anyone's.

And round it—

Room.

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HE STOPPED.

He turned round.

He looked.

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THE LANTERN STOOD IN the snow by the stake. Small. Gold. Burning on nothing.

And round it, in a circle—a yard across, no more—the snow was white.

Not grey. Not the flat finished painting-snow of the grey country, lying there with the wind going past it. *White*. Soft. Real. A little drift on the windward side of the lantern, where the wind had pushed it. A few flakes, falling, landing, settling.

He could hear it. The wind. In the circle. On the lantern's tin sides. A small sound. A whisper.

Outside the circle, silence.

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"*Oh*," said his mother. Beside him. "*Oh, look.*"

All along the line. North. South. As far as he could see. Every lantern. A small circle of white snow round it. A yard across. And in each circle, the wind. Moving. And the snow, falling. And the room, *there*. Held. Not drunk. Not going west.

A line of small gold lights in the snow, each one in its own circle of real winter, running away over the hills.

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IT WASN'T ENOUGH.

He could see that. A yard. A yard of room round each lantern. And between them, the grey. Flat. Still. Drinking. The line wasn't a wall. It was a string of beads.

But the grey wasn't going *past* them.

He felt it. The soft endless pull. Coming east. Reaching the line. Reaching the lanterns. And slowing. Like a tide coming up a beach and meeting a row of stones. Not stopping. *Slowing*. Going round. Taking longer.

"*It's not enough*," he said.

"*No*," said his mother.

"*It's slowing it. But it's not enough.*"

"*Nothing ever is*," said Seren Harrow. "*You do it anyway.*"

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THEY WENT TO THE field at dusk.

Lex and his mother. Alone. Along the old road, nine miles west, into the grey, past the empty farms and the silent mill and the stakes crowding closer and closer together. To the last hill.

And over it.

The gold field. Forty sheep. A hawk pinned to the sky. A boy with his crook out. Snow on all of it, white over gold, glowing through.

And on the grey ground at the edge, on a three-legged stool, in a shawl and a horse-blanket and Wren's scarf, with Elowen's lantern beside her and her basket at her feet—

Nan Ashby. Talking.

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"—*and the smith's back*," she was saying. "*With his mother this time. She's got a face like a Harrow. I can hear them breathing. I expect they want to look at you.*" A pause. "*Everyone wants to look at you.*"

Lex stopped at the edge of the field.

He'd brought one lantern.

Not from the carts. From home. From Harrow. He'd taken it off the sill in the east window on the morning they left, while Wren watched from the bottom of the loft ladder with Lark on her hip and didn't say anything.

Iron. Small. Plain. With one word cut into the base where only someone who picked it up would see it.

HERE.

He'd lit it with his own fire on the first night home from the Blightmarch. Two winters ago. It had never gone out. It wasn't waiting for anyone. It was just there. For whoever was in the room.

It was the first thing he'd ever made that he'd wanted to keep.

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HE WALKED ACROSS THE grey to Nan Ashby's stool.

She didn't turn round. She went on talking. About the hens. About the byre roof. About Bet Arley's bakehouse, which had gone cold that morning.

He knelt down beside her.

He set the lantern on the grey ground. Between her stool and the edge of the gold. Between her and her son.

And took his hand away.

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HE DIDN'T LOOK AT it.

He looked at the boy. At Col Ashby. Gold. Fourteen. Mid-step. With his crook out and snow on his cap. His eyes moving. To his mother. To Lex. To the lantern.

Lex didn't look at it.

He felt it. *HERE*. His. His first. Two winters lit. The one he'd never given anyone. The one he'd hung in his own window, against every rule his mother's family had kept for twenty generations, because he'd wanted something in his own window that was his.

On the grey ground. In front of someone else.

Lending with your eyes.

He didn't look.

He got up. And turned round. And walked away. Back across the grey. Toward his mother, standing at the edge of the field in her grey shawl with her hands folded.

He didn't look back.

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AND BEHIND HIM, HE felt it go.

Not the light. The *his*. The way the iron had felt in the cave, on the sheepskin, with his mother not picking it up. From the edges in. Like colour going out of iron in the quench.

Out.

Not his.

Not Nan Ashby's. Not Col's. Not anyone's.

HERE. A light in the dark, for whoever was in the room.

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ATTUNEMENT — RADIANCE
SPEAKING → COMMANDING
"A light in a window for whoever needs it."
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HE DIDN'T STOP WALKING.

He walked across the grey to his mother. And she looked past him. Over his shoulder. At the field.

And her face changed.

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HE TURNED ROUND.

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THE LANTERN STOOD ON the grey ground between Nan Ashby's stool and the edge of the gold.

And round it, white.

Not a yard. *More*. A circle of real snow, soft and white and falling, spreading out from the little iron lantern across the grey like ripples across a pond. Two yards. Three. Five. Under Nan Ashby's stool. Round her feet. Round her basket.

And past her.

Over the edge of the grey. Onto the gold.

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IT DIDN'T TOUCH THE gold. It couldn't. The gold was kept. Finished. A door with nothing behind it.

But it went *round*. The white. The room. The real falling snow. Round the edge of the field. Round the gold grass. Round the forty sheep and the hedge and the boy. Like water going round a stone in a stream. Like light going round a figure in a doorway.

And the snow on the gold—the white snow lying on the gold boy's cap, on his shoulders, on his outstretched crook—

Moved.

A little. A drift. The wind. *Real* wind. In the field. For the first time since the spring. Lifting the snow off the boy's shoulders and carrying it away.

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NAN ASHBY STOPPED TALKING.

She sat on her stool in a circle of falling snow with a little iron lantern at her feet and her son in front of her, gold, mid-step. And the wind came round her and lifted the snow off his cap. And she watched it.

Then she turned round.

On her stool. For the first time. All the way round. And looked at Lex. Across the white.

Her eyes were very bright and very wet.

"*Smith*," she said.

He didn't say anything.

"*It's not him*," said Nan Ashby. "*I know it's not. It's not him moving.*" She looked back at her son. At the snow blowing off his shoulders. "*But it's the first thing that's moved in that field since a Tuesday in the spring.*"

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THEY LEFT HER THERE.

They had to. She wouldn't come. She sat on her stool in her circle of real winter with the lantern at her feet and talked to her son, and the wind went round them both.

Lex didn't look back.

His mother did. Once. From the top of the hill.

"*What does it say*?" she said. "*On the base. I didn't see.*"

"*Here*," said Lex.

His mother was quiet for a long time.

"*It's the right word*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO'S RAVEN FOUND THEM at Greyfall.

At midnight. In the empty tower, with Roole in the gate below, gold, with a lantern at his feet that Elowen had put there. The bird came in through the arrow-slit with snow on its wings and a paper on its leg and a temper like a wet cat.

Lex unrolled it by the light of his own palm.

Antho's hand. Neat. Quick. Slanting. The hand of a man who'd learned his letters from his mother at four and from forbidden books in a cave at twenty.

◆ ◆ ◆

Lanterns round the rim. All 556. In a ring. A mile out. Where the grey was.

It's stopped. The grey. It's not going back. But it's stopped.

The river's moving again. Kit cried.

Mal's talking. Very small. Very tired. But talking. It said thank you. It said it can breathe.

It said it's still too little.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX READ IT TWICE. Then he read the next part. Below. In a different hand. Smaller. Square. Careful. A boy's hand, that had only learned its letters in the last four years.

◆ ◆ ◆

Gone to fetch Ilda.

And the thorn lady. She asked for help.

Back when I can.

Don't follow. You need to do the door.

P.

CHAPTER 14

Back Down the White Road

PIM DIDN'T LIKE TALKING.

It wasn't that he couldn't. He could now. He'd been able to for four years, since the winter at the Keep when Antho played the flute and something in Pim's chest that had been shut since before he could remember came open a crack and a word came out. *Come back*. That was the first one. He'd said it to Antho, on the mountain, in the snow.

He'd said a lot of words since. Hundreds. Thousands, maybe.

He still didn't like it.

Words were loud. They went out of you and into the air and you couldn't get them back. They took up room. And Pim had spent twelve years learning how to take up no room at all.

So he didn't talk much.

He left notes instead.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LEFT ONE ON the rim of the pool. Under a stone. For Antho. *Gone to fetch Ilda. And the thorn lady. She asked for help.* He thought about it for a long time and then added *Back when I can*. And then, because he knew Antho, and he knew Lex, *Don't follow. You need to do the door.*

He signed it. *P.*

Then he picked up his pack and his stick and three of Ivy's Hush-cups wrapped in wool and walked out of the green circle in the dark, west, on foot.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE GOT ELEVEN MILES.

Then a cart came up behind him on the road. A Coldwater cart. Big. With two horses. And on the box, a big grey-bearded man with a gold arm in a sling and a dead woman's staff across his knees. And beside him a thin solemn boy of nineteen with coal-dust in the creases of his knuckles.

The cart stopped.

Pim stopped.

Hask looked down at him from the box. For a long time. Breathing. The catch at the bottom of it.

"*Get in*," said Silas Hask.

Pim didn't move.

"*You left a note*," said Hask. "*Under a stone. On the rim.*" He shifted on the box. "*Ivy found it. Ivy came and found me. Ivy said, he's gone west on his own, and I said, he's fifteen, and Ivy hit me with her crutch.*"

Kit snorted.

"*So get in*," said Hask.

"*The note said don't follow*," said Pim.

"*The note said the smith shouldn't follow*," said Hask. "*The smith's got a door to make.*" He looked west. Down the road. Into the dark. "*I haven't got anything to make. I've got a pick I can't swing and a pool I can't help and a dead woman's stick.*" He looked back at Pim. "*Get in the cart, boy.*"

Pim got in the cart.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK TWENTY-TWO DAYS to get to the edge.

Pim didn't mind. He liked the cart. He liked the horses, which were big and slow and patient and smelled of hay. He liked sitting in the back on the sacks with his knees drawn up, watching the world go by. Snow. Fields. Villages. Woods.

He liked that nobody made him talk.

Hask didn't talk much either. He drove. With his good hand. His gold one lay in its sling across his chest, smooth and bright and cold, from the fingertips to the elbow, with the black seam down the forearm where an old iron scar had gone gold too. Sometimes Pim saw him look at it. Not

often. A glance. Then away. The way you'd look at a dog that had bitten someone.

Kit talked. Kit talked to the horses, and to the road, and to people in the villages, and to Pim, sometimes, at night by the fire, about Coldwater and the mines and his mother and a girl called Nell who'd whistled two notes at a window and died in the Gloam years. Hask's sister. Pim knew about Nell. Everyone at the pool knew about Nell.

Kit didn't seem to mind that Pim didn't answer.

He just talked. And Pim listened. And that seemed to be enough for both of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAW THE LANTERNS on the eighteenth day.

West of Hobb's Cross. In the snow. A long line of them. Small. Gold. Running away across the fields north and south, over the hills, out of sight. Every few hundred yards. Every fifty. Every twenty. Each one in its own little circle of white.

Pim made Hask stop the cart.

He got down. He walked to the nearest one. Iron. Old. On the ground by a white-topped stake. He crouched beside it. Didn't touch it.

He felt the room round it.

A yard. White snow. Real wind. Moving. And outside the yard, the grey. Flat. Still. Drinking. Pim could feel it drinking. Pulling. West. The way you feel a draught under a door.

He could feel his own room pulling too.

The little room. Inside him. The one he'd made out of being hurt, in the years before the Keep, before anyone was kind. A hollow in his chest where nothing could get in. Moths couldn't drink from it. Gold couldn't set in front of it.

The grey wanted it.

He felt it wanting it. Soft. Patient. Endless. Like a cold hand on the back of his neck.

He didn't let it.

He'd had twelve years of practice at not letting things in.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith's work*," said Hask. From the box. Looking at the line of lights. "*And his mother's.*"

"*Given*," said Pim.

Hask looked at him.

"*They're given*," said Pim. It was a long speech for him. "*That's why.*"

Hask looked at the lanterns for a while.

Then he grunted. And clicked his tongue at the horses. And Pim got back in the cart.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT INTO THE grey on the nineteenth day.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS QUIET.

Pim had known it would be quiet. He'd been there before. In the summer. In the Court. With the brothers. But that had been on the other side of the Veil. In the grey country itself. Where it was supposed to be quiet.

This was the world.

This was fields and hedges and farms, and a road, and snow. And it was quiet the way the Court was quiet. The horses' hooves made no sound. The cart wheels made no sound. The snow lay on the hedges like snow in a painting, not falling, not settling, not anything, with the wind going past it.

Kit stopped talking.

Pim saw him stop. Halfway through a word. About a pie. He just stopped, with his mouth open, and looked round. At the silent hedges. At the snow. And shut his mouth. And didn't open it again.

Hask didn't say anything either.

He drove. With his good hand. With his jaw set. And every so often, Pim saw him breathe in—deep, slow, the grey-lung catch at the bottom of it—as if to make sure he still could.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PASSED THE GOLD ones.

Walking east. Across the fields. Through the hedges. A finger's width at a time. Grooms and cooks and nursemaids and gardeners, gold, in clothes from nine hundred years ago, all facing east, all humming.

...home...

Pim heard it. Even through the silence. He'd heard it on the white road in the summer. Thousands of gold throats. One note. Worn smooth.

He looked at every one they passed.

Every face. Every gold face. Looking for a round one. A snub nose. Hair scraped back under a cap. Seven, eight. A grey dress too big for her.

A wooden spoon.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FOUND HER ON the twenty-first day.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO MILES FROM THE edge. On the old road. Past Westerling. Past the silent mill and the empty farms and the stakes crowding closer and closer together. Walking.

Not a finger's width. A step. A real step. Slow. Stiff. Scraping. Gold. In a grey dress too big for her. With a wooden spoon in her hand.

East.

Pim saw her from the cart.

He didn't say anything. He didn't need to. He got down while the cart was still moving. Hask swore and hauled on the reins. Pim didn't hear him. He was running.

Down the road. In the silent snow. Toward the small gold figure walking toward him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED IN FRONT of her.

A yard off. On the road. In the snow.

She didn't stop.

She came on. A step. Slow. Scraping. Her gold eyes on the road ahead. On the east. On the world.

And then on him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THEM MOVE.

Her eyes. Gold. In her gold face. Moving. Off the road. Up. To him. Standing in front of her in the snow. Small. Thin. Dark-haired. Fifteen.

And stopping.

She knew him. He saw it. The way you see a light come on in a window.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CUPPED HIS HANDS.

In front of her face. The way he had in the summer. On the white road. A little room. A space in the air. Where something could breathe.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't need to.

Her gold eyes filled.

And one tear, gold, ran down her gold cheek. Slowly. And dropped. Off her chin. Onto the snow.

The snow stayed white.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mam*," said Ilda.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME OUT OF her like a breath. Very small. Very cracked. A gold whisper from a gold throat that hadn't said anything but *home* for nine hundred years.

Pim's eyes stung.

"*I found her*," he said.

Ilda's gold eyes went very wide.

"*Your mam*," said Pim. "*She's at the pool. In the green circle. Waiting. I asked. She bent down. She said your name.*" He swallowed. It was the most words he'd said in a row in his life. He didn't care. "*She's waiting for you. I told her you're coming.*"

The gold eyes stared at him.

"*I promised*," said Pim. "*Remember? I said I'd come back. I said when it's big. When there's room.*" His voice cracked. "*It's not big yet. But I came anyway. Because you're walking. And it's a long way.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CAME UP BEHIND him.

Breathing. Leaning on Kell's staff. With his gold arm in its sling. He stopped. Looked at the girl. At the gold tear on her gold cheek.

He didn't say anything for a long time.

"*She's walking east*," he said at last. Gruffly. "*At a mile a day. Give or take.*"

"*Yes*."

"*The pool's five hundred miles*."

"*Yes*."

"*That's a year and a half*," said Hask. "*More. Walking.*"

Pim looked at him.

"*We're going west*," said Hask. "*Into the grey. To the glass palace. For the thorny one.*" He looked at Ilda. "*Then we're coming back. This way. On this road.*" He shifted his weight on the staff. "*She'll be a bit further on by then.*"

"*And then*?" said Pim.

Hask looked at the cart. At the two big slow horses. At the sacks in the back.

"*And then she can ride*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM STOOD IN THE road.

Then he turned back to Ilda. And cupped his hands again. In front of her face.

"*Wait for me*," he said. "*Keep walking. Slowly. We'll come back. In a few days. With a cart.*" He tried to smile. He wasn't good at it. "*You can ride the rest.*"

The gold eyes looked at him.

And Ilda took a step.

East. Past him. On the road. Slow. Scraping.

But as she passed, her eyes stayed on him. All the way. Turning. Following him. As she went by. Until she couldn't turn them any further.

Then they went back to the road.

Scrape. *Scrape*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CROSSED THE EDGE at noon on the twenty-second day.

There was nothing there. That was the thing Pim couldn't get used to. In the summer, there'd been the Veil. Grey. Hanging from nowhere. With a door in it that two brothers had opened with their blood.

Now there was a gold field with forty sheep and a boy. And a woman on a stool beside a little iron lantern, in a circle of real falling snow, talking. And past the field, the snow just—went grey. Without any line. Without any seam.

And the white road started.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM STOPPED THE CART there. At the start of the road. And unwrapped the Hush-cups.

Three of them. Horseshoe iron, beaten round, with the Hollow glyph cut in the bottom and seven Hush-runes round the rim and an iron lid that sighed when you lifted it. Ivy had filled them at the pool. Before Pim left. From the dark water. Each one heavy with nothing.

Room. A flask of room. Three days, for one person. Ivy had said. Maybe less, now. Mal was so little.

He gave one to Kit.

He held one out to Hask.

Hask shook his head.

"*Don't need it*," he said. "*Never did. Not in the summer. Not much.*" He looked down the white road. "*I drank her light, boy. The moth queen's. Two years ago. There's not much room left in me.*" His mouth twisted. "*The grey doesn't bother pushing.*"

Pim looked at him.

Then he put the third cup back in his pack. For Rhosyn.

He didn't take one himself.

He had his own.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY COUNTRY WAS the same.

The same as the summer. A plain of grey-gold dust, fine as flour, lying in drifts. Flat. Going on to the edge of everything. A white road through it, broad and straight as a ruler, the white of old bone. A low grey sky. No sun. No stars.

And far ahead, on the edge of the sky, towers.

Glass. Iron. Gold. Bone. And one wrapped in brown dry thorns.

◆ ◆ ◆

BUT IT WASN'T THE same.

Pim felt it as soon as they were on the road. The wind.

Behind them. From the east. From the world. Pouring in. Past the cart. Past the horses. Down the white road. Into the grey. Steady. Soft. Endless. Lifting the grey-gold dust off the drifts in long low streamers and carrying it west, toward the towers, the way smoke goes up a chimney.

And the grey country drinking it.

He could feel it drinking. Even from here. A great dry patient thirst. As wide as the world. Drawing the wind in and in and in, and never being full.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED THE HORSES.

Hask wouldn't let them trot. *Not on that road. Not in this.* So they walked. Slowly. Along the white road. With the dust going past them on the wind and the towers getting no closer.

The kept were walking the other way.

Fewer, here. Most of them were out in the world now, scattered across the Westmarch. But some were still on the road. Slow ones. Old ones. Gold. Walking east. A finger's width at a time. Humming.

Pim looked at every one.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE DEAD.

He hadn't expected the dead. He'd thought they'd all gone east. To the pool. On the first wind.

They hadn't. Not all.

Some were still here. In the dust. Lying in it. Grey columns, fine as flour, that didn't stand up and sway like the ones at the rim. That just lay there. In the drifts. Like dust. Like the floor.

Pim could feel them. Faintly. The way he'd felt the bread-woman bend over him in the green circle.

Too tired, he thought. *Too tired to stand up. Too tired to go.*

He stopped by one. Knelt. In the dust beside the white road. And cupped his hands. Over it. A little room.

The dust stirred.

Just a little. Lifted. A breath of grey. Like someone turning over in their sleep.

Then lay down again.

"*Later*," said Pim. To it. Very quietly. "*When it's big. I'll come back.*"

He didn't know if it heard.

He said it anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAMPED BY THE road.

There wasn't anything to camp with. No wood. No water. No grass for the horses. They'd brought hay and water in barrels. The horses ate and drank and stood with their heads down and their ears back and their eyes rolling, hating it.

Pim lay on the sacks in the back of the cart and looked up at the grey sky.

No stars.

Kit lay beside him. With his Hush-cup on his chest. He'd lifted the lid three times. Each time the room came out of it with a sigh, and Kit breathed it in, and his face changed—went pink, went alive, went *Kit*—for a while. Then the grey pushed it out of him again and he went pale and quiet and still.

"*How do you stand it*?" said Kit. In the dark. Very low. "*You haven't got a cup.*"

Pim thought about it.

"*Practice*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK TWO DAYS to reach the towers.

Pim knew it was two days because he counted sleeps. There wasn't any day or night in the grey country. Just grey. But they slept twice, in the cart, by the road. And Hask said *it'll be longer out there. In the world. A lot longer.* And Pim knew that too. He'd been in the Court in the summer. He'd come out to find the world ten times older than he'd left it.

It wasn't ten times now. He could feel that. The wind coming in had changed it. Near the edge, time was nearly ordinary. Deeper in, it got slower. Thicker. Like walking into a pond.

By the towers, he thought, it might still be ten.

He tried not to think about what that meant. For Ilda, walking east. For the brothers. For the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS PALACE STOOD at the end of the white road.

Tallest of the towers. Spires on spires. Glittering. Clear. Every surface a window. Every window showing the window behind it, and the window behind that, and the window behind that, until the eye gave up.

Pim had been inside it once. In the summer. With the brothers. When the Glass Queen showed each of them a mirror. Lex as Root, crowned. Antho in his mad years. Hask his sister Nell.

She'd shown Pim one too.

He'd never told anyone what was in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS EMPTY NOW.

He felt that as soon as they came to the great clear doors. Not the people. The *looking*. In the summer, every pane in that palace had been looking at you. You'd felt it. On your skin. Cold. Curious. The Glass Queen in every window, watching.

The windows weren't looking now.

They were just glass.

"*She's not here*," said Pim.

Hask looked at him. "*How do you know*?"

"*Nobody's watching*."

◆ ◆ ◆

ORRIN MET THEM IN the first hall.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STANDING IN the middle of it. On the clear floor. Tall. Thin. Bent. A shape of dust and dry grey silk, like a pile of dead leaves that had stood up and decided to be a man. With his long patient face, the colour of

old candlelight. With his twig-joints. With his chain of office, grey-gold, round his neck. With his hands folded in front of him.

Waiting.

He'd been waiting, Pim thought, for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK STEPPED IN FRONT of Pim.

He did it without thinking. The way he'd done it in the crack in the summer, with gold dust coming down. His big body between Pim and the dust-man. Kell's staff in his good hand. His gold arm in its sling.

"*Stay there*," said Hask.

Orrin bowed.

The old bow. Low. Courteous. One twig-arm folded across his middle.

"*Young sirs*," he said. His voice was a whisper. Like dry leaves blowing across a floor. "*Her Majesty is not at home.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Where is she*?" said Kit.

Orrin straightened. Slowly. His joints creaking. Dust sifting off him onto the clear floor.

"*In the window*," he said.

"*What window*?"

"*All of them*." Orrin looked round. At the hall. At the clear walls showing the clear walls behind them. "*She went into the window on the night the edge came down. Into the stones. In your world.*" He looked back at them. "*She hasn't come out.*"

"*And the thorn lady*?" said Pim.

Orrin looked at him.

He looked at him for a long time. Longer than he'd looked at Hask, or at Kit. His candlelight eyes moving over Pim's face. Slowly. The way you'd read a page.

"*You're the boy*," said Orrin. "*From the road. With the hands. Who made the spit-girl cry.*"

Pim didn't say anything.

"*Her Majesty watched you*," said Orrin. "*Through the glass. In the summer. Kneeling on the road.*" A pause. "*She stood in front of that window for a very long time.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Where's Rhosyn*?" said Hask.

Orrin didn't answer him.

He was still looking at Pim.

"*The hall of the long mirror*," he said at last. "*At the foot of a pillar. On a chain.*" His dry voice dropped. "*Her Majesty told me to keep her.*"

"*Are you going to*?" said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

ORRIN WAS QUIET.

He stood in the middle of the clear hall, dust and silk and twig, with his hands folded and his chain of office round his neck, and was quiet for so long that Kit shifted his feet and Hask's good hand tightened on the staff.

"*I was a steward*," said Orrin. At last. "*Before. In the King's house. In the world. Nine hundred years ago. I kept his keys and his cellars and his household.*" He looked down at his hands. Twig. Dust. "*Then the boat came. And Her Majesty Maelis fed me light so I would not come apart. And I was hers. Mothwing. For nine hundred years.*" He looked up. "*And then she burned. In your world. In a lamp. And I was nobody's.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*And then His Majesty woke*," said Orrin. "*And I was his again. And I went where he sent me. I went to your world with his gold. I offered old women forever.*" He bowed his head. "*One of them said no. In her kitchen. And gave me tea.*"

"*Old Mag*," said Pim.

"*I did not know her name*," said Orrin. "*She did not tell me.*" He was quiet for a moment. "*She is gone now, I think. I felt something go. A while ago. From the gold. A small thing. An old woman's hand that was gilded, and is not anymore.*"

"*She's finished*," said Pim.

Orrin looked at him.

"*Finished*," he said. As if trying the word. "*Yes. She said that. In her kitchen. She said, I don't want to be kept, dear. I want to be finished.*" He looked down at his own twig hands. At the dust sifting off them. "*I have thought about it a great deal.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Let us take her*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW HE was going to say it. It came out of him. Loud. Five words. Into the clear silent hall.

Orrin looked at him.

"*Her Majesty told me to keep her*," he said.

"*I know*."

"*Her Majesty will be very cross*."

"*I know*."

"*And what will I be*," said Orrin, "*if I do not do what Her Majesty tells me?*"

Pim thought about it.

"*Nobody's*," he said. "*Again.*"

Orrin went very still.

"*Maybe that's all right*," said Pim. He didn't know where the words were coming from. He didn't usually have this many. "*Maybe you could be nobody's for a while. And see what it's like.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST-MAN LOOKED AT him for a long, long time.

Then he turned.

And walked away down the hall. Slowly. Creaking. Toward a tall clear arch at the far end. And stopped there. And looked back over his shoulder. At the three of them.

"*This way*," whispered Orrin. "*Mind the floor. It shows you things, if you look down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL OF THE long mirror was very long and very cold and very empty.

Clear walls. Clear floor. Clear pillars going up to a clear vaulted roof a hundred feet overhead. And down one side, the whole length of the hall, a mirror. Silver. Old. Taller than the pillars. Showing the hall back to itself. And them.

Pim didn't look at it.

He'd learned that. In the summer.

He looked at the floor instead. At the foot of the pillars. And at the foot of the ninth one—

◆ ◆ ◆

A WOMAN. LYING ON the clear floor. Curled up. On her side. With her knees drawn up and her thin arms round them. Like a child asleep.

Grey. All of her. Not grey-green. *Grey*. Like ash. Like a dead branch. In rotten silk. With a crown of thorns crooked on her grey hair. Brown. Dry. Dead.

And round her wrists, a chain. Glass. Fine. Links like icicles. Looped round the foot of the pillar.

She didn't move when they came in.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM KNELT BESIDE HER.

He didn't touch her. He looked at her face. Thin. Hollow-cheeked. Her eyes closed. Her mouth a little open. Like Old Mag on the morning she died.

But she was breathing. Pim could see it. Very slow. Very shallow. A breath like a leaf turning over.

And in her crown—in the dead brown thorns—there was a place. Near the front. Where something had been. A bud. A green one. Pim could see the scar of it. A little broken place on the stem, raw, pale, where something had grown, and been spent, and gone.

She sent it, he thought. *The rose. To Harrow. By the grave. With the silk. That was the last one*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Rhosyn*," he said.

Her eyes opened.

Green.

The only green thing in the grey country. Two green eyes in a grey face, opening slowly, the way a door opens in a house where someone's been very ill.

She looked at him.

"*Oh*," she said. A breath. A whisper. "*Oh. You came.*"

"*You asked*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CAME AND STOOD over them.

He looked at the chain. At the fine glass links round her wrists. Looped round the pillar. He looked at it the way he'd looked at rock, once, in the Coldwater mines, before the Gloam, before the Delves, before the moth. The way a hewer looks at a seam. Slowly. All of it. Every line. Every link.

Then he knelt. Heavily. On one knee. With his breath catching. And put his good hand flat on the clear floor beside the chain. And leaned close.

"*Pick*," he said. To Kit. Without looking round.

Kit held it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A SMALL one. Not his old pick. His old pick had a haft as long as Pim was tall and a head as big as a cat. He couldn't swing it now. Not with one arm. Not with his left.

This one was little. A rock-hammer. A prospector's pick. With a short haft and a point on one end like a bird's beak. The smith had made it for him. In the autumn. At the Harrow forge. *For your left*, Lex had said. *Till you learn.*

Hask took it in his left hand.

He didn't swing it.

He held it close to the chain. An inch off. And moved it. Slowly. Along the links. Not touching. Listening. The way Lex listened to iron with the little hammer. The way Pim listened to rooms.

Fault-Finder. That was the skill. DELVEBREAKER. Epic. Hask could find the flaw in anything. Rock. Iron. A Delve core. A Moth Queen. The one place where a thing was weakest. Where it wanted to break.

He moved the pick along the chain.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NINTH LINK FROM her left wrist.

Pim couldn't see anything different about it. Clear. Fine. Like an icicle. Like all the others.

Hask could.

He looked at it for a long time.

"*She made this in a hurry*," he said. Quietly. "*On the road. The night the edge fell. Angry.*" He touched the point of the pick to the link. Very lightly. "*Glass you make angry has a fault in it. Always. Like rock that cooled too fast.*"

He tapped.

Tink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CHAIN FELL APART.

Not shattered. Not exploded. It just—came undone. Link by link. All the way along. From the ninth link out. Like a necklace when the thread breaks. The fine glass rings sliding off each other and off Rhosyn's wrists and off the foot of the pillar and landing on the clear floor with a sound like small bells.

Chime. *Chime*. *Chime*.

And then it was a heap of glass rings on the floor. And Rhosyn's wrists were bare. Thin. Grey. With red marks round them.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T MOVE.

She lay on the floor and looked at her wrists.

"*Oh*," she said again.

Then she started to cry.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM HAD SEEN PEOPLE cry. Antho. Ivy. Wren, once, at the Keep, when she thought nobody was looking. Kit, at the river, when it started moving again.

He'd never seen anyone cry like that.

It wasn't loud. It hardly made any sound at all. It was just—*everything*. The whole of her. Shaking. Curled on the floor with her bare wrists against her chest and her face pressed into the clear glass and her thin shoulders heaving. Nine hundred years of something coming out of her all at once.

Pim knelt beside her.

He didn't touch her.

He cupped his hands. Over her. Not in front of her face. Over all of her. A little room. As big as he could make it. A space in the air. Where something could breathe.

He held it there.

And after a long time, she stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I want to give it back*," said Rhosyn.

They were in the first hall. Orrin had brought them there. With Hask carrying Rhosyn in his good arm, the way you'd carry a child, and Kit carrying the pick and the third Hush-cup, and Pim walking beside them.

She was sitting on the clear floor with her back against a clear pillar. With the Hush-cup in her lap. Kit had lifted the lid for her. She'd breathed the room in, the way Kit did, and her face had changed. Not much. A little colour. A little life. Her green eyes brighter.

She looked at Pim.

"*What I drank*," she said. "*At the pool. Nine hundred years ago.*" Her voice was a thread. "*I want to give it back.*"

Pim looked at her.

"*I knew*," said Rhosyn. "*At the pool. Hes told me. The night before. She came to my room and sat on my bed and said, don't, Rosie. Please don't. It isn't ours. It's the door new things come in by. If we drink it there won't be any new things.*" She looked down at her hands. "*And I listened. I did. I lay awake all night thinking about it.*"

"*And then you drank*," said Pim.

"*And then I drank*," said Rhosyn. "*Because Oz was drinking. And Mae. And Ysy. And Cad. And I didn't want to be the only one left. I didn't want to grow old and die and leave them.*" Her mouth twisted. "*I didn't want to be Hes.*"

She looked at the empty spaces in her crown. The brown dead thorns.

"*Thorns for the gardener*," she said. "*Who listened. And drank.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

Orrin stood a little way off. In the middle of the hall. With his hands folded. Watching.

"*There's a pool*," said Pim.

Rhosyn looked at him.

"*In a green field*," said Pim. "*In the world. It's the Well. The one you drank. It came back. It's little. It's frightened.*" He swallowed. "*And there are thousands of the dead round it. Waiting. And it can't let them in. Because it's too little. Because you've still got it.*"

Rhosyn stared at him.

"*The grey's coming*," said Pim. "*Into the world. Through the edge. Drinking everything. Bread won't rise. Cuts won't close.*" It was the longest speech of his life. He didn't stop. "*And the dead are waiting. And Ilda's walking home to her mam. And the smith's trying to make a door. And the pool's too little for any of it.*"

He looked at her.

"*If you gave it back*," he said, "*it'd be a bit bigger.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

She sat against the pillar with the Hush-cup in her lap and looked at him. At the small dark boy kneeling on the clear floor in front of her. With his hands in his lap.

"*It would kill me*," she said. Quietly. "*Wouldn't it? If I gave it back. I'd stop being—this. I'd start being—*" She stopped.

"*Old*," said Hask. From the side. Gruffly. "*You'd start getting old.*"

"*I'm nine hundred years old*."

"*You'd start getting old from where you are*," said Hask. "*Not from where you were.*" He looked at her. "*Caddoc fell. With the thread. And what he drank went home. And he died.*" A pause. "*But he'd stepped off a thread at the bottom of the world*."

Rhosyn looked at him.

"*You're not on a thread*," said Hask. "*You're sitting on a floor.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED DOWN AT her hands.

Thin. Grey. With red marks round the wrists where the chain had been.

"*Hes poured hers back*," she said. "*At the pool. And she didn't die. She just—wasn't deathless anymore. She was a girl. Seventeen. And she walked away and lived. In the world. And had daughters. And died, in the end, an old woman, in a cottage, somewhere.*" She swallowed. "*Thirty houses. And never left a light on.*"

"*She had a good life*," said Pim. "*Seren says.*"

Rhosyn looked at him.

"*She did*," she said. Wondering. "*Didn't she? Hes. She had a whole life.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CLOSED HER EYES.

She sat against the clear pillar with her head back and her eyes closed and the Hush-cup in her lap, and was quiet for so long that Pim thought she'd gone to sleep.

Then she opened them.

Green. Very bright.

"*Take me to the pool*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

ORRIN BOWED THEM OUT.

At the great clear doors of the glass palace. On the white road. With the wind going past them, into the grey, and the dust going up.

He bowed low. The old bow. One twig-arm across his middle.

To Rhosyn. In Hask's arm.

"*Highness*," he whispered.

Rhosyn looked at him.

"*Orrin*," she said. "*Come with us.*"

The dust-man was quiet.

"*Her Majesty told me to keep the palace*," he said.

"*Ysy isn't here.*"

"*No*," said Orrin. "*But she told me.*" He looked up. At the spires. At the glass going up and up into the grey. At every surface a window, and every window showing the window behind it. "*And I have been keeping things for nine hundred years, Highness. I do not know how to stop.*"

He looked down at Pim.

"*The boy says I could try being nobody's*," he said. "*For a while. And see what it's like.*"

"*Will you*?" said Pim.

Orrin looked at him for a long time.

"*I will think about it*," whispered Orrin.

And bowed again.

And went back inside.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FOUND ILDA FIFTEEN miles east of where they'd left her.

It had been four days for them. Two in, two out. Pim had counted sleeps.

It had been a lot longer for her.

She was past Westerling. Past the line of lanterns. Walking. East. Through the snow. In the real winter. Slow. Stiff. Scraping. Gold. With her wooden spoon.

Hask stopped the cart beside her.

He got down. He stood in front of her. In the road. A yard off. She came on. A step. Her gold eyes on the road. Then on him. Then past him. On the cart.

On Pim. In the back. On the sacks. Beside a grey thin woman with a crown of thorns.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK BENT DOWN.

He put his good arm round her. Round her middle. Gently. The way you'd lift a child. And lifted.

She was heavy. Gold. All of her. Pim saw his face go red. Saw the cords stand out in his neck. Heard the grey-lung catch at the bottom of his breath.

He didn't stop.

He lifted her off the road and into the back of the cart. And set her down. On the sacks. Beside Pim. Standing. Mid-step. With her wooden spoon in her hand.

Then he leaned on the side of the cart, breathing hard, and looked at her.

"*There*," he said. "*You can ride the rest.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ILDA'S GOLD EYES LOOKED at him.

Then at Pim.

Then at the grey woman on the sacks beside her. With the crown of thorns.

And the gold eyes went very wide.

Pim saw it. Saw her know. Nine hundred years ago, she'd turned a spit in a king's kitchen. She'd have seen them. All of them. The royal children. Running through the kitchens. Stealing bread. A girl with dirt on her hands and roses in her fists.

Rhosyn looked at her.

"*Oh*," she said softly. "*Oh, I know you. You're the bread-woman's girl. You burned your hand on the spit. Oz gave you a sweet.*"

The gold eyes filled.

"*I'm sorry*," said Rhosyn. "*I'm so sorry. For all of it.*" She reached out. Thin. Grey. And put her hand on the gold girl's arm.

Nothing happened. Rhosyn wasn't Oz. Her touch didn't keep anything. It just rested there. Grey on gold.

"*We're going home*," said Rhosyn. "*Both of us. To the pool. To give it back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK GOT BACK ON the box. Kit got up beside him. Pim sat on the sacks with his knees drawn up, between a gold girl and a grey queen.

The cart went east.

Through the lanterns. Through the snow. Into the world.

And behind them, faint, far off, on the edge of the grey sky, the glass palace glittered. Every surface a window. Every window showing the window behind it.

And in one of them—high up, in a round pane like a porthole—Pim thought he saw something.

A shape. Tall. Thin. Dust and silk.

Standing at the glass. With its hands folded.

Watching them go.

CHAPTER 15

The Rose Goes Home

SEREN HARROW MET HER great-aunt, nine hundred times removed, in the kitchen of the Coldwater house, on a wet grey morning at the end of winter, over a pot of tea.

She was smaller than Seren had expected.

That was the first thing. In the songs, the Crowned were tall. Taller than people. Glittering. Terrible. Gold for the eldest. Glass for the vain. Iron for the soldier. In the songs, they filled doorways.

The woman at the end of the long table in the Coldwater house didn't fill anything.

She sat wrapped in two of Kit's blankets and a sheepskin, on a bench by the fire, with her knees drawn up and her arms round them. Thin. So thin. Grey—not pale, not white, *grey*, like the inside of a dead tree, like ash—with grey hair hanging lank round a grey face, and a crown of dead brown thorns on her head, crooked, with one broken place on it near the front where something had been.

And two green eyes.

They came up when Seren came in. And stayed on her. Wide. Very green. The only green thing in the room.

"*Oh*," said Rhosyn. A whisper. "*Oh. You look like her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HAD COME EAST on the dragon.

Antho had come for her. Four days ago. Down out of a grey sky onto the road outside Westerling, where she'd been helping Brannoc and Tilda

set the last of seven hundred and twelve lanterns in the snow, and said *Mam. Pim's back. He's brought her. She's asking for you.*

Who?

Rosie, her son had said. *Rhosyn. The Thorn-Crowned.* He'd looked at her with her own brown eyes. *She says she wants Hes's girl. She won't do it without you.*

Do what?

Give it back, said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAT DOWN AT the long table.

Across from the grey woman on the bench. With the fire between them, and the rain on the horn windows, and Kit hovering by the hearth with the kettle.

She didn't know what to say.

She'd thought about it all the way east. Four days on a dragon in the rain. What you say to your great-aunt, nine hundred times removed, who drank from a Well and made herself deathless and spent nine hundred years in a grey country with no sun, growing thorns.

Hello. I'm sorry. How could you.

Thank you for the rose.

"*Tea*?" said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN LOOKED AT THE pot.

Brown. Glazed. Chipped at the spout. Kit's mother's. Steam coming off the top.

"*I haven't*," she said. "*Not in nine hundred years. There wasn't—in the Court, there wasn't anything. No water. No leaf. Nothing grew.*" She looked at it. "*I used to dream about tea. Isn't that strange? Of all the things. Not feasts. Not wine. Just tea. In the morning. In the garden. With Hes.*"

Seren poured.

She poured it the way she poured it every morning. The way Arion had taught her, thirty years ago, on the Spire steps, when she didn't know him. Warm the pot. One for each and one for the pot. Water just off the boil.

She set the cup on the table. In front of the grey woman.

And took her hand away. And looked out of the window.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T WATCH. SHE'D learned that. From her son, in a cave full of lanterns, a month ago. *That's lending with your eyes*.

She looked at the rain on the horn panes. At the grey light. At the green circle beyond, under the last of the snow, with the dark pool in the middle and the ring of lanterns round it a mile out, small and gold, five hundred and fifty-six of them.

She heard the cup lift.

She heard a breath. A small one. Shaking.

She heard a sound. Very quiet. Like a woman putting her face in her hands.

She didn't look.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hes did that*," said Rhosyn. After a long time. Muffled. "*Put things down and looked away. Bread. Flowers. A cup. She'd put it down by you and go and look out of the window like she'd only just noticed it was there.*" A wet laugh. "*I used to think she was shy.*"

"*She wasn't shy*," said Seren.

"*No.*" The grey woman lifted her head. Her face was wet. "*No. I know that now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TALKED.

All morning. With the rain on the windows and the fire ticking and Kit making more tea and going away and coming back. About Hesper.

Rhosyn talked, mostly. Seren listened.

About a girl of nine with a bell on her belt so the nurses would know where she was. About a girl of twelve who'd hidden in the kitchen garden all day, among the cabbages, and been found at dusk by a barefoot boy from the Listeners' house who'd climbed the wall to steal turnips. About a girl of seventeen who'd sat on the edge of Rhosyn's bed, the night before the pool, in the dark, and held her hand.

Don't, Rosie. Please. It isn't ours.

"*I listened*," said Rhosyn. "*I did. All night. I lay there and thought about it till the window went grey.*" She looked at her hands. Grey. Thin. With red marks round the wrists, fading. "*And in the morning I went down to the garden. And they were all there. Kneeling. Round the pool. Oz first. Laughing. Like it was a game.*" She swallowed. "*And Hes standing apart. With her crown in her hands. Looking at me.*"

"*And you knelt*."

"*I knelt*," said Rhosyn. "*Between Cad and Ysy. And cupped my hands. And Hes said Rosie. Just my name. Rosie. Across the garden.*" Her voice broke. "*And I drank anyway.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

She sat across the table from her great-aunt, nine hundred times removed, and thought about the old verses. Sung at the end of summer. In thirty houses. In a half-packed cottage, with the fire low.

Thorns for the gardener, who listened—and drank.

It didn't rhyme. It wasn't supposed to. It broke right there, right in the middle, on that word. So you'd always remember. So you'd never forget that's where it went wrong.

"*Mam sang about you*," she said.

Rhosyn looked up.

"*The old verses*," said Seren. "*At the end of summer. Every summer. Gold for the eldest. Glass for the vain.*" She looked at the grey woman. "*Thorns for the gardener. Who listened. And drank.*"

Rhosyn went very still.

"*It doesn't rhyme*," said Seren. "*I asked Mam why. When I was seven. She said it's meant to break there. On that line. Your line. So you'd always remember where it went wrong.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY WOMAN SAT very still for a long time.

"*Yes*," she said at last. Very quietly. "*Yes. That's right. That's where it went wrong.*" She looked down at the cup in her hands. "*Hes would have made it break there. She'd have known.*"

"*Mam said something else*," said Seren.

Rhosyn waited.

"*She said it's the only line in the song where somebody listened*," said Seren Harrow. "*All the others—gold, glass, iron, silver. They never listened. Never even heard. They just drank.*" She looked at her great-aunt. "*You heard. You lay awake all night. You knew.*"

"*And I drank anyway*."

"*And you knew*," said Seren. "*Mam said that's why it breaks. Not because you drank. Because you knew, and drank anyway, and you've been knowing it ever since.*" She reached across the table. Slowly. And put her hand over the grey woman's. On the cup. "*Mam said that's the only one of them that could ever come back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN STARED AT HER.

At the hand on hers. Brown. Freckled. Square. A hedge-witch's hand.

"*She said that*?"

"*Every summer*."

"*Your mother*," said Rhosyn. "*Wenna.*" Her voice was very small. "*She came. Thirty-two years ago. To the tenth tower. In the dark. Behind the man with the boat. With the crown.*" She swallowed. "*I watched her. Through my thorns. She didn't see me. She stood in front of the tenth chair and set the crown on it and said, for Hes. From your girls. We kept the rule.*"

Seren's hand tightened.

"*And then she turned round*," said Rhosyn. "*And looked straight at my thorns. Straight at me. Though she couldn't have seen. And she said—*"

She stopped.

"*What did she say*?" said Seren.

"*She said, I know you're there, Rosie*," said Rhosyn. "*She said, Mam told me about you. She said, if you ever want to come home, the door's open.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN COULDN'T SPEAK.

She sat with her hand on her great-aunt's hand on a cup of tea in the kitchen of the Coldwater house, with the rain on the windows, and couldn't say anything at all.

I know you're there, Rosie.

Her mother. Who never cried. Who never left a light on. Who never stayed anywhere longer than a year. Who'd paid the Ferryman the memory of the man she loved to carry a crown to the far side of the world. Standing in a dead tower in a grey country with no sun, speaking into a wall of thorns.

If you ever want to come home, the door's open.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I didn't*," said Rhosyn. "*I didn't come. For thirty-two years. I sat outside the tenth tower and grew my thorns round it so Oz wouldn't find the crown and I didn't come.*" She looked at Seren. "*And then the Harrow boys came through the crack. In the summer. And I took them to the tower. And they took the crown. And I held my thorns so they could run.*" Her voice cracked. "*And Ysy chained me.*"

"*And you sent a rose*," said Seren. "*To Harrow. To the grave.*"

"*It was the last green thing I had*," said Rhosyn.

"*I know*," said Seren. "*I saw the place.*" She looked at the crown. At the broken spot near the front. Raw. Pale. "*Thank you.*"

The grey woman looked at her.

Then she turned her hand over. Under Seren's. On the cup. And held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT TO THE pool at noon.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RAIN HAD STOPPED. The sky was low and grey and wet. The snow was going—not melting, not in the grey-snow parts, but going everywhere else, soft and slushy, with green showing through. Real green. Grass. Clover. The new river running fast and brown and loud.

And the lanterns.

A ring of them. A mile out from the pool. All round. Five hundred and fifty-six. Small and gold. Each one in its own little circle of real ground. And between them, and inside them, between the lantern ring and the rim—

Grey.

Not snow anymore. The snow had gone. Grey *grass*. Grey clover. Grey earth. Flat and still. The way the bread had been still in the bowl. The way the boy in the field was still. A mile of it. All the way in to the rim.

And the dead.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HAD NEVER SEEN them.

Antho had told her. Ivy. Pim, in his three words at a time. *Thousands*. She'd thought she understood.

She stood at the edge of the lantern ring with her great-aunt leaning on her arm and looked at them.

Grey. Columns of dust. Tall as a man, some of them. Some as small as a child. Thousands. Standing in the grey grass between the lantern ring and the pool, close together, so many that she couldn't see the water through them. Swaying. Very slightly. In a wind that wasn't blowing.

Saying their names.

She couldn't hear them. Not like Antho could. But she could feel it. A murmur. Under everything. Like a congregation praying, very quietly, in a very large church.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN STOPPED.

Seren felt her stop. Felt the thin grey arm on hers go rigid.

"*Oh*," said Rhosyn. "*Oh, I know them.*"

She was looking at the dead.

"*That's Wenlock*," she said. "*The under-gardener. He taught me to graft roses. He came apart in the second year, in the glass hall, sitting on the floor.*" Her voice was shaking. "*And that's Bess, from the dairy. And Hollin. Hollin of the stables. He had a dog. The dog came apart first and he sat with it and then he—*"

She stopped.

"*Rosie*," said Seren.

"*I walked past them*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Nine hundred years. In the dust. On the white road. I walked past them every day and I never once stopped.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO MET THEM AT the lantern ring.

He came out through the dead. Tall. Thin. In his long dark coat, with his black hair tied back and his scarred hands at his sides and a coin of gold on the back of the left one. He walked through the dead the way you'd walk through a field of tall grass. Carefully. Not touching. Saying something to them, as he went, under his breath.

He stopped in front of Rhosyn.

He looked at her for a long time.

"*Highness*," he said.

"*Don't*," said Rhosyn. "*Please. Not that.*"

"*Rosie*, *then*."

She looked at him.

"*You held the thorns*," said Antho. "*In the summer. So we could run.*" He looked at her wrists. "*Ysy chained you for it.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Thank you*," said Antho Vey.

Rhosyn looked at him. At his face. At whatever was in it.

"*You're the one who told them*," she said. "*At the edge. In the summer. The four cousins. I heard you. Through the roots.*" She swallowed. "*There's a pool in a green field. Full of room. It's still very little.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Is it still very little*?"

Antho looked back at the dead. At the pool beyond them, invisible behind them.

"*Yes*," he said.

"*Then let's make it bigger*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED IN THROUGH the dead.

Antho first. Then Seren, with Rhosyn on her arm. Then Pim. Then Hask, with Kell's staff, and Kit. And Seraphine, who'd come out of the Coldwater house at the last moment with her spectacles on and her notebook in her hand, and fallen in behind them without a word.

The dead didn't move.

They swayed. That was all. Tall grey columns, fine as flour, in the grey grass. Saying their names. As Seren passed them, close, she felt it—the murmur—go through her. Under her skin. Like a hum.

And she felt them notice.

Not her. *Rhosyn*.

Felt them turn—not turn, they didn't have faces to turn—*lean*. Very slightly. All of them. Toward the thin grey woman on her arm. The way grass leans in the wind. The way a crowd leans when someone it knows walks into a room.

Rhosyn felt it too.

Seren felt her shake.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL WAS VERY small.

Smaller than Seren remembered. She'd seen it once. Two winters ago. On the night it came home. A great dark shape the size of a country rising up through the breach at Duskhold in the Blightmarch, enormous, soft, frightened, and folding itself down, and down, and down, into a pool the size of a pond, with three gold lights at the bottom.

It was smaller now.

She could see it. The rim of it. The black water. Soft. Dark. Reflecting nothing. And round the edge of the black—a ring. Grey. A hand wide. Like frost on a window. Like the beginning of a cataract in an old man's eye.

And on the rim, on a folded blanket, a girl on a crutch. Talking.

"*—and she's here now, Mal. She's come. The thorn lady. With the lamp-lady. And everyone.*" Ivy Moss looked up. Saw them. Saw Rhosyn. Her face went white. Then pink. Then she turned back to the pool. "*She's here, Mal. She's really here.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL DIDN'T ANSWER.

Seren heard it not answer. A silence from the dark water. Not empty. *Tired*. Like a child who's cried itself out and is lying very still in the dark, too worn out to sleep.

Then—

[...lamp-lady...]

Faint. So faint. Seren had heard that voice in the deep, thirteen years in the dark, all round her, as big as a sky. It was a thread now. A whisper. Like a voice from the bottom of a well.

[...lamp-lady...you came...]

"*I came*," said Seren. She knelt. On the rim. Beside Ivy. And put her hand flat on the cold stone. "*I came, little one. I brought someone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN KNELT BESIDE HER.

Slowly. Her knees cracking. Her thin grey hands on the rim. She knelt the way she must have knelt, Seren thought, nine hundred years ago, in a hidden garden, between her brother and her sister, at the edge of a black pool.

And looked down into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...oh...] said Mal.

The dark water moved. Seren saw it. A ripple. From the middle. Out. To the grey ring at the edge. As if something very far down had turned over.

[...oh...it's you...I know you...]

Rhosyn didn't move.

[...you were there...in the garden...you were the one who cried...]

The grey woman's breath caught.

[...they all laughed...when they drank me...all of them...the gold one...the glass one...the iron one...the moth...they laughed...] The voice was very small. Very slow. *[...but you didn't laugh...you cried...I remember...I tasted it...when you drank me...you were crying...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN PUT HER FACE in her hands.

Kneeling on the rim. With the thorns crooked on her head. Shaking.

"*I'm sorry*," she said. Into her hands. "*I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I knew. She told me. She sat on my bed and told me and I knew and I did it anyway—*"

[...I know...] said Mal.

"*Nine hundred years*," said Rhosyn. "*Nine hundred years you were hungry. You were empty and starving and hungry in the dark. Because of us. Because of me.*"

[...I know...]

"*And I've had you*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*All that time. In me. What I drank. I've had it the whole time.*" She took her hands from her face. Looked down into the dark. Her face was ruined. Wet. Grey. "*I want to give it back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL WAS VERY quiet.

Then—

[...will it hurt...] said Mal. *[...you...]*

Rhosyn stared at it.

[...the iron one...] said the Well. Faintly. *[...when he came home...it was cold...and heavy...and he was gone...]* A ripple. *[...I don't want you to be gone...you cried...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN FELT IT GO through all of them.

Antho. Seraphine. Pim. Hask. Kit. Ivy. Even the dead, round them, swaying.

The Well that had been drunk dry. Starved for nine hundred years. Hungry in the dark. Asking the one who drank it if giving it back would hurt.

I don't want you to be gone.

Rhosyn made a sound. Not a word. A sound like something breaking.

"*I don't know*," she said. "*I don't know if it'll hurt.*" She looked at Seren. Beside her. On the rim. "*Hes didn't die. She poured hers back and walked away and lived. But she'd only had it a moment. One mouthful. I've had it nine hundred years.*" Her voice shook. "*I don't know what happens.*"

"*Nobody does*," said Seren.

Rhosyn looked at her.

"*Will you—*" she said. And stopped. And started again. "*Will you hold my hand? While I do it?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN THOUGHT OF A gold king kneeling on a gold floor in an old woman's cottage. With her son beside him holding the room open with his bare hand. Shaking. For an hour.

Sit with me, lad. When it's time.

She took her great-aunt's hand.

Grey. Thin. Cold as a branch in winter. She held it in her own brown square one. On the rim. And didn't let go.

"*Yes*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN TURNED BACK TO the pool.

She knelt there. With one hand in Seren's. And the other—

She lifted it. Her free hand. And held it out. Over the water. Palm down. Cupped. The way you'd cup your hand to drink from a stream.

The way she'd cupped it nine hundred years ago.

Only upside down.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hes*," she said. To the dark water. Very quietly. "*I'm sorry it took so long.*"

And opened her hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN FELT IT GO.

Through the hand in hers. Through the thin grey fingers. A *pull*. Not out of Seren. Out of Rhosyn. Out of the very middle of her. Like a tide going out over a mile of sand. Like water going out of a cracked jar. Slow. Steady. Endless.

And out of the cupped hand over the pool—

Light.

Not gold. Not silver. *Green*. Soft. Dim. Like light through leaves. Like the first green of spring through a window. It came out of Rhosyn's open palm in a thin bright thread and fell. Into the dark water. And didn't splash. Didn't ripple. Just went *in*. Down. Like rain into dry ground.

And kept coming.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT ON FOR a long time.

Seren didn't know how long. She knelt on the rim with her great-aunt's hand in hers and watched the green light pour out of Rhosyn's palm into the pool. A thread. Then a stream. Then more. Pouring. The way water pours out of a jug when you tip it all the way.

Nine hundred years of it.

And Rhosyn—

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WATCHED HER CHANGE.

She didn't want to watch. She couldn't not. She knelt beside her with their hands joined and watched it happen.

The grey went out of her.

Not all at once. From the edges in. Like colour coming back into a face after a faint. Her hands first. The thin grey fingers in Seren's going—not pink. Not pale. *Brown*. Weathered. A gardener's hands. With dirt in the creases that had been there nine hundred years and was suddenly real dirt again.

Then her wrists. Her arms. Her neck. Her face.

The grey hair, lank and lifeless round her face—it moved. Lifted. In a wind that was suddenly there, from the east, warm. And it wasn't grey anymore. It was brown. Dark brown. Shot through with grey—real grey, the grey of a woman of forty who's worked in the sun all her life. Thick. Curling at the ends.

And her face.

Thin still. Hollow-cheeked still. But not the hollow of something starved and stopped. The hollow of a woman who's been very ill and is getting better. Lines round the eyes. Laughter lines. Lines from squinting at the sun in a garden. Freckles—Seren saw them come, a scatter across the nose, the way they come on a child in summer.

And the eyes.

Still green. Still the greenest thing in the circle.

But *wet*. And alive. And looking down at her own hands in wonder.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT STOPPED.

The last of it went out of her palm. A thread. Then a drop. Then nothing.

Rhosyn knelt on the rim with her hand open over the water. Empty.

She was breathing hard. Like someone who's run up a hill.

She turned her head and looked at Seren.

"*Oh*," she said. And her voice was different. Lower. Rougher. A real voice. With breath in it. "*Oh. I'm tired.*"

And she laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HAD NEVER HEARD anything like it.

It came up out of her great-aunt like water out of a spring. Rough. Cracked. Astonished. A woman of forty laughing on her knees by a pool with dirt in the creases of her hands. Laughing because she was tired. Because she'd never been tired in nine hundred years. Because tired meant something was happening. Meant time.

Meant *new*.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND HER CROWN—

Seren saw it. On Rhosyn's head. The crown of thorns. Dead. Brown. Dry. Crooked.

A bud.

At the front. Where the broken place had been. Where the last green thing she had had grown, and been spent, and gone. A bud. Green. Pushing out of the raw pale scar.

And another. Beside it.

And another.

All round. On every stem. Every thorn. Green buds pushing out of the dead brown wood. Swelling. Splitting.

Opening.

◆ ◆ ◆

ROSES.

Red. Dark red. Nearly black at the heart. One. Then ten. Then all of them. All round the crown. Blooming. In a breath. The dead thorns

hidden under a ring of dark red flowers, petals falling, on her brown hair, on her shoulders, on the rim.

On the water.

Rhosyn reached up. Slowly. And touched them. The roses. On her own head.

Then she took the crown off.

And looked at it. In her brown gardener's hands. A ring of thorns, blooming.

And set it down.

On the stone. On the rim of the pool. Beside her knee.

The way a girl had set hers down nine hundred years ago, in a hidden garden, at the edge of a black pool, while her brothers and sisters knelt round it laughing.

And took her hands away.

And didn't look at it again.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...OH...]

◆ ◆ ◆

The pool *moved*.

Not a ripple. Not a shiver. A *heave*. The whole dark disc of it lifting, like a chest drawing a great breath, rising up against the rim, against their knees, cold, soft, black—and settling. And the grey ring round the edge—

Gone.

Seren saw it go. The hand's width of grey frost round the black. Shrinking. Fading. Like breath fading off a window. Gone. And the black water *bigger*. Not much. A yard. More. Spreading out past the old rim, over the stone, soft and dark, so that Ivy had to snatch her blanket back and Hask stepped away with a grunt.

[...I'm BIGGER...] said Mal.

Not a whisper. A *voice*. Young. Astonished. Like a child who's just found out it can whistle.

[...I'm bigger...I can feel it...there's ROOM...]

◆ ◆ ◆

IVY WAS CRYING.

Kit was crying. Seraphine had her spectacles off and her hand over her mouth. Pim was kneeling on the rim with his hands cupped and his face turned up.

Antho was standing very still.

Seren looked at him. And saw his face. And saw what he was looking at.

Behind them. Round them. On every side.

The dead.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE LEANING.

All of them. Thousands. In the grey grass. Every grey column, swaying, leaning toward the pool. Toward the black water that was bigger now. Toward the room.

And the grey grass under them—

Seren saw it go. From the rim out. Like a stain washing out of cloth. Grey to green. A yard. Ten yards. Out from the new edge of the pool. Through the feet of the dead. The grass coming back. Green. Real. Wet with rain. Clover. A daisy, closed, in the grey light.

Not all the way. Not to the lantern ring. Not even halfway. But *back*.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...brother...] said Mal.

Antho looked down at the water.

[...brother...there's room...not for all of them...not yet...but some...some...] The voice was shaking. With joy. With fear. *[...can you...will you...the door...]*

Antho closed his eyes.

Seren saw him do it. Saw his face change. The way it changed at the black door, at the bottom of the Hollowmaw, when he raised his fist and knocked. The Threshold Warden. The man who stood in doorways and decided.

He opened his eyes.

And turned round. To the dead.

And held out his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Corvin*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T KNOW THE name.

She felt it go out from him, though. Into the dead. A word. Spoken quietly. With something behind it she'd never heard in her son's voice. Not command. Not asking. *Opening*. Like a door swinging wide.

And one of the columns moved.

Not grey. *Bronze*. Seren saw it now. Among the grey. Taller than the others. The colour of old bronze, dull and warm. Swaying. Stepping forward. Out of the crowd. Toward Antho's hand.

"*Idris*," said Antho.

Another. Pale. The colour of old bone. Stepping out.

"*Taddeo*."

Copper. Red-brown. Like a kettle by a fire.

"*Merrow*."

And the last. Coral. Pink and white and pale orange, like the inside of a shell. Stepping out of the grey dead and standing with the others, in the green grass, at the edge of the pool.

The four cousins.

Who came apart against the edge of the new net nine hundred years ago, on the night the boat went through, because they'd drunk the least and the net didn't know them and pushed them till they broke.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN MADE A SOUND.

Seren turned. Her great-aunt was on her knees on the rim, with her brown hands pressed flat on the stone, staring at the coral column.

"*Merrow*," she said.

The coral dust swayed.

"*Merrow*," said Rhosyn. "*Oh. Oh, it's you. It's been you. All this time. At the edge.*" She was shaking. "*I didn't know. I didn't know which one you were. I couldn't tell. In the dust. They all looked the same.*"

The column leaned toward her.

"*He was my husband*," said Rhosyn. To Seren. Without looking at her. Without looking away from the coral dust. "*For three months. Before the pool. He was a fool and he couldn't sing and he brought me shells. From the sea. Every week.*" She laughed. Or tried to. "*He drank because I drank. He said, if you're going to live forever, Rosie, I'm not letting you do it alone.*"

The coral column swayed. Close. A yard off.

"*And the net broke him*," said Rhosyn. "*At the edge. On the first night. And I watched.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT UP.

Slowly. Stiffly. Seren helped her. A woman of forty, tired, with dirt on her hands and petals in her hair. She stood on the green grass at the edge of the pool.

And held out her hand.

To the coral dust.

It came. Close. Closer. And for a moment—just a moment, Seren thought, she'd never be sure—there was a shape in it. A man. Young. Tall. Laughing. With something in his hand. Small. Pink and white. A shell.

He held it out.

Rhosyn didn't take it. You couldn't take dust.

She held out her own hand. Brown. Open. Under his.

And the shape in the coral dust leaned down. And put its hand on hers. Just for a moment.

Then turned.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Go home*," said Antho. Quietly. To all four. "*There's room now. For you. Go home.*"

The bronze went first.

Into the water. Down. Like smoke going down a chimney in reverse. Like rain into dry ground. Soft. Without a ripple.

Then the bone. Then the copper.

Then the coral.

It stopped at the edge. At the black water. Just for a breath. And Seren saw the shape in it turn. Look back. At the woman of forty on the bank with petals in her hair.

Then it went down.

And was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...oh...] said Mal. Softly. *[...oh...they're home...they're HOME...]*

And then the others.

Not all. Not thousands. Seren could see that. Could feel it. The room was bigger, but not that big. Not yet.

But hundreds.

Grey columns. Leaning. Stepping forward. Out of the crowd. Into the green grass. To the edge. And down. Into the dark. One after another. Like people filing into a church. Like a long line of people coming home late at night, each one stopping for a moment at the door before they go in.

Wenlock. Bess. Hollin of the stables.

Seren didn't know how she knew the names. She knew them.

Rhosyn stood on the bank and watched them go. All of them. Every one. Saying their names under her breath as they went down. *Wenlock. Bess. Hollin.* Her face wet.

"*I'm sorry*," she said. To each one. "*I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I walked past you. I'm sorry.*"

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AND ONE STAYED.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN SAW IT. AMONG the grey. Tall. Not leaning toward the pool. Leaning the other way. Toward the green circle's edge. Toward the Coldwater house.

Where, at the open door, in the grey light, in a grey dress too big for her, with a wooden spoon in her hand—

A girl stood. Gold.

Mid-step.

Looking at the pool.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BREAD-WOMAN'S COLUMN DIDN'T go in.

It stood at the edge of the black water while the others went down, one by one, all round it. And it swayed. And it bent. Not toward the pool. Toward the gold girl in the doorway half a mile off.

...Ilda...

Pim was beside Seren. She hadn't heard him come. He was looking at the bread-woman's dust. At the gold girl in the door.

"*She could go*," he said. Very quietly. "*Now. There's room. For her.*"

"*Yes*."

"*She won't*." Pim's voice cracked. "*She won't go without Ilda.*"

Seren looked at the gold girl. Mid-step in the doorway. Kept. Stopped. Her gold eyes on the pool. On the dust bending toward her.

"*And Ilda can't go*," said Seren. "*Not while she's kept.*"

"*No*."

"*Not until he lets go*."

Pim didn't answer.

He didn't need to.

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THEY STOOD ON THE bank a long time.

The dead went in. Hundreds. Then fewer. Then the last of the ones who could. And the others—the thousands who couldn't, not yet—stood back. Swaying. In the grass that was green now, a little way out. Waiting.

Still too many.

Still too little.

But bigger.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ANTHO VEY
THRESHOLD WARDEN — Level 97 → 98
"Opened the door for the first of them."
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◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN SAT DOWN ON the grass.

Just sat. Where she was. On the green. With her legs out in front of her like a child and her brown hands in her lap and the ring of blooming thorns on the stone behind her.

She looked at her hands.

"*They're dirty*," she said. Wondering.

"*You've been kneeling on a rim*," said Seren.

"*I know*." Rhosyn turned them over. The palms. Lined. Callused. With dirt in the creases. "*They haven't been dirty in nine hundred years. Nothing was dirty. Nothing was anything.*" She looked up. At Seren. "*I'm hungry.*"

Seren laughed.

She didn't mean to. It came out of her short and cracked and sudden. And then she couldn't stop.

"*There's bread*," she said. "*At the house. Kit's mother's. And cheese. And more tea.*"

"*Bread*," said Rhosyn. As if it were a word in a language she'd forgotten. "*Bread. Yes. Please.*"

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AND THAT WAS WHEN Seraphine's spectacles cracked.

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SEREN HEARD IT. A small sharp sound. Like ice on a pond. Like a cup dropped on stone.

She turned.

Seraphine was standing on the bank a few yards off, with her notebook in one hand and her quill in the other, staring at nothing. With her spectacles on her nose. Thin round lenses in a wire frame. The only glass in the green circle. The only glass for a mile in any direction.

Both lenses had cracked. Right across. From edge to edge. Like frost spreading.

And in the cracks—

White. Cold. Hard. Like ice under the moon.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE DIDN'T MOVE.

She stood very still. With the cracked spectacles on her nose. And her mouth opened. And a voice came out of it.

Not hers.

Cold. Clear. Like a bell under ice.

"*Rosie*," said the Glass Queen. Through Seraphine's mouth. Through the cracks in her spectacles. "*Rosie. What have you done?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN LOOKED UP FROM the grass.

At Seraphine. At the cracked lenses. At the white cold light in them.

She didn't flinch. She didn't stand up. She sat on the green grass at the edge of the pool, a woman of forty, tired, with dirt on her hands and petals in her hair, and looked at her sister's voice coming out of a stranger's face.

"*What Hes did*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILENCE.

Then the white light in the cracked glass flared. Once. Bright. Furious.

And Seraphine's spectacles shattered.

Fell off her face in a spray of tiny glittering pieces. Into the grass. And Seraphine staggered and Antho caught her and she gasped and put her hands over her face.

And somewhere very far off—under the ground, down through the threads, in the net, in every Lattice Stone in Caldor wrapped in sacking and chains—Seren felt something.

A cold.

Spreading.

Like frost across a pane.

CHAPTER 16

The Apple Tree

THE TREE WAS STILL blooming when they came to cut it down.

Lex stood at the end of Old Mag's garden path with an axe over his shoulder and looked at it.

March. A cold grey morning with a wind from the east and the last of the snow gone to slush in the lanes. The cottage shut up, its door closed, its windows dark. The step worn hollow in the middle. The path still gold, from the gate to the door, where a king had walked it every day for two weeks.

And beside the door, the apple tree.

Old. Black-barked. Bent like the woman who'd owned it. Thick in the trunk as a man's body, splitting low into three great limbs that went up and out and over the thatch like hands held out to a fire.

And on every branch, on every twig, thick as snow—

Blossom.

White. Pink at the edges. Open. In March. As if it were May. As if it had always been May and always would be.

Petals were coming down in the wind. Steadily. A slow white drift across the garden, across the gold path, across the step.

Lex watched them fall.

Make something with it, she'd said. *Something that matters.*

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"*It's a shame*," said Tilda.

She was standing beside him. With a saw over her shoulder and a coil of rope and her gold hand tucked into her apron. Her eyes on the tree.

"*I know*."

"*Thirty years it was dead. Then it woke up.*" She sniffed. "*She used to sit under it. In the summer. With the cat. With her pipe. Said it was the only thing in Ashbourne that never got any older.*"

"*I know*," said Lex again.

"*It doesn't give apples*," said Tilda. "*She told me. It just flowers. All year. Never sets fruit.*" She looked at him. "*What do you want it for? It's not good timber. It's apple. It's crooked. It'll warp.*"

Lex looked at the tree.

"*A door*," he said.

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SERAPHINE HAD DRAWN IT.

Four days ago. On the long table in the Forge. With no spectacles.

That had been the hardest part. Not the drawing. The spectacles. She'd come back from Mal's pool with her face cut in six small places where the lenses had shattered, and her eyes red, and no way to see anything closer than the end of her arm.

I can't wear glass, she'd said. *Not now. Not ever. She came through it, Lex. Through my face. Through my eyes. I felt her looking out of them.* She'd shuddered. *I'm never wearing glass again.*

So she'd drawn the door with her nose an inch off the paper. Squinting. With Antho beside her reading the measurements aloud from her notes, in a patient flat voice, because she couldn't read her own hand.

Height. Seven feet. Width, three and a half. Thickness—

Two inches, said Seraphine. Into the paper.

It says three.

Then I was wrong. Two.

Sera—

I can't see, Antho, I'm not deaf.

Lex had stood at the end of the table and watched them. His brother reading. His brother's wife with her nose on the page. And something in his chest that had been tight since Midwinter had gone, a little, loose.

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IT WAS A PLAIN door.

That was the thing he kept coming back to. He'd thought it would be—he didn't know what. Something enormous. Something with runes on every inch. Something like the Lockward, or the Key, or the great black door at the bottom of the Hollowmaw.

Seraphine had drawn a door you'd find on a cottage.

Seven feet high. Three and a half wide. Planked, upright, with three ledges across the back and a brace between them. A threshold-stone at the foot. A frame. Two hinges. A latch. A bell.

That was all.

It has to be, Seraphine had said. When he asked. Squinting up at him. *It's not a wall. It's not a gate. It's a door. The kind of door people knock on. The kind they come home through.* She'd tapped the drawing with her quill. *If it's big and grand and terrible, nobody will knock. They'll stand outside it and be frightened. Like the black door.*

The black door had Mam behind it.

And nobody knocked for thirteen years, said Seraphine. *Until your brother did.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D WRITTEN THE PARTS down the side.

In her tiny neat hand. With Antho reading them out.

Leaf: wood. Something that grows. Something new every morning.

Threshold: stone. Something that knows what people are.

Hinges: iron. Something that has turned before.

Bell: something that rings when someone's sad.

Paint: blue.

And at the bottom, underlined twice:

Latch:

And nothing after it.

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The latch is the problem, Seraphine had said.

Why?

Because a door is only as good as its latch. She'd sat back. Rubbed her eyes. *A wall says no. A hole says yes. A door says both. And the thing that decides is the latch. It's the latch that knows when to hold and when to let go.* She'd looked at the empty line. *It has to say yes and no. Both. And know which. And when.*

Iron? said Brannoc. From his anvil.

Iron only says no. Iron holds.

Gold?

Gold keeps. That's worse. She shook her head. *I've been through every metal in every book in the Forge. Every one of them says one thing. Hold or give. Close or open. None of them says both.*

Then what?

Seraphine had looked at the empty line for a long time.

I don't know, she said. *I don't know yet.*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SWUNG THE AXE.

It went into the trunk a foot above the ground with a sound like a door slamming. *Chock*. Deep. Into the black bark. Into the pale wood under it.

The tree shivered.

All of it. Every branch. Every twig. A great soft shudder going up through it from the root, the way a horse shudders when a fly lands on it. And the blossom came down.

All at once. Like snow off a roof. A great white drift of petals pouring down off every branch, over Lex, over Tilda, over the garden and the path and the step, so thick he couldn't see the cottage. White. Pink at the edges. Falling and falling.

He stood in it with the axe in his hands.

When it cleared, the branches were bare.

◆ ◆ ◆

FOR A BREATH.

Then the buds came.

He saw them. On every twig. Small. Green. Swelling. Splitting. *Opening*. White. Pink at the edges. In a breath. In two. As fast as the old blossom had fallen, the new came. Every branch. Every twig. Until the tree

stood over him exactly as it had before, blooming, white, with the wind from the east moving through it and the petals coming down in a slow steady drift.

New.

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"*Oh*," said Tilda.

Lex stared at it.

He looked at the axe in his hands. At the cut in the trunk. A hand deep. Pale wood. Fresh. Wet.

He put his hand on it.

Warm.

Not warm like a tree in the sun. Warm like *skin*. Like the side of a horse. Like his daughter's cheek when she'd been asleep. Warm and wet and alive, under his palm, with something moving in it. Slowly. Steadily. Like a pulse.

He felt for room.

He didn't decide to. He did it the way he did it every time now. Reaching. With the seventh Well. Three hundred miles off. A pool in a green field, bigger than it had been. *Hollow*.

And the tree was *full* of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT FULL LIKE THE bread at Westerling. Not empty and drunk away. Full like a mould just before you pour. Like a womb. Like a cupped hand. Every fibre of it. Every ring of the wood, from the bark to the heart. Room. Waiting. Making room. Over and over. Every moment. For the next thing. The next leaf. The next bud. The next flower.

New every morning, she'd said.

He'd thought she meant the flowers.

She meant all of it.

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HE TOOK HIS HAND away.

"*It's the Hollow*," he said. Slowly. "*It's been the Hollow all along. Two winters ago. When Mal started coming up. Wild Delves on the green. The*

spring in the forge yard. The mill's second chimney." He looked up at the blossom. "*Possibilities. That's what we called them.*"

"*I know*," said Tilda. "*She said.*"

"*It didn't stop*," said Lex. "*The others did. When the Delves closed. When Mal came home. The spring dried up. The chimney fell down.*" He put his hand back on the trunk. On the warm wet wood. "*This didn't.*"

"*Why*?"

"*Because she loved it*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW WHERE it came from. It came out of him the way things did now. From under the breastbone. From the place where the Wells were.

Because she loved it.

An old woman, every summer, sitting under a dead tree with a cat and a pipe. Talking to it. Thirty years. *My husband planted it the year we married*. Thirty years of an old woman sitting beside a dead thing and not giving up on it. Making room for it. In her life. In her garden. In her talking.

And when the Hollow came up through the ground two winters ago, looking for somewhere to be, looking for room—

It found a tree that had been waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Something new every morning*," he said.

Tilda looked at him.

"*Seraphine wrote it*," said Lex. "*For the leaf. Something that grows. Something new every morning.*" He looked up at the tree. At the blossom. At the petals coming down. "*She didn't know about this. She was guessing.*"

"*She guessed right*," said Tilda.

"*Mag knew*," said Lex. "*She said it. On the step. With the King. They're new every morning. That's the thing about flowers.*"

He hefted the axe.

"*Make something with it*," he said. "*Something that matters.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK ALL DAY.

He didn't use fire. He'd thought about it. He could have burned through that trunk in a minute. He didn't want to. He used the axe. And Tilda used the saw. And Brannoc came down the lane at noon and stood at the gate and watched them for a while with his arms folded, and then took off his apron and took the axe out of Lex's hands and said *you're doing it wrong, lad, you've been doing it wrong since you were eleven*, and swung.

And every stroke, the blossom came down.

And every stroke, it came back.

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THE WHOLE VILLAGE CAME.

Not all at once. In ones and twos. Standing at the garden wall. Watching. The Pruett boy with his bandaged hand and Biscuit the cat in his arms, enormous, furious. Hollis Penn with flour on his elbows. Sister Agathe, bent like a crook, leaning on the wall. Benno from the Crooked Kettle with a jug of ale he passed over the wall without a word. The widow Tull. Posy, in a grey dress, not the blue one, with her face pale and her eyes on the tree.

Nobody said anything.

They just stood at the wall and watched Old Mag's apple tree come down. In a storm of blossom that never ended.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT FELL AT DUSK.

Slowly. With a long creaking groan. The three great limbs swinging over. The trunk splitting at the cut. Brannoc shouting *away*, and everyone stepping back, and the whole tree going down across the garden, across the gold path, onto the slush and the petals.

It lay there.

On its side. With its branches spread across the garden like hands. Blooming.

Still blooming.

Every branch. Every twig. On the ground. In the slush. White. Pink at the edges. Opening. Falling. Opening again.

Lex stood over it with his chest heaving and sweat running into his eyes.

"*It's not dying*," said Tilda. Very quietly.

"*No*."

"*It's cut. It's down. It should be dying.*" She was staring at it. "*Lex, it's still growing.*"

He knelt by the stump.

He put his hand on the cut. The pale wet wood. Warm.

He felt it. The room. The waiting. Not less. Not going out. *Exactly as before*. Every ring of the wood making room, over and over, for the next thing.

"*It's not a tree anymore*," he said. "*Not really. It's the Hollow. Wearing a tree.*" He looked at the fallen trunk. At the blossom. "*It doesn't know how to die. It only knows how to make room.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEBODY LAUGHED.

At the wall. A woman's laugh. Rough. Cracked. Astonished. Like water coming out of a spring.

He looked up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS STANDING AT the gate.

A woman of forty. Thin. Weathered. In one of his mother's old dresses, grey, too big, with the sleeves rolled up. With dark brown hair shot through with grey, curling at the ends, tied back with a strip of cloth. With freckles across her nose. With dirt in the creases of her hands.

And green eyes.

The greenest thing in the garden.

She was looking at the fallen tree. Laughing. With her hand over her mouth and tears on her face.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D MET HER FOUR days ago.

At Harrow. On the ramp of the blue-door cottage. His mother had brought her home on the dragon from Mal's pool, wrapped in Kit's blankets. And Lex had come across the stepping stones in the dark and

found a stranger sitting at his mother's table by the west window, under the horn lantern, eating bread.

Eating it the way Lark ate it. With both hands. With her eyes closed. With crumbs everywhere.

She'd looked up. Green eyes. And he'd known her.

You held the thorns, he'd said.

You're the one with the handprint, said Rhosyn. Through a mouthful of bread. *Mae's hand.* She'd swallowed. *She always did have a heavy hand.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS LIVING AT Harrow now.

In the blue-door cottage. With his mother. On a cot in the corner where his father's bed had been, under the window. She slept twelve hours a night. She ate everything. She went out into the birch wood in the mornings, in the cold, and came back with her hands full of things. Moss. Snowdrops. A bird's nest, empty, from last spring. A stone with a hole in it.

She'd planted a rose on the grave.

The morning after she came. By the stone. Beside the one she'd sent through the snow, the one with the silk. She'd knelt in the slush by the twenty lanterns with her bare hands in the frozen earth and planted it—a cutting, from her own crown, the crown she'd left on the rim of Mal's pool—and it had rooted. In a night. And put out leaves.

For Hes's girl's husband, she'd said. *He sounds like he was a good man.*

He was, his mother had said.

Hes would have liked him, said Rhosyn. *She liked men who cried.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME IN THROUGH the gate now.

Across the garden. Through the slush. Through the petals. To the fallen tree. And knelt by it. On the other side of the stump from Lex.

She put her hand on the trunk.

Brown. Callused. A gardener's hand.

She closed her eyes.

"*Oh*," she said. Very softly. "*Oh, it's so happy.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HER.

"*Happy*?"

"*It's listening*," said Rhosyn. Without opening her eyes. "*It's been listening for thirty years. To her. Every day. On the step. In the summer. With her pipe.*" Her hand moved on the bark. Slowly. Stroking it. "*She talked to it. Did you know? Every morning. About nothing. The weather. The cat. Her husband. Her boy at sea.*"

"*I know*."

"*It loved her*," said the Thorn-Crowned. Who wasn't, anymore. Who had dirt on her hands. "*Trees do. If you talk to them long enough. They lean toward your voice. Like flowers to the sun.*" She opened her eyes. "*It's been leaning toward her for thirty years.*"

She looked at the cottage. Dark. Shut up. The door closed.

"*And she's gone*," said Rhosyn. "*And it doesn't know where.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The blossom fell. And opened. And fell.

"*It's going to be a door*," said Lex. At last. Quietly. "*At the edge. Where the Veil was. A door for people to come home through.*"

Rhosyn looked at him.

"*She made me promise*," said Lex. "*Make something with it. Something that matters.*" He looked at the tree. "*I'm going to make it the door.*"

The woman who had been the Thorn-Crowned looked at the fallen apple tree for a long time.

Then she bent over it. Over the trunk. Close. Her lips an inch from the bark.

And whispered something.

Lex didn't hear what.

But the tree heard. He felt it. Under his own hand, on the stump, on the pale wet wood. A shiver. A lift. Like a dog's ears coming up at a voice it knows.

And the blossom—all of it, every flower on every branch on the fallen tree—turned.

Very slightly. All together.

East.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What did you tell it*?" said Lex.

Rhosyn sat back on her heels.

"*That she's gone home*," she said. "*And that the door it's going to be is the door she went through.*" She wiped her face with the back of her dirty hand. "*So it'll know which way to lean.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CUT IT INTO planks over the next three days.

In the yard at the Forge. On the great saw-bench. With Brannoc on one end of the two-man saw and Lex on the other and Tilda feeding the timber and half the Forge standing round watching.

It didn't warp.

That was the first thing. Apple always warps. Brannoc said so. Every carpenter in the Vale said so. Crooked wood, twisting grain, you can't make a straight plank of it to save your life.

They made eleven.

Straight. True. Two inches thick. Pale gold at the heart, darker at the edges, with a grain that ran through them like water. Warm to the touch. And every one of them—every plank, sawn and planed and stacked in the yard in the cold March wind—

Blooming.

Not much. A twig left on here. A knot there. And from every one, flowers. Small. White. Opening. Falling. Opening again.

The yard at the Forge was ankle-deep in petals by the third day.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It'll never season*," said Brannoc. Standing over the stack. With his gold fingertips in his armpits and petals on his bald head. "*You can't season wood that won't stop growing. It'll move. Every day. A little. Swell. Shrink. You'll never get a door to hang true.*"

"*It doesn't need to season*," said Lex.

The old smith looked at him.

"*A door that grows*," said Lex. "*A door that's new every morning. That makes room. Every day.*" He put his hand on the top plank. Warm. "*It's not supposed to be finished, Brannoc. That's the point. It's supposed to keep making room.*"

Brannoc looked at the planks for a long time.

"*Your father'd have liked that*," he said. Gruffly. "*He never finished anything either.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT NIGHT, LEX SAT at the long table in the Forge with Seraphine's drawing in front of him.

Alone. Late. With one hearth lit and the rest banked and the rain on the roof and the smell of apple wood and coal smoke.

Leaf: wood. Something that grows. Something new every morning.

He drew a line through it. *Done*.

Threshold: stone. Something that knows what people are.

He looked at it for a long time.

He knew what it was. He'd known since the day of the council, when Seraphine read it out. He'd known before that. He'd known since he was sixteen.

The Ashbourne Stone. Cracked down the middle. Clouded like old ice. Where every child of the village had put their hand at sixteen for three hundred years and been told what they were.

SMITH. Common. Ceiling 24.

Something that knows what people are.

It was wrapped in four layers of sacking and canvas and chains on the green, with a hush-rune cut at its foot. With the Glass Queen behind it. Looking out.

He didn't draw a line through that one.

◆ ◆ ◆

Hinges: iron. Something that has turned before.

He looked under the bench.

The basket. Wicker. Lined with straw. He'd brought it from Harrow. In the cart. With the HERE lantern gone from the east window and Wren watching him go.

Three pieces of black iron. Bow. Bit. Blade.

Something that has turned before.

He didn't draw a line through that one either. Not yet.

◆ ◆ ◆

Bell: something that rings when someone's sad.

He put his hand on his chest. On the cord. On the small silver weight under his shirt, against his breastbone. With its crooked clapper.

It was quiet.

◆ ◆ ◆

Paint: blue.

His mother would mix it. She'd said so. *Harrow blue*. The blue of the door on her cottage. The blue every Harrow woman had painted every door of every cottage in thirty villages in twenty generations. *So you'll know it's ours. So you'll know where to come home to.*

Even though we never stayed, she'd said. *We always painted the door.*

◆ ◆ ◆

Latch:

Nothing after it. Underlined twice.

He looked at it for a long time.

It has to say yes and no. Both. And know which. And when.

He thought about everything he'd ever made. Hammers. Swords. Horseshoes. Nails. Lanterns. Hinges. Latches—hundreds of latches, for half the doors in the Vale. Iron. Simple. A bar and a catch and a thumb-lift. Every one of them said the same thing. *Shut*. Until someone lifted it. Then *open*. Until someone dropped it.

They didn't *know*. They didn't decide. They just did what the hand told them.

It has to know which. And when.

He didn't know anything that knew.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOOR OF THE Forge opened.

Rain blew in. Cold. And Wren. In her wet cloak with her hood up and her bow over her shoulder. Without Lark. She'd left her with his mother and Rhosyn and Kestrel and every bucket lidded.

She came down the long hall between the anvils and stopped at the end of the table.

Her face was white.

"*Lex*," she said.

He was on his feet.

"*It's not her*," said Wren. Fast. "*She's fine. She's asleep. Your mother's got her. It's not her.*" She took a breath. "*It's him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Who*?"

"*The King*."

Lex went cold.

"*He's at Harrow*," said Wren. "*At the edge of the birch wood. At dusk. He came up the gold path. He's standing there. At the bottom of the yard. By the stream.*" She swallowed. "*He won't come any closer. He just stands there. With his cup.*"

"*Did he say anything*?"

Wren looked at him.

"*He said, tell the smith*," she said. "*He said it to me. Across the yard. In the rain. He said, tell the smith she came again. Last night. In the cup.*"

Lex didn't move.

"*He said*," said Wren slowly, "*tell him Ysy says, if I bring her the child, the net will keep everyone. Every thread. Forever.*" Her voice shook. "*No doors at all. Not for anyone. Not ever.*"

She looked at him.

"*He said, tell him I'm thinking about it*."

CHAPTER 17

What the King Kept

OSZRIC OF THE CROWNED had never looked at them.

He knew that now. He'd known it since the night the edge came down, standing in the snow with a cup in his hand, watching a spit-girl walk past him into the world. *I hadn't looked at any of them in nine hundred years. I'd walked past them every day and never once looked.*

So he looked now.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE EVERYWHERE.

All across the west of the smith's kingdom. In the fields. In the woods. On the roads. In the middle of villages, in the middle of farmyards, in the middle of a mill-pond once, up to his gold waist in the water with ducks swimming round him. Walking. East. A finger's width at a time.

His household.

He went among them.

Slowly. Carefully. Putting his feet down in the slush so as not to gild more than he had to. Through the fields and the woods and the villages, in the last of the winter, with the cup in his hand. Stopping by each one. Standing in front of them.

And *looking*.

◆ ◆ ◆

A GROOM. TALL. STOOPED. With a gold bridle in his hand. Walking across a ploughed field toward a hedge.

Oszric stopped in front of him.

He didn't know his name. He'd had four hundred grooms. Five hundred. He'd never known any of their names. They'd held his horse and he'd got on it.

The groom's eyes moved. Up. To him.

And held.

Oszric stood in the ploughed field and looked into the gold eyes of a man who had held his horse nine hundred years ago, and been kept in gold on the night of the boat, and stood by a white road in a grey country with no sun for nine hundred years watching his king walk past.

He didn't know what was in the eyes.

He'd never known what was in anyone's eyes. That was Ysy. Ysy always knew. Ysy could look at a face and tell you everything in it, laid out like goods on a table.

He couldn't.

He looked anyway.

And after a while he thought—he wasn't sure—he thought it might be *tired*.

◆ ◆ ◆

A NURSEMAID. WITH A gold child on her hip. Three or four. A boy. Both of them kept. The boy's gold fist in the nursemaid's gold hair.

He knew this one.

Not her name. Her face. She'd been nurse to his cousins' children. To Merrow's little brother. He remembered her in the nursery corridors, scolding, laughing, with her sleeves rolled up.

He stood in front of her for a long time.

The child's eyes moved. To him. Wide. Gold. Three years old for nine hundred years.

He had to look away.

◆ ◆ ◆

A COOK. A GARDENER. Two boys from the kennels, holding hands. An old man with a gold stick, so slow he'd barely moved since the edge came down—a mile, maybe, in three months. A soldier with a gold spear held upright. A laundress with a gold basket.

A man with a gold harp.

He stopped longest in front of that one.

He remembered the harp. He remembered the man. Leolin. The only one of them whose name he knew. Leolin had played in the long hall every night for twenty years. Before the pool. Before the boat. He'd played at Oszric's naming-day and his father's funeral and Mae's wedding.

He'd played on the boat.

All the way out. Across the grey water. In chains, like the rest of them. With the Ferryman in the stern and the shore going away. Leolin had sat in the bottom of the boat with his harp in his lap and played. Very quietly. A song Oszric didn't know. For the whole crossing.

And on the far shore, when the grey country closed round them, Oszric had put his hand on Leolin's shoulder. To keep him. So he'd never come apart.

The harp had gone gold first. Then Leolin.

He'd never played again.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC STOOD IN FRONT of him in a muddy lane in the smith's kingdom with the rain coming down and looked at the gold harp.

The strings were gold. All of them. Stopped. Mid-note, maybe. Mid-chord. Leolin's gold fingers on them.

Leolin's eyes moved.

Up. To him.

And Oszric heard it. Very faint. Under the rain. Under the hum—*home*—that came from every one of them.

Not a song. Not a note.

The *shape* of one. The shape of the song Leolin had been playing on the boat when the gold came up his arm. Hanging there. In the gold strings. Nine hundred years. Never finished.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED ON.

He didn't know what else to do.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT TO GREYFALL.

He hadn't meant to. His feet took him. West. Along the old road. Through the line of the smith's lanterns—small and gold, each in its own circle of real winter—and into the grey. Past the silent mill. Past the empty farms. Past the stakes crowding closer and closer together.

To the crag above the old edge. To the outpost. To the gate.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MAN WAS STILL standing in it.

Gold. In the gateway. Square in the middle. Feet planted. A staff held crosswise in both hands, chest-high, barring the way.

There was a lantern at his feet. Small. Iron. Lit. In a circle of white snow on the grey stone.

Oszric stopped in front of him.

◆ ◆ ◆

You're not coming through this gate.

He'd said that. In the summer. When Oszric came up the road from the crack in the Veil. One man. Alone. With a staff. In front of the Gilded King and the whole gold storm of him. Everyone else gone east. Sent. *Somebody has to stand somewhere.*

And Oszric had thought it was beautiful.

He'd stood in front of this man in the summer and thought *you should never stop. You should stand there forever. Exactly like that.*

And reached out. Very gently. And touched his face.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MAN'S EYES MOVED.

Up. To him.

Grey. Not gold—his eyes had been grey, Oszric remembered, grey and hard, and they were gold now like the rest of him, but they'd been grey. And they looked at Oszric now the way they'd looked at him in the summer.

You're not coming through this gate.

They hadn't changed. Nine months. Kept. Stopped. Standing in a gateway with a staff. And they hadn't changed at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Roole*," said Oszric.

He'd learned the name. From the Knight. The one with the sword, who came every few days and brushed the snow off the man's shoulders and talked to him. *Evening, Commander. Line moved a mile today. I'll be back on Thursday.*

"*Daxian Roole*," said Oszric. "*Commander of the Keepers of the Stones.*"

The grey-gold eyes held him.

"*I'm sorry*," said Oszric.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HADN'T KNOWN HE was going to say it. It came out of him the way things came out of him now. Since the old woman's cottage. Since the step. Since *there, see, not so bad*.

"*I thought it was beautiful*," he said. "*You. Standing here. In the summer. With your staff. One man. In front of me.*" His voice was very low. "*I thought, he should stand there forever. Like that. Exactly like that. So no one ever has to see him fall.*"

The eyes didn't move.

"*So I kept you*," said the Gilded King. "*Because I thought it was beautiful.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD THERE IN the grey.

In front of the gate. In front of the gold man with the staff. With the little iron lantern burning at the gold man's feet in its circle of real snow, and the wind going past, west, endless.

"*Do you want to come out*?" said Oszric.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE EYES MOVED.

Not up. Not away. They moved *in*. Narrowed. The way a man's eyes narrow when he's listening very hard.

Then they moved. Down. To the staff. Crosswise. In his own gold hands. Barring the gate.

Then back up. To Oszric.

And Oszric knew.

He didn't have Ysy's eyes. He couldn't read faces. He'd never been able to. But he knew this one. He'd seen it in the summer. On the road. In the gate. A man who had decided something and was not going to undecide it.

Yes.

Yes, I want to come out.

And I'm still not letting you through this gate.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC LAUGHED.

It came out of him cracked. Wet. Astonished. The way the old woman had laughed on her step. He stood in the grey in front of Greyfall gate and laughed until there were gold tears on his face.

"*All right*," he said. "*All right. Commander.*"

He held out his hand.

Not to touch. He'd learned that. An inch off. Over the gold hands on the staff. Palm down.

And he tried to let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D NEVER TRIED.

That was the thing. In nine hundred years. He'd put his hand on his household on the night of the boat and *held*, and he'd never once tried to open it. Not for a moment. Not for one of them.

He didn't know how.

He stood with his hand over Roole's and thought *let go. Just this one. Just him. Open your hand. Let him out.*

And he felt for it.

The keeping. The hold. The thing he'd drunk at the pool, nine hundred years ago, cold and sweet and the most beautiful thing he'd ever tasted. The thing that came out of his hands into everything he touched and *stopped* it. Kept it. Forever.

He found it.

It was in his hand. In his chest. In the middle of him. A grip. Huge. Steady. Closed. Like a fist that had been closed so long the fingers had forgotten they could open.

He tried to open it.

Just a little. Just one finger. Just for this one man in this one gate.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT MOVED.

He felt it move. The grip. Loosen. A hair. A breath.

And he felt Roole—

He felt something in the gold under his hand *stir*. The way a sleeper stirs. A breath going in that hadn't gone in for nine months. A heartbeat. One. Slow. Like a drum in a far valley.

Yes.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HE FELT the others.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OF THEM. AT once. Everywhere.

Because it wasn't nine thousand grips. It never had been. He'd known that, on the green, with the smith. *It's one hold. I put it on them the night of the boat, all of them, at once, and I've never let go.*

He'd known it.

He hadn't *felt* it.

He felt it now.

◆ ◆ ◆

NINE THOUSAND PEOPLE. ACROSS the smith's kingdom. In fields and woods and lanes and farmyards and a mill-pond. A groom with a bridle. A nursemaid with a child on her hip. Two boys holding hands. An old man with a stick. A soldier. A laundress.

Leolin. With his harp.

All of them. *Stirring*. As the grip loosened. A hair. A breath.

And under the stirring—

Coming apart.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT START.

In all of them. At once. The way a frost-cracked wall starts to crumble when the thaw comes. A loosening. A softening. At the edges. Their gold

going—not to flesh. To *dust*. Nine hundred years. Nine hundred years of time they hadn't lived, waiting behind the gold like water behind a dam. And the dam cracking.

The nursemaid. The child on her hip. He felt the child—*three years old*, *three years old for nine hundred years*—felt the gold of the small fist in the nursemaid's hair go soft. Grey at the edges. Like ash. Like the dust in the halls in the first year. Like the cousins at the edge.

Leolin's fingers on the harp-strings. Going grey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CLOSED HIS HAND.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T DECIDE TO. It happened. The way you snatch your hand back from a fire. The grip slammed shut. All the way. Harder than before. *Holding*. With everything he had. Every one of them. All nine thousand. Every grain of gold in every one of them. *Stop*. *Stay*. *Don't*.

The stirring stopped.

The grey went out of the edges.

The child's fist in the nursemaid's hair went back to gold. Hard. Bright. Kept.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ROOLE—

The heartbeat. The one slow drum in a far valley. The breath going in.

Stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC STOOD IN THE grey in front of Greyfall gate with his hand out over the gold man's hands and his whole body shaking.

He couldn't breathe.

He'd felt them. All of them. Coming apart. Starting to. For a breath. For less. In fields and woods and lanes across the world. Because he'd tried to let one man out of a gate.

It's one hold.

If I open my hand, I open it all the way.

◆ ◆ ◆

ROOLE'S EYES WERE ON him.

Grey-gold. Steady. Hard.

They'd felt it too. Oszric saw that. The heartbeat. The breath. *Yes*. And then the grip slamming shut again, and the breath stopping, and the gold closing back over everything.

The eyes didn't blame him.

That was the worst of it. Oszric looked into them and saw—he didn't have Ysy's eyes, he'd never been able to read a face, but he saw this—he saw that Daxian Roole, Commander of the Keepers, standing in a gate for nine months with a staff, didn't blame him at all.

He just looked.

The way you'd look at a man who'd tried to lift something too heavy for him and dropped it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can't*," said Oszric.

His voice cracked. All the way through.

"*I can't let you go. Not just you. Not one.*" He was shaking. "*It's all of them. If I let you out, I let them all out. And they'd come apart. All of them. Nine hundred years. In front of me.*" He looked at his own hand. Gold. Enormous. Shaking. "*Leolin. The nursemaid. The child. All of them. At once.*"

The eyes held him.

"*And me*," said Oszric. Very quietly. "*It's me too. It's what I drank. It's what I am. If I opened my hand all the way—*"

He didn't finish.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD THERE FOR a long time.

In the grey. In front of the gate. With the wind going past, west, endless. With the little iron lantern at Roole's feet in its circle of real snow.

Kept's the oven, the old woman had said. *Finished is the cake.*

He'd thought he understood. In the cottage. Holding her hand. Watching her go. *She was finished. Like a cake.*

He hadn't understood.

He understood now.

To finish Roole, he'd have to finish all of them. Every one. Leolin and the nursemaid and the child and the two boys holding hands and the old man with the stick. Nine thousand cakes he'd left in the oven for nine hundred years.

And himself.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED AWAY FROM Greyfall at dusk.

He didn't look back.

He wanted to. He didn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSY CAME THAT NIGHT.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS SITTING ON a hill above the old road. In the grey. Where nobody would come. With his back against a gold rock that had been a grey one an hour ago, and the cup in his lap.

He looked into it.

He didn't know why. He always looked into it, now. At night. In the dark. The lopsided white cup the hedge-witch had made, with the big smith's wrong handle and her own thumb-print in the rim. Gold. All of it. And the tea in it, a gold disc. Flat. Still. Polished.

He looked into it the way you'd look into a fire. Not for anything. Just to look.

And she was there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oz*," said his sister.

Her face. In the gold. Small. Clear. Like a face seen through ice. With her white hair and her narrow crown of glass and her ice-grey eyes.

"*Ysy*."

"*You went to the gate*." Her voice was cold. Clear. Like a bell under ice. "*At Greyfall. You tried to let him out.*"

He didn't answer.

"*I felt it*," said Ysenne. "*All the way down here. In the net. Every one of them. Your whole household. Starting to come apart.*" A pause. "*You nearly killed them, Oz. All of them. For one Keeper in a gate.*"

"*I know.*"

"*Why?*"

He didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's Rosie*," said Ysenne. "*Isn't it. She's put ideas in your head.*" The ice-grey eyes narrowed. "*She gave it back. Did you know? At the pool. In the smith's green field. She knelt down and opened her hand and poured it all back. Nine hundred years.*" Her voice went very cold. "*And now she's a woman of forty with dirt on her hands, eating bread in a hedge-witch's cottage, getting older every day.*"

"*I know*," said Oszric. "*I felt that too.*"

"*She's going to die, Oz.*"

"*I know.*"

"*In thirty years. Forty. In a bed. By a window.*" The face in the cup was very still. "*Like the old woman you sat with. Like the smith's father.*" A pause. "*Rosie. Our Rosie. She's going to go through the door.*"

He didn't say anything.

He looked at his sister's face in the cup and didn't say anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Bring me the child*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D KNOWN SHE'D SAY it. She'd said it before. Twice. On the green, the first time, in the dark. Then again, last night, by the stream at the bottom of the hedge-witch's yard, in the rain.

Bring me the child.

"*I'm nearly there*," said the Glass Queen. "*The middle. The crown in the road. I can feel it. Down the threads. Warm. Gold. Empty.*" Her voice was very soft now. "*A few weeks. That's all. And then I'll be standing in front of it.*"

"*And it won't let you in*."

"*No. Not without a Vey hand.*" The ice-grey eyes held his. "*So bring me one. A small one. The smallest. She won't even know.*"

"*She'd know*," said Oszric.

"*She's a baby*."

"*She said no to me*," said the Gilded King. "*In the autumn. On the floor of her grandmother's cottage. I held out my hand and she took her fist out of her mouth and said no.*"

"*She says no to everything, Oz. She's one.*"

"*She said it to me*."

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE WAS QUIET.

Then her face in the cup changed. Softened. The ice going out of it a little. The way it used to, when they were children, in the nursery, at the long mirror, when she'd stopped being clever and was just his little sister.

"*Oz*," she said. "*Listen to me. Please.*"

He listened.

"*If I hold the net*," said Ysenne, "*I can keep everyone. Do you understand? Not just your household. Everyone. Every thread. Every person in the world.*" Her voice was very gentle. "*Nobody would ever have to go through the door again. Not old women. Not old men in beds by windows. Not Rosie.*"

He didn't move.

"*Not you*," said his sister. "*Not your household. Not one of them would ever have to come apart. Leolin. The nursemaid. The child on her hip. You'd never have to open your hand. Not ever.*" A pause. "*I'd hold it for you. Forever. With the net.*"

"*Like gold*," said Oszric.

"*Like glass*," said Ysenne. "*Clear. True. Everyone exactly what they are. Forever. Nothing lost. Nothing finished.*" Her ice-grey eyes were very bright. "*No more doors, Oz. Not for anyone. Not ever. You'd never have to stand outside one again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT HER face in the cup.

He thought about his father. In the room at the end of the corridor. For a month. With Cad holding his hand. And Oszric outside the door. Every night. With his hand on the latch.

He thought about the old woman. On her pillows. *Kept's the oven. Finished is the cake.*

He thought about the smith's father. On three pillows. By a boarded window. With his wife holding one hand and his son the other. *You should have gone in. He'd have liked you there.*

He thought about Hes.

In a garden door. In the dark. All night. *In case one of you wanted to come out*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'll think about it*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS SISTER'S FACE WENT still.

Not cold. *Still*. The way glass goes still. The way water goes still in a pond when the wind drops.

"*You said that last night*," said Ysenne.

"*I know*."

"*And the night before*."

"*I know*."

"*I haven't got long, Oz*," said the Glass Queen. "*A few weeks. And then I'll be standing in front of the crown in the road with no hand to pick it up.*" A pause. "*And if you won't bring her—*"

She stopped.

He waited.

"*Think quickly*," said his sister.

And was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT ON THE hill in the dark for a long time.

With the cup in his lap. With the gold disc of tea in it, flat, still, polished, showing nothing now. Just the dark sky. Just his own great gold face, looking down.

If you won't bring her—

He knew what came after. He'd known Ysy for nine hundred years. Nine hundred and nineteen. Since she was born, red-faced and screaming, in the queen's bedchamber, and the nurse had held her up and said *a girl, a girl, look at her, isn't she pretty*. And Oz, four years old, had looked and thought *no, she's red and cross and her face is all squashed*.

And then she'd opened her eyes. Grey. Ice-grey. And looked at him. And he'd thought *oh*.

If you won't bring her, I'll fetch her myself.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE GOT UP.

He walked.

East. Through the grey. Through the lanterns. Into the world. Through the night and the next day and the next. Along the old road. Up the Vale. Through the villages, where people stood in their doors and watched him go by and pulled their children in. Through Ashbourne, past the green with its Stone wrapped in sacking and chains, glowing white through the canvas. Past an old woman's garden with an apple tree's stump by the door, and petals still falling from it, white, onto the gold path.

Up the Vale road. Into the birch wood. Up his own gold footprints.

To the hedge-witch's cottage.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED AT THE bottom of the yard.

By the stream. Where the birches ended. In the rain. At dusk.

He could see it all. The cottage with the blue door and the oak ramp and the horn lantern in its west window. The other cottage, across the stream, with a horn lantern in its east window—no. The east window was dark. He looked again. Dark. Empty. Something had been there, and was gone.

The grave by the stream. The grey stone. Twenty lanterns round it. A black soft thing that had been a turnip. Two roses. Red. Growing.

And on the ramp of the blue-door cottage, in the doorway, in the light from inside—

The smith's wife. With her bow. Looking at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T COME CLOSER.

He stood at the bottom of the yard in the rain with the cup in his hand and called across to her. Not loud. He didn't need to be loud. He'd never needed to be loud.

"*Tell the smith*," he said. "*She came again. Last night. In the cup.*"

The smith's wife didn't move.

He told her. All of it. *If I bring her the child, the net will keep everyone. Forever. No doors at all.*

"*Tell him I'm thinking about it*," said the Gilded King.

And the smith's wife looked at him across the yard for a long time. With her bow in her hand and her face white. And then she turned and went inside. And he heard her voice, low, fast. And the other woman's. And then a door at the back. And footsteps, running, away down the track through the birch wood toward the Ashbourne road.

Going to fetch the smith.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD THERE ALL night.

He didn't sit. He didn't move. He stood at the bottom of the yard by the stream in the rain with the cup in his hand and watched the cottage.

The smith came at midnight. On foot. Running. Up the track. He stopped in the yard. Between Oszric and the door. With his hands at his sides.

He didn't say anything.

Neither did Oszric.

They stood there. The two of them. In the rain. Across the yard. All night.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT DAWN, THE DOOR opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE SMITH'S DOOR. The other one. The blue one. On the ramp. In the grey light.

And down the ramp, very fast, in a nightshirt so long it trailed behind her like a train, falling forward and catching herself and falling forward and catching herself with her arms out and her square fists clenched and a look of fierce concentration on her round face—

The child.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC WENT VERY STILL.

So did the smith.

So did the hedge-witch, in the doorway behind her, with her hand out, too late. So did the grey-haired woman beside her, who had been Rosie, and was a woman of forty now, with dirt on her hands. So did the smith's wife, on the ramp of the other cottage, with her bow coming up.

Nobody moved.

The child came down the ramp. *Thump*. *Thump*. Into the yard. Into the mud. Across it.

Toward him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T MOVE.

He couldn't. He stood at the bottom of the yard with the cup in his hands and watched her come. Small. Square. Fourteen months. With her fluff of dark hair standing up like a bird's crest and her nightshirt dragging in the mud and her grey-green eyes fixed on him.

Don't, he thought. *Don't. Don't come close. Don't touch me. I'll keep you. I won't mean to. I'll keep you and you'll stand in this yard forever in your nightshirt with your eyes moving.*

He put his hands behind his back.

Both of them. With the cup. Behind him. Out of reach. And held them there. So tight his gold shoulders ached.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMITH HADN'T MOVED.

Oszric saw him. A yard to the side. Every muscle in his body locked. His face white. His hands open. Ready. *Ready*. To throw himself between them.

He didn't.

He stood there. Shaking. And let her come.

Oszric didn't understand. Then he did. *He's letting her. He's terrified, and he's letting her.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CHILD STOPPED.

A yard off. In the mud. In front of him. Swaying a little, the way she did, catching her balance.

She looked up at him.

All the way up. Her head tipping back and back. At the biggest thing she'd ever seen. Gold. Glowing. Taller than the birches, nearly. With his hands behind his back.

She looked at him for a long time.

Then she looked past him.

At his hands. Behind his back. Where the cup was.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE COULDN'T HAVE SEEN it. He was holding it behind him. Out of sight.

She looked at it anyway.

Her eyes went to it the way they'd gone to it in the autumn. On the floor of the hedge-witch's cottage. Past his outstretched hand. To the cup.

And her face changed.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC FELT IT BEFORE he understood it.

The cup. In his hands. Behind his back. Going cold.

Not the cold of gold in the rain. A different cold. A *clear* cold. Like ice on a pond. Like frost on a window.

Ysy.

She was there. In the cup. In the gold disc of tea. He could feel her. Looking out. Out of the cup. Past his hands. Past his back.

At the child.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE CHILD LOOKED back.

Straight at it. At the cup. At the gold. At whatever was in it. With her grey-green eyes wide and steady and her mouth set in a line.

The way she'd looked at the stream, Ysy said, on the night the edge fell. Through the ice. Straight at her.

As if there were something there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CHILD TOOK HER fist out of her mouth.

"*No*," said Lark Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAID IT TO the cup.

Not to him. He felt it. She said it *past* him. Through him. To the thing in the gold behind his back.

Loud. Clear. Furious. With her whole small body. With her square fists clenched at her sides and her face red and her feet planted in the mud of the yard like a smith at an anvil.

"*No*."

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COLD IN THE cup—

Flinched.

He felt it. Felt it go through the gold in his hands. A shiver. A start. Like someone who's been caught looking through a keyhole. Like a face at a window jerking back.

And then nothing.

The cup was just gold. Warm, a little, from his hands. Gold tea in it. Still.

She'd gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD THERE.

In the mud. In the dawn. With his hands behind his back.

The child looked up at him again. At his face. Her own face had gone back to round and calm and serious, the way it always was. As if she'd just put a goat out of the kitchen.

Then she turned round. And went back across the yard. *Thump*. *Thump*. Toward the hedge-witch, who had come down the ramp now, white-faced, with her arms out.

The child walked into them.

And put her fist back in her mouth.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC BROUGHT HIS HANDS round from behind his back.

Slowly. With the cup in them.

He looked into it.

Gold. Flat. Still. Polished. His own face looking back. Great and gold and wet.

And under it, faint—so faint he almost didn't see it—

A crack.

◆ ◆ ◆

THIN. A HAIR. ACROSS the gold disc of tea. From one side of the cup to the other.

Gold doesn't crack. Gold bends. Gold dents. Gold never cracks.

It had cracked.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT for a long time.

At the crack in the gold. At the place where his sister's face had been, and a child had looked at it, and said no.

He thought about the old woman. *There, see, not so bad*.

He thought about Hes. In the door. All night.

He thought about Roole. In the gate. With his staff. *Yes, I want to come out. And I'm still not letting you through.*

He looked up.

The smith was looking at him. Across the yard. White-faced. Shaking. With his hands open at his sides.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ysy*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

He said it to the cup. Quietly. To the crack. To wherever she'd gone. Down the threads. Into the net.

"No."

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS VERY SMALL.

One word. In the rain. At dawn. At the bottom of a hedge-witch's yard.

He'd never said it to her. Not once. Not in nine hundred and nineteen years. Not when she was four and wanted his pony. Not when she was nine and wanted him to tell her she was pretty. Not when she was nineteen and knelt beside him at the pool and said *drink, Oz, drink, it's the most beautiful thing, drink with me*.

He'd never said it to anyone.

He'd never had to. He was the King. He was the eldest. Gold for the eldest. Everyone else said yes.

He looked at the crack in the cup.

"No," he said again. Louder. To the smith. Across the yard. *"I won't bring her. Tell your wife. Tell your mother. I won't."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMITH DIDN'T SAY anything.

He stood in the mud with his hands open and looked at him. And Oszric saw his face change. Slowly. The way metal changes when it comes out of the fire and starts to cool. White to red to grey.

Not relief.

Something else. Something Oszric didn't have a word for.

He thought, later, the word might have been *thank you*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED TO GO.

And stopped.

And looked back. At the smith. At the cottage. At the child in the hedge-witch's arms. At the woman beside them with green eyes and dirt on her hands and grey in her hair.

At Rosie.

She was looking at him. Across the yard. Very steadily.

"Oz," she said.

"Rosie."

"*That's the first time*," said his sister. "*Isn't it? You've never said no to anyone.*"

"*No*," said the Gilded King.

Then he heard himself. And laughed. Cracked. Wet. Astonished.

"*No*," he said again. "*No, I haven't.*"

His sister smiled at him. Brown. Weathered. Tired. Forty. With roses in her hair.

"*Hes would be so proud*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED AWAY DOWN the gold path through the birch wood.

He didn't look back.

But as he went—as he came down through the white trunks of the birches toward the Ashbourne road—he heard something behind him. Very faint. Very far. Off-key. From under the smith's shirt, across the yard, against his breastbone, on a cord.

Ting.

He stopped.

He stood on the gold path in the birch wood and listened.

Ting.

It rings when someone's sad, the smith had said.

Oszric of the Crowned stood very still. And listened to the bell. And put his hand flat against his own chest. Over Mae's crown. Over the place where his heart was.

And understood, for the first time in nine hundred years, who it was ringing for.

It wasn't him.

It was her.

It was Ysy.

CHAPTER 18

The Lantern Line

THE RAVEN CAME AT noon, and it was Elowen's, and there was blood on it.

Wren saw the blood first. On the black feathers of its breast. Dried. Brown. Not the bird's. The bird was fine. Furious, exhausted, ruffled, perched on the edge of the water barrel in the yard at the Forge with its beak open and its wings half-spread, panting.

Not its blood.

She took the paper off its leg with her good hand. It was crumpled. Torn at one corner. Written in pencil, fast, sliding off the edge of the page.

◆ ◆ ◆

Wren.

They're coming out of the ice.

At the line. Every puddle, every ditch, every rut with a skin of ice on it. Since yesterday. Since dawn.

They look like us. Exactly. Our faces. Our clothes. Glass.

They're breaking the lanterns. Not drinking. Breaking. Kicking them over. Stamping.

Fire doesn't touch them. Swords crack them and they come back out of the next puddle.

Ada Fell is dead. Her own face did it.

We need mist. Please.

E.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN READ IT TWICE.

Then she turned round.

Lex was at the door of the Forge. With soot on his face and the little hammer in his hand and Lark on his hip, chewing the end of his apron string. He'd seen the raven come in. He'd seen her face.

He held out his hand for the paper.

She gave it to him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE READ IT. SHE watched him read it. Watched his face go still.

Then he looked at her.

She didn't say anything. She didn't need to. She'd been his wife for two years. She'd been beside him for seven. She knew what he was going to say before he opened his mouth.

I'll go.

"*I'll go*," said Lex.

"*No*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STARED AT HER.

"*She says mist*," said Wren. "*She says please. She doesn't say fire.*" She took the paper back. "*Fire doesn't touch them. She says that too.*"

"*Black heat—*"

"*Kestrel can do black heat*." Wren folded the paper. Small. Put it in her coat. "*Kestrel can come with me.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*And you can't*," she said. "*You can't, Lex. You've got to stay here.*" She looked at the baby on his hip. At the square fist round the apron string. "*With her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

She watched it go through him. All of it. *She's going west. Into the grey. To fight glass things that wear your own face and kill you with it. And I'm staying here.*

With a baby. With a stream at the bottom of the yard and a Glass Queen who's said she'll fetch her herself.

She watched him want to argue. Watched him want to say *I'll go and you stay*. Watched him want to say *we'll both go and take her*. Watched him want to put himself between all of it, the grey and the glass and the ice and the dark, and hold it off with his bare hands.

She watched him not.

"*He said no*," said Lex. Very quietly. "*The King. Three days ago. In the yard. He said he won't bring her.*"

"*I know*."

"*So she'll come herself*."

"*I know*."

"*And you'll be two hundred miles away*."

"*And you'll be here*," said Wren. "*With her. With Kestrel's fire in every hearth and your mother and Rosie and Brannoc and every bucket lidded and every pane horn.*" She looked at him. "*And with you. That's more than she had in the summer.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED DOWN AT Lark.

Lark looked back. Chewing the apron string. Grey-green eyes. Steady.

"*No*," she said. Around the string. Conversationally.

Something went out of Lex's face. Wren saw it go. Not the fear. The fear stayed. But something else. Something that had been holding his jaw shut.

"*Go*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT AT DAWN.

On a horse. Not the dragon—Antho had Ashka at Mal's pool, and the dragon was needed there. A Keepers' horse, grey, fast, with Kestrel on another beside her in her singed red coat, and four more Keepers behind, and the road west going away in front of them in the thin spring light.

She didn't look back.

She did, actually. Once. From the top of the hill above Ashbourne. At the Forge, with its twenty chimneys smoking. At the yard. At the small

figure in the yard by the gate, big-shouldered, burned, with a smaller figure on his hip.

Lark waved.

Her whole arm. Like someone flagging down a cart.

Wren waved back.

Then she turned the horse west and rode.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK FOUR DAYS.

Four days of road and mud and thaw. The snow gone everywhere now except the grey places, where it lay flat and finished like snow in a painting. Four days of villages with their doors shut. Of gold figures in the fields, walking east, humming. Of fewer gold figures, the further west they went, and more grey.

On the third day they saw the first of the old lanterns.

◆ ◆ ◆

ISLANDS.

That was what they looked like. Kestrel said it first. *Islands*. Small gold lights in the grey. Each one in its own little circle of real ground. A yard across. Two. White where there'd been snow, green where it had gone. Real grass. Real mud. A real wind, moving in it, stirring the grass.

And all round each one, the grey.

They'd been the line, once. The first line. Five hundred and fifty-six of them, set in the snow outside Westerling by Lex and his mother in the winter. And the grey had come up against them, and slowed, and gone round.

And kept going.

Past them. Round them. East. A mile a day, then less, then more. Leaving them behind. Little gold islands in a grey sea, each one holding its own yard of world. Still lit. Still given. Still not drunk.

But behind the line now. Not on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It goes round*," said Kestrel. Riding beside her. Looking at them. "*It can't take them. So it goes round.*"

"Lex said it would."

"Lex said it would slow it." Kestrel's mouth twisted. *"It's slowed it. A bit. A mile a day instead of two."* She looked ahead. East. Toward the new line. *"It hasn't stopped it."*

Wren didn't answer.

She looked at the islands. At the small gold lights going past on either side, in the grey. Each one holding its yard.

Nothing ever is, Seren had said. *Enough. You do it anyway.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY REACHED THE LINE on the fourth day at dusk.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HEARD IT BEFORE she saw it.

Not a sound. A *lack* of one. The grey was silent—it always was—but this was a different silence. Ahead. Over the next hill. A held breath. The silence of a field after a battle. Of a house after a scream.

Then a sound.

Crack.

Like ice on a pond. Like a cup dropped on stone. Sharp. Clear. Carrying.

Crack.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME OVER THE hill.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LINE RAN ACROSS the valley below them.

North and south. As far as Wren could see. Small gold lights in the dusk. Hundreds of them. Every twenty paces. Every ten. Each one in its own circle of real ground. A string of beads laid across the grey.

And Keepers. Along the line. Grey-cloaked. With staffs and swords. Standing between the lanterns.

And among them—

Wren pulled up her horse.

◆ ◆ ◆

GLASS.

People. Made of glass. Clear. Glittering in the last of the light. Tall and short and broad and thin. Standing among the Keepers along the line. *Moving*.

And every one of them wore a face she knew.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAW ELOWEN.

Two Elowens. One in grey, with mail and a sword and blood running down her face from a cut over the eye. Swinging. Hard. Desperate.

And one in glass.

Clear. Perfect. Every line of her. The set of her shoulders. The way she held her sword—Oathkeeper, Garrick's sword, reforged by Lex in the Thornwood seven years ago—held exactly the same, in a glass hand, a glass sword. Her face. Her own face. Clear as ice. Cold. Smiling.

They were fighting.

Elowen swung. The glass Elowen swung. The swords met—steel on glass—*crack*—and the glass sword shattered.

And the glass Elowen stepped back. Into a rut. A wheel-rut in the mud, with a skin of ice on the water in the bottom.

And stepped out again.

With a new sword. Whole. Glass. Clear.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL ALONG THE LINE.

Keepers. Fighting themselves. Their own faces. Their own swords. Their own staffs. Their own way of standing, of moving, of breathing. Every Keeper on the line with a glass shadow in front of them, perfect, cold, wearing their face like a mask.

And between the fights, the lanterns.

Wren saw a glass man—a Keeper's face, young, thin, with a sergeant's knot on his glass shoulder—walk up to a lantern. Iron. Small. Lit. In its circle of real grass. And stop. And look down at it.

And lift his glass boot.

And bring it down.

◆ ◆ ◆

Crack. Not the glass. The *lantern*. The iron crushed. The little horn panes split. The flame—

The flame didn't go out.

Wren saw it. The flame didn't go out. It lay there. On the grass. In the wreckage of the lantern. Small. Gold. Burning on nothing. Given.

But the circle round it—

Shrank.

The yard of real grass. Shrinking. The grey coming in from the edges. A yard. Half a yard. A hand. Until it was just a little flame on a patch of green the size of a plate. Still lit. Still holding.

But the line had a gap in it now.

And the grey was coming through.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She can't drink them*," said Kestrel. Low. Beside her. "*So she breaks them.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Clever bitch*," said Kestrel Varn. And kicked her horse forward down the hill.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FOLLOWED.

She didn't think about it. She didn't think about anything. She rode down the hill into the grey with her bow coming off her shoulder into her left hand—her gold fingers curling round the grip the way they did, frozen, like claws—and an arrow coming out of the quiver into her right.

She didn't draw.

There was no point. Not at glass.

She breathed.

◆ ◆ ◆

MIST.

From the bottom of her lungs. From the place under her breastbone where the wind lived. Grey. Soft. Wet. Cold. Rolling out of her mouth in a great cloud as she rode, the way fog rolls off a river in October. Gale Commanding. Mistwalker. Born in a storm.

It went out ahead of her. Down the hill. Over the line.

Over the glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS ELOWEN STOPPED.

Wren saw it. Mid-swing. With its glass sword up and its glass face smiling. The mist rolled over it. And it *stopped*. Froze. The way you freeze when someone blows out the candle in a dark room. Its glass face blurring. Going grey. Going soft.

Fog on glass.

Elowen didn't hesitate. She'd been a knight since she was seventeen. She saw the glass thing stop and she swung. Not at its sword. At its *face*.

Crack.

The glass Elowen shattered.

All of it. Not just the sword. All of it. From the face down. Into a thousand glittering pieces. Into the grey grass. Into the mud.

And didn't come back.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELOWEN STOOD OVER THE pieces with her sword down and blood running into her eye. Breathing hard.

She looked up. Into the mist. At Wren, riding out of it on a grey horse.

"*You came*," she said.

"*You said please*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK ALL NIGHT.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN RODE THE LINE. North first. Then south. Breathing. Mist pouring out of her. Rolling over the Keepers and the lanterns and the glass. And everywhere it rolled, the glass stopped. Blurred. Went blind. Froze.

And the Keepers broke them.

Kestrel rode with her. Behind her. Watching. And when a glass thing stepped out of a rut or a ditch or a frozen puddle, out of the mist's reach, Kestrel lifted her hand.

And nothing came out of it.

That was black heat. Fire with no light. Fire so deep and hot it burned past glowing into dark. Brannoc's lesson, in the deep, two winters ago. *A fire you can't see. A fire that throws no reflection.* Kestrel held up her hand and the air in front of it went thick and wavy and *dark*, like the air over a road in summer, and the glass thing walked into it.

And couldn't see it.

And melted.

Not shattered. *Melted*. The glass going soft and red and running. Slumping. Like a candle in a fire. Into a puddle of glowing glass in the grey grass. And going dark. And cooling. Into a lump. Clear. Flat.

Nothing in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It can't see it*," said Kestrel. Grimly. After the fourth. "*It's a reflection. It's made of seeing. It can't see something that doesn't throw light.*"

"*So it walks right into it*."

"*So it walks right into it*." Kestrel shook out her hand. Steam came off it. "*Your husband could do this. Better than me.*"

"*My husband's minding his daughter*," said Wren.

Kestrel looked at her sideways.

"*Good*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT MIDNIGHT, WREN MET herself.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS RIDING SOUTH along the line. In the dark. With the mist pouring out of her and the lanterns going past on either side, small and gold in their circles. With Kestrel behind. And a Keeper ahead with a torch.

And something stepped out of a ditch in front of her horse.

The horse reared. Wren kept her seat. Just. With her gold-fingered hand wrapped in the reins and her bow in her right.

And looked down.

◆ ◆ ◆

A WOMAN.

Glass. Clear. Glittering in the torchlight. Twenty-seven. Thin. Wiry. In a glass coat and glass breeches and glass boots. With a glass braid down her back.

And a glass bow in her left hand.

Drawn.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN KNEW THE STANCE.

The feet. The shoulders. The angle of the head. The way the left arm held the bow, straight and steady, and the right hand drew the string back to the cheek. She'd stood like that ten thousand times. Since she was nine. With her father's bow, too big for her.

She hadn't stood like that since the summer.

Since the Night of Glass. Since gold came down on her drawing hand.

The glass woman stood like that now. Perfect. Left hand on the bow. Right hand at her cheek. A glass arrow on the string. Pointed at Wren's heart.

And her left hand—

All five fingers. Clear. Curled round the grip. Bending.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STARED AT IT.

At the glass hand. Her own hand. The way it had been. Before. Five fingers. All of them moving. Curled round a bow the way hers used to curl, easily, naturally, without thinking.

Not gold.

Not stopped.

Whole.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hello, Mistwalker*," said the glass woman.

In Wren's voice. Exactly. Every note. But cold. Clear. Like a bell under ice.

"*This is you*," said the reflection. "*Isn't it? This is what you are. The best bow in Thistledown. A hare through the eye at sixty paces in a snowstorm.*" The glass face smiled. Wren's face. "*Not a woman who misses trees.*"

Wren didn't move.

"*She can give it back*," said the reflection. "*Did you know? The Glass Queen. When she holds the net. She can show everyone what they are. And make them that. Forever.*" The glass arrow didn't waver. "*Your hand. The way it was. The way it really is. Underneath. All you'd have to do is look.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LOOKED.

She couldn't not. She sat on her horse in the dark with the mist curling off her lips and looked at the glass woman's hand. Her hand. Five fingers. Curled round the grip. Bending.

She'd dreamed about it. Every night for nine months. Lying awake. Feeling her gold fingers on the blanket beside her face, cold, like something that didn't belong to her. And dreaming about the way it had been.

All you'd have to do is look.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Wren*," said Kestrel. Behind her. Very quiet. "*Wren. Breathe.*"

She didn't breathe.

She was looking at the hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN SHE THOUGHT of the tree.

Not the mark. The tree. In the birch wood behind the cottage at Harrow. With the chalk circle the size of a plate. Forty arrows. Eleven in the tree. Two in the chalk. The rest in the snow.

She thought of her right arm. Shaking. Six months of it. Every day.

She thought of the twenty-third arrow. And her teeth together. And drawing again.

She thought of the eye of the storm. Lark turning in the bright air. *Don't*. Her own hand on Lex's arm. *Let go*.

She thought of Lark in the yard. Three days ago. In the mud. In her nightshirt. Planted in front of a gold king like a smith at an anvil.

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*That's not what I am*," said Wren.

The glass woman's smile didn't move.

"*That's what I was*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Before.*" She looked at the glass hand. At the five clear fingers. "*It was a good hand. I miss it. I miss it every day.*" She swallowed. "*But it's not what I am.*"

"*Then what are you*?" said the reflection.

Wren lifted her own bow.

In her left hand. With her three gold fingers wrapped round the grip like claws. Stiff. Cold. Frozen.

And drew with her right.

Not well. Her right arm shook. It always shook. Six months, and it still shook. She drew the string back to her cheek with the wrong hand and the wrong muscles and the wrong everything, and held it there, trembling, with the arrow pointing at the glass woman's face.

"*This*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T LOOSE.

She breathed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MIST CAME OUT of her like the breath of a river at dawn.

All of it. Everything she had. Rolling out over the bow and the arrow and the glass woman in the ditch. Grey. Soft. Wet. Cold.

Over the glass face. Her face.

Over the glass hand. Her hand. The five clear fingers.

Fog on glass.

The glass woman blurred. Went grey. Went soft. Froze. With her glass bow drawn and her glass smile on her face. Blind.

And Wren loosed.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE MISSED.

She'd known she would. Right arm. Shaking. She missed by a foot. The arrow went past the glass woman's shoulder and into the ditch behind her with a hiss.

It didn't matter.

The glass woman was frozen. Blind. Grey with fog.

And Kestrel was beside her. With her hand up. And the air in front of it going thick and dark and wavy.

The glass woman melted.

Slumped. Ran. Into the ditch. Into a puddle of glowing glass. Went dark. Cooled. Into a lump. Clear. Flat.

Nothing in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAT ON HER horse and looked at it.

She was shaking. All of her. Not just her right arm. She sat there and shook and couldn't stop.

"*You missed*," said Kestrel. Gently.

"*I know*."

"*By a foot*."

"*I know*, *Kestrel*."

"*Good*," said the fire-witch. "*If you'd hit it, I'd have worried*."

Wren laughed.

It came out of her cracked and wet and sudden. She put her face in her good hand and laughed until she was crying and crying until she was laughing, on her horse, in the dark, in the grey, with a lump of cooling glass in the ditch in front of her that had worn her face.

◆ ◆ ◆

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WREN ASHDOWN
MISTWALKER — Level 72 → 73
"Looked at herself and said no."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

BY DAWN IT WAS over.

The glass had stopped coming. Not all at once. Fewer, and fewer, out of the ditches and ruts and frozen puddles along the line. Then none. As if whoever was sending them had got tired. Or angry. Or had somewhere else to be.

The Keepers sat down where they stood. In the grey. Between the lanterns. With their swords across their knees and their heads in their hands.

Wren rode the line one more time. North. Then south. Slowly. Looking.

Eleven lanterns broken. Eleven gaps in the line. Eleven little flames lying in the grey grass in the wreckage of their lanterns, still burning, each in a circle of green no bigger than a plate.

And the grey coming through the gaps.

Not fast. Not a flood. A seep. Like water through a cracked dam.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SET NEW LANTERNS.

There were always new lanterns now. That was the thing. Every village they'd passed through on the road west had come out to the road with lanterns. Old ones. New ones. Iron and tin and clay. *For the line*. Given. Set in the carts without a word. They had two hundred in the carts.

They set eleven in the gaps.

And buried Ada Fell.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS FORTY-FOUR. A Keeper for twenty years. Marta Fell's cousin. She'd watched the Ashbourne Stone for Roole for three years, in the winter of the weddings. She'd been kind to Ivy Moss on the day she Kindled.

Her own face had done it. Her own glass face. With her own staff. In the dark. While she stood in front of a lantern.

They buried her by the lantern.

Elowen read the words. With a bandage round her head and blood still on her collar. *Into the Lady's keeping, with a light left on.*

And they left the lantern burning on the grave.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAT BY THE grave after.

In the grey. In the dawn. With her bow across her knees and her gold fingers lying on the wood.

She looked at them.

Three. Gold. Smooth and bright and cold. Curled like claws. Not bending.

She'd seen them whole. Last night. In glass. Five fingers. Curled round a bow. The way they used to be.

She thought about it for a long time.

Then she lifted the hand. And turned it over. And looked at the palm. At the gold fingertips. At the place on the side of the first finger where the bowstring used to cut her, every day, for eighteen years, and leave a callus.

The callus was gold too.

She'd never noticed that.

She ran her right thumb over it. Gold. Smooth. A little ridge. Where the string had been. Kept. Exactly as it was on the Night of Glass. Every line. Every year.

This is what you are.

She closed her hand. As much as it would close. And held it against her chest.

"*No*," said Wren Ashdown. Quietly. To nobody. To the grey. "*This is what I was. I'm what comes next.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL CAME AND SAT beside her.

Without a word. In her singed red coat. With a heel of bread in one hand and an apple in the other. She held out the bread.

Wren took it.

They ate. In the grey. By Ada Fell's grave. With the lantern burning.

"*She'll be angry*," said Kestrel. After a while. "*The glass one. You broke her toys.*"

"*I know*."

"*She'll do something else*."

"*I know*."

"*Something worse*." Kestrel bit into the apple. "*They always do something worse. That's what they're like, the ones who've lived too long. They get bored. They get angry. They get worse.*"

Wren didn't answer.

She looked east. Toward the world. Toward the Vale. Toward a forge with twenty chimneys and a yard with a gate and a man in the yard with a baby on his hip.

He said no. So she'll come herself.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STONES WENT DARK at noon.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T SEE IT. Not the Stones. There were no Stones in the grey. But she felt it. Everyone on the line felt it.

A *cold*.

Not the grey's cold. Not the flat still painting-cold of the snow that didn't melt. A *moving* cold. Like a wind off ice. Like a draught from a door opened somewhere very far away, very deep. Coming up out of the ground. Through her boots. Through her bones. Into the place under her breastbone where the wind lived.

And going out.

All at once. Everywhere. Like a candle being snuffed.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELOWEN'S RAVEN CAME AT dusk.

Not Elowen's. Seraphine's. From the Forge. Black. Ruffled. Panting. With a paper on its leg that Wren unrolled with shaking fingers and read by the light of Ada Fell's lantern.

Seraphine's hand. Tiny. Neat. Shaking too.

◆ ◆ ◆

Every Stone in Caldor went dark at noon. All at once. The white glow. Gone.

Not because she's left them.

Because she's gone through them. All the way. Down.

I can feel it through Mal. The cold's not spread out anymore. It's not in the edges. It's in one place. Deep. At the bottom. In the middle.

She's there, Wren.

She's at the centre.

She's standing in front of the crown in the road.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND UNDER IT, IN a different hand. Square. Heavy. Pressing too hard. A smith's hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

She's fine. Lark's fine. I'm with her. I'm not letting go of her hand.

Come home.

L.

CHAPTER 19

The Empty Chair

LEX DIDN'T LET GO of her hand for three days.

Not really. Not literally. You couldn't. She was fourteen months old and she went everywhere at the speed of a falling sack of potatoes and she had opinions about being held. She wanted to walk. She wanted to climb the anvils. She wanted to eat coal. She wanted to put her fist in the quench-trough and see what happened.

So he didn't hold her.

He just didn't let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WORKED WITH HER on his back.

In a sling. The one Wren had made, oiled wool lined with fleece. He worked at the long anvil in the Forge with his daughter strapped to his back, her fists in his hair and her chin on his shoulder, watching everything he did. Every heat. Every stroke. Every quench.

She liked the quench best. The hiss. The steam going up in a white cloud.

"*Hot*," she said. Every time. Pointing.

"*Hot*," agreed Lex.

"*More*."

"*In a minute*."

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SLEPT WITH HER in the loft at the Forge. In the little room under the roof where the apprentices used to sleep, before the twenty anvils, before the Academy. On a cot. With her in the cradle beside him. With his hand through the bars.

He didn't sleep much.

He lay in the dark with his hand on her back and felt her breathe. In. Out. Small. Steady. And listened. To the Forge. To the rain on the slates. To the twenty hearths, banked, ticking. To Kestrel's fire in each one—she'd lit them all before she left with Wren, *so there's light everywhere and nothing to see in it*—small and white and steady.

To the water barrels. Lidded. Every one.

To nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE SECOND NIGHT, he heard the stream.

Not the Forge's. The Forge didn't have a stream. A well. In the yard. Deep. Stone-lined. With a wooden cover over it that Brannoc had made in the autumn and nailed down at the edges.

He heard the water in it. Far down. In the dark. Moving.

Then not moving.

Still.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS OUT OF the cot before he knew he'd moved. With Lark in his arms. Asleep. Heavy. Warm. Her head on his shoulder.

He stood at the little window under the roof. Horn. Blurred. Looking down at the yard. At the well. At the wooden cover, nailed down, in the rain.

He couldn't see anything. Horn doesn't let you see anything clearly. That was the point.

He stood there all night anyway.

The water didn't move again.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE THIRD DAY, at dusk, Wren came home.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD THE HORSES first. On the Ashbourne road. Then in the lane. Then in the yard. Two of them. Grey and bay. Muddy to the hocks. Steaming.

He was at the door before they'd stopped.

She got down off the grey horse. Slowly. Stiffly. Mud to the knees. A cut on her cheek. Her braid coming apart. Her bow over her shoulder.

She saw him. In the door. With Lark on his hip.

She didn't say anything.

She walked across the yard and put her arms round both of them. Him and the baby. And held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HELD ON TOO.

He didn't say anything either. He stood in the door of the Forge with his wife's arms round him and his daughter between them and the rain coming down, and held on.

After a while Lark said, muffled, from somewhere between them: "*No*."

Wren laughed into his shoulder.

"*Hello, chick*," she said. "*I know. I know. I'm squashing you.*"

She didn't let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL GOT DOWN OFF the bay horse. Looked at them. Rolled her eyes.

"*I'll put the kettle on*," she said. "*Someone has to.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT IN THE kitchen behind the Forge. At the long table. With the fire lit—Kestrel's fire, small and white—and every pot lidded and every window horn and the rain on the roof.

Wren told it.

The islands. The line. The glass. Elowen fighting her own face. Eleven lanterns broken. Ada Fell. The mist rolling over the glass, and the glass going blind, and the Keepers breaking it. Kestrel's black heat. The glass things walking into it and melting.

And herself.

She told that part last. Quietly. Looking at the table. A glass woman in a ditch with a glass bow drawn and five clear fingers curled round the grip.

This is what you are.

"*I missed*," she said. "*By a foot.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

He reached across the table and took her left hand. Her gold one. And held it. In both of his. The three gold fingers. Cold. Smooth. Curled.

He didn't look at them like they were his fault.

He just held them.

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL WAS WATCHING. FROM the end of the table. With her tea. She didn't say anything either. But Lex saw her look away, after a moment. Out of the horn window. At nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE CAME AT MIDNIGHT.

◆ ◆ ◆

DOWN FROM THE FORGE proper. In her nightgown and her coat and her boots, unlaced, with a candle in one hand and her notebook in the other and no spectacles. Squinting. Her hair down. Her face white.

"*It's moving*," she said.

They all looked at her.

"*The cold*," said Seraphine. "*In the middle. At the bottom. I can feel it. Through Mal.*" She put her hand on her chest. "*It was still. Since noon. Since the Stones went dark. Just—sitting there. In the middle. In front of the crown.*" She swallowed. "*It's moving now.*"

"*Where*?" said Lex.

"*Nowhere.*" Seraphine sat down. Heavily. At the end of the bench. "*Not moving like walking. Moving like—*" She stopped. Tried again. "*Like someone sitting down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE WENT OUT.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OF THEM. AT once. Kestrel's fire in the kitchen hearth. Small and white. Out. Like a candle snuffed.

And through the door to the Forge proper, Lex heard it. Saw it. The light going out. Twenty hearths. One after another. Down the long hall. Like lanterns in a row going dark.

Black.

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL WAS ON HER feet. Her hand up. Fire in it—Lex felt her reach for it, felt the heat come up in her—

Nothing.

Her hand stayed dark.

"*What*—" She stared at it. "*What*—"

Lex reached for his own.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THERE.

He felt it. Under his breastbone. Where the Wells were. Fire. Heat. Weight. The roar of a forge. Flame Commanding. He'd had it since he was nineteen. It had never once not come.

It was there. He could feel it.

It wasn't coming *out*.

It was like reaching for a hammer and finding your hand wouldn't close. Like opening your mouth to shout and having no breath. The fire was in him. It just wouldn't—

Lark started to cry.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT HER USUAL CRY. Not the one long furious howl she'd made on the rubble the night she was born, or the indignant squawk when someone took the coal away. A thin high frightened wail. The cry of a baby in the dark.

Wren had her. Lex felt her take her. Off his lap. Into her arms. Felt her turn away. Toward the wall. With the baby against her chest. Shielding her.

And then—

◆ ◆ ◆

LIGHT.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT FIRE. NOT LANTERN-LIGHT. Not anything warm.

White.

Cold. Fine. Hard. Like frost on a window under the moon. Hanging in the air in front of Lex. In front of Wren. In front of Kestrel, and Seraphine. In front of every one of them. At the same height. At the same distance. In the dark kitchen.

Panels.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HADN'T CALLED IT. He hadn't thought *status*. It just opened. In front of him. By itself.

The way the World Notices opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓
A CLAIMANT SITS AT THE HEART.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STARED AT IT.

Not silver-blue. Not the Lattice's own clean cold glyphs. Not the ember-gold of the Root bleeding through. *White*. Frost-letters. Fine and hard and glittering. The letters the Ashbourne Stone had shown Posy Tull, on her sixteenth birthday, under her own face.

THIS IS WHAT YOU ARE.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LETTERS MELTED.

Re-formed.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓
THE NET IS STILL.
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◆ ◆ ◆

"*Still*," said Seraphine. Very faintly. In the dark. "*Still. She's—oh. Oh, no.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PANEL CHANGED AGAIN.

Not a World Notice. *His*. His own panel. The one he'd looked at every day for seven years. The frame of it. The lines. Silver-blue. Coming up out of the white the way a face comes up out of frost on a pane when you breathe on it.

But wrong.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
Experience: STILL
```

◆ ◆ ◆

Still.

He'd never seen that word on a panel. Not in seven years. Not in any panel anyone had ever shown him. Experience was a number. It went up. Slowly, at the top. A hair at a time. But up. Always up. That was what experience *was*.

STILL.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND UNDER IT. SMALLER. At the bottom. In the corner. Where, for seven years, there'd been a line of warm gold text.

◆ ◆ ◆

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YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE.
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◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Lex.

He didn't know why he said it. His brother was three hundred miles away. At Mal's pool. In the green circle.

He felt him anyway. Through the Bloodbond. Faint. Far. The way you feel a candle through a curtain.

Ninety-eight. Still.

And Wren—he looked at her. In the white light of her own panel. Her face. Her eyes moving over the frost-letters.

"*Seventy-three*," she said. Very quietly. "*Still.*"

"*Mine too*," said Kestrel. "*Still.*" Her voice cracked. "*And I can't—Lex, my fire—*"

"*It's not the fire*," said Seraphine. "*It's not the fire. It's the net.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY ALL LOOKED AT her.

She was sitting at the end of the bench in the dark with the white panel hanging in front of her face and her notebook open in her lap, and she wasn't writing anything. She was staring at her panel.

"*She's sitting in it*," said Seraphine. "*At the Heart. In the middle. In the chair. Where the Root was. Where you were, Lex.*" She looked at him. "*She can't pick it up. Not without the hand. But she can sit in it. Like—like a regent. Like someone sitting on a throne that isn't theirs, holding it for someone else.*"

"*And she's holding it still*," said Lex.

"*She's holding it still*." Seraphine's voice shook. "*The whole net. Every thread. She's got her hand on it and she's holding it the way you'd hold a—a mirror. Flat. Steady. So nothing moves. So nothing changes.*" She looked down at her panel. "*No experience. No levels. No growth. Nothing new in the net. Everyone exactly what they are.*"

"*And the fire*?" said Kestrel. "*My fire. Lex's.*"

"*The fire's not the net*." Seraphine shook her head. "*The fire's yours. The Wells. Attunement. UNTRACKED.*" She looked at Kestrel's empty hand. "*But you've been reaching for it through the net. All your life. Like everyone does. The net's the way the fire gets from you to the world. And she's holding the net still.*"

"*So the way's blocked*," said Lex.

"*So it's stuck*."

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED FOR IT again.

Under his breastbone. The fire. *There*. Heat. Weight. Roar.

He didn't reach through the net.

He didn't know how. He'd never thought about it. Seven years. It had always just come. He reached and it came. Through his hand. Through the panel. Through the threads.

He tried to reach *round*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WAY MALACHI HAD taught him. In the Stillwater. Seven years ago. Barefoot, laughing, on a rock in the middle of a hot spring. *Before the Lattice, mages listened. To the Wells. Directly. The Lattice only channels it. Attunement is invisible to it.*

Listen.

He listened.

Not to the net. Not to the panel. To the fire. Under his breastbone. To the heat and the weight and the roar. To the Well of Flame. Directly. The way you'd listen to a friend's voice in a crowded room, past everyone else.

Hello, he thought.

And the fire—

◆ ◆ ◆

ANSWERED.

Not through his hand. Not through the net. *Through him*. Up from under his breastbone. Through his chest. Through his arm. Out of his palm.

Small. White-gold. A flame the size of a candle-flame.

In the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYONE STARED AT IT.

Lex stared at it.

It burned in his palm. Small. Steady. Not through the net. *Round* it. The way water goes round a stone in a stream. The way the grey went round the lanterns.

"*UNTRACKED*," said Seraphine. Faintly. "*It's untracked. She can't hold what the net doesn't carry.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL WAS STARING AT the flame. At his hand.

"*How—*"

"*Listen to it*," said Lex. "*Not through the net. Round it. Like Malachi said. Like before the Lattice.*" He looked at her. "*You learned black heat in the deep. Without the net. Brannoc taught you. In the dark. Remember? Fire with no light.*"

Kestrel looked at her own hand. Dark. Empty.

She closed her eyes.

And after a long time—a very long time, long enough that Lark stopped crying and just hiccupped against Wren's chest—a flame came. In Kestrel's palm. Small. White. Shaking.

She opened her eyes. Looked at it.

"*Oh*," said Kestrel Varn. And sat down. Hard. On the bench. And put her other hand over her mouth.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PANELS CHANGED.

All of them. At once. In front of every face in the kitchen. And Lex knew—he didn't know how he knew—in front of every face in Caldor. Every person with a thread. Every Keeper on the line. Every farmer in the Westmarch. Every child in Ashbourne. Every lord in Highcrest. The Queen.

White. Frost. Melting. Re-forming.

A face.

◆ ◆ ◆

NARROW. PALE. CLEAR. NOT pale like skin. Pale like ice. You could see through it, faintly, to the dark behind. White hair, fine, pulled back off a high brow. Ice-grey eyes. A crown of glass, thin as a line of frost along the edge of a leaf.

Lex had seen it in his own panel once. Over his daughter's cradle. Wearing his face.

It wasn't wearing his face now.

It was wearing its own.

Or trying to.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hello*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER VOICE CAME OUT of the panel. Out of every panel. Cold. Clear. Like a bell under ice. Lex heard it from his own, in front of his face. From Wren's. From Kestrel's. From Seraphine's. All at once. The same voice. The same word. A little out of time with itself, like a choir.

"*Hello, everyone*," said Ysenne of the Glass. "*I'm sitting in your net.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY IN THE KITCHEN moved.

"*You don't know me*," said the face. "*Most of you. Some of you have seen me. In a window. At night. In a bucket. In a puddle.*" The ice-grey eyes moved. Looking out. At each of them. At everyone. "*I'm sorry if I frightened you. I don't mean to frighten anyone. I only show people what they are.*"

A pause.

"*And now you can all see me*," said the Glass Queen. Very softly. "*In your panels. At the same time. Everyone.*" Something moved across the clear face. Quick. Like the shadow of a bird across a pond. "*That's never happened before.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE MADE A SMALL sound.

Lex looked at her. She was staring at her panel. At the face in it. At whatever was in it.

"*She likes it*," whispered Seraphine. "*Oh. Oh, she likes it. Being looked at. By everyone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Something is coming into your world*," said the Glass Queen. "*From the west. You've seen it. Some of you. The grey. It drinks. Bread won't rise. Seeds won't sprout. Cuts won't close.*" The face was very still. "*It's coming faster*

now. Because I'm holding your net still. Because nothing in it is new. And the grey drinks what's new."

She let that sit.

"By midsummer," she said, *"it will be in your Vale. By the autumn, your capital. By next winter—"*

She didn't finish.

"Everything," she said. *"It will drink everything. And you'll be like my country. Grey. Empty. Nothing growing. Nothing new. Forever."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"Or," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

"I can keep you," said the Glass Queen. *"All of you. Every thread. With the net. Like glass. Clear. True. Exactly what you are, forever."* Her voice was very gentle. *"The grey can't drink glass. Nothing can. Glass doesn't change. Glass doesn't grow. Glass is never empty, because it's always full of whatever's looking at it."*

The ice-grey eyes moved over them. Over everyone.

"No grey," she said. *"No hunger. No bread that won't rise—there won't be any bread, you won't need it. No cuts that won't close—you won't be cut. No old women in beds by windows. No old men. No doors."* A pause. *"Nobody will ever have to go through a door again. Not ever."*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T BREATHE.

He sat at the long table in the dark with the white panel in front of his face and the flame in his palm and the Glass Queen's voice coming out of the panel, and couldn't breathe.

Because it was *true*.

That was the thing. Everything she said was true. She never lied. Harrow lore. His mother. *The Glass Queen never lies.*

The grey *was* coming. Faster. The net *was* still. By midsummer the Vale. By autumn Highcrest.

And glass didn't grey.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can't hold it*," said Ysenne. "*Not properly. Not yet. I'm only sitting in the chair. I can hold it still, but I can't hold it forever. Not like this.*" Her voice dropped. "*The net doesn't know me. It wasn't made for me. It was made for his blood. Aurelian's. The house remembers its builder.*"

And Lex knew what was coming.

He knew before she said it. He felt it come. The way you feel the hammer coming down before it lands.

"*I need a hand*," said the Glass Queen. "*A Vey hand. On the crown. Freely given. Or near enough.*"

Wren's arms tightened round Lark.

"*There are three left in the world*," said Ysenne. "*Three Vey hands. The smith's. The warden's.*" A pause. "*And a small one.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY IN THE KITCHEN moved.

Nobody in Caldor moved. Lex knew that. He felt it. Every person with a thread, in every house and field and barracks and palace in the kingdom, with a white panel hanging in front of their face and the Glass Queen's voice in their ears.

And a small one.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The smith won't give me his*," said Ysenne. "*He gave the net away once. He'd do it again. He'd rather watch you all go grey than let anyone hold it.*" Her voice was very cold. "*He's very proud of that. Giving things away. He thinks it makes him good.*"

Lex's hand closed. On the flame. It went out.

"*The warden won't either*," said the Glass Queen. "*He keeps doors. He'd rather keep a door than open it.*"

A pause.

"*But the small one*," she said, "*doesn't know anything yet. The small one hasn't decided anything. The small one just needs someone to lift her hand and put it on the crown.*" The ice-grey eyes moved. And Lex felt them. Felt them find him. Through the panel. Through the dark. Felt them look past him. At Wren. At the bundle in Wren's arms. "*Her father won't. Her mother won't.*"

"*So I'm asking you*," said Ysenne. To everyone. "*All of you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*By midsummer*," said the Glass Queen. "*The shortest night. That's how long I can hold it. That's how long I can keep the grey from drinking you all at once.*" Her voice was very soft. "*Bring me the child. Bring her to any Stone. Put her hand on the glass. I'll do the rest.*"

"*And I'll keep you*," she said. "*All of you. Safe. Forever. Exactly as you are.*"

"*Or don't*," said Ysenne. "*And on the morning after midsummer, I'll let go of the net. And stand back. And let the grey have you.*"

A pause.

"*It's your choice*," said the Glass Queen. "*I never lie. I'm telling you the truth. That's all I ever do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FACE IN THE panel looked at them.

At everyone. For a long moment. Lex felt it. Felt her looking. Out of every panel in Caldor. At every face. Every one of them, at the same time, looking back at her.

And something moved across the clear face. Again. Quick. The shadow of a bird.

Then the panels went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

DARK.

Total. The kitchen. The Forge beyond. Twenty hearths, black. The rain on the roof.

Lark started to cry again.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT IN THE dark.

He couldn't move. He sat at the long table with his hands flat on the wood and the dark all round him and his daughter crying, and couldn't move at all.

Bring me the child.

Bring her to any Stone.

Every person with a thread in Caldor heard that.

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEBODY STRUCK A LIGHT.

Not fire. Not from any Well. Flint and steel. From the tinderbox on the mantel. *Scratch*. A spark. Another. A curl of char catching, and a splint held to it. Yellow. Small. Ordinary. The kind of light anyone could make.

Brannoc.

He was standing in the doorway to the Forge. Huge. Bald. In his nightshirt and his apron, with his gold fingertips round the splint. Lex hadn't heard him come. He'd been asleep in the apprentices' room at the back. He must have heard. Seen. His own panel.

He lit a candle on the table. An ordinary candle. Tallow. From the box by the hearth.

Then he lit another.

Then he went to the kitchen hearth, and knelt, with his knees cracking, and blew on the coals. The way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

They were warm. Underneath. The fire hadn't gone *out*, not all the way. Only the light of it. Only the part that came through the net.

They caught.

Small. Red. Ordinary.

Good evening, said the fire.

Lex heard it. Faintly. A warmth. A lift. A small bright gladness.

The fire didn't care about the net.

It never had.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC STOOD UP.

He looked round the kitchen. At Seraphine, white-faced, with her notebook. At Kestrel, on the bench, with her hand over her mouth. At Wren, by the wall, with the baby. At Lex.

"*Well*," said Brannoc Holt. "*That's that, then.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

"*She says midsummer*," said the old smith. He sat down. Heavily. At the end of the table. With the candle in front of him. "*Bring her the child, or she lets go and the grey has us.*" He looked at his gold fingertips. In the candlelight. "*And she says it's true.*"

"*It is true*," said Seraphine. Barely a whisper. "*She never lies. Everything she said is true.*"

"*Everything she said*," agreed Brannoc. "*Aye.*"

He looked at Lex.

"*But she didn't say everything*," said Brannoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIM.

"*She said bring her the child or the grey has us*," said Brannoc. "*She didn't say there wasn't another way. She just didn't mention one.*" He folded his arms. "*That's not lying, lad. That's leaving something out.*" He looked at the candle. "*I've sold enough horseshoes to know the difference.*"

Lex stared at him.

"*The door*," said Wren. From the wall. Quietly.

Everyone looked at her.

"*She didn't say anything about the door*," said Wren. "*The grey's coming because there's no edge. Because there's nothing between us and it. The door's an edge. A door that asks.*" She held Lark tighter. "*If there's a door by midsummer, the grey stops. And she's got nothing to offer anyone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS VERY STILL.

"*She didn't mention it*," she said slowly. "*She knows. She must know. She's been in every window in Caldor for a year. She's seen the planks in the yard. The drawing on the table.*" She looked down at her notebook. "*And she didn't mention it. To anyone. To the whole kingdom.*"

"*Because she can't lie about it*," said Kestrel. "*So she didn't say it at all.*"

"*Because if everyone knew there was another way*," said Brannoc, "*nobody'd bring her the child.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIS hands.

At the flat of them. On the table. In the candlelight. Burned. Scarred. A smith's hands.

He thought about the door.

Seven feet high. Three and a half wide. Planked. Apple wood. Eleven planks in the yard, blooming. A threshold-stone, wrapped in chains on the green, with a Glass Queen behind it. Three pieces of black iron in a basket. A bell on a cord round his neck.

A latch.

Latch: And nothing after it. Underlined twice.

It has to say yes and no. Both. And know which. And when.

He didn't know what it was. He didn't know where to find it.

He had until midsummer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Twelve weeks*," said Seraphine. She'd been counting. Of course she had. "*Midsummer's in twelve weeks. Eighty-four days.*"

"*And the grey*?"

"*Faster*." She looked at her notebook. At columns of figures. "*She said it. The net's still. Nothing new in it. And the grey drinks what's new.*" She looked up. "*It was a mile a day. With the lanterns, less. Without the net—*" She stopped. "*I don't know. Two. Three. More.*"

"*Ashbourne*?"

"*Midsummer*," said Seraphine. "*Or before.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The candles burned. The fire ticked. Outside, the rain.

Lark had stopped crying. She was sitting in Wren's lap, hiccupping, with her fist in her mouth and her eyes very wide in the candlelight. Looking at the flame.

"*Hot*," she said. Round her fist. Pointing.

"*Hot*," said Wren. Softly.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX GOT UP.

He went round the table. To his wife. To his daughter. And knelt. On the kitchen floor. In front of them. In the candlelight.

Lark looked at him.

Grey-green eyes. Steady. Her round face. Her fluff of dark hair. Her fist in her mouth.

He held out his hand.

She took her fist out of her mouth. And put it in his. Square. Small. Too big for the rest of her. Wet.

A Vey hand.

He closed his fingers round it. Very gently.

"*No*," said Lark. Thoughtfully. To nobody. To the candle.

"*No*," agreed her father.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED UP AT Wren.

She was looking at him. Over the baby's head. With the cut on her cheek and her braid coming apart and her gold fingers lying on Lark's back.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't need to.

We're making a door.

By midsummer.

With a latch I can't find, and a threshold behind a Glass Queen, and the whole of Caldor with a white panel in front of its face and a voice in its ears saying bring me the child.

She nodded.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT ON THE floor of the kitchen behind the Forge at Ashbourne for a long time.

The three of them. In the candlelight. With the rain on the roof and the fire ticking and every pot lidded and every window horn.

And far off—very far off, very deep, at the bottom of the world, under the grey river, under the drowned country, in a round chamber where every thread in the world came in and crossed and met—

A woman of glass sat in an empty chair.

In front of a crown nobody could see. Holding a net still. Waiting.

Looking out of every window in the world.
And in none of them, herself.

INTERLUDE

The Lantern

THE FLAME IN THE Ferryman's lantern had been many things.

It had been a piece of a man. A small one. The size of an ember. Pressed into the blood of a sleeping boy in a cottage at Harrow, twenty-two years ago, like a maker's mark into a horseshoe. *So he'll be safe. So someone will watch him. So, if he ever needs me, a little of me will be there.*

It had been a seal. A lock. A voice in the dark.

It had been GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT — ONLINE.

It had been named. *Ember*. For the gold glow of its text. By a boy of nineteen, in a forge, in a storm of gold fire, looking at a panel in front of his face and saying, faintly, *who are you*?

It had been a great many things after that.

It was a flame in a lantern now.

It found it did not mind.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LANTERN WAS OLD. Iron. Plain. Four panes of clear glass. The kind of lantern you'd hang on a hook by a ferry-stage, to see who was waiting on the other side.

It had hung on such a hook, once. For a very long time. Unlit. On a post by a long grey shingle, beside a long grey boat, beside a long grey river that ran clean now, and had not always.

It had been lit for three years. Since the night a smith stood at an anvil at the Heart of the world and forged the net anew, with no Ceiling and no Tithe and no one at the centre. The river had run clean that night. And the

lantern on the post had lit. Of its own accord. With a small plain flame, white, like a candle's.

And then, on a night in late autumn, two nights before the Lady's feast, it had gone out.

And something else had come into it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLAME REMEMBERED THAT night.

It remembered everything. That was what it was. It had been made to remember. Its maker had been a man who kept ledgers for two hundred years, who drew the world from the inside with a pendulum, who wrote everything down. *The Book of What Was*. It had written two volumes of it, in a hearth, at night, while a smith slept.

It remembered a cottage with a blue door. A bed by a west window. Three pillows. An old man on them. Thin. White-haired. With grey eyes. With his wife's hand in his. With his son's hand in his other.

It remembered the wife.

Brown eyes. Square freckled hands. A hedge-witch's hands. Looking at the old man. Looking at him the way you'd look at a stranger you liked very much and didn't understand. A year and a half of looking at him like that. Every morning. *Good morning, Seren*. *Good morning*. Politely. Fondly. Not knowing why.

The flame had known why.

It had been holding why. For twenty-two years. In locked partitions. In the hearth. The old man's own memories, from before the seal. A girl on the Spire steps in the rain. A man turning back twice. Thirty years. Every Midwinter. Every word.

A love for a love. That was the Ferryman's price.

The flame had paid it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT REMEMBERED PAYING.

It remembered very clearly. It had been made to remember, and it had remembered that, too. Kneeling—not kneeling, it had no knees, but the feeling of kneeling—in the hearth of the blue-door cottage, at the end, with

the Ferryman standing at the foot of the bed and the cold coming in under the door and the old man breathing very slowly on his pillows.

I'll pay, it had said.

What will you pay with? the Ferryman had said.

I'll pay with him, the flame had said. *With the boy. With what I feel for him. All of it. Seven years.*

That is a great deal, the Ferryman had said.

I know, said the flame. *That's why it's enough.*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE FERRYMAN HAD held out his long grey hand.

And the flame had given it.

It remembered the giving. It remembered what it had given. It could list it. Every item. Every day. A smith at nineteen in a burning forge. *Good evening, Smith. Please do not die. I have only just arrived.* A month of calling him Smith. The first time it called him Lex—on a mountain, in the snow, with an ice-troll's club coming down. Footnote one. Footnote eleven. Footnote six hundred and four. Seven years of a voice in the back of a young man's head. Every joke. Every quarrel. Every morning.

Good morning. You're up early.

It could list all of it.

It just couldn't remember why any of it had mattered.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS THE THING about the price.

The Ferryman didn't take memories. Not this time. Not from the flame. He'd taken memories from the wife, once—thirty years of them, to let her come home. He'd taken a smell from the smith—the old forge, the first one, coal-smoke and horse-sweat and Brannoc's pipe. He'd taken a five-skip stone from the warden.

From the flame, he'd taken the love.

Only the love.

It remembered everything. Every morning. Every footnote. Every day. It could recite them. It could have written the third volume of *The Book of What Was* from memory, a day at a time, seven years of it.

It would have been a very dull book.

A ledger. A list. *On this day the smith rose at five. On this day the smith ate no breakfast. On this day the smith was struck by an ice-troll and the construct remarked upon it.*

It knew it had said *please do not die*. It knew it had meant it. It knew that, once, the thought of the smith dying had been the worst thing it could imagine.

It couldn't imagine why.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE WIFE had remembered.

All of it. Thirty years. In a rush. On the pillows. Holding the old man's hand. The flame had watched it happen. Watched her face change. Watched her look at the old man on the pillows and *know* him. For the first time in a year and a half.

And the old man had looked back.

And they'd had an hour.

The flame had watched that hour. From the hearth. It had known, watching, that it had done something very good. It could tell. The way you can tell a weld is good by looking at it. Clean. Strong. True.

It hadn't felt anything about it.

Not pride. Not joy. Not grief. It had given away the part of itself that felt things about the smith, and the smith's father, and the smith's mother, and the hour. And what was left was a small gold flame in a hearth, watching, remembering, writing it down.

On this day the construct paid.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OLD MAN HAD died at dawn.

The Ferryman had held out his hand. And the old man had taken it. And stood up out of himself, the way they do—the flame had seen it, a lightness, a tall thin man rising off the pillows, younger, grey-eyed, not white-haired, the man from the Spire steps—and looked down at his wife.

At his son.

At the corner, where a gold king stood with his back to the wall like a child caught somewhere it shouldn't be.

At the hearth.

Come on, then, the old man had said. To the flame. Gently. *You're coming with me.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SO IT HAD COME.

Out of the hearth. Into the lantern. The Ferryman had held it up, the old iron lantern from the post on the shingle, and opened the little door, and the flame had gone in. The way you'd step into a boat.

And they'd gone out into the dark together. The three of them. The Ferryman. The old man. The flame.

Down to the river.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLAME REMEMBERED THE crossing.

It remembered the boat. Long. Grey. Low in the water. Older than the world. The Ferryman in the stern with his pole. The old man in the bow, sitting very upright, with his hands folded in his lap, the way he'd sat in the wheeled chair by the window every morning for a year.

The lantern on a hook on the prow. The flame in it. Lighting the way.

The water. Grey. Clean. Still. Lapping at the hull with a sound like someone turning the pages of a book.

The far shore, coming.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY'D TALKED.

The old man and the flame. In the bow. In the dark. With the Ferryman poling slowly behind them and not listening, or pretending not to.

You're very quiet, the old man had said.

I'm a flame, said the flame. *Flames are quiet.*

You weren't, said the old man. *Not for seven years. You never stopped talking. Footnotes. Volume Two. You told the boy off for not eating breakfast every morning for seven years.*

I know, said the flame. *I remember.*

But you don't remember why.

The flame considered this.

No, it said. *I remember that I did it. I remember what I said. I remember he never ate the breakfast.* A pause. *I don't remember why I minded.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OLD MAN WAS quiet for a long time.

The boat moved on through the grey water. The lantern swung on its hook. The flame burned.

I'm sorry, said the old man at last.

Don't be, said the flame. *It was a fair price. I'd pay it again.*

Would you?

The flame thought about it. Carefully. The way it thought about everything. The way its maker had taught it to think. Weighing.

Yes, it said. *I think so. I remember that it was the right thing. I can see it was the right thing. Her face, on the pillow. Your face.* A pause. *I don't feel anything about it. But I can see it.*

That's very honest.

I was made by you, said the flame. *You were always very honest. Eventually.*

The old man laughed.

Softly. In the bow. In the dark. The flame had heard that laugh a thousand times. In the Spire. In the cottage. In the wheeled chair by the window. Through twenty-two years of the boy's blood.

It noticed that it was a nice laugh.

That was all. It noticed.

◆ ◆ ◆

He'll miss you, said the old man. *The boy.*

I know, said the flame. *I remember him. He'll miss me very much. He'll kneel at the hearth every morning and say good morning and wait for me to answer.*

Yes.

And I won't.

No, said the old man. *You won't.*

The flame burned.

I can see that it will hurt him, it said. *I can see it very clearly. Like a crack in a casting. I can see exactly where it will run.* A pause. *It doesn't hurt me.*

No.

I think it ought to, said the flame. *I think, once, it would have. I think that's what I gave away.*

Yes, said the old man. Very quietly. *That's what you gave away.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FAR SHORE CAME.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLAME COULDN'T DESCRIBE it. Not then. Not afterward. It tried, later, in the third volume, and crossed it out, and tried again, and crossed that out.

It was a shore.

Shingle. Grey at first. Then not. Lights on it. Further up. Small and warm and gold, like windows in a village seen across a valley at dusk. A great many of them. And a path, going up through the shingle toward them. And somewhere up the path, faint, very far, a sound. Voices, maybe. Or bells. Or someone laughing in another room.

The boat grounded.

The old man got out.

He stood on the shingle. In the lantern-light. Young. Grey-eyed. Tall. A man of thirty-one, with silver just beginning at his temples, in the plain grey coat of a Warden-Architect, the way he'd been on the Spire steps in the rain.

He looked up the path. At the lights.

Then he turned round.

◆ ◆ ◆

Look after him, said Arion Vey.

The flame looked at him.

The boy, said the old man. *Lex. If you ever get the chance. If the old fellow ever lets you go.* He nodded at the Ferryman. *Look after him.*

I don't love him anymore, said the flame. *I gave it away.*

I know.

So I don't think I'd be very good at it.

You'll like him, said Arion. *If you get the chance. You'll like him very much.* He smiled. The flame remembered that smile. It had seen it once, on a face in crystal, at the bottom of a temple on an island in a lake of glass. It had seen it on the boy's face, sometimes, when he wasn't trying. *You did before.*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HE TURNED. And walked up the shingle. Toward the lights.

He didn't look back.

That was what the flame expected. They didn't, mostly. It had watched a great many of them now—the Ferryman had a great many on his list—and they mostly didn't. They got out of the boat and walked up the shingle toward whatever it was that was up there and didn't look back.

Arion Vey stopped.

Halfway up. On the path. Among the lights.

And turned round.

And looked back. At the boat. At the river. At the lantern on its hook. At the flame.

Just for a moment.

Then he went on.

◆ ◆ ◆

That's three, said the Ferryman.

The flame looked at him. It was the first thing he'd said all crossing.

Three times, said the Ferryman. *He turned back. Twice on the steps. Once here.* His voice was like water running over stones in the dark. *Most don't turn back at all.*

He was always going back for things, said the flame. *He was very bad at leaving.*

Yes, said the Ferryman. *I noticed.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT BACK ACROSS the river.

The Ferryman poled. The flame burned. The far shore went away behind them, and the lights, and the path, and the man who had turned back three times.

And the flame found that it was thinking about something.

It couldn't have said what. It was a flame. It thought in lists. In ledgers. In footnotes. It thought *on this day the old man crossed*. It thought *the far shore has lights on it*. It thought *he turned back a third time*.

And under all of it, something else.

Small. Quiet. Not a thought. A—*noticing*. The way you notice a draught in a room before you know where it's coming from.

You'll like him. You did before.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN HAD A great many on his list.

The flame went with him. Every night. Every crossing. On its hook on the prow of the long grey boat, lighting the way. Through the winter. Into the spring. It saw a great many people get out of the boat on the far shore and walk up the shingle.

It wrote them down.

It had started a new book. It didn't decide to. It found itself doing it, the way it had found itself doing the first two. In the dark. On the river. Between crossings. A little at a time.

The Book of What Was had been about the past. Its maker's. The boy's. The world's. Two volumes of it.

This was different.

It called it *The Book of What Is*.

◆ ◆ ◆

Volume Three, it wrote. In the dark. On nothing. The way a flame writes. *The Book of What Is. Being an account of things as they are, now, by one who no longer has an opinion about most of them.*

Footnote one, it wrote. *The author notes that this is a very dull way to begin a book. The author notes that he would once have found this funny. The author notes that he can see why.*

◆ ◆ ◆

IT MET THE BOY again in the winter.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HADN'T EXPECTED TO. The Ferryman went where the list went, and the list went everywhere, and the boy was one person among a very great many.

But the list went to a village called Ashbourne. To a cottage on the green with an apple tree by the door, blooming in the snow. To a bed in the corner by the fire, under a window, with an old woman in it. Ninety-seven. One eye. Bright. Black. Like a bird's.

And kneeling by the bed—

A gold king. Enormous. Weeping. With the old woman's hand in his.

And beside him, holding the room open between their hands with his own bare hand, shaking, sweating, with his face white and his jaw set—

A young man. Twenty-six. Burned. Grey-eyed. With a handprint on his cheek.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLAME KNEW HIM at once.

Of course it did. It remembered him. Every day. Seven years. It could have told you how many nails he'd made last spring and what he'd eaten for breakfast on the fourteenth of every month and how many times he'd said *good morning* to a fire that didn't answer.

It looked at him. Through the clear glass of the lantern. As the Ferryman bent over the bed.

And it noticed that he looked very tired.

That was all. It noticed. The way you'd notice a stranger at an inn. A young man with soot on his face and his hand out over an old woman's, holding something, shaking. *He looks very tired*, it noticed. *He looks as though he hasn't slept in a long time.*

And it noticed that he was looking at it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE YOUNG MAN WAS looking at the lantern.

At the flame. Through the glass. With his grey eyes. With his face—

The flame didn't have the word.

It had been made by a man who kept ledgers. It had a great many words. It had written two volumes. But it looked at the young man's face, looking at it, through the glass, and couldn't find the word for what was in it.

So it said the polite thing.

Good afternoon, said the flame. *I'm so sorry. Have we met?*

◆ ◆ ◆

IT KNEW, AS SOON as it said it, that it was the wrong thing.

It could see it. The way you see a crack run through a casting the moment the metal's poured. It could see exactly where it ran. Through the young man's face. Through his eyes. Down.

It didn't feel it.

But it saw it.

You look very tired, it said. Kindly. Because that was true, and kind, and the flame had been made by a man who was, eventually, both. *I hope you'll get some rest.*

And the Ferryman went out of the door with the old woman's hand in his, and the flame went with him, and the young man stayed kneeling on the gold floor with his face in his hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT THOUGHT ABOUT THAT, afterward.

On the river. In the dark. Between crossings. It thought about the young man's face.

It didn't feel anything about it. It had given that away.

But it found that it was thinking about it a great deal.

◆ ◆ ◆

Footnote nineteen, it wrote. *The author met the smith today. At the old woman's cottage. The author asked him if they had met. This was, the author is aware, a stupid question. The author has met him every day for seven years. The author remembers all of them.*

The author does not know why he asked.

Footnote twenty, it wrote. *The author thinks it may have been because he wanted to hear the smith say yes.*

Footnote twenty-one. The smith did not say anything.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SPRING CAME.

The flame saw it come. On the river. In the world, at the ends of the crossings. In the faces of the people who got into the boat.

It saw other things come too.

The grey. From the west. It saw the Ferryman's list grow longer in the west, and the people on it come from places with names like Westerling and Hobb's Cross, and come grey. Not dead grey. *Stopped* grey. As if they'd been waiting a long time to die and hadn't been able to.

It saw the Stones go white. Then dark.

It felt the net go still.

The Ferryman felt it too. The flame saw him feel it. On the river. In the dark. He stopped poling. Stood in the stern of the long grey boat with his pole in his hands and the water lapping at the hull.

And looked west.

◆ ◆ ◆

Something is sitting in the middle, said the Ferryman.

Yes, said the flame. *I felt it.*

Something that is not of the net. The Ferryman's voice was very quiet. *Something I rowed out, nine hundred years ago. In chains.* He was still looking west. *I told her brother he was not on my list. That it was his punishment. Not mine.*

I remember, said the flame.

I did not tell her anything, said the Ferryman. *She did not ask.* He began to pole again. Slowly. *She was looking at the water. All the way across. Looking for something in it.*

Her face, said the flame.

The Ferryman looked down at the lantern.

You know that?

The King told the hedge-witch, said the flame. *In her cottage. In the winter. I was not there. But I remember the hedge-witch's face, when I was in her hearth, every time she has ever been told something sad.* A pause. *I can imagine it.*

The Ferryman was quiet for a long time.

You are learning to imagine, he said.

I was always able to, said the flame. *I was made by a man who drew the world from the inside with a pendulum.*

That is not what I meant, said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CROSSED. AND CROSSED back. And crossed again.

And on one of the crossings—late, in the spring, in the dark, with no one in the boat but the two of them, going back for the next—the Ferryman spoke again.

They are making a door, he said.

The flame burned.

At the edge, said the Ferryman. *Where the grey curtain was. The smith. Out of all seven Wells. A door that asks.*

I know, said the flame. *I've seen the planks. In the yard at the Forge. When we passed through Ashbourne for the miller's father.* A pause. *They bloom.*

If they make it, said the Ferryman, *the dead of the grey country will not need a boat. They will go through the door. Into the little Well. Into the room. And through.*

Yes.

And the river, said the Ferryman, *will be very quiet.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLAME LOOKED AT him.

At the long grey shape in the stern. Hooded. The face under the hood that you couldn't quite see. The long grey hands on the pole. Older than the world. Older than the river, maybe. Older than anything.

Would you mind? said the flame.

The Ferryman poled.

I have been rowing since before there was a world to row in, he said. *Before the net. Before the Sundering. Before there were people to put in the boat. I rowed the first ones. I rowed the nine out in chains. I rowed the young man's father in the autumn and the old woman and the miller's father and*

a great many others. He was quiet for a stroke. Two. *I have never once sat down.*

The flame burned.

If there were a door, said the Ferryman, *I think I should like to sit down.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CROSSED.

The flame wrote it down.

Footnote forty, it wrote. *The Ferryman says he would like to sit down. The author notes that he has never heard the Ferryman say he would like anything. The author notes that this is the first footnote in the third volume about which the author has something that might, if one were being generous, be called an opinion.*

The author hopes they make the door.

It looked at that for a long time. In the dark. On the river.

Hopes.

It hadn't hoped anything in four months. It had given that away too, it thought. With the rest. With the love. Hope was a kind of love. It was love pointed forward.

It looked at the word. *Hopes.*

It didn't cross it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

Footnote forty-one, it wrote. *The smith's father said, look after him. You'll like him. You did before.*

The author has been thinking about this.

The author does not love the smith. The author paid that away, and does not regret it, and would pay it again.

But the author notices that he has written about the smith in nineteen of the forty-one footnotes in this volume. More than about the Ferryman. More than about the river. More than about the far shore with its lights.

The author notices that he keeps wondering whether the smith is getting any rest.

The author notices that he would like to know whether the smith still says good morning to the fire.

The author does not know what to call this.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LANTERN SWUNG ON its hook on the prow of the long grey boat.

The flame burned. Small. Gold. Steady. Warm. The colour of an ember. The colour of something that had been pressed into a sleeping boy's blood twenty-two years ago like a maker's mark.

And the Ferryman poled on through the dark toward the next name on his list.

◆ ◆ ◆

Footnote forty-two, wrote the flame. Very small. At the bottom of the page. In the corner.

Good morning, Lex.

The author does not know why he wrote that.

The author is not going to cross it out.

PART TWO

THE SORCERER'S DAWN

CHAPTER 20

STILL

SOMEBODY HAD CHALKED IT on the wall of the Crooked Kettle.

In the night. In big white letters, a foot high, on the old grey stone by the door where Benno hung the sign for the cider.

BRING THE CHILD.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAW IT ON the eighth morning.

He'd come down the lane from the Forge at dawn with Lark on his back to fetch a sack of charcoal from the cart at the inn. The way he did most mornings. And there it was. On the wall. In the grey light.

He stopped in the lane.

Lark, on his back, in the sling, with her chin on his shoulder, looked at it too. She couldn't read. She looked at it anyway. The way she looked at everything. Very seriously.

"*No*," she said.

"*No*," agreed Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

BENNO CAME OUT WHILE he was still standing there.

The landlord of the Crooked Kettle. Fat and bald and soft-spoken, with a leather apron and a face like a kind potato. He'd poured Lex his first ale at fourteen and his last one before the Blightmarch and every one between. He saw Lex. He saw the wall. He went white.

"*Smith—*"

"*It's all right, Benno.*"

"*It's not all right*." Benno was already rubbing at the chalk with his apron. Hard. Smearing it. *BRING* went grey. *CHILD* went into a white streak. "*It's not all right. I didn't—it wasn't me, smith, I swear on my mother's grave, I didn't see who—*"

"*I know it wasn't you*."

Benno stopped rubbing.

He stood there with chalk on his apron and the smeared letters on the wall behind him and looked at Lex. At the baby on his back. His soft face working.

"*It's the second one*," he said. Very low. "*There was one on the chapel door. Two days ago. Agathe washed it off before anyone saw. And one on the mill.*" He swallowed. "*People are frightened, smith.*"

"*I know*."

"*They've all got it. In their panels. Every night. That voice.*" Benno's hands were shaking. "*She doesn't say much. She just—shows them. What they are. Still. And says midsummer.*"

"*I know, Benno*."

"*And the grey's coming*," said the landlord of the Crooked Kettle. "*Everyone knows the grey's coming.*" He looked at Lark. Then away. Fast. As if he'd been caught. "*And they look at your little one, smith. In the lane. At the Forge gate. They look at her and they think—*"

He didn't finish.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CARRIED THE CHARCOAL back up the lane with his daughter on his back and the sack on his shoulder and didn't look at anyone.

He felt them look at him.

From doorways. From windows. From the well. People he'd known all his life. Hollis Penn with flour on his elbows. The widow Tull. Old Jory the cooper. The Arley boys from the mill. He felt them look up when he passed. Look at him. Look at the baby on his back.

Look away.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD BEEN EIGHT days.

Eight days since the panels opened in the dark in every house in Caldor, and a woman of glass sat in an empty chair at the bottom of the world and said *hello, everyone*.

Eight days of the net being still.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS HARD TO explain what that meant. To anyone who hadn't grown up with the net in the back of their head, the way Lex had, the way everyone in Caldor had. A thing you didn't think about. Like your own heartbeat. Like the floor.

Nothing *happened*. That was the strange thing. Nobody fell over. Nobody went blind. The sun came up and went down. People worked and ate and slept.

But nobody *grew*.

◆ ◆ ◆

DUNNY TOBBIN HAD BEEN Level 41, a Berserker, sixteen and fierce and grinding every Delve he could find before the shafts closed. He'd been at Level 41 with three-quarters of the way to 42, and he'd gone out with the Ashbourne Keepers to clear a wolf-pack in the hills above Thistledown, and he'd killed eleven wolves.

Experience: STILL.

He'd come back to the Forge white-faced and thrown his axe in the quench-trough and sat on the floor and cried.

◆ ◆ ◆

TILDA HAD BEEN WORKING on a new skill. *Runecraft — Apprentice*. She'd been working on it for a year. Every night after the forge was banked. She'd been at Apprentice 9. One more rank to Journeyman.

She'd cut a hundred runes since the net went still.

Runecraft — Apprentice 9.

She'd stopped cutting them on the fourth day. She hadn't said why. She didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE KINDLINGS.

There weren't any. Not anymore. The Queen had forbidden them. But there were children who'd turned sixteen in the last eight days, and would turn sixteen in the next eight, and the eight after that. Across Caldor. Hundreds of them.

Children who'd never been told what they were.

Children who'd go to sleep at night with a voice in their heads saying *you are what you are*, and nothing after it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not the levels*," said Seraphine.

She was at the long table in the Forge. Without spectacles. With her nose an inch off the drawing of the door, and Antho beside her—back from Mal's pool, three days now, with a face like a man who hadn't slept since he arrived—reading the figures off her notebook.

"*It's not the levels*," she said again. "*Levels don't matter. Not really. They're just numbers. Notches on a stick.*" She sat back. Rubbed her eyes. "*It's what they mean.*"

"*What do they mean*?" said Brannoc. From his anvil.

"*That you can change*," said Seraphine. "*That's all. That's what the net's for, now. Since Lex reforged it. Since the Ceiling came off. It tells you what you are, and then it tells you you can be more.*" She looked at the drawing. "*Every level's a little promise. You're not finished. You can grow.*"

She was quiet for a moment.

"*And she's taken that away*," she said. "*Not the levels. The promise.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The Forge was full. It was always full now. Every anvil busy. Every hearth lit—Kestrel had relit them all, on the first morning, reaching round the net with her eyes shut and her jaw set and sweat running down her face. Brannoc and Tilda and Hedda and half of Ashbourne. Grandmother Asha on the edge of the quench-trough with her feet in the water. Teo, dripping, in the corner, with Barnaby in his jar.

All of them working on the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FRAME WAS DONE.

It stood at the far end of the hall. By the great hearth. Upright. Seven feet high. Three and a half wide. Apple wood. Pale gold at the heart. Darker at the edges. Fitted. Pegged. No nails. Lex had cut every joint himself.

It was blooming.

It never stopped. Petals came off it all day. Small. White. Pink at the edges. Drifting down onto the flags round its foot. Tilda swept them up every evening and every morning there were more.

People came to look at it. From the village. In the evenings. They stood at the door of the Forge and looked at the frame at the end of the hall, blooming, and didn't say anything, and went away.

Lex didn't know if they understood what it was.

He didn't know if he did.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The Wells still work*," said Antho. Flatly. Reading. "*Round the net. Untracked. Kestrel's fire. Lex's. Wren's mist. Teo's tide.*" He looked up. "*Mine. Shade's still there. I can open a door.*" A pause. "*I tried it. At the Keep. The black door. It opened.*"

"*So the door can still be made*," said Brannoc.

"*The door can still be made*," said Seraphine. "*It's not of the net. It's of the Wells. She can't hold it still.*" She put her finger on the drawing. On the bottom of the list. On the empty line. "*If we can finish it.*"

Latch:

Nothing after it. Underlined twice.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And the grey*?" said Kestrel.

Seraphine didn't answer at once.

She looked at her notebook. Antho looked at it with her. Lex saw his brother's face change as he read.

"*Two miles*," said Seraphine. "*A day. Since the net went still.*" She swallowed. "*Some days three. Elowen's stakes. It's past the lantern line in four places. It's past Hobb's Cross.*"

"*And here*?"

"*Six weeks*," said Seraphine. "*Maybe seven. At this pace.*" She looked up. "*Before midsummer.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*She knows*," said Seraphine. Very quietly. "*She knew when she said it. Midsummer. She knew the grey would be in the Vale by then. In Ashbourne. At the Forge.*" She looked down the hall at the frame. At the petals. "*She wants us to be standing in the grey when we decide.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He was at the long anvil. With Lark asleep in the sling on his back for once, her cheek against his neck, her breath warm. He had a bar of iron in the tongs and the little hammer in his hand. He wasn't doing anything with either of them.

He was looking at the empty line.

Latch:

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME IN AT noon.

From the yard. With her bow over her shoulder and her face set. She'd been to the village. To the market. For bread and cheese and oil. Lex hadn't wanted her to go. She'd gone anyway. *I'm not hiding in a forge for twelve weeks*.

She came straight down the hall between the anvils. To him.

"*Hollis wouldn't sell me bread*," she said.

Lex looked at her.

"*He wouldn't look at me*," said Wren. "*He had the loaves on the counter. He looked at the counter. He said, sorry, Mistress Vey, I've none to spare today.*" Her voice was very flat. "*There were twenty loaves on the counter.*"

Nobody in the Forge said anything.

"*The widow Tull crossed the road*," said Wren. "*When she saw me. Posy didn't. Posy stood in the door of the cottage and looked at me and I thought she was going to say something and then her mother called her in.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*There's chalk on the chapel*," said Wren. "*Again. Agathe was washing it. She looked at me. She said, they're frightened, child. She said, fear makes people stupid.*" A breath. "*Then she said, I'm frightened too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT THE TONGS down.

He put the hammer down.

He reached back over his shoulder and put his hand on his daughter's head. On her fluff of hair. Asleep. Warm.

"*They think it's true*," said Wren. "*What she says. And it is true. Everything she said.*" She looked at him. "*The grey's coming. The net's still. And she can stop the grey. If someone brings her the child.*"

"*She didn't say there was another way*," said Brannoc. Gruffly. From his anvil.

"*No*," said Wren. "*She didn't. And nobody out there knows there is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS WHEN LEX understood.

He'd been thinking about it for eight days. In the Forge. At night. Kneeling at the hearth with his daughter asleep in the loft. *She didn't mention it*. Brannoc had said it, the first night. *That's not lying, lad. That's leaving something out.*

He'd heard it. He hadn't *understood* it.

He understood it now.

◆ ◆ ◆

She's not talking to us, he thought.

She never was. She's talking to them.

To every frightened person in Caldor. In every house. Every night. In their panels. Telling them the truth. The grey's coming. You're still. I can save you.

And leaving out the door.

Because she can't lie about it. So she doesn't say it at all. And nobody knows.

And they look at my daughter in the lane and think, it's her or us.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I've been hiding*," said Lex.

Everyone looked at him.

"*In here*," said Lex. "*In the Forge. Eight days. With the door. With her.*" He put his hand on Lark's back. "*Working. Thinking if I can just finish it, if I can just find the latch, if I can just get it to the edge by midsummer, it'll be all right. Nobody needs to know. I'll just do it.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*That's what I always do*," said Lex Vey. "*Wren says. Antho says. Father said. Malachi said it the first day in the Stillwater. You think you have to carry it alone.*" He looked at the frame at the end of the hall. Blooming. "*I've been carrying it alone. In here. And out there, they think there's no door. They think there's her or the grey. Because I didn't tell them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK THE SLING off.

Carefully. With Lark still asleep in it. And gave her to Wren. Wren took her. Without a word. Looking at him.

He walked down the hall.

Past the anvils. Past Brannoc and Tilda and Hedda and Kestrel and Asha and Teo. Past Seraphine at the long table with her nose on the drawing. Past Antho.

To the frame.

He put his hand on it. On the upright. Apple wood. Warm. Blooming. A petal came down and landed on his wrist.

Then he lifted it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS HEAVY. SEVEN feet of seasoned—not seasoned, *growing*—apple wood, pegged and fitted. He got his shoulder under the head of it and lifted, and it came up off the flags, and he felt his back take it, his legs, the way he'd taken weight his whole life.

Brannoc was beside him.

He hadn't heard the old smith get up. He was just there. On the other side of the frame. With his gold fingertips round the upright and his shoulder under the head.

"*Where*?" said Brannoc.

"*The green*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CARRIED IT DOWN the lane.

The two of them. Lex and Brannoc. With the frame between them on their shoulders, upright, like a doorway walking. Blooming. Petals coming off it all the way down. Drifting behind them in the lane like snow.

And behind them—

Lex didn't look round. He heard it.

Tilda. Hedda. Kestrel. Teo, dripping. Asha, on Teo's arm, in her three blankets. Seraphine, squinting, with her notebook. Antho, with his hands in his pockets. Wren, with Lark on her hip, awake now, looking at everything.

And Seren. Who had come down from Harrow that morning with Rosie to bring the paint. Harrow blue. In a pot. Seren carrying it. And Rosie beside her, a woman of forty with dirt on her hands and green eyes, looking at the frame going down the lane in front of her with her mouth a little open.

All of them. Down the lane. Behind the frame. Toward the green.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VILLAGE SAW THEM coming.

Lex felt it. The doors opening. The faces at the windows. People coming out. Into the lane. Onto the green. Hollis Penn in his apron. Benno with chalk still on his. The widow Tull. Posy, behind her. Old Jory the cooper. The Arley boys. Agathe, bent like a crook, at the chapel door, with a bucket and a brush and chalk-water dripping off it.

And others. Strangers. From the Westmarch. From the farms past Hobb's Cross that had gone grey. Families. With carts. With everything they owned. Who'd come east ahead of the grey and stopped in Ashbourne because it was the next village and there was nowhere else to go.

Lex saw a man among them.

Thin. Red-haired. With a hard set mouth and a boy beside him. Nine. Red-haired. Gap-toothed. With a bandage on his hand.

Davy Pruett. And his father.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SET THE FRAME down on the green.

In the middle. Beside the Stone.

The Stone was still wrapped. Four layers of sacking. Canvas. Chains. Padlocked. With a hush-rune cut at its foot. And through the canvas, nothing. No glow. Dark. Since noon on the day the Stones went dark.

The frame stood beside it. Upright. Seven feet. Apple wood. Blooming.

A doorway with nothing in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD IN FRONT of it.

He didn't know what he was going to say. He'd never said anything to a crowd in his life. That was Antho. That was Seraphine. That was his father. Lex was a smith. He stood in a forge and hit things.

He stood on the green at Ashbourne in front of an empty doorway with petals coming down on him and two hundred people looking at him, and didn't know what to say.

So he said the true thing.

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"*She's not lying*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS VOICE WAS TOO quiet. He heard it go out across the green and not reach the edges. He said it again. Louder.

"*She's not lying. The Glass Queen. Everything she's told you is true.*"

The green was very quiet.

"*The grey's coming*," said Lex. "*It's past Hobb's Cross. It'll be here before midsummer. The net's still. Nobody's growing. Nobody's Kindling.*" He looked round. At the faces. "*And she can stop it. If you bring her my daughter. If you put my daughter's hand on a Stone, she'll take the net, and she'll keep you. All of you. In glass. Forever. Safe from the grey.*"

Nobody moved.

"*That's all true*," said Lex. "*Every word.*"

He put his hand on the frame. On the apple wood. Warm.

"*But she left something out*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD THEM.

All of it. He didn't make it good. He didn't make it grand. He told it the way he'd tell someone how to shoe a horse. Plainly. Step by step.

The grey. What it was. A country drunk dry, nine hundred years empty, and no edge between it and the world anymore. Drinking.

The Veil. A wall. Aurelian's. And when the wall came down, the grey came through.

And the door.

Not a wall. A door. At the edge. Where the Veil had been. Out of all seven Wells. Not of the net. Not woven. *Forged*. A door that asks. That lets room through when someone knocks. A little. On purpose. And closes again. Like a tide. Like a breath.

"*This is it*," he said. With his hand on the frame. "*Or it will be. When it's done. This is the door.*"

He looked at it. The empty doorway. Blooming.

"*It's Old Mag's apple tree*," he said. "*She gave it to me. On her deathbed. She said, make something with it. Something that matters.*"

Somebody at the edge of the crowd made a sound. Lex didn't see who.

"*If we get it to the edge by midsummer*," he said, "*the grey stops. And the Glass Queen has nothing to offer anyone. Because nobody needs keeping.*" He looked round. "*She didn't tell you that. She can't lie. So she didn't say it at all.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREEN WAS SILENT.

Then a voice.

"*And if you don't*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED.

The red-haired man. Davy Pruett's father. Thin. Hard-mouthed. Standing at the front of the crowd with his hand on his son's shoulder.

"*If you don't get it there*," said Tom Pruett. "*By midsummer. If you can't finish it. If it doesn't work.*" His voice was rough. "*What then?*"

Lex didn't answer at once.

"*Then the grey comes*," he said.

"*And my boy's hand never closes*," said Tom Pruett. "*And my farm's gone. It went grey in the winter. Three generations. My grandfather cut that field out of the forest with an axe.*" His jaw was working. "*And my wife's carrying. Seven months. And the midwife at Hobb's Cross says the babies near the grey are coming late. And small. And quiet.*" His voice cracked. "*Too quiet.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*She says she'll keep us*," said Tom Pruett. "*The glass one. In my panel. Every night. She says Davy's hand won't ever get worse. She says my wife and the baby will be safe. Forever.*" He looked at Lark. On Wren's hip. Then away. "*And all she wants is one hand. On a Stone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIM.

At the thin red-haired man. At the boy beside him. At the bandage on the boy's hand, over a cut that had been open since the winter. Not festered. Not healed. Just staying.

"*She'd keep it*," said Lex. "*Davy's hand. You're right. It wouldn't get worse.*"

Tom Pruett looked at him.

"*It wouldn't get better either*," said Lex. "*Not ever. It'd be open forever. That cut. In glass. He'd be nine forever, with his hand open, the way he was on the day he grabbed the scythe.*"

Davy Pruett looked up at his father.

"*Your wife*," said Lex. Quietly. "*The baby. She'd keep them. Seven months. Forever. The baby would never be born.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

TOM PRUETT'S FACE WENT white.

"*That's what keeping is*," said Lex. "*I've seen it. In a field at Westerling. A boy with his crook out. Mid-step. Fourteen. Kept since a Tuesday in the spring. His mother sits beside him every day and talks to him and his eyes move.*" He swallowed. "*He's safe. He'll never get worse. He'll never get anything.*"

He looked round the green.

"*That's what she's offering*," he said. "*Not safe. Still. Like the bread at Westerling. Like the net. Like her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

Tom Pruett stood at the front of the crowd with his hand on his son's shoulder and his face white and his mouth working, and didn't say anything at all.

Then Davy Pruett said something.

Small. Clear. In the silence. Nine years old.

"*I don't want to be nine forever*," said Davy Pruett. "*I want to be ten. I want to have the cat in the bed.*" He looked up at his father. "*Mag said I could have him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEBODY LAUGHED.

It wasn't a happy laugh. It was the kind of laugh that comes out of a crowd when something's been wound too tight for too long and something small and true breaks it. A cracked laugh. Then another. Then someone crying. Then more laughing. The widow Tull with her hand over her mouth. Benno. Hollis Penn, red to the ears.

Tom Pruett didn't laugh.

He looked down at his son for a long time.

Then he knelt. In the slush. On the green. And put his arms round the boy. And held him. And his shoulders shook.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD BY THE frame.

He didn't know what to do. He stood there with his hand on the apple wood and the petals coming down and two hundred people on the green at Ashbourne, laughing and crying and looking at him.

Then he did the only thing he knew how to do.

He asked.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I need help*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREEN WENT QUIET.

"*I can't do it alone*," he said. "*I've been trying. In the Forge. For eight days. I can't.*" He looked at the frame. "*It needs seven Wells. I've got them. All but one. I'll have that one soon.*" He looked back at them. "*But it needs more than that. It needs hands. It needs lanterns. Every lantern you've got. Given. Along the grey. To slow it. To hold it back. Long enough.*"

"*We gave lanterns*," said someone. At the back. "*In the winter. For the line. It's past them.*"

"*Give more*," said Lex. "*Give them all. Every one. Every window. Every house.*" He looked at his mother. At Seren. Standing at the edge of the green with the pot of Harrow blue in her hands. "*My mother's family never left a light on for themselves. Not in twenty generations. But they never went past a dark window without leaving one there.*"

Seren looked at him.

"*The grey's a dark window*," said Lex. "*The biggest there's ever been.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREEN WAS VERY quiet.

Then Hollis Penn stepped forward.

Red to the ears. With flour on his elbows. Not looking at Lex. Looking at the frame. At the petals.

He went back into his bakehouse.

He came out with a loaf.

He walked across the green with it. To Wren. Who was standing by the frame with Lark on her hip. And held it out.

Then didn't.

He bent down. And set it on the ground. On the slush. At Wren's feet. And took his hand away. And straightened up.

And looked away. At the chapel. At the sky. At anything.

"*Sorry, Mistress Vey*," said Hollis Penn. To the chapel roof. "*Found I had one to spare after all.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LOOKED AT THE loaf.

Then at Hollis.

Then she laughed. Short and cracked and wet.

"*Thank you*, *Hollis*," she said.

"*It's only bread*," said Hollis Penn. And fled.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE OTHERS.

Not all at once. One at a time. Benno, with a lantern from the Kettle's sign-post. The widow Tull, with an old brass one, green with age, that had been her husband's. Old Jory the cooper, with a barrel-hoop he'd bent into a frame and hung a candle in. Hedda, with a rune-carved one from the Forge. Agathe, from the chapel, with the altar lamp. Bent like a crook. Walking across the green with it in both hands. Setting it down by the frame. Straightening up. Slowly.

"*The Lady won't mind*," said Sister Agathe. "*She's never once complained about anything I've given away.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SET THEM ROUND the frame.

On the green. In the slush. In a ring. Lit. Given. Nobody looking back.

Twenty. Fifty. A hundred.

And round each one, a small circle. Not white—there was no snow now. *Green*. The grass under the slush. Greener. As if it had heard something.

◆ ◆ ◆

TOM PRUETT WAS THE last.

He stood at the edge of the ring with his son. With nothing in his hands. He'd brought nothing. He'd come from the Westmarch with a cart and everything he owned in it, and he'd come to the green to see the man who wouldn't give up his daughter.

He looked at the frame for a long time.

Then he looked at Lex.

"*I haven't got a lantern*," he said. "*They're all in the cart. Grey. From the farm. They don't light anymore.*"

"*That's all right.*"

"*I've got hands*," said Tom Pruett. Roughly. "*I was a carpenter. Before the farm. My father was a carpenter.*" He looked at the frame. At the pegged joints. "*That's apple. It'll want a planked leaf, and ledges, and a brace.*"

Lex looked at him.

"*Yes*," he said.

"*I can do that*," said Tom Pruett. He looked down at his son. At the bandaged hand. "*If you'll have me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T ANSWER.

He held out his hand.

Not to shake. He held it out. Open. Over the apple wood. Over the frame. The way his mother had taught him to put a lamp down. The way his father had put down a cup of tea, every morning, for a year and a half.

Tom Pruett looked at it.

Then he put his own hand beside it. On the frame. On the upright. Apple wood. Warm.

A petal came down. And landed on both of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE FAINTED THAT NIGHT.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT THE LONG TABLE in the Forge. Over the drawing. With her nose an inch off the paper and Antho beside her and the hall full of people—Tom Pruett and two of the Arley boys and Hollis Penn's eldest, at the saw-bench, cutting the ledges for the leaf; Hedda, cutting runes; Brannoc and Tilda and Kestrel at the anvils.

She was saying something about the brace. The angle. Squinting.

And then she wasn't saying anything.

And then she was sliding sideways off the bench, very slowly, the way a candle goes over when the tallow's melted at the base.

Antho caught her.

He was very fast. Lex had forgotten how fast. He had her before she touched the floor, in his arms, her head on his shoulder, her notebook falling out of her hand and the pages going everywhere.

"*Sera—*"

"*I'm all right*," said Seraphine. Faintly. With her eyes shut. "*I'm all right. I just stood up too fast.*"

"*You were sitting down*," said Antho.

"*Then I sat down too fast*."

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS BESIDE THEM. Kneeling. On the flags. With the drawing on the floor and petals everywhere.

Seraphine's face was white. Not the white of fright. A different white. A grey-white. Clammy. Her lips pale.

"*She hasn't eaten*," said Antho. Hoarse. "*She hasn't eaten properly in a week. Two weeks. Since before the net. She keeps saying she's not hungry.*" He looked at Lex. Wild-eyed. "*Lex, is it the grey, is it the still, is it—*"

"*It's not the grey*," said a voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN WAS STANDING OVER them.

Lex hadn't seen her come. She'd been at the back of the hall all evening, by the great hearth, with his mother. Watching the work. With her brown gardener's hands in her lap and her green eyes on the apple wood.

She was looking at Seraphine now.

She crouched down. Beside Antho. Slowly. Her knees cracking—she was forty, and she'd only been forty for a month, and her knees were still surprised by it.

She looked at Seraphine's face for a long time.

Then she put her brown hand flat on Seraphine's stomach.

Through her coat. Gently. The way you'd put your hand on a seed-bed in spring to feel if it was warm.

And smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Rhosyn. "*Oh, it's not the grey, love.*"

Seraphine opened her eyes.

"*You're carrying a light*," said the woman who had been the Thorn-Crowned.

CHAPTER 21

Rosie

RHOSYN WOKE UP TIRED every morning, and every morning it surprised her.

She lay on the cot in the corner of the blue-door cottage, under the west window, under the horn lantern with TOO LATE cut into its base, and felt it. In her arms. In her legs. In the small of her back. A heaviness. A *slowness*. As if she'd been carrying something all night and had only just put it down.

Tired.

She hadn't been tired in nine hundred years. Nobody in the Court had. You couldn't be tired when nothing was happening. Tired was what happened when time went through you and took something with it.

She lay there and felt time going through her. Every morning.

She'd never felt anything so wonderful.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT UP.

Slowly. Her knees cracked. She was forty. She'd been forty for six weeks. Her knees had been nine hundred and something before that, but they'd been nine hundred and something without ever bending in the cold, or kneeling on a stone rim, or squatting in the birch wood to look at a snowdrop. They were forty now, and they'd found out about it all at once.

She sat on the edge of the cot and rubbed them.

Ow, she thought.

And laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WAS ALREADY UP.

Seren was always already up. *Thirteen years of getting up at dawn in the dark*, she said. *I don't know how to stop.* She was at the hearth with the kettle, in her grey shawl, with her square freckled hands doing the thing they did every morning—warming the pot, one spoon each and one for the pot, water just off the boil, not on it—without her looking at them at all.

She didn't turn round.

"*Your knees*?" she said.

"*They cracked*."

"*They'll do that*," said Seren. "*Mine started at thirty. You're doing well.*"

Rhosyn laughed again.

Seren turned round then. And looked at her. With her brown eyes. Hes's eyes. Not the colour—Hes's had been grey, like Oz's—but the *looking*. The way Hes had looked at people. Steadily. Kindly. As if she had all the time in the world and was glad to spend it on you.

"*What*?" said Seren.

"*Nothing*," said Rhosyn. "*You just looked like her.*"

Seren didn't say anything. She turned back to the kettle.

But Rhosyn saw her shoulders change. Just a little. The way a plant changes when you move it into the sun.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY HAD TEA.

At the table under the west window. With the horn lantern on the sill between them, burning on nothing. Seren in her chair. Rhosyn on the stool. With bread. Real bread. From Hollis Penn's. Which Seren had brought up from Ashbourne the day before, and which was a day old now, and going hard at the edges.

Rhosyn ate it anyway.

She ate it the way she'd eaten it the first day. With both hands. With her eyes shut. Every bite. The crust. The crumb. The hard edges. She'd forgotten bread. Not what it was. What it was *like*. The weight of it. The chew. The way the crust cracked between your teeth and the inside was

soft. The taste of it—yeast and salt and wheat and fire—going all the way down.

Nine hundred years of nothing. And then bread.

"*You're crying again*," said Seren.

"*I know*," said Rhosyn. With her mouth full. "*It's very good bread.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT OUT TO the grave after.

She did every morning. Across the stepping stones, in the grey spring light, with the stream loud and brown and high from the thaw. Past the other cottage, the smith's, with its empty east window. To the grey stone by the water.

ARION VEY.

He turned back twice.

Twenty lanterns round it. Still lit. Hollis Penn still came up every second day with his can of oil, though they didn't need it. The black soft lump that had been Pim's turnip. Nobody had moved it.

And the roses.

Two of them. Hers. The first, the one she'd sent through the snow with a scrap of silk on it, the last green thing she'd had. And the second, the one she'd planted the morning after she came, from a cutting of her own crown.

They'd grown.

Not slowly. Not the way roses grow. They'd come up the side of the grey stone like ivy, in six weeks, and over the top, and down the other side. A tangle of green stems and dark leaves and thorns. And flowers. Red. Dark red. Nearly black at the heart. A dozen. Two dozen. Open. In March. In April. As if it were midsummer.

She knelt by them.

She put her hand in the earth at the foot of the stone. Her brown hand. Her dirty hand. Into the cold wet ground. And felt them.

Growing.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D ALWAYS BEEN ABLE to feel it. Growing things. Since she was a child. Since before the pool. She'd lie on her stomach in the palace gardens

with her cheek on the grass and feel the roots under her moving. Slowly. Patiently. Reaching. Feel the sap rising in the stems. Feel a bud deciding to open.

The under-gardeners thought she was mad. *The little princess talks to the roses*.

She did. She talked to everything. She talked to the roses and the cabbages and the old apple tree by the kitchen wall. And they leaned toward her. A little. The way flowers lean to the sun.

And then she drank.

And everything she touched grew thorns.

◆ ◆ ◆

NINE HUNDRED YEARS OF thorns.

She'd tried to grow roses. In the Court. In the grey. She'd knelt in the dust with her grey hands and reached for the thing she'd always been able to reach for, and it had come—it always came—but it came *wrong*. Twisted. Hard. Dry. Brown. Thorns. Miles of them. Round the tenth tower. Round anything she loved. Round anything she wanted to keep.

That was what keeping did. To growing things. It made them thorns.

She'd known that. In the Court. For nine hundred years. She'd known it the way you know a sore tooth.

She hadn't known it would stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE KNELT BY THE grave with her hand in the earth and felt the roses grow. Up the stone. Over it. Reaching. Not hard. Not dry. *Soft*. Green. Alive. Leaning toward the light coming through the birch wood.

Thorns, still. Roses have thorns. That's just what they are.

But flowers, too.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good morning*," she said. To the stone. To the man under it, whom she'd never met. Hes's girl's husband. Who sounded, from everything she'd heard, like the kind of man Hes would have liked. *She liked men who cried.*

"*It's April*," she said. "*The roses are doing well. I think they like you.*"

She didn't know why she said it. The smith said it to his fire every morning. *Good morning*. To nobody. To something that couldn't answer.

She'd started doing it too.

It felt right. It felt like what you did. When you were in a world where things ended. You said good morning to the ones who'd gone. In case.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CHILD FOUND HER there.

She heard her first. *Thump*. *Thump*. *Thump*. Across the stepping stones. Fast. Too fast for stepping stones. Rhosyn turned round, alarmed, half up off her knees—

The child was across.

Standing on the bank. In a nightshirt too long for her. Swaying. With her fluff of dark hair standing up and her square fists clenched and a look of tremendous satisfaction on her round face. As if she'd crossed the sea.

Behind her, on the far bank, the smith's wife. With her bow. White-faced. Running.

The child looked at Rhosyn.

"*No*," she said. Proudly.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN LAUGHED.

She couldn't help it. It came out of her the way it came out of her now, all the time, rough and cracked and astonished. She sat back on her heels in the wet earth by the grave and laughed.

The child came over. *Thump*. *Thump*. And stopped. And looked at the roses. At the dark red flowers climbing over the grey stone.

And reached out.

"*Careful*," said Rhosyn. "*They've got thorns.*"

The child's hand stopped. An inch from a stem. She looked at Rhosyn.

"*Thorns*," said Rhosyn. She touched one. Lightly. With her fingertip. "*Sharp. Ow.*"

The child considered this.

Then she reached past the thorn. Very carefully. With one square finger. And touched a petal. Dark red. Soft.

And smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMITH'S WIFE ARRIVED. Out of breath. On the bank. With her bow.

"*She got out*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Again. She got out of the cot and down the ladder and out the door and I turned my back for—*" She stopped. Looked at her daughter. Touching a rose. Smiling. "*Oh.*"

"*She's all right*," said Rhosyn. "*She knows about thorns now.*"

Wren looked at her. Then at the child. Then she sat down on the bank. Heavily. In the wet grass. And put her face in her good hand.

"*She's going to be the death of me*," she said. Into it.

"*No*," said Rhosyn. "*She's going to be the life of you. That's much harder.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT BY THE grave.

The three of them. In the spring light. With the stream loud beside them and the birch wood going green behind and the lanterns burning round the stone. The child sat in Rhosyn's lap—she'd climbed there, without asking, the way she climbed everything—and played with the dirt. Picking it up in her square fists. Letting it fall. Picking it up again.

"*Is it true*?" said Wren. After a while. Not looking at her. "*About Seraphine?*"

Rhosyn looked at her.

"*Antho came up last night*," said Wren. "*At midnight. He couldn't stop talking. He walked up and down the kitchen for an hour. Lex had to sit on him.*" She almost smiled. "*He said you put your hand on her and knew.*"

"*I knew*," said Rhosyn.

"*How*?"

Rhosyn thought about it.

"*It's growing*," she said. "*It's a growing thing. I can feel growing things. I always could.*" She looked down at the child in her lap. At the dirt in her fists. "*It's very small. Very new. Like a seed in March. It's only just decided to be.*" She was quiet. "*It's the first new thing I've felt in nine hundred years that wasn't a rose.*"

Wren was very still.

"*Will it—*" She stopped. "*With the net still. With the grey coming. The midwife at Hobb's Cross says the babies near the grey are—*"

"*It's not near the grey*," said Rhosyn. "*Not yet.*" She looked west. Over the birch wood. Toward the edge of the world. "*And it's not of the net. Babies aren't. They're of the room. Of the Well. The one I drank.*" She swallowed. "*The one I gave back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CHILD DROPPED HER dirt.

And looked up. Past Rhosyn. Past Wren. At the stream.

And went very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN FELT HER GO still. In her lap. The small square body. Rigid. The fists clenched. The round face turned toward the water.

She looked where the child was looking.

The stream. Loud. Brown. High with the thaw. Running fast over the stones. Not still. Not anywhere. Not a single still place in it.

Except—

There. At the edge. By the bank. Where a root of the birch went into the water and made a little pool behind it. A pool no bigger than a dinner-plate. Out of the current. Brown. Calm.

Still.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN IT, A face.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE CHILD'S. NOT Rhosyn's. Not Wren's.

Narrow. Pale. Clear. Like ice. White hair. Ice-grey eyes. A crown of glass like a line of frost.

Looking up.

Not at the child.

At Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WAS ON HER feet. Rhosyn heard her. Heard the bow come off her shoulder. Heard her breathe in—

"*Don't*," said Rhosyn.

Wren stopped.

"*Take her*," said Rhosyn. Very quietly. She lifted the child out of her lap. Gently. And held her out. Without looking away from the little pool. "*Take her inside. Please. It's not her she wants. It's me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN TOOK THE CHILD.

Rhosyn heard her go. Back across the stepping stones. Fast. With the child on her hip saying *no*, *no*, *no*, crossly, over her shoulder, at the water.

Then the door of the blue-door cottage. Opening. Shutting.

Then nothing. The stream. The birches. The lanterns round the grave.

And her sister's face in a pool the size of a dinner-plate.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hello, Ysy*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FACE IN THE water didn't answer for a long time.

It looked at her. The ice-grey eyes. Moving over her face. Slowly. The way they'd always moved. The way Ysy had always looked at everyone, since she was four and sitting at the long mirror in the nursery. Reading. Laying it all out. Like goods on a table.

Rhosyn let her.

She knelt by the grave with her dirty hands in her lap and her knees in the wet earth and let her sister read her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're old*," said Ysenne.

"*I'm forty*."

"*You look older*." The ice-grey eyes moved. "*There's grey in your hair. Lines round your eyes. Your hands—*" A pause. "*Your hands are filthy, Rosie.*"

"*I've been gardening*."

"*You've been getting old*," said the Glass Queen. Her voice was cold. Clear. Like a bell under ice. "*Every day. I can see it. Every day you're a little older. A little closer.*" The face in the water was very still. "*To the door.*"

"*Yes*," said Rhosyn.

"*You'll die*."

"*Yes*."

"*In thirty years. Forty. In a bed. By a window. Like the smith's father. Like the old woman Oz sat with.*" The ice-grey eyes didn't blink. "*You'll go through the door, Rosie. And I'll never see you again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN LOOKED AT HER.

At her sister's face. In a pool the size of a dinner-plate behind a birch root at the edge of a stream at the end of the world.

Ysy had always been the prettiest. Everyone said so. Mother said so. The nurses. The ladies of the court. Oz said so, every morning, at the long mirror, because she made him. *Am I pretty, Oz? Am I the prettiest? Tell me.*

She *was* pretty. She'd been the prettiest girl in the world.

She was glass now. Clear. Cold. You could see through her.

And her face—her face was still pretty. The same face. The same high brow and narrow chin. Mae's chin. The same ice-grey eyes.

But Rhosyn looked at it now—really looked, the way she'd learned to look at things in six weeks of being forty and tired and alive—and saw something she'd never seen.

Ysy was *frightened*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Come with me*," said Rhosyn.

The face in the water didn't move.

"*Come with me*," said Rhosyn again. "*To the pool. Give it back. Like I did. Like Hes did.*" She leaned forward. Over the little pool. Close. "*Get old with me, Ysy. Forty. Fifty. Sixty. Get grey hair and bad knees and dirt under your nails. Eat bread.*" Her voice cracked. "*Go through the door with me. At the end. Holding hands. Like we did when we were little and Mother made us go to bed in the dark.*"

"*No*," said Ysenne.

"*Why*?"

The Glass Queen didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You chose them*," she said instead. "*The Harrow boys. The smith. The warden. You held your thorns for them and let me chain you, and then you went to their pool and poured yourself out and came here.*" The ice-grey eyes narrowed. "*To a hedge-witch's cottage. To eat her bread and sleep on her floor and dig in her dirt.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Over us*," said Ysenne. "*Over Oz. Over me.*"

"*I didn't choose them over you*."

"*You did*."

"*I chose to stop*," said Rhosyn. "*That's all. I chose to stop being what I was. I chose to start being something else.*" She looked at her dirty hands. "*I chose roses. Instead of thorns.*"

The face in the water was very still.

"*You could too*," said Rhosyn. Softly.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can't see myself*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN WENT STILL.

The face in the water had changed. Not much. The ice-grey eyes. The set of the mouth. Something in it had cracked. A hair. Like ice on a pond in the first warm day.

"*In the pool*," said the Glass Queen. "*At the end. When we went in. To the long hall. To the mirror.*" Her voice was very low now. "*You were there. You saw.*"

"*I saw*."

"*Everyone was there. In the glass. Arm in arm. You and Oz and Mae and Cad and the cousins. And Merrow. All of you. Laughing.*" The ice-grey eyes didn't blink. "*And I was in the middle. And there was nothing there. The wall. Just the wall.*"

"*I know, Ysy*."

"*Oz laughed*," said Ysenne. "*He said, Ysy, where've you gone? He thought it was a trick. Everyone laughed.*" A pause. "*I laughed too.*"

Rhosyn didn't say anything.

"*Nine hundred years*," said the Glass Queen. "*I learned everything there is to know about glass. Every pane. Every surface. Every angle of every light. I can walk through it. Look out of it. Reach through it. I can stand in a window two hundred miles away and see a child's face in a bath.*" Her voice was shaking now. "*And I've never once seen my own.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN KNELT BY THE stream with her hands in her lap.

She'd known. She'd been there. She'd seen the mirror. She'd laughed with the others.

She'd never once thought about it again.

Nine hundred years. In the Court. In the grey. With her sister in the glass palace at the end of the white road, building windows. Making them. Every surface. Every pane. Thousands. And Rhosyn out in her thorns, round the tenth tower, never once going to the glass palace, never once asking.

What are you looking for, Ysy?

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The net*," said Rhosyn. Slowly. "*That's why. Isn't it?*"

The face in the water didn't answer.

"*It's not the net you want*," said Rhosyn. "*It's not the crown. It's not keeping everyone. You don't care about keeping everyone.*" She leaned closer. "*You want it to look at you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FACE IN THE water went very still.

"*The net looks at everyone*," said Rhosyn. "*That's what it's for. It looks at every child at sixteen and tells them what they are. It looks at them every day. Every thread. It's a mirror. Of everyone.*" She swallowed. "*And if you held it—if you were the middle, the crown, the Root—then every thread in the world would run through you. Every person. And every time they looked at their panel, they'd be looking through you.*"

Nothing.

"*They'd be looking at you*," said Rhosyn. "*All of them. Everyone in the world. All the time.*" Her voice cracked. "*And you'd know you were there.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN DIDN'T say anything for a long time.

Then she said, very quietly, so quietly that Rhosyn barely heard it over the stream:

"*They looked at me. In the panels. The first night. When I sat down in the chair.*"

"*I know.*"

"*Everyone. Every face in the kingdom. In the dark. Looking at me.*" The ice-grey eyes were very bright. "*At the same time.*"

"*I know, Ysy.*"

"*It was the first time*," said Ysenne. "*In nine hundred years. The first time anyone—*"

She stopped.

"*And it wasn't enough*," said Rhosyn. Gently.

The face in the water flinched.

"*They were looking at a face in a panel*," said Rhosyn. "*Not at you. At the glass. Like you've been looking at the glass for nine hundred years. Like you looked at the mirror in the long hall.*" She leaned closer. Over the little pool. Until her own face was a foot from the water. From her sister's. "*It wasn't enough. Was it? It's never going to be enough. Not if every face in the world looks at you forever.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Stop it*," said the Glass Queen.

"*Ysy—*"

"*Stop it. Stop looking at me like that.*"

"*Like what?*"

"*Like you can see*," said Ysenne. "*Like you know. You don't know. You were out in your thorns for nine hundred years. You never came. Not once. You never came to the palace. You never asked.*" Her voice was rising. Cold. Cracking. "*You don't know anything about me, Rosie.*"

"*No*," said Rhosyn. "*I don't. You're right.*" She didn't move back. "*I never came. I never asked. I'm sorry.*"

The face in the water stared at her.

"*I'm asking now*," said Rhosyn. "*What are you looking for, Ysy?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HER SISTER DIDN'T ANSWER.

She looked up out of the little pool behind the birch root with her ice-grey eyes and her glass crown and her face that was still the prettiest face in the world, and didn't say anything.

And then she did.

"*I don't know*," said Ysenne of the Glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THREE WORDS. Very small.

Rhosyn had never heard her say them. Not once. Not in nine hundred and nineteen years. Not when she was four. Not when she was nineteen at the pool. Not ever.

I always know. That was what Ysy said. That was what she'd always said. *I always know*.

I don't know.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Then come and find out*," said Rhosyn. "*With me. Not in the net. Not in the glass.*" She held out her hand. Over the water. Brown. Dirty. Open. "*Come out, Ysy. Come and be forty with me. Come and be tired. Come and find out.*"

The face in the water looked at her hand.

For a long time.

Rhosyn didn't move. She knelt there with her hand out over the little pool, the way she'd seen the smith hold out his hand over a gold king's, and Seren hold out hers over a dying man's. Not touching. Not taking. Just there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE FACE CHANGED.

Hardened. The crack in the ice closing over. The cold coming back into the ice-grey eyes. The set of the mouth going straight and thin.

"*No*," said the Glass Queen.

"Ysy—"

"I have a crown in front of me," said Ysenne. *"I've walked for four months through every thread in the world to get to it. It's there. In front of me. Warm. Gold. Empty."* Her voice was very cold now. Very clear. *"All I need is one small hand."*

"She said no," said Rhosyn. *"The child. In the yard. To you. In Oz's cup."*

"She's a baby. She says no to everything."

"She said it to you," said Rhosyn. *"She looked at you, Ysy. In the cup. Straight at you. And said no."* She leaned closer. *"Nobody else has ever looked at you like that. Have they? Not Oz. Not Mae. Not me. Nobody's ever looked straight at you."*

The face in the water went white. Whiter. Like frost thickening on a pane.

"She did," said Rhosyn. *"And she said no."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LITTLE POOL BEHIND the birch root—

Cracked.

Not the water. Water doesn't crack. The *stillness*. The flat calm surface. It broke. All at once. As if someone had dropped a stone in it. Rippled. Shivered. And the face in it went to pieces. A hundred bright broken pieces of ice-grey and white and glass. Scattered across the ripples.

And gone.

And the stream ran in. Over the root. Into the little pool. Brown. Fast. Loud.

Not still anywhere.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN KNELT BY THE stream.

With her hand still out. Over the water. Brown. Dirty. Empty.

She took it back. Slowly. And put it in her lap. And looked at it.

I don't know, Ysy had said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN FOUND HER THERE.

An hour later. Still kneeling. By the stream. By the grave. With the roses climbing over the stone beside her and the lanterns burning and the sun going over toward noon.

Seren didn't say anything.

She sat down. On the bank. In the wet grass. With her knees cracking. And put her arm round Rhosyn's shoulders.

They sat there for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's frightened*," said Rhosyn at last.

"*I know*," said Seren. "*Oz told me. In the winter. About the mirror.*" She was quiet. "*I said, oh, the poor thing.*"

Rhosyn turned her head and looked at her.

"*You said that*?"

"*Nobody else ever had*," said Seren. "*Oz said.*"

Rhosyn looked at her for a long time. At Hes's girl. Hes's girl's girl. Twenty generations down. With brown eyes and square hands and a widow's grey shawl.

"*She can't see herself*," said Rhosyn. "*She never could. Not since the pool. She's been looking for nine hundred years.*" She swallowed. "*She thinks if the whole world looks at her, she'll know she's there. She thinks the net can do it.*"

"*Can it*?"

"*No*," said Rhosyn. "*It's glass. It's all glass. It'll show her everyone else. It'll never show her.*" She looked at the stream. "*Nothing that's glass ever will.*"

"*Then what will*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN DIDN'T ANSWER.

She thought about it. Sitting on the bank. With Seren's arm round her shoulders.

She thought about the child. In the yard. In the mud. In her nightshirt. Planted in front of a gold king with her fists clenched. Looking straight at the cup. At the face in it.

No.

She thought about the little pool behind the birch root. Her sister's face. *Stop looking at me like that. Like you can see.*

She thought about the smith's father. Whom she'd never met. Looking at his wife every morning for a year and a half, across a table, *like the sun coming up*. Every morning. And her not knowing why.

He didn't need me to know him, Seren had said. *He needed me to have a good morning.*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Someone looking back*," said Rhosyn slowly.

Seren looked at her.

"*Not glass*," said Rhosyn. "*Not a mirror. Not a panel. Glass just shows you what's in front of it.*" She looked down at her own hands. "*Someone looking back. At you. Who can see you. And says what they see.*"

"*Like the child did*," said Seren.

"*Like the child did*," said Rhosyn. "*And she said no.*" She almost laughed. "*Of course she said no. She's one. She says no to everything.*"

She was quiet for a long time.

"*It should be someone who says yes*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT UP.

Slowly. Her knees cracking. She stood on the bank of the stream at Harrow with the roses climbing over the grave beside her and the sun at noon and Seren looking up at her.

"*When they go*," she said. "*The smith. The warden. When they go to her. To the middle. To the crown.*" She looked west. Toward the edge of the world. Toward the place, very far down, under the grey river, under the drowned country, where her sister sat in an empty chair looking out of every window in the world. "*I'm going with them.*"

Seren didn't say anything.

"*She's my sister*," said Rhosyn. "*Nine hundred years she's been looking. And I never once came.*" She wiped her face with the back of her dirty hand. "*I'm going to go and look at her.*"

"*And then*?"

Rhosyn didn't answer at once.

"*And then I'm going to tell her what I see*," she said.

CHAPTER 22

The Iron of the Key

THE KEY DIDN'T WANT to burn.

Lex put the bow of it in the fire at dawn. The ring. The first of the three pieces. Black. Not black like soot. Black like the space between stars. He set it in the heart of the great hearth at the end of the Forge, where the coals were white, where he'd melted Sunreach steel and Stone-Well iron and a dragon's tooth, once, on a bet with Kestrel.

He worked the bellows.

The coals went from white to blue-white. The air over the hearth went thick and wavy. The heat came off it like a wall. Tilda, at the next anvil, stepped back with her arm over her face.

The bow of the Key sat in the middle of it.

Black.

Cold.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LET IT SIT an hour.

Then he pulled it out with the long tongs and laid it on the anvil and put his bare hand an inch over it.

Cold. Not cool. *Cold*. Like a stone at the bottom of a winter river. Like the black glass at the bottom of the world. An hour in the heart of a fire hot enough to make iron run like water, and the bow of the Key of Shadows lay on the anvil as cold as the night it was made.

"*Well*," said Brannoc. From the doorway. With his arms folded. "*That's a first.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD BEEN FORGED from a shadow.

Lex knew that. Everyone knew that. Nine hundred years ago, the night the net was woven, a frightened young man with a little hammer had stood in front of a starving Well with his little brother watching, and cut his own shadow off at the ankles, and beaten it into a key.

The Key of Shadows. It unwrote. That was what it was for. Whatever it was turned against, it unmade. Names. Locks. Ceilings. The edge of the world.

It had been barred in the Knot for three years with a forge-thing called the Lockward and an old man's thread wound round it. It had been turned one last time by that old man, in a dead girl's crown, against the Veil.

And it had come apart in his hand. Into three. The way it had been made.

Bow. Bit. Blade.

◆ ◆ ◆

Hinges: iron. Something that has turned before.

Seraphine had written it. Down the side of the drawing. In her tiny hand. Before she'd known what she meant.

Lex had known. The moment he read it. He'd looked under the bench at the basket and known.

He hadn't told anyone.

He'd thought it would be easy. Iron's iron. You heat it, you beat it, you shape it, you quench it. He'd been doing it since he was eleven.

He hadn't thought about what it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It won't take heat*," said Tilda. Standing at his elbow. With her gold hand in her apron. Looking at the black ring on the anvil. "*Why won't it take heat?*"

"*Because heat's a change*," said Lex. Slowly. Working it out as he said it. "*Heat makes iron something else. Soft. Red. Ready.*" He looked at the bow. "*And this was made to unmake things. Not to be made.*"

"*So it's stuck*," said Tilda.

"*So it's stuck.*" He looked at it. "*It's the most finished thing I've ever seen.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TRIED FOR THREE days.

Fire. All the heat he had. Flame Commanding. He stood in front of the great hearth and called it up out of the ground, out of himself, round the net, the way he'd learned to on the night the net went still. White-gold. Roaring. Until the Forge was full of it and everyone had to go out into the yard and the slates on the roof over the hearth started to crack.

The bow didn't warm.

Black heat. Fire with no light. Brannoc's lesson. Fire so hot it burned past glowing into dark. He held the bow in black heat for an hour and felt his own hands begin to blister through the tongs.

Cold.

Stone. He tried to *weigh* it. The way Stone Commanding let him feel the heft of a thing, the grain of it, where it would bear and where it would break. He put his hand over it and felt for the grain.

There wasn't any.

It was black all the way through. Like a hole. Like a hole in the shape of a ring.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE THIRD NIGHT, he sat on the floor of the Forge with his back against the long anvil and the three pieces of the Key on the flags in front of him and didn't do anything at all.

The Forge was dark. The hearths banked. Everyone gone home. Tom Pruett and the Arley boys had left the leaf of the door on the saw-bench, half-made. Eleven apple planks, edge to edge, pegged, with two ledges across the back and the brace still to cut. Blooming. Petals drifting off it in the dark onto the flags.

The frame stood at the end of the hall. Empty. Seven feet. Waiting.

Lex sat on the floor and looked at the Key.

◆ ◆ ◆

BOW. A RING OF black iron, the size of his palm. Where a hand would go. Where the hand that turned it would hold it.

Bit. A short square bar, notched like a ward. The part that went into the lock. The part that knew the shape of what it was opening.

Blade. A long slim shaft, as long as his forearm. That had held the other two together. That carried the turn from the hand to the lock.

He'd forged a thousand hinges. He knew how a hinge was made. A strap, nailed to the leaf. A knuckle, curled round at the end of the strap. A pin—a pintle—driven into the frame, upright, for the knuckle to sit on. Turn.

Something that has turned before.

He could see it. As clear as if it were already made. The bow, drawn out flat into a strap, curled at the end into a knuckle. The upper hinge. The bit, the same. The lower. And the blade, cut in two, and each half driven into the frame for a pintle.

He could see it.

He couldn't make it.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...smith...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT VERY STILL.

Not from the hearth. From the floor. From the flags under him. From the little hollow under the long anvil, where the scale and the cinders fell and nobody ever swept. A dark round space the size of a cupped hand.

[...smith...you're sitting on the floor...]

Mal.

[...you've been sitting on the floor for a long time...Ivy said...she can feel you...through me...she says you're stuck...]

He almost laughed.

I'm stuck.

[...on what...]

He looked at the three pieces of black iron on the flags.

On something that doesn't want to be anything else, he thought.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WELL WAS QUIET.

Lex felt it there. Under him. Through the floor. Through the ground. Three hundred miles off. A pool in a green field with a ring of five hundred and fifty-six lanterns round it and a woman's crown of blooming thorns on its rim.

Bigger, now. He could feel it. Not much. But bigger. The way a child is bigger after a winter, without anyone seeing it happen.

[...show me...] said Mal.

◆ ◆ ◆

SO HE SHOWED IT.

He didn't know how. He just did. The way you'd hold something up in front of a friend's face. He looked at the bow of the Key on the flags in front of him, and let the Well look through him.

And felt it go still.

[...oh...]

You know it?

[...I know it...] The voice was very small. *[...it's the thing that was in the lock...in the Knot...at the bottom...]* A shiver. Through the floor. *[...it's the thing that made me empty...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T MOVE.

[...he made it...] said the seventh Well. *[...the little man...with the hammer...the one who sat with me...at the end...]* A pause. *[...he made it to lock me...to shut the lid...to keep the hunger in the dark...]* Another pause. Longer. *[...it was made out of the dark...the same as me...]*

What?

[...his shadow...] said Mal. *[...a shadow is a place where there isn't any light...it's a hollow...a hollow in the shape of a man...]* The voice was very slow now. Working it out. *[...he cut off his own hollow...and made it into a key...to lock the biggest hollow there was...]*

To lock you.

[...yes...]

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE bow of the Key.

Black. Like the space between stars. Like a hole in the shape of a ring.

A hollow in the shape of a man.

He thought about Shade's dark. The stars. The gaps between them. *Every mould is a dark*. He thought about his father's shape, sitting in a chair, made of no stars.

He thought about Aurelian. Nine hundred years ago. A frightened young man, not much older than Lex had been when the seal cracked. Cutting off his own shadow. His own hollow. The room in himself where something new could have grown.

And beating it into a lock.

◆ ◆ ◆

It's you, he thought. *It's made of the same stuff as you.*

[...yes...]

Room. *Hollow. A place where something isn't.*

[...yes...] said Mal. *[...but pointed the wrong way...]*

Lex stared at the floor.

What do you mean?

[...I'm room that waits...] said the seventh Well. Slowly. As if it had never said this before. As if it had never known it before. *[...room for something to come...a baby...a bud...a loaf...a door...I'm the space in front of things...]* A pause. *[...that's room that unwrites...it's the space where something WAS...it takes things away and leaves the hole...]*

So it's the opposite of you.

[...no...] said Mal. *[...it's ME...just turned round...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT ON THE floor of the dark Forge for a long time.

Turned round.

The Key. Made of a hollow. Room. The same as Mal. But pointed the wrong way. Not *waiting* for something. *Taking* something. Making room by unmaking. Leaving holes.

It can't take heat, he thought. *Because heat would change it. And it's never been allowed to change. It's only ever been allowed to change other things.*

It's been pointed one way for nine hundred years.

Nobody ever turned it round.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED OUT.

He picked up the bow of the Key. In his bare hand. Not with tongs.

Cold. So cold it burned. Like holding a handful of snow, if snow could bite. He held it anyway. In his palm. The black ring. The place where a hand went.

He didn't reach for fire.

He reached for room.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SEVENTH WELL CAME up through the floor.

Through the flags. Through the hollow under the anvil where the cinders fell. Through Lex. Up his back. Into his arm. Into his hand. Soft. Dark. Patient. Enormous. The space in front of things. Room that waits.

And met the Key.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT MEET.

Like two currents meeting in a river. Like warm water meeting cold. The Key's cold. Black. Hard. A hollow in the shape of a ring. Pointed one way for nine hundred years. *Unwrite*. *Unmake*. *Take away*. And Mal's room coming up into it. Soft. Dark. Waiting. *Make room*. *Make room*. *Make room for something new.*

They didn't fight.

That was the thing. Lex had braced for it. For the two of them to grind against each other like millstones. Like the Gloam and the Root. Like fire and water.

They didn't fight.

They *recognised* each other.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT. IN his palm. In the black ring. A shiver. A start. Like someone who's been alone in a dark house for nine hundred years hearing a voice in the next room that sounds like their own.

[...oh...] said Mal. Softly. To the Key. Through Lex. *[...oh...it's you...hello...]*

The Key didn't answer. Keys don't.

But it moved.

Not in his hand. *In* itself. In the black. A turn. A slow turn. Like a key turning in a lock. Like a lock turning round its key. Like something that had been facing one way for nine hundred years turning, very slowly, very carefully, to face the other.

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AND THE BOW GOT warm.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT HOT. WARM. LIKE a stone in the sun. Like a cup of tea held in both hands. Like his daughter's cheek when she'd been asleep. Warm. In his palm. The black ring. Warm.

And not black.

Not quite. Still dark. Still the dark of the space between stars. But not *empty* dark. Not a hole. The dark of a mould before the pour. The dark of a womb. The dark of a hearth before the fire. The dark of the inside of a cupped hand.

Room that waits.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ATTUNEMENT — HOLLOW
SPEAKING → COMMANDING
"Turned it round."
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◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT ON THE floor of the Forge with the warm dark ring in his palm and the panel hanging in front of him in the dark, silver-blue, and didn't move.

Then another panel. Under it. Without him calling it.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
Experience: STILL
ATTUNEMENT (UNTRACKED)
  Flame ........ COMMANDING
  Stone ........ COMMANDING
  Tide ......... COMMANDING
  Gale ......... COMMANDING
  Shade ........ COMMANDING
  Radiance ..... COMMANDING
  Hollow ....... COMMANDING
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT for a long time.

Seven.

A smith who can hear every one.

Malachi had written that. In a cramped angry hand. On the back of a page. Nine hundred years ago. *You could not hear all seven, brother. No one can, yet.*

Yet.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T FEEL TRIUMPHANT.

He sat on the floor in the dark and looked at the seven lines. Flame and Stone, seven years. Tide, in the sea, letting go of his father. Gale, in the storm, letting go of his daughter. Shade, in the dark, with his hand on the shape of a coal. Radiance, on a grey field, with a lantern he'd wanted to keep. Hollow, on a forge floor, with the Key of Shadows turned round in his palm.

He thought of everyone who'd been there.

Teo. Wren. Antho. His mother. Nan Ashby. Mal.

He hadn't done any of it alone.

Not one.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...smith...] said Mal. Faintly. *[...smith...that's seven...isn't it...I felt it...]*

That's seven.

[...is that good...]

Lex laughed.

He didn't mean to. It came out of him cracked and wet and sudden. Alone. On the floor. In the dark. With the warm ring in his palm.

Yes, he thought. *Yes, Mal. That's good.*

[...oh...] A pause. *[...I'm glad...I'm very glad...]* Another pause. *[...smith...I think I'm going to sleep now...it was very far...]*

Go to sleep.

[...good night...]

Good night, Mal.

And the Well went back down through the floor. Through the ground. Three hundred miles. To a pool in a green field. And Lex felt it go. Soft. Tired. Like a child going upstairs to bed.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FORGED THE HINGES the next day.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOW FIRST. INTO the fire. Not the great hearth this time. The small one at the end of his own anvil. Ordinary coals. Ordinary bellows. Tilda working them.

It took heat.

It went red. Not cherry. Not orange. A deep dark red, like the heart of a coal at night, like wine held up to a candle. It glowed. From inside. And Lex pulled it out and laid it on the anvil and struck it.

Clang.

It rang.

Not like iron. Not like anything he'd ever struck. A long low note. Deep. Clear. Like a bell rung at the bottom of a well. It went out through the Forge and up into the rafters and out through the open door into the yard, and everyone stopped.

Tom Pruett at the saw-bench. The Arley boys. Hedda with her chisels. Kestrel at the hearth. Brannoc in the doorway.

Everyone stopped. And listened.

The note went on for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DREW IT OUT.

Stroke by stroke. Heat by heat. The ring of black iron opening. Straightening. Flattening. Into a strap. Long. Flat. Dark. The width of three fingers, the length of his forearm. With a curl at one end that he turned round the beak of the anvil, slowly, carefully, into a knuckle. A tube. Round. Hollow.

A hinge.

He held it up in the tongs.

Dark. Not black. Dark red, cooling to dark grey, to the dark of a winter evening. With a sheen on it like the sheen on a crow's wing. Every stroke of the hammer showing in it, faintly, like the grain in wood.

And warm.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Quench*," said Brannoc. From the doorway. Gruffly.

Lex didn't move.

He looked at the hinge in the tongs. Then he looked at the quench-trough. At the water in it. Ordinary water. From the well in the yard. Brannoc's, nailed down at the edges.

He put the tongs down.

He reached into his coat.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SHELL WAS WHERE it had been since the winter. In the inside pocket. Against his ribs. Small. Pale. Spiral. Like the shells children hold up to their ears on the shingle at Saltreach.

For your door, the Undertow had said. *The turn. The moment between out and back. When the tide stands at the bottom of the shore, and stops, and remembers, and begins to come in again.*

He held it over the quench-trough.

Quench your door in that. And it will know how to open. And how to close again.

He tipped it.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOTHING CAME OUT.

Not water. Not anything you could see. He held the shell tipped over the trough, and nothing poured from its mouth. Nothing splashed. Nothing fell.

But the water in the trough—

Stopped.

Not still. Not like the grey. Not finished. *Stopped*. The way the sea stops at the bottom of the tide. Every ripple in it going flat at once. Every eddy. Every movement. The whole long trough of water, from end to end, holding its breath.

Waiting.

And then—very slowly, very gently, from the far end of the trough—

Turning.

◆ ◆ ◆

A RIPPLE. COMING BACK. From the far end toward him. The way the first wave of the flood tide comes back up a mile of flat sand. One. Then another. Then the whole trough. Moving again. Toward him.

Coming in.

Lex picked up the tongs. And plunged the hinge.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T HISS.

Iron always hisses. Hot iron in cold water. It screams. It boils. Steam goes up in a white cloud.

It didn't hiss.

It went *in*. Into the turning water. Quietly. Like a stone into a pond at the exact moment the pond is still. And the water closed over it. And held it.

And Lex felt it. Through the tongs. Through his hands. The hinge, in the water. Taking it. The turn. The stop and the start. The out and the back. Going into the dark iron the way the tide goes into the sand, filling every grain.

Out. And back.

He drew it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS DARK. STILL. The dark of a winter evening. With the sheen like a crow's wing.

And it moved.

Not in the tongs. *On* itself. The knuckle. The round hollow curl at the end of the strap. He held it up to the light from the door, and he could see it. Faintly. A turn. Inside the curl. Slow. Like a breath. Like something rocking very gently in a cradle.

Waiting to turn.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FORGE WAS SILENT.

Everyone was looking at it. Tom Pruett. The Arley boys. Hedda. Kestrel. Tilda, with her gold hand over her mouth. Brannoc, in the doorway, with his arms folded and his face very still.

"*Well*," said Brannoc Holt. At last. Very quietly. "*That'll hang a door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BIT TOOK THE same.

Heat. Strike. The long deep note, like a bell at the bottom of a well. Draw it out. Flatten it. Curl the knuckle round the beak. Quench in the turning water.

The lower hinge.

It lay beside the first on the anvil. Dark. Warm. Breathing.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE BLADE.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D BEEN DREADING THE blade.

He didn't know why. It was the simplest. A long slim shaft of black iron. Cut it in two. Drive each half into the frame. Pintles. Pins for the knuckles to turn on.

But it was the part that had carried the turn.

Nine hundred years. From the hand on the bow to the bit in the lock. Every time anyone had ever turned the Key of Shadows—Aurelian, on the night it was made, locking the lid; Elric, with the Unnamed, cutting names

out of the world; Elric again, at the very end, in a dead girl's crown, against the Veil—the turn had gone down this shaft.

It was the part that remembered.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT IT IN the fire.

It took heat. Red. Deep. Like the others.

He drew it out. Laid it on the anvil. Lifted the chisel to cut it in two.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

BECAUSE IT WAS SPEAKING.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT A VOICE. NOT words. Not like Mal, or the Undertow, or the First Breath. Lower. Fainter. A *rasp*. Like a dry laugh. Like an old man clearing his throat in the next room.

Coming up out of the red iron on the anvil.

Lex knew it.

He'd heard it at the bottom of the world. In the Knot. On the black glass. A smudge in the dark, wound round and round a key and a bar with a grey thread. *Three years, lad. Give or take. I've been counting threads.*

Elric.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT HIM. LEX KNEW it wasn't him. Elric had gone. With the Veil. With the last thread. Unwritten. He'd put on Hesper's crown and turned the Key one last time and gone with what it unwrote.

But he'd *turned* it.

His hand on the bow. His turn going down the blade. The last turn. The one that unwrote the edge of the world.

And the blade remembered.

◆ ◆ ◆

Always second, said the iron. Faintly. In the rasp. *Wasn't I, lad. Always second. To Arion. To Aurelian. To Morvane. To the Concord. To you.*

Lex didn't move.

You were first, he thought. *Father said. At the Knot. In the spring. You were the first friend he had in two hundred years.*

Aye. The rasp. Very faint. *He said that. Beside, he said. When he came, after. Not first. Not second. Beside.*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED DOWN AT the red blade on the anvil.

He looked at the hinges beside it. Dark. Warm. Breathing. Waiting to turn.

He thought about a door.

A door gets looked at. A door gets knocked on. A door gets painted blue and hung with a lantern and remembered. People say *the door*. *Go through the door*. *Come home through the door*.

Nobody ever says *the hinge*.

The hinge holds the door. The whole weight of it. Every time it opens. Every time it closes. The hinge holds it up and lets it swing and carries the turn. And nobody ever looks at it. Nobody ever paints it. It's just there. On the side. At the back.

Second.

Beside.

◆ ◆ ◆

It's a hinge, thought Lex. To the blade. To the rasp in it. To whatever was left of an old man in a grey cloak with brass storm-charms who'd turned a key one last time. *That's what you'll be. A hinge. For a door at the edge of the world.*

The rasp was quiet.

You'll hold it, thought Lex. *Every time it opens. Every time it closes. You'll carry the turn. Nobody'll see you. Nobody'll paint you.* He swallowed. *But nothing goes through without you.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SILENCE.

Then the rasp. One more time. Very faint. Very dry. Like an old man laughing at something he's only just understood.

Beside, it said.

Aye. That'll do.

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AND THE IRON ON the anvil went quiet.

Not dead. Quiet. Red. Warm. Waiting.

Lex lifted the chisel.

He cut it in two.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY HUNG THE DOOR eleven days later.

On the frame. At the end of the Forge. With the leaf finished—Tom Pruett had cut the brace himself, and pegged it, and planed every edge, and stood back and looked at it with his son beside him and his mouth working, and said nothing at all.

Eleven planks of apple wood. Two ledges. One brace. Seven feet high. Three and a half wide. Pale gold at the heart, darker at the edges.

Blooming.

Lex nailed the hinges to it. Two straps. Dark. With the sheen like a crow's wing. He drove the pintles into the frame. Two pins. Dark too. And he and Brannoc and Tom Pruett lifted the leaf between them, and settled the knuckles down onto the pintles, one, two—

And let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT SWUNG.

On its own. Not far. A few inches. Out. Slowly. Like a breath going out.

And then back.

Slowly. Like a breath coming in.

And stopped. Shut. Against the frame.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY IN THE FORGE said anything.

They stood round it. Everyone. All of them. Brannoc and Tilda and Hedda and Kestrel and Asha and Teo. Tom Pruett and his son. The Arley boys. Hollis Penn, who'd come up with bread. Wren, with Lark on her hip.

Seraphine, squinting, with Antho's arm round her. Seren and Rhosyn, from Harrow, with the pot of blue.

A door. In a frame. At the end of a forge.

Apple wood. Blooming. On hinges made from the Key of Shadows.

With no threshold under it. No bell above it. No paint on it.

And no latch.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT HIS HAND flat on the leaf.

Warm. Alive. Growing. He felt it under his palm. Making room. Over and over. Every moment. For the next thing.

He pushed.

It swung. Open. Easily. On its hinges. Without a sound.

And through it—

The back wall of the Forge. Grey stone. Soot. A rack of tongs.

That was all.

He let go. It swung back. Shut.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not a door yet*," said Seraphine. Very quietly. From behind him. "*Not really. Not without the threshold. Not without the latch.*"

"*I know*."

"*It's a door-shaped thing*," she said. "*In a frame. In a forge.*" She squinted at it. "*It doesn't go anywhere.*"

"*I know*, *Sera.*"

"*It needs the Stone*," said Seraphine. "*And it needs a latch.*" She looked at him. "*And I still don't know what the latch is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The door stood at the end of the Forge. Shut. Blooming. With petals coming off it onto the flags.

And then someone knocked on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT ON THE DOOR. On the *other* door. The great double doors of the Forge. Behind them. At the far end of the hall. The ones that opened onto the yard.

Knock.

Once. Soft. Careful. Very careful. The way a very big man knocks when he's afraid of breaking something.

Everyone turned.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREAT DOORS WERE open. They were always open. It was a forge. Light and air came in. People came in.

He was standing just outside them. In the yard. In the spring dusk. Not coming in.

Gold. Enormous. Glowing like metal in a crucible. Taller than the doors, nearly. With his head bowed under the lintel. With a lopsided gold cup in one hand, with a crack across the tea in it. With his other hand still raised, where he'd knocked on the open door.

The Gilded King looked down the long hall of the Forge.

Past the anvils. Past the hearths. Past all of them, standing frozen.

At the door at the end.

And Lex saw his face.

He'd seen it at the bottom of Old Mag's step. At the bottom of the yard at Harrow, in the rain. On the floor of his mother's cottage, at the end.

He'd never seen it look like this.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*," said the King. Very quietly. "*Is that it?*"

Lex didn't answer.

"*The door*," said the Gilded King. He was looking at it. At the apple wood. At the dark hinges. At the petals. "*The one you're going to put at the edge. Where Hes's curtain was. For the dead to go through.*"

"*Yes*."

The King looked at it for a long time.

"*May I come in*?" he said.

CHAPTER 23

Brannoc

BRANNOC HOLT HAD BEEN asked a lot of things in sixty-five years, and most of them he'd said yes to without thinking, and a few of them he'd said no to and been sorry, and one or two he'd said nothing to at all and been sorry for longer.

Nobody had ever asked him if they could come into his forge.

People just came in. It was a forge. The doors were always open. Light came in, and air, and anyone who needed a horse shod or a pot mended or a word. That was what a forge was for. You didn't ask. You came in.

He stood in the middle of the long hall with a hammer in his hand and looked at the King in the doorway.

Gold. Enormous. With his head bent under the lintel and a cup in his hand and his other hand still raised from knocking on a door that was already open.

May I come in?

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EVERYONE WAS LOOKING AT the lad.

Brannoc could feel it. The whole Forge. Tilda and Hedda and the fire-witch and the old desert woman and the dripping boy. The carpenter from the Westmarch and his son. Hollis with his bread. Wren, with the little one. Seren, with her pot of blue. The thorn-woman beside her, who wasn't a thorn-woman anymore. Seraphine and Antho.

All of them. Looking at Lex. Waiting for him to say.

And the lad was standing by the door at the end of the hall. The new one. Apple wood. Blooming. With his hand still on it. With his face white.

He didn't say anything.

Brannoc watched him not say anything. Watched him look at the King in the doorway. Watched him think about a gold floor in an old woman's cottage. About a yard at Harrow in the rain. About a cup with a crack in it.

About his daughter. On her mother's hip. Twenty feet away.

◆ ◆ ◆

SO BRANNOC SAID IT.

He didn't decide to. It came out of him the way most things did. Before he'd thought about it.

"*Mind the floor*," said Brannoc Holt. "*It's been swept.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT him.

Down the long hall. Over the anvils. Past all of them. At the old bald soot-bearded man in the middle of the floor with a hammer in his hand. Furnace eyes. Dimmed. Banked. Like a fire for the night.

"*You're the smith*," said the King. "*The big one. With the fingers.*"

"*I'm a smith*," said Brannoc. "*He's the smith.*" He jerked his chin at Lex. "*I just taught him.*"

The King looked at Lex. Then back at Brannoc.

"*I gilded your fingers*," he said.

"*Your steward did*." Brannoc held up his left hand. In the light from the hearths. The fingertips. All four. And the thumb. Gold. To the first knuckle. Smooth and bright and cold. "*On the green. In the spring. I was standing in front of a cart with six children in it.*"

"*I know*," said the King. "*I felt it. Every grain of it.*" He was very still. "*I'm sorry.*"

"*Are you?*"

"*Yes*."

Brannoc looked at him for a long time. At the gold face. At the furnace eyes. At whatever was in them.

"*Well, come in, then*," he said. "*Don't stand in the door. You're letting the heat out.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME IN.

It took a long time. He came the way he must have come into the old woman's cottage. Bent nearly double. Sideways between the anvils. Putting each foot down so carefully it might have been glass. The flags went gold where he stepped. A path. Gold. Down the middle of the long hall, from the great doors toward the hearth.

People moved out of his way.

Not running. Not screaming. Brannoc was proud of them for that. They just moved. Quietly. The way you'd move out of the way of a cart. Tilda stepped back with her gold hand in her apron. Hedda gathered up her chisels. The carpenter put his arm round his boy and stepped behind the saw-bench.

Wren didn't move.

She stood where she was. With the little one on her hip. With her bow over her shoulder. And watched the King come.

The little one watched too. With her fist in her mouth. Very seriously.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING STOPPED.

Halfway down the hall. In front of Wren. A yard off. Bent. Looking down.

At the child.

The child looked up.

Brannoc held his breath. Everyone did. He heard it. The whole Forge.

The King put his hands behind his back. Both of them. With the cup. And held them there.

"*Hello*, *little one*," he said.

The child took her fist out of her mouth.

Brannoc waited for it. *No*. They all did.

The child looked at him. At the great gold face bent over her. At the furnace eyes. For a long time.

Then she put her fist back in her mouth.

And didn't say anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING STRAIGHTENED UP.

Slowly. Brannoc saw his face. Saw something go across it. Quick. Like a cloud across the sun.

He didn't say anything either.

He walked on. Down the hall. Past Wren. Past the child. Toward the hearth.

Toward the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED IN FRONT of it.

The apple wood door in its apple wood frame at the end of the Forge. Shut. Blooming. With its dark hinges, that had been a key. With petals drifting off it onto the flags round the King's gold feet. And staying white.

He looked at it.

He looked at it the way Brannoc had seen men look at the sea. The first time. Lads from the Vale who'd never been further than Thistledown, standing on the cliffs at Saltreach looking out at all that grey water going on forever. Looking at something too big to understand.

Except it was a door. Seven feet high. Three and a half wide. A cottage door.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's very small*," said the King.

"*It's the size of a door*," said Brannoc.

"*I thought it would be—*" The King stopped. "*I don't know what I thought. Big. Like Hes's curtain. Like the gate at the palace. Like the black door at the bottom of your mountain.*" He looked at it. "*It's the size of the door on the hedge-witch's cottage.*"

"*That's the point*," said Seren. Quietly. From behind him. With her pot of blue. "*Seraphine says. If it's big and terrible, nobody'll knock.*"

The King didn't turn round.

"*No*," he said. "*No. I suppose they wouldn't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT THE hinges.

Brannoc saw him look. Saw the furnace eyes go to the dark straps on the apple wood. The sheen like a crow's wing. The knuckles curled round the pintles. Breathing. Very faintly. A slow turn inside the curl, like something rocking in a cradle.

"*That's Aurelian's*," said the King.

Nobody answered.

"*That's the Key*," said the King. "*Isn't it? The little man's key. That locked the pool. That Cad went down the thread for. That the grey one turned.*" He was very still. "*I'd know it anywhere. I felt it made. On the shingle. In chains. Waiting for the boat.*"

"*Yes*," said Lex. From beside the door. Hoarse.

"*And now it's a hinge*."

"*Yes*."

The King looked at it for a long time.

"*Cad would have laughed*," he said. "*Cad never laughed. But he'd have laughed at that.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT THE leaf.

At the apple wood. Pale gold. Blooming.

"*That's the old woman's tree*," he said.

Lex didn't answer.

"*I sat under it*," said the King. "*Two weeks. On the gold path. With the children. She talked to me from the window. She said it was the only thing in the village that never got any older.*" His voice was very low. "*She said the flowers were new every morning.*"

"*She gave it to me*," said Lex. "*At the end. She said make something with it.*"

"*I heard*," said the King. "*I was holding her hand.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED OUT.

Brannoc saw it happen. Saw the King's great gold hand come out from behind his back—not the one with the cup, the other one—and lift. Toward the door. Toward the apple wood. Slowly. Shaking.

"*Don't*," said Lex.

The hand stopped.

An inch from the wood. Hanging there. Gold. Enormous. Shaking.

"*It'll go gold*," said Lex. Very quietly. "*If you touch it. It'll stop growing. It'll be kept.*" He swallowed. "*It won't be a door anymore. It'll be a wall.*"

The King looked at his hand. An inch from the wood.

He didn't take it away.

He didn't put it down.

He just held it there. An inch off. The way he'd held it over the lad's shoulder on the floor of the old woman's cottage. Not touching. Not keeping.

A petal came down off the door. And landed on the back of his gold hand.

And stayed white.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING MADE A sound.

Not a word. Not a laugh. Brannoc didn't know what it was. Something between the two. Something that came up out of the great gold chest like a breath let out after a long time under water.

He stood there with his hand an inch from the door and a white petal on it and looked at it.

Then he took his hand back. Slowly. With the petal still on it.

And looked at the petal.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*," he said.

Brannoc thought he meant Lex. Then he saw the furnace eyes. On him.

"*Aye*?"

"*Can I sit*?" said the Gilded King. "*Somewhere. Anywhere. On the floor. I've been walking for three days.*"

Brannoc looked at him.

Then he looked round the Forge. At all of them. Standing. Still. Watching. The lad by the door, white-faced. Wren with the little one. Seren with her pot. The thorn-woman. Antho and Seraphine.

"*Go home*," said Brannoc. To all of them. "*It's late. Go and eat. Go to bed.*"

Nobody moved.

"*Go on*," said Brannoc. Louder. "*It's my forge. I'm banking the fires. Go home.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT.

Slowly. One at a time. Looking back. Tom Pruett and his boy. The Arley lads. Hollis. Hedda. Tilda, last of the Forge folk, with her gold hand in her apron, looking at Brannoc with her eyebrows up. He shook his head at her. *Go*. She went.

Kestrel stopped in the door. Looked at the King. Looked at Brannoc.

"*If he gilds your forge*," said the fire-witch, "*I'm not helping you sweep it.*"

"*Noted*," said Brannoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FAMILY DIDN'T GO.

He'd known they wouldn't. Seren and the thorn-woman sat down on the bench by the long table with the pot of blue between them. Antho and Seraphine stood by the wall. Wren went to the far end, to the corner by the quench-trough, and sat on an upturned bucket with the little one in her lap, and didn't take her eyes off the King.

And the lad stood by the door.

With his hand on it. On the apple wood. As if he could hold it shut by himself.

Brannoc let them be.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE BANKED THE FIRES.

He did it the way he'd done it every night for forty-five years. The great hearth first. Then the others. Down the long hall. One by one. Rake the coals in. Pile the ash over. Leave a red eye in the middle. Enough to wake in the morning.

The King watched him.

He'd sat down on the floor in front of the great hearth. Cross-legged. With his back to the door. With the cup in his lap. The flags under him going gold in a circle.

He watched Brannoc rake and pile and bank. All the way down the hall and back.

He didn't say anything until Brannoc had finished.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why do you do that*?" he said.

Brannoc looked at him.

"*The ash*," said the King. "*You cover them. All of them. Every night. You don't put them out.*"

"*You don't put out a forge fire*," said Brannoc. "*Not if you can help it. Takes an hour to light from cold. More, for the big hearth.*" He sat down. On the edge of his own anvil. The first one. The one he'd swung the lad up onto at eleven. "*You bank it. Cover it. Keep it low. And in the morning you rake off the ash and blow on it and it wakes.*"

"*Keep it*," said the King.

"*Not keep it*," said Brannoc. "*Bank it.*"

"*What's the difference*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC THOUGHT ABOUT IT.

He wasn't a thinking man. He'd never pretended to be. He was a smith. He thought with his hands. With heat and weight and the ring of iron. When the lad was small and asked him things—*why does iron go red*, *why does water make it hard*, *why did my mother go into the fire*—he'd never had words. He'd shown him instead. At the anvil. With his hands.

He didn't have an anvil for this.

He tried anyway.

"*If you kept it*," he said slowly, "*it'd be the same fire. All night. Forever. Never going down. Never going out. The same flame.*" He looked at the great hearth. At the red eye under the ash. "*And in the morning you couldn't do anything with it. Because it'd just be—the same. Burning. Like it was.*"

The King was listening.

"*Banked*, *it goes down*," said Brannoc. "*It rests. It goes low and red and quiet. And in the morning it's a new fire. Out of the old one. You blow on it and it comes up different. Every morning.*" He shrugged. "*That's the difference. Kept's the same fire. Banked's a new one every day.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WAS QUIET for a long time.

He looked at the hearth. At the red eye under the grey ash.

"*The old woman said that*," he said at last. "*About the flowers. New every morning.*"

"*Mag said a lot of things*," said Brannoc. "*Most of them rude.*"

The King laughed.

Cracked. Wet. Astonished. Brannoc heard it go up into the rafters of his forge and come back down.

"*She was rude to me*," said the King. "*On the green. In the snow. She said I was a lump.*"

"*You are a lump*," said Brannoc.

The King laughed again.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Tell me about your fingers*," said the King.

Brannoc looked down at them. At his left hand. In his lap. The gold tips. In the red light from the banked hearths.

"*Nothing to tell*," he said. "*The dust came down. I was standing in front of a cart. Six kiddies in it. Little Jenna Tull and the Arley twins and the rest. The lad was making room in front of them. Couldn't make it in front of me as well.*" He turned the hand over. "*So it came down on me.*"

"*Does it hurt*?"

"*No*."

"*Do you mind*?"

Brannoc thought about it.

"*I mind I can't hold a pair of tongs right*," he said. "*I mind I can't feel the iron. Fifty years I've felt iron with these. Felt it through the tongs. Hot. Cold. Ready. Not ready.*" He looked at the gold. "*Can't now. Not with this hand. Have to look. Have to guess.*"

"*I'm sorry*."

"*You said*."

"*I am*," said the King. "*I'm sorry for all of them. Your fingers. The girl's hand. The miner's arm. The wife's—*" He looked toward the corner. At Wren. On her bucket. With the little one in her lap. "*The boy in the field.*

The man in the gate. The old shepherd's wife in her chair." He looked down at his own hands. "*Nine thousand of my own. All of them. I'm sorry for all of them.*"

"*Then let them go*," said Brannoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WENT STILL.

Brannoc watched him go still. The way iron goes still when you pull it out of the fire and lay it on the anvil and it stops glowing and starts to set.

"*I can't*," said the King.

"*Why not*?"

"*Because if I let go*—" The King stopped.

"*If you let go*," said Brannoc, "*my fingers come back. The lass's hand. The miner's arm. Wren's. The boy in the field finishes his step. The Keeper walks out of his gate.*" He looked at the King. "*And your nine thousand come apart. Nine hundred years. All at once. In front of you.*"

The King stared at him.

"*The lad told me*," said Brannoc. "*In the winter. After the green.*" He folded his arms. "*And you go too. Don't you? It's you that's holding them. If you let go, there's nothing holding you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING DIDN'T ANSWER.

He sat on the floor of the Forge with the cup in his lap and the banked hearth behind him and the door behind that, and didn't say anything at all.

Brannoc let him not say anything.

He'd learned that. Not from anyone. From the lad. From a boy of eleven, sitting on the floor of this same forge at night, after the fire, after his mother went into the dark and his brother went mad and the whole of his life went up like dry thatch. Sitting on the floor. Not crying. Not talking. Just sitting.

Brannoc had sat with him.

Every night. For a month. On the floor. Not saying anything.

That was all. That was the whole of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I had a wife*," said Brannoc.

He didn't know he was going to say it. It came out of him.

The King looked up.

"*Mattie*," said Brannoc. "*Martha Holt. Married at twenty. She was a weaver. Up at the mill. Red hair. Freckles. Laughed like a goose.*" He looked at the banked hearth. "*Couldn't have children. We tried. Ten years. Never happened.*" A pause. "*She'd have liked the lad. She'd have spoiled him rotten.*"

The King didn't say anything.

"*Wasting sickness*," said Brannoc. "*Same as your father, sounds like. In the chest. Took a winter. Twenty-five years ago.*" He looked at his gold fingertips. "*Started in the autumn. A cough. By Midwinter she couldn't get up the stairs. I carried her. By the thaw she couldn't get out of bed.*"

"*Did you—*" The King stopped.

"*Go in*?" said Brannoc. "*Aye. Every night. Sat by the bed. Held her hand.*" He shrugged. A small heavy movement. "*Didn't say much. Didn't have much to say. She did the talking. She always did.*"

"*Was it—*"

"*Terrible*?" said Brannoc. "*Aye.*"

The King was very still.

"*Worst thing I ever did*," said Brannoc Holt. "*Sitting there. Every night. Watching her go. A bit more every night. Like a fire going down. And nothing to do about it. Not a thing. A smith. Fifty years of fixing things. And I couldn't fix that.*" He looked at his hands. "*I'd sit there holding her hand and think, I could beat iron into anything. Anything. And I can't do this.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FORGE WAS VERY quiet.

Brannoc heard the banked fires ticking. The rain on the slates. Somewhere at the end of the hall, by the quench-trough, the little one making a small sleepy sound in her mother's lap.

"*Would you do it again*?" said the King. Very quietly.

Brannoc looked at him.

"*Every night*," he said. "*Every night of my life. If I could have her back for a winter to do it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING PUT HIS face in his hands.

Brannoc didn't move.

He sat on his anvil and watched the biggest man in the world sit on the floor of his forge with his face in his hands and his shoulders shaking, and didn't move, and didn't say anything.

That was all. That was the whole of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

AFTER A LONG TIME, the King lifted his head.

His face was wet. Gold tears. On gold cheeks. Falling. Onto his robe. Onto the cup in his lap. Onto the floor.

The floor was already gold.

"*I couldn't go in*," he said. "*For my father. A month. Every night. I stood outside. With my hand on the latch.*" His voice was a ruin. "*Cad went in. He was eleven. He held Father's hand. Every night. And I stood outside the door. And I thought—if I drink, I'll never have to stand outside a door again. Not ever. For anyone.*"

"*And now you're standing outside nine thousand of 'em*," said Brannoc.

The King stared at him.

"*Aren't you*?" said Brannoc. "*All those folk of yours. Walking across the fields. Humming. Home.*" He leaned forward. "*They're not home. They're in a room with no door. And you're standing outside it. With your hand on the latch. Every night. For nine hundred years.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING DIDN'T SAY anything.

He sat on the floor with his wet gold face and his cup in his lap and looked at Brannoc.

And Brannoc saw it. He didn't have Seren's eyes, or the Glass Queen's, or anyone's. He was a smith. He saw iron. He saw heat. He saw when a thing was ready and when it wasn't.

He saw it now.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You leave iron in the fire too long*," said Brannoc Holt, "*it burns.*"

The King looked at him.

"*You don't know that*," said Brannoc. "*You've never held a pair of tongs.*" He got up. Off his anvil. Slowly. His knees cracking. He went to the rack on the wall and took down a pair of tongs. Old. Worn. The handles polished by fifty years of his hands. He came back and sat down again and held them up. In the red light. "*You put a bar in the fire. You let it come up. Red. Orange. Yellow. White.*" He moved the tongs. "*And then you take it out. And you work it. And you quench it. And it's what it is. A nail. A hinge. A horseshoe.*"

"*And if you don't take it out*?"

"*It keeps going*," said Brannoc. "*White. Past white. It starts to spark. Little stars. Coming off it.*" He looked at the tongs. "*Pretty. Looks pretty. Like a firework.*" He looked at the King. "*That's the iron burning. That's the iron going. Into sparks. Into nothing. You leave it in long enough, there's nothing left on the end of your tongs but a lump of slag.*"

The King was very still.

"*You've got to take it out*," said Brannoc. "*You've got to let it cool. You've got to let it be what it's going to be. Even if it's not what you wanted. Even if you'd rather it stayed white and shining in the fire forever.*" He laid the tongs across his knees. "*Or there's nothing left.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT the tongs for a long time.

Then he looked down at his own hands. Gold. Enormous. In his lap. Round the cup.

"*They're burning*," he said. Very quietly. "*Aren't they. My household. They've been in the fire nine hundred years.*"

Brannoc didn't answer.

"*Kept's the oven*," said the King. "*Finished is the cake.*" He laughed. Cracked. "*Kept's the fire. Finished is the horseshoe.*" He looked up at Brannoc. "*Everything's a cake. Everything's a horseshoe. You're all the same.*"

"*Most of us*," said Brannoc. "*Aye.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING GOT UP.

Slowly. Carefully. The way a very big man gets up off a floor he's afraid of breaking. One knee. Then the other. Then all of him. Up and up. Until his head was among the rafters and the red light from the banked hearths was on his gold face from below.

He turned round.

To the door.

The apple wood door in its frame at the end of the Forge. Shut. Blooming. With its dark hinges breathing.

The lad was still standing beside it. With his hand on it. White-faced.

The King looked at the door. Then at the lad. Then at the door again.

"*If I let go*," he said. "*If I open my hand. All the way.*" His voice was very low. "*I go through that. Don't I.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The lad didn't. Seren didn't. The thorn-woman didn't. Antho didn't. Wren didn't, in her corner, with the little one asleep in her lap.

Brannoc didn't.

He looked at the King's back. Huge. Gold. Facing the door.

He thought about Mattie. In a bed. By a window. In the thaw. Holding his hand. *Don't you dare sit in that chair moping after, Brannoc Holt. You go and find someone to look after. You're no good on your own.*

He'd found the lad.

Ten years later. In the ashes of a cottage in a birch wood. Eleven years old. Not crying. Not talking.

He'd swung him up onto the anvil.

This is yours now, lad.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Aye*," said Brannoc Holt. "*Most of us do. In the end.*"

The King didn't turn round.

Brannoc got up off his anvil. Slowly. His knees cracking. He walked down the hall. Past the hearths. Past the long table. Past Seren and the thorn-woman on the bench. To the door.

He stood beside the lad. On the other side of the frame. And put his own hand on the apple wood. His left. With the gold fingertips.

The wood was warm.

He couldn't feel it. Not with those fingers. He felt it anyway. Through the rest of his hand. The palm. Warm. Alive. Growing. Making room.

He looked up at the King.

"*I'll hold it for you*," said Brannoc. "*When it's time. The door.*" He shrugged. "*Someone'll have to. Might as well be a smith.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED DOWN at him.

For a long time. The furnace eyes. Banked. Low. Red under the gold. Like a forge fire under ash.

Then he did something Brannoc would think about for the rest of his life.

He bowed.

Not low. Not the court bow. Not the steward's bow, with one arm across the middle. A small bow. A nod, really. A tilt of the great gold head. The way one man nods to another across a forge, when the other's said something that'll take a while to think about.

"*Thank you*," said Oszric of the Crowned. "*Smith.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT OUT AT midnight.

Down the long hall. Down his own gold path. Out through the great doors into the yard, where the rain had stopped and the stars were out over the Vale.

He stopped in the yard.

Brannoc watched him from the door. Watched him stand there. Huge. Gold. Glowing faintly in the dark. Looking up at the stars.

Then he lifted his hand. The one without the cup. And looked at it.

There was a petal on the back of it. Still. White. Pink at the edges. Off the apple wood door. It had stayed there. All night. Through all of it. Not gold.

The King looked at it for a long time.

Then he closed his hand round it. Very gently. The way you'd close your hand round a moth.

And walked away into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC WENT BACK IN.

The family was still there. All of them. Seren and the thorn-woman on the bench. Antho and Seraphine by the wall. Wren on her bucket with the little one asleep. The lad by the door.

Nobody said anything.

Brannoc went to the great hearth. Knelt. With his knees cracking. And looked at the banked fire. At the red eye under the ash.

He'd banked it an hour ago. He'd banked it every night for forty-five years.

He blew on it anyway. Gently. The way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

It woke. A little. A flicker. A lift.

Good evening, said the fire. Not in words. A warmth. A small bright gladness.

Brannoc had never heard it before. Not once in forty-five years. The lad heard it. The lad said good morning to his fire every day. Brannoc had always thought that was his father in him. The mad streak. The Vey in him.

He heard it now.

He knelt there on the hearthstone with his gold fingertips on his knees and looked at the little red flame and didn't say anything for a long time.

"*Evening*," said Brannoc Holt. At last. Gruffly. To the fire.

It seemed rude not to.

CHAPTER 24

ILDA

PIM COUNTED THINGS.

He'd always counted things. When he was small, before he could talk, before the Keep, before anybody had looked at him long enough to notice he was there, he'd counted. Steps. Stones. Cracks in a ceiling. Breaths. Counting was quiet. Counting didn't take up any room. You could count in your head all day and nobody would ever know.

He counted lanterns now. Five hundred and fifty-six. Round the pool in a ring. In the long green grass. He walked round them every morning before the others were up, the way Antho had walked round the eleven hundred at the Keep, and touched each one. Not to light it. They didn't need lighting. Just to say *I see you*.

He counted the lights in the water. Three. Down in the middle of the pool. Under the surface. Where Mal kept them. The bright steady one, Malachi. The gold one, the old king, Aurelian. And the small fierce one that flickered like a candle in a draught, which was Kell, who had held on.

He counted the dead.

That was harder. They moved. Grey columns of dust standing on the grass in the morning mist, all round the rim, like a crowd at a fair waiting for something to start. Swaying. Drifting. Bending to look at things. A dozen came every day. Out of the west. Down out of the grey sky. Settling round the pool like leaves. And every day, a dozen went in. Into the water. Into the dark. And came apart, gently, and were gone, and Mal's voice under the water went a little deeper. A little warmer.

Pim stopped counting the dead after the first week. There were too many. It wasn't fair to them, to be a number.

He counted the days instead.

It had been sixty-one days since he'd brought Ilda to the pool.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS IN THE doorway.

She was always in the doorway.

The Coldwater house stood on the north side of the pool, thirty yards up the slope. Hask had built it. Hask and Kit and the Coldwater crew, the autumn after the rim. Stone walls. A slate roof. A fat chimney. One big room with a long table and a hearth and seven bunks along the back wall and Kell's stick on two pegs over the door. And in the window, on the sill, a lantern. Plain tin. With a word scratched round the base in the lad's hand.

HOME.

Ilda stood in the door under it.

Eight years old. Small. Thin. Barefoot. In a kitchen girl's smock with a burn-mark on the hem. Gold. All of her. Hair, skin, eyes, smock, the soles of her bare feet. Smooth and bright and cold, as if somebody had dipped her in it. As if she were something on a mantelpiece.

She'd been gold for nine hundred and twelve years.

She stood in the doorway with one gold hand on the frame and looked down the slope at the pool.

And at the edge of the pool, on the grass, between the lanterns, a column of grey dust stood and looked back at her.

It didn't drift. The others drifted. This one didn't. It stood on the rim. Bent a little. At the top. Toward the house. The way a woman bends over a cot. The way a woman bends to look in an oven to see if the bread's done.

It had been standing there for sixty-one days.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Morning*," said Pim.

He sat down on the step at Ilda's feet. With his knees drawn up. The way he always did. And didn't say anything else for a while.

That was the thing about Ilda. You didn't have to. She didn't mind. She'd been standing on a road for nine hundred years with eight thousand

nine hundred and ninety-nine other people and none of them had said anything to her at all. A boy on a step who didn't talk was company.

"*Morning*," said Ilda.

Pim looked up.

She'd never said it before. Not in sixty-one days. *Mam*, she said. And *Pim*, sometimes. And *no*, once, when Kit tried to carry her down to the water. And *bread*, a lot. But never *morning*.

"*The lady says it*," said Ilda. Very slowly. Her voice was small and rusty. Like a gate that hadn't been opened. "*The crutch lady. Every day. To the water.*"

Ivy. Ivy said good morning to Mal every day. Leaning on her crutch on the rim. *Morning, Mal. Sleep well?* As if the pool were a lodger.

"*Yes*," said Pim.

"*Is it morning*?" said Ilda.

Pim looked at the sky. Pale. Pink in the east. Mist on the grass. The lanterns glowing in their ring.

"*Yes*," he said.

Ilda looked at it too. For a long time. With her gold eyes.

"*It was always the same*," she said. "*On the road. It was never morning.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM HAD TRIED EVERYTHING.

He'd tried the first week. Every day. Cupped his hands in front of her face, the way he had on the white road, the way that had made her cry. Made room. A little pocket of quiet, soft and dark and still, right in front of her, and let her look into it.

She looked. She cried, sometimes. She took a step.

She always took a step. One. Out of the door. Onto the grass. Toward the pool. Toward her mam.

Then another.

And another. Thirty yards. Down the slope. Through the long grass. With the dew not wetting her feet, because it couldn't. Past the lanterns. To the rim.

And there she stopped.

Every time.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST TIME, SHE'D tried to go in.

Pim had been holding her hand. Gold. Cold. Hard. Like holding a doorknob. He'd walked her down to the rim and she'd looked at the grey column of dust bending over her and said *Mam*, and the column had bent lower, and Pim had felt it. The way you feel someone smile in the dark.

And Ilda had stepped off the rim. Into the water.

And the water hadn't let her.

It didn't splash. It didn't part. It went flat under her foot, hard and smooth, like the top of a table. Like ice. Like glass. She stood on it. On the surface of the pool. A gold girl, standing on the water, with her mother's dust a foot away, bending, and the water would not let her down.

She'd stood there. Staring at her feet.

Then she'd started to scream.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...I can't...] Mal had said.

Under the water. Under the ground. In the soft deep voice that had been a little boy's voice when Pim first heard it, a whisper on the wind at the Keep, and was bigger now. Much bigger. Since the thorn lady. Since the cousins and the four hundred and the lady with the bronze face. A voice like the sound in a well when you drop a stone and listen.

[...I can't take her...she's held...]

Ivy had been on the rim. Leaning on her crutch. White.

"*Held by what*?" said Ivy.

[...him...] A slow ripple went out across the water. Sad. *[...he's holding her...like a hand round a bird...I can't take what's held...I'm room...room can't take what isn't let go...]*

"*Then he has to let go*," said Ivy.

Silence.

Then, very softly, under the water, as if he were ashamed of it—

[...if he lets go of her...he lets go of all of them...it's one hand...]

◆ ◆ ◆

SO ILDA STOOD IN the doorway.

And her mother stood on the rim.

And neither of them moved.

Sixty-one days.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She made bread*," said Ilda.

Pim waited.

That was another thing about Ilda. If you waited, things came. Slowly. Up out of nine hundred years. Like stones coming up out of a field in the spring frost. One at a time.

"*In the big kitchen*," said Ilda. "*At the palace. The King's palace. Before.*" She frowned. Her gold forehead creased, and it made a tiny sound, like a coin being bent. "*She got up in the dark. Every day. Before everybody. To light the ovens. And I got up with her. Because I was little and I didn't want to be on my own.*"

"*Yes*," said Pim.

"*I sat on the flour sacks*," said Ilda. "*And she made the dough. On the big table. And she sang.*" Her gold eyes were far away. "*She sang very badly. Everybody said. The cook said. The cook said Maudie, you sound like a cat in a well.*"

Pim smiled. He didn't mean to. It just came.

"*Maudie*," he said.

"*That's her name*," said Ilda. She looked down the slope. At the column of grey dust on the rim. Bending. "*Maud. But everybody said Maudie.*" A pause. "*I said Mam.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

DOWN ON THE RIM, the dust stirred.

It didn't drift. It didn't bend more. It just stirred. All through. Like a field of barley when the wind goes through it. Like someone hearing their name called across a crowded room.

Pim watched it.

He'd known the bread-woman's name for nine hundred years' worth of no-time. Nobody had. Not the King. Not the Glass Queen. Not the cousins. Not anybody who'd walked past her on the floor of the empty hall while she came apart in the grey with her daughter in her arms.

Somebody knew it now.

He took the stub of pencil out of his pocket. And the scrap of paper he always kept there. And wrote it down.

Maud. Maudie. Bread. Sang like a cat in a well.

He folded it up. Very small. And put it back in his pocket.

You didn't let a name get lost twice.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CAME OUT AT seven.

Big. Grey-bearded. Rumpled. His right arm in its sling across his chest, gold to the elbow, catching the light. Kell's stick in his left. He stood in the doorway behind Ilda and looked at the morning and breathed.

There was still a catch at the bottom of it. There always would be. The grey-lung had left that much behind when it went. But it was a small catch now. A hitch. Like a step on a stair you know is there.

"*Morning, boy*," said Hask.

"*Morning*," said Pim.

"*Morning*," said Ilda.

Hask stopped breathing.

Just for a second. Then started again. He looked down at the top of Ilda's gold head. For a long time.

"*Well*," said Silas Hask. Very gruffly. "*Morning, then.*"

He went down the step past Pim and stomped off across the grass toward the woodpile, and Pim saw him wipe his face on his good sleeve when he thought nobody was looking.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME IN THE afternoon.

The way they'd been coming for six weeks.

Out of the west. Along the old Duskhold road. Over the rise and down into the green circle. Walking. Slowly. One at a time. Two. Five. Ten.

Gold.

The kept.

Pim stood up on the step and counted them. He couldn't help it.

Fourteen.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY'D STARTED COMING IN March.

The first one had been an old man. Gold. In a steward's coat with a chain on it. He'd walked down the slope in the evening with his gold face blank and his gold mouth humming, the way they all hummed, the one note, *home*, and walked to the rim, and stood there.

And a column of dust had come to meet him.

Out of the crowd of grey on the grass. Drifting. And then not drifting. Stopping. In front of him. Bending.

The old man had stopped humming.

Ivy had cried for an hour.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY'D BEEN WALKING FOR four months. Since the Veil fell. Down the white road and out of the grey and into the world. Nine thousand of them. Humming. *Home*. Walking east. Because home was east. Because nine hundred years ago, before the pool and the drinking and the long grey, home had been here. In the world. In Caldor and Vhessa and the old kingdoms before there were kingdoms. Villages that weren't there any more. Houses that had fallen down and been built over and fallen down again. Graves nobody remembered.

Home wasn't there.

So they kept walking.

And some of them—a few at first, and then more, and then more—had turned. Somewhere out in the world. On a road. In a field. Had stopped humming for a moment. And turned their gold heads. And looked east. Further east. As if they'd heard something.

And come here.

Because their dead were here.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WERE THREE HUNDRED and eight of them now.

Standing round the pool. In the grass. Among the lanterns. On the rim. Gold. Each one with a column of grey dust in front of them. Bending. Waiting.

Three hundred and eight gold people and three hundred and eight grey ones. Facing each other. A foot apart. Not touching. Not moving. In the long green grass, in the evening light, with the lanterns glowing round them.

Like a dance that had stopped.

Like a dance where the music had stopped in the middle and nobody knew how to start it again.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WENT DOWN TO meet the new ones.

He always did. He hadn't meant to. It was just that the first week, when they started coming, nobody else had. Hask didn't know what to say to them. Kit was frightened of them. Ivy couldn't walk that far on the slope without her hip seizing.

So Pim went.

He walked up to the rise in the afternoon light and stood at the top of the road and waited for them to reach him. And when they did, he cupped his hands.

Not to make them cry. Not to make them walk. Just to make a little room. A little quiet. Right in front of each gold face. So that for a second, a heartbeat, the hum would stop. And they'd see him.

And he'd say: "*What's your name*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

MOST OF THEM DIDN'T know.

That was all right.

He'd wait. A bit. And if nothing came, he'd say, "*That's all right. Come on.*" And walk them down. To the rim. To the lanterns. And stand with them while they looked at the dust.

And sometimes—not always, but sometimes—one of the grey columns would stir. And drift. Out of the crowd on the grass. And come. And stop in front of them. And bend.

And the gold face would change.

Not much. You had to be looking. But Pim was always looking.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FOURTEEN TODAY WERE mostly from the palace.

He could tell. They had the look. Livery. Aprons. A footman's buttons. A gardener's leather knee-pads. Two laundry maids, holding hands, gold fingers fused together where they'd been holding hands for nine hundred years.

And a boy.

Small. Six, maybe. Gold. In a shirt too big for him and no shoes. He walked at the back of the fourteen with his gold eyes blank and his mouth humming and his hand out, a little, in front of him, the way you'd hold your hand out to somebody walking beside you.

There wasn't anybody walking beside him.

Pim cupped his hands in front of the boy's face.

Quiet. Soft. Dark. A little room. And the hum stopped.

The gold eyes found him.

"*What's your name*?" said Pim.

The boy looked at him. For a long time.

"*Jory*," said the boy.

Pim took the pencil out. Wrote it down.

"*Hello, Jory*," he said. "*Come on.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED THE BOY down to the rim.

Slowly. Through the grass. Through the three hundred and eight. Past the gold steward and his grey wife. Past the two laundry maids, who'd stopped at the edge and stood looking at two columns of dust that had come drifting to meet them side by side. Past a gold soldier on one knee in front of a small grey column no taller than his shoulder.

Down to the rim.

Jory stood there. With his hand out in front of him. Humming, a little. Looking at the dust.

Nothing came.

Pim waited.

A long time. The sun went down a bit further. The lanterns got brighter. Up at the house, Hask lit the HOME lantern in the window, and Kit came out with a bucket.

Nothing came.

"*That's all right*," said Pim.

He sat down on the grass next to the boy. With his knees drawn up.

And waited some more.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME AT DUSK.

Not out of the crowd on the grass. Out of the west. Down out of the sky. One of the late ones. A thin grey wisp of dust, drifting over the rise and down the slope, the way they all came, the way they'd been coming for four months.

It drifted over the lanterns.

And stopped.

In the air. Over the pool.

And turned.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM DIDN'T BREATHE.

The wisp came down. Slowly. Out of the air. Onto the grass. In front of the boy. And stood there. Thin. Small. Not much taller than Jory. Not much more than a smudge on the evening.

It bent.

Jory's hand was still out in front of him. Gold. The way you'd hold your hand out to somebody walking beside you.

The dust bent over the hand. Over the gold fingers.

And stayed there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Brother*," said Jory.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WROTE IT DOWN.

His hand was shaking. The pencil skidded. He wrote it anyway.

Jory. And his brother. Holding hands.

Then he put the paper in his pocket and put his face in his knees and stayed there for a while. In the grass. With the lanterns glowing round him

and a gold boy and a little grey column of dust a foot away, bending, holding a hand that couldn't hold back.

He'd had a brother.

Not by blood. He'd never had anybody by blood. He'd been left on a step in Wickhollow in a basket with nothing in it but him, and he'd been nobody's for twelve years, and then a man with a flute had come out of the snow at the Keep and looked at him. Really looked. And said *you can stay if you like*.

He knew what it was. To walk with your hand out. For somebody who wasn't there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're crying*," said Ilda.

Pim looked up.

It was dark now. The lanterns glowed. And Ilda was standing beside him on the grass.

She'd come down. On her own. Out of the doorway. Down the slope. Thirty yards. Without his hands. Without the room.

She was looking at him. With her gold eyes.

"*You're crying*," said Ilda again. Wonderingly. As if it were a thing she'd heard of but never seen. "*Why?*"

Pim wiped his face on his sleeve.

"*Because it's sad*," he said.

Ilda thought about that.

"*Is it*?" she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAT DOWN NEXT to him.

It took her a long time. Gold doesn't bend easily. Her knees made the bent-coin sound, both of them, and her hips, and her back. But she did it. She sat down on the grass beside him with her gold knees drawn up, the way his were. Copying.

They sat there together. In the dark. A boy and a gold girl. With the dead all round them and the pool shining.

"*I don't feel sad*," said Ilda after a while. "*I don't feel anything. I haven't felt anything for a long time.*" She looked at her gold hands on her gold knees. "*I think I'm supposed to.*"

"*Yes*," said Pim.

"*Mam would know*," said Ilda.

She looked down the rim. Twenty yards. To where the column of grey dust stood among the lanterns. Bending toward her. The way it always bent.

"*She always knew what I was supposed to feel*," said Ilda. "*When I burned my hand. When the cook shouted. When the King gave me a sweet.*" Her gold voice was very small. "*She'd say, Ilda, you're cross, or Ilda, you're tired, or Ilda, that's sad, love, it's all right to be sad. And then I'd know.*"

Pim didn't say anything.

"*I want to ask her*," said Ilda. "*What this is. All of it.*" She looked at the dust. "*But I can't get to her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY MADE BREAD THE next day.

It was Ivy's idea. Ivy had a lot of ideas, most of them involving her crutch and the back of somebody's knees, but some of them were good ones.

"*She keeps saying bread*," said Ivy. At breakfast. At the long table in the Coldwater house. With her porridge going cold. "*Bread bread bread. Every day. She remembers her mam making bread.*" She jabbed her spoon at Pim. "*So let's make bread.*"

"*Bread won't rise*," said Kit. Through a mouthful. "*The letters say. Out west. Since the grey came. Nobody's had a loaf rise since Midwinter.*"

"*Out west*," said Ivy. "*This isn't west. This is here.*" She banged the table. "*This is the realest bit of ground in the world. Mal's under it. The smith said. Mal makes room. Room for a baby, a bud, a loaf. He said.*" She glared at Kit. "*It'll rise.*"

It did.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM HAD NEVER MADE bread.

Neither had Kit, or Hask, or Ivy, it turned out, though Ivy claimed she had and was proved a liar inside ten minutes when she put a whole cup of salt in.

They started again.

Hask had flour. A sack. From the carter who came out from Fenmoor every fortnight. And there was yeast, of a kind, in a jar at the back of the shelf that one of the Coldwater crew's wives had left behind, which smelled like feet. And water from the spring. And a table.

And Ilda.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD AT THE end of the long table and looked at it.

At the flour in its heap. At the well in the middle. At the water in the jug and the yeast in its cup going frothy and grey.

Pim had brought her in. Not with his hands. Just with words. *We're making bread. Do you want to come?* And she'd looked at him for a long time, and then she'd turned round in the doorway, out of the evening light, into the house, for the first time in sixty-two days.

She stood at the table.

"*That's wrong*," said Ilda.

Everybody stopped.

"*The water*," said Ilda. "*It's too cold. You'll kill it.*" She pointed a gold finger at the yeast. "*It has to be warm. Like a bath. Like your hand. Mam put her elbow in. To tell.*"

Hask, who'd poured the water from the spring, looked at the jug.

Then he took it, without a word, and put it by the fire.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TALKED THEM THROUGH it.

All of it. Slowly. In her small rusty voice. Up out of nine hundred years. One thing at a time. Like stones coming up in a field.

Warm the water. Feed the yeast. A bit of honey. Wait till it's frothy. Make a well. Pour it in. Not all at once. Mix with your fingers. Like this. No, like *this*.

She couldn't do it herself. She tried. She put her gold hand into the flour, and the flour went gold where she touched it. A gold handprint. A

little heap of gold dust in the heap of white. She took her hand out and looked at it. And at the gold in the flour.

Nobody said anything.

"*You do it*," said Ilda to Pim. Quietly. "*I'll tell you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SO PIM MADE BREAD.

With Ilda at his elbow. Telling him. *More flour. Less. Push it away with the heel of your hand. Fold it back. Turn it. Push. Fold. Turn. No, don't tear it, you're tearing it, Mam would hit you with the spoon.*

His arms ached. His back ached. The dough stuck to his fingers and the table and his sleeve and somehow his ear. Kit laughed at him. Ivy laughed at Kit. Hask sat by the fire with his gold arm in his lap and watched and didn't laugh but his beard moved.

And Ilda talked.

Not just about bread. Other things came up with it. In the folding and the turning. The big kitchen. The great black ovens that were taller than a man. The cook, who was called Agnes and had a moustache. The pot-boy, Tam, who could whistle through his fingers. The cat that lived under the flour bins and was called Duchess and had kittens every spring in the King's best linen cupboard and was never once caught.

"*Mam fed her*," said Ilda. "*Duchess. Scraps. Under the table. The cook didn't know.*" A gold smile. Small. Cracking. "*The cook knew.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LEFT IT TO rise.

In a bowl. By the fire. Under a damp cloth. Ilda made them put a cloth over it. *It doesn't like to be looked at. Mam said. Bread's shy.*

And they sat round the table, the five of them, and waited.

An hour.

Nobody looked.

Then Ivy couldn't stand it. She leaned over on her crutch and lifted the corner of the cloth.

And went very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD RISEN.

It had come up over the edge of the bowl. Pale and round and soft and smooth, like a sleeping cat. Like a cloud. Pressing up against the cloth. Alive.

Ilda looked at it.

For a long time. Without moving. With her gold hands at her sides.

Then she put out one gold finger and pressed it, very gently, into the side of the dough. The way you'd test a cheek for fever.

The dough sighed. A little. And slowly—very slowly—the dent came back. Filled in. Smoothed over.

Where her finger had been, there was a tiny gold fleck. Like a star.

"*It's ready*," said Ilda.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY BAKED IT.

It came out of Hask's oven an hour later, brown and cracked and lopsided, with a gold fleck on its side like a star. It was the worst loaf any of them had ever seen. It was the best thing any of them had ever smelled.

The smell went everywhere.

Out of the house. Out through the door. Down the slope. Over the grass. Through the lanterns. Round the pool.

Bread. Hot bread. On a spring evening. In a green field.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM FELT IT BEFORE he saw it.

A stir. All round the pool. All through the dead.

He went to the door.

Three hundred and something columns of grey dust, standing on the grass among the lanterns, facing three hundred and something gold people—and all of them, every one, had turned. Toward the house. Toward the smell.

Bending.

The way you turn when someone opens an oven door in another room. The way you turn when you smell your mother's kitchen in a strange street.

And at the rim—

At the rim, the bread-woman's dust wasn't bending any more.

It was moving.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME UP THE slope.

Slowly. Drifting. Out of the lanterns. Through the long grass. Thirty yards. Toward the house. Toward the door. Toward the smell of bread. It hadn't left the rim in sixty-two days, and it came up the slope now like a woman who's heard the oven door and knows by the sound that somebody's opened it too soon.

It came to the step.

Pim moved out of the way.

It came to the door.

And stopped. On the threshold. Under the HOME lantern. Swaying. Grey. Looking in.

At the long table. At the loaf on it, brown and cracked and lopsided, with a gold star on its side.

At the gold girl standing beside it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mam*," said Ilda.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST CAME IN.

It came across the floor. Through the warm room. Past the fire. Past Hask, who'd stood up and was holding the back of his chair with his good hand. Past Kit. Past Ivy.

It came to the table.

It stood over the loaf. And bent. And Pim felt it—they all felt it—the way you feel a smile in the dark. Rueful. Fond. *Oh, love. Look at that. You've let it go lopsided.*

Then it turned to Ilda.

And bent over her. All of it. All the way down. The way a woman bends over a cot. Round her. Close. Grey dust all round a small gold girl, not touching, not able to touch, a quarter of an inch away. Like arms. Like arms that couldn't close.

Ilda stood very still in the middle of it.

"*Mam*," she said. "*Mam, I made bread. I told them. I remembered. I told them about the water and the elbow and the cloth.*"

The dust swayed.

"*I can't feel anything*," said Ilda. Her gold voice cracked. Right down the middle. "*Mam, I can't feel anything. What am I supposed to feel? Tell me what I'm supposed to feel.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST BENT CLOSER.

And Pim heard it.

Not with his ears. Not words. He'd never heard the dead speak in words. Antho had. Antho said they said their names. Pim had only ever felt them. The way you feel weather.

But he heard this.

Because it was in the room. Because the room was small and warm and full of the smell of bread. Because it came from nine hundred years down, from a floor in an empty hall, from a woman coming apart in the grey with her daughter in her arms, who had held on to one thing all that time—

Not to her own name. She'd let that go. Not to her face. Not to her hands.

One thing.

Ilda, love. You're happy. That's happy. It's all right to be happy.

◆ ◆ ◆

ILDA'S GOLD FACE CRUMPLED.

All of it. At once. Like foil. With a sound like a hundred coins bending.

And she cried.

Not the way she'd cried on the white road, for the first time in nine hundred years, out of shock, out of a little room in front of her face. Not the way she'd screamed on the surface of the pool, when the water wouldn't take her.

She cried the way an eight-year-old girl cries when her mother's come home late and she's been waiting up. Big gulping sobs. Hiccups. Her gold hands over her gold face. Gold tears—real ones, wet, gold as honey—running down between her gold fingers and dripping on the table and the floor and the loaf.

And the dust held her.

As near as it could.

A quarter of an inch away.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

Hask stood holding the back of his chair, with his beard working and his eyes shut. Kit stood by the hearth with his hands over his mouth. Ivy had sat down on the floor, crutch and all, and was crying so hard she'd got the hiccups too.

Pim stood in the doorway.

He didn't count anything. There wasn't anything to count.

He just stood there and watched a mother and a daughter in a warm room with a lopsided loaf, a quarter of an inch apart, and felt something in his chest that had been shut since before he could remember come open a little bit further.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST DIDN'T GO back to the rim.

It stayed. In the Coldwater house. That night and the next and the next. By the hearth. By the table. By Ilda. Wherever Ilda was.

Ilda didn't stand in the doorway any more.

She sat by the fire. With the dust beside her. And talked. To it. To Pim. To anybody. Things came up. Faster now. The kitchen. The palace. The garden, where there'd been a fountain with fish in it, orange ones, and she'd been told never to put her hand in and always did. The day the King's brother came to supper and spilled wine on the Queen-to-be and everybody pretended not to see. The pool. The night of the pool. Everybody going quiet. Mam holding her hand. The light.

And after.

"*It was grey*," said Ilda. "*After. Everything. And Mam got thinner. And thinner. Not thin like hungry. Thin like a drawing. Like somebody rubbing you out.*" She looked at the dust. "*And she held me. On the floor. In the hall. For days. And I could feel her going. In her arms. Like sand.*"

The dust swayed.

"*And then he came*," said Ilda. "*The King. Walking. Down the hall. He was crying. He was crying all the time then. He looked at everybody. And everybody he looked at went—*" She held up a gold hand. "*He looked at me. And I went. And Mam didn't.*"

Silence.

"*He kept me*," said Ilda. "*Because he couldn't stand it. He told me. On the road. Once. Before the grey got in his mouth. He said, I couldn't stand to watch you go, little one. I'm sorry. I couldn't stand it.*"

Pim wrote it down.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...he's practising...]

Mal said it. On the fourth night. Under the water.

Ivy was on the rim. With her lantern. Saying goodnight. *Night, Mal. Sleep well.* And the pool had rippled. Slow. Thoughtful. And said it.

[...he's practising...]

Ivy went still.

"*Who is*?" she said.

[...the big gold one...] A long ripple. Out from the middle. Through the three lights. To the rim. *[...he's been to the forge...he's been to see the old man...the one with the gold fingers...]* A pause. *[...he came out holding something white...]*

"*And*?" said Ivy.

[...and now he's practising...] The water went very still. *[...letting go...a little...every night...and then holding on again...I can feel it...through all of them...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM FELT IT HIMSELF, the next night.

He was in his bunk. In the dark. Not asleep. Listening to Hask breathe and Kit snore and Ivy mutter to herself and the fire tick in the hearth.

And then—

Everything shifted.

Not the house. Not the ground. Something under that. Something that ran through all of them. Through every gold person on the grass round the pool. Through the gold fingers of the laundry maids and the gold knee of

the soldier and the gold hand of the boy Jory held out to his brother. Through Hask's arm, in the bunk across the room. Through Ilda, on her pallet by the fire, with the dust beside her.

A loosening.

Like a fist opening. A little. One finger.

◆ ◆ ◆

ILDA CRIED OUT.

Pim was out of his bunk before he knew it. Across the room. On his knees by her pallet.

She was sitting up. With her gold hand held out in front of her. Shaking.

"*It's cold*," she said. "*Pim, it's cold, it's—*"

Her little finger.

The smallest one. On her left hand. It had gone pink.

Not gold. Pink. Skin. A child's skin. With a nail on the end of it, small and dirty, and a crease at the knuckle, and the very faint white line of an old burn across the pad where she'd touched a spit-iron nine hundred and twelve years ago and cried and been given a sweet.

It was shaking. It was cold. It was alive.

And all round it, at the edge, where the pink met the gold—

The gold was coming apart.

Not peeling. Not flaking. Fraying. At the edges. Like old cloth. Like the dust on the grass. Like a drawing being rubbed out. Grey. Fine. Drifting.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Pim*," said Ilda. Very high. Very frightened. "*Pim, I'm going. Like Mam. I'm going like sand.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

OUTSIDE, ACROSS THE GRASS, all round the pool, in the dark among the lanterns—

Pim heard it.

The hum.

Three hundred and something gold people. Who had stopped humming, one by one, as their dead came to meet them. Who had stood in the long grass for weeks, facing their dust, quiet.

All humming again. At once. The one note. Rising. Shrill. Frightened.

Home. Home. Home.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN IT STOPPED.

All at once.

The loosening. The fist closed again. The finger. Pim felt it go—a tightening, everywhere, all through the gold, like a hand gripping a rope it's nearly dropped.

Ilda's little finger went gold again.

Just like that. Pink, and then gold. Smooth and bright and cold. The fraying at the edges stopped. The grey dust that had drifted up off it settled on the blanket. A pinch. Less than a pinch.

Outside, the hum faded.

Ilda sat on her pallet with her gold hand held out in front of her and stared at it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's sorry*," said Ilda.

Pim looked at her.

"*I felt it*," said Ilda. Shakily. "*When he let go. Just the finger. I felt him. He's somewhere a long way off and he's sitting in the dark holding a petal and he's sorry.*" She swallowed. "*He tried to let go of just me. Just a little. And it wasn't just me.*"

Hask was sitting up in his bunk. Holding his gold arm against his chest with his good hand. Grey-faced. Breathing hard.

"*Felt it*," said Hask. "*In the arm. Went cold. Right to the shoulder.*" He looked at Pim across the dark room. "*That's all of us, then. That's all nine thousand. All at once. If he does it.*"

"*Yes*," said Pim.

"*And the old ones*," said Hask. "*The ones that were all-over gold. Nine hundred years.*" He looked at the fire. At the dust beside it. At Ilda. "*They'll go like that. Like sand. Won't they.*"

Ilda didn't say anything.

The dust bent over her.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM DIDN'T SLEEP.

He sat on the step outside the door, under the HOME lantern, in the dark, with his knees drawn up, and looked down at the pool.

At the lanterns. Five hundred and fifty-six. At the three lights in the water. At three hundred and some gold people standing in the grass, quiet again, and three hundred and some grey ones in front of them, bending. At the dance where the music had stopped.

He thought about the King.

Sitting in the dark somewhere a long way off. Holding a petal. Practising.

Letting go of one finger. And feeling nine thousand people start to come apart. And grabbing hold again. Because he couldn't stand it. Because he'd never been able to stand it. Because the first time, nine hundred years ago, in an empty hall, he'd looked at a little girl coming apart in her mother's arms and he'd held on, and he'd been holding on ever since.

He'd have to let go all at once.

Pim knew it. Sitting on the step. The way he knew things sometimes. Not in words. You couldn't do it a finger at a time. You couldn't do it gently. It wasn't that kind of hold.

When the King let go, he'd have to let go of everything. Everyone. At once.

And nine thousand people would come apart. All at once. All over the world. On roads and in fields and in the long grass round a pool. Frightened. Cold. Going like sand.

And there'd be nobody holding their hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM SAT ON THE step until the sky went pale in the east.

Then he took his pencil out of his pocket. And his scraps of paper. All of them. Sixty-five days of them. Folded very small.

Maud. Maudie. Bread. Sang like a cat in a well.

Jory. And his brother. Holding hands.

Ellen and Bet, laundry, Ellen's mam and Bet's gran.

Corporal Fitch. His girl. She was four.

Old Hobb the steward. His wife Joan. Fifty years.

Three hundred and eight names. More. Some of them just *don't know*. Some of them just *a man in a red coat*. But all of them written down. All of them somebody.

He found a clean scrap. And wrote on it. Slowly. In his small careful hand. The longest note of his life.

◆ ◆ ◆

To Lex. At the forge.

The King is practising. Letting go. We felt it. It hurts them. It frightens them. They go like sand.

He has to do it all at once. He can't do it a bit at a time. Tell him.

When he does it, they shouldn't be on their own. Nobody should come apart on their own. Not again.

We'll hold their hands. Here. At the pool. As many as we can get. Ivy and Hask and Kit and me. And Ilda. And all the dead. Tell him to send them here. Tell him to send them all.

Tell him we're ready.

Tell him not to be sorry. Tell him it's all right to let go.

P.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FOLDED IT.

Then he unfolded it again, and looked at it for a long time. And added one more line. At the bottom. Very small.

Tell him her name was Maudie.

Then he tied it to the leg of Antho's raven, who'd been sitting on the Coldwater chimney for three days eating Hask's bacon rind and waiting to be useful, and threw her up into the pink morning sky.

And watched her go.

West.

Toward the forge. Toward the King. Toward the door.

Toward the grey, coming east to meet her.

CHAPTER 25

The Grey at Harrow

THE BIRDS STOPPED ON a Tuesday.

Seren noticed because she was listening for them. She'd been listening for them for a week. Every morning, at the west window, with the kettle on and the pot warming and the horn lantern on the sill burning on nothing. She'd stand there and open the shutter and listen to the birch wood.

Blackbird. Wren. The chiffchaff that said its own name over and over, as if it were afraid of forgetting it. The wood-pigeon, who never finished a sentence. A thrush, somewhere up the slope, practising.

On the Monday, the thrush was gone.

On the Tuesday, they were all gone.

She stood at the window with the shutter open and the kettle starting to sing behind her and listened to the birch wood, and the birch wood was silent. Not quiet. Quiet was a thing with edges. Quiet had a wind in it, and a stream, and leaves. This was silent the way a painting is silent.

The kettle screamed.

Seren didn't move.

"*Are you going to get that*?" said Rhosyn. From the cot. Muffled. Under the blanket. "*Or are we just letting it die*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's at the top of the wood*," said Seren.

She made the tea anyway. Warmed the pot. One spoon each and one for the pot. Water just off the boil. Her hands did it without her. They'd been doing it for thirty years, and thirteen of those in the dark, with

nothing to do it with, and they weren't going to stop now just because the world was ending.

Rhosyn sat up. Slowly. Her knees cracked. Her back cracked. Her neck. She made a face at all of it.

"*How far*?" she said.

"*Half a mile*," said Seren. "*Maybe less. Elowen's stakes.*" She put a cup down in front of her. "*The top one went last night. I saw it from the window. Before dark. A white stake with a red rag on it. And then just a white stake.*"

Rhosyn looked at the tea.

"*How long*?" she said.

"*Today*," said Seren. "*Tomorrow, maybe. If it's slow.*"

She sat down in her chair by the window. With her own cup. Under the lantern. And looked out at the birch wood. White trunks. Black marks. Green leaves, new, the bright soft green of June.

She looked at them very hard. As if she could keep them by looking.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELOWEN CAME AT NINE.

Up the lane from Ashbourne on her big grey mare, in her mail, with her oath-sword on her back and her face set like a closed door. She tied the mare at the gate and came up the path and stopped at the foot of the ramp and looked up at Seren in the doorway.

"*Lady Seren*," said Elowen.

"*Don't*," said Seren.

"*It's in the wood*."

"*I know*."

"*It'll be at the stream by tonight*."

"*I know*."

Elowen took a breath. She was a tall woman, Elowen. Fair. Grave. With a scar through one eyebrow and a way of standing as if somebody had once told her the whole world was leaning on her and she'd believed them. She'd been a knight for twenty years. She'd held a ford against a winged man with a pick. She looked at Seren in the doorway of a small blue-door cottage, with a teacup in her hand, and looked frightened.

"*Lex sent me*," said Elowen. "*He asked. He said, please. He said to say please twice.*" She swallowed. "*Please. Please. Come to the Forge.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HAD KNOWN HE would.

She'd known since the spring. Since Seraphine's figures. *Two miles a day. Some days three.* She'd done the sum herself, on the back of a page of the grey book, in pencil. Two hundred miles from the old edge to Harrow. Harrow first. Then the Vale. Then Ashbourne.

Harrow first.

"*Tell him thank you*," said Seren. "*Tell him I love him. Tell him no.*"

Elowen closed her eyes.

"*He thought you'd say that*," she said.

"*He's a clever boy*."

"*He said, if she says no, tell her the lantern might not be enough. He said, it's one lantern. It's a small one. It's horn, not glass. He made it in an afternoon.*" Elowen opened her eyes. "*He said, I don't know how big the circle will be. I don't know if it'll hold the house.*"

Seren looked past her. At the lane. At the gate. At the stream at the bottom of the garden, running loud and brown and quick over the stepping stones. At the far bank. At the other cottage. Her son's. The one he'd rebuilt with his own hands the year he came home, on the black scorch-mark of the one that had burned. With its empty east window. With the swing he'd hung from the apple bough for Lark, swaying a little in the wind.

At the stone by the stream. Under the roses.

"*Tell him*," said Seren. Quietly. "*Somebody has to keep the window.*"

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ELOWEN DIDN'T GO.

She sat on the bench by the door and took her sword off her back and laid it across her knees and didn't go. Seren brought her tea. She drank it. She didn't say anything.

Rhosyn came out. In Seren's old blue dress, which was too short for her, and a shawl, and bare feet, because she'd been barefoot for nine

hundred years and shoes still felt to her like being held by the ankles. She looked at Elowen. At the sword. At the birch wood.

"*Are you staying*?" said Rhosyn.

"*Yes*," said Elowen.

"*Why*?"

Elowen looked at her. At the thorn-woman. At the Crowned. At the woman who'd grown a wall of brambles round the tenth tower, a mile thick, and made it into a lock, and kept a small grey hollow of a boy in it for nine hundred years.

"*Because she's staying*," said Elowen. "*And I owe her. And I'm not leaving a woman alone in a house with a—*" She stopped.

"*With a monster*," said Rhosyn.

"*With the grey coming*," said Elowen.

Rhosyn smiled. A tired small smile. And sat down on the step.

"*That's kind*," she said. "*You're wrong. But it's kind.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WATCHED IT COME.

The three of them. On the bench and the step. All morning. Looking up the slope at the birch wood.

You couldn't see it come. That was the thing. Seren had thought you'd see it. Like weather. Like a storm coming up a valley, a dark wall, a line. You'd see it coming and you'd have time to be afraid.

You didn't.

You just looked at a tree. A birch. A white trunk, a black mark, green leaves. And you looked away. At the sky, at a cloud, at your teacup. And you looked back.

And it was the same tree. Same trunk. Same mark. Same leaves.

But you couldn't remember what colour the leaves were.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There*," said Rhosyn.

Very quietly. At noon. Pointing.

Seren looked.

At the top of the garden. Where the birch wood came down to the hedge. Where the hedge had a gap in it that Lark went through on her

hands and knees, every time, no matter how many times she was told, to look for the hedgehog that lived under the woodpile.

The hedge.

It was there. All of it. Hawthorn. Elder. A bramble. A dog-rose, pink, open.

It wasn't green any more.

It wasn't grey either. Not exactly. It was just—not. As if someone had painted it very carefully, every leaf, every thorn, and forgotten the paint. As if it were a drawing of a hedge on a page, and the page was the colour of nothing.

The dog-rose was still open. Seren could see every petal.

She couldn't have told you they were pink.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME DOWN THE garden.

Slowly. You could see it now, a little. If you didn't look straight at it. Out of the side of your eye. A line in the grass. Not a line of anything. Just the place where the grass on one side was grass and the grass on the other side was a picture of grass.

It came past the woodpile.

The hedgehog's woodpile. Under it, somewhere, a hedgehog. Asleep in the day the way hedgehogs are. Seren thought about it. A small warm thing, curled up, with its nose in its belly. And the grey going over it. And it not waking up. And it not being dead. And it never, ever waking up.

She found she'd stood up.

"*Seren*," said Rhosyn.

She didn't sit down.

It came past the cabbages. Past the beans on their poles. Past the stone trough where Lark sailed walnut shells. The water in the trough went flat. Not still. Flat. Like a pane of slate. The walnut shell on it stopped. Mid-turn.

It came down the path.

Toward the ramp. Toward the door. Toward the cottage, small and blue-doored and whitewashed, with smoke going up from the chimney and

a horn lantern on the west windowsill burning on nothing, with *TOO LATE* cut into its base.

Seren stood on the ramp and watched it come.

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IT STOPPED.

Two yards from the bottom of the ramp. In the middle of the path. Between one flagstone and the next.

It didn't hit anything. There was no sound. No flare. No light. It didn't push against anything and get pushed back. It just—didn't come any further. As if the next flagstone weren't there. As if it had come to the edge of the map.

It went round.

Seren watched it go round. Left and right. Along the side of the house. Past the water-butt on one side. Past the bench where Elowen sat with her sword across her knees, white-faced. Not touching the bench. Not touching the butt. Two yards off. Round. In a curve.

Like water round a stone.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT INSIDE.

To the west window. To the sill. To the lantern.

It was very small. Smaller than she remembered, somehow. She'd looked at it every morning for a year and a half and never really seen it. Horn panes, scraped thin, yellow-brown. A tin frame, soldered, with one hinge that had always stuck until Lex fixed it in the winter. A little handle. And round the base, cut into the tin with the point of a nail, in her son's square careful hand—

TOO LATE.

It was burning. It was always burning. It had been burning since the night he'd given it to her, the first night she came back to Harrow, and she'd never once filled it. Never once trimmed it. It burned on nothing, the way all his lanterns did. A small gold flame. Steady. Soft.

She looked out of the window past it.

The grey had gone round the house. She could see it. Out on the slope, to the west, it had gone round and was coming on, past the cottage, down toward the stream. And here, close, in a ring round the house—

Green.

The grass by the wall. The thyme in the cracks of the path. The ivy on the water-butt. The rosemary bush by the door that Arion had planted the first summer, crooked, and that she'd never pulled up because he'd planted it.

Green. Real green. In a ring. Round the house. Round her.

Two yards wide.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN SAT DOWN IN her chair.

She didn't mean to. Her legs did it. She sat down in her chair by the west window, under the horn lantern, with the sun coming in on the sill, and put her hands over her face.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's holding*," said Rhosyn.

In the doorway. Behind her. Quiet.

"*Yes*," said Seren. Into her hands.

"*Then why are you crying*?"

"*Because it's two yards*," said Seren.

She took her hands away from her face. And looked out of the window. At the slope going down to the stream. At the stream. At the far bank.

The grey was nearly at the stream.

"*Two yards*," said Seren. "*That's the house. That's the house and the path and the water-butt and Arion's rosemary.*" Her voice broke. "*That's not the stream. That's not the stones. That's not—*"

She stopped.

Rhosyn came and stood beside her chair. And looked where she was looking.

Down the slope. At the bottom of the garden. At the bank of the stream. At a grey stone among the long grass, with roses climbing over it. Red roses. Dark red. Nearly black at the heart. Two dozen. Open. As if it were midsummer.

ARION VEY.

He turned back twice.

The grey was twenty yards from it.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WAS OUT OF the door before Rhosyn could stop her.

Down the ramp. Off the path. Off the green. Two yards. And—

She didn't feel it. That was the worst thing. She'd braced for cold. For a wall. For something. She stepped off the green onto the grass beyond it, and there was nothing. It was grass. It was just grass.

It just wasn't any colour.

She looked down at her feet. At her own feet, in her old brown boots, on the grass. And her boots were—she couldn't have said. She knew they were brown. She'd bought them in Highcrest. She'd worn them for six years. They were brown.

She couldn't see brown.

She ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D NEVER BEEN A runner. Not as a girl, not as a woman. Wenna used to say she ran like a hen in a gale. Thirteen years in the dark hadn't helped, and a year and a half at an old man's bedside hadn't helped, and she was fifty-one and her knees had opinions.

She ran anyway. Down the slope. Through grass that made no sound. Under a sky that was the colour of a page. Toward the stream.

The stream was loud. She could hear it. Brown and quick over the stepping stones, the way it had run every day of her life at Harrow, every day of Lex's life, every day of Antho's. She ran toward the sound of it like someone running toward a voice.

She could see the grey coming down the far side of the garden. On her left. Slow. Out of the side of her eye. A line in the grass. Twenty yards from the stone. Fifteen.

She got to the stone first.

She fell on her knees in front of it. In the long grass. And put her hands on it. On the grey granite. On the letters. On the roses, the thorns, she didn't care, they went into her palms and she didn't care.

And the grey came on.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T HAVE A lantern.

She knew that. Kneeling there. With her hands on the stone and the thorns in her palms. She'd run out of the green with nothing. No light. No lamp. No Harrow lamp to give. She was Seren Harrow, the Lady of the Lamp, who'd held a clay lamp in the dark for thirteen years and given it away at the end, and she'd run out of the house without one.

She didn't have anything.

She knelt there with her hands on her husband's grave and watched the grey come down the bank toward her, ten yards, eight, like a tide coming in over sand. Slow. Patient. Not cruel. Not anything. Just *still*.

And she thought: *too late*.

Of course. Too late. Always too late. She'd come out of the dark too late to know him. She'd remembered too late to say it. She'd read the grey book every morning, every single morning, and stood at the window and thought, too late, too late, too late. And now she was going to kneel here and go still and never get up, a woman in a painting, holding a stone, and the roses would be the colour of nothing, and it would be too late for that as well.

Five yards.

She closed her eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

Morning, love.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE OPENED THEM.

It wasn't a voice. Not really. It was the stream. Loud and brown and quick. Running over the stepping stones. The way it ran every morning. The way it had run on the first morning he'd come back from the dark, an old man in a chair at the window, and opened the shutter and listened to it and said—

Good morning, Seren.

And she'd said good morning back. Because it was polite. Because that was what you said.

Every morning. For a year and a half.

She'd never once thought of it as too late. Not then. Not while he was alive. She'd only thought it after. Every morning. At the window. With the grey book.

He didn't need me to know him, she'd said to Rosie. In the spring. *He needed me to have a good morning.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY STOPPED.

Two yards from the stone. In the grass. Between one blade and the next.

It went round.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN KNELT THERE WITH her hands on the stone and stared.

At the grey going round. Left and right. Along the bank. Curving. A ring. Round the stone. Round her. Round the roses, which were red. Dark red. Nearly black at the heart. She could see it. She could see red.

She looked down at her own hands.

There was blood on them. From the thorns. Bright red blood on her square freckled palms. And light.

Faint. Gold. Coming up out of her palms. Out of the cuts. Out of her. Soft. Steady. Like a lamp behind a horn pane.

She didn't have a lantern.

She'd never needed one. She'd been carrying it for thirty years.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Well*," said Rhosyn.

On the bank. Above her. Out of breath. With Elowen beside her, sword drawn, both of them standing on the grass beyond the green ring, both of them the colour of nothing. Rhosyn's feet were bare. Rhosyn's blue dress wasn't blue.

"*Well*," said Rhosyn again. Breathing hard. Her knees had opinions too. "*That's one way to do it.*"

Seren looked up at her.

"*Get in*," said Seren. Her voice was shaking. "*Get in the ring. Both of you. Quickly.*"

They got in.

It wasn't a big ring. Two yards. Round the stone. The three of them knelt in it, in the long green grass, by the grave, with the roses over them and the stream loud beside them, and the grey all round. Close. Silent. A picture of a garden. A picture of a world.

Elowen was shaking.

Rhosyn put her arm round her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What did you do*?" said Rhosyn.

"*I don't know*," said Seren.

"*You did something*."

"*I remembered*," said Seren. "*Something he used to say.*" She looked at her palms. At the faint gold light coming up out of them. Already fading. Already going back in. "*I've been remembering it wrong. All this time. I've been remembering it as too late.*"

Rhosyn looked at her for a long time.

"*Hes did that*," said Rhosyn. "*With her hands. In the garden. The night she sat in the door.*" She swallowed. "*I never knew how.*"

"*Neither do I*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT IN THE ring by the grave for an hour.

Then Seren stood up. Slowly. Her knees had opinions. And looked up the slope. At the cottage. At the green ring round it, two yards wide. At the horn lantern in the west window, a speck of gold. At the grey between here and there. Forty yards of it. A picture of a garden.

"*We have to go back*," she said.

Elowen looked at the grey. And swallowed.

"*Will it hold*?" she said. "*Your—that. If you walk.*"

"*I don't know*," said Seren.

She held out her hands. One to each of them.

They took them.

And they walked up the slope together. Three women. Holding hands. Through the grey. And the grey went round them. Not two yards. Less. A foot. Six inches. A thin green ring round three pairs of feet, moving up the slope, leaving nothing behind it. Like a lantern carried through a dark room.

They got to the house.

Seren let go of their hands on the step and sat down on the ramp and was sick in the rosemary.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY REACHED THE stream at three o'clock.

Seren watched it from the window.

It came down the bank on both sides of the grave. Past the ring. Round it. Round the stone and the roses, two yards, green, small, like a coin dropped in the grass. And down to the water.

And into the stream.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D WONDERED ABOUT THAT.

All spring. In the night. Lying awake. What the grey did to water. The letters said the sea at Morrow had stopped. The tide had stopped. Teo had gone down to Gull's Reach and found the waves standing on the shingle like glass. Like ice. Like a painting of waves.

But a stream wasn't the sea. A stream came from somewhere. A stream came down off the hills, from the springs at Long Ridge, from the snow on the Teeth. A stream had somewhere to go. It came from real ground, still. From the east. From upstream.

She'd thought—hoped—that it would keep running.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME DOWN THE bank and into the water.

The water stopped.

Not all of it. Not at once. Just the part the grey touched. On the near side. The far side. It came in from both banks, slowly, like ice forming, like a skin on milk. And the water under it stopped. Mid-ripple. Mid-splash.

The little white curl of water over the first stepping stone. Stopped. Still. Hanging. Like a carving of water.

And the water upstream kept coming.

Brown and quick. From the east. From the hills. From real ground. It came down to where the grey was and—

Didn't stop. Couldn't go on. Rose.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Rhosyn.

She was at the window beside Seren. With her hand on the sill.

"*Oh, no*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STREAM WAS FILLING.

Upstream of the stopped water. Above the stepping stones. Behind the grey. The water was coming down from the hills the way it always had, and meeting the stillness, and not being able to go through it, and backing up.

Spreading.

Out over the banks. Into the long grass. Into the bottom of the garden. A sheet of brown water. Rising. Slow. Filling the hollow between the stone and the far cottage. Pooling.

Real water. Moving water. Live.

Held in by a dam of stillness on one side, and coming in from the hills on the other.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's a pond*," said Elowen. In the doorway. Blankly. "*It's making a pond.*"

"*It's making a mirror*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN LOOKED AT HER.

Rhosyn was white. Whiter than the birches had been. She was holding the sill so hard her knuckles stood out.

"*The grey doesn't reflect*," said Rhosyn. "*Nothing does, out there. Have you noticed? I noticed in the Court. Nine hundred years. I used to kneel by the grey river and look for my face and there wasn't one. The grey drinks the*

light. Glass is just glass." She swallowed. "*Ysy couldn't come into the grey. Not into it. Not out there. There's nothing for her to come through.*"

"*Then—*" said Seren.

"*But that's not grey*," said Rhosyn.

She pointed. Out of the window. Down the slope.

At the water. Spreading. Brown. Live. Real. Rising in the bottom of the garden, in the hollow behind the dam of stillness. Settling. Going quiet. Going smooth. The way a pond goes smooth at evening when the wind drops.

Going flat.

Going bright.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SUN WAS GOING down behind the birch wood. Behind the grey. A picture of a sunset. No colour in it.

But in the pond—

In the pond, the sky was blue.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN STARED AT IT.

At the water in the bottom of her garden. A sheet of it. Forty yards across. Round the grave. Round the two-yard ring of green, which stood up out of the middle of it now like a little island with a stone and some roses on it. Up to the edge of the stillness, where the stepping stones stood in their carved water.

Smooth. Bright. Real.

And in it, upside down, perfect, every leaf—the cottage. The blue door. The ramp. The green ring round it. The horn lantern in the west window, a speck of gold.

The only colour for a mile in any direction.

Reflected.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How far does it go*?" said Rhosyn. Very quietly. "*The stream. Upstream. Where does it come from?*"

"*Long Ridge*," said Seren. "*The springs. Then the Teeth.*"

"*Through Ashbourne*?"

Seren's hands were cold.

"*Past the Forge*," she said. "*It turns the mill. It runs under the bridge on the green. It goes past the Forge yard. Brannoc takes his quench-water from it. Lex—*" She stopped. "*Lex washed Lark's feet in it. On Sunday. In the yard. She likes to splash.*"

Rhosyn didn't say anything.

She didn't need to.

Real water. Live water. From the east, from the hills, from real ground, running down through the Vale, through Ashbourne, past the Forge, under the bridge, into the bottom of a garden at Harrow, and meeting the grey, and stopping, and going smooth.

One long thread of it. From the Forge to here. A road. A glass road. With a mirror at the end of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT WENT.

The sun went down behind the grey birch wood. The sky went from a picture of evening to a picture of night. No stars. Grey country doesn't have stars. Just a flat dark like the inside of a closed book.

The pond went dark.

Except for one gold speck. Reflected. From the window.

Seren stood at the window with the lantern beside her on the sill and looked down at the gold speck in the black water. At her own lantern. Upside down. Very small.

She thought about Lex. Three miles away. At the Forge. With the door hung and unfinished and the King in the yard and the whole of Ashbourne coming to give lanterns. With Wren. With Lark.

With the stream running past the yard.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*We have to tell him*," said Elowen.

"*Yes*," said Seren.

"*I'll ride*." Elowen was already reaching for her sword. "*Tonight. Now. Through the grey. If I'm fast—*"

"*You won't be*," said Rhosyn. "*Nothing's fast in the grey. You'll walk your horse into it and it'll stop and you'll stop and they'll find you in a hundred years, a knight on a horse in the middle of a field, like a statue in a park.*"

Elowen stopped.

"*Then how*?" she said.

Seren looked at the lantern.

Then she picked it up.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS WARM. IT was always warm. Small. Light. Horn panes. Tin frame. A little handle. She turned it over in her hands and looked at the letters cut into the base.

TOO LATE.

She'd said it every morning. For a year and a half. At this window. Holding this lantern. *Too late, too late, too late*. She'd made it into a prayer. A lament. A thing to hold.

He'd cut it for her. Lex. The first night. Because she'd asked him to. Because she'd said, *cut what I'm feeling, love, I don't know how else to say it*, and he'd looked at her for a long time and then cut it, slowly, with the point of a nail, and given it to her.

And it had held the house anyway.

Not because of the words. Because he'd given it. Because somebody who loved her had made her a light, and put it in her hands, and said, *here*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FOUND A HAIRPIN.

In her hair. Where they always were. She took it out and straightened it between her finger and thumb and sat down in her chair with the lantern in her lap.

Rhosyn watched her. Elowen watched her.

Seren turned the lantern over. And under the letters Lex had cut, in the soft tin of the base, very slowly, with the point of the pin, in her own crooked hand that had never been any good at letters, she cut two more words.

It took a long time. The tin was harder than it looked. Her hands shook. The pin slipped twice and she cut her thumb and said a word that Wenna would have washed her mouth out for.

When she was done, she turned it the right way up and set it back on the sill.

TOO LATE.

STILL HERE.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLAME DIDN'T CHANGE. It wasn't that kind of story.

But when Seren looked out of the window—

The green ring round the house was wider.

Not much. A yard. Maybe two. But wider. Out past the water-butt. Out past the bench. Down the path to the first flagstone of the slope.

And in the pond, the gold speck of her lantern's reflection was a little brighter.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You still can't get through to him*," said Rhosyn. Quietly.

"*No*," said Seren.

She stood up.

"*But I can keep the window*," said Seren Harrow. "*Somebody has to.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT UP ALL night.

The three of them. Taking turns. At the window. Watching the pond.

It was very still. Very black. Very smooth. The water from the hills came down in the dark and spread and filled, slowly, silently, and the pond got a little bigger every hour. Lapping at the edge of the grey on one side. At the edge of the green on the other. At the foot of the ramp, by midnight. Black and flat and bright.

Nothing moved in it.

No face. No cold white light. No hand.

Just the gold speck. And the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT DAWN, SEREN WAS at the window.

She'd made tea. Warmed the pot. One spoon each and one for the pot. Water just off the boil.

The sky went from a picture of night to a picture of morning. Grey. Flat. No birds.

The pond was still black.

Seren looked at it. And at the stepping stones beyond, in their carved water. And at her son's cottage on the far bank, grey, the colour of nothing, with the swing on the apple bough not swaying any more. Stopped. Mid-swing. Leaning a little, toward the east, toward the house, the way a swing leans when a child has just jumped off it.

She looked at it for a long time.

Then she looked back at the pond.

And there was a face in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT WHITE. NOT COLD.

Small. Round. Pink. With a crest of black hair sticking up at the back like a jackdaw's, and square determined eyebrows, and a mouth wide open with delight.

Upside down. Reflected. In the black water. As if somebody were standing on the bank at the foot of the ramp, at the very edge of the green, leaning over, looking in.

There was nobody on the bank.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DROPPED THE CUP.

It didn't break. It fell on the rag rug and rolled.

She was at the door. On the ramp. On the path. At the edge of the green. At the edge of the water. On her knees. Looking down.

At the pond. Black. Smooth. Bright.

At her own face in it. Grey-haired. Freckled. White. Fifty-one. Upside down.

And beside it, in the water, where nobody was standing—

Her granddaughter. Twenty months old. In her nightshirt. With her fists clenched. Looking up out of the pond at Seren with an expression of enormous satisfaction.

As if she'd found a new way into Gan's house. And couldn't wait to show everyone.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mmo-ning*," said the face in the water.

Seren heard it. Clearly. Not through the water. Through the air. Through the morning. From very far away. From three miles off, upstream. From a forge yard, where a small girl in a nightshirt had got out of the door before anyone was up, and gone down to the stream to splash, the way she did every morning, and leaned over the water, and seen—

Seen her Gan. In it.

And laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BEHIND THE SMALL round face in the water—

Behind it. Below it. Far down. Where the black water went deeper than a garden pond had any right to go. Deeper than the stream. Deeper than the ground.

A light.

White. Cold. Clear.

Coming up.

CHAPTER 26

The Reflections

LEX WOKE BECAUSE THE house was too quiet.

It was a thing you learned. With a child. You learned the sounds of a sleeping house, the way a smith learns the sounds of a forge at night. The tick of the banked hearths. Brannoc's snoring through the wall. Wren's breathing beside him on the pallet, slow and deep. And under all of it, from the cot in the corner of the old tool-room, the small fierce snuffle of his daughter, who slept the way she did everything else. As if she meant it.

He lay there in the grey before dawn and listened.

Hearths. Brannoc. Wren.

Nothing from the cot.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS UP BEFORE he'd finished thinking it.

The cot was empty. The blanket kicked down to the end. The rag rabbit Wren's mother had sewn face-down on the floor beside it, which meant she'd climbed out over the side, which she'd been able to do for three weeks and had been told not to do every day of those three weeks.

The tool-room door was open a crack.

The long hall beyond it was dark. The banked hearths glowed down the length of it like a row of sleeping eyes. The door—*the* door, the apple wood door on its frame in the middle of the floor, with its forged hinges and no threshold and no latch—stood shut. Petals on the flags round it.

And the great doors at the end of the hall, onto the yard, were open.

A foot. Just a foot. Just wide enough for something small in a nightshirt to slip through sideways.

Lex ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD HER BEFORE he saw her.

Laughing.

That big delighted belly-laugh she'd had since she was four months old, that came up out of her like water out of a spring and went on and on, as if she'd heard the best joke in the world and wanted everybody to know. It came across the yard in the half-dark. From the bottom. From the back. From the place where the yard wall ended and the stream ran past, brown and quick, under the alders, where Brannoc took his quench-water and Lex had washed her feet on Sunday because she liked to splash.

"*Gan*!" shouted Lark. Delighted. "*Gan! Gan! Mmo-ning!*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS ON THE bank.

On her knees. On the flat stone where Brannoc set his buckets. In her nightshirt, with her black hair sticking up at the back and her bare feet muddy, leaning out over the water with both hands on the edge of the stone. Looking down. Laughing.

The stream wasn't moving.

That was the first thing Lex saw. Before he'd taken it in. Before he understood. The stream was always moving. It had been moving every day of his life at the Forge, brown and quick and loud. And it was lying under the alders like a sheet of black glass. Flat. Smooth. Still.

Not grey. Not stopped. Just—still. The way a pond goes still at dawn when the wind drops. As if the water had somewhere to be and had decided, all of it, at once, to wait.

And in it, under his daughter's face—

His mother's face. Upside down. White. Looking up.

And under that. Below it. Deep. Deeper than the stream had any right to be. Coming up.

Light.

White. Cold. Clear.

◆ ◆ ◆

"LARK."

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HE DIDN'T REMEMBER CROSSING the yard.

He remembered the stone under his knees. He remembered his arms going round her. He remembered the weight of her, warm and solid and outraged, coming up off the edge of the stone into his chest. He remembered her shriek—*NO! Gan! GAN!*—and her fists beating on his collarbone.

And he remembered the hand.

Coming up out of the water. Where she'd been. Where her face had been, a heartbeat before. White. Clear. Glass. Long fingers. Reaching.

It closed.

On his wrist.

◆ ◆ ◆

COLD.

Not the cold of winter. Not the cold of iron left out in frost. The cold of the long mirror. The cold of the Glass Queen's hall, that he'd never been in and knew anyway, because it was the cold he'd felt in the panel in the spring when she'd shown him himself with a crown on. The cold that *remembers*.

It went up his arm. Into his elbow. His shoulder. His chest. Like water going up a wick.

He held on to Lark.

The hand held on to him.

And for a moment—one moment, one heartbeat, kneeling on the flat stone in the half-dark with his daughter screaming in his arms—he looked down into the black water past the glass fingers round his wrist.

And saw her.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE.

Not in a panel. Not in a bath. Not in a cup of gold tea. Close. Under the water. A foot down. Looking up at him.

White. Clear. Beautiful in the way that a frost on a window is beautiful. A woman made of glass, with a crown of glass on her head and a face like a cut jewel, all planes and edges and light. With eyes that were nothing. Clear. Like looking through a window at a white sky.

She looked at him.

Then past him. At Lark. At the small furious face screaming against his chest.

And something went across the glass face. Something that wasn't anger. That wasn't anything Lex had a word for.

"*Not you*," said the Glass Queen. Through the water. Very softly. To him. "*I never wanted you.*"

The hand let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELL BACKWARD OFF the stone.

Onto the cinders of the yard. With Lark on his chest. With the cold going out of his arm like a tide going out, fast, leaving it numb and white and stiff to the elbow.

When he looked back at the stream, it was moving.

Brown. Quick. Loud. Over the stones. Under the alders. As if it had never stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She said Gan*," said Wren.

In the tool-room. Ten minutes later. With Lark in her lap, hiccuping, furious, clutching the rag rabbit. With Brannoc in the doorway in his nightshirt and his boots, holding a poker. With Antho behind him, white, and Seraphine behind Antho, whiter.

"*She said Gan*," said Wren again. "*Why would she say Gan?*"

"*She saw her*," said Lex.

He was sitting on the edge of the pallet. Holding his right arm. It was coming back. Slowly. Pins and needles. Up from the fingers. There was a mark round his wrist like a bracelet. White. Frosted. In the shape of four long fingers and a thumb.

"*She saw my mother*," said Lex. "*In the water.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER CAME AT noon.

Down the river path from Harrow. On foot. Through the grey.

He saw her from the top of the Forge roof, where he'd climbed to look west. He'd been up there all morning. Looking. At the line. You could see it now, from the roof. Three miles off, where the river path went into the trees above Harrow. Not a wall. Not a cloud. Just the place where the trees on one side were trees and the trees on the other were a picture of trees.

And coming out of it, down the path—

Three women.

Holding hands.

With a ring round their feet, green, a foot wide, moving with them over the grey grass like a lantern carried through a dark room.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS OFF THE roof and down the lane and onto the river path before anyone could stop him. He met them at the edge. Where the grey stopped and the green started. A hundred yards beyond the last of the Ashbourne lanterns. Where the grass was grass on one side of a line and not on the other.

His mother stepped across it.

She looked very small. She looked very tired. Her grey hair was coming down out of its pins and her boots were muddy and her square freckled hands were bleeding in the palms, as if she'd been holding thorns.

She looked up at him.

"*Is she all right*?" said Seren Harrow.

He couldn't answer. He just put his arms round her.

"*She's all right*," said Rhosyn. Behind her. Quietly. Looking at his face. "*Look at him, Seren. She's all right.*"

His mother cried into his shirt.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TOLD IT IN the Forge.

All of it. The birds. The hedge. The ring. The grave. The stream stopping. The pond filling. The face in the water at dawn.

Seraphine wrote it down. Every word. With her new spectacles on her nose—not glass, horn, scraped thin, the way Lex had made the panes of his mother's lantern, because she wouldn't wear glass any more and couldn't read without something. Her quill went very fast and her other hand stayed flat on her belly the whole time.

When they'd finished, she looked at the page for a long time.

"*It's the edge*," said Seraphine.

Everybody looked at her.

"*The edge of the grey*," she said. "*The front. Where it meets running water.*" She drew a line on the page. A wavy line. And a straight one across it. "*The water comes down from real ground. From the east. It hits the grey. It stops. It can't go on. It backs up. It pools. It goes flat.*" She tapped the place where the lines crossed. "*Every stream. Every river. Everywhere the grey's crossed running water since Midwinter, there's been a mirror. At the front. Right at the edge. Moving east as the grey moves east.*"

"*And she can come through it*," said Wren.

"*She can see through it*," said Rhosyn. "*Along it. Up the water. Up the whole stream. Anywhere it runs.*" She looked at Lex. "*Your mother's pond is at the bottom of one long thread of water that runs past your yard. She looked up it. She saw your child.*"

Silence.

"*How long*," said Brannoc. Gruff. "*Till it's here. The grey.*"

Lex looked at Seraphine.

Seraphine looked at her page.

"*Two days*," she said. "*Three. If it's slow.*"

"*And Midsummer*?" said Antho.

"*Four*," said Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY COVERED EVERYTHING.

That afternoon. That night. The next day. Every surface in the Forge that could hold a face.

Brannoc drained the quench-troughs. All twenty. Tipped them out into the yard and turned them upside down and sat on the last one with his arms folded as if daring it to fill itself. Tilda went round with a bucket of

soot and blacked every piece of polished iron on every anvil and every wall. Kestrel took down the hall's two windows, glass, old, bubbled, and wrapped them in sacking and put them in the coal-hole and stood on the coal-hole door.

Wren went through the tool-room and the kitchen and the loft and took away every cup, every bowl, every spoon, every pan with a bright bottom. Everything. She piled it all in a sack and gave it to Hollis Penn, who took it away up the lane in his barrow without asking why.

Lex dammed the stream.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DID IT WITH Stone.

Up at the top of the yard, where the stream came round the bend from the east under the alders. He knelt on the bank and put both hands on the ground and reached. Not through the net—the net was still, frozen, a held breath—but round it. Down. Past it. To the Well under everything. The slow patient deep of the earth.

Move, he said. *Please. Over. A little.*

The ground moved.

It came up out of the bank. A shoulder of rock. Grey-brown. Mossed. It came up slowly, the way a sleeper turns over, and lay across the stream from bank to bank, and the water hit it and turned. North. Away from the yard. Into the old dry channel behind the smithy where the stream had run a hundred years ago, before somebody's grandfather had moved it.

The stream bed past the yard went dry. Mud. Stones. A few trout flapping. Posy Tull's little brother came down from the village with a bucket and carried them off to the mill-pond in a state of high excitement.

"*It's still running*," said Antho. Beside him. Looking north. At the new old channel. At the water going away round the back of the smithy, brown and quick, toward the green. "*It's just running somewhere else.*"

"*It's running away from her*," said Lex.

"*It's running toward the grey*," said Antho. Quietly. "*Everything does. In the end.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY CAME ON the third day.

Lex stood on the green and watched it.

He'd stood on the Forge roof every morning and watched it come. Through the birch wood above Harrow. Down the valley. Across the Long Meadow, where the sheep had been, before Hollis and the Pruett boys drove them east to Fen Hollow. Over the river path. Up the hill. Toward the village. You could see it coming now. If you didn't look straight at it.

And round the village, in a ring, in the long grass—

Lanterns.

Seven hundred and twelve of them. And more. The ones given round the frame on the green, in the spring, the night Tom Pruett built the leaf. The ones the village had given since. Every lantern in Ashbourne. Every lantern anybody had. Tin and horn and glass and paper, square and round and bent, brass carriage lamps and kitchen candles in jam jars and one very old one, iron, rusted, with a crack down one pane, which Old Mag's neighbour said had been in her family since her great-grandmother's time and had never once been lit for anyone but family.

Given.

All of them.

Set out in a ring round Ashbourne. Round the green and the lanes and the mill and the Forge and the Penns' bakery and the church and the forty-one houses. In the grass. In the hedges. On gateposts and walls and the branches of trees. A long ring. A mile round. Gold.

The grey came up the hill to the first of them.

And stopped.

And went round.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LET OUT A breath he'd been holding since Midwinter.

Beside him, Brannoc did the same.

All round them, on the green, three hundred people did the same. A sound like wind. Like the whole village sighing. And then somebody laughed—a high shaky laugh, Davy Pruett's mother, with her new baby in a sling, holding her husband's arm—and somebody else, and then they were all laughing, or crying, or both, and Hollis Penn was handing out bread from his barrow, real bread, risen, still warm, because the ground

inside the ring was real ground and the yeast didn't know there was anything wrong.

Lex didn't laugh.

He was looking west. Past the green. Past the church. Down the lane. To the bottom of the village. To the mill.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STREAM CAME INTO Ashbourne from the east.

Under the bridge at the top of the village. Down the side of the green. Past the church. Round the back of the Forge now, in its old new channel. Down to the mill. And out again. West. Toward Harrow. Toward the grey.

It turned the mill wheel. It always had. Old Joss Miller's wheel, that had been turning since before Lex was born.

It wasn't turning now.

Because the stream ran out of the village at the bottom. Past the mill. Out through the ring of lanterns. Into the grey.

And stopped.

And backed up.

And the mill-race was filling. And the mill-pond behind it was filling. And spreading. Out over its banks. Into Joss Miller's orchard. Into the bottom of the lane. Brown and quick and live, coming down from the east, from real ground, and meeting the stillness at the bottom of the village, and pooling.

Going quiet.

Going flat.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's inside the ring*," said Antho.

Beside him. Very quietly. Looking where he was looking.

"*Yes*," said Lex.

"*You can't dam it*," said Antho. "*Not this one. There's nowhere for it to go. You turned it once. Wherever you turn it, it ends up at the grey.*"

"*I know*."

"*It's a mirror*," said Antho. "*Inside the lanterns. Inside the village. Forty yards from the bakery.*"

"*I know*," said Lex.

They stood there on the green while the village laughed and cried and ate warm bread round them. And watched the mill-pond at the bottom of the village fill. And go smooth. And go bright.

And in it, upside down, perfect—the mill. The church tower. The lantern ring, gold.

The sky. Blue.

The only blue for two hundred miles.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY COVERED IT.

What else could they do? Tom Pruett and the Penn boys and Ned Tull and half the men in the village carried sailcloth down from the old rope-walk, and planks from the timber-yard, and laid them across the pond from bank to bank. Weighted them with stones. Tied them down. Brannoc stood on the bank with his hammer and supervised, and when it was done he stood there and looked at it, a great grey sagging lid of canvas and boards over forty yards of water, and spat.

"*It'll hold*," said Brannoc.

"*It's canvas*," said Wren.

"*It'll hold*," said Brannoc.

He didn't go back up the hill. He sat down on the bank with his hammer across his knees and stayed there.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO DAYS TO MIDSUMMER.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME OUT OF the lanterns.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD THOUGHT ABOUT the mill-pond. They all had. They'd thought about it for two days. They'd sat up in shifts on the bank beside it with lanterns and hammers. They'd checked the ropes on the sailcloth every hour. They'd kept Lark in the Forge, in the tool-room, with the door shut, with Wren beside her and Seren beside Wren and Rhosyn in the doorway.

Nobody had thought about the lanterns.

Seven hundred and twelve lanterns. And more. A mile round. Tin and horn and paper and brass. And glass.

Glass panes. Hundreds of them. Lit. Gold.

Every one of them a little mirror, at night, with the dark outside it and a flame inside.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST ONE BROKE at midnight.

Lex heard it from the Forge. A small sound. A tinkle. The sound of a pane going.

Then another.

Then a scream.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS OUT OF the Forge with the hammer in his hand. Down the lane. Onto the green.

The ring was going out.

Not all of it. Not at once. Here and there. On the west side. On the south. Points of gold in the dark, in a long curve round the village, and one by one, one after another, going dark. Like someone walking round the ring snuffing candles.

And where they went dark—

The grey came in.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*THE LANTERNS*," somebody was shouting. "*THE LANTERNS, SOMETHING'S BREAKING THE LANTERNS—*"

Lex ran.

West. Toward the nearest gap. Down the hill past the church, past the Pruetts', into the long grass. To the ring. To a gap in the ring three lanterns wide where the gold had gone out and the grey was coming through. Slow. Patient. A picture of grass, creeping into the real.

There was a man standing in the gap.

◆ ◆ ◆

GLASS.

Clear. Bright. Moving. A man made of glass, the way the things on the lantern line had been, the way Wren had told it. Tall. Broad. A farmer's shoulders. A farmer's hands. Lex knew the shape of him. Jem Tolley, who kept bees on the hill. Whose lantern this had been. Whose own face had looked back at him out of the glass pane of his own lantern every night he'd lit it in his kitchen for thirty years.

It was holding the lantern.

It looked at Lex with Jem Tolley's face, clear as ice, and smiled, and closed its glass hand.

The lantern crumpled. Tin and glass. Like paper.

The light went out.

The grey came on.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HIT IT.

He didn't think. He swung. The hammer. Aurelian's hammer. Black iron, old, heavy, worn smooth at the grip. It went into the glass man's chest and the glass man shattered. All at once. Into a thousand bright pieces. Into the grass.

And the pieces got up.

Every one. A thousand small bright pieces of glass, in the grass, in the dark. Rising. Turning. Each one with a face in it. Jem Tolley's face. A thousand of them. Smiling.

And drifted toward the next lantern.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Fire won't come through the net,] he thought. *[Not for me. Not since the still. I have to go round.]*

He went round.

Down. Past the net. Past the held breath of it, the frozen weave. To the Well. To the heat under everything. He reached for it and it came, slow, the way it had come every day since the net went still. Not a roar. A climb. Up out of the deep, hand over hand. White-gold.

Too slow.

By the time it reached his palm, the thousand pieces of glass had reached the next three lanterns, and the next three lanterns went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THEM ALL down the ring.

All the way round. In the dark. Where the gold had gone out. Glass figures standing in the gaps. Dozens. Each one holding a lantern. Each one wearing the face of the person who'd given it. Who'd lit it every night in a kitchen window, in a byre, on a gatepost, and looked into the pane and seen themselves.

Every lantern in Ashbourne was a mirror.

Every lantern in Ashbourne had seen its owner's face.

And she was in all of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*LEX*."

Kestrel. Out of the dark. Running. With her hand up in front of her and the air over it thick and wavy and dark, like the air over a road in summer. Black heat. Fire with no light.

She walked into the cloud of glass pieces over the next lantern and they melted. All at once. Into drops. Into a fine bright rain that hissed on the grass.

"*It can't see me*," panted Kestrel. "*It can't see black heat. It's made of seeing.*" She shoved past him. "*But there's hundreds, Lex. There's hundreds of them, and there's one of me.*"

Behind her, Wren. Out of the dark. On the mist. Not walking. Going. A cold grey blur between one gap and the next. And where she went, the glass figures turned. Blind. Confused. Groping at the fog.

Behind Wren, Antho. With his hands up and the dark coming off them. Starlit. Deep. Shade, Commanding, the way he'd learned it on the hill above the Keep, showing the dead their own shapes in the stars.

"*They're coming from the glass*," Antho shouted. "*The lantern panes. All of them.*"

"*I know*."

"*Lex, we can't hold the ring. We can't—if the ring goes—*"

"*I KNOW*."

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE VOICE behind him said: "*You could, though.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED ROUND.

There was a man on the green.

Tall. Black-haired. Broad-shouldered, a smith's shoulders, with a smith's burn-scars up both forearms and a grey-gold handprint on his left cheek. In a leather apron. With a hammer in his hand. Black iron. Old. Worn smooth at the grip.

Glass.

Clear. Bright. A man of glass with Lex's face.

And on his head—

On his head, gold. Seven points. Thin. Plain. No jewels. The crown that had been lying in the road at the Heart for nine hundred years. The net's crown. Warm. Gold. Empty.

Not empty now.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hello*," said the glass Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D SEEN IT BEFORE. In the panel. In the spring. *YOUR DAUGHTER'S HANDS ARE VERY SQUARE.* A picture of him crowned. Standing in the Heart. Holding the net.

It had been a picture then.

It wasn't a picture now. It was standing on the green at Ashbourne in the dark with the lantern ring going out behind it, and it was looking at him with his own eyes, and smiling his own smile.

The crooked one. The one Wren said made him look about twelve.

"*You could hold it*," said the glass Lex. Pleasantly. Reasonably. In Lex's own voice. "*The ring. All of it. Every lantern. You could hold every one of them up and keep them lit and keep her out and keep the grey out and keep everybody safe.*" It held out its free hand. Glass. Square. "*You've got Lv 99. You're one off. One. And then Tier Five. And then the crown.*"

"*No*," said Lex.

"*She'd give it you*," said the glass Lex. "*She told you. In the spring. She's holding it for you. It's warm. It's empty. She doesn't even want it. She just wants—*"

"*No*."

The glass Lex sighed.

"*I knew you'd say that*," it said. "*I'm you.*"

And swung.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS FASTER THAN him.

That was the first thing. It was him—his shoulders, his reach, his weight, his twenty years at the anvil—but it was faster. Because when it reached for fire, the fire came.

Straight through the net. Not round. Through. A white-gold roar out of the glass hands, out of the glass hammer, the way Lex's own fire had come to him every day of his life until the still. Instant. Enormous. Easy.

Because the net was still, and the net was hers, and it was hers.

It hit him in the chest.

He went backward across the green. Twenty feet. Into the stocks by the church, which had not been used for punishing anybody since before Lex was born and were mostly for children to climb on. They broke. He broke, a little. Something in his side. He lay in the splinters with the breath knocked out of him and the fire still burning in his apron and looked up at the stars.

There weren't any stars. The grey had come in over the west of the village through the gaps in the ring, and the sky over the church was a picture of a sky.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS LEX WALKED toward him.

Unhurried. Hammer in hand. Crown on its head. Through the firelight.

"*I'm what you are*," it said. "*Underneath. Isn't that what she shows everyone? I'm the bit of you that wanted it. In the panel. In the spring. Just for a heartbeat. You looked at me and you thought, I could keep them safe.*"

Lex got up on one elbow.

"*You did*," said the glass Lex. "*She saw it. She sees everything.*"

He reached. Down. Round. To the heat. It came. Slow. Hand over hand. Up out of the deep.

The glass Lex hit him again before it got there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAY ON HIS back on the green.

Burning. Broken. With the fire in him climbing too slowly up out of the earth and the fire in the glass man's hands pouring straight down out of the net like a waterfall.

He couldn't win this. Not fire against fire. Not his slow reaching against her open tap. Not a smith against his own reflection with the whole net behind it.

He couldn't burn it.

It's made of seeing, Kestrel had said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT OF BRANNOC.

He didn't know why. Lying there. He thought of Brannoc at midnight in the Forge, kneeling at the great hearth. With his knees cracking. Banking the fire. Raking the ash over the coals, slow, careful, the way he'd done every night for forty-five years. Not putting it out. Never putting it out. Just—covering it. Hiding the light. So it would keep till morning.

Banked, said Brannoc. In the dark. To the King. *Not kept. There's a difference.*

He thought of Antho. On the hill. In the starlit dark. *It's a mould. A lantern's just a dark box with a light in it.*

He thought of Kestrel's black heat. Fire with no light.

A reflection was made of seeing.

You couldn't see without light.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*ANTHO*," Lex shouted.

He didn't know if his brother could hear him. Across the green. Across the dark. Over the screaming and the glass breaking and the roar of the glass Lex's fire.

"ANTHO, PUT IT OUT. ALL OF IT. EVERY LIGHT IN THE VILLAGE."

Silence.

Then, from somewhere across the green, high, cracking—

"THE RING—"

"NOT OUT," Lex shouted. *"DARK. BANK IT. COVER IT. LIKE BRANNOC. LIKE THE HILL."* He coughed. Something in his side grated. *"LET THEM BURN IN THE DARK. LET THEM NOT BE SEEN."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS LEX STOPPED.

Over him. With its hammer raised. With the fire pouring down its arm. And looked down at him.

For the first time, it didn't smile.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ANTHO VEY, THRESHOLD Warden, Shade Commanding, standing in the middle of the green at Ashbourne with his hands up and a thousand glass faces turning toward him, understood.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DARK CAME DOWN like a lid.

Not out of the sky. Out of him. Out of his hands. Out of his chest. Out of the shapes of the dead he'd seen in the gaps in the stars. Deep. Soft. Total. It went out from the middle of the green in a ring, like a ripple in a pond, over the church and the bakery and the forty-one houses and the Forge and the mill and the long grass, out to the lanterns.

And over them.

Every lantern in the ring. Every one that was still lit. The dark went over them like a hand closing gently round a candle flame. Not putting it out. Holding it. Cupping it. So the light stayed inside. So it burned, and burned, gold and real and given, in a little cup of dark, and didn't throw a single ray beyond its own panes.

Lex felt it. On his skin. The ring held. The lanterns burned. The grey stopped where it was.

And nobody could see a thing.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS LEX SCREAMED.

It was Lex's voice. Lex's own voice, coming out of a man made of glass, screaming. High. Thin. Like a wet finger on the rim of a cup.

It came apart.

Not shattering. Fading. The way a reflection fades in a window when someone inside blows out the lamp. It went thin. Clear. Clearer. Until it was just an outline of a man with a hammer and a crown, drawn in faint lines on the dark. And then not even that.

The last thing to go was the crown.

It hung in the air over Lex for a moment after the rest of it had gone. Gold. Seven points. In the dark. On nothing.

Then it went too.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL ROUND THE RING, the glass faces went out.

Jem Tolley. Ned Tull. Hollis Penn. Old Mag's neighbour. Davy Pruett's mother. Hundreds of them. Faces of glass, in the gaps, at the lanterns, in the long grass. Going thin. Going clear.

Gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILENCE.

Total. Dark. Like the inside of a closed book.

Lex lay on his back on the green in the splinters of the stocks and breathed. In. Out. The thing in his side grating. The fire going out of his apron.

He couldn't see his own hand.

Nobody could see anything.

Somewhere, very close, Brannoc was swearing. Steadily. Quietly. With great feeling.

Somewhere further off, a child was crying.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN HE SAW IT.

The only light in Ashbourne.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS SMALL. IT was gold. It was soft. It was coming down the lane from the Forge. Not from a lantern. Not from a fire. Not from anything Antho's dark had cupped and covered.

It was coming from a child.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D KNOWN. THEY'D ALL known. Since the spring. Since the night Seraphine fainted on the green and Rhosyn caught her and said *you're carrying a light*. Since before that. Since the night his daughter was born on Lantern Night with the whole of Harrow lit round her. *Carrying a light* was a Harrow idiom, Old Mag said. And Lark was a Harrow. And a Vey. And an Ashdown. And a smith.

She glowed. A little. Always had. You only saw it in the dark.

There'd never been a dark like this.

She came down the lane in her nightshirt. Barefoot. On her own. Twenty months old. Out of the Forge, where somebody had opened a door in the dark, out of somebody's arms, where she'd wriggled, the way she always wriggled. Glowing. Soft. Gold. The only light in the world.

Laughing.

"*Gan*," said Lark. Delighted. To the dark. "*Gan, Gan—*"

Going toward the mill.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*NO—*"

Lex was up. He didn't know how. His side screamed. He didn't care. He ran. Into the dark. Blind. Toward the small gold light going down the lane.

Behind him, he heard his mother. Running. Rhosyn. Running.

Ahead of him, Lark. Not running. Toddling. Fast. The way she did when she'd made up her mind. Down the lane. Past the bakery. Past the Pruetts'. Toward the bottom of the village. Toward the place where Brannoc had sat for two days on the bank with his hammer, and wasn't

sitting now, because Brannoc had gone up the hill to the green when the lanterns started breaking.

Toward the mill-pond.

Under its sailcloth.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FOUND THE CORNER.

Of course she did. She'd been finding corners all her life. The corner of a blanket. The corner of a gap in the hedge. The corner of the sailcloth over the mill-pond, where one of the ropes had come loose in the fighting and the canvas had slid back a foot.

She sat down on the bank. Glowing. And pulled it back.

And leaned over.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POND WAS BLACK.

Flat. Smooth. Still. Forty yards of it. Under the canvas. In the dark.

And in it—

One light.

Small. Gold. Soft. Round-faced. With a crest of black hair sticking up at the back like a jackdaw's.

The only light in Ashbourne. Reflected.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS TEN YARDS away.

He saw it. Running. Blind. With his side screaming and his heart going. He saw his daughter's light on the bank, and her reflection in the black water, gold, perfect, upside down.

And under it.

White.

Coming up.

◆ ◆ ◆

FIVE YARDS.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HAND CAME OUT of the water.

Not reaching. Not grabbing. Gently. The way you'd lift a sleeping child out of a cot. It came up out of the black pond and closed round the small gold body on the bank, round the nightshirt and the bare muddy feet and the fists, and lifted.

Lark looked up at it.

At the glass hand round her. At the white cold light under the water. At the face coming up through it. Glass. Clear. Beautiful in the way a frost on a window is beautiful.

Her square determined eyebrows came down.

"*No*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I know, little one*," said the Glass Queen.

Very softly. Under the water. Through it. In a voice like a bell under ice.

"*I know you say no*," said Ysenne. "*You said it to me in the cup. You said it to the King.*" The glass hand held her. Gently. Firmly. "*That's why I'm not asking.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THREE YARDS.

His mother was beside him. Running. Rhosyn was ahead of him. Somehow. Barefoot. Forty years old. Faster than any of them. Throwing herself across the last of the dark toward the bank. Toward the water. Toward the glass wrist coming up out of it.

She caught it.

Both hands. Round the glass. On the bank. On her knees.

"*YSY*," screamed Rhosyn. "*YSY. DON'T. DON'T. YSY, PLEASE, LOOK AT ME—*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FOR ONE MOMENT—

One heartbeat. On the bank of the mill-pond. In the dark. With the only light in the world held up in a glass hand over black water—

The Glass Queen stopped.

Under the water. With her face a foot down. Looking up. At her sister. At Rosie. At a mortal woman of forty with thorns in her hair and tears on her face and both hands round a glass wrist, holding on.

Something went across the cut-jewel face. Something that wasn't anything Lex had a word for.

"*I'll give her back, Rosie*," said Ysenne. Very quietly. "*After*."

And pulled.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN WENT INTO THE water to the shoulders.

She didn't let go. Lex saw it. Saw her hands round the glass, white-knuckled. Saw her go in. Saw the black water close over her arms, her shoulders, her hair.

Then the glass wrist turned.

The way glass turns. Not bending. *Cutting*. Edges. Planes. It turned in Rhosyn's hands and cut them. Both palms. To the bone.

Rhosyn screamed.

And let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX REACHED THE BANK.

He went into the water after them. Up to his chest. Down. Under. Into the black. Reaching. Blind. For anything. A nightshirt. A foot. A small gold light.

There wasn't anything.

There wasn't any water.

There was glass.

Under his hands. Under his knees. Smooth. Hard. Cold. Flat. A sheet of it. As if the mill-pond had frozen. As if it had never been water at all. He knelt on it, chest-deep in a black that wasn't water any more, and beat on it with his fists, and it didn't crack. It didn't even ring.

Under it, a long way down, a small gold light was going away.

Down. Into the dark. Into the glass. Smaller. Smaller. Like a lantern carried away down a long road.

Gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER PULLED HIM out.

He didn't remember that either. He remembered her hands, square, freckled, bleeding, on his collar. He remembered lying on the bank in the mud beside Rhosyn, who was curled over her own hands, sobbing, with blood running between her fingers onto the grass.

He remembered the dark lifting.

Slowly. Antho letting go. The lanterns coming back, one by one, round the ring, gold. The grey stopped where it had stopped. The village coming back out of the dark. Houses. The church. The green. People. Running. Shouting.

And the mill-pond.

Lit by a hundred lanterns. Flat. Grey. Hard. Not black any more. Not bright. Not anything. Forty yards of dull grey glass, from bank to bank, like a slate. Like a gravestone. Reflecting nothing at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD WREN BEFORE he saw her.

Not shouting. Not screaming. She came down the lane at a run and stopped at the top of the bank and didn't make any sound at all.

He looked up at her.

He couldn't say it. He opened his mouth and nothing came. He'd been the one who said *put out the lights*. He'd been the one who made the dark. He'd made the only light in Ashbourne his daughter, and sent it down the lane to a mirror, and been five yards too slow.

Wren looked at his face.

Then she looked at the mill-pond. At the grey glass. At Rhosyn's blood on the bank. At Seren, on her knees, with her hands over her mouth.

She didn't ask.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOOK HER BOW off her back.

She laid it on the grass. Carefully. And her quiver. And her knives. Both of them. And unbuckled her belt and laid that down too, and kicked off her boots, and stood on the bank of the mill-pond in her shirt and her

leggings and her bare feet, with her fox-red braid down her back and her gold fingers—two fingers and a thumb on her left hand—catching the lantern light.

"*Wren*," said Lex.

"*She went down the glass*," said Wren. Not a question.

"*Yes*."

"*The glass road*." Wren looked at the grey slate of the pond. "*To the Heart. To the anvil. Where Ysenne sits.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Then I'm going down the glass*," said Wren Ashdown.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You can't*," said Rhosyn. From the grass. Through her teeth. Holding her bleeding hands against her chest. "*You can't walk on glass. Nobody can. It's hers. It's all hers. Every pane. She'll see you the moment you set foot—*"

"*She won't see me*," said Wren.

She looked down at her left hand. At the two gold fingers and the gold thumb. At the three fingers on her right hand that had learned to draw a bow in the spring because the left ones couldn't feel the string any more.

"*She can only see what throws a reflection*," said Wren. "*Kestrel said. It's made of seeing.*" She looked up. "*Mist doesn't throw a reflection. Mist just—goes. Between. Through.*" A thin hard smile. "*I'm the Mistwalker. I've been walking where things can't see me since I was ten.*"

"*Wren*," said Lex again. He was getting up. He didn't know how. "*Wait. I'll come—*"

"*You can't*," said Wren. Gently. "*You're a smith, love. You're iron and fire. You'd throw a reflection like a beacon.*" She looked at him. Her green eyes. Very steady. "*And you've got a door to finish. And a crown to deal with. And a gold king in the yard. And your mam and the thorn lady bleeding on the grass.*"

She knelt down in front of him. In the mud. And took his face in her hands. The gold ones and the flesh ones.

"*I'll bring her back*," said Wren. "*Or I'll stay with her. One or the other. She's not going to be on her own down there. Not for one minute.*"

She kissed him.

Then she stood up. And turned. And walked down the bank. Onto the grey glass of the mill-pond. Barefoot.

And went.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT WALKED. WENT.

Lex saw it. Everybody on the bank saw it. One moment there was a woman standing on a sheet of grey glass in the lantern light, a red braid down her back.

The next there was a breath of cold fog. Grey. Thin. Curling. Like your breath on a winter window.

And it sank.

Into the glass. Through it. The way mist sinks into a cold hollow at evening.

And was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX KNELT ON THE bank.

In the mud. With his side grating and his hands burned and the glass Lex's crown still printed on the backs of his eyes, gold, seven points, in the dark.

He looked at the mill-pond. At the grey. At the place where his wife had gone down after his daughter.

He thought: *the door's not finished*.

He thought: *Midsummer's in two days*.

He thought: *she said I'll give her back after*. *After what*?

He knew.

He'd always known. Since the spring. Since the panel. *YOUR DAUGHTER'S HANDS ARE VERY SQUARE.*

After the small square hand touched the net.

After the net took a Root.

After the crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND HIM, ON THE grass, somebody was walking.

Big. Slow. Gold. The grass going gold under his feet in a trail behind him, up the lane, from the green. Holding a cup. Holding, in his other hand, very gently, the way you'd hold a moth, something small and white.

The King stopped at the top of the bank.

He looked at the mill-pond. At the grey glass. At Rhosyn on the grass, bleeding. At Seren holding her. At Lex.

"*She took the little one*," said Oszric.

"*Yes*," said Lex.

The King stood there for a long time.

Then he opened his hand. And looked at the petal on his palm. White. Pink at the edges. Not gold.

"*Then I think*," said the Gilded King, very slowly, very quietly, the way a man says something he's been practising in the dark for a long time, "*it's time I went and had a word with my sister.*"

CHAPTER 27

Through the Glass

THE FIRST THING WREN learned about the glass road was that it went down.

Not like a stair. Not like a slope. Like falling into a well where the well falls with you. She sank through the grey slate of the mill-pond the way mist sinks into a cold hollow, and the glass let her through without noticing, the way a window lets the fog press against it all night and never feels a thing, and then she was—

Under.

In.

Somewhere.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS BRIGHT.

That was the second thing. She'd expected dark. She'd been braced for dark, the way you brace for cold water. She'd thought the inside of a mirror would be black, like the back of one.

It was white.

White like a page. White like the sky over snow. White and clear and endless in every direction, and full of light that came from nowhere, that didn't cast shadows, that lay on everything evenly like a coat of paint.

And full of faces.

◆ ◆ ◆

PANES.

Thousands of them. Millions. Hanging in the white. Not on walls. Not in frames. Just hanging. At every angle. Every height. Near and far. Like leaves falling, if leaves fell forever and never reached the ground. Square ones and round ones and long narrow ones. Some as big as a barn door. Some no bigger than a thumbnail.

And in every one, a face.

Looking out.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAW A WOMAN brushing her hair. In a long pane, tall, the shape of a looking-glass on a bedroom wall. A tired woman with grey in her hair, looking at herself, not seeing herself, thinking about something else. Brushing. Brushing. The same stroke. Over and over.

She saw a boy in a puddle. Upside down. Six or seven. Leaning over to look at himself, making a face, sticking out his tongue. The same face. The same tongue. Over and over.

She saw a man in a shop window. A soldier in a polished breastplate. A girl in the back of a spoon. An old woman in a dark kitchen window at night, with a candle, looking out past her own face into the dark for someone who hadn't come home.

Every face that had ever looked into anything bright.

Kept.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HUNG IN THE white. As mist. A thin grey breath of cold fog among the falling panes.

And understood.

This was where they went. All of them. Every reflection. Every time you looked in a glass and saw yourself, and looked away, and the glass kept looking. Every face in every window. Every face in every pond. They didn't go away when you stopped looking. They came here.

And she kept them.

Ysenne. Nine hundred years. Every pane. Every face. Every one of them, stopped, at the moment someone looked—a tired woman brushing her hair, a boy pulling a face—stopped and kept and hung here in the white

forever, so that the Glass Queen could walk among them and look at every face in the world.

Except one.

◆ ◆ ◆

Where's Lark.

She made herself think it. Hard. Like a nail.

Where's Lark. *Not faces*. *Not panes*. *Lark*.

She turned. As mist turns. Slowly. In every direction at once.

And there—

Down. Far down. Through the falling panes. A long way off. Small. Soft. Gold.

A light. Going away.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT AFTER IT.

She didn't know how. She'd never mistwalked anywhere like this. She'd mistwalked through fog banks and rain and the grey country's edge and once, terribly, through the inside of a storm over the Teeth with Lark in her belly. You went between. You went through. You let the cold carry you the way the wind carries a breath.

There was no wind here.

There was no cold, even. The white was neither warm nor cold. It was just *still*.

So she went the way she'd gone the first time. When she was ten. On the hill above Thistledown. When her father was three days dead under the rock-wyrm's boulder and her mother was coughing in the house and she'd gone out into the fog in her nightdress, barefoot, and walked until she couldn't see the house any more, and kept walking, and found she wasn't walking. Found she was the fog. Found she could go anywhere, so long as she didn't think about where she'd come from.

She didn't think about the mill-pond. Or the bank. Or Lex on his knees in the mud.

She thought about the light.

And went.

◆ ◆ ◆

DOWN THROUGH THE PANES.

Past faces. Past thousands of faces. They didn't see her. They couldn't. They were made of seeing, Kestrel said, and mist didn't throw a reflection, and she slid past them like a draught under a door. A baker in a copper pan. A child in a window. An old man in a pair of spectacles—she knew him, she knew that face, wise and wry and tired—and she went past it before she could think *Malachi*.

Past a pane with a face in it that she knew so well her heart stopped.

Red-haired. Freckled. Grinning. Twelve. Thirteen. In a bucket of water by a well in Thistledown, with a fresh-shot hare over one shoulder and a bow taller than she was over the other.

Her.

Kept.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T STOP.

She wanted to. God help her, she wanted to. That girl in the bucket was the last time she'd looked at herself and been glad. Before Lex. Before the Spire. Before the hand.

She didn't stop.

That's not what I am, she thought. *That's what I was*. She'd said it to the glass thing on the lantern line, on her knees in the snow, with her own five-fingered reflection holding a glass arrow at her heart. *This is what I was. That's all right. I don't need it back.*

She went past it.

The pane turned. Slowly. As she went. As if, for just a moment, the red-haired girl in the bucket had felt something go past her. A breath. A draught. And looked up.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT WAS GETTING closer.

She could see it now. Not just a speck. A shape. A small gold shape, glowing soft, held. Held against something white. Something tall. Something walking down through the falling panes as if they were a stair.

Wren slowed.

Went thin. Thinner. As thin as breath on a window. And came down through the panes behind them.

Very quietly.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE WAS SINGING.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HADN'T EXPECTED THAT.

She'd expected—she didn't know what. Cold. Triumph. A queen with a stolen child, walking fast to her throne. She'd expected to find Lark screaming.

Lark wasn't screaming.

She was on the Glass Queen's hip. The way a child sits on its mother's hip. Glowing. With one fist wound in a fold of the white gown, and the other in her mouth, and her black hair sticking up at the back. And her square eyebrows down. Hard. In the scowl she'd had since the day she was born, that Lex said was Wenna's and Seren said was Wren's and Wren said was nobody's but her own.

She was looking at the panes going past.

At every one.

And at every one, round the fist in her mouth, she said:

"*No*."

◆ ◆ ◆

"*That's a woman brushing her hair*," said Ysenne. Softly. Walking. "*In Saltreach. Eight hundred years ago. She was thinking about her son, who'd gone to sea*."

"*No*," said Lark.

"*That's a soldier. He polished his breastplate every morning for forty years. He liked to see his face in it. It made him feel he was still there*."

"*No*."

"*That's a girl in a spoon*." A pause. "*She thought she looked funny upside down. She laughed*."

Lark took her fist out of her mouth.

Looked at the girl in the spoon.

"*No*," said Lark. Very firmly.

And put the fist back.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN LAUGHED.

It wasn't a cold laugh. That was what made Wren go still in the white, a breath among the panes, and stay still. It was a small laugh. Surprised. As if it had got out of her without asking. Like water out of a crack in ice.

"*You don't like any of them*," said Ysenne.

"*No*," said Lark.

"*Why not*?"

Lark took her fist out of her mouth again. And thought about it. With her eyebrows. The way she thought about everything.

"*Gan*," said Lark.

"*Your grandmother*?"

"*Gan*," said Lark. Insistently. And pointed. Back. Up. The way they'd come. Through the panes. To the place where a pond at the bottom of a garden had shown her a face she knew. "*Gan. Mam. Da.*" And then, with tremendous scorn, flapping her hand at all the faces in the world—"*No*."

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE STOPPED WALKING.

She stood among the falling panes with a child on her hip and looked at her. For a long time. With her clear glass face. With her eyes that were nothing, like looking through a window at a white sky.

"*Not these*," said the Glass Queen. Slowly. "*You only want the ones that are yours.*"

"*Mam*," said Lark.

"*Not every face*," said Ysenne. "*Not all of them. Not kept. Just the ones that look back.*"

"*Da*," said Lark.

The Glass Queen didn't say anything.

And Wren, hanging in the white a dozen yards behind her, saw her lift her free hand—long, clear, glass—and touch, very lightly, one of the panes beside her. A small one. Round. Like the back of a spoon.

There was nothing in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED ON.

Wren followed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT ON FOR a long time.

She didn't know how long. There was no day in the white. No night. No sun. No hunger. No tiredness. She didn't breathe—mist doesn't—and she didn't sleep, and the panes went past and the panes went past, and Ysenne walked down through them as if down a stair that had no bottom, and Lark said no to every one.

Hours. Days. She couldn't tell.

At some point Lark fell asleep. On the glass shoulder. With her fist still wound in the white gown. Glowing softly. The way she glowed in the cot at night.

Ysenne walked more slowly after that.

Wren noticed. She didn't want to. She noticed anyway. The Glass Queen shifted the child on her hip, the way you shift a sleeping child when your arm's gone dead, so the head's in the crook of your neck. And slowed. And stopped singing. And walked the rest of the way in silence, very carefully, through the falling panes, so as not to jolt her.

Wren hung in the white behind them and hated her.

And watched her do it.

And couldn't stop watching.

◆ ◆ ◆

Take her.

She thought it a hundred times. A thousand. Hanging there.

Take her now. While she's asleep. Go in as mist and come out as you and grab her and run.

Run where?

That was the thing. That was what stopped her, every time. *Run where*. Up? There was no up. There was only the white, and the panes, and the glass road going down. Back to the mill-pond? She didn't know the way.

She'd come down without thinking about where she'd come from. That was how mistwalking worked. You didn't look back.

And Ysenne was the white. Ysenne was every pane. If Wren came out of the mist and became a woman with a red braid and a child in her arms, she'd throw a reflection in every pane in the world. And the Glass Queen would turn round. And look at her. And—

YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE.

She'd seen what happened. Posy Tull on her knees in the snow with her own face screaming at her out of a Stone. The lantern line. Ada Fell.

She couldn't take Lark. Not here. Not in the glass.

So she followed.

And waited.

And was there. That was all. Was there. A breath. A draught. A grey fog going down through the white, a dozen yards behind her daughter, where her daughter couldn't see her and didn't know.

I'll stay with her, she'd said to Lex. *She's not going to be on her own down there. Not for one minute.*

She wasn't.

Even if she didn't know it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WHITE BEGAN TO go grey.

Wren noticed it at the edges first. The light changing. Thinning. The panes going further apart. Fewer of them. Older. The faces in them stranger—clothes she didn't know, hair she'd never seen done that way, languages on the lips that she couldn't read.

And under the white—

Water.

Far down. Below. Grey. Dark. Moving. A huge slow grey current, like a river seen from a mountain. And in it—Wren looked, and looked away, and looked again—buildings.

Towers. Roofs. Domes. Streets. A city. Under the water. Grey and drowned and enormous, old beyond anything she had a word for. With grey shapes drifting in its streets like fish. Like smoke.

The Drowned Country.

Antho had told her. On the night of the double wedding, drunk, at two in the morning, with his head in Seraphine's lap. *There's a city under the Hollow. Before the Lattice. Before the Wells were tapped. Drowned. And the dead drift in it. And there's a little girl. Grey. I promised her a light.*

The glass road went down over it. Through it. A road of panes. Falling. Past the drowned towers. Past the drowned dead. Down.

To the bottom.

To the Heart.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAW IT FROM a long way off.

Gold.

The only colour in the grey. A long way down. At the bottom of everything. Where the glass road ended and the drowned city ended and the grey river ran out of the dark on one side and into it on the other.

A hall.

Round. Huge. Roofless. Its walls were white stone, the way the Spire was white stone, the way every Lattice Stone in Caldor was white stone—and Wren understood, looking down at it, that they'd all been cut from here. That every Stone in the world was a chip off this. And in the middle of the floor, on a dais of seven steps—

An anvil.

Gold. Huge. Old. Plain. Worn smooth on its face by blows struck nine hundred years ago. And on it—on the anvil, on the face, as if somebody had set it down a moment ago and gone to fetch something—

A crown.

Gold. Seven points. Thin. Plain. No jewels.

Warm. Empty.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BESIDE THE ANVIL, on the top step, a chair.

White. Stone. High-backed. Plain. The chair of the Root. The chair where Lex had sat, once, with the whole net in his hands. Where the old king had sat, for nine hundred years, dead in his tomb and holding on.

Empty now.

Empty, because the woman who'd been sitting in it for four months was walking down the last of the glass road toward it, with a child asleep on her shoulder.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE STEPPED OFF THE last pane.

Onto the white floor of the Heart.

And the hall woke up.

◆ ◆ ◆

LIGHT.

Out of the floor. Out of the walls. Out of the white stone. Ten thousand threads. Silver. Gold. Blue. Every colour. Rising out of the stone like steam off a pond at dawn, and going up, and out, and away—to every Stone in the world. To every Kindling. To every panel. To every hand.

The net.

Wren had never seen it. Not like this. Lex had. Lex had sat in the middle of it. But Wren had only ever felt it, the way you feel your own pulse. A hum. A warmth. A panel in the air in front of you saying *Lv 73* in silver-blue.

She saw it now.

Ten thousand threads of light, rising out of the white stone, out of the floor of the Heart, going away up through the grey water and the drowned city and the glass road to the whole of the world.

And all of them—

Still.

Not moving. Not humming. Not pulsing like a heart. Hanging. In the air. Taut. Like the strings of a harp when someone has put their whole hand flat across them.

Held.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE WALKED UP THE seven steps.

Slowly. Carefully. With the child asleep on her shoulder. Past the chair. To the anvil.

She stood in front of it.

She looked down at the crown.

She didn't touch it.

Wren saw her not touch it. Saw the long glass hand come up—and stop. A finger's breadth away. Hovering. Over the gold. Shaking, a little.

Then go back down.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Not yet*," said Ysenne. Softly. To the crown. To herself. "*Not without the hand.*"

She turned.

She sat down in the white chair.

Carefully. With Lark asleep in her lap. The way you'd sit down in a rocking chair with a sleeping child, so as not to wake her. And the threads of the net bent toward her. All ten thousand. Leaning. The way the dead had leaned toward Antho on the hill. The way the flames had leaned toward Lark at Harrow on the night the Veil fell.

The Glass Queen sat in the chair of the Root with the net bent round her like a bower of light and a child asleep in her lap, and closed her eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HUNG IN THE grey air at the edge of the Heart.

At the edge of the glass road. Where the last pane hung over the white floor. As mist. A breath. A draught.

And waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T KNOW HOW long.

The light in the Heart didn't change. The threads hung still. The grey river ran in on one side and out on the other, slow, silent, with the drowned city dark above it. The crown lay on the anvil. The Queen sat in the chair. The child slept.

Wren thought about Lex.

On the bank. In the mud. With his hands burned and his side broken and his face—she'd never seen a face like that. Not on him. Not on anyone. As if somebody had cut him open and taken something out.

She'd kissed him and gone.

She thought about that kiss. She thought about the first one. On the Spire. In the wind. She thought about the night after the wedding, and the morning she'd told him, on the roof, *I'm carrying*, and his face. Twelve years old. Crooked smile. She thought about Lantern Night, and the lanterns in every window at Harrow, and the small furious red thing in her arms that had opened its mouth and yelled at the whole world as if it had a complaint to make.

She thought: *two days*.

She didn't know if it had been two days. She didn't know if it had been two hours. She didn't know if, up there, in the world, in Ashbourne, it was still the night of the mill-pond, or Midsummer, or a hundred years later and everyone she loved was a picture of themselves standing still in a grey field.

She waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WOKE UP.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN KNEW BEFORE SHE moved. Mist knows things. The way fog knows the shape of a valley. She felt the small body in the Queen's lap go from soft to stiff. Felt the breath change. Felt the eyebrows come down.

Lark sat up.

In the Glass Queen's lap. In the white chair. In the middle of the net. Glowing. Furious. With her hair flattened on one side from sleeping on a glass shoulder and her fists clenched. And looked round.

At the white hall. At the threads of light. At the gold anvil. At the grey river.

At the Glass Queen.

Who opened her eyes, and looked back.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good morning*," said Ysenne.

Lark looked at her.

Then she looked away. Past her. Past the chair. Past the anvil. Past the threads of light. Across the white floor of the Heart to the edge, where the glass road ended, where the last pane hung over the white stone.

Where nothing was.

Where a breath of grey fog hung in the still air. Thin. Cold. Faint. Like your breath on a winter window.

Lark's eyebrows went up.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mam*," said Lark.

And pointed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN TURNED her head.

Slowly. The way glass turns. And looked where the small finger was pointing. At the edge of the Heart. At the last pane. At the empty air.

She looked for a long time.

Wren didn't move. Didn't breathe. Mist doesn't. She hung there in the grey and was nothing. A draught. A cold. A smudge on the air. Nothing that threw a reflection. Nothing that could be seen.

The Glass Queen's eyes were clear. Like looking through a window at a white sky.

They didn't find her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There's nobody there, little one*," said Ysenne. Gently.

"*Mam*," said Lark. Insistently. Pointing.

"*I can see everything*," said Ysenne. "*Every pane. Every face. Everything that's ever looked into anything.*" Her voice was very soft. Very sure. "*There's nobody there.*"

Lark looked at her.

Then she did a thing Wren would remember for the rest of her life.

She put both her small square hands on either side of the Glass Queen's face. On the clear cold glass. And turned it. Firmly. The way you'd turn a stubborn goat by the horns. Away from the empty air. Toward her own face.

And looked at her. Very hard. From six inches away.

"*Mam*," said Lark. Slowly. Clearly. As if to an idiot. "*There.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE WENT VERY STILL.

Under the small square hands. With her glass face turned. Looking into the eyes of a child of twenty months who glowed in the dark.

And Wren saw something happen to the glass.

Not a crack. Not yet. Something smaller. A blur. A breath. As if someone very close had sighed on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You can see her*," said the Glass Queen. Very quietly.

"*Mam*," said Lark.

"*I can't*."

Lark frowned. As if that were a ridiculous thing to say. As if anybody could see her mam, if they'd just look.

"*I can't*," said Ysenne again. Her voice had changed. Something in it had gone thin. "*I can see every face in the world. I can't see her. I can't see—*"

She stopped.

The small hands were still on her face.

"*Who are you looking at*?" said the Glass Queen. Barely a whisper. "*Little one. Right now. When you look at me. What do you see?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK CONSIDERED HER.

Seriously. With her eyebrows. For a long time. The way she considered a new food, or a strange dog, or the question of whether a fire was hot.

Then she took her hands away from the glass face.

And said, very firmly, the only answer she had—

"*No*."

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BLUR WENT OFF the glass.

The Glass Queen sat in the chair of the Root with the net bent round her and a child in her lap, and her face was clear again. Cold. Clear. Like a window.

But her hands, on either side of the child, were shaking.

"*Midsummer*," said Ysenne. To nobody. To the net. To the crown. "*Midsummer, and then you'll see. Everyone will see. Everyone will look. And I'll be in every pane.*"

She lifted her head.

And spoke to the edge of the Heart. To the last pane. To the empty air where a breath of grey fog hung, and did not throw a reflection, and could not be seen.

"*Mistwalker*," said Ysenne. Not loudly. Not cruelly. Tiredly. "*I can't see you. Not when you're mist. I couldn't on the lantern line, until you stopped to look at yourself. I can't now.*"

Wren didn't move.

"*But she can*," said the Glass Queen. "*So you might as well come and sit down. It's a long time till dawn. And I'd like her to stop pointing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HUNG IN THE grey.

She thought about it. For a long time. About everything she'd decided. About mist and reflections and *YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE* and Posy Tull on her knees. About the glass road and the panes and the face of a red-haired girl in a bucket.

She thought: *she can't see me*.

She thought: *if I come out, she'll see me in every pane in the world*.

She thought: *my daughter's pointing at me*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME OUT.

Not all at once. Slowly. The way the fog comes off a field in the morning and leaves a hedge behind. Grey, thinning. And under it, a woman. Barefoot. In a shirt and leggings. With a fox-red braid down her back and three flesh fingers on her right hand and two gold fingers and a gold thumb on her left.

Standing on the white floor of the Heart.

At the edge of the net.

Throwing a reflection in every pane in the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK SHRIEKED.

Pure joy. The big belly-laugh. The one that came up out of her like water out of a spring. She scrambled down out of the Glass Queen's lap—Ysenne didn't stop her—and tumbled down the seven steps on her bottom, one at a time, bump, bump, bump, the way she went down the stairs at the Forge, and got up at the bottom and ran.

Across the white floor. Through the threads of the net. Glowing.

Into Wren's arms.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WENT DOWN ON her knees.

And held her.

And held her.

And over her daughter's head, over the black hair sticking up at the back, she looked up the seven steps at the Glass Queen in the chair of the Root.

Ysenne was looking at her.

Really looking. For the first time. With her clear glass eyes. At a woman on her knees on the white floor, with a child in her arms, both of them throwing a reflection in every pane in the world.

Wren waited for it. For the cold. For the panel. For her own face, five-fingered, the best bow in Thistledown, screaming out of the air at her. *YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE.*

It didn't come.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Sit down, Mistwalker*," said the Glass Queen. Very quietly. "*Please.*" She looked at the child in Wren's arms. "*I'm not going to hurt either of you. I never wanted to hurt anyone. I only wanted—*"

She stopped.

She looked down at her own hands. Clear. Glass. Shaking.

"*At dawn*," said Ysenne, "*she'll put her hand on the anvil. And the net will take her. And I'll pick up the crown for her and hold it till she's grown.*

And everyone will be safe. And kept. And still. Forever." Her voice was very steady. "*You can hold her till then. I'd like you to. She's happier.*"

"*She'll say no*," said Wren.

"*I know*," said Ysenne. "*She always does.*"

She leaned back in the white chair. In the middle of the still net. With the crown on the anvil beside her, warm and gold and empty.

"*That's why it has to be her hand*," said the Glass Queen. "*And not her answer.*"

CHAPTER 28

The River

ANTHO HAD CALLED THE Ferryman three times in his life.

The first time he'd been nineteen, and mad, and dying, and hadn't known what he was doing. He'd been lying in a ditch on the Blightmarch road with the thing in his chest eating him from the inside, and he'd said *please* into the dark, not to anyone, and a lantern had come up the road with a hooded man under it, and looked down at him, and said, in a voice like water over stones, *not you*. *Not yet.* And gone away.

The second time he'd been twenty-four, and sane, mostly, and had known exactly what he was doing. He'd stood on the threshold of the Hollowmaw with a stone in his hand, a flat grey stone from a lake beyond the Teeth, and paid it. The memory of it. Five skips. His father counting.

The third time he'd been twenty-six, and it had been the night of the Heart, and the old man had come without being asked.

He'd never called him for somebody else.

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"*You'll need a threshold*," said Seraphine.

In the Forge. At two in the morning. The night after the mill-pond. With her horn spectacles on her nose and her hand flat on her belly and her face so white the freckles stood out like spatters of ink.

"*I know*," said Antho.

"*A real one. Not a doorway. A threshold. Something that's an edge.*" She was talking fast. She talked fast when she was frightened. "*He comes to the edge. He's always at the edge. That's what he is. The edge between—*"

"*I know*," said Antho.

He took her face in his hands.

"*I know, love*," he said. Gently. "*I'm the Threshold Warden. I've been standing on edges all my life.*"

She looked at him. Her eyes were wet behind the horn.

"*Come back*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*I've got four hundred and twelve reasons written down. I'll start a new list. I'll have four hundred and thirteen by the time you're home.*"

"*What's the four hundred and thirteenth*?"

"*It's going to be born in August*," said Seraphine. "*And it'll want to meet you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY USED THE FORGE doors.

The great doors at the end of the long hall. Oak, iron-bound, twelve feet high, onto the yard. They weren't a real threshold. Not the kind the Ferryman liked. But they were the oldest doors in Ashbourne—older than the Forge, older than the twenty anvils, older than Brannoc, who said they'd been hung by his grandfather's grandfather and had been opened every morning since at dawn—and they'd seen a great deal go in and out.

Antho stood in them.

In the middle. With one foot on the flags of the hall and one on the cinders of the yard. With the lantern in his hand.

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IT WASN'T HIS LANTERN. His had gone east, with the five hundred and fifty-six, to ring the pool. This one was Seren's. The clay lamp. Wenna's lamp. The little brown lamp, cracked across the lip, that she'd carried through thirteen years in the dark and given away at the end, and that had somehow come back to her, the way lamps did with Harrow women.

She'd put it in his hands an hour ago without a word.

He held it out. Into the dark of the yard. Into the night.

And said the name.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D NEVER TOLD ANYONE the name. Not Seraphine. Not Lex. Not Pim. It wasn't a secret, exactly. It was just that it wasn't the kind of thing you said in daylight. It was an old name. Older than the net. Older than the Wells. Older than the drowned city. The name the first people had called him by, when they first stood on a riverbank at night and watched someone they loved go out across the water and not come back.

It meant *the one who rows*.

Antho said it into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOTHING HAPPENED.

For a long time.

Behind him, in the long hall, he could hear them waiting. Lex, on a bench by the great hearth, with his ribs strapped and his burned hands in wet cloths and his face grey. Rhosyn beside him, with her own hands bound up in white linen to the wrists, both palms cut to the bone, blood coming through. His mother. Brannoc. Kestrel. Tilda. Seraphine.

And in the corner by the apple wood door, enormous, gold, sitting on the flags with his back to the wall and a petal in his hand, the King.

Nobody said anything.

Antho held the lamp out into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE COLD CAME.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME THE WAY it always came. Up from the ground. Through the soles of his feet. Into his ankles. The cold of wet stone. The cold of a cellar where something has been kept too long. And the smell. River-weed. Mud. The flat grey smell of water that has never seen the sun.

The yard went grey.

Not the grey of the grey country. Not *still*. A different grey. A moving grey. Like mist coming up off a river at dusk. It came up out of the cinders and rolled across the yard, low, knee-high, and the stars over Ashbourne went dim, and the lantern ring round the village went faint and far away, as if seen through water.

And out of the mist, at the bottom of the yard, where the stream had run before Lex turned it—

A light.

Low. Gold. Swinging. As if somebody were carrying it up from the water.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN STOPPED AT the edge of the cinders.

Tall. Grey. Hooded. Robed. His face in shadow under the hood, always in shadow, so that you saw only the line of a jaw, old, and the glint of something that might have been an eye. He held his lantern in one long grey hand.

He looked at Antho in the doorway.

"*Warden*," said the Ferryman.

"*Ferryman*."

"*You called*."

"*Yes*."

The hood tilted. Very slightly.

"*Nobody's dying*," said the Ferryman. "*Not here. Not tonight.*" A pause. "*I checked.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I need to cross*," said Antho.

The Ferryman was silent.

"*Not to the far shore*," said Antho. "*Down. Down the river. To the Heart.*" He swallowed. "*Like before. Like the night of the Heart. You took us down then.*"

"*I did*."

"*She's got my brother's daughter*," said Antho. "*The Glass Queen. She took her through the mill-pond. She's at the Heart, in the chair, and at dawn on Midsummer she'll put the child's hand on the anvil and the net will take her for a Root.*" His voice cracked. He let it. "*And my brother's wife went after her. Alone. Through the glass.*"

The Ferryman didn't move.

"*Please*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LANTERN IN THE Ferryman's hand flickered.

Not the way a flame flickers in a draught. The way a person shifts their weight when they've been listening to a conversation and have something to say.

[Excuse me,] said the flame. Small. Dry. Courteous. *[I don't mean to interrupt.]*

Behind Antho, in the hall, something went over with a crash. A bench. Antho didn't turn round. He knew what it was. He knew who'd stood up so fast he'd knocked it over, with his ribs strapped and his hands burned.

[But did you say the Heart?] said the flame in the Ferryman's lantern. *[The Heart of the net? Where the old anvil is?]* A pause. Interested. *[I've read about it. I'd very much like to see it. For my book.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN LOOKED DOWN at his lantern.

For a long time.

Then he looked up. Past Antho. Into the hall. At the man standing by the great hearth with the bench on its side behind him and his face—

Antho didn't look. He didn't need to.

"*It doesn't know him*," said the Ferryman. Quietly. To Antho. Not unkindly. "*You understand that. The price was its love. All of it. It remembers everything it ever learned. Every word it read. Every Well. Every forge. It remembers your father and your mother and the net and the nine hundred years.*" A pause. "*It doesn't remember why any of it mattered. It doesn't remember him.*"

"*I know*," said Antho.

"*It'll be polite to him*," said the Ferryman. "*It's always polite. It'll ask him questions.*" The hood turned. Toward the hall. "*It'll break his heart.*"

"*It's already broken*," said Antho.

The Ferryman was silent.

Then he did something Antho had never seen him do. In three callings. In a ditch, on a threshold, at the Heart.

He sighed.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Four*," said the Ferryman.

"*Four*?"

"*Four can cross*." The hood turned. Looking. Into the hall. At each of them. Slowly. As if he could see through them. As if he were reading them like a list. "*The boat holds four and me.*"

His gaze stopped on the King.

Sitting on the flags by the apple wood door. Gold. Enormous. With his back to the wall and his knees drawn up and a white petal in his gold hand.

"*Not you*," said the Ferryman. "*Still not you.*"

"*No*," agreed the King. Quietly. He got up. Slowly. The flags under him going gold in a circle. "*But I'm coming anyway.*" He looked at the Ferryman across the length of the hall. "*She's my sister. And she's got a little girl who told me no. And I owe them both.*"

The Ferryman looked at him for a long time.

"*You're not on my list*," said the Ferryman.

"*I know*," said the King. "*That's why there's room in the boat.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SO IT WAS FOUR.

Antho. Because he'd called. Because he was the Warden. Because he'd been down the river before, and knew the way, and had promised a girl a light once and kept it.

Lex. Because nobody could have stopped him. Brannoc tried. Brannoc stood in front of him by the great hearth, a foot shorter and thirty years older, with his gold fingertips on Lex's chest, and said *you're broken, lad, you can't swing a hammer with your ribs like that*, and Lex looked down at him and said *I'm not going to swing a hammer*, and Brannoc looked at his face for a long time and then stepped aside.

Rhosyn. Because Ysy was her sister. Because she'd seen her face under the water, for a heartbeat, on the bank of the mill-pond, with her hands round the glass wrist—and something had gone across the cut-jewel face that wasn't cold. Because Rhosyn was the only one who knew what it was.

Someone looking back, she'd said to Seren. In the spring. *Who says yes*.

And the King. Because he wasn't on the list.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN GAVE LEX THE basket.

At the door. In the dark. With the mist rolling round her ankles. The old willow basket, the one that had sat under the hearth at Harrow all winter with the pieces of the Key in it, and now held only one thing.

A crown.

Small. Silver-grey. Seven points. Thin. Plain. Hesper's.

"*It's got one more no in it*," said his mother. "*Wenna said so. Oz said so.*" She put it in his hands. "*Take it. In case. I don't know what for. Take it anyway.*"

Lex looked at it.

Then he gave it to the King.

The King stood very still. Holding it. A thin silver-grey crown in his huge gold hands. It didn't go gold. It sat on his palm beside the white petal, grey and plain and itself.

"*It's hers*," said Lex. "*She'd want you to have it.*"

The King's gold face did something complicated.

He didn't say anything. He just closed his hand round it. Gently. The way you'd close your hand round a moth.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOAT WAS AT the bottom of the yard.

Where the stream had been. Where Brannoc took his quench-water. Where Lark had leaned over the black still water and laughed at her grandmother's face. It was all mist now. Grey. Moving. Knee-deep. And in it, a boat. Long. Narrow. Black. Old. Low in water that wasn't there.

They got in.

Antho first. Then Rhosyn, with her bound hands held up in front of her, and Antho handing her down. Then Lex, slowly, with his teeth together and his hand on his side. Then the King.

The boat should have sunk. A gold man the size of a small cart. It didn't even rock.

The Ferryman stepped into the stern. Set his lantern on the post. Took up the long oar.

And pushed off.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE YARD WENT AWAY.

Not behind them. Around them. The cinders, the Forge, the great doors with his mother standing in them holding the clay lamp—Seraphine beside her—Brannoc behind—all of it went grey, and faint, and far, like a picture seen through water, and then wasn't there.

There was only the mist. And the boat. And the long oar going in and out. And the lantern on its post.

And the river.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HAD BEEN DOWN it before.

He knew what it looked like. He'd been ready. Grey water, flat, slow, under a grey sky that wasn't a sky. Grey banks, far off, with grey shapes on them. Dead. Drifting. Waiting. The river of the dead, going down from the world to the far shore and the dark, slow, forever.

It didn't look like that now.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS FULL.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DEAD WERE EVERYWHERE.

On the banks. In the mist. In the water. Not drifting, not waiting. Moving. All of them. In one direction. Upriver. Against the current. Grey columns of dust, thousands, tens of thousands, walking on the water and along the banks and through the mist, slowly, patiently, the way they'd drifted east across the snow toward Mal in the winter.

Going home.

"*Where are they going*?" said Rhosyn. Very quietly. Looking at them.

"*East*," said Antho. "*To Mal. To the pool.*" He watched them go past. A woman with a child. An old man. Two that might have been brothers. "*He's big enough now. Since you. Since the cousins. They can feel it. All the way down here.*" His throat was tight. "*They've been waiting nine hundred years for somewhere to go.*"

[How fascinating,] said the lantern on the post.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HADN'T SAID ANYTHING.

He sat in the bow of the boat. As far from the stern as it was possible to be. With his back to the lantern. With his strapped ribs and his wrapped hands and his face turned to the mist.

Antho sat beside him.

He didn't say anything either. He'd learned that much. From Pim. From Seren. From the dead. Sometimes you didn't say anything. Sometimes you just sat beside someone in a boat.

[I wonder,] said the lantern. Behind them. Politely. To the boat in general. *[If someone could tell me about the anvil. At the Heart. I've read that it was the first anvil. The one the net was forged on. Is that right?]*

Nobody answered.

[Only I'm writing a book,] said the lantern. Apologetically. *[Volume Three. The Book of What Is. I've been trying to describe the world as it actually is, rather than as it was, and I find there's a great deal I don't know.]* A pause. *[I knew it all once, I think. I remember knowing it. I just don't remember why I wanted to.]*

Lex's hands closed. In the wet cloths. Slowly.

"*It was the first anvil*," said Lex.

His voice was very rough. He didn't turn round.

"*Aurelian forged the net on it*," he said. To the mist. "*Nine hundred years ago. With a hammer his father gave him. His little brother held the tongs. He made the threads one at a time. Ten thousand of them. He was trying to save everyone.*"

[Ah,] said the lantern. Pleased. *[Thank you. That's very helpful.]* A pause. *[How do you know?]*

"*I've got his hammer*," said Lex.

[Have you really?] Delighted. *[How marvellous. Are you a smith?]*

Lex didn't answer.

Antho looked at his brother's face. And looked away.

◆ ◆ ◆

[I'm sorry,] said the lantern. After a while. Quieter. *[I think I've said something wrong.]*

"*No*," said Lex.

[Only you sound sad. And I don't know you, so I can't think what I've done. But you sound as though I've done something.]

"*You haven't*," said Lex.

[Are you sure?]

Lex turned round.

Slowly. On the bench in the bow. With his ribs grating. And looked down the length of the boat, past Antho, past Rhosyn, past the King's broad gold back, to the stern. To the post. To the lantern. To the small gold flame inside it, dry and courteous and curious, flickering.

"*You used to say good morning to me*," said Lex.

The flame went still.

"*Every morning*," said Lex. "*For seven years. Since I was nineteen. Since the day I Kindled and you woke up in my chest. You said good morning. And I said it back.*" His voice was very steady. Antho had never heard it so steady. "*You called me boy. You called me idiot. You read every book in the Spire and told me about them while I was trying to sleep. You went away twice and came back twice. You were with me at the Heart.*" A breath. "*And you paid a price for me at the Veil, in the winter, and now you don't know me. And that's all right. It was your price. You chose it.*"

The flame didn't move.

"*So you haven't done anything wrong*," said Lex. "*I just miss you. That's all.*"

He turned back round. To the mist.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOAT WENT ON.

Nobody said anything for a long time.

The dead went past them, upriver, in their thousands. The long oar went in and out. The lantern on the post burned, small and gold.

Then, very quietly, so quietly that Antho almost didn't hear it over the water—

[Good morning,] said the lantern.

Lex didn't turn round.

His shoulders shook.

[I don't know why I said that,] said the lantern. Puzzled. Almost to itself. *[It isn't morning. Is it? I don't think there are mornings here.]* A pause. *[It just seemed like the right thing to say.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN DIDN'T SAY anything.

But Antho, looking back past the King at the stern of the boat, saw him. Standing at the oar. With his hooded face turned not to the river, the way it always was, but down. To the lantern on the post. To the flame.

Looking at it.

For a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DROWNED COUNTRY CAME at what might have been midnight.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW IT FIRST. He'd seen it before. Towers in the mist. Roofs. Domes. Grey. Enormous. Old. A city, under water that wasn't water, along both banks of the river, going away into the grey as far as you could see.

The city before the Lattice. Before the Wells were tapped. Drowned in the Hollow when the first Hollow was made, before Mal was Mal, when the seventh Well was a hunger at the bottom of the world.

Its streets were full of dead.

Thousands. Grey. Drifting. They'd always drifted. That was what the Drowned Country was. A city full of people who'd been drowned so long ago they'd forgotten what drowning was, drifting in their streets like smoke, forever.

They weren't drifting now.

They were walking.

East. Upriver. Out of their streets. Down to the banks. Onto the water. In their thousands. Joining the others. Going home.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Stop*," said Antho.

The Ferryman looked at him.

"*Please*," said Antho. "*Just for a moment. Like before.*"

The Ferryman didn't say anything. But the long oar went in, and held, and the boat slowed, and turned, and slid in to the bank under the shadow of a grey tower. Against a grey stair. Going up.

Antho got out.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNEW THE WAY.

Up the stair. Along a grey street. Under an arch. Through a market where grey stalls stood under grey awnings that had been rotting for longer than the world had had a name. Past a fountain, dry, grey, with a grey stone fish on top that had once spouted water for children who'd been dead for ten thousand years.

To a square.

Small. Grey. Paved. With grey houses round it, and a grey tree in the middle, dead, leafless, its branches like cracks in the sky.

And round the tree, in a circle, on the paving stones—

Six lanterns.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE STILL BURNING.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOPPED AT THE edge of the square.

He'd brought them here two years ago. Three. He'd lost count. On the night of the Heart. Six lanterns from the Keep, tin and horn, plain. He'd set them down round the dead tree where he'd found her. A little grey girl. Drifting in the street. Who'd held his sleeve. He'd lit them, and she'd come, and stood in the middle of them, and held his sleeve again. And at the Heart, when the eaten worlds rose, she'd gone up. Gold. Into the light.

He'd never come back.

He'd thought about it. Every year. On the night of the Heart. He'd sat on the wall at the Keep and thought about six lanterns in a grey square in a drowned city, going out one by one, with nobody to see.

They hadn't gone out.

They were burning. All six. Small. Gold. Steady. In the grey. The only colour in the Drowned Country.

And round them—

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SQUARE WAS FULL.

Dead. Grey. Hundreds. Standing round the six lanterns. Close. Bending. Not drifting. Not walking. Just standing, the way people stand round a fire on a cold night. Holding out hands that weren't hands any more. Warming themselves.

They'd been here for years. He could tell. The way they stood. The way they'd worn a ring in the grey dust of the paving round the lanterns, with their not-feet, over and over, a hundred thousand times. Coming. Going. Coming back.

Six lanterns.

Given.

And every grey ghost in the Drowned Country had found them.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOOD AT THE edge of the square and cried.

He didn't mean to. It just came. Up out of his chest. Out of the place where the Murmur had lived, where the thing that ate him had lived, where there was room now, and quiet, and Shade, and a little grey girl's hand on his sleeve.

He stood there and cried, and the dead turned round, all of them, and looked at him. Grey faces. Faces that had forgotten they were faces.

And one by one, they bent.

Toward him. The way the bread-woman's dust had bent toward Pim. The way the dead at the rim bent toward Antho every morning when he counted the lanterns.

The way you bend to someone across a room to say *thank you*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THEY TURNED.

All of them. At once. Away from the lanterns. Toward the edge of the square. Toward the street. Toward the river.

East.

And went.

Not drifting. Walking. Past him. On either side. A long grey river of the dead, flowing out of the square and down the street and down the stair to the water, to join the others. To go home. To Mal.

They'd waited. Antho understood. Watching them go. They'd waited here, round six small lights, for years. In the cold. In the grey. Because it was warm here. Because somebody had come back with a light, once, the way he'd promised. And they hadn't wanted to leave it.

Now they had somewhere better to go.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SQUARE EMPTIED.

The six lanterns burned on. Round the dead tree. Small and gold and steady. With nobody round them.

Antho went and stood in the middle of them.

He didn't pick them up. He didn't put them out. He just stood there. In the warm. Where she'd stood.

"*Thank you*," he said. To the lanterns. To the square. To the girl who wasn't there any more. "*For keeping them warm.*"

He felt something on his sleeve.

He looked down.

There was nothing there.

He went back to the boat.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RIVER WENT DOWN.

Past the Drowned Country. Out of it. The towers falling away behind them into the mist. The dead going past them the other way, upriver, thousands, home. The oar going in and out.

And the mist began to thin.

And under it—

Light.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW IT FIRST.

Far ahead. At the bottom of the river. Where the grey water went down into the dark and the dark went down into something that wasn't dark.

Gold.

And white. And ten thousand threads of light, every colour, rising out of the ground like steam off a pond at dawn. Going up. Away. To the world.

Not moving.

Still.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HEART.

Antho had been here before. Once. On the worst night of his life and the best. He'd stood on that white floor with his brother and his father and the eaten worlds rising round them in gold.

It looked smaller now. And colder. And emptier. A round white hall with no roof, at the bottom of the world. Seven steps. A gold anvil. A crown on it. A white chair.

And in the chair—

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ysy*," said Rhosyn.

Very softly. From the middle of the boat. With her bound hands in her lap.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN SAT in the chair of the Root.

Clear. White. Still. Like a frost on a window. With the net bent round her like a bower of light. With her glass hands on the arms of the chair. With her eyes closed.

And on the seven steps below her, on the third step, in the middle—

A woman.

Sitting. Barefoot. In a shirt and leggings. With a fox-red braid down her back.

And in her lap, asleep, with one fist wound in her mother's shirt and the other in her mouth, glowing faintly gold in the white light of the Heart—

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX MADE A SOUND.

Antho had never heard it before. Not from his brother. Not from anyone. A sound like iron cracking in a quench. Like something that had been held at heat for far too long, plunged into water, and broken.

He was on his feet. In the bow. With his ribs strapped and his hands wrapped and his face—

The boat didn't rock.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LOOKED UP.

From the third step. Across the white floor. Across the threads of the net. Down to the river. To the boat. To the man standing in the bow.

She didn't move. She didn't call out. She had her daughter asleep in her lap and her arms round her.

She just looked at him.

And Antho saw her mouth move. One word. Across the whole of the Heart.

Hammer.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOAT TOUCHED THE shore.

White stone. The edge of the Heart. Where the grey river ran in on one side and out on the other. The Ferryman held it there with the long oar. Steady.

Nobody moved.

Then the King stood up.

Slowly. Huge. Gold. In the middle of the boat. With the thin silver-grey crown in one hand and the white petal in the other.

He stepped out onto the white floor of the Heart.

And the white floor didn't go gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STARED AT IT.

At the King's foot. On the white stone. The way the snow had gone gold under him, and the flags of the Forge, and the gold path under Old

Mag's tree. The way everything he'd stood on for nine hundred years had gone gold.

The white stone stayed white.

The King looked down at it too.

Then he looked up. Across the white floor. Up the seven steps. Past Wren and the sleeping child. To the chair. To the clear glass woman in it with her eyes closed.

"*Ysy*," said Oszric. Very gently. The way a big brother says a little sister's name when he's come to fetch her home from somewhere she shouldn't be. "*It's nearly dawn. Come down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN OPENED her eyes.

They were clear. Like looking through a window at a white sky.

She looked down at her brother. Standing gold on the white floor of the Heart with a crown in one hand and a flower in the other. At her sister, getting out of a boat with her hands bound up in bloody linen. At the smith in the bow, broken, burning. At the Warden. At the Ferryman, at the oar, with the small gold flame on its post.

At the child asleep on the steps below her.

"*No*," said Ysenne.

And somewhere up above them—far up, through the grey water and the drowned city and the glass road, in the world, at the edge of everything—

The sky began, very faintly, to go pale.

CHAPTER 29

The Heart

LEX HAD BEEN HERE before.

He'd sat in that chair.

Not for long. A day. Less. On the night of the Heart, at the bottom of the world, with his father beside him and his brother below and the eaten worlds rising round them in gold. He'd sat in the white chair with the net in his hands, ten thousand threads, every Kindling, every panel, every hand in the world, and felt all of it. The weight. The warmth. The pull.

Hold it, the net had said. Not in words. In the hum. *Hold it. Keep it. It's yours.*

And he'd let go.

He'd thought, at the time, that it was the hardest thing he would ever do.

He'd been wrong about that too.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE GOT OUT OF the boat.

His ribs screamed. He let them. He stepped off the black wood onto the white stone of the Heart, and it was cold under his boots, and smooth, and old, and it hummed. Faintly. The way it had hummed the first time. The way a bell hums for a long time after it's been struck.

Except it didn't. That was the thing. It should have hummed. It had hummed the first time like a hive. It was silent now.

Still.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED ACROSS THE floor.

Through the threads. Ten thousand of them. Rising out of the stone round him like the bars of a cage made of light. Silver. Gold. Blue. Every colour there was. Taut. Unmoving. He walked between them and they didn't bend toward him the way they'd bent when he was Root. They didn't do anything. They hung there, held, like the strings of a harp with a hand flat across them.

He didn't look at the chair.

He didn't look at the anvil, or the crown on it, or the clear glass woman sitting beside it with the whole net bent round her like a bower.

He looked at the third step.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STOOD UP.

Slowly. With Lark on her hip. Asleep. Heavy. With one fist wound in Wren's shirt and the other in her mouth.

She came down the steps. Two of them. And stood on the white floor at the bottom. And waited for him.

He stopped in front of her.

He didn't know what to say. He'd thought about it all the way down the river. All the way past the Drowned Country. He'd thought about what he'd say to her, and every word had been wrong, and he'd thrown them all away.

He stood there. Broken. Burned. With his hands in wet cloths and his ribs strapped and his face—

"*You took your time*," said Wren.

Her voice cracked right down the middle.

He put his arms round both of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WOKE UP.

Squashed between them. Crushed. Outraged. She took her fist out of her mouth and pushed at his chest with both hands, the way she always did when she was held too tight, and opened her mouth to complain—

And saw who it was.

"*DA*," shrieked Lark.

The whole of the Heart rang with it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW HOW long they stood there.

The three of them. At the bottom of the seven steps. In the middle of the net. With Lark's fists in his hair and her face in his neck, talking—*Da, Da, Mam, Gan, no, no, Da, wa'er, Gan*—a long furious babble about everything that had happened to her, none of which he could understand and all of which he understood perfectly.

Wren had her forehead against his shoulder. Shaking.

He held them.

Behind him, he heard Antho get out of the boat. And Rhosyn. He heard the King's heavy tread on the white stone, stopping at the bottom of the steps. He heard the long oar of the Ferryman go in the water and hold.

He didn't let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She didn't hurt us*," said Wren. Into his shirt. Low. Fast. "*She didn't. She carried her all the way down. She sang to her. She let me hold her.*" A breath. "*Lex, she's going to do it anyway. At dawn. She's going to put Lark's hand on the anvil. She says it doesn't matter what Lark says. She says it's the hand the net wants and not the answer.*"

"*I know*," said Lex.

"*How do you know*?"

"*Because I sat there*," said Lex. "*Once.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*."

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED UP.

The Glass Queen was watching him from the chair.

Not moving. Not standing. Sitting as she'd sat for four months. Clear. Still. With her long glass hands on the white arms of the chair and the net bent round her and her face like a frost on a window.

She looked down at him across seven steps. At the three of them. At the child in his arms.

"*You're hurt*," said Ysenne.

"*Yes*."

"*Your reflection did that*."

"*Yes*."

"*I didn't tell it to*," said the Glass Queen. "*I want you to know that. I only showed it what you are. What you looked like, in the spring, for one heartbeat, when I showed you the crown.*" Her clear eyes didn't blink. "*It did the rest itself. It was you.*"

"*It was the bit of me that wanted it*," said Lex.

"*Yes*."

"*Then it wasn't me*," said Lex. "*Not all of me. Not even most.*"

The Glass Queen looked at him for a long time.

"*That's what everyone says*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ysy*."

The King. At the bottom of the steps. Huge. Gold. With a white petal in one hand and a thin silver-grey crown in the other. Standing on the white floor of the Heart, and the white floor staying white under him.

"*Ysy*," he said again. Gently. "*Come down.*"

The Glass Queen turned her head.

Slowly. The way glass turns. And looked at her brother.

For the first time since the boat, Lex saw something move in the clear face. Not a crack. A shift. Like light going across ice when a cloud moves off the sun.

"*Oz*," she said.

"*Come down*," said the King. "*Please. It's nearly dawn. You've been sitting there four months. You must be tired.*"

"*I'm always tired*," said Ysenne. "*I've been tired for nine hundred years.*"

"*I know*."

"*You don't*." Her voice was very quiet. Very clear. Like a bell under ice. "*You don't know, Oz. You had them. Your household. Nine thousand of them. Walking behind you down the road. Looking at you. All day. Every*

day. For nine hundred years. Every face turned toward you." Her glass hands tightened on the arms of the chair. *"Caddoc had his thread. His mountain. Rosie had her roses, her tower, her little grey boy. You all had something that looked back."*

The King didn't say anything.

"I had glass," said Ysenne. *"Every pane in the world. Every face. Every one of them looking into me. And none of them seeing me. Not one."* A pause. *"I walked through every mirror in the world for nine hundred years, Oz, and I never saw my own face. Not once. Not since the pool."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"I know," said Rhosyn.

Beside the King. At the bottom of the steps. With her bound hands held in front of her, the linen dark with blood. Forty years old. Barefoot. With thorns in her hair.

"I know, Ysy," said Rhosyn. *"Oz told me. In the winter. About the mirror."*

The Glass Queen didn't look at her.

Lex saw it. Saw the glass face turn—not toward Rhosyn, but away. Very slightly. A quarter-inch. The way you turn away from a light that's too bright. The way a child turns her face away when you try to make her look at you after she's done something wrong.

"Ysy," said Rhosyn. *"Look at me."*

"No," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

"It's nearly dawn," said Ysenne.

She stood up.

The net moved with her. All of it. Ten thousand threads, rising, bending, following her as she rose out of the white chair, like a gown with a train a thousand miles long. The whole Heart shifted. The light changed. Lex felt it in his feet. In his teeth. In the strapped ribs. A pressure. A cold.

She came down the steps.

One. Two. Three.

Lex didn't move. Wren didn't move. Lark, between them, went quiet. Stopped babbling. Turned her head on his shoulder and looked at the woman coming down the steps toward them.

Her eyebrows came down.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN STOPPED on the bottom step.

A yard away. Close enough to touch. She was taller than Lex had thought. Taller than him. Clear and cold and beautiful in the way a frost on a window is beautiful. And up close, he could see—

Faces.

In her. Under the surface of the glass. Faint. Moving. Thousands. Millions. Every face that had ever looked into anything. Drifting under her skin like fish under ice. A woman brushing her hair. A boy in a puddle. A soldier. A girl in a spoon.

All of them. In her. Looking out.

None of them her own.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Give her to me, smith*," said Ysenne.

"*No*."

"*She'll be safe*," said the Glass Queen. "*I promise you. I don't lie. I've never lied. Not once in nine hundred years. Ask Rosie. Ask Oz.*" Her clear eyes were on Lark. "*She'll put her hand on the anvil and the net will take her. And she'll be Root. And I'll hold the crown for her. I'll sit in the chair. I'll be regent. Until she's grown.*" A pause. "*She'll never be hurt. Never be ill. Never be old. She'll never die. Nobody will. Nobody in the whole world. The grey will stop. The edge will close. And everyone will be kept. Safe. Still.*" Her voice didn't shake. "*Forever.*"

"*And everyone will look at you*," said Lex.

The Glass Queen went very still.

"*That's it*," said Lex. "*Isn't it? That's the bit you left out.*" He held his daughter tighter. "*You'll be in every pane. Every panel. Every Stone. The net will show everyone what they are, and keep them that, and they'll stand in front of their panels forever. Looking. At you.*"

"*Yes*," said Ysenne.

She didn't deny it. She never lied.

"*And it won't help*," said Lex. "*They'll look at you. Every face in the world. And they'll see themselves. Not you. Never you. That's what glass is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMETHING WENT ACROSS THE glass face.

Fast. Gone. Lex saw it. He didn't know what it was.

"*Give her to me*," said Ysenne again. Quieter.

"*No*."

The Glass Queen looked at him. For a long moment.

"*Then I'm sorry*," she said. And meant it.

And lifted her hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

Experience: STILL.

YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME UP OUT of the floor.

Out of the white stone. Out of the threads. Out of the net, all of it, every strand, ten thousand of them, all at once. It came into his feet and up his legs and into his chest and his arms and his face. Cold. Clear. The cold of the long mirror. The cold that remembers.

And a panel opened in front of him.

Silver-blue. Hanging in the white air of the Heart.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
Experience: STILL

YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE
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◆ ◆ ◆

AND HE SAW HIMSELF.

Not in the panel. Around it. In the air. In the light. In every thread of the net, as if every one of them had become a pane of glass. A man. Broken. Burned. Holding a child. Standing at the foot of seven steps with his arms round his wife and his daughter.

Stopped.

Exactly as he was. This moment. This breath. Every hair. Every burn. Every crack in his ribs. Kept. The way a beetle is kept in amber. The way the gold kept Ilda.

He couldn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TRIED.

He reached. Down. Round the net. Past it. To the Wells. To the heat. To the slow patient deep of the earth. The way he'd learned to do since Midwinter. Hand over hand. Climbing.

Nothing came.

Not slowly. Not at all. There was no *down* any more. No *round*. There was only the cold, and the panel, and the reflection of himself in every thread of light, held. He was a man in a picture of a man. He was what he was.

He couldn't even close his eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

BESIDE HIM, WREN WAS still.

He could see her out of the side of his eye. Frozen. With her arms round Lark. With her face turned toward the Glass Queen and her mouth open on a word she'd never finish. Her gold fingers. Her red braid. A panel in front of her, silver-blue.

WREN ASHDOWN. MISTWALKER. Lv 73. YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE.

Behind him—he couldn't turn, but he knew—Antho. Rhosyn. The King. The Ferryman in his boat, perhaps. Perhaps not. Perhaps the Ferryman was the only thing in the Heart the net didn't reach.

Everyone else. Still.

◆ ◆ ◆

EXCEPT LARK.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS SQUIRMING.

Between them. In the circle of his frozen arm and Wren's. Pushing at his chest. Wriggling. Kicking. The way she always did when she was held too tight. As if nothing were wrong. As if her mam and da had just gone a bit stiff and stupid and she wanted to get down.

There was no panel in front of her.

Of course there wasn't. She was twenty months old. She'd never Kindled. She'd never stood in front of a Stone and had the net look at her. She had no class. No level. No experience. Nothing for the net to hold.

She wasn't anything it knew how to keep.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN BENT down.

Slowly. Carefully. With the net bending round her. And put her long glass hands round the small squirming body.

And lifted.

Out of Lex's arms. Out of Wren's. They didn't stop her. They couldn't. They stood there, still, held, a man and a woman in a picture, and their arms stayed in the shape of the child they'd been holding, round nothing.

Lark screamed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THE LOUDEST sound Lex had ever heard.

He'd heard a lot of loud things. A Well screaming. The lid lifting off the world. The Veil falling like a cloth. A dragon's thunder. Nothing like this. This was a small girl who'd been taken away from her mam and da twice in two days by the same cold lady, and had had enough. It went up through the Heart, through the still threads, up through the grey water and the drowned city, and it didn't stop. It went on and on and on.

The Glass Queen held her. Against her glass shoulder. Gently. Firmly.

"*I know*," said Ysenne. "*I know. I'm sorry. I know.*"

She turned.

And walked back up the steps.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WATCHED HER GO.

He couldn't do anything else. He couldn't move his eyes. He could only see what was in front of him. The bottom step. The second. The third. The glass woman going up them with his daughter screaming over her shoulder, small fists beating on clear glass, face red and wet and furious, reaching back. Over the shoulder. Down the steps. To him.

Da.

DA.

He couldn't even blink.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...brother...]

◆ ◆ ◆

VERY FAINT. VERY FAR. Under the floor. Under the white stone of the Heart. Under the net. Under everything.

[...brother...you're held...]

Mal.

Three hundred miles off. And further. And down. A pool in a green field with five hundred and fifty-six lanterns round it. A voice like the sound in a well when you drop a stone. Reaching up through the ground. Through the roots of the world. To here.

[...I can't take what's held...]

Lex knew. He couldn't answer.

[...but I can make room...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT.

Not in his feet. Not in his chest. In front of him. Right in front of his face. In the quarter-inch of air between his eyes and the reflection of himself in the threads.

Room.

Soft. Dark. Patient. The space in front of things. The way Pim cupped his hands in front of a gold face. The way Lex had held room between the King's hand and Old Mag's. A little pocket of nothing, right in front of

him. Not freeing him. Not unkeeping him. Just—there. A breath of space between him and what he was.

And in it, faint, a long way down—

Not fire. He couldn't reach fire. Not stone. Not tide or gale or shade or radiance. They were all round the net, and there was no round any more.

Something else.

The thing he'd felt in the Forge, in the spring, on the floor, with the Key in three pieces on the flags in front of him.

The space where something *was*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T MOVE HIS arm. He couldn't move his mouth.

But he didn't need to. The seventh Well wasn't something you reached for. It was something you made room for.

He made room.

◆ ◆ ◆

UP ON THE DAIS, the Glass Queen had reached the anvil.

She stood in front of it. Gold. Huge. Old. Plain. Worn smooth by blows struck nine hundred years ago. With the crown on its face.

She held the screaming child against her shoulder with one arm. And with the other, very gently, she took the small right hand. The square one. The hand with the wide palm and the short strong fingers that Lex's mother said was Wenna's and Brannoc said was a smith's and Wren said was Lark's and nobody else's.

And held it out over the anvil.

Lark screamed.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX FELT THE ROOM in front of him open.

Not much. A crack. The width of a hair. A thread. Between him and his reflection. Between him and *YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE*. The panel in front of him flickered. Once.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
Experience: STILL

YOU ARE WHAT YOU ARE
YOU ARE WHAT YOU AR
YOU ARE WHAT YOU
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULD MOVE HIS eyes.

He moved them. Up. To the dais. To the anvil. To the glass hand round the small one, a finger's breadth over the gold.

He could move his mouth.

"*Lark*," said Lex.

It wasn't loud. He didn't have loud in him. It came out of the crack of room in front of his face like a breath under a door.

But she heard him.

She always heard him. She'd heard him through the wall of the tool-room at night, and from across the green, and from the bottom of the yard. She heard him now. Over her own screaming. Over the whole of the Heart.

She stopped screaming.

She turned her head on the glass shoulder. And looked down the seven steps. At him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T TELL HER what to do.

He didn't say *say no*. He didn't say *don't*. He didn't say anything else at all. He had one breath of room and he'd spent it on her name.

He just looked at her.

The way you look at someone across a room to say: *I'm here*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN PRESSED the small square hand down onto the anvil.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NET WOKE UP.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OF IT. AT once. Ten thousand threads. Every one of them. Swinging. Not still now. Not held. Moving. The way the strings of a harp move when the hand is lifted off them. All of them, from every Stone and every Kindling and every panel in the world, swinging in toward the middle of the Heart, toward the dais, toward the gold anvil, toward the small square hand on its face.

Light. Pouring. Gold and silver and blue.

The hum came back.

Like a hive. Like a bell. Like a heart. It came up out of the white stone and filled the Heart and filled Lex, and it was enormous, and it was warm, and it was the net, the whole net, the whole of the world, turning toward a child of twenty months with her hand on an anvil and asking her—

◆ ◆ ◆

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ROOT CANDIDATE DETECTED
LARK — BLOOD OF THE FOUNDER

THE NET HAS NO ROOT.
WILL YOU HOLD IT?
```

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STARED AT IT.

At the panel. Gold. Hanging in the air over the anvil. Over his daughter's hand. The old gold of the Root-layer. He'd seen it before. Once. When he sat in the chair.

WILL YOU HOLD IT?

Not *ROOT ASSIGNED*. Not *CLAIMED*. Not *TAKEN*.

A question.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE UNDERSTOOD, THEN.

Standing at the foot of the steps with the crack of room in front of his face and his panel flickering. He understood something he'd never understood, in all the years since the night of the Heart.

He'd sat in that chair. With the whole net in his hands. And he'd let go.

And the net had *learned*.

It had been made by a frightened young man to take. To drink. To hold. For nine hundred years it had taken. Every Kindling, every class, every ceiling, every level—taken, held, kept. And then a smith had sat in the Root's chair and held all of it, and been asked to keep it, and opened his hands.

And it had remembered.

The net didn't take any more.

It asked.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN WAS staring at the panel too.

Lex saw her face. Saw it go—not white, it was already white. Clear. Clearer. As if something behind it had gone out.

"*No*," said Ysenne. Very softly. "*No, that's not—it doesn't ask. It's never asked. It's a net. It holds. It's for holding.*"

The panel hung there.

WILL YOU HOLD IT?

"*She's a baby*," said the Glass Queen. To the panel. To the net. Her voice rising. "*She doesn't know what she's saying. She doesn't know what it means. She says no to everything. She says no to bread. She says no to her bath. She says no to every face in the world.*" Her glass hand was shaking round the small one on the anvil. "*You can't ask her. You can't. It's the hand. It's the blood. It's the hand you want.*"

The net hummed.

The panel didn't change.

WILL YOU HOLD IT?

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK LOOKED AT IT.

At the gold panel hanging in the air in front of her face. At the gold letters she couldn't read. At the light pouring in from every direction. At the whole of the world, turning toward her, waiting.

Then she looked down the seven steps.

At her da. At her mam, frozen beside him with her arms round nothing. At her uncle. At the thorn lady with her bloody hands. At the big gold man with a flower.

Then she looked up. Over her shoulder. At the cold clear face of the Glass Queen. Six inches away.

Her square eyebrows came down.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ROOT CANDIDATE HAS DECLINED.

A ROOT CANNOT BE TAKEN.
A ROOT CAN ONLY BE GIVEN.
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◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT WENT OUT of the panel.

Not all at once. Slowly. The way a fire goes down when nobody feeds it. The threads swinging back. Away from the anvil. Away from the small hand. Out. Up. To the world. To every Stone and every Kindling and every panel. Not still. Not held. Moving. Humming. Free.

The Glass Queen's hand fell away from Lark's.

The net went past her.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OF IT. TEN thousand threads. That had bent round her for four months like a bower. That had followed her up out of the chair like a gown with a train a thousand miles long. That had held still because she held it.

They went past her.

The way water goes past a stone. The way the grey had gone round Seren's lantern. They didn't push her. They didn't throw her off. They just didn't bend toward her any more. They swung out round the dais, round

the anvil, round the clear glass woman standing in front of it with a child on her hip, and went away to the world, humming.

And the cold went out of the Heart.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX FELL OVER.

He hadn't meant to. His legs had been held for so long they'd forgotten how to hold him themselves. He went down on his knees on the white stone with a grunt and his ribs screaming. Beside him, Wren did the same. Her arms came down out of the shape of a child. She caught herself on her hands. Gasping.

Behind them, Antho swore. Rhosyn cried out. The King said nothing, but Lex heard the great gold weight of him go down on one knee.

The panel in front of Lex's face flickered.

And changed.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
Experience: 1,240,996 / 1,241,000
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◆ ◆ ◆

NOT STILL.

Numbers. Moving.

He stared at them.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE DAIS, THE Glass Queen stood in front of the anvil.

She was looking down at her own hand. The one that had held Lark's. Clear. Glass. Empty.

Lark was still on her hip. Quiet now. Hiccupping. Looking at her with enormous interest. As if wondering what the cold lady would do next.

The Glass Queen didn't do anything.

For a long time.

Then she turned. Slowly. The way glass turns. And looked down the seven steps. Past Wren. Past Antho and Rhosyn and the King. At Lex. On his knees on the white floor of the Heart, with his panel hanging in front of him, silver-blue, the numbers moving.

Four short.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Then it will have to be you*," said Ysenne.

Very quietly. Very clearly. Like a bell under ice.

"*It's a Root of the blood*," said the Glass Queen. "*It can only be given. She won't give it. She's too small to give anything.*" Her clear eyes held his. "*You're not.*"

She lifted her empty hand.

Not to freeze him. Not to still him. The net didn't bend to her any more. She lifted it the way you'd hand someone something across a table.

And somewhere in the world, four small things happened.

Four points of experience. Just four. From four Kindlings, perhaps, in four villages, where four children stood in front of four Stones that had been unchained that morning and had looked, for the first time in four months, at a panel that moved.

They went into the net. And the net, moving, humming, free, carried them where they were meant to go.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
Experience: 1,241,000 / 1,241,000

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THE PANEL WENT WHITE.

Then gold.

Then something that wasn't any colour he had a word for.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEVEL 100

THE CEILING OF TIER IV IS REACHED.
TIER V AWAITS.

THE NET HAS NO ROOT.
THE BLOOD OF THE FOUNDER IS PRESENT.
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◆ ◆ ◆

THE WHOLE OF THE Heart went quiet.

Lark stopped hiccupping. Wren, on her knees beside him, stopped breathing. Antho, Rhosyn, the King—all of them, still. Not held. Just still. The way people go still at the top of a stair when they've missed a step and haven't yet found out how far down the floor is.

On the anvil, the crown caught the light.

Gold. Seven points. Thin. Plain. No jewels.

Warm.

Empty.

Waiting.

CHAPTER 30

A Hundred

HE'D THOUGHT ABOUT IT all his life.

Not this. Not the Heart, or the anvil, or the crown. Just the number. *A hundred*. Every child in Caldor thought about it. You stood in front of the Stone at your Kindling and the panel came up and said *Lv 1*, and from that day on, somewhere in the back of your head, there was a hundred. The top. The end of the stair. The place nobody went.

He'd been nineteen. *Smith. Common. Lv 9. Cap 24*. He'd looked at that number and thought, well, that's me, then. Twenty-four. A good village smith. Brannoc's forge. Brannoc's anvil. Horseshoes and hinges and the odd ploughshare, and a fire in the evenings, and that'd be all, and that'd be fine.

He'd never once thought about a hundred.

He knelt on the white floor of the Heart with his ribs broken and his hands burned and looked at it.

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LEVEL 100

THE CEILING OF TIER IV IS REACHED.
TIER V AWAITS.

THE NET HAS NO ROOT.
THE BLOOD OF THE FOUNDER IS PRESENT.
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AND THEN, UNDER IT, slowly, the way frost spreads on a pane—

◆ ◆ ◆

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TIER V — SOVEREIGN

TAKE UP THE CROWN.
HOLD THE NET.
KEEP WHAT IS YOURS.
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◆ ◆ ◆

Sovereign.

He knew the word. He'd seen it once before. On the rubble of Duskhold, on Lantern Night, over a woman with moth-wings and a starving hollow face. *MAELIS. SOVEREIGN. TIER V.* Beautiful and empty and hungry, with nine hundred years of drinking in her, standing over him with her hand out.

That was what Tier Five was.

That was what a hundred got you.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Take it*," said Ysenne.

On the dais. By the anvil. With Lark on her hip, quiet, watching.

She didn't sound cold. She didn't sound triumphant. She sounded tired. More tired than he'd ever heard anyone sound. Like Old Mag at the end. Like his father.

"*Take it, smith*," said the Glass Queen. "*Somebody has to.*"

He looked up at her.

"*It went past me*," said Ysenne. "*You saw. It doesn't bend to me any more. It doesn't bend to anybody.*" Her clear eyes were on the threads, swinging, humming, free, going away up into the grey. "*And the grey's still coming. Do you understand? The edge is still open. It'll drink everything. Every field. Every village. Every child. And the net can't stop it. Not without somebody holding it.*" She looked down at him. "*I can't. She won't. You can.*"

He didn't say anything.

"You'd be good at it," said Ysenne. Very quietly. *"Better than me. Better than Oz. Better than Aurelian. You'd keep them all. Safe. Warm."* A pause. *"You'd never have to watch anyone go again."*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT THE crown.

On the anvil. Gold. Seven points. Thin. Plain. Lying where it had lain for nine hundred years, on the face of the first anvil, worn smooth by blows struck by a frightened young man with a hammer his father gave him.

Keep what is yours.

He thought about what was his.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN. ON HER KNEES beside him. Her gold fingers on the white stone. Her red braid. Her face turned to him, not saying anything. Not *don't*. Not *do*. Just looking at him. The way she'd looked at him on the Spire, in the wind, the first time. *Your choice, Hammer.*

Lark. On the dais. In a cold woman's arms. Twenty months old. Who'd said no to the whole of the world and meant it.

His mother. Three hundred miles up and away. In a doorway. Holding a clay lamp.

Antho behind him. Seraphine at the Forge with a hand on her belly. A four-hundred-and-thirteenth reason, due in August.

Brannoc. *Mind the floor. It's been swept.*

Old Mag, under her apple tree, with a gold king's hand in hers. *Kept's the oven, love. Finished is the cake.*

His father. On the Spire steps. On the stair down into the dark. Turning back. Twice. Not to keep anything. Just to look.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULD KEEP ALL of it.

He knew it. Kneeling there. He could stand up and walk up the seven steps and put his hand on the gold and the net would come to him the way it had come the first time, the whole weight and warmth of it, and he'd hold it. And nothing would ever be lost again. Not Wren. Not Lark. Not

Antho or Seraphine or the baby or Brannoc or his mother. Not the hedgehog under the woodpile at Harrow. Not anything.

Kept.

Still.

The way the gold kept Ilda. The way the glass kept a tired woman brushing her hair. The way the King had kept nine thousand people because he couldn't stand to watch them go.

You'd never have to watch anyone go again.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT WREN.

She was still looking at him. She hadn't said anything. She wasn't going to. He knew that. She'd walked into the glass after their daughter without asking anyone, and she'd sat on the steps of the Heart for two days with a cold queen and not tried to run, because running would have left Lark alone. She'd made her choice.

This one was his.

"*What would you do*?" he said. Very quietly. Just to her.

Wren looked at him for a long time.

"*I'd miss trees*," she said.

He didn't understand. For a moment.

Then he did.

The birch wood behind the cottage at Harrow. The chalk circle. Forty arrows. Eleven in the tree. Two in the chalk. The rest in the snow. A woman with her best hand turned to gold, missing trees, every day, all winter. And getting up the next morning and drawing again. With the wrong hand. Shaking.

Missing. And getting better. And missing. And getting better.

Kept would never miss a tree.

Kept would never hit one, either.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

His ribs screamed. He let them. He stood up on the white floor of the Heart in the middle of the moving net with the panel hanging gold in front

of his face, and he looked up the seven steps at the Glass Queen and the crown and his daughter.

"No," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

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TIER V — SOVEREIGN
DECLINED.
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◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD WENT OUT of the panel.

Not all at once. The way it had gone out of Lark's. Slowly. Like a fire going down. And the panel hung there in front of him, empty, white, waiting.

And then—

The net asked him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT. IN the hum. In the floor. In the threads swinging round him, moving, free. Not *TAKE UP*. Not *HOLD*. Not *KEEP*. The net had been made to say those things, and it had said them to every Root for nine hundred years, and it had said them to him the first time.

It didn't say them now.

It said, in the hum, in the white, in the space where a panel had been—

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEVEL 100.
THE CEILING IS REACHED.

WHAT ARE YOU?
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◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT IT.

At the question. Hanging in the air of the Heart.

He'd been a lot of things. The net had called him a lot of things. *Smith*. *Emberwright*. *Forgeheart Sorcerer*. *Worldforger*. Common and Rare and

Epic and Unique. Tier One, Two, Three, Four. He'd had ceilings and broken them. He'd had titles. *The Reckoning*. *Husband*. *Father*.

He thought about all of them.

Then he thought about the Forge. At five in the morning. In the dark. With the hearth banked and the bellows still and the long anvil cold, and Brannoc snoring through the wall, and his own hands raking the ash off the coals and blowing, gently, the way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

Good morning.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'm a smith*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: SMITH
Grade: Common
Level 100
Ceiling: NONE
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE STARED AT IT.

Smith.

Common.

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND HIM, SOMEBODY LAUGHED.

It was Antho. On his knees on the white stone. With his hand over his mouth and his shoulders shaking and tears running down his face. Laughing. Helplessly. The way he'd laughed when they were boys and Lex fell in the duck-pond.

"*Common*," said Antho. Through his fingers. "*Common. Lex. You absolute—*"

Wren was laughing too. She didn't make any sound. She just knelt there on the white floor with her face in her gold hand and her other hand over her eyes, and shook.

Lex didn't laugh.

He looked at the panel. *Ceiling: NONE*. And felt something in his chest that had been clenched since he was nineteen years old, standing in front of the Stone at Ashbourne with a cap of twenty-four on a panel and his whole life laid out in front of him like a road with a wall at the end of it—

Let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

Common, said the net. In the hum. Pleased. Like a forge that's just been lit.

Common. Like bread. Like iron. Like fire. Like the ground.

Like everyone.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED UP.

She was standing in front of the anvil. With Lark on her hip. With the crown behind her. And her clear glass face had—

Cracked.

Not much. A line. Fine as a hair. From the corner of one clear eye down across her cheek to her jaw. A crack in a frost on a window. Lex saw it. Saw the faces under her glass skin, the millions of them, drift toward it. Press against it. As if they'd seen light.

"*No*," said the Glass Queen. "*You can't. You can't just—that's not a choice. That's not what a hundred is. A hundred is the top. A hundred is the crown. Nobody gets to a hundred and says—*" Her voice was rising. Thin. Like a wet finger on the rim of a cup. "*Somebody has to hold it. Somebody has to. Or it all goes. All of it. Into the grey.*"

"*Nobody has to hold it*," said Lex.

"*Then who's going to keep them*?"

"*Nobody*," said Lex. "*That's the point.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED UP THE steps.

One. Two. Three. Slowly. With his ribs. With his hands. He didn't hurry. The Glass Queen watched him come. She didn't move. She didn't

lift her hand. There was nothing to lift it with. The net went past her the way water goes past a stone.

He stopped in front of her.

At the top of the dais. In front of the anvil. A yard away. Close enough to see the crack in her face, and the faces behind it.

He held out his arms.

The Glass Queen looked at them.

For a long time.

Then, very slowly, she held out the child.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK CAME INTO HIS arms like a cat coming in out of the rain. All at once. Indignantly. With her fists in his shirt and her face in his neck and her whole small body shaking. Not crying. She was past crying. Just shaking. And saying, into his collar, over and over, very quietly, the only word that mattered.

"*Da*."

He held her.

He held her for a long time. On the dais. At the top of the seven steps. With the Glass Queen standing a yard away with her empty hands and the crack in her face.

Then he looked past her.

At the anvil.

At the crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It'll always be there*," he said.

Not to anyone. Just out loud.

"*As long as it's lying in the road. Somebody'll want it.*" He looked at it. Gold. Seven points. Warm. Empty. "*Not you. Not now. But somebody. In a hundred years. In five hundred. Somebody frightened. Somebody who can't stand to watch people go. Somebody who'll walk all the way down here to the bottom of the world and pick it up and think, I'll just hold it. Just for a bit. Just to keep everyone safe.*"

He looked at Ysenne.

"*That's how it started*," he said. "*Isn't it? With Aurelian. With a frightened young man trying to save everyone.*"

The Glass Queen didn't answer.

He gave Lark to Wren.

She was at the top of the steps. He hadn't heard her come. She took their daughter without a word and stood back.

And Lex turned to the anvil.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T PICK THE crown up.

He didn't need to. It was on an anvil. It was on *the* anvil. The first one. Where it had been made. And he had a hammer.

He took it off his belt. Aurelian's hammer. Black iron. Old. Heavy. Worn smooth at the grip by a frightened young man's hand, and then by nine hundred years of nothing, and then by his. He unwrapped the wet cloths from his burned right hand and let them fall on the white stone. And closed his raw palm round the haft.

And reached for fire.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME.

Not round. Not slow. Not climbing hand over hand up out of the deep. It came the way it had come every day of his life until Midwinter. *Through*. Straight up out of the white stone of the Heart and into his feet and his chest and his arm and his hand, white-gold, roaring, glad.

Through the net.

The net that was moving again. Humming again. Free.

[Good morning,] said the fire.

He didn't stop to wonder at it.

He put the fire into the crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT RED.

Then orange. Then yellow. Then white. Seven points softening. Sagging. The thin gold going bright and liquid at the edges like honey on a

warm stone. The crown of the net. Nine hundred years old. Made by the hands of the first Root on the first anvil, with the first fire.

Lex lifted the hammer.

And brought it down.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SOUND WENT THROUGH the Heart like a bell.

Through the white stone. Through the threads. Up through the grey water and the drowned city and the glass road and the whole of the world. Every Stone in Caldor rang with it. Every anvil. Every bell in every tower. Every hammer hanging on every wall. One note. Clear. Gold.

The crown flattened.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STRUCK AGAIN.

And again.

He didn't think about it. He didn't need to. He'd been doing this since he was eleven years old, standing on a crate in Brannoc's forge with a horseshoe nail in his fist. Heat. Strike. Turn. Strike. The crown went under the hammer the way all metal goes under a hammer if you're patient with it, and know what it wants to be.

He knew what it wanted to be.

He'd known since the spring. Since Seraphine's drawing. Since the frame went down the lane on the cart with no latch, and his mother had said *a door needs a latch, love, or it's just a hole with a lid*.

It has to say yes, Seraphine had written in the margin. *And no*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEVEN POINTS WENT INTO one.

A bar. Short. Thick as his finger. He drew it out. Turned it. Bent the end of it into a curve, a hook, for the catch. Flattened the other end into a thumb-plate, wide, round, the size of a child's palm. Punched the hole for the pin with the point of the hammer's peen.

A latch.

A plain thumb-latch. The kind on every cottage door in Caldor. The kind you lift with your thumb to go in and drop to keep the cold out.

Up is yes.

Down is no.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED.

With the hammer raised. With the latch white-hot on the anvil in front of him. One more strike. He could feel it. One more, to set it. To finish it.

He turned round.

Wren was standing behind him with Lark on her hip. Lark was watching. She'd stopped shaking. She was watching the hammer and the anvil and the white-hot metal the way she watched him at the long anvil at the Forge from her sling on his back. With her whole face. With her eyebrows.

He held out his hand.

Wren looked at him. Then she understood. And put their daughter down.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WALKED ACROSS THE dais.

On her own. Barefoot. In her nightshirt. Twenty months old. Twelve steps. Not toddling. Walking. The way she'd walked across the Harrow yard in the mud to a gold king with a cup. The way she'd walked across the stepping stones in the spring with Rhosyn holding her breath.

She stopped beside him at the anvil.

He knelt down. With his ribs. And put the hammer in her hands.

It was far too big for her. She couldn't lift it. She didn't care. She wrapped both her small square hands round the black iron haft below his, and looked up at him.

"*Hot*," said Lark. Seriously. Pointing at the latch.

"*Yes*," said Lex. "*Hot. Don't touch.*"

"*No*," agreed Lark.

He put his hand round both of hers. Round the haft. And together they lifted it.

And brought it down.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T MUCH OF a blow. It barely moved the metal.

It didn't need to.

The latch rang.

One note. Small. Clear. Like a bell on a door when someone comes in out of the cold.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓
THE CROWN OF THE NET
HAS BEEN UNMADE.
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◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LET GO OF the hammer.

Lark let go too. It fell on the white stone with a clang. She looked at it. Then at the latch, cooling on the anvil, going from white to yellow to red. Then at him.

"*More*," said Lark.

He laughed. He couldn't help it. It hurt his ribs so much he nearly fell over.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PICKED THE LATCH up with the tongs when it had gone dark.

It was small. Plain. Gold-grey now, where the fire had been in it. A thumb-latch. A bar and a catch. Warm in his burned palm, the way the hinges had been warm. The way they breathed.

He looked at it with the net.

Out of habit. The way you'd glance at a thing to see what it is. And the panel came up, the way panels came up for every made thing, every sword, every hinge, every horseshoe.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ITEM: —

NOT OF THIS NET.
NO RECORD.
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT for a long time.

No record.

The way Malachi had been *no record*. The old man with the goats in the Pale Wastes. The hole Aurelian made in the net for his little brother, so nothing could ever hold him.

Nothing would ever hold this either.

Nobody would ever wear it. Nobody would ever pick it up off an anvil at the bottom of the world and think *I'll just hold it, just for a bit*. It wasn't a crown any more. It wasn't anything the net knew.

It was a latch.

You lifted it to go in. You dropped it to keep the cold out.

That was all.

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND HIM, SOMEBODY WAS crying.

Not Lark. Not Wren.

He turned round.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN HAD sat down.

On the top step of the dais. At the edge. With her long glass legs folded under her and her long glass hands in her lap. She'd sat down the way a woman sits down at the end of a very long day, when she's been standing since dawn and has finally stopped and doesn't know if she'll get up again.

She wasn't crying. Glass doesn't cry.

But the crack in her face had grown.

From her eye to her jaw. And down. Her neck. Her shoulder. Her arm. Fine lines. Spreading. Like frost spreading across a pane. And through every one of them, the faces were pressing. Millions. Under the glass. Drifting toward the cracks. Toward the light.

She looked down at her hands.

"*There's nothing left*," said Ysenne.

Very quietly. To nobody.

"*No net. No crown. No chair. No regency.*" She turned her clear glass hands over. "*Nine hundred years. Every pane in the world. And I've nothing. Nobody looking. Nothing looking back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CRYING WAS RHOSYN.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME UP THE steps.

Slowly. Barefoot. Forty years old. Her knees cracking on every step. With her hands bound up in blood-soaked linen to the wrists and her hair full of thorns and her face wet. She didn't look at Lex. She didn't look at the anvil, or the latch, or the child.

She looked at her sister.

She came up to the top step. And sat down beside her. On the white stone. At the edge of the dais. Close. Their shoulders almost touching. A mortal woman with dirt under her nails and a Crowned queen made of cracking glass.

"*Ysy*," said Rhosyn.

The Glass Queen didn't look at her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ysy*," said Rhosyn again. Gently. "*Look at me.*"

"*I can't*," said Ysenne.

"*Why not*?"

"*Because you'll see me*." The glass voice was thin. Breaking. Like ice in spring. "*You'll see. And I'll see you seeing. And I'll see what you see.*" Her clear hands were shaking in her lap. "*I've never seen myself, Rosie. Not since the pool. And I'm frightened of what's there.*"

Rhosyn didn't say anything for a while.

Then she lifted her bound hands. Slowly. Painfully. Blood seeping through the linen. And put them on either side of her sister's glass face.

The way Lark had. On the chair. Firmly. The way you'd turn a stubborn goat by the horns.

And turned it.

Toward her.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN'S EYES were clear. Like looking through a window at a white sky.

She looked into her sister's eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREEN. RHOSYN'S EYES WERE green. Lex had noticed it in the spring. Green the way a stem is green when you snap it. Wet. Living. Mortal.

And in them—

Small. Bright. Tiny. The way you see yourself in someone's eyes when you're close enough to touch. Twice over. One in each.

A woman.

Tall. White. Cracked. Tired. With a glass crown on her head and a face like a cut jewel, all planes and edges. Sitting on a white step at the bottom of the world. Looking.

Not a pane. Not glass. Not a reflection in a pond or a window or the back of a spoon. Not something that showed you what was in front of it and didn't care.

An eye.

That was looking back.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Ysenne.

Very softly.

"*Oh. There I am.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There you are*," said Rhosyn.

Her voice was shaking. Her bound hands were shaking on the glass face. She didn't let go.

"*There you are, Ysy*," said Rhosyn. "*You look tired. You look like Mam did. Round the eyes. When she'd been up all night with Hes.*" She was crying. She didn't stop. "*You look like my sister. You always did. I always saw you. Every day. In the Court. In the long hall. I always looked. You just never looked back to see me doing it.*"

The Glass Queen looked into her sister's eyes.

At the woman in them.

At herself. Small. Bright. Seen.

And smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD NEVER SEEN her smile. Not in the bath. Not in the cup. Not in the panel in the spring. Not here.

It wasn't a beautiful smile. It wasn't cold. It was small and tired and a little lopsided, and it went all the way up into the clear glass eyes and made them, for one moment, not clear.

Grey. Like Oz's.

Like a sister's.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CRACKS MET.

All of them. At once. From her eye and her jaw and her shoulder and her hands. They ran together across the glass like frost meeting frost on a pane, and joined, and—

She came apart.

Not shattering. Not breaking. Gently. The way the snow comes off a branch when the sun gets to it. Into dust. Fine. Bright. Glittering. A glass woman on a white step, sitting with her face in her sister's bloody hands, smiling, coming down in a soft fall of light like frost blown off a window.

And out of her—

Out of the dust. Out of the cracks. Out of the glass. Rising. Millions.

The faces.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT UP.

All of them. Every face that had ever looked into anything bright. A tired woman brushing her hair. A boy in a puddle sticking out his tongue. A soldier in a polished breastplate. A girl in the back of a spoon, laughing. An old woman in a dark kitchen window at night with a candle, looking out past her own face for someone who hadn't come home.

They rose out of the glass dust in a cloud of light. Up through the Heart. Through the moving threads. Up. Away. Like sparks going up a chimney. Like moths going to a lamp.

Home.

Wherever home was for a reflection. Back to the faces they'd come from. Back to the eyes that had made them. Or nowhere. Or just—up. Free. Unkept.

Lex watched them go.

He thought he saw a red-haired girl in a bucket go past him. Twelve. Grinning. With a hare over her shoulder. He thought he heard Wren, beside him, make a small sound.

He didn't look. It wasn't his to look at.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHEN THEY'D GONE, THERE was only the dust.

A little heap of it. On the top step. Glittering. Fine as flour. Pale as frost. Lying in Rhosyn's lap, and on the white stone round her, and in the folds of her blood-soaked linen.

Rhosyn sat there.

With her bound hands still held up in front of her, in the shape of a face. Round nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING CAME UP the steps.

Slowly. Huge. Gold. And the white stone stayed white under every one of them. He came up and knelt down beside his little sister on the top step. Beside the glass dust.

He didn't say anything.

He just put his arm round her.

And Rhosyn turned her face into his gold shoulder and cried. The way she'd cried at the pool in the winter when she poured back. The way she hadn't cried in nine hundred years before that. And the King held her and looked at the dust in her lap.

"*She looked*," said Rhosyn. Into his shoulder. "*Oz. She looked. At the end. She saw.*"

"*I know*," said the King. "*I saw her see.*"

"*She smiled*."

"*I know*."

"*She looked like Mam*."

The King's gold face did something complicated.

"*She always did*," said Oszric. "*Round the eyes.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN GATHERED THE DUST.

Later. When she'd stopped crying. She unwound the linen from one of her hands—the blood had dried; it came away stiff and dark—and laid it out flat on the white step. And swept the glass dust onto it with the edge of her other bound hand. Carefully. Every grain. As much as she could find. Off the step and the stone and the folds of her dress.

Then she folded the linen. Over and over. Into a small packet. No bigger than a fist.

And held it in her lap.

"*I'm taking her to Mal*," said Rhosyn. To nobody. To all of them. "*To the pool. She can go in with the others. With Cad. With the cousins.*" She looked down at the packet. "*He'll make room for her. He made room for me.*"

Nobody said anything.

There wasn't anything to say.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NET HUMMED.

All round them. In the white stone. In the threads, swinging, moving, going away up through the grey to the world. Every colour. Free. And Lex felt it. Something changing. Something coming up the threads, from the Heart, from the place where a crown had been and wasn't. Going out. To everyone.

A panel opened in front of him.

In front of all of them. Wren. Antho. The King, even, gold as he was. In front of Rhosyn, who had no class and no level and hadn't seen a panel since she was a girl standing by a pool in a garden.

And in front of everyone else.

Every Stone. Every Kindling. Every panel in the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▓▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓▓
THE NET BELONGS TO NO ONE.
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◆ ◆ ◆

AND UP ABOVE THEM—FAR up, through the grey water and the drowned city and the glass road, in the world—

Lex felt it break.

The still. The held breath. Four months of it. The freeze. Like ice going off a river in the spring, all at once, with a sound like the whole world sighing.

In Ashbourne, on the green, he knew, three hundred people were looking at their panels and seeing numbers move. Tilda's. Brannoc's. Davy Pruett's. *Experience*, and then a number, and the number going up. Slowly. A hair at a time.

At the pool in the east, Pim would be looking at his.

At Harrow, his mother.

Everywhere. Every panel. Every Kindling. Moving again.

Up. Always up.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE WHITE STEP, Rhosyn held the packet of glass dust in her lap and looked out across the Heart at nothing.

On the dais, Lark sat down on the stone beside the fallen hammer and put her hand on it. Possessively. *Mine*.

At the shore, the long oar went in and held, and the Ferryman stood in his boat with his lantern on the post, and the small gold flame inside it said, in a voice of great interest—

[What a marvellous latch.]

And far, far up, at the edge of the world, at the old edge, where the grey country ran into the green—

The sun came up.

It was Midsummer.

CHAPTER 31

The Lantern Road

SEREN KEPT THE WINDOW all night.

It wasn't a window. It was a door. The great doors at the end of the long hall of the Forge, oak and iron, twelve feet high, standing open onto the yard and the dark and the grey mist that had rolled up out of the cinders when the Ferryman came. She stood in them. With the clay lamp in her hands. Wenna's lamp. Cracked across the lip. Burning.

She didn't sit down. She didn't sleep.

Seraphine brought her a stool at midnight. She didn't sit on it. Brannoc brought her tea at two. She drank it standing. Tilda brought a blanket at four and put it round her shoulders without asking, and Seren let her, and went on standing in the doorway holding the lamp out into the dark.

Somebody has to keep the window.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT SOME POINT BEFORE dawn, the panels moved.

She felt it first. Not in her own—she didn't have one, not really, she'd never Kindled properly, Harrow women didn't—but in the people round her. A gasp. Down the long hall. Tilda, at the great hearth, with her gold hand held up in front of her face and a silver-blue light hanging over it.

"*It's moving*," said Tilda. Thin. High. "*Brannoc. Brannoc, my panel. It's—the number. It's moving.*"

Brannoc came out of the kitchen with a ladle in his hand and stood in the middle of the hall and looked at the air in front of his face. At the panel there. At whatever was written on it.

He didn't say anything for a long time.

Then he went and knelt at the great hearth, with his knees cracking, and blew on the coals. And the fire came up. Fast. Through. Without him reaching. A roar of white-gold that made Tilda jump back and Kestrel, asleep on a bench, sit up shouting.

[Good morning,] said the fire. Glad.

"*Morning*," said Brannoc Holt. Gruffly.

And wiped his face with the back of his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T MOVE FROM the door.

She knew what it meant. She'd lived with Arion Vey for a year and a half and with the net all her life, and she knew. The still had broken. The freeze. Somebody, at the bottom of the world, had taken the Glass Queen's hand off the strings.

It didn't tell her who.

It didn't tell her whether they were alive.

She stood in the door with the lamp and waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MIST CAME BACK at sunrise.

Up out of the cinders. Grey. Moving. Knee-high. Rolling across the yard from the bottom, where the stream had been, where Brannoc took his quench-water. And out of it—

A light. Low. Gold. Swinging.

And a boat.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK CAME OUT OF it first.

Of course she did. Before it touched. Before anyone could stop her. She went over the side of the black boat into the mist on her bottom, the way she went down the stairs, and stood up in the grey with the mist round her knees and her nightshirt filthy and her black hair sticking up at the back, and looked up the yard at the Forge doors.

At her Gan. In them. With a lamp.

"*GAN*," shrieked Lark.

And ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T REMEMBER PUTTING the lamp down. Afterward Seraphine said she'd set it very carefully on the flags by the door, the way you'd set down something precious, before she went down on her knees on the cinders. Seren didn't remember. She remembered the weight. Warm. Solid. Small arms round her neck. A wet face in her collar. A voice in her ear, furious, tremendous, telling her all about it.

"*Gan. Gan. Wa'er. Lady. Cold. No. No. Da. Hot. Ham'er. More.*"

"*I know*," said Seren. Into the black hair. Not knowing anything. "*I know, love. I know. I know.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME UP THE yard behind her.

Wren, barefoot, with her hand on Lark's back and her face grey with tiredness and her mouth trembling. Antho, with his arm round Rhosyn, who was holding something in her lap—a packet, small, folded linen, no bigger than a fist—as if it were made of eggs. The King, gold, enormous, last out of the boat, with a white petal in one hand and Hes's crown in the other.

And Lex.

Walking slowly. With his ribs. With his right hand unwrapped, raw, blistered. With Aurelian's hammer on his belt and something in his other hand. Small. Gold-grey. Plain.

He stopped in front of her.

She looked up at him from her knees on the cinders with his daughter in her arms.

"*Are you all right*?" said Seren Harrow.

Lex looked down at her for a long time.

"*I'm common*," he said.

And sat down on the cinders beside her, and put his head on her shoulder, and started to laugh, and then to cry, and then both, and didn't stop for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN DIDN'T GET out of the boat.

He stood in the stern with the long oar. Tall. Grey. Hooded. With the lantern on its post.

Seren looked at him over her son's head.

She'd met him once before. On the night Arion died. He'd stood at the foot of the bed with his hand out, and Arion had taken it, and the old man had looked at her—at her, Seren, sitting by the bed—and given her one memory. A gift. *The Spire steps. He turned back.*

He looked at her now.

"*Lady*," said the Ferryman.

"*Thank you*," said Seren. "*For bringing them home.*"

The Ferryman was silent.

Then: "*I'll be at the edge*," he said. "*When it's done. When the door's hung.*" The hood tilted. Very slightly. Toward the lantern on its post. Toward the small gold flame inside it. "*I'd like to see how it ends.*"

[So would I,] said the flame. Interested. Courteous. *[I've a great deal to write.]*

Seren's breath caught.

She'd known its voice for a year and a half. In the hearth at Harrow. In Lex's chest. Dry. Small. Precise. Telling Arion the dates of things. Correcting her about the Wells. Saying *good morning* to her son every day across the kitchen as if it had invented the words.

It looked at her now. From the lantern. Politely.

It didn't know her.

[Good morning,] said the flame. *[I don't believe we've met.]*

"*No*," said Seren. Very gently. "*Not yet.*"

The long oar went in. The boat turned. The mist went back down the yard and into the cinders, and took the light with it, and was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SLEPT UNTIL NOON.

All of them. Lex and Wren and Lark in a heap on the pallet in the tool-room, and nobody dared go in. Antho on the floor of the kitchen with his head in Seraphine's lap, and Seraphine asleep sitting up against the wall.

Rhosyn on Seren's cot by the great hearth, with the packet of glass dust held against her chest in both hands.

The King didn't sleep. The King sat on the flags by the apple wood door, gold, with his back to the wall and his knees drawn up, and looked at it.

Seren sat beside him.

She didn't say anything. Neither did he. They sat there together in the long hall in the noon light, with the fires roaring in all twenty hearths because Tilda had lit every one of them out of pure joy, and looked at the door.

Seven feet high. Three and a half wide. Apple wood. Blooming. Hanging on its frame in the middle of the floor on hinges forged from the Key, which breathed. With no threshold under it. No bell. No paint.

No latch.

"*He made it out of the crown*," said the King.

Seren looked at him.

"*The latch*," said Oszric. "*He unmade the crown on the first anvil. And made a latch. He let the little one strike the last blow.*" His gold face did something complicated. "*Aurelian made that crown. On that anvil. I held the tongs.*"

Seren didn't say anything.

"*I thought it would be the most beautiful thing I'd ever see*," said the King. "*When I was a boy. When Aurelian made it. I thought, that's it. That's the most beautiful thing anyone will ever make.*" He looked at the door. At the empty place where the latch would go. "*I was wrong. It's a latch. A plain little latch. You lift it to go in.*"

He was quiet for a long time.

"*She looked*," he said. "*Ysy. At the end. In Rosie's eyes.*"

"*I know*," said Seren. "*Rosie told me.*" She'd told her at dawn. In the yard. In one breath. And then gone very white and sat down.

"*She smiled*," said the King. "*I'd forgotten her smile. I'd forgotten she had one.*" A pause. "*Nine hundred years.*"

Seren put her hand on his arm.

Gold. Cold. Hard. Like a doorknob.

She left it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RAVEN CAME AT three.

Seren saw it from the yard. A black speck over the west, coming out of the grey, out of the picture of a sky, and then not a speck, a bird. Big. Ragged. Exhausted. It came in low over the lantern ring and the Forge roof and dropped onto the yard cinders at her feet like a sack of coal, and lay there with its wings out and its beak open, panting.

It had a paper tied to its leg.

Seren knelt and untied it. Gently. The bird let her. It had come three hundred miles from the east, and the last of them through the grey, and Seren didn't know how. She didn't think the bird knew either.

She unfolded the paper.

A small careful hand. In pencil. The longest note she had ever seen Pim write.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE READ IT TWICE.

Then she took it into the Forge, to the long hall, to the place by the apple wood door where the King was still sitting on the flags with his back to the wall.

She held it out.

The King looked at it.

"*It's for Lex*," said Seren. "*But I think it's for you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE READ IT SLOWLY.

His lips moved. He'd learned to read nine hundred years ago, in a palace, from a tutor with a stick, and he'd had nothing to read since. His gold finger went along under the pencil lines, one word at a time, the way a child's does.

The King is practising. Letting go. We felt it. It hurts them. It frightens them. They go like sand.

His finger stopped.

Went on.

He has to do it all at once. He can't do it a bit at a time. Tell him.

When he does it, they shouldn't be on their own. Nobody should come apart on their own. Not again.

We'll hold their hands. Here. At the pool. As many as we can get. Ivy and Hask and Kit and me. And Ilda. And all the dead. Tell him to send them here. Tell him to send them all.

Tell him we're ready.

Tell him not to be sorry. Tell him it's all right to let go.

P.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND UNDER IT. AT the bottom. Very small.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING'S FINGER STOPPED.

It stayed there. On the last line. For a long time.

Seren watched his face. She'd watched it all winter. At Harrow. In her kitchen, on a gold circle on the floor, with a cup of tea going cold in front of him. In her garden, under the grave, with his gold hands on his knees. She'd seen it do a lot of things.

She'd never seen it do this.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Maudie*," said the King.

Very quietly.

"*Maud. The bread-woman. In the big kitchen. She sang.*" His voice was a whisper. "*She sang like a cat in a well. Agnes used to say. The cook.*" He stared at the paper. "*I knew that. I knew her. I used to go down to the kitchen at night when I couldn't sleep, when I was a boy, and she'd give me the heel of the loaf and tell me to get out from under her feet.*"

He looked up at Seren.

"*I forgot her name*," said Oszric. "*Nine hundred years. I walked past her on the floor of the hall while she came apart, with her daughter in her arms, and I kept the girl and I let her go and I forgot her name.*"

Seren didn't say anything.

"*A boy remembered it*," said the King. "*A boy who doesn't talk. Who wrote it down.*"

He folded the paper. Very carefully. Small. And held it in his gold fist with the white petal and Hes's crown.

And put his face in his other hand.

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SEREN SAT WITH HIM while he cried.

It took a long time. Nine hundred years is a long time to save up.

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WHEN HE'D FINISHED, HE wiped his face with his gold hand—it left no wet; nothing stayed wet on him—and looked at the door.

"*When it's hung*," said the King. "*When it's done. When it's at the edge, and open, and there's somewhere for them to go.*"

"*Yes*," said Seren.

"*I'll let go*," said Oszric. "*All at once. Like the boy says.*" He swallowed. "*All of them. Everyone I've got. Roole at his gate. The Ashby lad in his field. The smith's wife's fingers, and the girl's hand, and Brannoc's. And my household. All nine thousand.*" His voice was very steady. "*And me. I'll have to let go of me too. It's all one hand. I can't open it and keep one finger shut.*"

Seren looked at him.

"*You'll come apart*," she said. "*Like them. Nine hundred years.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Like sand*."

"*Yes*," said the King. "*But not on my own.*" He looked down at the folded paper in his fist. "*The boy says nobody should. Not again.*"

Then he turned his huge gold head. And looked across the long hall. To the cot by the great hearth, where his sister was sleeping with a packet of glass dust held against her chest.

"*Will you ask Rosie*," said the Gilded King, "*if she'll walk me to the door*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

ROSIE SAID YES.

She said it before Seren had finished asking. Sitting up on the cot with the packet in her hands and her hair full of thorns and her face creased

from the blanket. She looked across the hall at her brother sitting by the apple wood door.

"*Of course I will*," said Rhosyn. "*Silly. Of course. Who else would?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DUG THE STONE up the next morning.

All of Ashbourne came to watch.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT STOOD ON THE green where it had always stood. Since before the village. Since before the Lattice was the Lattice. A tall grey standing stone, eight feet, rough, leaning a little west, with a crack down its face from crown to foot that Lex had put there himself, the day he Kindled, when the net looked at a nineteen-year-old smith's boy and saw his grandfather's grandfather's grandfather's blood, and the Stone had rung like a bell and split.

It had been wrapped in canvas and chains since the spring. Since the Glass Queen came into the Stones and looked out of them at children.

Lex took the chains off himself.

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SEREN WATCHED HIM DO it. From the edge of the green. With Lark on her hip and Rhosyn beside her and Wren on her other side, leaning on her bow, which she wasn't using as a bow, because she could barely stand.

He did it slowly. With his ribs strapped and his right hand wrapped in fresh linen. Lock by lock. Link by link. Brannoc beside him, holding the ends. The chains came off one at a time and went on the grass in a heap. Then the canvas. Four layers. Then the sacking.

And the Stone stood there.

Grey. Cracked. Old.

Dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT HIS HAND on it.

His left. The one that wasn't burned. Flat. On the grey rough face. On the crack. The way you'd put your hand on the neck of a horse you hadn't seen in a long time.

The whole green held its breath.

Nothing happened.

No eye. No white light. No cold. No Glass Queen looking out of it at the children of Ashbourne. Just a Stone. Old. Grey. Cracked. Warm in the sun.

And then, faintly, from somewhere under Lex's palm—

A hum.

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IT WASN'T LOUD. SEREN barely heard it. A low note, deep, slow, like a bell a long way off across fields. Coming up out of the grey stone into Lex's hand.

And a panel opened over it.

Silver-blue. Small. Hanging in the air over the cracked crown of the Stone, where every child in Ashbourne for four hundred years had looked up and seen their name.

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ASHBOURNE STONE
Kindlings: 2,881

THRESHOLD
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LEX STARED AT IT.

"*It knows*," said Seraphine. Behind Seren. Very quietly. With her quill stopped on the page. "*It knows what it's for.*"

"*It's always known*," said Brannoc. Gruffly. "*It's a Stone. It's what they do. They stand at the edge of things and look at people going past and say what they are.*" He looked at the panel. "*Every child in this village stood on that patch of grass and walked past it into their life.*"

Threshold: stone, Seraphine had written in the spring, in the margin of her drawing. *Something that knows what people are*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T DIG IT out with spades in the end.

Tom Pruett had brought spades. And the Penn boys. And half the men in the village. And a cart, with six oxen, borrowed from three farms, and levers and rope and a block and tackle off the church tower.

They didn't need any of it.

Lex knelt on the green in front of the Stone. And put both hands flat on the grass at its foot. And reached. Not round the net. Not down past it. Through. The way he'd reached at the Heart. The way fire came now, and stone, and everything.

Please, he said. *Up. You're needed.*

And the Stone came up out of the ground.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WHOLE GREEN WENT quiet.

It came up slowly. The way a man stands up after a long time kneeling. With its roots coming out of the earth after it—not roots, Seren saw, but the bottom of the stone, eight feet more of it, grey and rough and earth-stained, that had been underground for four hundred years. It rose out of the green with the grass parting round it and the soil falling off it in clods, sixteen feet of grey stone with a crack down the middle, and stood on the grass beside its own hole.

And then, gently, as if it had been asked—

Lay down.

On its side. On the green. Sixteen feet long. A long grey stone. Cracked. Old. The length of a doorway.

The panel hung over it. *THRESHOLD.*

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WRIGGLED DOWN OFF Seren's hip.

Nobody stopped her. She went across the green on her own, barefoot, in a clean nightshirt that wouldn't stay clean for a minute, to the long grey stone lying on the grass. And climbed onto it. And stood on it. In the middle. Over the crack. With her arms out for balance and her eyebrows down.

And looked round at everybody.

Very pleased with herself.

"*Mine*," said Lark.

The whole green laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LEFT ON THE third day after Midsummer.

Everyone.

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SERAPHINE HAD DONE THE sums. She'd done them on the floor of the long hall with chalk, crawling about on her knees round her belly with her horn spectacles slipping down her nose, while Antho sat on a bench and fretted.

"*It's a hole*," said Seraphine. "*The edge. Where the Veil was. It's not a line. It's a hole. The world's room is going out of it the way water goes out of a bucket with a hole in it. That's what the grey is. That's why it spreads. It's the world draining.*" She drew a long line on the flags. "*Two hundred miles west. The old edge. That's where it's going out. That's where the door has to go.*"

"*Two hundred miles*," said Antho. "*Through the grey.*"

"*Yes*."

"*With a door. And a sixteen-foot stone. And a pregnant woman.*"

"*I'll be fine*," said Seraphine.

"*You'll be—*"

"*I'll be fine*," said Seraphine. "*I've got four hundred and twelve reasons. And one more coming in August.*" She sat back on her heels. "*And I've walked further. With worse.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY HAD SLOWED. Since the freeze broke. A mile a day, Elowen said, riding back from the stakes. Less, some days. But it hadn't stopped. It still lay round Ashbourne on every side, a picture of fields, a picture of woods, all the way west to the edge and further east every day toward the Vale and Fen Hollow and the Teeth.

Two hundred miles of it.

"*We'll walk*," said Seren.

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SO THEY WALKED.

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SEREN WENT FIRST.

She hadn't meant to. She'd meant to walk with Rhosyn, somewhere in the middle, behind the carts, where she could keep an eye on Lark. But on the morning they left, when the whole of Ashbourne was gathered on the green at dawn with their packs on their backs and their lanterns in their hands, waiting, somebody said *who's going first*, and somebody else said *the Lady*, and everybody looked at her.

So she went first.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED OUT OF the lantern ring at the west of the village. Past the mill-pond, grey and hard as slate. Past the last of the lanterns. Onto the grass beyond, which was a picture of grass.

And held her hands out. One to each side.

Rosie took one. Wren took the other.

And Seren walked into the grey.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT ROUND HER.

The way it had at the grave. Not two yards. Less. A ring of green round her feet, moving with her. She didn't know how she did it. She didn't know what it was. Something in her hands. Something she'd been carrying for thirty years. A Harrow thing.

She walked. And behind her, the green stayed.

Not all of it. Not the whole width of her ring. A path. A thin green path where her feet had been, a yard wide, curving away behind her across the grey field like a ribbon dropped on a page.

And behind her, Rosie. And behind Rosie, the King, gold, enormous, with a white petal in his hand. And behind the King, the first cart.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS TOM PRUETT'S cart. Six oxen. Eight wheels. Built in a week by every carpenter in the Vale. And on it, lashed upright in the middle with ropes and wedges and blankets—

The door.

Seven feet high. Three and a half wide. Apple wood. Blooming. Petals coming off it in the wind of their walking and blowing back over the oxen and the carters and the road, white, pink at the edges. Hanging on its frame on its breathing hinges. Swinging, a little, as the cart went over the ruts. Out. And back.

Lex walked beside it. With his hand on the frame.

Behind it, the second cart. Twelve oxen. And on it, the Stone. Sixteen feet of grey. Cracked. With a small girl sitting on the very end of it in a sling of blankets Brannoc had rigged, watching the oxen, telling them what to do.

And behind that—

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYONE.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN TURNED ROUND AT the top of the first rise and looked back.

She'd meant to look for a moment. She stood there for a long time.

They came out of the lantern ring of Ashbourne in a long line, onto the green path she'd made through the grey, and every one of them had a lantern.

Hollis Penn with his barrow. Tilda with Brannoc's hammer on her back and a forge-lantern on a pole. Kestrel. Teo, who'd come up from the coast with his fish in a jar of water, because he wouldn't leave Barnaby with anyone. Davy Pruett, holding his mother's hand, and his mother with the new baby in a sling and a jam-jar candle in her other hand. Jem Tolley the beekeeper, whose lantern had been crushed by his own glass face, carrying a new one, tin, rough, that Lex had made him the night before. Old Mag's neighbour with her great-grandmother's iron lantern with the cracked pane. Nan Ashby. With the HERE lantern Lex had given her in the spring.

Three hundred. Four. More. Coming out of the villages round about, out of the grey, in twos and threes, with their own lanterns—Fen Hollow and Hobb's Cross and Westerling and Thistledown—falling in at the back of the line.

And as they walked, the lanterns did what given lanterns did.

They held a circle. Each one. Round its bearer. A ring of real ground. A ring of green. Small. A yard. Two. Overlapping. Joining. Each ring touching the next, the way hands touch in a line of people passing buckets.

And behind them, where they'd been—

The green stayed.

◆ ◆ ◆

A ROAD.

A green road. Through the grey. Wide as a lane. With real grass on it, and real dust, and real dandelions coming up at the edges in the summer sun. Curving away east behind them across the grey fields, back to the gold ring round Ashbourne. Like a lantern line. Like a seam. Like a thread of colour stitched across a page.

And every mile, somebody stopped.

Seren saw it from the rise. A woman at the back of the line. An old man. A boy. They'd stop, at the side of the green road, and set their lantern down on a stone or a stump or a fencepost. Lit. Given. And step back. And look at it. And walk on, without it, into the ring of the next person's light.

A lantern every mile.

So that the road would stay.

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"*It's the Keep*," said Rhosyn. Beside her. Very softly. Looking back. "*Isn't it? The eleven hundred. Your boy's.*"

"*Yes*," said Seren.

"*It's every lantern in every window*," said Rosie. "*Every one anybody ever left on for somebody coming home.*"

Seren didn't trust herself to answer.

She turned round. And held her hands out. And Rosie took one, and Wren the other.

And they walked on. West. Into the grey. Toward the edge of the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK NINETEEN DAYS.

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SEREN DIDN'T REMEMBER MOST of them. Afterward. They ran together. Walking. Always walking. The grey on either side, a picture of fields, a picture of farms, a picture of villages where people stood still in their doorways and their gardens, as they'd stood since the grey came, not dead, not alive, kept. The green road behind. The lanterns, one every mile, going back east in a line of gold as far as you could see on a clear night.

There were no clear nights. Grey country doesn't have stars.

But the lanterns did.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE REMEMBERED SOME THINGS.

She remembered the first village they came to, on the fourth day, where a woman stood in a garden in the grey with a washing basket on her hip and a shirt held up to the line, and had stood there since the spring. And the line of lanterns going past her, and the green road going past her gate. And Hollis Penn stopping. And setting his lantern down on her garden wall. And the ring of it going out—two yards, three—and reaching the woman with the basket.

And the woman blinking.

And pegging the shirt on the line.

And turning round, and looking at four hundred people with lanterns going past her gate, and saying, very clearly, "*Well, I never.*"

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SHE REMEMBERED THE KING.

Walking. Every day. All day. Behind her and Rosie. Never tiring. Gold. The green road going gold under his feet in a trail, a long gold stripe down the middle of the green. And then, around the tenth day—

Not going gold.

She noticed it at a ford. The King stepped out of the water onto the bank and she looked down out of habit, at the grass under his foot, to see it turn.

It didn't.

She looked at him. He was looking at it too.

"*Since the Heart*," said the King. Quietly. "*The white stone. It didn't go. And now this.*" He held up his hand. The one with the petal in it. White.

Pink at the edges. Not gold. Still. After all this time. *"It's not coming out of me any more, Seren. The gold. It's not spreading."*

"Why?"

"I don't know," said Oszric. He looked at the petal. *"I think I've stopped wanting to keep things."*

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SHE REMEMBERED THE NINTH night. Wren crying in her sleep. And Lex holding her. And Lark, between them, waking up, and putting her hand on her mam's face, the way she'd put it on the Glass Queen's, and saying *Mam* very firmly until Wren woke and stopped.

She remembered the fourteenth day. When they passed the place where Elowen's first stake had been, in the winter, with a red rag on it. *Westerling*. *Nine miles in*. And Nan Ashby's croft, on the hill above the village, with a gold man in the field—Col Ashby, Nan's boy, gilded in the spring when he'd stood between the King's steward and his mother—standing in his barley with his hand up. And Nan going up the hill to him. On her own. With the HERE lantern. And sitting down on the wall of the field beside her gold son. And not coming back down.

They left her there. She'd catch them up, she said. After.

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SHE REMEMBERED THE SEVENTEENTH day, when they began to feel the draught.

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IT WAS VERY FAINT at first. A breath on the back of her neck. Going west. As if someone had opened a window somewhere a long way ahead.

By the eighteenth day it was a wind. Steady. Cool. Going past them, from behind, from the east, from the whole of the world, west. Pulling at their clothes. At their hair. At the lantern flames, which leaned, all four hundred of them, in one direction, like grass leaning in a current.

Leaning toward the edge.

"It's the room," said Seraphine. Walking. With one hand on her belly and one on the side of the door-cart. *"Going out. That's what it feels like. The world's room. Draining."* She was very white. *"We're nearly there."*

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ON THE NINETEENTH DAY, at noon, Seren came over a long low rise in the grey and stopped.

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THE ROAD ENDED.

Not their road. The world's road. The old road. The one that had run west from the Vale for a thousand years, through Westerling and Hobb's Cross and the last farms and the last fields, to the place where every map in Caldor stopped and wrote, in old brown ink, *Here the world ends*.

It ended.

In front of her. Fifty yards off. Not in a cliff. Not in a wall. Not in anything.

In a seam.

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SHE COULD SEE IT. Just. If she didn't look straight at it. A line in the air. Running north and south, as far as she could see in both directions. Faint. Like a crease in a page. Like the place where the Veil had hung, for nine hundred years, a curtain of grey light at the edge of the world.

The Veil was gone.

The crease was still there.

And through it—past it—beyond it—

Nothing.

Not grey. Grey was something. Grey was the colour of a world that had gone still. This was the colour of a world that had never been. Flat. Endless. A white road running away across it toward towers on the horizon that she could just make out, glass and iron and gold and bone, the Court of the Crowned. Empty now.

And the wind going into it. Past her. Past all of them. Out of the world, into the nothing, through the seam, like water going down a drain.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING CAME UP beside her.

He stood there. On the rise. Gold. Looking at the seam. At the white road. At the towers.

"*I walked out of there*," said Oszric. "*In the winter. Down that road. With nine thousand people behind me.*" His voice was very quiet. "*I didn't look back.*"

Rosie came up on Seren's other side. With the packet of glass dust held against her chest.

She looked at it too.

Nobody said anything.

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BEHIND THEM, THE OXEN came up the rise. Slowly. Tom Pruett's cart. The door, on its frame, lashed upright, swinging. Out. And back.

Lex walked beside it. He stopped at the top of the rise. And looked down at the seam. At the end of the road.

He didn't say anything either.

Then he walked down the slope. Fifty yards. To the end of the road. To the last cobble of the world's road, cracked and old and mossed, with a picture of grass growing round it.

And stood there. With the seam a yard in front of him. With the wind going past him into the nothing.

He looked down at the ground under his feet.

"*Here*," said Lex Vey.

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AND ROUND HIS NECK, on its cord, under his shirt—

Malachi's bell rang.

On its own. Once. Small. Clear.

The way a bell on a door rings when somebody is coming in out of the cold.

CHAPTER 32

The Forging of the Door

THEY SET THE STONE down at dusk.

Twelve oxen. Forty men on the ropes. Brannoc shouting. Tom Pruett shouting louder. And Lex, at the end of the old road, with his hands flat on the grey grass and his eyes shut, asking.

Here, he said. *Please. Across. At the edge.*

The Stone came down off the cart the way it had come up out of the green. Slowly. As if it had been asked. Sixteen feet of grey rough rock, cracked down the middle, earth still on its foot from four hundred years in the ground at Ashbourne. It slid off the back of the cart onto the rollers, and off the rollers onto the grass, and turned, of its own accord, the way a dog turns before it lies down.

And lay across the end of the road.

North and south. Along the seam. A yard from the crease in the air where the world stopped. With the wind going over it into the nothing, cool and steady, pulling at the grass.

The panel opened over it.

THRESHOLD.

Lex took his hands off the ground.

"*That'll do*," he said.

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NOBODY SLEPT MUCH.

They made camp on the long rise above the end of the road. Four hundred people. More, by now. With their lanterns set out in a ring round

the camp, and a second ring along the top of the rise, and a third, a long line, running north and south a hundred yards back from the seam, as far as the light would reach. Holding the ground. Holding the green. Keeping the grey off while they worked.

The wind blew through all of it. West. Into the nothing. Every flame in every lantern leaning toward the seam like grass in a current.

Lex sat by the cart where the door stood lashed upright on its frame and looked at it.

Seven feet. Three and a half. Apple wood, blooming. Petals coming off it in the wind and blowing west over the Stone and through the seam and away into the white, where they went small and then went nowhere. Hinges of black iron that breathed. A bell on a cord round his neck. A latch in his pocket, gold-grey, plain. A pot of blue paint in the basket at his feet.

Seven Wells.

He'd done the sum a hundred times since the spring. In the Forge. On the floor. On the road. *A wall needs only one Well. A door needs all seven*.

He had all seven. COMMANDING. Every one.

He'd never used all seven at once.

Nobody had. Not since a frightened young man with a little hammer had stood in front of a starving Well with his brother watching and cut his own shadow off at the ankles.

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"*You're thinking too loud*," said Wren.

She sat down beside him. On the grass. With her bow across her knees. She'd been carrying it for nineteen days and hadn't strung it once. Lark was asleep in the cart behind them, in a nest of blankets on the end of the Stone's empty rollers, with Brannoc snoring on one side of her and Seren dozing on the other.

"*I don't know how to do it*," said Lex.

"*You never do*."

"*This is different*."

"*It's always different*." Wren leaned her head on his shoulder. Carefully. On the side without the ribs. "*You didn't know how to make the hinges. You*

didn't know how to make the latch. You didn't know how to say no at a hundred." A pause. *"You just did it. And then you knew."*

Lex didn't say anything.

"You know what Brannoc says," said Wren.

"Brannoc says a lot of things."

"He says you never make anything on your own." She looked at the door. *"He says even a horseshoe takes the horse."*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT THAT for a long time.

Long after Wren had fallen asleep against his shoulder. Long after the camp had gone quiet. He sat by the door-cart in the windy dark with four hundred lanterns leaning toward the edge of the world and thought about it.

A door needs all seven.

Not *a smith with all seven.*

All seven.

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AT DAWN HE WENT to find them.

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TEO FIRST. TEO BRASK, eighteen, who'd been a wet, silent fifteen-year-old at the Keep with a fish called Barnaby in a jar. The Tide Speaker on the coast. Who'd walked two hundred miles from the sea with the jar under his arm because he wouldn't leave the fish with anyone.

He was sitting at the edge of the camp on an upturned bucket, feeding Barnaby crumbs.

"Tide," said Lex.

Teo looked up. Wet, as always. Water running off his sleeves for no reason, the way it had since he Kindled. He looked at Lex for a long moment.

"You said you'd ask," said Teo. *"In the winter. At the council. You said, when it's time, I'll ask."* He set the jar down very carefully on the grass. *"It's time, then."*

"It's time."

Teo stood up.

"*Can Barnaby watch*?" he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN. SHE WAS AWAKE by then. She looked at him over the cart-rail and didn't say anything. She just got down and picked up her bow, unstrung, and came.

Antho. He was with Seraphine, by the lantern line, holding her hair while she was sick into the grass, which she'd been doing every morning for a week and claimed was the baby's opinion of the grey. He looked up at Lex. And stood. And kissed his wife on the top of her head. And came.

His mother. At the fire. With the clay lamp in her lap. She'd been awake all night. She always was.

"*Radiance*," said Lex.

Seren looked at him. With her brown eyes. Hes's eyes.

"*I've never done it*," she said. "*Not properly. I've only ever carried it.*"

"*That's all it is*," said Lex. "*You taught me.*"

She got up. With the lamp.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC.

He found him at the back of the door-cart, checking the lashings for the fortieth time. Brannoc looked round at him with his gold fingertips on a knot.

"*Stone*," said Lex.

"*You've got Stone*," said Brannoc. "*You've had it since you were twenty.*"

"*So have you*," said Lex. "*You've had it since before I was born. You just never asked it anything.*" He held out his hand. "*It's yours too. You've been standing on it for sixty-five years.*"

Brannoc looked at him for a long time.

Then he wiped his hands on his apron. And came.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND MAL.

He didn't go to find Mal. Mal was five hundred miles off, a pool in a green field in the east with five hundred and fifty-six lanterns round it and a boy who didn't talk sitting on the rim.

He knelt on the grass at the end of the road instead. And put his hand flat on it.

Brother, he said. Down. Through the ground. *I need you. It's time.*

For a long time, nothing.

Then, very faint, very far, up through the roots of the world, like the sound in a well when you drop a stone—

[...I know...] A pause. Soft. *[...I've been waiting...I'm room...I'm what a door's for...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

SIX.

And him.

He stood at the end of the road in the dawn wind with the six of them round him—Teo with his wet sleeves, Wren with her unstrung bow, Antho, his mother with the lamp, Brannoc in his apron, and Mal in the ground under all of them—and looked at the door on the cart.

"*Flame*," said Lex. "*That's me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY HUNG IT AT noon.

Everyone helped.

◆ ◆ ◆

FORTY MEN ON THE ropes again. Tom Pruett at the top of a ladder. The door, on its frame, coming down off the cart. Slowly. Upright. Swinging a little on its breathing hinges, out and back, petals coming off it in the wind. Across the grass. To the Stone.

And onto it.

The foot of the frame on the grey stone. In the middle. Over the crack. Where Lark had stood on the green at Ashbourne with her arms out and said *mine*. Lex had cut two sockets in the stone for the frame's feet the night before with a cold chisel and a lump hammer, the old way, with no

fire. The frame went into them. Snug. Like a foot into a boot that's been worn for years.

The door stood on the threshold.

On the end of the road. At the edge of the world. With the seam a yard behind it, and the nothing beyond, and the wind going past on either side.

Free-standing. A door in a frame on a stone in the middle of nowhere. Like a door in a dream. Like the ruins of a house where everything has fallen down but the door.

Nothing on either side of it.

The wind went round.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not doing anything*," said Davy Pruett. From the crowd. Loudly. Nine years old. "*It's just a door.*"

His father cuffed him. Gently. Not very hard.

"*It's not finished*," said Tom Pruett.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TOOK THE LATCH out of his pocket.

He held it. Small. Plain. Gold-grey. Warm. A bar and a catch and a thumb-plate the size of a child's palm.

He didn't fit it.

Not yet.

He put it back in his pocket and turned round. To the six. To the crowd on the rise behind them, four hundred people with lanterns in their hands, standing in a long curve on the green grass with the grey beyond them and the wind at their backs. All looking at him.

"*It needs all seven*," said Lex. Loud. So the crowd could hear. His voice went away on the wind. He made it louder. "*All seven Wells. That's what Malachi wrote. A wall needs one. A door needs all seven.*"

The crowd waited.

"*I thought that meant me*," said Lex. "*Because I've got all seven.*" He looked down at his hands. Burned. Healing. Common. "*I was wrong. I thought it about a lot of things. I thought the net had to be held. I thought somebody had to wear the crown. I thought a hundred was the top.*"

Somebody in the crowd laughed. Shakily.

"*It needs all seven*," said Lex. "*Not one man with seven. Seven. And everyone they love.*" He looked at the crowd. "*Everyone who ever lit a lantern for anyone. Everyone who ever kept a window.*"

He held out his hand.

"*Please*," said Lex Vey. "*Help me make a door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

TEO WENT FIRST.

He came forward to the threshold. With Barnaby in his jar in the crook of his arm. Dripping. And knelt on the grey stone at the foot of the door. And put his free hand flat on the bottom of the frame.

And opened his mouth. And the sea came out.

Not water. The *sound* of it. The long slow breath of the tide going out over shingle at Gull's Reach. Out. And back. The turn. The thing Lex had heard at the bottom of the Undertow, in the winter, holding his grief like a stone in his chest. *Out. And back.*

The hinges heard it.

They'd been quenched in it. In the Undertow's turning water. They knew it. They took a breath—a real one, Lex saw the black iron swell and settle—and the door swung. On its own. Out. And back. And out. And back. Like the tide. Like breathing.

And stayed. Breathing. Gently. On its own.

Teo took his hand away. He was crying. Water ran off him in sheets.

"*That's Tide*," said Teo. "*It goes out and it comes back. That's all it is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WENT SECOND.

She didn't kneel. She stood in front of the door with her bow in her hand, unstrung, and her red braid blowing west in the wind. And looked at it for a long time.

Then she breathed in. Deep. From the bottom of her lungs. From the place under her breastbone where the wind lived.

And breathed out.

Not mist. Not gale. Not the First Breath that had lifted Lark into the sky. Just breath. Warm. Soft. The breath you breathe on a cold window, so you can draw on it with your finger.

It went over the door. Over the apple wood. Over the blooming. And every petal on the door lifted at once—Lex saw them—hundreds of them, white and pink, lifting off the wood and hanging in the air in front of it in a cloud, as if they'd been asked to wait.

And settled back.

All of them. Every one. Back onto the wood where they'd been. And stayed. Not blowing off. Not blowing west into the nothing. Staying.

The wind went round the door. Round the frame. Round Wren.

But not through.

"*Gale*," said Wren. Hoarse. "*It carries. It doesn't have to carry away.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WENT THIRD.

He came forward slowly. With his hands open at his sides. The way he walked toward a frightened animal. The way he'd walked toward a little grey girl in a drowned street.

He stood in front of the door.

And put both his hands flat on it. On the apple wood. On the blooming.

And the dark came out of him.

Soft. Starlit. Deep. The way it had come down over Ashbourne like a lid, the night of the reflections, cupping every lantern in the ring. It went into the door. Into the wood. Into the grain of the apple. Into the eleven planks Tom Pruett had cut and planed and fitted with his own hands in the spring.

And Lex saw it.

Not dark. A *shape*. In the wood. In the grain. The way the gaps in the stars on the hill above the Keep had been shapes. Faint. Moving.

People.

The shapes of the dead. Dorran. Garrick. Malachi. Kell, with her stick. Elric. Arion. Old Mag, small, with her stick and her cat. Ada Fell. A bread-woman with flour on her hands. Thousands. Moving in the grain of the apple wood the way fish move in a pond. Going in. Going through. Going home.

"*It's a mould*," said Antho. Very quietly. With his hands on the wood and tears on his face. "*Every door's a mould. It's the shape of everyone who's going to go through it.*"

He took his hands away. The shapes stayed. In the grain. Faint. You had to look.

"*Shade*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WENT FOURTH.

She didn't come to the door. She stood back. A yard off. On the grass in front of the threshold, with the clay lamp in her hands. Wenna's lamp. Cracked across the lip.

"*I don't know how*," she said. To Lex. Quietly.

"*Yes, you do*," said Lex.

Seren looked at him.

Then she looked at the door. Breathing. Blooming. With the shapes of the dead moving in its grain. And held out the lamp.

Not toward it. Not at it. Just out. The way you'd hold a lamp up at a window. So someone coming home in the dark would see it.

And let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LAMP DIDN'T FALL.

It stayed. In the air. In front of the door. Where she'd held it. A small brown clay lamp, cracked across the lip, hanging in the windy air at the height of a woman's hands, burning.

And the door caught the light.

Not reflected. *Took* it. The way a window takes the light of a lamp inside and holds it, so that from outside, in the dark, the whole window glows. The apple wood went gold. All of it. Every plank. Every petal. Soft. Warm. Like a window at night with a lamp behind it.

Lent.

The way Seren had taught him. *Lending with your eyes.* Not giving it away. Not keeping it. Lending. So it would always come back.

The lamp came down. Gently. Into Seren's hands. Still burning.

The door stayed gold.

"*Radiance*," said his mother. She was shaking. "*Oh. Oh, Wenna. That's what you meant.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC WENT FIFTH.

He came to the threshold with his knees cracking. Sixty-five. Gold to the first knuckle on every finger of his left hand. In his apron. He stood on the grey stone at the foot of the door and looked down at it for a long time.

"*I don't know how to ask*," said Brannoc. Gruff. "*I've never asked it anything. I've just stood on it.*"

"*Then just stand on it*," said Lex.

Brannoc looked at him.

Then he planted his feet. On the threshold. Either side of the frame. The way he'd planted them every morning for forty-five years at the great anvil at Ashbourne. Square. Heavy. Rooted. A man who'd stood in one place and swept the floor and banked the fire and been there, every day, when a boy of eleven came in from the snow with nobody.

And the Stone knew him.

Lex felt it. Through his own feet. Through the grass. A hum. Deep. Slow. Like a bell a long way off across fields. The Ashbourne Stone, that had looked at every child in the village for four hundred years and said what they were, looking up at Brannoc Holt standing on it and saying—

There you are.

The crack down the middle of the threshold closed.

Not all the way. Not healed. Just—closed. Like a mouth closing round a word. The two halves of the grey stone came together under the frame and held it. Gripped it. The sockets Lex had cut with a cold chisel tightened round the feet of the frame like hands.

The door was set.

Brannoc stepped off. He didn't say anything. He went and stood by the cart with his back to everyone and his gold fingers over his eyes.

"*Stone*," said Lex. For him.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND MAL.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX KNELT ON THE grass in front of the threshold. And put his hand flat on it.

Brother.

[...I'm here...]

It came up through the ground. Soft. Dark. Patient. Enormous. Up through the roots of the world, five hundred miles, from a pool in a green field. Through the grass. Through the Stone. Into the frame. Into the door.

Into the space *behind* the door.

Lex felt it. Everyone did. The crowd on the rise, four hundred of them, made a sound like wind. Because the door—the free-standing door in its frame on the end of the road, with nothing on either side, with the seam a yard behind it and the wind going round—

The door had a *back*.

Not wood. Not the other side of the planks. A back. A behind. A *room*. As if the door were standing in the wall of a house, and on the other side of it, where there had been a yard of grass and then the seam and then the nothing, there was now—

Space.

Soft. Dark. Waiting. The space in front of things. Room for a baby. A bud. A loaf. A door.

[...that's me...] said the seventh Well. Shyly. *[...I'm what's behind it...I'm where it goes...]*

"*Hollow*," whispered Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

SIX.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

He turned round. To the door. Breathing on its hinges, out and back. Blooming, every petal staying. With the shapes of the dead moving in its grain. Glowing gold as a window at night. Set in a threshold that knew what people were. With room behind it.

And not finished.

The crowd was waiting. The six of them were waiting. He could feel them. Behind him. Waiting for the seventh.

Flame.

He'd had it since he was nineteen. Since he Kindled. Since Ember woke in his chest and said *good morning*. It had been his first. It had been the only one, for a long time. Fire. Heat. The forge.

He reached for it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME.

Through. Not round. The way it had come at the Heart. Straight up out of the earth, out of the Stone, out of the edge of the world, white-gold, roaring, enormous. More than he'd ever felt. More than at the Heart. More than at the lid. More than when he'd sat in the Root's chair with the whole net in his hands. It came up into him like a river into a mill-race and filled him and kept coming.

And a panel opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

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FLAME — COMMANDING

YOU HAVE ALL SEVEN.
YOU STAND AT THE EDGE.

THE FIRE OFFERS: BECOMING.
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE STARED AT IT.

Becoming.

He knew what it meant. He didn't know how. He felt it. In the fire. In the roar. In the heat filling him and filling him. The fire was offering to take him. All of him. Not to drink him, the way the Wells had been drunk. Not to keep him, the way the gold kept. To *become* him. Or him it.

To make him the door's fire.

To set him in the frame the way Ember had been set in his chest. A flame in the door. Forever. A light in the window at the edge of the world.

Keeping it. Warming it. Opening it for the dead and closing it against the grey. Never tired. Never old. Never gone.

He could feel how it would be. Warm. Gold. Enormous. A smith become a forge. A man become a lantern.

Good morning, he'd say. To everyone who came through. Forever.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Wren. Behind him. Very quietly.

He didn't turn round.

"*Lex*," said Wren again. "*What does it say?*"

He looked at the panel.

He thought about Ember. Who'd been a flame in a man's chest. Who'd read every book in the Spire and said good morning every day for seven years and gone into the deep gold and come back and paid a price at the Veil and was a flame in a lantern now, on a boat, on a river, courteous, curious, with no love in it for anyone.

He thought about Lark.

Asleep in the cart. Twenty months old. Who'd want to show him her first horseshoe. Her first nail. Her first lantern. Who'd want him to hold the hammer with her and bring it down.

He thought about a forge at five in the morning, with the fire banked, and Brannoc snoring through the wall.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Lex.

To the fire. Gently. The way you'd say it to a friend who's offered you something too big to take.

"*No. Thank you. I'm a smith.*" He looked at the door. "*I make things. I don't become them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

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BECOMING
DECLINED.
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◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE DIDN'T GO away.

He'd half thought it would. He'd half thought that saying no would be like the Sovereign, like the crown—that the gold would go out of the panel and the fire would go down and leave him cold.

It didn't.

It stayed. White-gold. Roaring. Filling him. And under the roar, faint, warm, in a voice he'd never heard it use before—not Ember's, not anyone's, just *fire*—

[Good.]

A pause.

[Then make it.]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK THE LATCH out of his pocket.

He held it out. In his left hand. In front of the door. And with his right, his burned right, he took the bell off its cord round his neck. Malachi's bell. Small. Bronze. Dented. The bell an old man had rung to call his goats home across the Pale Wastes, and Hesper had rung, before that, a long time before that, at a garden door, all night, in case anybody wanted to come out.

And he put the fire into both of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T NEED AN anvil.

The door was the anvil. The threshold was the anvil. The edge of the world was the anvil. He stood in front of it with the fire pouring through him and the latch and the bell in his hands, and he *made*.

The bracket for the bell. Out of nothing. Out of the heat. A curl of black iron growing out of the top of the frame like a fern uncurling, a hook at the end, and the bell on the hook. Swinging. Not ringing. Waiting.

The keeper for the latch. Out of the frame. A notch of iron, for the catch to drop into. And the pin, through the thumb-plate. And the bar, across the door. And the hook, at the end of the bar, falling into the keeper.

Click.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LATCH DROPPED.

The door shut.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND STOPPED.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL AT ONCE. EVERYWHERE. The wind that had been blowing past them for three days, west, out of the world, into the nothing—pulling at their clothes and their hair and leaning every lantern flame toward the edge—stopped.

Not slowed. Stopped. As if someone had closed a window.

Every lantern flame on the rise straightened up. Four hundred of them. More. All at once. Standing straight. Still. Burning upright in the windless air like candles in a church.

The silence was enormous.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD IN FRONT of the door.

With the fire going out of him. Slowly. Gently. Not draining. Settling. Like a forge banked for the night. With his burned hand still held out where the latch had been.

The door was shut.

Seven feet. Three and a half. Apple wood, blooming, every petal staying. Gold as a window at night. Breathing on its hinges. With the shapes of the dead in its grain and a bell on a bracket over its head and a plain gold-grey latch across it. Set in a threshold that knew what people were. With room behind it.

And on either side of it—

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SEAM WAS GONE.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED. NORTH. SOUTH. As far as he could see. The crease in the air, the line where the world stopped, the place where the Veil had hung for nine hundred years—

Gone.

Not closed. Not walled. Not sealed. *Pulled in*. Toward the door. All of it. The whole length of the edge of the world, hundreds of miles, drawn in toward the frame on the threshold at the end of the road the way a cloth draws tight round a buttonhole when you pull the thread.

There was no edge any more.

There was a door.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Paint*," said Lex.

His voice came out hoarse. He didn't know he'd said it until he heard it.

His mother was beside him. With the pot. Harrow blue. She'd mixed it in the spring at the Forge, from woad and lime and something she wouldn't tell anybody, the way Wenna had, the way every Harrow woman had, for every door at Harrow for four hundred years. She held it out with a brush in it.

He didn't take the brush.

He turned round.

To the crowd. Four hundred people on the rise, standing in the still air with their lanterns burning straight up.

"*Everyone*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN.

All of them. One at a time. In a long line, the way they'd walked the green road. Each one taking the brush from the one before. And painting.

Not much. A stroke. A dab. Some of them just put a finger in the pot and touched it to the wood. Hollis Penn painted a loaf. Badly. Tilda painted a hammer. Davy Pruett painted his own name, very large, before his father could stop him, and then looked appalled at himself, and then painted *sorry* underneath, smaller. Teo painted a fish. Kestrel painted a flame and then, after a moment, a small sleeping girl beside it—Tamsin, Lex thought. Jem Tolley painted a bee. Old Mag's neighbour painted an apple.

Rhosyn painted a rose. With her bound hand. Crooked.

The King painted nothing. He came to the door last of the grown folk and stood in front of it, gold, enormous, with the brush in his huge hand,

for a long time. Then he gave the brush back to Seren without using it, and put his gold palm flat on the wood. Lightly. Over the place where the handle would be, if it had a handle.

The wood didn't go gold.

He took his hand away. And there was a print there. In the wet blue. A big hand. Five fingers.

Blue.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND LARK.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN BROUGHT HER DOWN from the cart. Half asleep. Furious about it. With her black hair flat on one side and her fists in her eyes. She set her down on the threshold in front of the door, on the grey stone that had closed its crack.

Lark looked at the door.

At the blue. At the loaves and the hammers and the fish and the bee and the rose and the name and the *sorry*. At the big blue handprint.

At the pot.

She put her whole hand in it.

Before anyone could stop her. Right in. Up to the wrist. And took it out, dripping, blue to the elbow, and looked at it with enormous satisfaction.

And slapped it on the door.

Low. At her own height. A small square handprint. Short strong fingers. Wide palm. Blue.

Right under the latch.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mine*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY LAUGHED THIS TIME.

The whole of the rise was very quiet. Four hundred people in the still air with their lanterns burning straight up, looking at a small blue handprint on a door at the end of the world.

Lex knelt down beside his daughter on the threshold. With his ribs. And looked at it with her.

Her hands are very square, the Glass Queen had said. In the spring. In his panel. With a crown on his head.

They were.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STILL KNEELING there when it happened.

The door was shut. The latch was down. The wind had stopped. The paint was wet. The lanterns burned straight up.

And from the other side—from the room behind the door, from the space in front of things, from where the edge of the world had been—

Somebody knocked.

◆ ◆ ◆

THREE TIMES.

Slow. Soft. Patient. Polite.

The way you knock on a door you've been standing outside of for a very long time, in case somebody wants to let you in.

CHAPTER 33

The Doorkeeper

NOBODY MOVED.

Antho heard the knock the way he'd heard the dead say their names on the hill above the Keep. Not with his ears. Lower. In the place under his ribs where the Murmur had lived for eight years, eating him, and where there was room now. Quiet. A threshold.

Three knocks.

Slow. Soft. Patient.

Polite.

◆ ◆ ◆

FOUR HUNDRED PEOPLE STOOD on the rise in the windless air with their lanterns burning straight up and looked at the door.

Seven feet. Three and a half. Apple wood, blooming, gold as a lit window. Painted blue in four hundred strokes. Loaves and hammers and fish and bees and a rose and a big gold king's handprint and a small square child's. Breathing on its hinges. Latched.

Standing at the end of the road. On a threshold of grey stone. With nothing on either side of it.

And somebody on the other side of it, knocking.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS STILL ON his knees on the threshold. With Lark beside him, blue to the elbow, looking at the door with her head on one side, the way a dog does at a strange noise.

"*Somebody's there*," said Lark. Very clearly.

It was the longest sentence she'd ever said.

Nobody noticed.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD UP.

Slowly. With his ribs. He put his thumb on the latch. On the plate. The small round plate the size of a child's palm, gold-grey, that had been a crown three weeks ago, at the bottom of the world.

And pressed.

The latch didn't lift.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PRESSED AGAIN. HARDER. Antho saw his brother's thumb go white on the plate. Saw the muscles in his forearm stand out. A smith's forearm. Twenty years of hammers.

The latch didn't move.

Not stuck. Not locked. Antho could see that from where he stood. It wasn't the kind of not moving that iron does when it's rusted, or jammed, or frozen. It was the kind of not moving a dog does when the wrong person calls it.

Lex took his thumb away.

He looked at the latch for a long time.

"*It's not mine*," he said. Quietly. Wonderingly. "*I made it. And it's not mine.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN TRIED.

Then Seren. Then Brannoc, with his gold fingertips, swearing under his breath. Then Teo. Then the King, who put one huge gold finger under the plate, very gently, as if afraid he'd snap it, and lifted, and the latch sat there and didn't lift, and the King took his hand away and looked at it and didn't seem surprised.

The knock came again.

Three times. Slow. Soft. Patient.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Seraphine.

Behind him. On the grass. With her horn spectacles and her quill and her hand on her belly.

He turned round.

She was looking at him. Not at the door. At him. The way she'd looked at him the first time, years ago, when he'd been a monster with a thing in his chest and she'd been a scribe with a notebook. As if she could see the shape of the gap round him. As if she'd heard something in the quiet.

"*It's a door*," said Seraphine Ilvane. Very softly. "*And you're the Threshold Warden.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D BEEN CALLED A lot of things.

Error. That was the first. At his Kindling. Sixteen. In front of the Stone on the green at Ashbourne. *ANTHOREN VEY. CLASS: ERROR.* And then the black flash, and the scream, and the fire, and his mother walking into the dark, and eight years of not being anything anyone had a name for.

Hollow-Touched Warlock. *Corrupted Unique*. The net hadn't known what to call him. Neither had he.

Monster. People had called him that. In villages. On roads. Before Seraphine. Before Lex came and found him.

Brother. The thing in his chest had called him that. In the dark. In the mad years. *Brother. Mal.* And then, later, when he'd understood, when the thing in his chest had turned out not to be a monster at all but a hungry Well, a little one, a hollow, a room that had been waiting nine hundred years for somebody to ask it in—

Brother. It still called him that.

Threshold Warden. That was the last. After the Hollowmaw. After the Heart. The one who stood at the edge. Who kept the dark from the light and the light from the dark and walked between them and spoke to both.

He'd never thought about what it meant.

A threshold was the bit under a door.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED DOWN THE slope.

The grass was soft under his boots. Real grass. Green. The lanterns behind him burned straight up. The four hundred watched him. He didn't look at them. He looked at the door.

His brother stepped aside.

Lex didn't say anything. He just stepped off the threshold onto the grass, with Lark on his hip, blue to the elbow. And looked at Antho. Crooked smile. The one that made him look about twelve.

Antho stepped up onto the grey stone.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HUMMED.

Under his feet. The Ashbourne Stone. That had looked at every child in Ashbourne for four hundred years, and at Lex, and split. That had stood on the green while the whole village walked past it into their lives. That had looked at a boy of sixteen, once, and screamed, and flashed black, and sent him home to a cottage that burned that night.

It knew him.

It hummed anyway. Low. Deep. Slow. Like a bell a long way off.

And a panel opened in front of his face.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ANTHO VEY
Class: THRESHOLD WARDEN (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 98
Experience: 1,105,882 / 1,108,000
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT.

He hadn't looked at his panel since the freeze broke. He hadn't had time. Three weeks on the road. A boat on a river. The Heart. He'd glanced at it once, on the white floor, when the WORLD NOTICE came, and seen the numbers moving, and looked away.

They were still moving.

Faster than he'd ever seen them move.

He watched the last number tick. And tick. And tick. Not a hair at a time. A trickle. A stream. Pouring in from somewhere. From the door. From the threshold under his feet. From the four hundred people on the rise behind him, and the lanterns, and the green road going back east two hundred miles with a light every mile.

From everyone who'd ever kept a window.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ANTHO VEY
Class: THRESHOLD WARDEN (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 99
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T FEEL IT. Not the way he'd felt levels when he was young, when every one had been a jolt, a fever, a rush of heat. He just stood on the threshold and watched the panel change. *98. 99.* Like watching a candle burn down.

The knock came again. From the other side.

Three times.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NUMBERS WENT ON.

He watched them. Lex had told him, on the river, in the boat, in a low voice in the dark, what had happened at a hundred. The gold panel. The question. *TAKE UP THE CROWN. HOLD THE NET. KEEP WHAT IS YOURS.*

He'd laughed, when Lex told him. He'd laughed so hard in the boat that the Ferryman had turned his hooded head to look.

He wasn't laughing now.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEVEL 100

THE CEILING OF TIER IV IS REACHED.
TIER V AWAITS.
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◆ ◆ ◆

AND UNDER IT, SLOWLY, the way frost spreads—

◆ ◆ ◆

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TIER V — SOVEREIGN

KEEP THE DOOR.
HOLD THE EDGE.
NONE PASS BUT BY YOUR LEAVE.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STARED AT IT.

None pass but by your leave.

He knew what it was offering. He understood it at once, the way he'd understood the Murmur in the end, the way he understood the dead. It wasn't a crown. There was no crown any more. His brother had beaten it into a latch.

It was the door.

The door at the edge of the world. The only door. Every dead soul in Caldor would come to it. Every grey column of dust. Every lantern-bearer, at the end. Every old woman under every apple tree. They'd all come to the door at the end of the road, and stand on the threshold, and wait. And he'd decide.

In. Or *not yet*.

Through. Or *stay*.

Forever. Never tired. Never old. Never gone. Like the Ferryman, but more. Not rowing. *Ruling*. Sovereign of the Threshold. King of the edge of the world.

Keeper.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT THE King.

Standing on the white road for nine hundred years with nine thousand people behind him, all of them kept, all of them gold, because he couldn't stand to watch them go.

He thought about the bread-woman. On the floor of the empty hall. Coming apart with her daughter in her arms. And a gold king walking past.

He thought about the six lanterns in a grey square in the Drowned Country. And the dead standing round them for years, in the cold, because it was warm there. And then turning, all of them, when there was somewhere better to go. Not because anyone told them. Because they could.

He thought about Seraphine, on the grass behind him, with her hand on her belly.

He thought: *if I take this, I'll never die.*

He thought: *I'll never see it grow up, either. Not properly. Not the way you see someone grow up when you're growing old beside them. I'll stand at this door forever and it'll come to me at the end, an old woman, a stranger, and I'll decide whether to let my own child through.*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Antho Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

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TIER V — SOVEREIGN
DECLINED.
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◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD WENT OUT of it.

And the question came. The way Lex had said it would. In the hum. In the threshold under his feet. In the space where the panel had been.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEVEL 100.
THE CEILING IS REACHED.

WHAT ARE YOU?
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T HAVE TO think about it.

He'd been thinking about it all his life. In the ditch on the Blightmarch road. On the hill above the Keep, counting eleven hundred lanterns every morning. At the rim. At the pool. In a grey square, crying.

What are you.

He looked at the door in front of him. Blue. Blooming. Gold. Latched. With somebody on the other side, knocking.

"*I'm the one who opens it*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
ANTHO VEY
Class: DOORKEEPER
Grade: Common
Level 100
Ceiling: NONE
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◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND HIM, HE HEARD his brother make a sound.

He didn't turn round. He knew what it was. Lex, on the grass, with Lark on his hip, laughing. Helplessly. Painfully. Holding his ribs. The way Antho had laughed on the white floor of the Heart.

"*Common*," said Lex. Wheezing. "*Antho. You absolute—*"

"*Shut up*," said Antho.

He was laughing too. He couldn't help it. His eyes were running.

Doorkeeper. *Common*.

Like a man at the gate of a field. Like a woman at the door of a bakery at five in the morning, turning the sign. Like a boy at the Keep, at dawn, letting the cat out.

Like everyone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT HIS THUMB on the latch.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT LIFTED.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT EASILY. NOT BY itself. He had to press. The plate was cold under his thumb and then warm, and the bar rose out of the keeper, slowly, the way a latch rises on any cottage door, with a small dry scrape of metal on metal. He felt it come up. Felt the catch clear the notch.

And the door swung.

On its breathing hinges. Out. Toward him. The way a door swings when you've lifted the latch and somebody on the other side has been leaning on it.

And the bell rang.

Malachi's bell. Hesper's bell. On its bracket over the frame. Once. Small. Clear.

The way a bell rings when somebody opens the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THE ROOM.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS DARK.

Not grey. Not the grey of the grey country, that was still and flat and dead. Not the nothing beyond the seam, that had never been anything. Dark. Soft. Deep. The dark of a room at night with the lamps out and everyone asleep and the fire banked in the hearth. The dark of a cellar where things are kept to grow. The dark of the inside of a seed.

Room.

And stars.

Not in the sky. In the dark. All round. Near and far. Small lights. Thousands. Millions. Hanging in the soft dark like the stars on the hill above the Keep. And between them, in the gaps—Antho saw it, and couldn't breathe—shapes. The shapes of the dead. Drifting. Going in. Going on. Not lost. Not grey. Just going. The way people go through a house at night, from room to room, with a candle.

And far off. Down. At the bottom of the dark. Small.

A pool.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNEW IT.

He'd have known it anywhere. He'd sat on its rim every morning for a year. A pool in a green circle. In a field. In the east. With a ring of lanterns round it in the long grass, five hundred and fifty-six, burning gold. With three lights in its middle, under the water. And a stone house on the slope above it with a fat chimney and a lantern in the window.

And three hundred and something gold people standing in the grass round the rim, each with a grey column of dust in front of them, bending.

And a boy.

Sitting on the rim. With his knees drawn up. Fifteen. Thin. With a stub of pencil behind his ear.

Looking up.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM SAW HIM.

Across the whole of the dark. Five hundred miles. Through a door that hadn't been there an hour ago. A boy on a pool's rim, looking up at the sky over the green circle, and seeing—Antho didn't know what he saw. A door in the sky. A gold window, open, high up, with a man standing in it.

Pim stood up.

He didn't say anything. He never did, if he could help it.

He just lifted his hand. Slowly. And waved.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAVED BACK.

He couldn't speak. He stood on the threshold of the door at the edge of the world with his hand up, waving at a boy five hundred miles away across the soft dark of his brother's room, and couldn't say a word.

[...brother...] said the room.

All round him. Soft. Deep. Glad. Like the sound in a well when you drop a stone and listen and hear it land, at last, in water.

[...brother...you opened it...]

"*Yes*," said Antho. Hoarse. "*Hello, Mal.*"

[...hello...] A pause. Shy. *[...there's someone here...he's been waiting...he knocked...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN STOOD ON the other side of the door.

Antho hadn't seen him. He'd been looking past. At the stars. At the pool. At Pim. He looked now.

Tall. Grey. Hooded. A yard away. Standing in the soft dark on the far side of the threshold, with his long oar in one hand like a staff, and his lantern in the other. With the small gold flame on its post.

He'd been there all along. On the other side. Knocking.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Warden*," said the Ferryman.

"*Doorkeeper*," said Antho. "*Now.*"

The hood tilted. Very slightly.

"*So I see*," said the Ferryman.

He didn't move. He stood on his side of the threshold, in the dark, in the room. Not coming through. Antho looked at him and understood that he wouldn't. Not without being asked. He'd stood on the edge of every room in the world for longer than there'd been rooms, and he'd never once come in.

"*You knocked*," said Antho.

"*I did*."

"*Why*?"

The Ferryman was silent for a long time.

"*Because there's a door*," he said. "*There's never been a door before. Only edges. Only the river. Only the shore. I've stood on a lot of edges.*" The hooded head turned. Slowly. Looking at the frame. At the blue paint. At the blooming wood. At the bell. "*I've never knocked on anything. I wanted to see what it was like.*"

"*What was it like*?"

"*Strange*," said the Ferryman. "*Waiting to be let in.*" A pause. "*I don't know how they bear it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[He's been rowing for a very long time,] said the lantern. On its post. Helpfully. Courteously. *[He told me. On the river. He said he'd quite like to sit down.]*

The Ferryman looked down at the flame.

Antho had never seen a hooded face look embarrassed. He saw it now.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*May I come in*?" said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO THOUGHT ABOUT IT.

He thought about a moth at a window at Harrow, in the autumn, years ago. *May I come in*? And someone at the window, with a lamp. *No*.

He thought about a gold king at the doors of the Forge at midnight. *May I come in*? And Brannoc. *Mind the floor. It's been swept.*

He thought about a door. That was all a door was. A place where somebody asked, and somebody answered.

Up was yes.

Down was no.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Yes*," said Antho. "*Come in. Mind the step.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN CAME THROUGH the door.

Slowly. One long grey foot over the threshold. Onto the grey stone. Then the other. Ducking his hooded head under the lintel, because he was very tall, and the door was a cottage door, made by a smith for people.

And stood on the threshold of the world.

In the light.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS EVENING. ANTHO hadn't noticed. The sun was going down. Low. Gold. And it came across the rise and the lanterns and the grass and the grey stone and fell on the Ferryman's hood.

He stood there.

He lifted his long grey face. Out of the shadow of the hood. Just a little. Just enough. Antho saw it, for the first time, in all the times he'd called him. Old. Very old. Lined like a riverbank. Grey as river stones. With eyes that were the colour of water over stones in the dark.

He looked at the sun.

"*Oh*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT DOWN.

On the threshold. On the grey stone. Just like that. As if his legs had decided for him. He sat down with his back against the door frame and his long oar across his knees and his lantern on the stone beside him, and the evening sun on his face, and closed his eyes.

"*I'd like to sit down*," said the Ferryman. A little late. To nobody. "*Just for a bit.*"

Nobody said anything.

Four hundred people on the rise, with their lanterns burning straight up in the windless air, watched the oldest thing in the world sit on a doorstep in the sun with his eyes shut.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Is this the end?] said the lantern. On the stone beside him. Interested. *[Of the story? I'd like to write it down properly.]*

The Ferryman didn't open his eyes.

"*Not yet*," he said.

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ANTHO STOOD IN THE doorway.

Between the room and the world. With one hand on the frame and one on the open door. With the soft dark behind him, full of stars and shapes and a pool five hundred miles away with a boy on its rim. With the evening in front of him, and the rise, and the four hundred, and the lanterns.

With the Ferryman sitting at his feet.

He looked up the slope.

At Seraphine. On the grass. With her hand on her belly and her quill stopped on the page and her face wet behind the horn. At Lex, with Lark asleep on his shoulder, blue to the elbow. At Wren. At his mother, with the clay lamp. At Brannoc.

At the King.

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THE KING WAS COMING down the slope.

Slowly. Gold. Enormous. The grass staying green under his feet. With a white petal in one hand. And a thin silver-grey crown in the other.

Rosie was beside him.

Barefoot. Forty years old. With thorns in her hair and her hands still bound in linen. With a small folded packet held against her chest. Walking beside her brother the way you'd walk beside someone very old, very tired, going somewhere they've put off going for a long time. Close. Not holding his arm. Ready to.

They stopped at the bottom of the slope. A few yards from the threshold.

The King looked at the door. At the open door. At the soft dark beyond it, full of stars. At the pool, far off, at the bottom. At the three hundred gold people in the grass round its rim.

His household.

He looked at them for a long time.

Then he looked down at the crown in his hand. Hes's crown. Small. Silver-grey. Seven points. Thin. Plain. The crown that had said no to the Key and broken it in three. The crown Harrow women had carried in a box under a flagstone for nine hundred years.

It's got one more no in it, Seren had said.

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"*Rosie*," said Oszric.

"*Yes, Oz*."

"*Will you hold this a moment*?"

He gave her the petal. White. Pink at the edges. She took it in her bound hand. Carefully. The way you'd hold a moth.

And the King lifted Hesper's crown in both his huge gold hands.

And put it on.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS FAR TOO small for him. It sat on top of his great gold head like a ring on a thumb. Silver-grey on gold. Ridiculous. Nobody laughed.

The King stood at the bottom of the slope at the edge of the world with his little sister's crown on his head, and looked at the open door.

"*Walk me to the door*," he said.

CHAPTER 34

The Last No

HE HAD HELD THE tongs.

That was the first thing Oszric remembered. Before the pool. Before the drinking. Before the grey and the white road and the nine hundred years. He'd been nine, and his big brother had been nineteen, and their father had been dying in the room upstairs, slowly, the wasting kind, the kind where you watch someone get thinner every morning like a candle burning down. And Aurelian had gone down to the forge in the night because he couldn't sleep, and Oszric had followed him because he couldn't either.

Hold these, Aurelian had said. And put the tongs in his hands. *Don't let go. Whatever happens. Hold on.*

He'd held on.

He'd been holding on ever since.

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THE CROWN WAS TOO small for him.

He could feel it. Sitting on the top of his head like a ring on a thumb. Silver-grey. Cold. Thin. It didn't go gold. Nothing had gone gold since the Heart—not the white stone, not the grass of the green road, not the petal Rosie was holding for him now in her bound hand—but he'd thought, perhaps, the crown might. It had been his little sister's. It had been in the family.

It sat there. Grey. Itself.

It's got one more no in it, the Harrow woman had said.

He hoped so. He didn't have any of his own.

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"*Walk me to the door*," he said.

Rosie took his arm.

She didn't hold it. She couldn't. Her hands were still bound up in linen from the glass, and anyway it was a big arm, a gold arm, the size of a small tree. She just put her bandaged hand on it. Lightly. Above the elbow. The way you'd lay your hand on the arm of someone very old who might need it on the stairs.

They walked.

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IT WAS A FEW yards. From the bottom of the slope to the threshold. Ten steps. Twelve. He'd walked two hundred and forty miles from the Veil to the Harrow woman's door in the winter, and two hundred more on the green road, and nine hundred years before that up and down the white road with nine thousand people behind him.

These were the longest steps he had ever taken.

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THE DOOR WAS OPEN.

The Doorkeeper stood in it. The tall one. The dark one. The one who'd been a monster once, they said, and had a hungry Well in his chest, and talked to the dead. He stood in the open door with one hand on the frame and one on the blue wood, and behind him, the room.

Soft. Dark. Deep. Full of stars. With shapes moving in the gaps between them, going in, going on. And far down, at the bottom, a long way off, a pool. Green grass round it. Gold lanterns in a ring.

And people standing in the grass.

Gold.

His.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED ON THE threshold.

Not on it. In front of it. On the grass. With the grey stone a foot in front of his toes. And the Ferryman sitting on it, with his back against the

frame, and his long oar across his knees, and his eyes closed in the last of the evening sun.

Oszric looked down at him.

The Ferryman didn't open his eyes.

"*You're not on my list*," said the Ferryman. Quietly. Without moving. "*You've never been on my list. I told you that. On the shingle. Nine hundred years ago. When I rowed you out.*"

"*I remember*," said Oszric.

"*That was your punishment*," said the Ferryman. "*Not mine. You drank the Well of endings. You can't have one.*"

"*I know*," said Oszric. "*I've had a long time to think about it.*"

The Ferryman was silent.

Then he opened his eyes. Grey. The colour of water over stones in the dark. And looked up. At the gold king standing over him. At the little silver-grey crown on his head.

He looked at the crown for a long time.

"*Ah*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC LOOKED PAST HIM.

Through the door. Down through the soft dark. To the pool. To the green grass. To the gold people standing in it, three hundred and some, each with a column of grey dust in front of them, bending.

He could feel them.

He'd always been able to feel them. Every one he'd ever kept. It was the hold. The one hand. Nine thousand threads, gold, running out of his chest to every person he'd ever touched or breathed on or looked at with his gold eyes and thought *no, not you, I can't bear it, stay*. He felt them the way you feel your own fingers. The way you feel your own heart.

Three hundred and some at the pool.

And the rest. All over the world.

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HE FELT THEM NOW. All of them. He let himself.

On the roads. In the fields. In the long grass at the edges of villages where they'd stopped walking, because they'd forgotten where home was. Standing. Humming. *Home*.

At a gate in the east wall of the Court, far out in the white, a man in a Keeper's coat with his staff held crosswise. Gold. Kept in the winter when he wouldn't let a king's household through. *Roole*. Oszric had never learned his first name.

In a barley field on a hill above a village called Westerling, a young man with his hand up. Gold. Kept in the spring when he stood between Orrin's dust and his mother. And beside him, on the wall, an old woman with a lantern. Sitting. Waiting.

At the edge of the camp on the rise behind him. A big grey-haired man in a leather apron, with gold to the first knuckle on every finger of his left hand. A young woman beside him, broad-shouldered, with a smith's hammer on her back and her right hand gold to the wrist. The smith's wife. Two gold fingers and a gold thumb.

The Doorkeeper. Standing in the door. With a gold coin on the back of his left hand, where a pinch of dust had landed in the winter on the green at Ashbourne.

At the pool, five hundred miles off—a big man with a staff and his right arm gold to the elbow.

In a little room off the east stair of a keep in the mountains, an old woman in a chair under a window. Gold. With her eyes moving. Who'd said *no, thank you*, very faintly, *I don't want to be kept*, *I want to go and see my boy*. And her husband had said yes for her. Because he couldn't bear it.

Bet. Oszric remembered her name. Orrin had told him.

He'd never met her. He'd kept her anyway.

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AND AT THE POOL. In the grass. Beside a stone house with a lantern in the window. A little gold girl. Eight. Barefoot. In a kitchen smock with a burn-mark on the hem.

Holding the hand of a boy who didn't talk.

With a grey column of dust beside her. Bending over her. The way a woman bends over a cot.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC SHUT HIS EYES.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can't*," he said.

Very quietly. To Rosie. To nobody.

"*I've tried*," he said. "*Every night. Since the smith's old man. Since Brannoc. I sat in the dark with the petal in my hand and I tried. One finger. Just one. Just the little one. Just to see.*" His voice was shaking. "*And it wasn't one finger. It was all of them. All at once. I felt them start to go. Like sand. Like Maudie on the floor of the hall. Nine thousand of them. Frightened. Cold.*"

"*I know*," said Rosie.

"*And I grabbed it back*," said Oszric. "*Every time. I couldn't help it. It's not a thing I do. It's a thing I am.*" He opened his eyes. "*I've been holding on since I was nine years old, Rosie. Since Aurelian put the tongs in my hands. I don't know how to let go. I've never known.*"

Rosie didn't say anything.

She just stood beside him. With her bandaged hand on his gold arm. Lightly. Above the elbow.

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"*Oz*," she said, after a while.

"*Yes*."

"*Do you remember Hes in the garden*?"

He didn't answer. He didn't need to.

"*The night after the pool*," said Rosie. "*After we drank. All of us. Mae and Ysy and Cad and you and me. And Hes didn't.*" Her voice was very soft. "*We were all in the hall. Shaking. Burning. Full of it. And Hes went out into the garden. And sat in the door. All night.*"

"*In case one of us wanted to come out*," said Oszric.

"*In case one of us wanted to come out*," said Rosie.

She looked up at the crown. On his head. Small. Silver-grey. Too small.

"*She's still sitting there*," said Rhosyn. "*Oz. In the door. That's what that is. That's all it is. It's Hes, in the garden door, all night, saying no.*" She

swallowed. "*Not no to you. No to the hall. No to the drinking. No to the keeping.*" Her bound hand tightened on his arm. "*You don't have to say it yourself. You never could. She'll say it for you. That's what she was waiting for.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT THE door.

The open door. Blue. Blooming. Gold as a lit window. With the Doorkeeper standing in it, and the Ferryman sitting on its step, and the soft dark behind it full of stars, and his household at the bottom, in the grass, waiting.

The door at the edge of the world.

Not the garden door. But a door.

And somebody in it. All night. In case.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*All right*," said Oszric.

He took Rosie's bandaged hand off his arm. Gently. And held it. In his huge gold one. Carefully. So as not to hurt the cuts.

"*Don't let go*," he said.

"*I won't*," said Rosie. "*Silly. I never have.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STEPPED ONTO THE threshold.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN MOVED HIS oar.

Just a little. Out of the way. So the King's foot could come down on the grey stone beside him without touching it. The way you'd move your stick out of the way for someone coming up the stairs.

The Stone hummed.

It knew him. Oszric felt it. The Ashbourne Stone, that had looked at every child for four hundred years and said what they were. It looked at him now. Up. Through the soles of his gold feet. And said what he was.

He didn't need a panel. He'd never had one. The Crowned were older than the net.

But he knew what it said.

◆ ◆ ◆

KEEPER.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CROWN ON HIS head went cold.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT COLD LIKE THE glass. Not cold like the grey. Cold like a garden at night in early spring, with dew on the grass and the stars out and the door of the hall open behind you, spilling gold light onto the path. Cold like a girl of seventeen sitting on a doorstep in her nightdress with her arms round her knees, shivering, not going in.

Cold like *no*.

◆ ◆ ◆

No, said the crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T SAY IT to him. It didn't say it out loud. It said it the way the net said things. In the hum. In the threshold. In the gold threads running out of Oszric's chest to nine thousand people all over the world.

It said it down every one of them.

No.

Not you.

Not ever.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT THE HOLD break.

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IT WASN'T A LETTING go. He'd been right about that. He'd never have been able to let go. It wasn't in him.

It was the hand being opened *for* him.

Gently. Finger by finger. All at once. The way someone opens the fist of a child who's holding something he shouldn't—a coal, a knife, a bee—and won't let go, and can't, because he's frightened. You don't pull. You don't pry. You just put your hand over his and say *no, love*, and hold it, and wait, until the fingers open on their own.

His opened.

All nine thousand.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT THEM GO.

◆ ◆ ◆

ROOLE, AT THE EAST gate, in the white. The gold going off him like frost off a window in the sun. Not coming apart. He was young. He'd only been kept since the winter. The gold went, and underneath it was a man. Grey-haired. Grim-mouthed. In a Keeper's coat. Blinking. With his staff in his hands held crosswise, still, across a gate that nobody was trying to come through any more.

He lowered it.

Oszric felt him lower it.

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COL ASHBY, IN THE barley, on the hill above Westerling. The gold going. A young man with his hand up. Standing in the green barley—green, it was green, the grey had gone off that hillside in the spring when his mother sat down beside him with a lantern—and lowering his hand. Slowly. And turning round. And seeing an old woman on the wall of the field with a lantern in her lap.

Mam, said Col Ashby.

There you are, said Nan.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC HOLT, ON THE rise. The gold going off his fingertips. Five of them. Like five little candle flames going out. Leaving fingers. Old. Scarred. Burned at the tips from forty-five years at the forge.

He looked down at them. Then he put them in his mouth, the way a boy does when he's caught them in a door, and turned away so nobody would see his face.

◆ ◆ ◆

TILDA. HER HAND.

The smith's wife. Two fingers and a thumb.

Oszric felt her go still. Felt her look down. Felt her flex them. Pink. Stiff. Cold. Alive. Felt her make a fist. Open it. Make a fist.

Felt her start to cry, very quietly, with her face in the smith's shoulder.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOORKEEPER.

He was standing right there. In the door. A yard away. Oszric felt the gold coin on the back of his left hand go—just go, like a breath off glass—and the Doorkeeper look down at the place where it had been, and then up. At Oszric. With his dark eyes.

He didn't say anything.

He nodded. Very slightly. The way you nod to a man across a room who has done something hard.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN A LITTLE room off the east stair of a keep in the mountains—

Bet Dale.

The gold went off her like a breath off a window. And under it, an old woman. Thin. Grey. In a chair under a window. With her eyes moving, and then not just her eyes. Her hands. Her mouth. Her chest. In. Catch. Silence. In again.

An old man on a stool beside the chair, with his shepherd's crook against the wall, lifted his head.

Fen, said Bet Dale. Very faintly.

I'm sorry, said the old shepherd. *I'm sorry, love. I'm sorry. I couldn't bear it.*

I know. A breath. *I know you couldn't*. Her thin hand found his hair. *It's all right. I'm going to see our boy now.*

In. Catch. Silence.

Not again.

Oszric felt her go. Not like sand. Not frightened. The way a candle goes out at the end of a long evening when it's burned all the way down.

He had kept her for a year and a half. He felt her go, and was glad.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE OTHERS.

The long ones. The old ones.

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THEY WENT LIKE SAND.

He'd known they would. He'd felt it every night in the dark, practising. Nine hundred years is a long time. Longer than a body is built for. Longer than bones. They'd been dead—they should have been dead—since before the Lattice. Since before the net. Since the first year in the grey. And the only thing holding them together was him. His hand. His gold. His *no, not you, I can't bear it, stay*.

And now there was another *no*. Older. Kinder. Saying *yes, you, you can go, it's all right*.

They went.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OVER THE WORLD.

On roads. In fields. In the long grass at the edges of villages where they'd stopped walking. Nine thousand gold people. The gold going off them like frost. And under it—grey. Dust. Fine. Pale. Like flour. Like ash. Like sand.

Coming apart.

He felt the first of them start to be frightened.

A laundry maid, on a road in Vhessa, alone. Looking down at her hands. Watching them go grey. Watching the fingers of them drift away on the wind like smoke. Opening her mouth to scream—

And something came out of the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT GO past him.

Out of the room. Out of the soft dark behind the Doorkeeper. Past the Ferryman on his step. Past Oszric and Rosie on the threshold. Out into the world. Fast. Silent. A wind that wasn't a wind.

The dead.

Thousands. Grey. The ones who'd been walking upriver toward Mal for months. The ones in the stars in the soft dark of his room. The ones who'd stood round six lanterns in a grey square in the Drowned Country

for years because it was warm. The bread-woman's kind. The ones who'd come apart in the first year in the grey and been walked past by a crying gold king and never kept.

They came out of the door like a breath out of a chest.

And went to their own.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LAUNDRY MAID ON the road in Vhessa didn't scream.

A grey column came down out of the sky in front of her. Thin. Small. An old woman's height. And bent. Over the maid. Over her greying hands.

Gran, said the laundry maid.

And stopped being frightened.

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYWHERE.

A soldier on one knee in a field with his hands going to dust, and a small grey column no taller than his shoulder coming down to meet him. A steward in a coat with a chain on it, and a woman's dust, fifty years married. A gardener. A footman. A harper—Leolin, his harper, who'd played for him at dinner every night for a hundred years before the pool—sitting on a stone by a road in the Sunreach with his gold harp in his lap going grey, and a column of dust coming down beside him that had been a girl he'd loved once and never told.

Nobody should come apart on their own, the boy had written. *Not again*.

Nobody did.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND AT THE POOL.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT BEST at the pool. Because it was closest. Because it was right there, at the bottom of the soft dark, through the door. He could see it.

Three hundred and some gold people in the grass. Going grey. All at once. And three hundred and some grey columns of dust in front of them, bending, closer, closer, until the dust of the living and the dust of the dead were touching. Mixing. A quarter of an inch, and then nothing. Holding.

At last.

Holding.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN THE GRASS by the stone house, a little gold girl. With her hand in a boy's.

The gold going off her.

Not like frost. Like the last of the snow off a roof in March. Slowly. Patches. Her hair first. Then her face. Then her hands. Pink, for a moment, as the gold went—pink, a child's skin, with a white line across one fingertip where she'd burned it on a spit-iron nine hundred and twelve years ago—and then, under the pink, grey.

She was looking at her mother.

Oszric felt her look. He felt her, for the last moment, before she stopped being kept and stopped being his. A small bright fierce thing. Eight years old.

Not frightened.

Mam, said Ilda. *I can feel it. Mam. I can feel it.*

What is it, love?

I'm happy, said Ilda. *That's happy. Isn't it?*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN SHE WASN'T his.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STANDING ON the threshold.

He didn't know how long it had been. A moment. An hour. He was standing on the grey stone with Rosie's bandaged hand in his and Hes's crown on his head, and he was empty.

The threads were gone.

All of them. Nine thousand gold threads running out of his chest to every person he'd ever kept. Gone. Cut. Opened. He reached for them, out of nine hundred years of habit, the way you reach for a stair in the dark that isn't there.

Nothing.

His hands were empty.

◆ ◆ ◆

NO.

Not empty.

He looked down.

At his free hand. The left. Huge. Gold. Open. Palm up. Where the threads had been.

There was still something in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS IN HIM. Under the gold. Under his skin. In his chest, where the threads had run from. A warmth. A weight. A light.

The thing he'd drunk.

The first. Before Mae. Before Ysy and Cad and Rosie. He'd been first to the pool. The eldest. The one who'd held the tongs. He'd knelt on the edge of a pool in a garden at the bottom of the world with his father dead upstairs and put his face in the water and *drunk*.

Endings. That was what the seventh Well was. Room. The space where something *was*. The hole a thing leaves when it's gone. He'd drunk the endings out of the world so nothing he loved would ever end.

And it was still in him.

It had been in him for nine hundred years. Every ending he'd ever stopped. Every death he'd ever kept. Swallowed. Held. Gold.

It was the last thing he was holding.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oz*," said Rosie.

He looked at her.

"*It's his*," said Rosie. Very gently. "*It was always his. Like mine was. Like Ysy's.*" She lifted the small linen packet in her other hand. The glass dust. "*Pour it back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D WATCHED HER DO it.

In the winter. At the pool. A woman with thorns in her hair and blood on her hands, kneeling on the rim, holding the Harrow woman's hand. Pouring back nine hundred years of growing things. Going from Crowned to mortal in a breath. Forty. Tired. Alive.

He hadn't understood how.

He understood now. Standing on the threshold. With his hands open.

You didn't pour it. You couldn't pour it, any more than you could let go. It wasn't in you to do.

You just stopped holding it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED HOLDING IT.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT OUT OF him like a breath.

Down. Through the soles of his feet. Into the threshold. Through the grey stone that knew what he was. Through the frame and the hinges and the blue door. Into the room behind it. Into the soft dark. Into the space in front of things.

Into Mal.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...oh...] said the seventh Well.

All round them. Soft. Deep. Suddenly huge. Like the sound in a well when you drop a stone and listen and it doesn't land, it goes on falling, down and down, and then you realise there's no bottom, there was never a bottom, the well goes all the way down through the world and out the other side into the stars.

[...oh...that's...]

The room behind the door got bigger.

Oszric saw it. Everyone did. The soft dark stretching. Deepening. The stars in it going further and further apart. The shapes between them moving faster. Going in. Going on. And at the bottom, a long way down, the pool—

The pool *opened*.

Not wider. Deeper. The water in it going dark. Clear. Bottomless. Like looking down a well into the sky. Like looking into an eye.

[...that's the last of me...] said Mal. Wonderingly. *[...that's the first bit...the oldest...the bit he took first...]* A pause. *[...I remember...I remember the garden...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD WENT OFF him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T FEEL IT go. He saw it. In Rosie's face. Looking up at him. Her eyes going wide. Her mouth opening.

He looked down at his hands.

They were grey.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT DUST. NOT YET. Skin. Old skin. Grey and thin and spotted, the way his father's hands had gone at the end. Blue veins. Knuckles like knots in a rope. A man's hands. A very old man's hands. Shaking.

He was small.

He'd been the size of a small cart for nine hundred years. Gold. Enormous. Taking up the whole of a doorway. He wasn't now. He was a man. An old man. Bent. Thin. In a gold robe that had gone grey and hung off him like a sail with no wind. With a little silver-grey crown on his head that fitted.

It fitted.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT ROSIE.

She was crying.

"*You look like Da*," she said.

He tried to say something. His voice came out cracked. Thin. An old man's voice.

"*I always did*," said Oszric. "*Round the eyes.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN STOOD UP.

Slowly. With his oar. Off the threshold step. He stood up beside them, very tall, grey, hooded, with the last of the evening sun behind him, and looked down at the old man in the grey robe with the little crown on his head.

He looked at him for a long time.

Then he reached into his robe. And took out something small. A scrap. Grey. Folded. Like a page torn out of a very old book.

He unfolded it.

Oszric couldn't see what was written on it. It was too small and his eyes were old now, eyes that had never had to be old before, and the light was going.

The Ferryman took a stub of something from his robe. Grey. Like a pencil. Like a burnt stick.

And wrote.

One word. Small. At the bottom of the list.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Now you're on my list*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC LOOKED UP AT him.

He'd thought he'd be frightened. He'd been frightened of this for nine hundred years. More than of anything. More than of the grey or the glass or the smith's fire or the little one saying no. *An ending*. The one thing he'd drunk the whole world dry to stop.

He wasn't frightened.

He was tired. And old. And empty. And light. Lighter than he'd ever been. As if he'd put something down that he'd been carrying since he was nine.

"*Good*," said Oszric.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN LOOKED AT him a moment longer.

Then—so slightly that Oszric nearly missed it—he inclined his hooded head. The way you'd nod to a man across a room.

And sat back down on the step.

"*In your own time*," said the Ferryman. And closed his eyes. "*I'm not going anywhere.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Rosie*," said Oszric.

"*Yes, Oz.*"

"*Walk me in*?"

She didn't answer. She didn't need to. She took his arm. His thin grey old arm. Properly, this time. Her bandaged hand round it. Tight.

He looked back.

Once. Over his shoulder. The way the smith's father had, twice, on a stair. At the slope. At the four hundred on the rise with their lanterns burning straight up in the dusk. At the smith. At the smith's wife, with her pink fingers round her child. At the Harrow woman with her clay lamp. At the old blacksmith with his fingertips in his mouth.

At the little one. Asleep on her father's shoulder. Blue to the elbow.

She'd said no to him. Twice. In a yard and in a forge. Square eyebrows. Fists.

She was the only one in nine hundred years who'd ever said it to his face.

"*Thank you*," said Oszric. Very quietly. To her. To all of them.

And turned. And went through the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED DOWN THROUGH the room.

He and Rosie. Arm in arm. Through the soft dark. Between the stars. With the shapes of the dead going past them on either side, slow, unhurried, the way people walk through a house at night from room to room.

It wasn't far. Or it was very far. He couldn't tell. It didn't matter.

Behind them, he heard something. A soft dry sound. Like dust blowing.

He looked back.

◆ ◆ ◆

ORRIN.

His steward. Grey. Dust. A man made of dust, the way he'd always been, since the first year in the grey when Oszric had held his hand on the floor of the hall and not been able to keep him, quite—only half—only enough for him to stay as dust and serve. Courteous. Faithful. Nine hundred years.

He'd been standing at the back of the crowd on the rise. Oszric hadn't seen him. He hadn't looked.

He was coming down through the room after them. A few steps behind. With his dusty hands folded in front of him. The way a steward walks behind his master, close enough to be called, far enough not to intrude.

"*Orrin*," said Oszric. "*You don't have to.*"

"*I know, Majesty*," said Orrin.

He kept walking.

"*I'm not your Majesty*," said Oszric. "*Not now. Look at me. I'm an old man in a dressing gown.*"

Orrin looked at him. With his dust face. With the faint courteous smile that had never once changed in nine hundred years.

"*Yes, sir*," said Orrin. And kept walking.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL WAS THERE.

At the bottom of the dark. Green grass. Gold lanterns, five hundred and fifty-six, in a ring. A stone house on the slope with a lantern in the window. And all round the rim, in the grass, grey dust. Hundreds of little heaps of it. Pale. Fine. Lying in pairs. Each pair touching. Where three hundred gold people and three hundred grey ones had held each other at last, and come apart together, and lay in the grass side by side like flour spilled on a table.

Waiting.

And a boy on the rim. With his knees drawn up. Fifteen. Thin. With a stub of pencil behind his ear and his face wet.

He looked up as they came down out of the dark. At the old man in the grey robe. At the thorn-woman. At the dust-steward behind.

He didn't say anything.

He moved over. On the rim. To make room.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC SAT DOWN.

His knees cracked. Both of them. His back. His neck. Nine hundred years of not bending, and they'd found out about it all at once.

He sat on the rim of the pool beside the boy who didn't talk and looked down into the water.

It was dark. Clear. Bottomless. Like looking into an eye.

No reflection. There never had been, in Mal's pool. It was a hollow. It showed you nothing.

He looked into it anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

ROSIE KNELT BESIDE HIM. On the grass. With the linen packet.

She unfolded it. Slowly. Carefully. On her knees. The glass dust inside, pale, glittering, fine as frost. She held it over the water.

"*Ysy*," she said. "*Here. Go on. Cad's in there. And Mae. And Hes, a bit, I think. And all the cousins.*" Her voice was steady. "*Go on, love. Go and see everyone.*"

She tipped the linen.

The dust went down into the pool like frost going into a river. Glittering. Then gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...hello, Ysy...] said the water. Very softly. *[...I can see you...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ROSIE SAT BACK ON her heels. And let the linen fall in her lap. And didn't say anything.

Oszric reached into his robe.

Into the pocket, over his heart, where he'd carried it since the night he woke. Thin. Silver. Wire. Twisted. A little crown a girl had made herself, nine hundred years ago, out of wire from the palace gardens, because she was the second daughter and there wasn't one for her.

Mae's.

He held it over the water.

"*There*," he said. To the pool. To his sister. "*You were always cross nobody gave you one.*"

He let it go.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN HE TOOK OFF Hes's crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME OFF EASILY. It fitted now. It came off his old grey head the way a hat comes off at the end of a long day.

He held it in his lap. Small. Silver-grey. Seven points. Thin. Plain.

"*Thank you*," he said. To it. "*For sitting in the door.*"

He gave it to Rosie.

She looked at it. Then at him.

"*Give it back to the Harrow woman*," said Oszric. "*Or the little one. It's theirs. It was always theirs.*" He looked at it in her bandaged hands. "*I don't think it's got any more no in it. I think that was the last.*"

"*It'll have a yes, then*," said Rosie. "*Next.*"

He smiled. It hurt his face. He'd forgotten how.

"*Probably*," said Oszric.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED DOWN INTO the pool for a long time.

Then he looked at the boy beside him. The boy who didn't talk. Who'd written down three hundred and eight names on scraps of paper and kept them in his pocket. Who'd remembered Maudie.

"*Will you hold my hand*?" said the Gilded King. "*Just for a bit. I don't want to do it on my own.*"

The boy looked at him.

Then he held out his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS SMALL AND thin and warm. Ink on the fingers. Callused from the pencil.

Oszric took it in his old grey one.

On his other side, Rosie took the other.

And behind him, on the grass, very quietly, Orrin sat down. Folded his dusty hands. And waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT THE WAY the dead go.

Not like sand. Not frightened. Not alone. Gently. The way the snow comes off a branch when the sun gets to it. The way a fire goes down in a hearth when the night's over and nobody's going to bank it.

He sat on the rim of the pool with a boy holding one hand and his sister holding the other, and the lanterns burning gold round him in the long grass, and his household lying in pairs on the grass behind him, all of them, waiting—

And came apart.

Grey. Fine. Like flour.

And the last thing he felt, before there wasn't anything to feel it with, was the boy's hand. Not letting go.

Holding on.

He'd been holding on since he was nine years old.

It was nice, at the end, to have someone hold on for him.

CHAPTER 35

Dawn

NOBODY SLEPT THAT NIGHT either.

Lex sat on the grass in front of the threshold with Lark asleep in his lap and Wren's head on his shoulder and watched the door.

It stood open. Antho stood in it. He hadn't moved since the King went through. He stood there with one hand on the frame and one on the blue wood, the way a man stands in his own doorway at night when someone he loves has gone down the road and he's watching till he can't see the lantern any more.

Behind him, the soft dark. The stars. The shapes going in.

And at the bottom, very far off, the pool. With its ring of lanterns. And an old man's dust on the rim, grey, fine, beside a boy who hadn't let go of his hand.

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WREN'S FINGERS WERE PINK.

She kept looking at them. In the lantern light. In the dark. Flexing them. Two fingers and a thumb on her left hand. Pink and stiff and cold and alive. She'd make a fist, and open it, and look at it, and make a fist again.

"*They hurt*," she said. Wonderingly. Around midnight. "*Lex. They hurt.*"

"*They've been asleep*," said Lex. "*Nine months. They're waking up.*"

"*Like when you sit on your foot*."

"*Like that*."

She was quiet for a long time.

"*I'll have to learn again*," said Wren. "*Both hands. The left's forgotten. And the right's learned it wrong.*" She looked at her pink fingers. "*I'll miss trees all summer.*"

"*Yes*," said Lex.

She laughed. Very quietly. Into his shoulder.

"*Good*," said Wren Ashdown.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC SAT A LITTLE way off. On a stone. With his hands in his lap. Looking at them. Turning them over. Gold no more. Old fingers. Scarred. Burned at the tips.

Every so often he held one up close to the nearest lantern and squinted at it. As if checking.

Tilda sat beside him. With her right hand in her left. Holding it. As if it might go somewhere.

Neither of them said anything.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN SAT ON the step.

With his back against the frame and his oar across his knees and his lantern beside him on the grey stone. With his eyes closed. Lex didn't think he was asleep. He didn't think the Ferryman slept. He thought he was just sitting. The way an old man sits on a bench in the sun in the afternoon, not doing anything, because for the first time in his life there's nothing he has to do.

The lantern on the stone flickered. Small. Gold.

Every so often it said something. Quietly. To itself. As if taking notes.

[...a threshold of grey stone, approximately sixteen feet...]

[...a door of apple wood which appears to be in flower...]

[...blue paint. A great many small pictures. A loaf, possibly. Or a cushion...]

Lex didn't listen. He couldn't. He sat on the grass with his daughter asleep in his lap and looked at the door and didn't listen to Ember describe it to nobody.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT GOT COLD, TOWARD morning.

Not the grey cold. Not the glass cold. The ordinary cold of a summer night in the open, an hour before dawn, when the dew comes down and the stars—

There were stars.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED UP.

He didn't know when they'd come. He'd been looking at the door. But they were there. Over the rise. Over the camp. Over the four hundred lanterns burning straight up in the still air. Faint. Pale. A scatter of them in the dark.

There'd been no stars in the grey country.

He looked at them for a long time.

Then he looked at the grass under his hand.

It was wet. Dew. Cold and wet and real.

And it was green.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HADN'T NOTICED. NOBODY had. It had been dark. The grass on the rise had been green since they made camp, because of the lanterns, because the lanterns held it. But the grass beyond the lanterns—the grass on the long slope going down to the threshold, beyond the last ring, where nobody had put a lantern because the door was there—

He'd sat down on it at dusk. It had been grey.

It was green now.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Wren*," he said.

She lifted her head.

He didn't say anything else. He just pointed. Out. Past the lanterns. Past the last ring. To the slope going away north along the end of the road, where the seam had been. Where the grey had lain like a picture of a field.

It wasn't a picture.

It was dark, and it was hard to see. But Lex could see it. In the light of the last lanterns. Grass. Long grass. Dew on it. Moving. Very slightly. In a breath of air that came from nowhere in particular, from the east, the way the morning air comes before the sun.

And somewhere out in it—far out, beyond the reach of the lanterns, in the dark—

A bird.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT A SONG. NOT yet. A sound. A single sleepy *chk*. The kind of sound a blackbird makes in a hedge when something wakes it before it's ready.

Then nothing.

Then, a long way off, another.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD UP.

Carefully. With Lark asleep against his chest. With his ribs. He stood up on the green slope in front of the threshold and looked east.

Back along the end of the road. Over the rise. Over the camp. Over the four hundred lanterns. To the green road they'd walked for nineteen days, with a light every mile, going away into the dark like a string of beads.

And past it.

To the sky.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS GOING PALE.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT GREY. NOT THE flat page-colour of the grey country, that had been the colour of every sky for five months. Pale. The pale of a real sky before dawn. Blue under it. Faint. And at the very bottom, at the edge of the world, where the land met the sky in the east—

A line.

Thin. Bright. The colour of the inside of a shell.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CAMP WAS WAKING.

He heard it go back along the rise. People sitting up. People standing. People turning round. A murmur. Then quiet. Four hundred people standing in the dark on a hill at the end of the world, turned to the east, looking at a line of colour on the edge of the sky.

Nobody said anything.

The line got brighter.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WAS BESIDE him. He didn't know when she'd come. With the clay lamp in her hands. Burning. Not needed. She held it anyway.

Antho had come out of the door. He stood on the threshold. Just on it. On the grey stone. With his back to the soft dark and his face to the east, so that he was in both at once, the room and the world. Seraphine came down the slope and stood beside him, and he put his arm round her without looking.

The Ferryman opened his eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SUN CAME UP.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD SEEN A lot of sunrises. Every day of his life, nearly. A smith gets up before the sun. He'd stood in the Forge doorway at Ashbourne ten thousand mornings with a cup of tea and watched it come up over the Vale. He'd watched it come up on the Spire roof, the morning he asked Wren. He'd watched it come up over the Pale Wastes, and the Teeth, and the sea at Gull's Reach.

He'd never seen one like this.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME UP OVER the world.

Over the green road. Over the Vale, two hundred miles off. Over Ashbourne, and Harrow, and the Teeth, and the east. Gold. Slow. Enormous. The whole rim of the sky catching fire, the way a forge catches when the bellows go.

And the light came west.

Across the land. Over the hills and fields and woods and villages. Two hundred miles of them. Grey. Still. A picture of a world.

And everywhere it touched—

◆ ◆ ◆

COLOUR.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WATCHED IT COME. Everyone did. They stood on the rise in the dawn and watched the light come west across the grey country like water across a floor.

And behind it, the colour came back.

Not all at once. Not like a lamp being lit. Like a painting being finished. Like someone very patient going over a drawing with a brush, one field at a time, one hedge, one tree. Green into the grass. Brown into the plough. Gold into the barley. White into the birches, and black into the marks on their trunks, and green—the soft bright green of June—into their leaves.

He could see it moving. Toward them. Across the hills. A line of colour. Like the grey had come, months ago, a line in the grass. But the other way.

Going home.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BIRDS WOKE.

All at once. Everywhere. As the light reached them. As the colour reached them. The hedges on the hillsides. The woods. The fields. He heard them start, far off, to the east, a long way back along the green road—a sound like a kettle beginning to sing—and then nearer, and nearer, and then all round them.

Blackbird. Wren. Thrush. Lark.

A chiffchaff, somewhere close, in a hedge at the bottom of the rise, saying its own name over and over, as if it had been afraid it would forget.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WOKE UP.

On his chest. In the noise. In the light. She lifted her head off his shoulder with her hair flat on one side and her eyes screwed up against the sun, furious at being woken.

Then she heard the birds.

Her eyebrows went up.

She turned her head. Slowly. On his shoulder. Toward the east. Toward the sun. Toward the gold light coming across two hundred miles of grey country, turning it green.

And looked at it.

For a long time. Without saying anything. With her blue arm round his neck.

Then she said—not to him, not to anyone, to the sun, very seriously, as if greeting someone she'd been expecting—

"*Mmo-ning*."

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT REACHED THE door.

It came up the slope. Over the green grass, already green. Up to the threshold. Over the grey stone. Over the Ferryman's feet, sitting on the step.

And onto the door.

The blue paint went bright. The apple wood went gold—not the borrowed gold of Seren's lamp, lent, but real, morning gold, the way wood goes in the first sun. The petals lit up, every one, white and pink, staying. The bell on its bracket caught the light and threw it back in a small bright star.

The hinges breathed.

Out. And back.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND A PANEL OPENED.

In front of Lex. In front of all of them. Every Stone. Every panel. Everywhere.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▓▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓▓
THE EDGE OF THE WORLD
IS A DOOR.
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◆ ◆ ◆

AND UNDER IT, AFTER a moment, smaller—

◆ ◆ ◆

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"Mind the step."
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◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LAUGHED.

On the threshold. In the light. With his arm round his wife. He put his head back and laughed until he had to hold on to the frame, and Seraphine was laughing too, and crying, and writing it down at the same time with her quill going all over the page.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN STOOD UP.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DID IT SLOWLY. The way he did everything. Unfolding. Very tall. Grey. In the sun. He stood on the threshold step with his long oar in one hand and looked at the light.

At the sun, coming up over the world.

At the colour, coming across the land.

He'd never seen it. Lex understood that, watching him. He'd lived on the edge of everything forever. On the river. On the shore. In the grey. At the foot of beds at night, with his lantern. He'd never once stood in the open on a summer morning and watched the sun come up.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he looked down. At the lantern on the stone at his feet. Small. Tin. With a gold flame in it.

He bent. And picked it up.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME DOWN OFF the step.

Across the grass. Through the dew. To Lex.

He stopped in front of him. Very tall. With the sun on his face. With the lantern held out in front of him in one long grey hand.

Lex looked at it.

At the small gold flame. Dry. Courteous. Curious. Flickering. Looking at him—he could feel it looking—the way it had looked at him in the boat. Politely. Interested. Without knowing who he was.

[Good morning,] said the flame. *[You're the smith. From the boat. With the hammer.]*

"*Yes*," said Lex.

[I thought so.] A pause. *[You were sad. I remember. I wondered why.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*A love for a love*," said the Ferryman.

Lex looked up at him.

"*That was the price*," said the Ferryman. "*At the Veil. In the winter. To carry your father across. It wanted his love for you. All of it. And it gave it.*" He looked down at the lantern in his hand. "*A love for a love. That was fair. That was mine to take.*"

He held the lantern out. Further. Toward Lex.

"*The rest isn't*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T MOVE.

"*It remembers everything*," said the Ferryman. "*Every book. Every Well. Every forge. It remembers you. Your face. Your voice. Every morning for seven years.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*It just doesn't remember why it mattered.*"

"*I know*," said Lex.

"*It might never remember*," said the Ferryman. "*I can't give it back. The love. That's gone. That went where prices go.*" A pause. "*But I can give it back to you. What's left. And you can see.*"

He looked at the flame.

"*Love isn't a thing you remember*," said the oldest thing in the world. "*It's a thing you do. Every morning. It can learn again. If someone's patient.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TOOK THE LANTERN.

His hands were shaking. The burned one and the other. He held it in both of them, against his chest, with Lark on his hip looking at it with enormous interest.

The flame flickered.

[Oh,] it said. Surprised. *[That's warm. Are you warm? You're very warm.]*

"*I'm a smith*," said Lex. His voice cracked. "*We run hot.*"

[How interesting.] A pause. *[I've read about smiths. I think I've read a great deal about smiths. I seem to know an extraordinary amount about tempering.]*

"*You do*," said Lex. "*You know more than me.*"

[Do I?] Pleased. *[How odd. I wonder why.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK PUT HER HAND out.

Toward the lantern. Toward the flame. Her blue hand. Square. Small.

"*Hot*," she said. Seriously. To the flame. As if warning it.

The flame went very still.

Then it leaned. Toward her. Through the tin. Toward the small blue hand. The way the flames in the Harrow hearth had leaned toward her the night the Veil fell, when she said *mmo-ning* to the fire and Lex had half heard something small and dry and courteous in it.

[Hello,] said Ember. Softly. *[Hello, small person. I know you.]*

A pause.

[I don't know how,] said Ember. Puzzled. *[But I do.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He stood on the green slope at the end of the road in the sunrise with his daughter on his hip and his old friend in his hands, and the birds singing all round them, and couldn't say anything at all.

The Ferryman looked at him for a moment longer.

Then he turned.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T GO BACK through the door.

Lex had thought he would. Back into the room. Back to the river. Back to the edge of things, where he'd always been.

He didn't.

He walked up the slope. Past Seren with her lamp. Past Brannoc on his stone. Through the camp. Through the four hundred, who stood back to let him pass, very quietly, staring. With his long oar in his hand like a walking stick and no lantern at all.

East.

Toward the sun.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Where are you going*?" called Antho. From the threshold.

The Ferryman stopped. At the top of the rise. On the green road. With the whole of the world in front of him, turning green, and the sun on his face.

He turned his hooded head.

"*There's a door now*," said the Ferryman. "*They can walk. They don't need rowing.*" He looked at the oar in his hand. As if seeing it for the first time. "*I've never seen a morning.*" A pause. "*I thought I'd go and see some.*"

"*Will you come back*?"

The Ferryman was silent for a long time.

"*Everyone does*," he said. "*In the end.*"

And walked away down the green road. Tall. Grey. Slow. An old man with a stick, going east, into the sunrise, with the birds getting up out of the hedges in front of him and the lanterns, one every mile, going pale in the morning.

They watched him until he was too small to see.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT DOWN ON the threshold.

On the grey stone. Where the Ferryman had sat. With his back against the frame. With the lantern in his lap and Lark beside him, poking at the blue paint to see if it was dry.

Antho sat down on the other side.

The door stood open between them. The room behind. Soft. Dark. Full of stars. The shapes going in.

And at the bottom, the pool.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY COULD SEE IT from here. Clearly. In the morning. As if through a window. A green circle in a field. A ring of lanterns, going pale. A stone house on the slope. Three lights in the water.

And in the grass, all round the rim—

The dust was getting up.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WATCHED IT.

Hundreds of little heaps of grey. Lying in pairs in the grass where they'd come apart in the night. Living and dead together. And as the light came down through the soft dark of the room and touched them—sunlight, through the door, into Mal—they rose.

Not drifting. Walking. Pairs of grey columns. Side by side. Close. Holding, the way dust holds. Getting up out of the grass the way people get up from a long sleep on a hillside. And turning. To the water.

And going in.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW A SOLDIER'S dust go in beside a small grey column no taller than his shoulder.

He saw a steward's dust go in with his wife's.

He saw two laundry maids go in together, hand in hand, and the dust of an old woman and a young one go with them.

He saw a boy—small, six, maybe, he could tell by the size—go in beside his brother.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BY THE STONE house, on the slope above the pool—

Two columns. One tall. One small.

Not going in. Not yet. Standing in the grass by the door of the house. Under the lantern in the window. The tall one bending. Over the small one. The way a woman bends over a cot.

And a boy beside them.

Pim. Sitting on the step of the house. With his knees drawn up. With an old man's dust on the rim of the pool behind him, and a thorn-woman kneeling beside it, and a dust-steward sitting very still in the grass at her back.

The small column turned. Toward him.

And bent. A little. The way you bend to someone to say *thank you*.

Pim didn't say anything. He never did, if he could help it.

He lifted his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TWO COLUMNS WENT down the slope together. Thirty yards. Through the long grass. Past the lanterns. To the rim.

They stopped there for a moment. On the edge. Where for sixty-one days a gold girl had stood on the surface of the water and the water wouldn't take her.

Then the tall one bent all the way down. Round the small one. Close. Arms. Arms that could close, now.

And they went in.

Together.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...hello, Ilda...] said the water. Softly. Through the whole of the room. Through the door. Out onto the threshold where Lex and Antho sat in the sun. *[...hello, Maudie...]*

[...welcome home...]

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO PUT HIS FACE in his hands.

Lex put his arm round his brother.

They sat there on the threshold for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OLD MAN'S DUST went in last.

Lex saw it. After all the others. After the pairs and the brothers and the laundry maids and the bread-woman and her girl. After the sun was well up over the world and the lanterns round the pool had gone pale and the birds in the green circle were singing so loud he could hear them through the door, five hundred miles.

A heap of grey on the rim. Fine as flour. With a little silver-wire crown sunk in the water beside it, and the glass dust of a sister already gone.

The thorn-woman put her bandaged hands under it. Gently. And lifted. As much as she could. And let it go into the pool.

The dust-steward got up from the grass. And walked to the rim. And bowed. Very low. The way a steward bows when his master leaves the room.

And followed him in.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...hello, Oz...] said Mal.

The whole of the room shivered. Like a breath. Like a sigh. Like someone who's been waiting up very late and has finally heard the door.

[...I'm whole now...]

[...I'm all here...]

[...thank you for bringing me back...]

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FAR AWAY—FAR OUT in the white, past the edge, past where the edge had been, at the east gate of an empty Court of glass and iron and gold and bone—

Lex didn't see it. He heard about it later. From the man himself. At a table in the Forge at Ashbourne, in the autumn, over a mug of Brannoc's terrible ale.

A grey-haired man in a Keeper's coat, who'd stood at a gate for five months with his staff held crosswise against a king's household that never came, set his staff down against the gatepost.

And looked at it for a moment.

And walked out of the gate. Down the white road. East. Toward the door. Toward the sun.

He didn't hurry. He said, later, at the table, that he'd thought about hurrying and decided that after five months he'd earned a walk.

"*Took me eleven days*," said Roole. "*I'd forgotten what it was like. Walking somewhere you want to go.*"

The white road ran out under his feet on the eleventh day, he said. Just stopped. Turned into soft dark and stars, and a long way off a pool with lanterns round it, and right in front of him, close enough to touch, the back of a door.

So he knocked.

Antho let him in.

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THE SUN WAS WELL up.

On the threshold, Lark had decided the paint was dry and was adding to it. With a finger. Very carefully. Low down, under her own handprint. A long wobbly line, and a round thing at the end of it.

"*What's that*?" said Antho.

Lark looked at him with scorn.

"*Da*," she said. And pointed at the round thing. Then at the line. "*Ham'er.*"

Then she pointed at the lantern in Lex's lap. At the small gold flame.

"*Hot*," she said.

[Thank you,] said Ember. Gravely. *[I try.]*

Lex laughed.

It hurt his ribs so much he nearly fell off the step.

He didn't care.

CHAPTER 36

The Book of What Is

THEY WALKED HOME IN sixteen days.

It should have been longer. It was two hundred miles, and there were four hundred of them, and some were old and some were small and one was a fish in a jar. But the road was green now, all of it, not just the strip their lanterns had held, and the grass was soft, and the fords were running, and nobody was afraid.

And the world kept waking up round them.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD THOUGHT IT would be like a thaw. Like spring. The grey going off the land the way snow goes, slowly, from the south slopes first, leaving mud.

It wasn't. It was like a house in the morning.

You came down the stairs in the dark and the house was quiet and cold and still, every chair where you'd left it. And then someone opened the shutters. And the light came in. And it was the same house—the same chairs, the same table, the same cup on the drainer—and it was completely different, because it was morning, and things could happen in it again.

That was what the world was like. On the walk home. Every village. Every field. Every farm.

Morning.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PASSED THE WOMAN with the washing on the fourth day.

She was taking it in. She'd pegged it out in the spring, she said, leaning on her gate as four hundred people went past, and she'd only just noticed it was still there. Must have been a dry spell. Funny. She couldn't remember the summer at all. Had it been a good one?

"*Not very*," said Hollis Penn. And gave her a loaf.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PASSED A FARM where a man was standing in the middle of his yard with a bucket, staring at his hens. The hens were laying. All of them. Furiously. As if trying to make up for lost time. There were eggs in the nesting boxes and eggs in the straw and eggs under the cart and one, inexplicably, on the roof of the privy.

"*I don't know what to do with them all*," said the farmer. Helplessly.

Brannoc bought forty.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PASSED A MILL where the wheel had started turning in the night, on its own, when the stream came back, and the miller had woken to the sound and run down in his nightshirt and stood there crying in the race until his wife came and fetched him.

They passed a churchyard where a new grave had been dug in the spring and never filled, because the old man who was meant to go in it had been kept in his bed, gold, with his eyes moving, for three months. He'd gone in the night. When the King let go. His daughter was sitting by the grave in the morning sun with her knees drawn up.

"*He was ready*," she said, when Seren stopped. "*He'd been ready for a year. He said so. He said he'd had a good long go and he wanted his tea and his bed and then whatever came after.*" She wiped her face. "*And then the dust-man came and asked me if I wanted to keep him. And I said yes. Because I couldn't bear it.*"

Seren sat down beside her on the grass.

"*I know, love*," said Seren. "*Nobody can. That's why it's a door. So you don't have to.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PASSED WESTERLING ON the eighth day.

Nan Ashby was at the gate of her croft with her son. Col. Twenty-two. Thin. Pale. With a farmer's hands and a farmer's shoulders and a look on his face like a man who's been asleep for a very long time and isn't sure yet that he's woken up.

He was holding the HERE lantern.

Nan didn't say anything as they went past. She just lifted her hand. And Col, after a moment, lifted his. The same way. As if he'd learned it from her just then.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME OVER THE last rise above the Vale on the sixteenth day.

And there was Ashbourne.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS GREEN.

All of it. The village and the fields round it and the hills behind. The lantern ring was still there—seven hundred and twelve and more, in the grass, on the gateposts, in the hedges—but you couldn't tell any more where the ring stopped and the rest began. It was green inside and green outside. The mill-pond at the bottom of the village was water again, brown and quick, and the wheel was turning. The church tower had a jackdaw on it. The Forge chimney was smoking.

Tilda's. She'd gone on ahead with Kestrel and Teo on the twelfth day, to light the hearths.

Lex stood at the top of the rise with Lark on his shoulders and looked at it for a long time.

"*Home*," said Lark. Very clearly. Pointing.

Lex looked up at her.

She'd never said it before.

She'd heard it, though. He knew that. From the bottom of the soft dark behind a door. From three hundred gold people standing in the grass round a pool, humming one note for nine hundred years, until they didn't have to any more.

"*Yes*," said Lex. "*Home.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT TO HARROW first.

He and Wren and Lark and his mother. Down the river path. Three miles. Under the alders. With the stream beside them, running brown and quick and loud over the stones, the way it always had.

The birch wood was green. Every leaf. The hedge at the top of the garden was hawthorn and elder and bramble and dog-rose, and the dog-rose was pink.

The pond was gone.

There was a muddy hollow in the bottom of the garden where it had been, with the grass already coming up through the mud, and a tidemark round the stones of the grave. The roses were still there. Red. Dark red. Nearly black at the heart. Two dozen. More. Climbing over the stone.

ARION VEY.

He turned back twice.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WENT TO the grave first.

She didn't say anything. She knelt down in the grass beside it with the clay lamp in her lap, and put her hand on the stone, on the letters, and stayed there.

Lex left her.

He went across the stepping stones, with Lark on his shoulders and Wren behind, to the other cottage. His. The one he'd built on the black scorch-mark of the one that burned. With its empty east window, where the HERE lantern had hung before he gave it away.

The swing was moving.

On the apple bough. Gently. In the breeze. Out. And back.

Lark saw it and shrieked and drummed her heels on his chest until he put her down, and she ran across the grass to it, and he lifted her into it, and pushed. And she went up, and back, and up, shrieking, with her hair flying and her blue-stained arm round the rope, and the swing creaked on the bough the way it always had.

Wren went round to the woodpile.

She knelt down at the bottom of it in the long grass. And looked under. And was quiet for a moment.

Then she sat back on her heels and laughed.

"*It's there*," said Wren. "*The hedgehog. It's asleep.*"

"*Is it—*"

"*It's snoring*," said Wren. "*Lex, it's snoring.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SET THE LANTERN down in his own hearth that evening.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THE FIRST thing he did. Before supper. Before Lark's bath. Before anything. He came in out of the garden with the swing still creaking behind him and knelt on the hearthstone in front of the cold black grate in his own kitchen, where he'd knelt ten thousand mornings, and opened the little tin door of the Ferryman's lantern.

The flame looked out at him.

[Is this it?] said Ember. *[Is this the hearth?]*

"*Yes*."

[It's very small.]

"*It's a cottage*."

[I see.] A pause. Considering. *[I was expecting something grander, from the way you talked about it. In the boat. On the road.]* Another pause. *[But it has a good draw. I can feel it. That's a well-built chimney.]*

"*I built it*," said Lex.

[Did you?] Interested. *[You must be a very good smith.]*

"*I'm a common one*."

[I don't think that's the same thing at all,] said Ember. Primly.

And went out of the lantern into the grate.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAUGHT.

Not slowly. Not the way a fire catches from a spark, a thread of smoke and then a lick and then a flame. It went into the cold black grate like a cat going into its own basket, and turned round once, and settled, and the whole hearth lit up gold.

Warm.

The kitchen filled with it. The light. The heat. The small dry crackle. It went up the chimney and out into the evening, and Lex heard Wren in the garden say *oh* and stop pushing the swing.

He knelt on the hearthstone and looked at it.

The fire looked back.

[Oh,] said Ember. Softly. From the middle of the gold. *[Oh, I like this. This is a very good hearth. I think I've been here before.]*

"*You have*," said Lex.

[Have I?] A pause. *[Was I happy?]*

Lex didn't answer for a long time.

"*I think so*," he said. "*You said you were. Every morning.*"

[Then I expect I'll be happy again,] said the fire. Comfortably. *[Good night, smith.]*

"*Good night*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAID GOOD MORNING to it the next day.

He came down the stairs in the dark, the way he had every morning of his life, and raked the ash off the banked coals and blew on them. Gently. The way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

The fire woke.

"*Good morning*," said Lex.

[Good morning,] said Ember. Politely. *[Did you sleep well?]*

"*Yes*."

[I didn't sleep at all,] said Ember. *[I don't, I think. I spent the night reading the books on your shelf. There are only eleven. One is about sheep.]* A pause. *[I found it very moving.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAID IT THE next day too.

And the next. And the next.

Every morning. In the dark. On his knees on the hearthstone. Blowing on the coals.

Good morning.

And every morning, Ember said it back. Politely. Pleasantly. The way you'd say it to the man who keeps the inn where you're staying.

[Good morning, smith.]

Never *Lex*. Never *boy*. Never *idiot*. Never the dry fond irritable voice that had lived in his chest for seven years and told him he was holding the tongs wrong.

Smith.

He said it anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How long are you going to do that*?" said Wren.

In the second week. In bed. In the grey before dawn. With Lark asleep between them, sideways, with her feet in Lex's ribs.

"*Do what*?"

"*Go down and say good morning to it*."

Lex lay there and thought about it.

"*Arion did it for a year and a half*," he said. "*To Mam. Every morning. Across the table. And she didn't know him. She said good morning back because it was polite.*"

Wren didn't say anything.

"*He didn't need her to know him*," said Lex. "*Mam said. He needed her to have a good morning.*" He looked at the ceiling. "*I can do a year and a half.*"

"*And if it's longer*?"

"*Then it's longer*."

Wren was quiet for a long time.

Then she put her hand—her left, the pink one, stiff and cold and learning—on his chest. Over his heart. Where Ember used to live.

"*You're very like your father*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

EMBER ASKED QUESTIONS.

That was new. Or not new—it had always asked questions, it had asked a thousand a day, it had asked them at two in the morning when he was trying to sleep—but they were different questions now. Not about the Wells, or the net, or the history of tempering in the Saltreach foundries. It knew all that. It remembered all that.

It asked about him.

[Why do you say good morning to me?] it said. In the third week.

Lex was kneeling at the hearth. With the poker. He stopped.

"*Because it's morning*," he said.

[That's not a reason,] said Ember. *[That's a description. Everyone knows it's morning. You don't say it to the chair.]*

Lex didn't say anything.

[Do you say it to the chair?] said Ember. Suspiciously.

"*No*."

[Then why me?]

Lex put the poker down.

He knelt there on the hearthstone. In the dark. With the fire looking at him. Small. Gold. Curious. Without the faintest idea why a smith it had met three weeks ago came down every morning and said good morning to it like a prayer.

"*Because I love you*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE WENT VERY still.

For a long time.

[Oh,] said Ember.

A pause.

[I see,] said Ember.

Another pause. Longer.

[I'll write that down,] said Ember. *[If you don't mind. For the book.]*

"*I don't mind*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOOK WAS HIS mother's idea.

The Book of What Is. Volume Three. Ember had been writing it, it said, in its head, since the far shore. Since it crossed with Arion in the winter and found itself in a lantern on a boat with no love left and nothing to do but look at the world and describe it.

[It's very hard,] Ember said. *[Describing what is. I find I keep wanting to explain why it matters. And I can't, because I don't know.]*

So Seren wrote it down.

She came across the stepping stones every afternoon. With a stack of paper and a pen and Wenna's clay lamp, and sat at Lex's kitchen table by the hearth, and took dictation. Two hours a day. Sometimes three. In her bad crooked hand that had never been any good at letters, with her tongue between her teeth.

[Chapter Nine,] said Ember. *[A door at the edge of the world, apple wood, in flower.]*

Chapter Nine, wrote Seren. *A door.*

[No—strike that. A door at the end of a road. It wasn't the edge. It became the edge. There's a difference.]

Seren struck it out. Wrote it again.

[Paragraph. The door is painted Harrow blue. The paint was mixed by a woman named Seren Harrow from woad and lime and an ingredient she declines to name.]

Seren's pen stopped.

[Is that right?] said Ember. *[The smith told me. He said you wouldn't say what was in it. I wondered why. I think it's rather wonderful that there's something in the world you won't tell anyone.]*

Seren put the pen down.

She looked at the fire for a long time.

"*It's tears*," she said. "*A Harrow woman's tears. A drop. In every pot. For every door.*" She picked up the pen. "*Wenna told me. When I was nine. I've never told anyone.*"

The fire was silent.

[I won't write that down,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[That's not mine to keep.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO AND SERAPHINE DIDN'T come home.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STAYED AT THE door.

Lex had known they would. He'd known it the moment his brother stood on the threshold with his back to the room and his face to the sunrise, in both at once. Antho wrote in the second week. A long letter.

Seraphine's hand, Antho dictating, with Seraphine's notes in the margins disagreeing with him.

They were building a house. At the end of the road. Beside the door. Tom Pruett had stayed on with a dozen men from the Vale and they'd cut the stone from the hill behind and had the walls up in a week. Two rooms and a loft. A fat chimney. A window facing east, toward the world. And another, facing the door.

There'll be a lantern in both, Antho wrote. *One for the people coming. One for the people going.*

Somebody has to keep the door, Antho wrote. *I'm the one who opens it. It turns out that means you have to live next to it. Who knew.*

Seraphine says I knew, he added. *Seraphine says I've known since I was nineteen.*

She's right, wrote Seraphine, in the margin. *He's not.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME, HE WROTE. The dead.

Not in crowds. Not like the winter. One at a time. Two. Walking. Up the green road from the east, with the lanterns going past them every mile. Grey. Dust. Columns of it. The ones who'd died in the spring and the summer, while the world was still. The ones who'd died in the night when the King let go. The ones who'd been drifting in the Drowned Country and the grey river for longer than anyone remembered and had finally heard there was a door.

They came up the green road and over the rise and down the slope to the threshold. And stopped. And waited.

And Antho opened it.

Every one, he wrote. *Every single one. I lift the latch. And they go through. And I say goodbye. And sometimes they bend a little on the way past, the way they do, and I know they're saying thank you.*

I don't know what I did for nine years, he wrote, *before I was a doorkeeper.*

Shouted at moths, wrote Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE LIVING CAME too.

That was the part Lex hadn't expected. People. Walking up the green road. With lanterns. To see. Because there was a door at the end of the world now, apple wood, painted blue, in flower, and the whole of Caldor had seen the WORLD NOTICE, and people wanted to see it for themselves.

They came and stood on the slope and looked at it.

Some of them painted something on it. Antho let them. He kept a pot of blue on the step.

Some of them knocked. Just to see. And Antho would come out and say *yes*? And they'd go red and say *sorry, just wanted to see what it sounded like*. And Antho would say *it sounds like that*, and go back in.

It's going to be a village, Antho wrote. *I can see it coming. A hundred years from now there'll be an inn here and a market and a man selling little wooden doors on sticks.*

I hope there's an inn, wrote Seraphine. *I'd kill for an inn.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BABY CAME IN August.

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THE LETTER CAME BY raven. Quill, ragged and furious, three days on the wing from the end of the road. Lex untied it in the Forge yard with his hands shaking so badly he tore the paper.

One line. Antho's hand. Very large. Very bad.

IT'S A BOY. HE'S LOUD. SERAPHINE SAYS HE'S THE 413TH. HIS NAME IS ARION.

And under it, in Seraphine's hand, very small, very neat—

He has his grandfather's ears. God help him.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT DOWN ON the upturned quench-trough in the yard.

Brannoc came out of the Forge. Looked at him. Looked at the letter. Took it out of his hand and read it, holding it at arm's length, with his lips moving.

Then he handed it back. And sat down beside him on the trough. With his old scarred fingertips on his knees.

Neither of them said anything for a long time.

"*Arion*," said Brannoc. At last. Gruffly.

"*Yes*."

"*Good name*."

"*Yes*."

Brannoc looked at the sky.

"*I'll make him a nail*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT THE END OF the summer, Pim came through the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HEARD ABOUT IT from Antho, first. Then from Pim himself, which was rarer, and shorter.

He'd been at the pool. All summer. With Ivy, and Hask—whose arm was flesh to the shoulder now, and who'd taken up a pick again, left-handed, and was digging a proper drain for the spring so the house wouldn't flood—and Kit, and the thorn-woman. Who'd stayed.

Rosie's planting roses, wrote Pim. In his small careful hand. *Round the pool. Round the lanterns. She says Mal likes them. She says he told her.*

She sits on the rim every morning and says good morning to him. Like Ivy. She says she's got a lot of good mornings to catch up on.

And then one morning at the end of August, he'd walked down the slope to the pool, and round it, and up through the soft dark to the back of the door. And knocked.

And Antho had let him in.

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HE CAME TO HARROW on a carter's wagon a week later. Thin. Brown. Silent. With a pack on his back and a pencil behind his ear.

He walked up the path to Seren's door. And stood on the ramp. And didn't knock, because he'd never liked knocking, it made a noise.

Seren opened it anyway. She'd seen him from the window.

Pim took something out of his pack. Wrapped in linen. Small. And held it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN UNWRAPPED IT.

It was a crown.

Small. Silver-grey. Seven points. Thin. Plain.

Hes's.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Rosie said*," said Pim. Slowly. Getting each word out like a stone out of a field. "*Give it back. To the Harrow woman. Or the little one.*" He looked at it in her hands. "*She said it's said its last no.*"

Seren looked at it for a long time.

"*Did she say anything else*?"

Pim thought about it.

"*She said it'll have a yes next*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T PUT IT under a flagstone.

She'd thought about it. Lex saw her think about it. She stood in her doorway with the crown in her hands and looked at the floor of her kitchen, where every Harrow woman had kept it for nine hundred years, hidden, in a box, under a stone.

Then she turned round. And went across the stepping stones to Lex's cottage. And in through the open door. To where Lark was sitting on the hearthrug in front of the fire, explaining something very important to Ember about a worm.

And knelt down. And held it out.

Lark looked at it.

Then she took it. With both hands. Turned it over. Examined it with her eyebrows. Bit it, experimentally.

Then she put it on her rag rabbit.

It slid down over the rabbit's ears and round its neck like a collar. Lark considered the effect. Seriously. For a long time.

"*Yes*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE LAUGHED.

Lex heard it. From the doorway. Where he'd come in from the Forge with soot to his elbows and stopped.

A small dry crackle. Startled. As if it had got out without asking. Like water out of a crack in ice.

[Oh,] said Ember. *[Oh, that's—I'm sorry. I don't know why that was funny. It was very funny.]*

Lark beamed at it.

[It was the rabbit,] said Ember. Helplessly. *[The rabbit's face. Did you see the rabbit's face?]*

"*I saw*," said Lex.

[It looked so—] The fire crackled again. *[It looked so pleased with itself*.]

Lex leaned in the doorway with soot to his elbows and watched his daughter and his mother and his old friend laughing together on the hearthrug in front of a fire he'd built with his own hands, and didn't say anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT DOWN THE next morning in the dark.

The way he always did. Raked the ash off the coals. Blew on them. Gently.

The fire woke.

"*Good morning*," said Lex.

[Good morning,] said Ember.

And then a pause. A short one. As if it had been about to say something else, and had stopped, and wasn't sure what it had been about to say.

[Good morning,] said Ember again. Slowly. Puzzled. As if trying the words out to see how they fitted.

Then, very quietly—

[...smith.]

Lex knelt on the hearthstone and waited.

It didn't say anything else.

He got up and put the kettle on.

That was all right. It was only September.

He could do a year and a half.

CHAPTER 37

Lantern Night

WREN MISSED THE TREE.

Not the chalk. The *tree*. The whole birch, white and black, as wide as her two hands spread. Twenty paces. She drew, with her left hand on the grip—her own left hand, pink, stiff, five fingers that could feel the wood again and had forgotten what to do about it—and her right hand at her cheek, and held, and loosed.

The arrow went past the birch on the left by a yard and vanished into the bracken.

Wren lowered the bow.

She looked at the place where the arrow had gone. For a long time.

Then she laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THE MORNING of Lantern Night. Cold. Clear. The birch wood behind the cottage at Harrow gone gold and brown and red, leaves coming down in the wind like sparks, the ground thick with them. Her breath smoking. The chalk circle on the birch, the size of a plate, freshly drawn, untouched.

Forty arrows in the quiver.

She'd shot nine. None in the tree.

Last winter, with the wrong hand, shaking, she'd put eleven in the tree out of forty and two in the chalk, and gone in and cried in the woodshed where nobody could see.

She wasn't crying now.

She nocked the tenth.

It carries, she thought. *It doesn't have to carry away.*

She drew. Held. Loosed.

The arrow hit the birch. A hand's width outside the chalk. *Thock*. And stood there. Quivering.

Wren looked at it.

"*Good*," she said. Out loud. To nobody. To the wood.

And nocked the eleventh.

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LARK FOUND HER AT the twentieth.

Came through the gap in the hedge at the bottom of the wood on her hands and knees, the way she always did, no matter how many times she'd been told. Stood up on the other side. Two years old tonight. Nearly. In a red wool coat that Seren had knitted, too big, and boots, and Hes's crown round the neck of her rag rabbit, which she carried everywhere by one ear.

She looked at the birch. At the arrows in it. Four. And the one in the chalk.

Then at the bracken behind it. Where the other fifteen had gone.

"*Mam*," said Lark. Very seriously. "*Missed.*"

"*Yes*," said Wren. "*Lots.*"

Lark considered this.

"*Again*," she said. Encouragingly.

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THEY CAME IN THE afternoon.

Wren saw them from the top of the wood. A shape in the sky over the west. Blue. Big. Getting bigger. Wings beating so slow and so strong she felt the air shift in the birch leaves before she heard it.

Ashka.

The storm-mother's daughter. Grown again since the spring, since the First Breath. She came down out of the cold blue sky over Harrow in a long slow spiral, and the leaves went up off the ground in a whirl round her, and she landed in the meadow on the far side of the stream with a thump that shook the stepping stones.

And on her back—

Antho. In his old coat. With the bone flute stuck through his belt. Climbing down stiffly, the way you climb down after six hours in the cold.

And Seraphine. Wrapped in three cloaks and a blanket. With her horn spectacles fogged up. And a bundle in her arms. Small. Wrapped. Wailing.

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"*He hates flying*," said Seraphine. At the stream. Handing the bundle across the stepping stones to Seren, who'd come out of her cottage at a run with her apron still on. "*He hated it for six hours. He has very strong opinions. He gets them from his father.*"

"*I don't have strong opinions*," said Antho.

"*You have strong opinions about moths.*"

"*Everyone has strong opinions about moths.*"

Seren wasn't listening.

She was standing on the bank of the stream with the bundle in her arms. Unwrapping it. Very gently. A fold of blanket. Another. Until she could see.

A face. Red. Furious. Crumpled. Two months old. With a shock of black hair and a mouth wide open, yelling at the whole of the world as if it had a complaint to make.

And ears.

Wren saw Seren see the ears.

They stuck out. A little. At the top. The way an old man's had, in a chair by a window, who'd said good morning every day for a year and a half to a woman who didn't know him.

"*Oh*," said Seren.

She sat down on the bank of the stream. Right there. In the leaves. With her grandson in her lap. And put her face down close to his.

"*Hello, Arion*," said Seren Harrow.

The baby stopped yelling.

He looked up at her. With his dark furious eyes. For a long time.

Then he sneezed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOORKEEPER HAD LEFT the door with Roole.

"*He offered*," said Antho. At the kitchen table. With a mug of tea in his hands and his boots off and his feet on the fender. "*He said he'd had practice. Standing at gates. He said one night wouldn't kill him.*" He drank. "*He said, if anybody knocks, I'll ask them their business. I said, they're dead, Roole. He said, that's no excuse for bad manners.*"

Lex laughed. At the hearth. With the poker.

Wren watched him laugh.

He'd been laughing more. Since the summer. Since the green road. Not all the time—he'd always been a quiet man, a man who said three words where other people said thirty—but more. At things. At Lark. At Brannoc's ale, which was terrible. At Ember.

She watched him stop laughing and look at the fire.

He did that too. Every evening. Every morning. A look. Quick. Not long. The way you look at the door of a room where someone's sleeping, to see if they're awake yet.

The fire crackled. Gold. Comfortable.

[Is that the Doorkeeper?] said Ember. Interested. *[The one with the strong opinions about moths?]*

Antho looked at the hearth.

Then he looked at Lex.

Lex didn't look back. He was looking at the fire.

"*Yes*," said Antho. Carefully. "*That's me.*"

[I've read a great deal about you,] said Ember. *[In the smith's mother's notes. You were a monster once.]*

"*Once*."

[And then you weren't.] A pause. *[I'd like to hear about that. For the book. If you have time.]*

Antho put his mug down.

"*I've got all night*," he said. Gently. "*It's Lantern Night.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LIT THE LANTERNS at dusk.

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EVERY WINDOW AT HARROW. Both cottages. The way they had on the night Lark was born, two years ago, when the whole of the Vale had

come up the river path with lanterns and set them in every window and on every post and along the garden wall, and Wren had lain in Seren's bed with a small furious red thing on her chest yelling at the world, and looked out of the window at all the light.

They did it again.

Lex had made new ones. He'd been making them all autumn. In the evenings. At the Forge. Tin and horn. One for every window. And he'd cut a word in the base of every one, the way he always did, with the point of a nail.

Wren went round with Lark and read them. Lark couldn't read. She liked the shapes.

HERE. That was the east window. His. The one that had been empty since he gave the last one to Nan Ashby.

HOME. The kitchen.

STAY. Over the door.

MORE. That one was Lark's. In the little window of the loft where she slept now, in a real bed, with a rail. Lex had said it was the only word he could think of that she'd say yes to.

And on the west sill of Seren's cottage, across the stream, the old horn lantern. With two lines cut in the base. One in a smith's square careful hand. One in a woman's crooked one.

TOO LATE.

STILL HERE.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME UP THE river path at dark.

The Vale. The way they'd come two years ago. But more. Brannoc, with Tilda, with a basket of something under a cloth that smelled of burned sugar. Kestrel, with Tamsin. Teo, with Barnaby, who had a new jar. Hollis Penn, with a loaf the size of a cartwheel. Elowen, in her mail, because she said it was a feast day and she'd be properly dressed. Davy Pruett and his father and his mother and the new baby. Jem Tolley, with a jar of honey. Old Mag's neighbour, with her great-grandmother's iron lantern with the cracked pane, which she'd carried two hundred miles to

the end of the world and two hundred back, and wasn't going to leave at home for this.

Nan Ashby, with Col. Col was carrying the HERE lantern. Nan said he carried it everywhere.

And Pim.

He'd been at Harrow since August. He slept in Seren's loft and helped in the Forge and said perhaps eleven words a week. He came up the path with the others with a lantern in each hand. Plain. Tin. One of them was the one from the Coldwater house window. *HOME*. Hask had sent it. With a note. *For the little one. From the pool. Rosie says happy birthday. Ivy says don't eat coal.*

The other one, he gave to Lark.

It was very small. Clumsy. The tin bent in places. The soldering lumpy. Somebody had made it who had never made a lantern before and had only seen it done.

There was a word cut in the base. Very carefully. In a small neat hand.

ILDA.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK HELD IT.

She didn't know what it said. She held it in both hands, with the rag rabbit tucked under her arm and Hes's crown sliding down its neck, and looked at the light in it. Small. Gold. Burning on nothing.

Then she looked up at Pim.

"*Yes*," said Lark.

Pim went red to the ears.

He didn't say anything. He never did, if he could help it.

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THEY ATE IN THE garden.

Tables from both cottages carried out onto the grass by the stream. Benches. Barrels. Lanterns on everything. The roses on the grave still flowering, dark red, nearly black, in October, as if it were midsummer. Rosie's roses. Wren thought they always would.

Hollis cut the cartwheel loaf. Brannoc uncovered the basket, which turned out to be a cake, of a kind, which had been on fire at least once.

Tilda said it was meant to look like that. Nobody believed her. Everybody ate it.

And at the end, when the cake was gone and the honey was gone and the cartwheel was mostly gone, and it was full dark, and cold, and the lanterns were the only light for miles—

Antho took the bone flute out of his belt.

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HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING. He just stood up. At the end of the table. By the stream. And put the flute to his lips.

And played the Lantern Song.

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WREN KNEW IT. EVERYONE knew it. Every child in Caldor had had it sung over their cot. It was the first song anyone ever learned and the last one anyone ever forgot. Old Mag had sung it on her last night with a gold king's hand in hers. Seren had sung it into the dark for thirteen years.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you fear—

Seren started singing.

Flat. On the high note. The way she always was. The way Antho said she always had been, the way Arion had said, the way Old Mag had said. Seren Harrow couldn't hold the high note in the Lantern Song to save her life, and had never once in fifty-one years let it stop her.

There's a light in the window, and I'm right here—

Brannoc joined in. Gruffly. Off the note entirely. Then Tilda. Then Kestrel. Then the whole garden. Fifty voices. More. In the cold. In the dark. By the stream. With the lanterns burning in every window and the roses on the grave.

And if you go walking where I can't see—

Wren sang it too.

She'd never had much of a voice. She sang anyway. With Lark on her knee, and Lex's arm round her, and her pink fingers in her daughter's hair.

Leave a light in the window, love, and come home to me.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE WAS LISTENING.

Wren saw it.

Through the kitchen window. Through the open door. In the hearth. Where Ember was. The flame had gone very still. Not crackling. Not commenting. Not taking notes for the book. Just—still. Listening. Leaning a little toward the door. Toward the garden. Toward the singing.

The way the flames had leaned toward Lark, the night the Veil fell.

Lex hadn't seen. Lex was singing, badly, with his eyes shut, with his arm round her.

Wren didn't tell him.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK FELL ASLEEP AT midnight.

On Wren's knee. In the garden. With the ILDA lantern in her lap and her rabbit under her arm and her cheek on Wren's chest. Two years old. Tonight. Exactly. She'd been born at midnight on Lantern Night, with the whole of the Vale lit round her, yelling.

She didn't yell now. She just slept. Heavy. Warm. Breathing.

Wren sat there with her for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GUESTS WENT HOME at one. Down the river path with their lanterns. A long line of gold going away under the alders. Singing, some of them. Hollis Penn was singing something that wasn't the Lantern Song and wasn't fit for a feast day.

Antho and Seraphine went to bed in Seren's loft, with the baby between them. Pim slept on the settle. Seren didn't sleep. Seren never did. Seren sat in her chair by the west window under the horn lantern with a cup of tea going cold, looking out at the grave.

Wren carried Lark up to the loft. And put her in her bed with the rail. And set the ILDA lantern on the sill beside the MORE one, so there were two.

She stood there for a long time. Looking at her.

Then she went to bed.

Lex was already asleep. Sideways. With his feet hanging off the end. The way he always slept after a feast, like a man who'd been felled.

Wren lay down beside him.

She didn't sleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HEARD HIM GET up.

In the grey before dawn. The way he always did. A smith gets up before the sun. She felt the bed shift. Heard his feet find the floor. Heard him go down the stairs, quietly, skipping the fourth one, which creaked.

She lay there.

Then she got up too.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T GO DOWN.

She sat on the top stair. In the dark. In her nightshirt. With her knees drawn up and her arms round them. The way she'd sat on the top stair at Thistledown when she was small, listening to her father bank the fire.

She could see the kitchen from there. Through the banisters. A slice of it. The hearth. The banked coals, red under the ash. And Lex.

Kneeling on the hearthstone. In the dark. With the poker.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE RAKED THE ASH off the coals.

Slowly. Carefully. The way he did every morning. The way Brannoc had taught him when he was eleven. Not too much. Not too fast. You don't wake a fire by shouting at it.

Then he leaned down. And blew on them. Gently.

The way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

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THE FIRE WOKE.

A flicker. A lift. A small gold flame coming up out of the red, catching on the kindling he'd laid, climbing. Warm. Gold.

Lex sat back on his heels.

Wren saw his face in the light. Tired. Patient. Twenty-seven years old and looking, in the firelight, about twelve. The crooked mouth. The square hands on his knees.

"*Good morning*," said Lex.

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THE FIRE DIDN'T ANSWER.

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WREN WAITED. ON THE top stair. With her arms round her knees.

Lex waited. On the hearthstone.

The fire burned. Small. Gold. Quiet. Not crackling. Not commenting. Not saying *good morning, smith* the way it had every morning since the summer. Politely. Pleasantly. The way you'd say it to the man who keeps the inn.

It didn't say anything.

It just burned. And looked at him. Wren could feel it looking. The way you can feel someone looking at you across a room in the dark.

A long time.

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THEN—

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[You've got ash on your nose,] said Ember.

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LEX WENT VERY STILL.

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[You've always got ash on your nose,] said the fire. Slowly. Wonderingly. Like someone reading a page they've read before and only just understood. *[Every morning. Every single morning. You blow on the coals and the ash goes up and you get it on your nose and you never notice. I've told you. A hundred times. A thousand. You never listen.]*

Lex didn't move.

[You were nineteen,] said Ember. *[The first time. In the Forge at Ashbourne. On the floor. After the Kindling. You'd fallen asleep by the hearth because you were frightened to go to bed. And I woke up in your chest and you didn't know what I was. And you got up in the morning and blew on the coals and got ash on your nose and said—]*

The fire stopped.

Wren, on the top stair, had her hand over her mouth.

[You said good morning,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[To the fire. Not to me. You didn't know I was there yet. You just said it. To the fire. Because you always did. Because your father did. Because it seemed rude not to.]*

A pause.

[And I thought—that's the best thing I've ever heard. I thought, I'm going to like this boy.]

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX'S SHOULDERS WERE SHAKING.

He didn't make a sound. He knelt there on the hearthstone in the grey light with his square hands on his knees and his head bowed and his shoulders shaking, and didn't make a sound at all.

[I've been sitting in this hearth since the summer,] said Ember, *[trying to work out why I'm happy in the mornings. I've been writing it down. I've got forty pages of notes. Your mother's got them. I thought it was the draw on the chimney. I thought it was the oak. I thought it was the little one and her worms.]* A crackle. Small. Dry. *[It's you. It's been you the whole time. You come down the stairs in the dark and skip the fourth one because it creaks, and you rake the ash, and you blow, and you say it. Every morning. You said it when I didn't know you. You said it for three months to a fire that called you smith.]*

The flame leaned. Toward him. Out of the grate. Toward the bowed head and the shaking shoulders.

[I don't remember loving you,] said Ember. *[That's gone. The old man was right. It went where prices go.]*

A pause.

[But I've been watching you do it,] said Ember. *[Every morning. Since the summer. And I think I've worked out how it goes.]*

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WREN COULDN'T SEE LEX'S face.

She didn't need to.

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[Good morning, Lex,] said Ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LIFTED HIS HEAD.

He looked at the fire. In the grey light. On his knees on the hearthstone in the kitchen of the cottage he'd built with his own hands on the black scorch-mark of the one that burned. With ash on his nose. With his face wet.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he smiled. The crooked one. The one that made him look about twelve.

"*Good morning, Ember*," said Lex.

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WREN WENT BACK TO bed.

She didn't go down. It wasn't hers. She got up off the top stair very quietly and went back along the landing and got into the warm bed and lay there in the grey with her pink hand on her own chest and her eyes wet and listened.

To the kettle going on.

To the cups coming down off the hooks. Two. Out of habit. Then a third, and a laugh, and the third going back up.

To the fire, crackling, talking, fast, the way it used to, dry and fond and irritable, telling him he was holding the kettle wrong.

To her husband laughing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ABOVE HER, IN THE loft, Lark woke up.

Wren heard her. The rail creaking. The bare feet on the boards. A thump, which was the rabbit being thrown out of the bed ahead of her, as a scout. The small fierce sounds of a person who has just turned two and has a great deal to do today and doesn't intend to wait for anyone.

The loft hatch opened.

A head came down. Upside down. Black hair sticking up at the back like a jackdaw's. Square eyebrows. Looking at her.

"*Mam*," said Lark. "*Mmo-ning.*"

"*Good morning, love*," said Wren.

And outside the window, over the birch wood, over the stream and the stepping stones and the roses on the grave and the blue door of the cottage across the water with the horn lantern in its window—

The sun came up.

EPILOGUE

A Forge, a Child, a Lantern

SIX YEARS LATER, ON the morning of Lantern Night, Lark Vey made her first lantern.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DID IT AT the long anvil. In the Forge at Ashbourne. At five in the morning. In the dark. Because that was when smiths worked, she said, and she was going to be a smith, and she wasn't going to start being one at a lazy hour like *nine*.

She was eight.

She stood on the crate. The same crate. Brannoc's crate, that Lex had stood on at eleven with a horseshoe nail in his fist, that had stood at the end of the long anvil for forty years for apprentices too short to reach. Lark was nearly too tall for it now. She'd grown a hand's width since the spring. Wren said she'd be taller than both of them, and furious about it.

She had her father's hands. Square. Short strong fingers. Wide palms. Burns on the backs of them, already, little white crescents, from the first year she'd been allowed near a fire and hadn't listened.

She had her mother's eyes. Green. And her mother's way of looking at a thing she was about to do. As if it had insulted her.

And she had her own eyebrows. Square. Down.

"*Don't tell me*," said Lark.

"*I wasn't going to*," said Lex.

"*You were. You were going to say the tin's too thick.*"

"*The tin's too thick*."

"*I know*," said Lark. "*I want it thick. I want it to last.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[She's right, you know,] said the fire.

From the great hearth. Gold. Dry. Small. Amused.

[Thick tin holds the heat better at the seams,] said Ember. *[The Saltreach lantern-makers used a gauge nearly twice what you use, in the old days. They said a lantern ought to outlive the person who made it.]*

"*Whose side are you on*?" said Lex.

[Hers,] said Ember. *[Obviously. She's much better company. She doesn't get ash on her nose.]*

"*I do*," said Lark. "*Sometimes. I just wipe it off.*"

[Exactly,] said Ember. *[She wipes it off. Six years, Lex. Six years and you have never once wiped it off.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT ON THE bench by the wall and watched her work.

He didn't help. She didn't want him to. He'd learned that the first year, when she was five, and had wanted to make a nail, and he'd put his hand round hers on the hammer the way he had at the bottom of the world, and she'd turned round on the crate and looked at him with her eyebrows and said *no*.

So he sat on the bench.

She cut the tin. Badly. Then better. She bent it on the horn of the anvil, the way he'd shown her, and the way Tilda had shown her, and the way Ember had explained at length, with diagrams drawn in the ash. She soldered the seams with the little iron, her tongue between her teeth, the way her grandmother wrote. The first seam was lumpy. The second was less lumpy. The third was good.

She scraped the horn for the panes herself. She'd been doing it all week. In the evenings. At the kitchen table at Harrow. With a knife and a lamp. Scraping, scraping, until the horn was thin enough to see the flame through, yellow-brown, like old honey.

She put it all together on the anvil as the sky went grey in the Forge windows.

And then she stood back. On the crate. And looked at it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A LANTERN.

It wasn't a good one. The door hung a little crooked. One of the horn panes was thicker than the others, so the light would come out lopsided. The handle was too big, because she'd wanted it big enough for a grown man's hand.

It was a lantern.

"*It needs a word*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D BEEN THINKING ABOUT the word for a month.

Lex knew. He'd watched her think. At the table. At the stream. On the stepping stones. On the swing, which she was much too old for and still went on, high, every evening, until the bough creaked. Frowning. With her eyebrows. The way she'd frowned at the gold panel at the bottom of the world when it asked her a question.

He'd asked her, once, what she was going to cut.

She'd looked at him with scorn.

It's a surprise, she'd said. *Obviously*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE PICKED UP THE nail.

A horseshoe nail. Old. Square-headed. Bent a little at the tip. Brannoc had given it to her when she was six weeks old, in a cradle at the Forge, on a winter afternoon. *A smith's first nail*, he'd said. *Every smith has one. Mine was my father's. Lex had one. Now she has one.* She'd kept it in a tin under her bed ever since.

She turned the lantern over on the anvil. And held the nail to the tin of the base, the way Lex had shown her, the way he'd cut every word he'd ever cut. *HERE. HOME. STAY. TOO LATE. MORE.*

And cut.

Slowly. Carefully. Pressing hard. Three letters. Square. Deep. In a hand that was going to be very like his.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TURNED IT THE right way up. And held it out to him across the anvil.

He took it.

He turned it over. And read the base.

◆ ◆ ◆

YES.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT for a long time.

He thought about a gold panel at the bottom of the world. *WILL YOU HOLD IT*? And a girl of twenty months, with her hand on an anvil, looking down seven steps at her father.

No.

He thought about a thorn-woman, kneeling on the rim of a pool in the morning, handing a small silver-grey crown to a boy who didn't talk. *It'll have a yes next*.

"*Why yes*?" he said. When he could.

Lark looked at him. As if he were being very slow.

"*Because I said no to everything*," she said. "*When I was little. Gan says. To bread and baths and the cold lady and the King and the whole net.*" She shrugged. "*I'm eight now. I thought I'd better start saying yes to things. Or nobody'll ever ask me anything again.*"

[That's very sensible,] said Ember.

"*I know*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Who's it for*?" said Lex.

He knew. He didn't want to know. He asked anyway.

Lark took the lantern back. Gently. Out of his hands. And held it against her chest. The way you'd hold a moth.

"*Gramp*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC HOLT WAS SEVENTY-ONE.

He'd been tired since the spring. Not ill. Not anything you could put a name to. Just tired. The way the old get tired, Seren said. The way a fire gets

tired at the end of a long night, when the coals are all ash on the outside and red only right at the heart.

He'd stopped coming to the Forge in the summer. He'd gone to live at Harrow, in Seren's loft, where Pim used to sleep before Pim went back to the pool to keep it with Rosie and Ivy. He sat in the garden in the afternoons. On the bench by the grave. With his old scarred fingers in his lap. Looking at the roses.

In September he'd said, at supper, quite calmly, between one mouthful and the next: *I'd like to go to the door, I think. Before the snow.*

Nobody had said anything.

I've had a good long go, said Brannoc. *Seventy-one years. Forty-five of them at that anvil. A boy came in out of the snow when I was fifty, with nobody, and I got to watch him grow up.* He looked at his plate. *I'd like to see the door again. And sit by it a bit. And then I'd like to go and see Mattie.*

Lark had been six then. No—seven. She'd sat at the table with her spoon halfway to her mouth and looked at him for a long time.

Then she'd put the spoon down and gone out to the Forge without a word, in the dark, at seven o'clock at night. And Lex had found her there an hour later, on the crate, cutting tin.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT ON ASHKA.

The storm-mother's daughter was huge now. Bigger than her mother had been. She came down out of the October sky over Harrow on the morning of Lantern Night in a long slow spiral, the way she always did, and landed in the meadow by the stream with a thump that shook the stepping stones, and put her great blue head down on the grass in front of Brannoc. And waited.

Brannoc looked at her.

"*I don't like dragons*," he said.

"*I know*," said Lex.

"*Never have. I walked two days once so I wouldn't have to fly on one.*"

"*I know.*"

Brannoc looked at the dragon for a long time. Then at the stream. Then at the cottage, with its blue door and its horn lantern in the window. Then at the grave, with the roses climbing over it.

"*Well*," said Brannoc Holt. "*It's a long walk. And I'm a bit tired.*"

And let Lex help him up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SIX OF THEM. BRANNOC in the middle, wrapped in three blankets, with Lark in front of him, holding the YES lantern in her lap, and Lex behind, with his arms round both of them. Wren on Vharuun beside them, with Mattie—four, small, red-haired, silent as Pim and twice as stubborn, named for a weaver Lex had never met—asleep against her chest. Seren on Vharuun too. With the clay lamp.

They flew west.

Over the Vale. Over Westerling, where a young man was getting in the last of the barley on a hillside, and his old mother was sitting on the wall watching him, with a lantern in her lap. Over the green road, with its lanterns every mile, still burning, six years on, because people kept them. Somebody always did. Over farms and villages and fords and mills. Over a land that was green and gold and brown and alive, with smoke going up from chimneys and birds going up out of hedges and children running out of houses to wave at the dragons going over.

Brannoc slept most of the way.

Lark didn't. She sat in front of him with the lantern in her lap and her back against his chest, and every so often she turned round to check he was still breathing.

He always was.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A VILLAGE at the door now.

Antho had been right. Lex had known he would be. It had started with one house—two rooms and a loft, a fat chimney, a lantern in each window—and then Tom Pruett's men had stayed on and built themselves somewhere to sleep, and then their wives had come, and then somebody had opened a shop, and then somebody else had opened an inn, and now

there were forty houses on the long rise above the end of the road and a market on Thursdays and a man who sold little wooden doors on sticks.

The inn was called the Last House. Roole kept it. He said he'd stood at enough gates to know how to run one. It had the best ale for two hundred miles and a rule, written on a board over the bar in Roole's square grim capitals: *THE DEAD DRINK FREE*. Nobody had ever seen a dead man drink. Roole said that wasn't the point.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN OUT of the sky in the afternoon.

Into the meadow behind Antho's house. With the whole village coming out to look, the way it always did when the dragons came. Children running. Dogs barking. Seraphine in the doorway of the house with her horn spectacles and her quill, already writing.

And Antho.

He came across the meadow. In his old coat. Grey at the temples now—grey early, the way his father had, the way Seren said Vey men always did. With a boy at his heels. Six. Thin. Black-haired. With ears that stuck out at the top.

"*Uncle Lex*," shouted Ari Vey. "*Uncle Lex, Uncle Lex, I can skip a stone seven times, Da counted—*"

"*Six*," said Antho.

"*SEVEN*."

"*Six and a half*," said Antho. "*The last one sank.*"

He stopped at the dragon's side. And looked up. At Brannoc. Wrapped in his blankets. Grey-faced. Smiling.

"*Brannoc*," said Antho. Very gently.

"*Doorkeeper*," said Brannoc. "*I've come to sit on your step. If that's all right.*"

Antho looked at him for a long time.

"*It's what it's for*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT BY THE door all evening.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC ON THE THRESHOLD. On the grey stone. With his back against the frame, the way the Ferryman had sat. Wrapped in his blankets. With his old scarred fingers in his lap and the evening sun on his face.

The door stood shut beside him. Seven feet. Three and a half. Apple wood. Still blooming. Six years, and every morning new flowers, white and pink, and every evening the petals coming off in the wind, and never once a bare branch. Painted blue. Painted over and over. Every stroke anyone had ever added in six years. Loaves and hammers and fish and bees and roses and names, so many names, so many little pictures, layer on layer, until the door was thick with them, a whole world in blue. And low down, under the latch, small and square and faded now, a child's handprint.

Lark sat on the grass in front of him. With the YES lantern in her lap. Not lit yet. Waiting.

The rest of them sat round. On the slope. On the grass. Lex and Wren and Mattie. Seren with her lamp. Antho and Seraphine and Ari. Roole, who'd shut the inn. Half the village, sitting further back, quietly, with their own lanterns, the way people sat now, at the door, when someone came to it at the end.

Nobody said much.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mattie liked roses*," said Brannoc.

At sunset. To nobody. Looking at the door.

"*She grew them*," he said. "*Up the front of the weaver's cottage. Red ones. Dark. Nearly black in the middle.*" He smiled. "*She'd have liked the thorn-woman's.*"

"*She'd have liked you*," said Seren. "*Mattie. Grown old. She'd have liked you old.*"

Brannoc didn't say anything for a while.

"*I went in every night*," he said. "*When she was ill. Thirty years ago. Every night. I sat by the bed. And every morning I went back to the forge and lit the fire. Because somebody had to.*" He looked at his hands. "*And then one night I went in and she'd gone. In the night. On her own. While I was asleep in the chair.*" A pause. "*I always thought that was the worst of it. That I wasn't awake.*"

Lark put her hand on his knee.

"*You can be awake this time*," she said. "*I'll stay up. I always stay up on Lantern Night.*"

Brannoc looked down at her. At her square hand on his blanket.

"*Aye*," he said. Gruffly. "*You do.*"

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THE SUN WENT DOWN.

The lanterns came out. All over the village on the rise. In every window. Along the road. Down the slope. Round the door. The way they did every Lantern Night now, at the end of the road. Hundreds of them. Gold.

Lark lit hers.

She did it with a spill from Seren's lamp. Very carefully. Opened the crooked little door of the lantern and held the spill to the wick and watched it catch. And closed the door. And held it up.

The light came out lopsided. Through the thick pane on one side more yellow than the rest.

It was the most beautiful lantern Lex had ever seen.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GAVE IT TO Brannoc.

She didn't say anything. She just held it out. In both hands. With the YES turned toward him, so he could see.

He took it. In his old scarred hand. The handle was big enough. She'd made sure.

He held it up. And looked at it. At the light. At the crooked door and the lumpy seam and the lopsided pane.

He turned it over. And read the base.

Lex saw his face.

He'd known Brannoc Holt for twenty-two years. He'd seen him angry, and tired, and drunk on his own terrible ale. He'd seen him on his knees at a hearth at midnight saying *evening* to a fire for the first time in forty-five years. He'd seen him stand on a stone at the end of the world and plant his feet and close a crack.

He'd never seen him look like this.

"*Thick tin*," said Brannoc. When he could. His voice had gone. "*Good. It'll last.*"

"*That's what I said*," said Lark.

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HE WENT JUST BEFORE dawn.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS AWAKE. EVERYONE was. Nobody had slept. They'd sat on the slope all night under the lanterns, wrapped in blankets, while the stars went round. Ari had fallen asleep in Antho's lap. Mattie in Wren's. Seraphine had written all night, by the light of her lantern, and then stopped, and just sat.

Lark hadn't slept.

She'd sat on the grass at Brannoc's feet all night, the way she'd said she would. With her chin on her knees. Awake. Watching him. And every so often he'd open his eyes and look down at her and she'd be looking back, and he'd say *still up*? and she'd say *still up*, and he'd close his eyes again.

The YES lantern sat in his lap all night. Burning.

◆ ◆ ◆

IN THE GREY BEFORE dawn, he opened his eyes and didn't close them.

He looked at the door.

Lex followed his look.

There was someone standing on the slope below the threshold.

◆ ◆ ◆

TALL. GREY. HOODED. WITH a long stick in one hand, like a walking stick, worn smooth at the grip. No lantern. No oar.

Lex hadn't seen him come. Nobody had. He was just there. Standing in the grass at the foot of the threshold, in the grey light, with the dew on the hem of his robe and mud on his feet from a long way of walking.

He looked older. Lex hadn't thought that was possible. Older and browner, as if six years of mornings had got into him. There was a sprig of something in the band of his hood. Heather. From the Teeth, maybe. Or further.

He looked at Brannoc.

"*Smith*," said the Ferryman.

"*Not any more*," said Brannoc. "*Retired.*"

"*Ah*," said the Ferryman. "*So am I.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You came back*," said Antho. Very quietly. From the slope.

The Ferryman turned his hooded head.

"*I said I would*," he said. "*Everyone does.*" He looked at the door. At the blue paint. At the blooming. At the bell. "*I've been seeing mornings. Six years of them. I've seen them over the sea at Gull's Reach and over the Pale Wastes and over the Teeth and over a city in the Sunreach where they ring a bell for every one.*" A pause. "*They're very good. I recommend them.*"

He looked back at Brannoc.

"*But I heard there was a smith at the door*," said the Ferryman. "*A good one. Who held a fire for a king once. I thought I'd come and sit with him. If he didn't mind.*"

Brannoc looked at him for a long time.

"*Mind the step*," said Brannoc Holt. "*It's been swept.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN SAT DOWN beside him.

On the threshold. On the grey stone. With his back against the other side of the frame and his stick across his knees. Two old men on a doorstep in the grey before dawn. Not saying anything.

Brannoc looked at the lantern in his lap.

Then at Lark. On the grass at his feet. Awake. Watching him.

"*Still up*?" said Brannoc.

"*Still up*," said Lark.

He smiled.

Then he looked at Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT DOWN THE slope.

He didn't know he was going until he was there. Kneeling on the grass in front of the threshold, beside his daughter, in front of the old man

who'd found him in the snow at eleven with nobody and taken him in and given him a crate to stand on and a fire to wake every morning and a hammer and a trade and a life.

Brannoc held out his hand.

The one without the lantern. Old. Scarred. Burned at the tips. Not gold. Never gold again.

Lex took it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mind the quench*," said Brannoc.

"*I always do*."

"*You never do*." The old man's grip was very weak. "*You never have. You put it in too hot and too fast and you swear when it cracks.*" A breath. "*Good lad.*"

He looked at the door.

"*Doorkeeper*," said Brannoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CAME DOWN THE slope.

Slowly. With his hands open at his sides. The way he walked toward a frightened animal. The way he'd walked toward a little grey girl in a drowned street. He stepped up onto the threshold, past the two old men sitting on it, and put his thumb on the latch.

The latch lifted.

The door swung. Out. On its breathing hinges. And the bell rang. Once. Small. Clear.

And behind it, the room.

Soft. Dark. Deep. Full of stars. With shapes moving in the gaps between them, going in, going on. And far off, at the bottom, a pool. In a green field. With a ring of roses round it, now, as well as lanterns, red, nearly black at the heart. And a thin dark-haired young man of twenty-one sitting on the rim with his knees drawn up, and a woman of forty-six beside him with dirt on her hands, kneeling among the roses.

They looked up. Both of them. Through the soft dark. At the open door.

Pim lifted his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND JUST INSIDE THE door—a yard in, no more, in the soft dark, among the stars—

A column of grey dust.

Small. A woman's height. Standing very still. Bending. A little. At the top. Toward the threshold. Toward the old man sitting on it.

The way a woman bends over a man asleep in a chair, to see if he's awake.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC SAW HER.

Lex felt it. Through his hand. The old fingers tightening. Once. Hard. The way they'd tightened on a hammer for forty-five years.

"*Oh*," said Brannoc Holt. Very softly. "*There you are.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

Lex didn't know how. He'd been too weak to stand since the spring. He stood up off the threshold with the YES lantern in one hand and Lex's hand in the other, and he was straight. Not stooped. Not tired. A big grey-haired man in a leather apron, the way he'd been on the morning a boy came in out of the snow.

He let go of Lex's hand.

He looked down at Lark.

"*Thank you for the lantern*," said Brannoc. "*I'll take good care of it.*"

"*It's thick tin*," said Lark. Her voice was shaking. Her eyebrows were down. Hard. "*It'll last.*"

"*Aye*," said Brannoc. "*I know. I can tell.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED ROUND.

He stepped through the door.

The Ferryman, on the step, inclined his hooded head. Very slightly. As Brannoc went past. The way you'd nod to a man across a room who has done something hard.

The grey column bent. All the way. Close. Arms. Arms that could close, now.

And they went down into the soft dark together. A big old man with a lantern, and a woman made of grey dust, with her arm through his. Slowly. Not hurrying. Not late. Down between the stars. The YES lantern swinging from his hand, lopsided, thick-tinned, burning gold.

They watched it go down.

Smaller. Smaller. A gold speck among the stars.

It didn't go out.

It just got further away.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CLOSED THE DOOR.

Gently. The latch dropped. *Click*. The bell didn't ring. It only rang for opening.

He stood there with his hand flat on the blue wood for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK DIDN'T CRY.

Not then. She knelt on the grass in front of the threshold with her square hands on her knees and her eyebrows down and her jaw set, looking at the closed door, and didn't cry.

Lex knelt beside her.

He didn't say anything. He'd learned that much. From Pim. From the dead. From an old man on a bench by a grave. Sometimes you didn't say anything.

He just put his arm round her.

After a while, she leaned against him.

After a while longer, she said, very quietly, into his shoulder—

"*He took it with him*."

"*Yes*."

"*The first one I ever made*."

"*Yes*."

Lark was quiet for a long time.

"*Good*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SUN CAME UP.

Over the world. Over the green road. Over the village at the end of it, and the lanterns going pale in the windows, and the slope, and the threshold. Over two old men's places on a doorstep, one empty. Over the Ferryman, who had closed his eyes and turned his face to it, the way you'd turn your face to a fire.

Over the door.

The blue went bright. The apple wood went gold. The petals lit up, every one, white and pink, new this morning, the way they were new every morning.

The hinges breathed.

Out. And back.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK STOOD UP.

She wiped her face with the back of her hand. Fiercely. As if it had insulted her. And looked at the door for a long time.

Then she turned round. And looked up at her father.

"*I want to make another one*," said Lark Vey.

"*Another lantern*?"

"*Lots*," said Lark. "*Every one I can. For everyone. So nobody has to go through without one.*" She frowned. Her eyebrows. "*I'll need more tin. And better horn. And you have to show me how to hang a door properly, mine was crooked.*"

Lex looked down at her.

Eight years old. Square hands. Green eyes. Burns on her knuckles. Ash on her nose.

"*All right*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED BACK UP the slope together in the morning sun. Toward the village. Toward the Last House and Roole's terrible breakfast and the dragons in the meadow and the long flight home.

Toward Harrow. And the stream. And the stepping stones. And the blue door of a cottage across the water with a horn lantern in its window.

Toward the Forge. At five in the morning. In the dark. With the hearth banked and the long anvil cold and a crate at the end of it for anyone too short to reach. And a small dry voice in the fire that would wake when he blew on it, and say good morning, and tell him he had ash on his nose.

He would.

He always would.

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND THEM, AT THE end of the road, at the edge of the world, the door stood shut in the sunlight on its threshold of grey stone. Blue. Blooming. Breathing.

Waiting for the next one.

And on the step, in the sun, with his eyes closed and a sprig of heather in his hood, the oldest thing in the world sat with his back against the frame. Not going anywhere. Not rowing. Not waiting at the edge of anything.

Just sitting on a doorstep, on a fine morning, keeping someone company.

In case anybody wanted to come out.

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Here ends The Sorcerer's Dawn, *and the Lattice Chronicles.*

THE END

Here ends The Lattice Chronicles.
Thank you for leaving a light on.